Let's Circle Back

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/73187376.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Cyrene (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Top Phainon/Bottom Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Office, POV Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Masturbation, Oblivious Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Baker Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Unreliable Narrator, Childhood Trauma, Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Insecure Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Come Eating, Coming In Pants, Dry Humping, Virgin Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon Has a Large Penis (Honkai: Star Rail), Creampie, Yearning Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Clingy Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Semi-Public Sex, Clothed Sex, Coming Untouched, Kitchen Sex, Office Sex, Sexual Overstimulation, Crying During Sex, Overcoming Trauma, Phainon is Bad at Feelings (Honkai: Star Rail), Anal Fingering, Anal Sex, Hair-pulling, answering the phone during sex, Phainon has a Creampie Kink, So does Mydei lowkey, Frottage,

Squirting, Enemies to Lovers, Angst and Fluff and Smut, Drunken Confessions, Love Confessions, Drunk Sex, Dubious Consent, Because of the drunk sex, Coworkers to Lovers

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-10-27 Completed: 2025-12-19 Words: 178,281
Chapters: 31/31

Let's Circle Back

by Loving_Healer

Summary

Phainon is just a regular office worker. Sure, the CEO's son, Mydei, hates him and only him, but he has gotten used to simply ignoring all the glares that the other man gives him. But when Phainon gets drunk during a company dinner, he learns that Mydei was the one who took him home.

And for some reason, Mydei refuses to disclose any details of this night that Phainon could not recall. But Phainon wasn't going to back down without a fight.

Office Phaidei AU

Notes

Honestly, I just really wanted to write Phaidei office sex.

Just wanted to note: Because this fic is based off my own experiences of working in a corporate office, this office is based off a U.S. corporate office.

Chapter 1

“He's staring at you.”

“He's probably just glaring at me.”

“Wow! How'd you know?”

Phainon rolled his eyes at Cyrene's sarcastic tone while trying to focus on whatever was on his computer screen, but Cyrene only laughed at him in response while continuing to linger at his cubicle. Phainon would probably consider Cyrene to be his closest friend, whom he had known for a major part of his life. They had even joined the same company for work following their college graduation. But that didn't mean she had to physically be so close to him all the time, right? Though, it was very typical Cyrene behavior to appear and disappear at her own whim.

“Is there a reason why you're still here?” Phainon heaved a sigh, clicking through various documents on his computer.

“I think Mydei is such a fun guy to be around.” Cyrene finally tore her gaze away from the distance to glance down at Phainon, who wasn't paying the least bit of attention to her.

“*Everyone* thinks that,” Phainon grumbled. “*Everyone* but me.”

“Why don't you ask him why he hates you?” It was hard to agree with the woman when she was trying to stifle her laughter at the same time.

“Like he'd tell me.” Another deep sigh escaped Phainon at the reluctant thought of a certain golden-haired man. He didn't want to waste a single one of his thoughts on that man.

“You never know.” Cyrene giggled, peeking at the documents that Phainon was perusing. Cyrene was also a part of the human resources department, so she was often found loitering around Phainon's cubicle while taking one of her many coffee breaks. “Maybe this time, he'll talk to you.”

“He barely wants to talk to me about work *while* we are at work,” Phainon retorted. “What makes you think he would want to talk about anything with me *besides* work?”

To put his position into perspective: Mydei, the CEO's son, was a very hard-working man who took his job quite seriously. He was very knowledgeable, bright, and everyone had no problems with him becoming the next CEO when it was his time to take over. Mydei was also quite polite and courteous with everyone in the company, and no one had any qualms with the man– everyone except for *Phainon*, specifically.

Since the moment Phainon was hired many years ago, Mydei had been treating him with nothing but rudeness. Glares when Phainon hadn't even spoken, blatant disregard when Phainon tries to greet him in the mornings, and just a half-hearted grunt every time Phainon gave him something work-related. Phainon would consider himself quite the extroverted person, and because of his job as well, he was very good at talking with others. He had tried quite hard to befriend the man, especially since they were close to each other in age, and the department Phainon worked in consisted entirely of women. But he barely made it far with the other man.

In fact, Phainon wouldn't be surprised if he actually went *backwards* with the man. Mydei didn't even address him by his name! At this point, Phainon was sure the man didn't actually know his real name. He ended up being nicknamed “Deliverer” because Phainon only approached Mydei to deliver documents to him. Which wasn't Phainon’s fault, because the guy didn't want to talk to him outside of work-related things anyway! Mydei didn't even want to talk to him *while* he was delivering work-related things! It came to a point where Phainon would just blatantly ignore Mydei unless he had to discuss anything work-related with him, and he would just have to disregard every single one of Mydei's sharp glares every single day in the office.

Unfortunately for Phainon, the human resources department that he was a part of worked very closely with the executive department, where Mydei obviously would be working in, as the CEO's son. And because of that, their cubicles and office spaces often overlapped, which also meant that Phainon had to see Mydei every day while at work. And that was where he

was now, trying to focus on these new hire onboarding documents while feeling a deathly glare boring straight through the back of his head. And to top it all off, Cyrene was narrating the entire situation as if Phainon didn't already know that Mydei was staring a hole right through him.

Cyrene hummed, fiddling with her coffee cup. “There has to be some reason why he treats you so poorly over everyone else.”

Phainon couldn't help but sigh once more. How many times had he sighed already? “Just bring Castorice into this. She's the employee relations person; maybe she can go ask Mydei why he hates me so much.”

Cyrene laughed heartily at his idea. “You might be onto something, Phainon.”

“I truly do not care,” Phainon mumbled. “That guy can do whatever he wants. If he hates me, he hates me. Fine. Whatever. At least he's good at his job.”

“Don't you want another man in your life?” Cyrene giggled once more. “You work in an all-women's department, after all.”

“You are all way nicer to me than the other guy, that's for sure. I don't need him at all.”

With another laugh, Cyrene finally departed from his cubicle, muttering about some sort of plan for them to reconcile. Phainon wasn't sure exactly what she was setting up and why she wanted them to get along so much, but Phainon didn't pay the least bit of attention to her departing words. It was just one of Cyrene’s usual antics, was what he told himself.

And for the rest of the workday, Phainon was unbothered. Although it was suspicious, Phainon couldn't complain, as he had finished the most work he had ever had in his entire life. He reviewed a record number of onboarding documents, answered a record number of emails, and finished reviewing a record number of exit interviews. The rest of the day seemed to pass by in a blink of an eye, but it was when he was packing up his bag to leave for the day that the director of their department, Aglaea, stepped out of her office.

Phainon raised an eyebrow upon laying eyes on his boss. It was a common sight to see the setting sun lowering beneath the horizon beyond the large office windows during this time of day, cascading a soft, orange glow all along the walls of the office space, but it definitely wasn't common to see his boss during this hour. Aglaea was an extremely hard worker, who was usually the first to arrive in the office and the last one to leave. Despite everyone’s worries of overworking, it was hard to tear that woman away from her work. And yet, here she stood, right when the workday ended. What could she possibly want right now? She didn't have her coat or bag with her, so it didn't seem like she was planning on leaving

As if reading his mind, she glanced up at him with a smile. “Phainon, I was thinking of having dinner with all the corporate teams. Would you care to join us?”

“A corporate dinner?” Phainon raised an eyebrow. Although it wasn't the first time, they usually happened at the end of each fiscal year to celebrate something. It was the middle of some random month; why were they going out to dinner?

Aglaea nodded. “That's right. Cyrene is already heading to the other departments to spread the word. Don't you want to eat out on the company's money?”

It wasn't as if Phainon could exactly be opposed to that, and with a sigh, he pushed in his office chair and, once the rest of the human resources department had gathered together, they departed from the building together. He spotted each of the different departments reconvening outside while the heads of the executive department discussed with each other the directors.

“Phainon.” A light tug against his sleeve, and Phainon whirled his head around to find himself facing his other coworker, Castorice. She had already withdrawn her hand and was standing a respectful distance away with a curious expression across her face. “Do you know what this is for?”

“This dinner?” With a quick glance toward the other departments gathering outside the building, Phainon shook his head. “What could they possibly be trying to do, gathering an entire company at the last minute?”

Castorice frowned. “I was thinking the same. We wouldn't be able to fit so many people into one restaurant at the last minute.”

But before Phainon could respond, Aglaea was already approaching the two of them, with the vice president of their department alongside her.

“There's a change in plans.” Phainon did not appreciate the sparkle in Aglaea's eyes as she spoke these words. “Since this is so last-minute, and we cannot possibly ask any restaurant to accommodate so many people at once, we have decided to split into groups.”

“Groups?” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “So just… a department dinner?”

“Close.” Aglaea hummed.

“We're eating with the execs!” The VP, Tribbie, just looked a little too excited at the news for Phainon’s liking. “We get to eat with Dei!”

A cheer resounded from behind the two higher-ups, and Cyrene soon came into view. She had an all-too-pleasant smile across her lips. “I let the other department know they can pick where to eat, since they are the executive department that's paying, after all.”

Aglaea and Tribbie thanked her, and Phainon was pulled along by the rest of the group once they found out the restaurant that they would be dining at. But the entire time, Phainon's brain was too busy swirling with this new information to even react with them or process where they were going. Why was this happening? Were they even celebrating anything in particular? And they *really* had to dine with the executive department of all departments? As much as the human resources department worked with the executive department, it wasn't as if he particularly spoke with the higher-ups all that much. The only people he really spoke to in the executive department were the executive assistant and… Mydei, much to his dismay.

A gentle chime of a bell roused Phainon from his thoughts, and he blinked blankly at the scenery before him. He was so deep within his thoughts that he didn't notice that they had already arrived at the dimly lit restaurant, with

warm lighting washing over each of the clothed tables. It wasn’t very crowded in the restaurant, but there were enough people to fill almost all of the tables that Phainon could see. To little surprise to Phainon, they were eating at quite an expensive restaurant, and the two departments were quickly led to a group of tables near the back of the restaurant.

Phainon joined the edge of the farthest table with Castorice and Cyrene. Castorice usually sat away from the group, and Cyrene just joined whichever chair was next to Phainon. Admittedly, he just really wanted the seat as far away from the executive department as possible. Although he hadn't laid eyes on Mydei yet, he wasn't exactly looking forward to seeing him anyway. And he was sure Mydei wanted to see him even less.

“You're sitting so far, Phainon,” Cyrene immediately teased the other man, plucking the laminated menu from the table with an amused hum.

“Aren't you sitting far as well?” With a light laugh, Phainon mirrored Cyrene in scanning the menu before him. And with all the elaborate dishes and extravagant prices laid out in front of his very eyes, he was truly glad none of this was coming out of his own wallet.

“I just went and joined you, you know.” Despite never taking his eyes off the menu, he could almost hear Cyrene’s smile. “Don't you want to get along with the higher-ups when you have the chance?”

Phainon cleared his throat. “I'm quite satisfied with where I'm sitting now. And it'd be such a hassle to try and move people now when we have all already settled in our seats.”

“Oh, don't you worry about that, Phainon! I can get people to move if you *really* want to sit closer to the executive department. It's part of my charm as a recruiter after all!”

The next few seconds involved desperate swaying of menus as Phainon quickly shot his hand out to lower Cyrene's waving one that was already held high in the air. Her cheeky grin and parted lips had already uttered a single syllable before Phainon could stop her. And it was just a single

moment later before a stray menu had slapped Cyrene in the face, silencing whatever else was about to leave her lips.

Castorice watched the entire fiasco with wide eyes from across the table. Swinging arms and menus flying through the air in every attempt to silence the other person. She had heard that the two were close because they had grown up together, but she didn't realize they would outright brawl with each other.

One moment, there was a craze of limbs all about in the air, and the next second, the two were sitting back in their seats and straightening their clothes and hair as if nothing had happened approximately two seconds ago.

“You don't have to do all that just for me, Cyrene.” Despite Phainon’s appearance now tidied up once more, his breathless voice gave away what had just occurred.

“I'd do anything for my good friend.” Cyrene's unwavering smile sent shivers down Phainon’s spine.

“Please, there's really no need.” Phainon managed a laugh, glancing down at the discarded menus to try and finish his order.

Cyrene hummed, leaning back in her chair and throwing her gaze over to the other end of the group of tables. Thankfully, Cyrene didn't push the conversation any further, and Phainon was able to place his order with the waiter in peace. It seemed that something was on Cyrene's mind, but Phainon was never good at finding out what occurred inside her mind ever since he was young. It always seemed as if she were thinking ahead, thinking of other possibilities, as if she could see something that everyone else could not. Phainon had gotten accustomed to this side of Cyrene, and despite all of her teasing, it was why she was such a good person he could rely on.

It was a few more moments of speaking with Castorice and Cyrene about work, coworkers, and their hobbies outside of work, that their food finally arrived at the table. Even though it was a work day the following day,

Cyrene had somehow roped Phainon into sharing a bottle of wine with her, and here he was with his salad, roasted chicken breast lathered in a rich, savory sauce, and this giant bottle of wine that Cyrene swore was worth the price.

“Do you even plan to come into work tomorrow?” Phainon laughed at the monstrous size of the bottle set before them. Cyrene had already picked up her wine glass to take in the scent that wafted from the glass.

“Why do you think I asked you to share?” With a wink of her long eyelashes and an innocent smile, she downed everything that was in the cup.

Phainon watched with an incredulous gaze as she swiped the lipstick that had stained the rim of her glass. “Cyrene, there's plenty in that bottle. It's not going anywhere.”

She batted her eyelashes in Phainon's direction. “Once you get a taste, you'll be doing the exact same thing too!”

Phainon couldn't believe she had already downed her entire wine glass without touching the food that was served right in front of her, but it was normal for Phainon not to question Cyrene's amusing behavior.

“Stop giving me that dubious stare.” Cyrene slapped her hand against Phainon’s shoulder. “Just try it!” Cyrene eagerly grasped his glass for him, shoving it in front of his face.

Frowning, Phainon waved her insistence away, returning his attention to the delicious food in front of him instead. “I'll try it after I eat a bit. You can go ahead and enjoy it as much as you want.”

Surprisingly, Cyrene acquiesced, but she made no move to pour herself another glass of the wine. Phainon figured she would get more later and didn't think much of it, so he began to dig into his own meal. The chicken breast was extremely tender, soaking up much of the sauce that it was lavished in and making the meat explode in flavor with every bite, and it paired extremely nicely with the fresh salad that he had ordered on the side.

What made it taste even better was the fact that he wasn't paying at all, and he enjoyed much of his meal while exchanging words every now and then with the other two women. And when Phainon felt that the savory sauce was almost too overpowering in his mouth, his hand had instinctively reached for the wine that was waiting before him.

Staring at the red liquid swirling in his wine glass and sparkling underneath the chandelier that hung high above their heads, Phainon gently tipped the glass against his lips, letting the taste of the wine fall between his parted lips and run across his tongue. His eyes widened at the first touch against his tongue as the flavor practically washed across his being. Phainon was surprised at how sweet it was, with barely any bitterness to the wine. Strong wines usually tasted quite bitter; maybe this wine didn't contain a lot of alcohol?

“How is it?!” Cyrene's eyes were practically sparkling as Phainon lowered his glass. He had to admit it, but Cyrene was right; he had almost downed his own glass of wine right on the spot upon his very first taste of it.

“It's… good. Very good.” Phainon couldn't rip his own gaze away from the remaining liquid that sat in his cup, and Cyrene excitedly grabbed the wine bottle to fill his glass back up to its previous amount.

“Right?!” She set the bottle down against the table, pushing the glass back toward Phainon. “Have as much as you want!” Cyrene hadn't even filled her own glass despite her excitement over the wine, but Phainon could barely raise his hand before it was swatted from the air. “Don't worry about me; I'll get more wine later.”

With a light laugh, Phainon nodded and enjoyed the rest of his meal, including the wine.

“Phainon?”

The man in question laughed loudly with the largest grin plastered across his face, clumsily settling his chin into the palm of his hand. “I'm here! I haven't gone anywhere! Right?”

Cyrene stifled her laughter at Castorice's futile attempts to get the other man to respond with any sort of sane answer. “Yep, he's gone.”

After Phainon had taken his first sip of the wine Cyrene had ordered, he had basically consumed the entire contents of the wine bottle all by himself. And it was an abnormally large bottle of wine. Sure, Cyrene definitely got her money’s worth, especially since the higher-ups were paying, but she didn't expect Phainon to drink the entire bottle without anyone's help. She couldn't exactly recall Phainon being such a heavy drinker before. Was he stressed at work? Should she have warned Phainon that the wine's alcohol content was high?

Phainon held a languid smile along his lips, with hazy eyes that stared at nothing in particular. He had already finished his meal before drinking the last drops of the wine, and now he was in a state of complete disarray. Although Cyrene actually ordered the wine for Phainon, she didn't think he would enjoy it so much. But she had to hand it to herself; she really knew everything there was to know about her closest friend! Including his taste in alcohol, apparently.

Castorice stared worriedly in Cyrene's direction, who was watching Phainon with much amusement. Everyone else was beginning to leave now that dinner had concluded and the bill had been paid, and they were all parting from the tables and bidding their farewells. But she was unsure how Phainon was going to get home when he could barely answer Castorice's questions. “Do you know where Phainon lives? I'm not sure anyone here would be able to help him home.”

A devilish smile almost crept upon Cyrene's face, but she bit it back before anyone could notice. “I know someone who would be able to carry Phainon home.”

“Really?”

“Mydei!”

Castorice's face paled upon hearing the name that had left Cyrene's lips. “You–You're going to call Mydei? I thought he didn't like Phainon?”

But before Cyrene could answer the other woman, she had already locked eyes with gold. Batting her eyelashes innocently, she tilted her head to the side. “Mydei, can you help me?”

The CEO's son and one of the most reliable workers in the company approached her with an eyebrow raised. He was previously sitting at the far end of the other tables; in fact, it may have even been the farthest chair from the drunk man that was currently slurring nonsensical words together in the seat right next to her.

The golden-haired man opened his mouth only to immediately shut it upon laying eyes on the other man, who didn't seem to even notice Mydei's presence. It was very clear that the other man was drunk out of his mind, and that sharp stare that bore straight through silver hair, Cyrene always noticed there was something off about how the man stared at her friend. And she was all the more eager to find out what it was.

“Did you drink today?” Cyrene tried to assess Mydei’s stature, and besides a slightly reddened face and a tired expression, he seemed fine.

Mydei glanced at his seat before darting his eyes back toward the recruiter. “Only a glass. I don't usually drink.”

“Perfect!” Cyrene clapped her hands together with a delighted expression on her face. “Unfortunately, neither Castorice nor I is strong enough to carry Phainon home, and I really don’t want to just call a car and leave him be. Would you perhaps do us a favor of bringing him home? I can give you his address and call a car for you too.”

With narrowed eyes, the expression that fluttered across Mydei’s face for half a second didn't escape Cyrene's attention in the slightest–surprise at the request, which was expected, with a hint of nervousness and… anticipation? There was no mistaking his expression, and it only made Cyrene more curious as to what ran through Mydei’s mind when it concerned the only male worker of the human resources department.

Cyrene didn't have long to analyze his reaction, as Mydei's face quickly returned to the sharp gaze that he usually wore. “Give me his address.”

Mydei sighed tiredly. “I don't mind. And no need to call a car.”

Castorice's eyes widened like saucers at hearing Mydei agreeing to bring him home, while Cyrene quickly tapped Phainon’s address into Mydei’s phone before the man changed his mind.

“He doesn't live far from here.” Cyrene turned the phone screen toward Mydei, illuminating his face in the dim restaurant with the directions to his apartment. “It's just a humble apartment a few blocks down from here.”

Taking the phone from Cyrene's grasp, Mydei nodded after studying the route for a few moments. “Get home safe.”

“Thank you!” Cyrene rushed to stand from her chair, giving Mydei more space as he easily threw one of Phainon’s arms over his shoulder.

“Thank you, Mydei,” Castorice also thanked the golden-haired man, studying Phainon's face, who appeared extremely confused at the new predicament now that he was practically leaning against some other man. They were now the only ones left at the table, as everyone had already returned home.

“Castorice?” Phainon squinted at the woman in front of her. “How are you carrying me from that far away?”

Cyrene shut her eyes in another attempt to hold in her laughter, taking deep breaths as if she were about to explode. “I hope… he doesn't cause you much trouble, Mydei.”

Mydei huffed exasperatedly, and she watched the two men hobble out of the restaurant. Phainon seemed to be talking about something that she could only assume didn't make sense at all, and Mydei silently let him talk his ears off.

She wondered how Phainon was going to react tomorrow.

Chapter 2

A pounding head and a screaming alarm. Those were the first things Phainon woke up to as he slammed his hand against his phone on the nightstand, fumbling wherever he could along the screen until the device in his hand finally stilled. His face was buried in the sheets, with his arm dangling off the bed from when he had shut off his alarm, but he regrettably pushed himself off his mattress until his eyes could find his bedroom washed in a gentle morning glow.

He squinted in front of him, glancing strangely around at the familiar sight before him. When had he gotten home? *How* had he gotten home?

Phainon could barely remember what had happened the previous night, and the more he tried to think about it, the more his head ached. It felt as if someone were punching from inside his brain, and his head throbbed with every slight thought he tried to have. All he could remember was that cursed wine that Cyrene had convinced him to get, and now he was suddenly back in his bed. Sure, it tasted delicious, but now he was dealing with the aftermath of that giant bottle that Cyrene had said they would share, only to let him drink the entire thing all by himself. Why didn't she stop him? Should he just call out?

With a shake of his head to immediately dismiss that thought, which he severely regretted because it only made his head throb more, he whisked himself away to the bathroom to get himself ready. He had never gotten so drunk in his life to the point where he couldn't recall a single thing that had happened to him, so he couldn't even guess what he had done last night or what had even happened. Phainon was always at least somewhat aware, but the previous night was something that he had never experienced before. Once his head stopped throbbing, he would make a mental note to himself to never listen to one of Cyrene's whims ever again.

Phainon noticed while approaching the bathroom that he was no longer dressed in the outfit he had worn yesterday to work. He was dressed in the usual outfit that he wore when he slept, which consisted mainly of a random

shirt and sweatpants. He didn't notice any stray clothing items on the floor, and sure enough, once the interior of his bathroom swept into his vision, the clothing that he wore last night was in the hamper. Maybe drunk Phainon still had some semblance of sanity? Or was his daily routine so strict that even drunk Phainon followed it out of habit?

He didn't really have much time to dwell on it as he had to get ready for work, and he spent the rest of his morning tidying himself up, dressing himself in a new outfit for work, and taking painkillers for his suffering head. Resolving to just buy a salad at the cafeteria for lunch, as his head hurt far too much to think about eating anything at the moment, it was when he had approached the living area of his apartment that his eyes fell upon a plate of perfectly crafted, steaming honeycakes set upon the center of his counter near his kitchen.

Blinking once, twice, and three times, the plate of golden honeycakes did not disappear from his eyes, and approaching closer only allowed the sweet scent of the viscous syrup to waft into his nose. The berries that littered the pancakes shone in the morning sunlight, sparkling under Phainon's gaze no matter how much he stared at them.

Did drunk Phainon… order food last night?

But that didn't make sense at all. Would he really get hungry and order food after having dinner and consuming a giant bottle of wine? Maybe drunk Phainon ordered pancakes much later into the night, hours after the dinner took place? But that didn't make sense either, as the honeycakes were perfectly set upon a ceramic plate that Phainon knew he had bought with his own money. There wasn't a sight of a receipt, to-go container, or plastic bag anywhere to indicate that he had bought food, no matter how much Phainon searched his kitchen. Admittedly, Phainon only really knew how to cook salads, if you could even call that cooking, so preparing these honeycakes himself was already not an option. Unless drunk Phainon was a master chef, which Phainon severely doubted.

Grimacing, Phainon brought a hand to his head in a poor attempt to soothe the pounding against his skull. His head hurt way too much to be thinking about these abnormalities in his own apartment. Seriously, he should

probably stay home, but his urge to get revenge against Cyrene was the only thing fueling him at this point. Was it his fault that he drank all the wine? It was, but he was going to bicker with Cyrene about it first.

With his last remaining strength, he decided to pack the honeycakes to bring with him to eat for lunch, or maybe a breakfast at his desk once he arrived at work. He grabbed his keys off the counter, only to realize that his car was still at work, as he didn't take it when the departments went out for dinner, and with a deep sigh, he called a car to take him to the office. And within a short car ride, he finally arrived at one of the many skyscrapers in the city. He definitely could have walked to work, but he really didn't want to deal with that while his head still felt like it was exploding.

“Good morning!” Cyrene appeared at his cubicle as delighted and pleasant as she usually did every morning. Phainon could only stare at her silently before setting down his belongings and turning on his work computer.

“You really let me drink that entire bottle by myself, huh?” Phainon shot an accusatory stare in Cyrene's direction, who continued to smile.

“I got you coffee?” A paper cup was set down on his desk, with the smell of the drink immediately filling Phainon's senses. It was a hot coffee, with steam emitting into the air, and Phainon knew Cyrene definitely made it exactly as he liked it. “I'm more surprised that you came into work today. How are you feeling?”

“Fine enough to come in, I suppose.” Phainon cracked a smile, but he didn't dare laugh in case it rattled his head anymore. Thanking her for the coffee, he took a sip while watching Cyrene scan the office floor.

“Did you get home okay?” Cyrene's crystal, shining pink eyes landed on Phainon, but he had known her for so long that he could see that there was something different behind her eyes that almost made Phainon hesitant to respond. It almost looked as if there was a specific answer she was looking for.

Narrowing his eyes at how eager Cyrene looked for his answer, he tried to answer as nonchalantly and vaguely as possible. “I got home fine.”

“Nothing happened?” Cyrene learned forward, pressing him for more details.

With a frown, Phainon replied, “I don't remember.”

A loud sigh left Cyrene's chest with a pout she didn't try to hide. Phainon clearly did not give her the answers she was seeking. “Of course you don't remember. There was so much alcohol in that wine.”

“*Why* did you even let me drink all of it by myself?”

Cyrene giggled, winked, and left his cubicle without another word, only silently waving her hand to bid farewell. Although it was very typical Cyrene behavior, he couldn't help but feel unsettled by that. Phainon could never wrap his head around what Cyrene was thinking, no matter how long he knew her, and his pounding headache didn't exactly help with that.

The coffee that Cyrene had made for him was his only saving grace as he started delving deep into his work. As someone who worked in the human resources department, his job mainly consisted of a lot of emails and documents pertaining to employer information. And he mostly spent the majority of his time in the morning just addressing employee concerns and preparing onboarding documents for new hires in different departments. One of which he needed to get signed by a manager belonging to the executive department.

“Great,” Phainon grumbled to himself before pushing himself out of his chair. Although the medicine he took in the morning was helping with his headache, it still wasn't enough to fully relieve him, and he could only hope while taking the papers from the printer that Mydei would treat him with much indifference today. Phainon didn't think he could stand any more than Mydei’s usual grunts and glares today.

On the other side of the floor was the executive department, and, as usual, the executive assistant was not there. Usually, Phainon could deliver documents that needed signatures over to the executive assistant instead, but the executive assistant was always running around doing other things

for the executives. It was why Phainon was always, unfortunately, met with Mydei instead.

“Mydei?” Phainon gently knocked on the open office door, spotting a head of golden hair peeking from above the desktop monitors. With a grunt of acknowledgement from the other man, Phainon stepped inside to hand him the papers.

“*Now* you come over?” The other man sneered in Phainon’s direction, practically ripping the documents right out of Phainon's hand.

“Sorry?”

Golden eyes quickly scanned the papers before they were set aside. “You only came to hand me documents as usual, *Deliverer*.”

Phainon's mouth opened, but no sound was able to come out. What was with this sudden hostility today? Usually, Mydei just threw him a few grunts and glares, and maybe just a comment about being the Deliverer, before waving Phainon out of his office. And why was he even more bothered that Phainon was just doing his job, as usual?

“Was there… something else you needed from me?” Despite the confused expression that was evident on Phainon's face, Phainon mustered his best polite smile, with eyes desperately trying to find any sort of answer on the other man's face, who seemed to be shooting an even more icy glare than he usually did.

Mydei scoffed, turning back to his computer screen. “Nothing at all.”

“Nothing at…” Phainon's straining smile immediately turned into a scowl as he buried the frustration that was creeping into his being. “You're going to make all of these comments and then say you want nothing from me?”

“Didn't you already do your job, Deliverer?” Without even tearing his eyes from the screen, Mydei swiped the papers from his desk and waved them in the air. “I'm sure there is nothing else you need in this office.”

“Well, it sounded like *you* needed something.”

“And I already got it. So leave.”

Clicking his tongue, Phainon had no choice but to just turn around and exit the office, but no matter how much he tried to wipe that conversation from his mind, he could not bury the anger that was now coursing through his veins. What was that guy's problem? And why was he extra prickly today? It wasn't as if Phainon did anything particularly different today, even after running through and analyzing the one-minute exchange multiple times through his throbbing head. Maybe something else happened at work, and he was just taking it out on Phainon?

A deep sigh left his body as he slumped into his chair. Whatever. This was just typical Mydei behavior, which was what he was going to tell himself. There were only a few more hours until his lunch break, and Phainon was just going to sink himself into his work until then. He didn't need to make his precious, pounding brain take up time and energy worrying over a golden-haired, rich man who obviously did not care in the slightest for him. Phainon wasn't going to let that guy get under his skin. Phainon was going to be calm, collected, and move on from that exchange to focus on his work.

“What the hell is wrong with that guy?!” Phainon buried his face into his hands, with Castorice trying her best to soothe his frustration and anger. Phainon had spent the last two hours just running the only conversation he had with Mydei over and over in his head, and even when he tried to focus on his work, all he kept seeing on his computer screen were those two cursed, golden eyes and his permanent glare that made Phainon's skin crawl. And then it was suddenly lunch hour. Although he was angry at Mydei’s irrational behavior, Phainon was even more furious with himself for having spent so long just thinking about Mydei.

“Maybe something happened to him at work today?” Castorice had a gentle hand rubbing circles along Phainon's shoulder in a comforting manner, her worried gaze shifting between Phainon's slumped body and Cyrene's amused expression.

“I just so happened to run into him today, but I thought he was courteous as usual.” Cyrene patted the top of Phainon's head, and he had to stop himself from swatting her hand away.

“Courteous… right.” Phainon scoffed. “I don't think that man has a single polite bone in his body.”

“Did you want me to talk to him, Phainon?” Castorice offered, but Phainon pushed himself off the cafeteria table and immediately shook his head. Castorice was in charge of employee relations, after all, and Phainon didn't want to drag work into this.

“It's really fine, Castorice.” He offered a small smile in her direction. “It's not a huge deal. That guy just… gets on my nerves.” It was truly the nicest way Phainon could phrase it.

Cyrene hummed. “Maybe something happened when he took you home?”

The breath caught in Phainon’s throat, and he coughed, managing between fits of desperate breaths: “He *what?*”

Castorice quickly tried to salvage the conversation. “Since you were so drunk, we didn't want to leave you by yourself, but neither of us would be any help carrying you home. Everyone was leaving so…”

“So I asked Mydei to carry you home,” Cyrene simply finished, as if this information was not about to make Phainon’s head explode.

“You asked *Mydei* of all people to bring me home?”

“Who else could I ask?” Cyrene pouted at Phainon, as if she could cutely act her way out of this conversation. “Did you want me to ask one of the higher-ups to bring you home?”

“No, I…” Phainon sighed exasperatedly. After running through the employees in the executive and human resources departments, Mydei really was the best person to ask to bring him home. “So *that's* how I got home? *Mydei* brought me home?”

The entire morning ran through Phainon's head. His previous work clothes were placed neatly in the hamper. His keys were already set upon the counter. He was already wearing his nightwear when he woke up. Phainon didn't really notice this either when he first woke up, but even his phone was plugged into his charger right on his nightstand, where he always left it every single night. Was that really all due to Mydei?

The earlier conversation that he had with Mydei flashed through his mind, and he mentally shook his head at the insane thought he had just had. Mydei couldn't even stand the sight of him, let alone clean him up for the night, organize his keys, and even charge his phone before leaving. Those must've all been due to drunk Phainon stumbling around his own apartment before crashing for the night. He would bet his own life that Mydei dumped him right at his front door and left.

“Maybe that's why he hates me even more so right now?” Phainon sighed with a tired hand running through his hair. “Maybe he hated that he had to see me for so long outside of work hours. Or maybe he hated having to take me home.”

“He seemed fine with taking you home last night,” Castorice muttered, but Phainon wasn't the least convinced.

“He was probably just being polite with you guys while dumping me outside of my apartment right after.”

Cyrene laughed at his statement. “I'm sure he at least brought you inside, Phainon. But, why don't we take Mydei off our minds? I noticed you brought something other than a salad today, Phainon.”

The steaming honeycakes that Phainon had just taken out of the microwave glistened in front of him from the glass container that he had shoved them into this morning, with three pairs of eyes all falling upon Phainon's choice of lunch for the day.

“Did you make them?” Castorice inspected the honeycakes.

“I did not make them.”

“So you… bought them?”

Phainon could not answer Castorice’s question.

“Are you really going to eat strange honeycakes whose origins are a mystery?” Cyrene chuckled and inspected the honeycakes alongside Castorice with wide, sparkling eyes full of interest and curiosity. “Where did they come from anyway?”

“They were on my counter this morning.” Phainon frowned while recalling the strange morning that he had. “On a plate that was definitely from my kitchen cabinet.”

“Were there dishes in the sink?” Castorice suggested.

“There were no dishes in the sink. Or anywhere near the sink.”

Cyrene's eyes seemed to brighten, but before Phainon could ask what sort of revelation she had come to in her brain, she was already pushing the glass container towards Phainon. “You should eat up!”

Phainon narrowed his eyes suspiciously at the other woman. “Were you not just questioning me for eating food with unknown origins?”

“Trust me.” She pushed the container closer. “I can promise it is safe.”

His eyes shifted between the honeycakes and Cyrene. “Do you know where they're from?”

“Less talking, more eating!” Cyrene had shoved the utensils into Phainon's hands, and under her eager gaze, Phainon warily sliced a part of the honeycakes dripping in syrup to shove them into his mouth.

“How… are they?” Castorice still had a worried gaze directed towards Phainon, while Cyrene was excitedly awaiting a response.

But Phainon was too busy to even begin answering Castorice’s question. These golden honeycakes were no short of perfection. Even after hours of sitting on his table and in this glass container when he packed them for

work, the outer edge of the honeycakes still retained a crispy layer, with the inside of the honeycakes retaining a soft, bouncy, and fluffy texture. The syrup was rich and, admittedly, *very* sweet, but the berries that were scattered about along the honeycakes' surface and in the container provided a sour and refreshing balance to offset the sweetness of the thick syrup. And with the berries also picking up stray remnants of the syrup, they were not too sour either.

"How are they?!" Cyrene leaned closer when Phainon failed to respond to Castorice's question, and Phainon swallowed the remaining bites of food in his mouth.

"They're… really good." Phainon was almost in awe at these honeycakes, and he stared down at the rest of the food he had left to enjoy. "They're actually… *really* good." There were truly no other words Phainon could use to describe the absolute delicacy that had blessed his taste buds. Even the fancy restaurant that they had dined at the previous night could not compare to these honeycakes that sat in front of him.

Cyrene seemed quite pleased at his answer as she settled back into her seat to enjoy her second coffee of the day that she had just poured for herself earlier. Although Cyrene never answered the true origins of these honeycakes, Phainon was now too busy trying to savor the rest of his lunch, as he could never enjoy such a delight ever again. He didn't know where they came from, and it would be impossible to try and find out where they came from unless he wrung it out of Cyrene. And even then, would Cyrene's conclusion even be correct?

The honeycakes didn't last nearly long enough, with Phainon inhaling them as if he were a part of an eating competition. But with the last remnants of the syrup lingering on his tongue and his lunch break coming to an end, he bid a brief farewell to Castorice and Cyrene so that he could throw his trash away and get some water. And of course, his leisurely lunch break was utterly ruined when he ran into the source of his stress for the last few hours.

There was a small break room, equipped with a small kitchen, on every floor of the office building. So, it made complete sense that he had

happened to run into this man when they both worked on the exact same floor. It was completely and utterly normal to run into this man on the floor where they both worked. It wasn't as if this was the most Phainon had ever seen this man in a single day or anything like that. Of course not. It was completely normal to run into your coworker whom you share a floor with multiple times a day.

Phainon tried to ignore him; he really did. He threw away his trash, as he planned, and he also grabbed a cup for water. But the entire time, Phainon could not tear his eyes away from the only other person in the kitchen. He would approach the trash bin with his eyes glued to the other man's back, and it was then that he noticed how muscular the man was. The way that his back flexed even underneath the white dress shirt was quite a sight to behold; he had never stared at this man for so long to even notice, as most of their interactions were, at maximum, one minute long. But Phainon was quite into working out and exercising, yet this man's build rivaled even his own.

Phainon reached over the counter next to the other man to get a cup, and the entire time, Phainon's eyes were not looking at the cup at all. His eyes were trained on the other man, who was mixing a drink, but he had already stored the ingredients away. So, Phainon could not tell what he was making other than the fact that it was pink. Maybe some sort of fruit juice?

“You're staring, Deliverer.”

Phainon visibly shook out of his thoughts at the abrupt words that broke the silence in the kitchen, and he tore his gaze away to focus on the cup that was now being crushed in his own hand. But something inside of him didn't want to let Mydei have the last word, despite not wanting to talk to the other man in the slightest.

His eyes flickered between the pink drink and the empty cup in his hand, as he had yet to fill it up with any water. “I… heard you took me home yesterday. I just wanted to say thank you.”

Mydei scoffed. “You can't even remember a single thing from last night, yet you want to thank me?”

“Is it so wrong to want to thank someone for a kind gesture, even if one does not remember?” Phainon snapped. Okay, maybe it wasn't a good idea to continue the conversation with this man. He was already getting annoyed after only a couple of sentences.

“Would you even be thanking me if you remembered what happened last night?”

“What?”

“Forget it.”

Mydei whirled around on his feet with his glass in hand to abruptly leave the room, but Phainon wasn't about to back down and let him have the last word just yet.

“What happened last night?” Phainon turned around to face the door where Mydei had halted in his steps. What an odd statement to say. If Mydei was saying that, did that mean something truly extraordinary actually happened last night? Was that really why Mydei was giving him so much attitude today?

“Nothing happened.” Mydei threw a glare over his shoulder, but he could barely take another step before Phainon had opened his mouth once more.

“Did you make it home okay?”

“Why does that matter to you?”

“I'd like to hear if the person who helped me wasn't too majorly inconvenienced by bringing me home last night.”

“It was a major inconvenience.”

“So, did you make it home okay?”

A deep sigh left the other man, and he pivoted on his feet so that he was finally facing Phainon. Usually, Phainon was never one to approach Mydei so closely, and they mostly interacted when one of them was sitting at their

desk. So seeing Mydei in such close proximity with both of them standing only emphasized just how big a frame Mydei truly possessed. It shook Phainon to his core in an indescribable way.

“You seemed to enjoy your lunch today.”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows at the sudden change in topic. Mydei saw him at the cafeteria? It wasn't too unusual to notice a coworker in the eating area of the corporate building, but Phainon was just surprised that Mydei had even taken notice of him, let alone what he was eating. “What does that have to do with anything?”

Mydei stayed silent for a brief moment, with eyes wandering the floor beneath their feet, before he finally opened his mouth once more. “Nothing. I got home fine.”

Much to Phainon's disbelief, Mydei departed from the kitchen before Phainon could utter another word.

Chapter 3

Of course Phainon couldn't think of anything else except for what had just happened. *Of course he couldn't.* Not only was that the longest conversation he had ever had with the CEO's son, but the entire conversation was filled with an exceptional mystery that kept swirling in his head, which was now faintly throbbing from the questionable night.

What happened last night?!

Castorice and Cyrene seemed to act as if nothing unusual had happened, which meant that whatever Mydei was referring to, happened when they were both by themselves, most likely either on the way to Phainon's apartment or at his apartment. What could have possibly happened in those few minutes? Phainon knew he didn't live very far from the restaurant that they ate at, so not much could have happened, right?

Phainon was sitting at his desk, staring blankly at whatever he had pulled up onto his computer screen, with a new cup filled with water on his desk. He couldn't focus on a single word that was appearing in front of him, and no matter how much he tried to conjure a single memory from last night, his brain would end right at the bottle of wine that Cyrene had convinced him to order. He remembered what he ate, he remembered that he was filling his entire body with that wine, and he remembered how amused Cyrene was that he was drinking so much, but he could not, for the life of him, recall anything else from that night.

He wanted to bash his head against his desk in any sort of attempt to remember, but he knew his pounding head would not stand for it. But, what possibly could have happened in those few minutes of Mydei stumbling to carry Phainon home to earn even more of his ire? Did Phainon throw up on him? Share some embarrassing and uncomfortable secrets? Since Phainon had never been so drunk before, he couldn't even begin to imagine what he was like while drunk, and there were no other witnesses to his drunken stupor except for Mydei himself.

No one except for Mydei himself knew what happened.

If only one person knew what happened, then there was only one person that Phainon could rely on to hear what had happened, and it would be from the man involved in this whole situation. But, Phainon doubted Mydei would just tell him so easily, especially after these last two conversations that he had with Mydei today. How could Phainon convince such a stubborn man to confess the truth?

How else would a person get the truth from another person? From squeezing it out of them, of course. But the next step would be, how could Phainon squeeze the truth out of him? He would have to basically torture the guy to force the truth out of him, but what was something Mydei hated enough that Phainon could constantly bother him with until he confessed the truth?

Of course, Mydei hated Phainon!

It was as if a shining light had dawned across Phainon's entire being, and realization enveloped his entire being. Of course, what else would bother and frustrate Mydei to the point of exasperation and desperation? Obviously, it would be no one other than Phainon's mere presence. As much as Phainon didn't really want to spend so much time with Mydei, this was also the only way to figure out what exactly happened last night and to fill in the missing memories in his brain.

Would all of his efforts really be worth it? Phainon wasn't sure, but it would bother him for the rest of his life that someone he didn't get along with knew a side of Phainon that even *he* didn't know about. But, surely it wouldn't take a long time to squeeze the truth from Mydei, right? It seemed that Mydei hated Phainon with an extreme passion, and Phainon would probably only have to bother him for a couple of days before the other man finally spilled the truth.

Phainon immediately stood from his desk chair as if possessed and rushed down the hallway, passing all sorts of cubicles before finally finding himself in front of that cursed office once again. The door was open, almost inviting the mayhem that Phainon was about to bring.

“Mydei!” Phainon poked his head inside unannounced, and he swore he saw the owner of the office flinch upon hearing his singsong voice.

“If you left something in the kitchen, I didn't see it.” Mydei continued to appear as unfazed as possible, with eyes never straying from the computer screens.

“Hey, want to get dinner tonight?”

“*What?”*

Phainon definitely got Mydei’s attention now, who was now glowering in Phainon's direction with another one of his nasty glares.

“I asked if you wanted to get dinner with me.” Phainon slid himself through the entrance of the office as if Mydei had invited him inside, and he leaned a hand against the mahogany desk that was neatly organized with piles of documents. “If you don't want to get dinner, maybe we can do something else?”

“I'm busy.”

“With what?”

“Nothing that is of your concern.”

“If you're going grocery shopping, let me come with.” Phainon kneeled on the floor, resting the side of his head against the desk to smile cheekily up at Mydei's furious expression. “If you're going to the gym, I can be your spotter. If you're going to a café, let me buy you a coffee.”

Mydei's eyes narrowed. “I don't drink coffee.”

“Then, I'll buy you whatever you want. Just say the word.” Phainon channeled his inner Cyrene and winked at the man, who gawked at the action. His plan was working–a little too well, actually. He may just get the truth today. “You don't seem like a sweets guy, so maybe I can buy you some sort of savory pastry?”

Mydei's eyes darkened. “That's unnecessary.”

“Then–”

“What are you even doing here anyway?” Mydei sighed tiredly. “And get off the floor.”

“I'm here to invite you out with me, obviously.” Phainon didn't listen to Mydei's statement in the slightest, choosing to continue kneeling on the floor and blinking innocently. “Where are you going after work? Let me come with you.”

Mydei shut his eyes with another deep breath, and Phainon watched him silently overcome his fueling anger over the silver-haired man who refused to let him get any work done. “You…” Mydei slowly opened his eyes, and the annoyance that was swirling in gold had now dissipated. “What do you want from me?”

Phainon grinned. “I want to know what happened last night.”

The annoyance immediately returned to Mydei's eyes, much to Phainon's amusement. “You’re here because of *that?*”

Neglecting to respond, Phainon only continued to bat his eyelashes up at the golden-haired man.

“You are…” Another deep breath escaped Mydei's being. It was clear that he was at the end of his patience. Phainon watched the man curse under his breath, muttering about something which Phainon could not hear, no matter how much he strained his ears, but it didn't seem like it was related to the events of the night in question. But when gold suddenly snapped up to meet Phainon's eyes, a new sort of resoluteness reflected in them.

“You are *never* getting the truth out of me.” Mydei abruptly stood up and sped out of the office, leaving Phainon to his own devices. He was left with slumped shoulders and wide eyes, staring up at nothing now that no one occupied the office chair that was still spinning in front of him from the previous occupant.

That little–

How could he just leave?! And in the middle of their conversation?! And leave Phainon on the floor?!

Phainon slowly stood up, glancing around the small but tidy office. Mydei was nowhere to be found, and it was the first time that Phainon was actually bothered by the fact that Mydei was not here. After repeatedly glancing around the nearby offices, hallways, and cubicles to further confirm this fact, Phainon swiped a tired hand down his face.

This was going to be a lot harder than he had originally anticipated.

Who knew Mydei was so competitive? Was competitive the correct word, or would it be secretive? There was absolutely no reason why Mydei should keep the events of last night to himself, so why was it so hard to wring the truth out of Mydei's mouth? If Phainon was the drunk one, wouldn't all the embarrassment and shame be held upon Phainon's drunken shoulders? If anything, he would've expected Mydei to constantly rub Phainon's shame and embarrassment in his face rather than be so tight-lipped about what had occurred between them. Unless…

Unless *Mydei* was the one who did something embarrassing last night?

Phainon's eyes shot wide as his footsteps halted in the middle of the hallway. He was on the way back to his cubicle when this sudden realization popped into his head. Surely, this was the only sound reasoning that made sense. It wasn't that drunk Phainon did anything embarrassing, but it was actually *Mydei* who made a fool of himself. It would explain why Mydei refused to reveal any of last night’s events to Phainon, and why Mydei was treating him with so much more hostility than usual. The shame that washed over Mydei's being merely from seeing Phainon most likely made Mydei snap after whatever he had done last night. Surely, that was the full truth, right? Now, everything that Phainon had to do was made clear to him.

Phainon needed to know. He *needed* to know what happened last night.

Not only could he hold it above Mydei's head for the rest of their working careers, but maybe Mydei would actually bother to learn Phainon's name this time. Wait, Phainon was in HR. He should definitely not be blackmailing staff. Well, it wasn't as if he was asking for anything bad, right? He just wanted Mydei to learn his name, and maybe even treat him a little more politely.

Nodding to himself, Phainon finally sat himself back down into his cushy office chair. There were only a couple more hours left of work, and he needed the time to pass by as quickly as possible to begin his operation.

The time flew by, all according to Phainon's plan. He felt as if he was working the most diligently he had ever worked in his entire life. The classic, professional smile of his almost seemed natural when speaking with other staff, almost as if his entire being could not wait to confront a certain man again. And when the clock struck the final minute of work, Phainon could not stop his body from shaking in anticipation as he packed his things away and turned his work computer off. It would be the weekend starting tomorrow, and Phainon was planning on seeing Mydei every single day. And that included the weekends as well–anything to find out what embarrassing thing Phainon had missed Mydei doing.

“Phainon!”

His breath caught in his throat at the woman's voice, and he quickly glanced over to the woman who had linked an arm around his.

“Cyrene, whatever you want to say, I'm busy today.” He flashed an apologetic smile at his coworker and close friend, but she didn't seem convinced.

“*Busy?”* Cyrene almost looked offended with her accusatory stare and pout. “Since when did you make *plans?”*

“I–I make plenty of plans.” The stuttering was very unconvincing on Phainon's part. But he was in a bit of a hurry; if Mydei left the office before Phainon could catch him, he wouldn't be able to bother him for the rest of the weekend. “Whatever it is, it'll have to wait, okay?”

With a gaze cast downward, she released Phainon's arm. “Then, text me when you're free.”

After a quick nod and a wave, Phainon dashed out of the office. He briefly passed Mydei's office on the way to the elevator, and to no surprise, the office door was closed shut with the lights turned off. That would mean Mydei was already beginning to leave the building, and Phainon didn't have much time left until he could solidify his spot next to Mydei for the rest of his free time.

The elevator doors chimed open onto the ground floor of the building, and Phainon made a mad sprint to the parking garage. He actually did know where Mydei usually parked and exactly what car he drove, mostly because Phainon wanted to ensure he could effectively avoid the other man every morning. But now, that information was being used for a different reason, and relief washed over him when he spotted that familiar strawberry blonde hair in the distance.

“Mydei!”

The golden-haired man in the distance grew rigid at the voice that echoed across the parking spots. He was standing adjacent to the driver's side of his car and about to open the door, and an expression of pure annoyance, exasperation, and disbelief crossed his face. Phainon had to fight hard not to burst into laughter at the extreme reaction Mydei had upon immediately seeing Phainon. There was no way Mydei would be able to keep his secret for long, not if Phainon had anything to say about it.

“You're… actually here.” Mydei eyed Phainon with extreme and utter shock.

Meanwhile, Phainon had finally met Mydei's side but was too busy gasping for breath from practically sprinting across the corporate building and parking structure. “I… told you I would be.”

“You didn't say anything at all about stalking me after work.”

“*We* are spending the evening together.” Refusing to acknowledge Mydei’s statement, Phainon grinned at the other man, who only returned a face of pure disgust. “Whether you like it or not.”

“Can I not just report you to HR?”

“You can. To me.”

A loud sigh left Mydei's lips. “So, what if I climb into my car and drive without you?”

Phainon eyed the car door, where Mydei's hand was grasping the handle. “Try me.”

Raising an eyebrow, Mydei scoffed. “*Try* you?”

“Try and drive without me.” Phainon smirked with a cock of his head. He propped an elbow against the car, which didn't escape Mydei's notice. “Just go ahead.”

The two men stood in the parking lot staring at each other in a silent act of challenging and analyzing the other, with cars whizzing past them to leave the parking structure now that the work day was over. With the sun lowering into the sky, casting an orange glow along the two men, it almost looked as if Mydei were glowing with his golden hair. Phainon almost felt like he was about to engage in a duel with the CEO's son, with the wind from the exiting cars rushing through their hair and the rays of remaining sunlight that cascaded along the floor.

“So,” Mydei was the first one to break the silence, “if I tell you what happened last night, you will leave me alone.”

“I'm a man of my word.” Phainon's smile grew at these words. Surely, this meant that Mydei was going to reveal the truth, right?

Mydei scoffed once more. “Right. That's what you said last night too, when you said you would remember.”

Finally! Some details were being revealed!

“I said that?” Phainon's eyebrows shot upwards. He was trying hard to fight his growing curiosity and anticipation to squeeze more out of the man standing in front of him.

“You did.” Mydei crossed his arms. His eyes lowered as he muttered, “I should've known you wouldn’t remember a single thing.”

“I…” The rest of Phainon's words died in his throat. Why was Phainon suddenly feeling guilty right now? With the way Mydei worded his statement and the sudden shift in tone, it almost sounded as if Phainon promised him something. But what could he have possibly promised with a man whom he barely conversed with? “I don't really know what I'm like when I'm drunk. Did I… say something to you?”

Mydei seemed to assess him warily, and the unreadable expression that was across his face soon hardened. “It's none of your concern.”

“It *is* my concern!” Phainon wanted to throw his hands up into the air in exasperation. Now they were back at square one, with Mydei stubbornly refusing to tell him anything at all. “I can't remember what *I*, myself, said, and it's killing me!”

“Just forget about it.” The sound of the car door being opened filled Phainon's brain as Mydei began to seat himself inside. Phainon had to act quickly, or else he would miss his chance.

“Wait!” Before Mydei could close and lock the door, Phainon swung it back open. Was this the most desperate Phainon had ever acted? Yes, but now the need for the truth was eating away at Phainon even more so. Was it not that Mydei did something embarrassing, but Phainon had told him something important only to forget? And that was why Mydei was so angry? But, what would Phainon possibly tell a man that he was absolutely sure despised his presence? And, why was Mydei stubbornly hiding the truth when he was angry that Phainon couldn't remember? Wouldn't reminding Phainon what he had said solve both of their problems? Too many questions with no answers swirled in Phainon's mind, but he didn't have time to dwell on them as the source of all those questions and answers was about to leave him.

“I'm sure it is best that you don't remember,” Mydei spat. “So let go of my car door.”

“I'll be the judge of that,” Phainon retorted. “They were *my* words, were they not?”

“I'm sure it was all just drunken drivel on your part, that you did not mean at all.”

“Then just tell me what I said, and I can tell you if it was all *drunken drivel* or not.”

The two men resumed their previous staredown, with neither man acquiescing to the other. Phainon's hand was firmly grasping the car door, while Mydei's hand was glued to the door handle from inside, but neither man made another move or another sound, choosing to stay silent until the other person faltered first. They had been lingering in the parking structure for so long that the sounds of all the cars leaving had begun to dwindle, until only the traffic from the streets outside filled their ears.

“Get in my fucking car.”

The words slapped Phainon in the face just like the restaurant menu Cyrene had slapped against him the previous night, and he almost couldn't believe what his ears had just picked up. His heart began pounding, wondering if what he had heard wasn't a part of his wishful imagination. “What?”

Mydei's eyes darkened. “*Get in my car*.”

Scurrying as if his life depended on it, Phainon rushed to the other side of the car, sliding into the passenger seat and slamming the car door shut before Mydei even had a chance to start the car. Now that he was sitting inside, the interior was extremely nice. With a large screen in the center of the dashboard and red leather seating, Phainon did not doubt in his mind that he was being treated *very* nicely as the CEO's son.

“Where are we going?” Phainon watched the screen flicker on, with the roaring engine vibrating his entire body now that Mydei had turned the car

on.

“I thought it didn't matter.” Mydei wasn't paying the least bit of attention to him as he buckled in his seatbelt and put the car into reverse.

“I'm just curious.” After buckling in his own seatbelt, Phainon relaxed into the luxurious seats, scanning the large screen in front of him to try and find any information about Mydei. He thought that, maybe, if he learned more about the other man, it would somehow jog his memory of last night's events. But the screen didn't reveal much at all. It was just showing some generic home screen, and the only customizable information Phainon could find was the name of Mydei's cell phone that was connected to the system. “Does that say *‘fig stew’?*”

“What says ‘fig stew’?”

“The name of your phone.”

“...I don't know what you're talking about.”

“It's right there!” Phainon gesticulated wildly at the grand screen before them, but Mydei's eyes never left the road.

“I'm driving.”

“Then look when we're at a stoplight.”

“That's dangerous.”

“It's for a second!”

“A second could mean the difference between life and death on the road.”

Phainon opted to just shut his mouth and let the man drive instead. He hadn't realized that this man was so serious both inside the office *and* outside the office, but he couldn't exactly argue with the driver of the car over how to drive his own car. Instead, he turned his attention to the scenery outside, of the city scenery and the after-work traffic that filled the crowded streets. People of all ages walked along the sidewalk, visiting the various

stores along the streets, and the setting sun cast a gorgeous glow over the entire city. It was a beautiful evening, and it was a perfect way to begin the weekend. It was too bad that Phainon had planned to spend his precious evening and weekend with this man who abhorred his presence.

He had no choice but to sit in silence. Although he didn't mind being quiet, what he *did* mind was being in such close proximity to a man who hated him. Phainon hadn't planned for this, as it was a spur of the moment to start annoying Mydei with his own presence. But it felt extremely awkward and tense, and Phainon's brain kept reminding him of every single instance Mydei had glared at him, snapped at him, and ignored him at work. The silence was beating down on his body, and he could barely bring himself to glance in the direction of the driver. Phainon wanted to say anything to break this heavy silence, but it really didn't help that Phainon had basically forced himself into this car. All he could do was fidget in his seat with his eyes glued to the outside scenery. He was the most aware of his presence in this car than he had ever been before. Was this really how he would spend his time until Mydei finally confessed the truth? Was there even a chance of Mydei opening up to him in the slightest?

But finally, after the longest and heaviest few minutes of his life, the car pulled over to a tiny parking lot off the side of the street and shut off. Phainon glanced around at the area before them while Mydei began exiting the car, and with Phainon following close behind, he found himself standing in front of a very humble bakery.

He was in awe at the very cute sign, so much so that he had to chase after Mydei, who had already entered the little shop. It had a theme of pastel yellow and white, with most of the furniture consisting of white oak wood. While Phainon was too busy admiring the sight before him, Mydei had already grabbed a tray near the entrance and begun stocking up on various sorts of pastries. And, much to Phainon's surprise, not a single pastry on his tray was savory.

"Do you want anything?" Mydei stopped in front of Phainon with the tray in his hands.

Phainon gawked at the tray that was packed to the brim. It almost looked as if half the bakery's stock was in his hands. But what surprised him even more was the offer that Mydei had given him. “You're actually going to buy me something?”

“*Hmph*. If you don't want anything, just say so.” Mydei immediately whirled around toward the cash register, and Phainon scrambled to react.

“Wait, wait!” Phainon wildly waved his hands to try and stop the other man. “Let me look around!”

With a sigh, Mydei finally halted his steps, giving Phainon a chance to actually look at the shelves of pastries that were organized all along the walls of the small store. There were pastries of almost any kind of flavor imaginable, both consisting of sweet and savory. Not only were there pastries, but an assortment of cakes, cookies, and other sweet treats could be found organized together in a separate part of the store. Not only was the store neatly organized, but they had almost any kind of dessert imaginable in such a small space.

Since Phainon had never actually visited this bakery before, he opted for a simple and safe choice. It was just a butter croissant, which he carefully placed on the top of Mydei's overwhelming pile.

“That's it?” Mydei almost frowned at the single croissant that lay on top of the numerous other pastries in the tray.

“Are you going to let me buy something else?” Phainon teased. He was shocked that this man was even buying something for him in the first place, so he didn't want to push his luck by adding more than warranted.

“Is there nothing else that you want?” The gaze that Mydei gave him was one that Phainon had never seen on Mydei's face before. He was used to the glares and scowls that he always received, but why did he look so rejected at Phainon's choice of pastry?

“Are you… actually offering to buy me more?” His eyes wildly searched Mydei's expression to ensure he didn't miss a single emotion across his

face. Phainon also wanted to make sure that this man was actually serious, but it really didn't seem like Mydei was trying to humor him.

“Take as much as you want. I'll buy it for you.”

“Really?” After all the rudeness and impoliteness Mydei had thrown his way, Phainon really couldn't believe that this was the same man who had snapped at him earlier this morning just for handing him some papers.

“How many times do I have to tell you that I will?” Mydei snapped.

There it was–the tone of voice that Mydei always used with Phainon. It made Phainon jump into action, and with a couple more items added to the already overflowing tray, Mydei approached the counter to check out. Phainon wasn't surprised when Mydei was handed three boxes of pastries, and he held one up to Phainon, which he could only assume possessed the pastries that Mydei had bought for him.

Taking the box from Mydei, he stared in shock at the handful of pastries that were carefully packed into the carrier through the transparent window on the side of the box. Phainon still couldn't believe that Mydei, the man who scowled at the mere sight of him, who glared every time they made eye contact, and who didn't even know his name, willingly spent money on him.

Phainon smiled, admiring the delicious pastries inside. It was a true and genuine smile. It wasn't one of his polite, HR smiles, and it wasn't a straining smile from trying to appear calm and collected in front of stress at work. It was a real smile, one that he was so sure he would never have had around Mydei of all people. Yet, here Phainon was, feeling appreciated by the other man.

He lowered the box, locking eyes with Mydei. “Thank you, Mydei.”

Mydei paused, staring blankly at Phainon. But right now, Phainon didn't care how much Mydei didn't like him. Somehow, Phainon didn't hate being around him right now. Maybe Mydei wasn't as bad as he had originally thought. Or maybe, Mydei was finally warming up to him after all of these

years. Whatever it was, Phainon could say that he actually didn't mind being with Mydei right now. When did Phainon start to feel relaxed around Mydei? Suddenly, his tense shoulders from the car ride were gone, the expectancy of glares and scowls disappeared, and he actually felt like he was spending a pleasant evening with his coworker.

“It's nothing.” Mydei whipped his head around and exited the store, with Phainon following close behind. It must've been too hot in the store because Mydei's ears were burning red, but maybe the store kept warm for all the pastries on the shelves. But somehow, Phainon's chest was also feeling warm. It was probably because this was the first time Mydei had ever treated him with such kindness, even if the other man was still speaking with him in a rough manner. And somehow, Phainon couldn't get enough of this new side of Mydei, a side that he had never been a witness to before.

He wanted *more*.

With the car roaring to life once more, the both of them settled into their seats before they were off. The sun had officially lowered underneath the horizon, with the beautiful array of colors slowly fading away into a vast, night sky. Unfortunately, due to being in the city, stars were not a common sight in the sky, but today, it seemed as if nothing could ruin Phainon's mood.

It was a comfortable silence–vastly different from the car ride to the bakery. Phainon was excited to try the pastries that Mydei had bought him, and he couldn't stop himself from staring down at the box in his lap and smiling at the thought that this was Mydei’s first, officially kind gesture toward him. Was this how Mydei was treating everyone but him at the office? Would he buy pastries for everyone else too? Why… did he have to treat Phainon so coldly?

“Mydei,” Phainon couldn't stop the emotions swirling in his chest. It had never bothered him before; he had always brushed it off. All the glares that were shot at him and the blatant coldness that Mydei threw his way– Phainon never paid any mind to it. But why was today so different? Why could he not tear his eyes away from the box of pastries sitting in his lap?

Why did this simple box feel so heavy? “Why do you treat me so differently?”

A silence followed his question. Maybe Phainon was pushing him too much. Or maybe, Phainon was the only one who felt any sort of connection with the other man today. He thought, after today, that Mydei would, at least, answer this question, but maybe they had already returned to two coworkers who regularly ignored each other's presence. Then again, Phainon was the one who forced himself into his car and had money spent on today. It would make sense if Mydei despised him even *more* now.

“Remember the events from last night, and you'll figure it out.”

Phainon’s head shot up at those words, and he whipped his head around to stare at the driver with wide eyes. “You *told* me last night?!”

“This is your place, right?”

Instead of answering his question, Mydei shifted the car into park after pulling up to the curb. Phainon’s gaze flickered outside the window, where he saw his apartment building. But, Phainon wasn't ready to leave yet. He was just beginning to get more details about the previous night. And how else could he squeeze the truth out of Mydei if he left so early?

“What's your address?” Phainon turned to Mydei with a smile. “Let me come over tomorrow.”

“I'm working.”

“You *work* tomorrow?” Phainon was flabbergasted. Wasn't it the weekend tomorrow?

“I work every weekend.” Mydei didn't seem the least annoyed with this information. He was stating it as if it were a simple fact, as if it were normal for him to work seven days a week. Was it really that arduous as the next CEO?

Nonetheless, this put a wrench in Phainon's plans. He had meant to annoy the man all day and every day to finally force the truth out of him, but it wasn't as if he could disturb Mydei while he was working on a weekend. It probably already felt terrible enough just having to go into the office on the weekend. Well, at least Phainon got his weekend back.

“I see. It must be hard, being the next CEO.” With a light chuckle, Phainon stepped out onto the sidewalk. “Then, I'll see you on Monday.”

Mydei nodded, and Phainon watched the black sedan merge into traffic and disappear from his view.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Ahh! Phainon!”

“Do you like it right there, my love?”

“Mmm! Just like that!”

“Hah… Are you close? Can you cum for me?”

“AHH! PHAINON, I'M–”

Phainon's eyes shot open at the first beat of his blaring alarm. Heart pounding, chest heaving, and straining pants–these were words that Phainon would use to describe his morning the entire weekend. Now here he was again, Monday morning, with another pulsing erection.

He shut his alarm off with a groan, burying his burning face into the palms of his sweaty hands. Wasn't Phainon too old for wet dreams now? Where were all of these coming from? Phainon hadn't had sex in years, yet he was having the same dream every single night, sleeping with a mysterious person who he could never recall the moment he opened his eyes. The person’s face, body, and voice–all of it disappeared the moment Phainon saw his bedroom. And every single morning, Phainon had to get himself off to the sounds of moans he could not recognize and barely even recall but shot straight to his dick every time his hands wrapped around his length.

He had work in about an hour, but he couldn't possibly go into the office like this. Phainon was tired of how many times he had gotten himself off already. Was he a teenager going through puberty again? Why was this happening to him? He didn't even have this many wet dreams when he was *actually* a teenager. But it wasn't as if anything unusual happened over the weekend.

With a sigh, Phainon buried his hand in his pants, immediately jumping at the brief touch of his fingertips along his erection. His breath hitched in his throat as he began stroking himself, pushing his waistband aside to give relief to the straining erection that had been asking for attention since the moment he opened his eyes. His dick stood proudly in the air, fully hard over a dream that he could not fully remember.

Pleasure rushed through his veins, and his eyes lowered to the dick in his hand that was already pulsing in satisfaction. All Phainon could think of was what a greedy bastard his dick was, getting pleasured every single morning, but he had to bite his bottom lip to stifle a groan when the moans from his dreams echoed in his mind. Where did they come from? Who was Phainon even listening to?

And why did they feel so familiar?

A gasp escaped his lips the faster his hands pumped his aching cock. Heels dug into the bed at the warmth that began to churn in the pit of his stomach, and Phainon’s eyes had fluttered shut as he became a slave to the pleasure rushing through his entire body. He could feel his dick quivering in absolute delight in the palm of his hand and leaking in precum, coating his length, and the squelching sounds that reverberated from his hand only spurred him faster.

“Mmph! Phainon!”

“Faster! Ahh, Phainon! Right there!”

Phainon gritted his teeth and threw his head back at the moans that echoed in his head and haunted his sleep, and he couldn't help his own grunts and moans from slipping past his lips and filling his bedroom. His legs were shaking and tangling within his own sheets, with electricity sparking through each and every one of his limbs as he approached his own high.

He was left panting and gasping for breath over the moans of a person that he couldn't even imagine where they came from, and he could almost imagine himself thrusting into the warmth of this stranger whom he lusted over. The way they called his name so beautifully, the way they pleaded for

him so lovingly–all of it was too much for Phainon's brain, and he swore he could almost feel the twitching and fluttering of the insides that he imagined sinking himself into.

The wet and warm insides that enveloped his cock, the delicious moans that echoed in his ears–all of it was too realistic, and he found himself wildly thrusting into his pumping hand, moaning into the morning air, and burying his other hand into the sheets as his stomach tightened over the oncoming orgasm that was about to take hold of his entire body. Phainon swore he could even hear the slapping of skin echoing across the bedroom walls, almost as if that mysterious partner were in his room right at that moment, riding his dick and taking in his entire girth deep inside of them. The weight of the other person falling into his lap, bouncing against his thighs, and massaging and squeezing around his needy cock to milk him of every single drop possible–Phainon could feel every single sensation as if it were all real.

Alternating between teasing the head of his dick and pumping his entire length, Phainon could not take the pleasure that was numbing his entire body anymore. His back arched off the mattress, his mouth dropped open, and a long, wanton moan ripped through the air as his hips violently jolted against his hand. His vision turned white as he imagined spilling himself inside of that deep and cavernous warmth, and his cum splattered against his stomach as his body spasmed against his bed. His fingers continued grasping and pumping his quivering dick of all his cum until he could no longer take the pleasure that was running through his veins.

His body slumped into his bed, his brain dizzy, and the view of his bedroom slowly returned to him. As Phainon lay there, chest heaving from recovering from his orgasm, a thought suddenly popped into his mind.

He left his car at work again because he had caught a ride with Mydei last week.

"Good morning!"

Phainon could not return the same enthusiasm to his close friend, and he dropped his belongings at his desk before dropping himself into his office chair. He could not even believe that he, at his age, had masturbated right before coming into work. Sure, he wasn't *that* old, but he was surely old enough not to have wet dreams three days in a row over someone that probably didn't even exist.

He furrowed his eyebrows. There was no way that statement was true. It just didn't sit right with him. The dreams felt too realistic for them to be just a wild imagination. But Phainon really hadn't had sex in *years*. He couldn't even remember the last time he had slept with anyone. Maybe his brain was unconsciously recalling his previous experiences? But, for some reason, that didn't sound right to Phainon either.

“Phainon!”

He jumped at his name being called, whirling his head to Cyrene, who had her eyes narrowed in concern, leaning in his direction with a hand on her hip. “Are you okay? You didn't respond to me earlier either.”

“Fine.” Phainon responded a little too quickly, which didn't escape Cyrene's notice.

She raised an eyebrow with a small frown, but she didn't question him, only handing him a coffee that she had already prepared for him in her other hand. “Just don't forget we have that monthly meeting with the executive department today. And you *will* be telling me what happened to you later.”

Cyrene departed, but the mention of the executive department had reminded him. Since Phainon had the entire weekend to himself, he had completely forgotten his true objective: Operation Annoy Mydei.

He was only able to gather a couple of facts from the previous week: Something extraordinary had happened, and it may be related to something Phainon had said to Mydei–something so important that it hurt Mydei that Phainon had forgotten, causing him to treat Phainon with even more hostility than usual. And the most important thing he learned was that Mydei had revealed why he treated Phainon so much differently from

everyone else in the company–something that Phainon had been wondering about for literal *years*.

Mydei *really* had to tell him so much important information while Phainon was drunk out of his mind? Could he not have told Phainon this anytime earlier, back when Phainon was trying to befriend him when he first joined the company? He *really* had to choose that night specifically? Was it a coincidence, or was it *because* Phainon was drunk that Mydei decided to reveal the truth?

There was no point in dwelling on questions with no answers. It only made his head spin, and the fastest way he would be able to get the answers he needed was to go to the source himself. Resolving to pass the time until the meeting between the human resources department and the executive department, Phainon quickly buried himself in his work.

The human resources department and the executive department met monthly, mostly because the two departments worked so closely together that it was just convenient to meet monthly to provide regular updates and feedback. Usually, it was mostly the managers and other higher-ups who participated the most in these meetings, but it was important for everyone in these two departments to attend. Which also meant that the star of his operation would have to attend this meeting as well.

The meeting usually occurred for an hour, right before their lunch hour, and Phainon resolved to catch Mydei the moment their meeting ended and before he could escape to drag him to the cafeteria with him. Phainon was going to spend every possible moment with him, and he was not going to let Mydei take a single break. He would rush to finish as much work as he could in the mornings, drag him to lunch, and follow him back to his office for the later half of the day to bother him for as much as possible before returning to his desk before the workday ended. It was a genius plan–one that would even bother Phainon if he were the one in Mydei's position.

When the time for the meeting arrived, he walked with Castorice and Cyrene over to one of the many conference rooms in the building. This one, located on the floor that they worked on, was one of the largest conference rooms that the company had, and it was also the most technologically

advanced out of all the other conference rooms. With a giant monitor, the most expensive and ergonomic desk chairs, and the largest conference table, Phainon was sure it was because the executive department existed on this floor. The coolest feature of the meeting room was that the all-glass, floor-to-ceiling windows could flicker shut with a click of a button, blocking out the view of anyone standing outside the room. That was probably due to the human resources department, as they were always tasked with dealing with important and confidential employee information.

Seating himself in the luxe office chair, Phainon watched the executive department settling into their own seats from across the long conference table. But he was specifically eyeing a golden-haired man who was sitting near the head of the table. Phainon could barely even remember all those years when he hated having to speak with Mydei, because now, watching him from afar and completely ignoring Phainon's burning gaze, he almost could not wait for the meeting to end so that he could bother Mydei to the fullest. It felt almost as if he were finally exacting his revenge against the other man, who had treated him so coldly for so many years. And seeing Mydei so obviously bothered by Phainon's presence satisfied him.

Mydei was easy to bother, and he was easy to evoke a reaction from. Why hadn't Phainon done this earlier in retaliation for Mydei's obvious malice? Phainon was no longer trying to avoid Mydei's gaze in the hallways or bracing himself for the insults that would spew his way whenever he tried to deliver any documents to him. Now, it was as if he had turned the tables, and Mydei was now the one avoiding him while trying not to spill what had happened after the company dinner had concluded. It was an amazing feeling, one that Phainon refused to let go of.

Once the CEO had entered, the meeting started. Phainon couldn't believe that this man was Mydei's father, as they shared almost zero resemblance. The CEO was a very stoic, expressionless man, with narrowed eyes and a sharp jawline. He had very sharp and harsh features, emphasizing his impassiveness, and no emotion dared to cross his face. It was the exact opposite of Mydei, who was easy to get a rise out of. And, although Phainon hated to admit it, he was definitely a sight for sore eyes. Mydei had objectively, conventionally attractive features. That may be why so many

people in the office favored him so well. He may not have been much of a talker, but he was good at his job, intelligent, and good-looking. Those three factors definitely put him in everyone's books as a solid employee.

With different leaders from the two departments standing up to speak and provide updates, the meeting finally came to an end when the clock struck the next hour. Unfortunately, Phainon had to tear his eyes away from the CEO's son to take notes during the meeting on anything important that applied to his job, such as changes in laws that affected important onboarding documents, but once the meeting had ended, Phainon practically sprang out of his chair, shocking the two women with whom he had arrived at the meeting room with.

“Mydei!” Phainon called over the rushing of the other staff exiting the room to begin their lunch break. Phainon rushed against the foot traffic until he found himself right in front of that beloved head of golden hair. “Eat lunch with me?”

The other man was reviewing his notes, and golden eyes immediately turned up to glare at Phainon at the sound of his voice. “I'm busy.”

Despite the usual nasty glare, Phainon grinned. Somehow, dealing with Mydei’s abhorrent attitude was becoming easier and easier. “The meeting just ended. Surely, you don't have anything else for the next hour during lunch?”

“I need to review my notes.”

“You can do that after lunch, right?”

“I have other things to do after lunch.”

Mydei pushed himself from his chair, and Phainon knew he was running out of time. “Then, review your notes during lunch with me. When else are you going to eat? It's important to eat, and it looks like you work out, right?”

His golden eyes narrowed in Phainon's direction. “I'd rather review my notes in silence.”

Phainon watched Mydei packing up his things, and Phainon began racking his brain for anything else that could make the other man even slightly pause. He only needed one more second to make the man stop so that he could scramble to think of another way to convince him to spend time with him.

“I haven't eaten the pastries you bought me yet.”

Mydei suddenly stopped. He was just pushing in his office chair and was about to exit the room, but instead, he turned his gaze back onto Phainon. “You haven't? It's been three days.”

To be honest, because of Phainon's hangover on Friday and still going into work, he immediately collapsed upon returning home. And upon waking up with an erection for the next two days with wet dreams haunting him every night, he had completely forgotten about the pastries that he was given. Phainon only remembered this morning, when he was about to pack a salad for lunch, that he recalled those abandoned pastries and decided to bring them instead.

“I… forgot.” Phainon's lips turned up into a wry smile, neglecting to fully explain any details. “I want to try them with you, since you're here.”

It seemed that Mydei had a soft spot for these pastries, which Phainon definitely filed that fact in the back of his mind. Phainon wasn't sure if it was these pastries specifically, or just pastries in general. But Mydei's cold eyes had softened, his tense shoulders relaxed, and his fingers that were rushing to gather all of his things finally stilled.

His eyes flickered back and forth between Phainon's straining smile and the notes in his hand, and a deep sigh finally left his chest after a couple of seconds of internal debate. “Fine. Let's go.”

Phainon's eyes widened. “Really?!”

“Do you, or do you not want to, eat lunch with me?” Mydei’s harsh tone immediately returned, and Phainon rushed to follow the other man out of the room.

With each of them returning to their desks to store their notes away, Phainon and Mydei approached the elevator to head for the first floor, where the company cafeteria was located. The first floor consisted of the main lobby, some spare private office spaces that were usually used for interviews, and the employee cafeteria, which was in the back of the first floor. Scanning his office badge, he led Mydei into the cafeteria, where most of the staff had gathered for their lunch break.

They settled in a corner of the grand space at an empty table, and Phainon placed the pastry box that he had snatched from his desk when he had put his notes away.

“Did you eat all of those pastries you bought already?” Phainon was attempting a conversation while opening the box in front of him.

“Not all of them,” Mydei answered. “Did you think I could eat all of those in one sitting?”

Phainon laughed, and he realized that it was probably the first time he had ever laughed in front of Mydei and to Mydei. Was it just Phainon, or was Mydei treating him so much more gently today? Was it really all due to these pastries? “I was already surprised that you were getting so much in the first place. I don't know what your eating habits are like.”

“It's my favorite bakery. I visit every day.”

“*Every* day?” Phainon's eyebrows shot upward. “You go every day, and still get that much?”

“The same things aren't made every day, so I try to stock up on the ones that won't be there the next time I visit.”

“I see.” Phainon was trying to store this information in the Operation Annoy Mydei file in his head. He needed to know everything he could

possibly know about this man to finally get the truth out of him. “You must visit a lot to know that.”

“I do.”

“I didn't realize you liked sweets so much.”

“You would've known if you remembered the events of that night.”

Phainon flinched at the words that dropped onto him like a bucket of cold water. Mydei just had to use every opportunity he could to rub in his face that he knew what happened that night, while Phainon didn't, didn't he?

“We talked about sweets that night?” The box was finally opened, showcasing all of the pastries that Mydei had bought for him. Despite them being a couple of days old, they still looked delicious.

“We did.” Mydei neglected to expand on his sentence, and Phainon mentally cursed at the lack of detail. Mydei was too good at playing this game.

“We must've talked about a lot of things that night.” Phainon forced a chuckle, trying to make it seem as if it didn't bother him that Mydei somehow remembered that specific night in extreme detail.

“*You* were definitely talking about a lot of things.”

So it was true. Phainon definitely talked Mydei's ears off, most likely about random, embarrassing stories from his own life. How long was the walk back to his apartment that he had blabbered about his own life, talked about sweets, promised Mydei something, and had even gotten Mydei to confess the reason for his hatred against Phainon? It only made Phainon more frustrated that he could not remember those, probably, ten to fifteen minutes of his life. Why were these couple of minutes the most pivotal minutes of his entire life?

“I must've told you some embarrassing stuff, right?” Phainon lightly laughed. He couldn't even begin to imagine what he had possibly spilled

into Mydei’s ears. Mydei might now be the second person to know the most about Phainon, right after Cyrene. All because of that fifteen-minute walk back to his apartment.

“Not really.” Mydei furrowed his eyebrows while recalling the night that Phainon could not. Okay, fine. Brag about it right in front of Phainon's eyes, why don't you? “You *did* talk a lot about yourself, but I wouldn't say it was anything embarrassing.”

“Like what?”

“You really thought you could get it out of me, huh?”

Phainon scoffed, shaking his head with a smile. “You're too good at this, Mydei. At least give me something.”

With a challenging eyebrow raised, Mydei crossed his arms. “I did. It's sitting right in front of you.”

Phainon's eyes darted back down to the pastries that were sitting in front of him on the table. He had completely forgotten about them while trying to extract more information from the other man.

“You know what I mean.” Throwing a pout in Mydei’s direction, Phainon plucked up the first item that he had only meant to get: the butter croissant. Because it was a few days old, it was a little hard now, but Phainon didn't hesitate to take a healthy bite from one end of it.

Because it was a couple of days old, the exterior of the golden croissant was no longer as crispy and flaky as it should have been. But despite that, the texture of the inside of the croissant was somehow still buttery, soft, and chewy inside of his mouth. With a perfectly airy interior, the fluffiness of the croissant almost made it melt into his mouth, and Phainon was sure it would've done just that had the croissant still been fresh. And after he had finished his bite, the taste of the butter that lingered on his tongue only left him craving more.

Phainon stared at the rest of the giant croissant in his hand, and he was utterly ecstatic that there was still so much left. Admiring the inner structure of the croissant, he was taken aback when someone had cleared their throat from right across from him. Phainon was ripped from his thoughts of the butter croissant and met with golden eyes that he forgot were watching him the entire time.

“How… is it?” It was as if Mydei was struggling to ask Phainon for his opinion, and he had to basically force the words out of his own mouth. Well, Phainon was sure it didn't exactly feel good to ask for feedback from someone he didn't like.

“It's good.” Phainon held the croissant in front of Mydei's face with a huge grin on his face. “It may be a little old, but if it's already good like this, I cannot possibly imagine what it was like when it was fresh.”

Mydei stared at the croissant being held in front of him, and Phainon swore he saw his shoulders relaxing. Was Mydei really that worried over Phainon's feedback? Or maybe it was just that hard to ask for Phainon's feedback?

“I'm glad you like it,” was all Mydei said as he continued to study the croissant.

Frowning, Phainon waved the croissant in front of them. “I'm holding this up so that you can eat it, you know.”

The other man's eyes immediately shot to lock with Phainon's, and his nasty, signature glare returned. “I'm not eating this.”

“It's not even that old!”

“I absolutely do not ever want to share food with *you*.”

Grumbling under his breath, Phainon lowered the croissant and bit back a sigh. He had almost forgotten that the man in front of him didn't just dislike him; Mydei absolutely *despised* him. Their simple, civil conversation just now had made him forget, and the evening that they had spent at the bakery

also made him forget. But did he really have to word it like that? A simple rejection would've been fine, but he didn't have to act so disgusted by the idea of sharing a meal with him. “Fine. Suit yourself.”

He finished the rest of his croissant, but he truly did not feel like eating the rest of the food in front of him. It just left a terrible taste in his mouth that someone who hated him had spent money on him, and Phainon eventually dug into his pocket to pull out his phone. “Let me pay you back for these.”

“I told you, I was going to pay for them,” Mydei immediately retorted.

“It just doesn't sit right with me that you paid for them.”

“Then make it sit right with you.”

Mydei really knew just how to rub Phainon the wrong way, didn't he?

Phainon could not stop his exasperated sigh this time. “Look. I don't want to owe a favor to someone who hates me.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “You don't owe me anything.”

“If you gave me something for free, then I obviously owe you something back,” Phainon snapped. He was being reminded of why he hated spending time with Mydei so much, and at this point, he just wanted to leave for the day and try his operation again tomorrow. “Just tell me where to send the money.”

“And why would I tell you that?”

“So I can send you money.”

“I don't need your money.”

Right. The CEO’s son probably took a bath in dollar bills and a solid gold tub every single day. Phainon was sure the money he spent at the bakery every evening was just chump change to him. But how else could he pay Mydei back? If he didn't want money, what else could Phainon possibly offer him?

At the expression flickering in distress across Phainon's face, Mydei continued to speak: “I already told you. You don't owe me anything.”

“But–”

“Your words were already enough for me.”

Pausing, Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. What words was he talking about? Running their most recent conversation in his head, his eyes eventually landed on the rest of the pastries that were still sitting in their box. All they really talked about were the pastries and references to the night of the company dinner.

“The words… about the croissant?” He slowly lifted his gaze toward Mydei, whose anger had dissipated from his face and left him with a normal, stoic expression.

“I'm glad that you enjoyed the croissant.”

Phainon could not believe the sight that he was now currently laying his eyes upon. His heart stopped in his chest, his breathing stilled, and his eyes widened like saucers as if to capture this moment and ingrain it into his head as a photographic memory.

Mydei was smiling.

There was no mistaking it. His lips were curved upwards into a soft smile, with golden eyes sparkling under the cafeteria lighting. With eyes slightly lowered and a faint splash of red across his cheeks, Mydei was the absolute picture of a shy maiden who appeared as if she had been given the greatest compliment in the world from her beloved. It was as if she had prepared a grand feast for her beloved, who was showering her with compliments over the delicious food that she had prepared just for her loved one.

And even when their lunch break had ended an hour later, Phainon could not erase that picture-perfect moment out of his head for the entire rest of the day.

Chapter End Notes

- **Phainon's "Operation Annoy Mydei" File**

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Okay, seriously, what is happening to you?”

It was the end of the workday, and Phainon had missed his chance of squeezing himself into Mydei's car before he left the office building, as he had planned. Why? Because he was currently being cornered by two women at his own office desk.

Staring between the two women towering over him before he could even stand to leave his own cubicle, Phainon put on the most relaxed smile he could muster while answering Cyrene's question. “I don't know what you're talking about.”

“You were… talking to… *Mydei*.” Castorice spoke these words as if it were a crime for Phainon to be seen interacting with the CEO's son.

“Isn't it normal to speak with a fellow coworker who you work very closely with?” Phainon almost wanted to laugh at his own reasoning; clearly, it was not normal for him to be speaking with Mydei, and it was clear that Cyrene was also trying to hold in her own laughter at hearing his response.

“Since when did you two get so friendly?” Only a smile surfaced on Cyrene's lips, but she managed to hold herself in. “Weren't you the one who was so against Mydei taking you home while you were drunk?”

“I have no idea what you're talking about.” Phainon's own smile gave him away.

Castorice turned to Cyrene in a low whisper, but Phainon clearly caught every syllable that she spoke: “Has Phainon finally lost it?”

Cyrene narrowed her eyes, muttering in response, “I think Mydei has officially made him crack.”

“You guys, I can hear everything you are saying.” Phainon couldn't hold in his laughter this time upon seeing the embarrassment that washed over Castorice’s face. Cyrene, however, was hard to embarrass.

“So, answer our questions.” With her usual delighted smile, Cyrene returned her attention back to Phainon. “What did Mydei do to make you lose it this time?”

“Maybe he finally lost it when Mydei took him home?” Castorice's worried gaze shifted between Phainon and Cyrene, who sharply gasped at these words.

“Maybe Mydei has been stalking Phainon now that he knows where Phainon lives?!”

“That is *not* happening!” Phainon cried. “And anyway, if I were actually being stalked, I would be staying at your place, Cyrene, rather than returning home every single day to a stalker.”

Her shoulders deflated, as if she was actually looking forward to Phainon being stalked by the CEO's son. “I guess that's true.”

“Look, Mydei didn't make me ‘crack’ or anything. I'm fine. He's fine. We're both fine.” Phainon only received two very dubious stares in response, and he narrowed his eyes at them. “What?”

“Mydei has definitely… been acting very differently.” Castorice was nervously shifting in place.

“*Too* differently,” Cyrene continued.

Flickering his gaze between Cyrene and Castorice to await more details, neither one of them decided to expand on their statements. “*Okay*, is that a *good* differently or a *bad* differently?”

“Differently,” Both women replied in unison.

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “Can I, at least, get some examples?”

The two women locked eyes with each other as they fell deep into thought. Well, Phainon couldn't tell if they were thinking or if they were having a silent conversation with each other.

Cyrene was the first one to turn back to Phainon. “He's been more… How should I say this?” She hummed, leaning her weight on one leg. “Expressive?” With Castorice nodding enthusiastically in agreement, Cyrene continued: “He reacts more when you speak with him. He's usually very straight-faced, but polite. I don't know how to describe it, but he feels… *warmer* now.”

“*Warmer*,” Phainon deadpanned. “What does that even mean?”

It was Cyrene's turn to furrow her eyebrows. “It's… hard to describe for you when Mydei always treats you so rudely. But to everyone else, he is much different than before.”

Phainon laughed. “Wow, thanks.”

“I think it's a good thing,” Castorice jumped in. “He seems more… open.”

With another vague answer, Phainon smiled wryly. “Are you guys purposefully talking in riddles, or?”

“It's a very minute change,” Cyrene added. “Just because we see Mydei quite often is why we noticed, but I don't think the average employee would notice. But, it just seems more like… Like we can talk to him now.”

Phainon coughed, covering his own sarcastic laugh. “If *you* can talk to him now, what does that make me?”

“He was always intimidating,” Cyrene continued. “Intimidating, but polite. Nowadays, I don't think he is so intimidating anymore. He feels less like the CEO's son and more like… more like a coworker now.”

Her words embedded into Phainon's brain. More like a coworker, and less intimidating? And this has started to happen just recently?

“*So*, what's up with you?” Cyrene deftly turned the conversation topic back onto Phainon with a sly smile. “Has Mydei been growing on you the last few days?”

Phainon's face burned red at her words, and he scoffed despite his immediate reaction. “Absolutely not. That guy still despises me with his entire soul.”

“I didn't ask about *him*.” Cyrene shoved a perfectly manicured nail against Phainon's chest. “I asked about *you*.”

“I still would rather not have anything to do with him.” Phainon averted his glare toward nothing in particular at the thought of the other man, but the finger pressing into his chest only emphasized how rapidly his heart rattled his rib cage. Clearly, even his own heart had a visceral reaction at the mere thought of the source of all his stress recently. His body was already entering fight-or-flight mode just thinking about the other man.

Cyrene hummed, slowly sliding her finger away. “Then, why do you keep trying to speak with him? Seeing you approach Mydei after the meeting today was anything but natural.”

“And even asking him to lunch too!” Castorice squeaked. “That was… quite a sight, Phainon.”

Phainon couldn't help but agree with the two women, and another wry smile appeared upon his lips while reflecting on his horrible situation. “Long story short, I'm trying to convince Mydei to tell me what happened when he brought me home.”

“But he won't tell you what happened?” Cyrene raised an eyebrow.

“No.” Phainon sighed tiredly. “I keep bothering him every day, and he keeps dropping vague bits of information that aren't enough to fully piece together what happened. I just want to know what happened while I was out, but for some reason, he refuses to tell me.”

Humming once more, Cyrene offered, “Maybe Mydei did something embarrassing while taking you home?”

Phainon did have that thought initially when he was trying to guess why Mydei refused to tell him the entire truth of the events, but he had later dismissed it when he learned that he had said something important to Mydei and then forgot, earning Mydei’s ire in the process. “*I* was the drunk one, not Mydei.”

“But Mydei was *definitely* not sober,” Cyrene stated. She stated it so matter-of-factly that Phainon had almost missed this new, key detail, and his eyes widened when his brain fully processed her words.

“He wasn't?!” Phainon's gaze immediately shot up to lock eyes with her.

Cyrene shook her head. “When I asked him to bring you home, his face was red. He said he only drank a glass, but I couldn't tell if he was lying or if he gets drunk very easily. Whatever it was, he was definitely not sober.”

“He also looked very tired,” Castorice added.

“I'm sure sleepiness and being buzzed isn't a good combination.” Cyrene shrugged. Something was swirling in Cyrene's eyes, almost as if she were putting her own puzzle pieces together. “Maybe alcohol makes Mydei sleepy?”

“Sleepy…” Phainon murmured to himself in a low voice. All of this information was currently being stowed into the Operation Annoy Mydei file, and although he had learned new information, it still wasn't quite enough to piece everything together. Even while gathering the rest of his belongings, exiting the building, and bidding farewell to Cyrene and Castorice, Phainon was still having trouble trying to figure everything out. But, this new information definitely shed some light on a couple of curious areas.

The fact that Mydei was not sober was quite interesting in itself. How was Mydei able to remember everything in such clear detail despite being drunk? Sure, he wasn't blackout drunk like Phainon was and still held some

semblance of sanity, but the fact that he recalled every single detail was extremely curious. And suspicious. How could he remember everything so well? Unless, something external helped him remember? Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. What external thing could possibly jog Mydei's memory?

Maybe he had a really good memory even with alcohol in his system? Maybe Cyrene was correct in that he really did only drink one glass. But, it wouldn't make sense as to why he was so tired. Castorice didn't say he looked tired, but *very* tired. And Phainon didn't think they would stay at the restaurant very late anyway, since they all still had work the next day. Either Mydei drank more than a glass; he was very easily affected by the alcohol, even with just one glass; or his bedtime was just extremely early.

With two men, who were clearly not in their right minds, stumbling through the streets, Phainon had to rethink the entire walk back to his apartment from the restaurant. Pulling out his phone on the way to finally retrieve his car from the parking structure, he typed in the restaurant name that they had dined at and his address. It was just short of a ten-minute walk; Phainon had originally guessed about fifteen minutes if Mydei was struggling to bring Phainon along with him, but now, after learning that Mydei was *also* drunk, the walk had to be definitely longer than that. It made sense how they could've talked about so many things if the walk was actually much longer than fifteen minutes.

All that aside and filed away into his mental operation files, tomorrow he had to glue himself to Mydei's side once more. Phainon missed his opportunity to join him for the evening today, but he would continue to do that tomorrow and the following days if Cyrene and Castorice decided to not disrupt his plans again. But how was he supposed to glue himself to Mydei's side if the only thing Phainon really knew was that Mydei liked sweets? And that bakery?

There was something about that bakery that exceptionally piqued Phainon's interest. There had to be a very specific reason why Mydei chose to visit every single day, right? Surely, no sane customer would buy piles of pastries every single day, no matter how much a person enjoyed pastries and other baked goods. And if he liked pastries so much, wouldn't he try pastries at other bakeries? Why specifically buy piles and piles of pastries

from the *exact same bakery?* Maybe he should do his own investigation of the bakery to find some more clues about Mydei.

After that earlier conversation he had with Cyrene and Castorice, Phainon was almost positive that Mydei had finished his business at the bakery by now, giving Phainon free rein to explore the bakery to the fullest. He didn't really get a chance to study much of the bakery when he first visited with Mydei, as most of his attention was on Mydei rather than the bakery, but this time, Phainon was going to take notes on why the bakery was just so special to Mydei. If anything, it may just be the most convenient bakery to visit after work, considering that the location was so close to their office building. But, there were enough mysteries swirling in Phainon's mind to warrant exploring the bakery himself.

Hopping into his car, which he felt like he hadn't driven in so long, he searched for the nearest bakeries to the corporate building. Since he barely paid much attention to the bakery other than its cutesy decorations and light color scheme, Phainon didn't know what the bakery was called. But alas, after briefly searching through pictures of the closest bakeries, Phainon was reunited with that same pastel yellow and white color scheme that he saw last week. It definitely wasn't the closest bakery to the corporate office by any means, but it was still relatively close. And after putting his car into reverse and pulling out of the parking structure, it was only a couple of minutes later that he was pulling off the street into that familiar parking lot.

Phainon glanced around the tiny space and breathed a sigh of relief. Mydei's car was not there, confirming that Mydei was done with his business at the bakery, and Phainon exited his car to come face-to-face with the bakery’s front door.

“The Chimeras' Bakery?” Phainon couldn't help voicing the name of the bakery out loud, staring up at the bubbly font that spelled out the name he had neglected to remember. He would've never imagined that such a quaint bakery would be named after a mythical monster, but he filed the name away and proceeded inside.

The interior was the same as he had remembered it to be from yesterday, with white oak furniture and a pastel yellow and white color scheme.

Pastries, cakes, and other baked goods of all kinds were lined up on shelves along the walls, and from the obvious empty spaces in some of the shelves, Phainon was sure that it was evidence of Mydei's visit for the day.

"Welcome!" The cashier smiled at him once he had entered the little shop, but upon locking eyes with Phainon, her smile faltered slightly. "You didn't come with Mydei today."

Phainon raised an eyebrow. "You remember me?"

The cashier nodded. "I usually work evenings. Monday, Wednesday, and Friday."

"I see." Phainon *did* visit the bakery for the first time with Mydei last Friday. "I assume Mydei is a regular here? You seem to know him quite well."

"*Err*, yes." The cashier nodded stiffly. "He is here every day. You're the first person he has ever brought to this bakery himself. That's why I remember you so well."

Eyes widening in surprise, Phainon cocked his head to the side. "Really?"

"Yes. I figured you must be special to Mydei, if he was bringing you here himself."

Phainon actually had to hold in his laughter, and he swore he almost spit at the insane comment the cashier had made. Instead, Phainon cleared his throat in an attempt to bury his laughter away. "Right."

Fortunately, the cashier didn't seem to notice. "If you need anything, let me know."

With a nod, Phainon resumed his search around the bakery. He spotted the butter croissant he had tried before, which he picked up, but a particular card portraying the name of one of the pastries caught his attention.

"*Fig Stew?*"

His words seemed to capture the attention of the cashier, who began to elaborate: “Some of our specialty items that are the owner's own recipe have their own name. One of them is Fig Stew; obviously, it is not fig stew at all.”

But not only did the name catch Phainon's attention, as it was the name Mydei had purposefully given his phone and refused to acknowledge, the pastry in which the name belonged to was an extremely familiar set of golden honeycakes littered with berries. Those same honeycakes that were lathered in syrup and melted in Phainon's mouth the day after he had gotten drunk, these were the same honeycakes that Phainon thought he would never taste again.

Did *Mydei* give him those honeycakes?

A certain memory flashed in Phainon's mind of a certain break room in the office building. Phainon was arguing with Mydei over trying to convince the other man to tell Phainon what had happened that night, and if he had gotten home okay after dropping Phainon off at home. It was then that he had randomly said that sentence in the middle of their conversation:

You seemed to enjoy your lunch today.

Was *that* why Mydei said that to him? Because *Mydei* had bought it for him himself? Wait.

Phainon turned toward the cashier. “What are your hours here?”

The cashier hummed. “Seven in the morning to seven in the evening, every day.”

There was no possible way Mydei could have bought him these golden honeycakes after dropping him off at home. They didn't even start eating at the restaurant that night until about seven in the evening. Phainon frowned. Where did the golden honeycakes come from? Did Mydei just have them with him the whole time? But Mydei didn't take his car to Phainon's place, and he doubted Mydei would just bring honeycakes with him to the restaurant.

Then, where did the honeycakes come from? More specifically, *how* did Mydei give him those honeycakes?

“Do you have a question about the item Fig Stew?” That cashier could see just how confused and conflicted Phainon was, but he shook his head in response.

“Just doing my own thinking.” With a light laugh, Phainon added the honeycakes to his tray. Despite the mystery surrounding the honeycakes that had appeared on his counter that day, that wasn't going to stop him from indulging in them later. “Is there a reason the name is ‘Fig Stew’?”

“The specialty items are all named after characters in a children's book,” the cashier began to explain. “It's a book about small chimeras and their adventures in a city where the sun doesn't set. I believe the owner’s favorite character is Fig Stew.”

A children's book about chimeras… That explained the name of the bakery.

“So, I'm guessing these honeycakes are the owner's favorite recipe?”

Smiling, the cashier nodded. “That's correct. It is the owner's favorite thing to make in this entire shop.”

“I'm assuming the owner makes everything here, then?”

“That's also correct.” There was an extreme fondness in the eyes of the cashier as she continued to describe the owner of the bakery. “The owner wakes up every day at two in the morning to make these, and he continues to work until seven in the morning.”

“That's quite amazing.” With a chuckle, Phainon placed his tray of goods, consisting of the croissant and the golden honeycakes, in front of the cashier, who immediately began to pack them up into their respective boxes. “Your boss sounds like an amazing man.”

She nodded enthusiastically, pushing the boxes over to Phainon. “I admire him a lot.”

A few moments passed by, with Phainon silently standing at the counter, and he stared blankly at the boxes, at the counter, and eventually met the eyes of the cashier. “How much is it?”

The cashier’s eyes widened, waving her arms wildly in front of her. “There's no need to pay!”

“No need?”

She cleared her throat, lowering her arms. “Someone special to Mydei does not need to pay at this establishment.”

Did Mydei really contribute so much money to the bakery that Phainon was able to get food for free? Well, he *did* buy piles of pastries every day; Phainon was sure it was a pretty penny to buy so many every single day. But was Mydei really held in such high regard as a customer here?

“Mydei must be quite the special customer here.” Phainon chuckled, with the cashier joining him.

“Yes, he is. If you have any questions about him, too, I'd be happy to answer anything that I can.”

His eyes widened at her words. Now *that* was an offer. One that Phainon could not refuse.

“Really? Do you know that much about him?”

It seemed that this question seemed to shake the cashier from whatever stupor she had been in while speaking with Phainon, and her body grew rigid at his words. Opening and closing her mouth, her eyes wildly searched Phainon and the counter between them for a few moments in some sort of internal debate, but she finally, hesitantly responded, “I think it should be okay, since Mydei seems to treat you so specially.”

Phainon really did not know what that cashier was seeing last week when he had come here with Mydei, but whatever it was, he had to be thankful for it right now. There was a lot he didn't know about Mydei, but what

should he ask first? It had to be something concerning the bakery first, that was for sure.

“Does Mydei truly come here every day?”

The cashier nodded confidently. “Every single day.”

“And he gets something every day?”

Much to Phainon's surprise, the cashier shook her head. “Not every day.”

That was interesting. Why would he visit a bakery and not buy anything?

At the silence from Phainon, the cashier quickly scrambled to add, “He gets along with the workers here as a regular, so he often comes to visit us as well since we also give him free pastries.”

Raising an eyebrow, Phainon recalled the giant pile that Mydei had bought last week. “He never pays?”

“*Err.*.. He does.”

That made more sense now. It would basically be robbery if Mydei didn't pay for a giant stack almost every single day. “How much was last week's pile?”

“I… don't remember.”

“Do you have a guess?”

“Um…” Her eyes widened like saucers as they trembled and glued themselves to the wooden counter between them.

“If you really can't remember, no need to force yourself.” Phainon laughed. “I didn't mean to make it sound like an interrogation; I was only curious how much that giant pile would've cost him.”

The cashier's shoulders visibly relaxed as she let out a weak chuckle. “Right. Was there… anything else you wanted to know?”

“Anything else?” Phainon hummed. What sort of vague question could he ask that would garner an elaborate response? “If I wanted to please Mydei, what should I bring him, talk about with him, or do with him?”

“Please Mydei?” The cashier fell deep into thought, and with a frown, she began reciting as many facts as she knew about the regular: “Mydei enjoys sweets. Anything sweet. His favorite color is pink, his favorite fruit is pomegranate, and… He doesn't like alcohol, so don't take him to a bar.”

Phainon was quite shocked that the cashier even knew a regular's preference in alcohol. This bakery really was quite suspicious, and definitely something to take note of when concerning Mydei.

“He doesn't like alcohol? Just the taste, or?”

She shrugged. “He says it makes him very sleepy, and he doesn't enjoy drinking it. I'm not specifically sure if it's the taste or not, but since he likes sweets so much, it just might be.”

Interesting. Why did Mydei even bother drinking a glass that night if he didn't like alcohol? And Castorice and Cyrene were right: That one glass probably made Mydei tired. Phainon smiled at the thought that was now officially confirmed. Mydei was a sleepy drunk. Why did Phainon find that so amusing? He was almost tempted to give Mydei a bottle of alcohol just to see him with a bright red face, half-lidded eyes, and slurring his words together in an attempt to stay awake. It'd be an adorable sight to witness.

Phainon's brain halted. *Adorable?*

Adorable because… Because it was so different from the Mydei he usually knew! Yes, that was exactly it. Phainon didn't find *Mydei* adorable; just seeing this different side of Mydei was adorable. Well, not that the different side of Mydei was the thing that was adorable; it was *seeing* how different he was from his usual self would be adorable. Yes, that was exactly it.

He inwardly sighed to himself. Maybe he was spending a little too long in this bakery, and the heat from all the pastries was getting to him.

Taking the boxes into his hand, Phainon thanked the cashier for all her help with his questions and was on his way back to his car. He had spent such a long time in the bakery that the sun had fully disappeared from the sky, and it was dark outside when he stepped into the cool, outside air. Checking his phone, which illuminated his face in the dark, it had just struck seven in the evening. Right when the bakery closed.

His trip to the bakery was definitely a fruitful investigation, and he had a lot to review regarding his operation against Mydei. Thanks to Cyrene, Castorice, and the cashier whom he should've gotten the name of, he learned that Mydei really was affected by the alcohol when he had taken Phainon home the night of the company dinner. Not only that, but there was something extremely particular about The Chimeras' Bakery that Mydei was hiding.

He had specifically lied to Phainon about buying something every day. And the cashier's response to Mydei visiting every day but not buying anything every day was suspicious. He would go and visit the employees and to get free food? That didn't sound like Mydei at all. Mydei wouldn't need the free food at all; he was drowning in money, and Phainon was sure the pastries took almost nothing out of his heavy bank account. Or maybe, Phainon just really didn't know Mydei at all. Maybe those employees were actually his friends? Phainon didn't really pay much attention to Mydei interacting with the cashier.

He made a mental note to himself to pay closer attention to Mydei while in the bakery. That also meant that Phainon would have to force his way into Mydei's car once more after work to go to the bakery with him again tomorrow. Well, he was already planning on doing that anyway.

Mydei would just have to be prepared for Phainon once again.

Chapter End Notes

- **Phainon's "Operation Annoy Mydei" File**

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“How long have you been waiting for this, hm?”

“Phainon, please–*”*

“I know, my love.” Phainon leaned down, brushing his lips tenderly along the ear of his partner, who had their quivering legs spread wide underneath Phainon, waiting for his entrance and his entrance alone. “But I want to take this slow, okay?”

The other person swallowed thickly. Their cheeks were glowing red, and their enchanting eyes were brimming with tears. Phainon couldn't help himself from gulping at the delicious sight as he bent down, lapping at the tears that were threatening to run down their cheek.

“You're so beautiful, my love.”

The person gasped, their body growing rigid once Phainon began to press his dick to their twitching entrance. He could feel just how desperate the other person was, with their hole fluttering with all its might to suck Phainon's leaking tip inside. He couldn't tear his eyes away from the erotic sight, and his eyes darkened, teasing his tip along the desperate ring of muscles and watching the person below him spasm from the pleasure. He watched the entrance pulse against his tip, memorizing every single ridge and vein upon Phainon's shaft, and Phainon couldn't help but become mesmerized by the sight.

“You… bastard.”

Phainon laughed at their reaction, ignoring his own visceral need to shove himself deep inside all at once. His stomach was coiling, flaring in heat at the thought of being inside this person and making a mess out of the person

underneath him. He needed his dick to be submerged in that delicious warmth right at this moment, but the reactions he was getting from the other person were just too amusing. They were just too lovely. His beloved *was just too lovely.*

“Answer me, [redacted].” The name that left Phainon's lips disappeared in the night breeze. “How long have you been waiting for me?”

The other person was panting for breath in an attempt to still their hips. Their chest was heaving up and down, with fingernails digging into his sheets. “Too long.”

The resoluteness in the other person’s voice sent shivers down Phainon's spine, and with a smirk, Phainon planted his hands along the other person's waist, grasping tightly at the smooth skin underneath his fingertips. “You are… going to be the death of me, [redacted].”

“I'd like to see you try and die before you get inside of me.” The other person scoffed. “I told you, I've been waiting too long for this.”

Another laugh shook Phainon's chest once more. “For this? *Or for* me?”

The person's face bloomed red, and with a frown and a glare shot in his way, two arms swung around Phainon's neck to pull him closer. Phainon had to throw a hand out to catch himself before he collided with their head, but the breath in his throat hitched upon locking eyes with his partner. Their eyes, filled with so much love, certainty, and passion, stared deeply into Phainon's blue ones, and those perfectly soft lips soon parted for the gentlest and most loving voice Phainon would ever have the pleasure of hearing.

“For you, Phainon.”

Phainon's eyes shot open, facing the ceiling of his bedroom in the morning, before he could see any more of that scene.

What scene? The image, the voices, the feelings, all of it was already fading away.

But why did Phainon feel so empty this time? He couldn't even remember why. He couldn't even remember if he had felt like this the previous morning, or the morning after that. But soon, everything was quickly forgotten, and all that was left was him and his aching dick, as usual.

Phainon was back at work after another masturbation session, which had been his usual routine every morning nowadays, much to his annoyance. Was there a syndrome for having the opposite of erectile dysfunction? Was Phainon just really backed up?

Pushing that aside, Phainon was spending his morning doing very important research that was completely unrelated to the actual job that he was hired to do. Now that it was a new work day, and another opportunity to annoy Mydei, he had to brush up on his tactics. He was running out of things to talk about with the other man, and Phainon needed to find something new or else Mydei would just storm out of the room in the middle of their thirtieth conversation about sweets and pastries. And Phainon knew he would do that because *Mydei had already walked out on him mid-conversation before*.

Upon his computer screen, the words “Fig Stew Chimera” were typed into a search engine. Phainon still wasn't sure if Mydei had taken a liking to fig stew because of the bakery or because of this children's storybook that the cashier was referring to, but it was worth a shot to investigate the man’s phone's name and bring it up in conversation with him.

There really weren't many relevant search results. And Phainon figured out it was because this story was a very old children's storybook that didn't gain a lot of popularity because there was a homosexual couple in the story. Well, homosexual chimeras, to be more specific, as all the characters in the story were chimeras. But it received a lot of backlash from the public for trying to integrate homosexuality into a story meant for children, and it was soon forgotten by the public over time.

The main character was named Vigethos, and the children's storybook was quite literally called *The Cycles of Vigethos* because it followed Vigethos living his happiest moments with his chimera friends in this world where

the sun never set and the fun never ended. And when one adventure ended, another one would begin, thus bringing homage to the title of the storybook.

Vigethos was the one who had a boyfriend, an orange chimera named Fig Stew, and a lot of the public was furious that the main character of all characters was the gay one. Not only was there a gay character, but it also had to be the main character, which was the feedback that the storybook had gotten. And it seemed like there were no other romantic pairings in this story except for Vigethos and Fig Stew, which also received some backlash.

There was also a lot of concern about children wanting to be just like Vigethos, as the main character was hailed as a hero of the chimeras, and parents were worried that their children would want to be gay as a part of their admiration for Vigethos, which was honestly ridiculous to Phainon. It was a shame this storybook received so much backlash, because Phainon thought the chimeras were actually extremely cute. His only concern was why the main character's name was something like *Vigethos,* and his boyfriend got *Fig Stew*. Where the hell did *Vigethos* come from?

Phainon didn't really care much for the plot or for any of the other chimera characters. He was only here to learn more about Fig Stew in hopes of bringing him up in conversation with Mydei. Besides being the boyfriend of the main character, Fig Stew was orange and possessed crimson red eyes. He loved sleeping and taking baths. He loved baking. And despite dating the main character, Fig Stew treated him with much harshness, brushing off Vigethos's advances but acquiescing in the very end. Many haters of their gay romance cited Fig Stew's coldness as a way of showing that the chimera was being "forced" into dating the main character, which made Phainon frown. Truly, the only thing Phainon could really find about Fig Stew was the drama surrounding his relationship with the main character. The storybook's plot wasn't even about their relationship, but that was all Phainon could find while scanning through all the search results.

Yet, his eyes immediately halted, freezing in one particular spot on his computer screen. This wasn't related to Fig Stew at all, but the main

character. The hero and protagonist of the story, who carried the hopes and dreams of all the chimeras in their world, was nicknamed the “Deliverer.”

That was definitely a coincidence, right? That Mydei called him by the same title? He definitely wasn't referring to the storybook, right? Because it was true that Phainon quite literally delivered papers to him while at work, so the nickname made complete sense. But, this also confirmed that Mydei definitely knew about the storybook and didn't name his phone after some honeycakes in a bakery. Maybe Phainon could subtly bring up Vigethos when bringing up Fig Stew and see how Mydei reacted.

With a sigh, Phainon closed all the tabs that he had opened about the chimeras. He couldn't really find anything else about Fig Stew, and it didn't help that Fig Stew wasn't even the main character either. Though, it slightly piqued Phainon's curiosity that Mydei's main character wasn't the main character. Usually, children gravitated toward the main character, especially when they were the brave and heroic sort. Why did he choose the orange chimera out of all the chimeras? Phainon figured that was something else he could also bring up with Mydei, and after spending half an hour digging through the internet, he was finally returning to the work he was supposed to be doing.

When his lunch break finally arrived, Phainon rushed out of his seat, only to almost drop the salad he had packed for lunch upon arriving at the familiar office.

Mydei wasn't in his office?

The door was wide open, the lights were on, but no one was inside. The chair was still, signaling that Mydei had been gone for a considerable amount of time. But where would he go right before their lunch hour?

Phainon must've appeared extremely confused and bewildered standing outside of an empty office that didn't belong to him, because someone's voice cut through his thoughts: “He already left.”

He whirled around, becoming face-to-face with one of the security guards of the company who appeared to be dropping something off at the executive

assistant’s desk. The security guards were usually found on the first floor, but it wasn't unusual to see them on upper floors as well. Despite her delicate appearance, she was a formidable employee who was not to be messed with.

“Did you happen to see him, Hysilens?”

Her lips turned downward, tilting her head to the side as she recalled the memory. “He was already on the first floor when I was coming up here just now.”

His eyes widened at the information. He was already that far away?

Nodding in her way to thank her, he dashed down the corridor and down the elevator, eventually landing himself right in front of the entrance to the cafeteria. But upon entering the cafeteria, the man he was searching for wasn't in there.

In fact, for the next couple of days, Phainon could not find Mydei at all. Every time Phainon rushed over to his office the minute their lunch hour began, Mydei was already gone. And the minute their workday ended, Mydei’s office was already dark, with the door locked shut. Phainon had even tried to bother him in the middle of their workday at some random hour, but the man's office door would be closed. And it wasn't as if Phainon could just barge into a closed office, so he had no choice but to return to his cubicle.

It was the fourth day of this behavior repeating, and the work week was already beginning to end. Phainon hadn't seen Mydei in *days*, which was something he should've been relieved about. However, this was the most frustrated he had ever felt. He knew exactly what Mydei was doing, and it was working. And it infuriated Phainon that Mydei was getting on his nerves even after not seeing each other in the office. What did Phainon want? He was mad if he had to see Mydei, and he was also mad if he *didn't* see Mydei.

Clicking his tongue, Phainon checked the time on his work computer. They had a little over half an hour left of the workday, and then Phainon wouldn't

see him again until the following Monday. That wouldn't do at all. He wouldn't be able to succeed in his operation at all if he only saw Mydei once a week. Squinting at the desk clock that was ticking down the minutes Phainon had left, he racked his brain for any sort of plan that could salvage his situation. He had to figure this out now before the weekend started, but the only way to beat Mydei at this little game he was playing was to play it faster than him.

His shoulders instantly relaxed. That was it. *He just had to be faster.*

So before the work hour was even close to being done, Phainon had already snuck out of his cubicle before anyone could notice.

Before anyone had even begun to leave the office, and before any of the staff had even begun to pack up their things to leave for the day, the door adjacent to Phainon shut, with the occupant of said office turning around to lock the door.

“Going somewhere?”

The occupant jumped, whirling around with wide golden eyes to lock onto Phainon’s narrowed ones. He was leaning against the wall next to the office, with his arms crossed across his chest and the biggest smirk he had ever had plastered across his face. Truly, Phainon had to pat himself on the back.

“What are you doing here?” Mydei’s wide and incredulous eyes roamed Phainon's entire body as if he could not even believe that Phainon was actually standing before him.

“What else would I be doing here?” Cocking his head to the side, Phainon pushed himself off the wall. “Accompanying you home is why I'm here.”

Mydei clicked his tongue, and his signature cold glare replaced the incredulity that his eyes previously held. “Don't you have work to be doing at this time?”

“Don't you also have work to be doing at this time?” Phainon shot back. It was about twelve minutes before the workday was finished; plenty of time

for Mydei to sneak out before anyone had even begun to leave.

Mydei stayed silent, glowering in his direction. “There is *absolutely no way* that I am *voluntarily* bringing you over to my home.”

“Fine.” Phainon shrugged. He wasn't about to cower under his harsh stare and his seething tone; he had been waiting too long to see Mydei to give up now. “Then we can do something else then.”

“*Go home*, Deliverer,” Mydei snapped.

Phainon smirked once more. “Then take me with you.”

Clicking his tongue once more, Mydei decided to step right past Phainon and head for the elevator. But Phainon wasn't about to let him leave without him.

“Why do you like that bakery so much?”

As expected, the mention of the bakery made Mydei stop in his tracks. Pivoting on his feet, he shot a glare in Phainon's direction. “Why does that matter?”

“I'm just curious.” Phainon tried to answer with as much nonchalance as he could muster.

“I like it.”

“You don't have any other bakery you buy from?”

“What's wrong with having a favorite bakery?”

Phainon raised an eyebrow. “You're going to spend that much money on the same type of pastries?”

Mydei's eyes darkened in response. “Why are you worrying about how I spend my money?” He sneered. “You should be worrying about your own spending habits.”

“Well, *sorry* I'm not as rich as the CEO's son.”

“Then maybe you should stop thinking about the money of *the CEO's son*.”

Mydei whirled around on his feet once more, disappearing from Phainon's view. It was the end of the workday now, and more people were beginning to head to the elevator. But Phainon couldn't stop repeating Mydei’s words in his mind. How did they always fight every single time? Was it really necessary for Mydei to lash out at Phainon every time Phainon opened his mouth? Phainon was constantly flickering between being intrigued by the other man and then wanting to punch the other man within a couple of conversations, and it always threw Phainon's head into complete and utter disarray. Despite the sour taste left in Phainon's mouth after their argument, he forced his feet to follow after the other man into the parking structure.

Fortunately, Mydei hadn't caught on to the fact that Phainon knew exactly where he parked, and he found Mydei's car in the exact spot that he was expecting. The man of Phainon's entire operation was opening his car door and was about to safely seat himself inside.

“Mydei.”

Phainon watched the man pause with a deep sigh leaving his body. He didn't look the least surprised that Phainon was here, and he gazed at the silver-haired man with an exhausted expression. “Just get in if you're here already.”

Scoffing incredulously, Phainon couldn't help the smile that grew upon his lips at how easily the other man caved, and he quickly jumped into the luxury car before Mydei could change his mind.

“Don't you have anything better to do?” Mydei cast him a look while starting the car. “Any other people to bother with your presence? I'm sure Cyrene enjoys your company much more than I do.”

“*Aww*, Mydei, no need to be shy!” Phainon almost keeled in utter laughter at the disgusted expression that flashed across his face–it was almost worth channeling his inner Cyrene once again. He had to swipe a stray tear that

was gathering in the corner of his eye from trying to hold himself in, but his grin was impossible to hide. “If you love me, just say so.”

“I would *never* say that to *you*,” Mydei growled. There was a dangerous emotion swirling in Mydei’s golden eyes, one that Phainon chose to ignore, just like the rest of his cold demeanor.

“I'll get you to bite one day, Mydei.” Phainon relaxed into the seat. “Where are we going today? Back to the bakery, as usual?”

“I already went today.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow, but he soon lowered it. He must've gone either in the morning before work or during lunch, since Phainon couldn't catch the man during their lunch hour.

“Then,” Phainon glanced over to Mydei, who wasn't meeting his gaze, “are you free today?”

“Who's asking?”

“Phainon’s asking.”

“Then I'm not free.”

“Do you want to go to the mall with me?”

“Did you not just hear a word I said?”

Phainon laughed heartily, pulling out his phone to try and find what he was looking for. “I want to buy a book. Would you care to join me?”

“I'm sure all you read is just nonsense.” Mydei scoffed.

“And I'm surprised that *you* can read.”

The moment those words left his mouth, Phainon immediately backed himself into the passenger side’s car door before Mydei even had a chance to swing. Raising his arms and attempting to quiet his laughs over the

shaking fists of the other man, Phainon continued his proposal: “Wouldn't you care to join me at the bookstore? I'm sure it'll be a story that you enjoy.”

“I thought you said I didn't know how to read,” Mydei spat. It was very clear Mydei still wanted to punch the daylights out of him, and he was holding himself back with all his might.

Phainon smirked. “That's why I was going to choose a children's storybook for you.”

“I don't need to read such pointless stories.” Mydei exhaled deeply, and it seemed that all of his anger left with that breath as he settled back into his seat. “I have more important things to occupy my time with.”

“Wouldn't you like to know what storybook I want to buy?”

“Why would I concern myself with *anything* regarding you?”

That was a good point. Mydei didn't care in the least for Phainon, and Phainon was basically shoving himself into Mydei's life without his consent. He was sure that if he left Mydei's car right now that Mydei would drive right out of the parking structure as normal. But before Phainon could think of an answer or a way to deftly change topics, Mydei had already caught what was on Phainon's phone screen, which he had dropped from trying not to get punched by the other man.

“*The Cycles of Vigethos?”* Mydei furrowed his eyebrows at the bright screen illuminating the dim interior of the car. As the sun was setting now, no light was entering the parking structure, and Mydei and Phainon were basically sitting in the dark.

With a frown, Phainon dropped his gaze to the phone in his lap. “It's the book I want to buy.”

“Why?”

“Why?” Phainon did not think this far. “Well–”

“You won't find it.”

Phainon blinked blankly at Mydei, who had returned his attention to his car and begun to exit the parking structure.

“What makes you think I won't find it?”

Mydei leisurely responded, turning the steering wheel with elegance and ease, “They canceled printing of this storybook a long time ago, when it was first published. You won't find it anywhere.”

Returning his gaze to his phone, Phainon made eye contact with those two little chimeras falling in love. “That doesn't mean I can't try, right?”

“You won't find it at a typical bookstore selling published books,” Mydei retorted. “You'd have to visit a used or vintage bookstore to find such an old book. But most people don't bother selling children's books anyway.”

“You sound like you already know.”

“I do.”

The silence that followed his assertive statement was heavy. It didn't sound like Mydei wanted to talk about the book at all, and he didn't even mention the book in relation to himself. Yet, it seemed like Mydei had tried to search everywhere for it already. This book must've meant a lot to Mydei for him to be so sure that Phainon could never find that book himself. It wasn't as if Phainon needed the book himself, but now, suddenly, Phainon *needed* that book.

“Do you know this book?” Phainon decided to take a shot in the dark, with only the setting sun ahead of him now that the car had pulled out of the parking structure.

Mydei didn't answer, and Phainon didn't know how much he could push his luck. It was clear that Mydei had heard his question, since it was the only sound that reverberated between them besides the powerful car engine. With tense shoulders, Phainon's eyes were shifting back and forth in his lap,

trying to decide if he should just shut his mouth or bring up another topic, when Mydei decided to break their silence this time.

“Where did you find out about this book?”

The question hung in the air, and Phainon slowly raised his gaze over to Mydei, who was still paying attention to the road. It wasn't an accusatory question by any means, but it wasn't a question asked out of curiosity. But Phainon couldn't place his finger on why Mydei was asking, if it was neither out of curiosity nor an accusation. His tone of voice was definitely… softer, but that didn't help Phainon figure anything out at all.

“I went to the bakery a few days ago,” Phainon began to explain. He tried to gauge Mydei’s reaction at the mention of the bakery once more, but he seemed to be focused on something else this time. Something that captured Mydei’s attention more than the bakery? They were at a stoplight now, so it wasn't the road this time. “And I noticed the honeycakes… I…”

At the reminder of the honeycakes, he had forgotten that Mydei was the one who had bought them for him that night. His voice died in his throat, and he shut his mouth. Phainon should probably thank Mydei for the honeycakes; he was sure at the mention of them that they both were aware that the other person knew how they had appeared on Phainon's counter that day, and he parted his lips, only for no sound to escape.

He couldn't get the words that he wanted to leave his mouth for some reason. It was just a simple thanks, but why was his heart beating so fast all of a sudden? His pounding heartbeat was too busy taking over his senses to think rationally, and it was rattling his entire chest to the point where it was hard to even take a breath. Balling his fists in his lap, feeling his fingernails digging into his skin, he took a shaky breath, furrowing his eyebrows as if exerting force upon himself to get the words out. “Thank you… for the honeycakes.”

It didn't feel like Phainon was even in his body anymore. It felt empty, cold, and his shoulders were shaking. He couldn't tear his gaze away from the dashboard even when the car rumbled to life and began moving once the light had turned green, and the heavy silence only made Phainon's throat

close up on itself as the weight of the emptiness crushed his entire being. Phainon was gritting his teeth, hating how long he was waiting for Mydei's voice to break the silence this time. Why was he taking so long to respond? He wanted to take back his words and forget they had ever happened, anything to stop himself from feeling like he wanted to bolt out of the car. He has thanked Mydei before, but what was different this time?

“I'm glad you liked them.”

Mydei's smooth voice, cutting through the thick silence, made Phainon's shoulders immediately drop. Raising his eyes over to Mydei, he was shocked to see that the other man was already leaning over in his direction and staring at him, and Phainon's breath caught in his throat before he could think of a response.

Eyes widening, he scrambled to think of something, averting his gaze from the golden eyes that were staring so deeply into his soul. It was hard to breathe, his face was hot, and he couldn't stop himself from fidgeting in his seat. When did the car stop? They had already pulled up to a curb, but Phainon didn't have the space in his head to deal with anything else except for the golden eyes he wanted so badly to stop boring into him. Why was he staring at him so intently? And when had they gotten so close? It felt like every single detail upon Phainon's body was in clear view underneath his glowing, golden eyes, but Mydei was barely leaning over the console in between their seats. And yet, it felt like even the other man's body heat was washing over him in waves, and Phainon swallowed thickly.

“They were… really good.” Phainon forced a weak laugh, his eyes gluing themselves to the gear shift of the car in any attempt to rid themselves of the silence that was somehow pulling him closer to the other man. He forgot why they were even talking about this in the first place, and he racked his brain to recall what exactly they were talking about. “I… would love to eat them again. I actually bought them again when I went on Monday, but they didn't stand a chance.”

Phainon was rambling. He knew that. But his brain was refusing to work with him, and he had forgotten why he was even here in the first place. He just wanted to talk about anything that would take his mind off of his

clammy hands, burning face, and palpitating heartbeat. Phainon just wanted any sort of excuse to get away from this car, away from this man who knew so much more than him. Hurriedly tapping his fingers on his phone screen, his phone had automatically locked and was only displaying the time to him.

Mydei didn't respond, but Phainon heard him shifting back into his seat. Tension that had somehow gathered in Phainon's body immediately escaped him, and his shoulders instantly relaxed, the breath suddenly returning to his lungs. He forced his eyes onto Mydei once more, but this time, the man refused to look at him.

“This is your apartment, right?”

It was as if Phainon snapped out of a daze, and he whipped his head around to spot the very familiar apartment building. So, Mydei really didn't plan on spending his evening with him. Why did it kind of hurt that Mydei hadn't even entertained spending time with him in the slightest?

With a wry smile, Phainon unbuckled his seat belt and gathered his bag sitting by his feet. “Thanks for the ride back.”

He shut the car door without turning back, entering the lobby of the apartment building without another glance toward the streets.

What was that mood in the car just now?

Chapter End Notes

- **Phainon's "Operation Annoy Mydei" File**

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“You're so pretty.”

The other person paused, halting in their steps, and Phainon almost toppled over and onto the floor because he was leaning on the other person. “Do you even know who I am?”

Phainon hummed, frowning at the person in front of him. He couldn't place his finger on who they were, but they were definitely a sight to behold. With delicately sharp and intimidating features, they were a chic, fearsome beauty that made Phainon's heart race. Or maybe that was the alcohol, but it felt like Phainon couldn't keep his hands off of them.

“I used to have blonde hair.” Phainon laughed at the thought that came to him while admiring the other person's features, running his fingers through the golden hair in front of him, and causing the other person to immediately tense. “My hair was a little longer than it is now, and I dyed my entire head blonde. It was in college. I used to think I was so *cool and edgy back in the day.”*

The other person stayed silent, listening to Phainon's rambling while glaring at the hand that was messing up his hair.

“I don't know why I dyed my hair blonde.” He hummed once more, thinking back to his younger school days. “Maybe I thought it was cool? That only cool people have blonde hair? Is that why you have blonde hair? Because you're cool? Cool and pretty?”

The other person scoffed and rolled their eyes. “Is that all that comes out of your mouth? Nonsense and empty compliments?”

“But they're not empty.” Phainon shoved his face right into the other person’s space, and they flinched at the sudden proximity. “You're really… really pretty.” His voice lowered into a whisper, dropping down to the quivering lips in front of him. They looked so soft, so delectable, so–

The sunlight streamed into Phainon's eyes before his work alarm even had the chance to shake him awake. He blearily blinked the sleep out of his eyes, rolling over and stretching across his bed. Based on the morning sunlight that was washing his room in a gentle glow, it was about time for him to get up from work anyway.

He paused mid-stretch, pushing himself up and staring right into his lap.

Phainon wasn't hard?!

It was truly a great start to his morning. After almost an entire week of having to masturbate before work and on the weekends, he was finally free from the shackles of whatever lust had possessed his body. He couldn't remember what dream he had last night that didn't warrant an erection this time, but it really felt like nothing could ever ruin his morning, even though it was now Monday morning, and he had to go into work again.

He had spent his entire weekend trying to find that dumb children's storybook online, but with no progress. It really wasn't anywhere at all, but Phainon didn't want to admit that Mydei was right. If anything, it only fueled Phainon's urge to want to prove him wrong, and he made a mental note to himself to start exploring vintage and used bookstores. He wasn't sure how many of these existed in the city, but he had to convince himself that there was at least one copy of *The Cycles of Vigethos* out there that Mydei had somehow missed.

“Good morning!”

Cyrene's usual singsong voice cut through his thoughts, and a perfect cup of coffee landed upon his desk. Speaking of, when did she start making his coffee every morning? She never used to do that before, but all of a sudden,

Phainon was so accustomed to it by now. Then again, he could never wrap his head around Cyrene's behavior.

“Thank you again.” He smiled toward the other woman after placing the coffee cup into a safer place on his desk, away from any chance of being knocked over.

“How are you today, Phainon?” She leaned against the wall of Phainon's cubicle, her bright pink eyes narrowed despite her smile, yet her eyes still appeared to be sparkling.

Frowning, Phainon stared right back at her with narrowed eyes. “Fine.”

“Really?” Cyrene hummed, tilting her head to the side. “Just fine?”

“What are you looking for, Cyrene?” He continued to stare suspiciously at his coworker and good friend, but a teasing smile crept upon his lips. He could never bring himself to act even somewhat negatively toward his close friend. “You're lingering.”

“I always linger.” She winked playfully, pushing herself off the cubicle, but she suddenly sighed wistfully with a shake of her head. “*Ahh*, I just haven't been able to see my good friend since he became *so* preoccupied with another man. Is it wrong for me to want to ask about my good friend after his lengthy absence?”

“You're being dramatic, Cyrene.” Phainon's teasing smile became amused after watching the dramatic display in front of him. “I've always been here.”

“And yet, you always *dash* out the moment any of our breaks start!” Cyrene pouted.

“I don't *dash* out.”

“Okay, I was definitely not exaggerating there.” Cyrene crossed her arms across her chest with an eyebrow raised and a dubious smile. “Are you stalking Mydei today? Or can I finally have you for a day?”

“I don't stalk Mydei, and you can have me whenever you want.” Phainon scoffed, with his amused smile never fading.

Cyrene hummed. “*Right*. There's actually somewhere I want to take you after work today. Play with me?”

“I'll play.” Phainon leisurely leaned back in his chair. “Where are you taking me?”

“You'll see!” Another playful wink of her long eyelashes towards Phainon's direction. “I know you'll love it.”

And then she was off, as Cyrene usually was.

He couldn't possibly fathom what place Cyrene had in mind today. Every time Cyrene chose to hide the details, and he tried to guess, he would be terribly wrong. During their younger days, he was always at Cyrene's beck and call, as she was the type of spontaneous person to jump into something the moment she was even slightly interested.

For her environmental science report, she drove them out to a landfill center. For a mythology course, she made him sleep the night on a haunted ocean liner. She had seen a video about unclaimed airport luggage online and had dragged him to their sorting centers. Phainon couldn’t even fathom the number of abandoned buildings that he had walked through. Cyrene woke him up in his apartment before dawn one day and told him she had signed them up for skydiving that very same day, and he had to owe his motorcycle license, which he doesn't even use, to Cyrene. And when many of her other college friends warned her of the dangers of driving a motorcycle, she drove herself and Phainon to visit a car junkyard.

These were only just a handful of experiences that he had with Cyrene, who always claimed how romantic and exciting spontaneous adventures were, and Phainon always let himself be dragged around by her whims. They were quite carefree when they were young and in school, but she had begun to slow down once they both started their full-time jobs. It had been a long time since Cyrene had asked him out to a mysterious location, and he

couldn't help his mind from wandering to possibilities of what they would be doing while he was trying to focus on his computer screen.

He had been so deep into his thoughts for so long that he hadn't even realized that their lunch hour had arrived. Panicking, he grabbed the bare essentials and rushed over to Mydei's office before the man could sneak away. Since their lunch hour had just started, Phainon was probably too late already, as Mydei had started the habit of leaving even earlier just to beat out Phainon. But he almost tripped over his own feet when he saw that Mydei was actually waiting for him outside his door.

He was waiting for him. For *Phainon*.

His body instantly heated up at the thought, spreading through every limb in his body at the sight before him. His heart was quickening its pace as he stepped up to face Mydei, with his surprised blue eyes glued to the man in front of him. He was dressed warmly since the weather was approaching winter, with a black wool coat, black slacks, and a black turtleneck that clung tightly to his chest. Even after gaping at him, Phainon still couldn't believe that Mydei was actually here and not just a figment of Phainon's wishful imagination, and those words repeated wildly in his head.

Mydei was waiting for him. Mydei was waiting for him.

"You're late," Mydei stared tiredly in Phainon's direction, who was trying to tidy himself from rushing over so quickly.

Phainon chuckled sheepishly, running a hand through his hair and ignoring how sweaty his palms felt. "I… didn't realize you would be waiting for me. And the lunch hour just started."

"*Hmph*, you would've missed me had I left earlier when I originally planned." Mydei crossed his arms. "I only waited because I thought you were already on your way over to stop me ten minutes ago." Despite his harsh words, he didn't hold his usual harsh tone of voice, which was quite atypical for Mydei.

“*Hah*, I'm surprised you even entertained the idea of waiting for me.” Throwing a smirk in Mydei's direction, the man only returned a sharp glare before departing from the floor. Phainon quickly followed after him to keep up with his brisk pace. “Did something good happen today, Mydei? What's with this ‘waiting for me’ thing you're pulling today?”

“Shut your mouth before I change my mind.”

Phainon instantly shut his mouth.

Mydei led them to the cafeteria, and it felt like it had been a long time since Phainon had dined here with him. Although Phainon did bring himself a salad, he was surprised that Mydei also packed himself his own meal, and thinking back on it now, he couldn't actually recall Mydei bringing anything to work to eat.

“I usually sleep during my breaks.” Mydei could see exactly what was swirling in Phainon's mind. “So I don't usually bring anything.”

“You don't eat lunch at all?” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows.

“I eat a filling breakfast, eat a pastry a little before noon, and eat dinner at home,” Mydei simply explained. “Today, since I knew you were going to come bother me, I packed a lunch this time.”

His words comforted Phainon, whose shoulders relaxed as he began taking out his own salad to eat. “I'm surprised you don't eat better than that, with being the CEO's son and all. I would've thought you had a private chef cooking for you all the time.”

Their workplace, Kremnos Corporation, was an extremely famous company in the technology industry. It was contracted with the government to support the military, which meant that it attracted a lot of attention and a lot of money. Being the CEO's son, Phainon had just assumed that Mydei was filthy rich and had access to any kind of luxury imaginable.

“I don't live with my father.” Mydei took a bite of his lunch, consisting of pan-fried, seared beef and onions.

“Still, I would've just assumed you had a private chef, or at least a maid or something.” Phainon leisurely stabbed his salad.

“I don't have any of those things,” Mydei answered. “Clearly, you overestimate me.”

Phainon hummed in acknowledgment. “Do you live by yourself?”

“I do.”

“In a fancy house?”

“A penthouse.”

Sheesh. Phainon was suddenly too poor for this conversation.

“You didn't want to hire a private chef or a maid after living in a penthouse?” He stared up at Mydei, who seemed to be more focused on the food than the conversation itself.

“I don't need it.”

“But you have all the money in the world,” Phainon remarked. “Wouldn't it just make your life easier without having to spend much of your fortune?”

“Money does not solve all your problems.”

The harsh tone that cut into the conversation made Phainon stop, and an unbearable silence settled upon their shoulders. Phainon sat there, with the cafeteria noise completely disappearing from his ears, staring at Mydei with an indescribable emotion bubbling up inside of him. He didn't know what to do or how to deal with these feelings surfacing in his chest, so he could only sit there in silence, wringing his fingers together, with his eyes glued onto golden hair.

Mydei, who still would not meet Phainon's eyes, had his head bowed low. He was pushing the remaining food around in his container with his fork. “There are things you cannot buy with money.”

His voice was cold and expressionless, as if he were stating a simple fact, but Phainon still could not bring himself to speak for the rest of their lunch break.

It had been about an hour since their lunch break had ended, and Phainon felt like he had to apologize. For the past hour since returning to the cafeteria, he kept fidgeting in his office chair, bouncing his leg, and running his fingers through his hair at every stray strand of hair that dared to fall into his eyes. Every little noise or movement bothered him, and he couldn't focus in the slightest on these documents sitting right in front of him.

He definitely said something wrong to Mydei during lunch. As much as he argued and bickered with the other man, even Phainon could tell the difference in reaction when he touched on a sore spot, and he would've never expected that Mydei’s sore spot was money. As the CEO's son, he was probably always hearing all sorts of talk and discussions about money in the executive department.

Did that mean… Mydei hated his job?

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows at the new thoughts sprouting in his head. Does Mydei even want to work here? He was the CEO's son after all, something that Mydei had no control over. It seemed like everyone in the company had just accepted he would be the next CEO, but did Mydei accept that notion himself? Or was it something that he just forced himself to deal with while he was here? Maybe he was desensitized to all the discussions about money.

He had to admit, Phainon had never considered Mydei’s position before. Then again, he had never thought about Mydei so much in his entire life. He would always ignore him and his glares, returning his attention back to his own work in his own department and had taken Mydei’s position as a matter of fact. It was a truth in this company; one that no one ever dared question, and he wondered if anyone had ever thought about Mydei and his relationship with the company. Did Mydei even get along with his father in the first place? Phainon never paid any attention, as he rarely saw the CEO at all.

With a groan, Phainon slapped his hands against his desk and pushed himself to his feet, startling his nearby coworkers. He flashed them an apologetic smile, fishing for some documents that didn't actually need any signatures before running toward the office that held all the answers to his questions.

The office door was open, and Phainon could barely spot a head of golden hair peeking above the computer monitors that had their backs facing the entrance. He was resolute in coming over, but his steps faltered now that he was here. Phainon had no idea what to say.

Would a simple apology suffice? Phainon hadn't the slightest clue as to how deeply Mydei's hatred for money went. It could vary anywhere from, he doesn't care about money, maybe due to having so much of it; to, he didn't have enough money to save a dying relative or friend, and now he despises that money makes the world turn. His eyes lowered to the carpeted floor beneath his leather shoes, brainstorming different apologies. Maybe Phainon should turn around and bring a peace offering before apologizing. Then again, Mydei had all the money in the world to buy his own peace offering.

"Why are you just standing there?"

His eyes shot up from the floor to meet gold. Mydei was staring at him inquisitively and in an accusatory manner, peeking from behind his computer monitors that were obscuring much of his body.

"I…" Phainon took a step forward upon being spoken to, but he stopped again in the middle of the hallway. His eyes flickered anywhere except for the office that was right in front of him, yet he couldn't bring himself to step inside.

A sigh could be heard ahead of him, and he could hear the movement of Mydei's office chair. "Stop blocking the hallway."

A pitiful laugh escaped Phainon's throat, and he dragged his feet until he was finally standing adjacent to the office door. Despite how crude and

indirect it was, that was the first time Mydei had ever invited Phainon into his office.

Phainon sighed heavily, finally bringing himself to meet Mydei's emotionless gaze. “I only came here to apologize.”

“Apologize?” Mydei raised an eyebrow.

“For lunch,” Phainon continued, wringing his fingers together, “for what I said. I'm sorry.”

Mydei neglected to answer, and it only made Phainon antsy. He could never get used to these heavy silences with the other man, no matter how much they fought, and he forced his brain to spew some more words just to whisk this silence away.

“I don't know anything about you,” Phainon admitted. “And I don't know what you've been through. So, I'm sorry if I said anything you didn't want to hear today.”

Mydei continued to stare at Phainon, completely unmoving and devoid of any emotion. “Like you said, you didn't know anything. So there's nothing to apologize for.”

“But I know I said something wrong.” Anger began bubbling to the surface as he stepped into the office. He always hated how much Mydei dismissed him and hated how much Mydei never seemed to care about him. Was it really that hard to learn Phainon's name? “And I want to apologize for that.”

“There's no need.” Mydei waved his hand dismissively, his attention already returned to his work.

Phainon clenched his teeth, ignoring the heat that was going to explode in his head. “I'm sorry, Mydei.”

Unsurprisingly, he didn't respond, but Phainon didn't want to leave this office without at least being acknowledged. He thought back to his previous

thoughts, when he had thought about whether Mydei even enjoyed working at this company as its heir.

“Do you like your job?”

That made Mydei pause. His eyes finally stared up at Phainon with a curious air. “Do I like my job?”

“Do you like what you do?” Phainon gestured to his desk, his computer, and his office. “Running a company, being the CEO's son. Do you like it?”

His golden eyes drifted, seeming to digest the weight of his words. “You asked two very different questions.”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. He did?

At the inquisitive stare being shot back at him, Mydei elaborated, “‘Do I like what I do,’ and ‘do I like being the CEO's son,’ are two very different questions.”

Were they? Wasn't Mydei’s entire job being the CEO's son and learning about the company to eventually run the whole show?

“Then–”

“I've never thought about whether I liked my job or not,” Mydei cut him off. “This is…” His eyes searched in front of him, taking in the office and his responsibilities, “just a job I have to do.”

Something in the way Mydei spoke, the way he was looking at something in the office that wasn't there, felt like Phainon was breaching enemy territory. It was a side to Mydei that Phainon had never considered before. Yet suddenly, he had found himself standing at the looming gate of Mydei's life, and he wasn't sure if he was allowed inside. And Phainon wasn't sure if they would ever open for him.

“Do you… like being the CEO's son, then?” Phainon couldn't help but ask the other question that Mydei had neglected. It was burning in his mind that

if Mydei thought his job and being the CEO's son were two very different things, then…

“Do you want to go to the bakery today?”

The sudden question shook Phainon to his core, and it was the first time that Mydei had ever willingly invited him anywhere. He almost would've thought he had hallucinated his words if Mydei wasn't staring at him so expectantly. His heart beat rapidly at the invitation, his eyes widened at the implications, and he opened his mouth to immediately agree, only to remember.

Fuck, he actually had plans for once.

“I…” Phainon didn't even want to admit that he was busy. He wanted to revel in this invitation for the rest of his life and remember that Mydei had voluntarily welcomed his presence for the first time since he had started working at this company. His heart sank at the thought that he couldn't accept, and he averted his eyes from the expectant golden ones.

“We can go next time.”

Phainon couldn't imagine what sort of face he held, but Mydei’s voice was gentle, something that he wasn't expecting. He was expecting Mydei to make a comment about Phainon not accepting the invitation, or maybe another snarky remark about how Phainon only shoved himself into Mydei’s life when Mydei didn't want him there. But instead, the soft, soothing tone was something he could have never imagined Mydei’s smooth, deep voice could hold, especially around someone like Phainon. “You don't have to look so heartbroken you can't go.”

Blue eyes glanced pitifully toward Mydei, but his eyes widened upon the sight that he saw. A soft, tender smile was being directed in Phainon's way, gracing Mydei’s lips in a way that had Phainon's hands sweating. He couldn't even say that his heart started pounding upon locking eyes with Mydei and his gentle smile, because his heart and his breathing completely stopped at the sight. How was Phainon supposed to deal with himself after

this smile? It suited Mydei so well, and he couldn't help but think of how beautiful it looked.

Mydei was glowing. It was the only description Phainon could bring to his malfunctioning mind. The window behind Mydei's desk had its window shades open, cascading sunlight into the room that perfectly bounced along his golden hair. It wrapped around his face, showering him in gold, almost as if a halo was hovering over him, and Phainon had to force air into his lungs with a deep breath before he began to lose himself over this sight that he would never be able to see again.

Because Mydei despised Phainon, and it was just a truth that he would have to accept.

With a small smile, Phainon nodded, swallowing dryly and leaving the office and all of his thoughts behind without another word.

Chapter End Notes

- **Phainon's "Operation Annoy Mydei" File**

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon should never see Mydei smile again.

It felt like it was something he shouldn't have seen. It felt like he was sneaking a sight that wasn't meant for him. He had to bury away his pounding heart, his staggering breaths, and his blurring vision, all because Phainon knew that Mydei would never smile at him like that ever again.

Phainon had made Mydei carry him home while blackout drunk, purposefully bothered him at work, dragged him around during his breaks, forced himself into his car multiple times, and made him answer clearly private questions. Mydei had never sought him out before, and it tore Phainon up inside at the thought that Mydei would just live his life so leisurely if Phainon just left.

Should he just give up?

It didn't seem like Mydei was going to tell him what happened that night anytime soon, and the more Phainon found out about that night or about Mydei, the more he felt like he was approaching a line that he wasn't supposed to cross. And all of these feelings that Phainon kept experiencing were things that he didn't know how to deal with. Phainon had been scared, angry, and frustrated with the other man, but what were these other emotions that kept welling up inside of him? Making it hard for him to breathe? Making it hard for him to even see?

He couldn't deal with Mydei anymore. He couldn't handle it anymore. Phainon wanted to go back to the old days when they would just ignore each other and move on with their lives.

Phainon hated Mydei.

He hated how Mydei blatantly ignored him. He hated how Mydei made him feel like nothing at all. He hated how Mydei never acknowledged him. He hated how much Mydei made his heart pound, his hands sweat, and his breath falter. It only made Phainon more frustrated with himself because he didn't know *why* he was feeling like this, and every time he approached Mydei, he only felt like his heart was being shattered into pieces. He didn't want to see Mydei anymore, not if Mydei was going to keep treating him like nothing at all.

He swiped a hand along his face, wiping his eyes and taking deep breaths. Every little space he had in his head was all reserved for Mydei, and all the spare time that Phainon had was all for Mydei. It felt like he was doing everything for nothing. Why did that one little smile throw Phainon's entire operation out the window? He couldn't even begin to wrap his head around what had happened, and even if someone asked, he wouldn't know where to start. When did he start feeling like this?

What happened to Phainon?

It felt like it was just two weeks ago that he was ignoring Mydei’s signature glares, and just a few days ago that he had been slotting himself into Mydei's life and teasing the man for his obvious reactions. When did these complicated emotions start to emerge between them, and how did he suddenly find himself at the border between his life and Mydei's? Phainon didn't mean to take this so far; he only wanted to learn what happened that night. Then why was he suddenly looking for Mydei, thinking about Mydei, and learning about Mydei? He should be trying to figure out what happened that night, right? Then why was Phainon trying to push himself into a life that didn't want him there?

Sure, Mydei was the only other person who knew what happened between them, but there had to be another way than this. Whatever…this was. This relationship that Phainon couldn't name. These feelings that Phainon couldn't list. When was the last time Phainon had ever felt like himself? What was Mydei to him? He couldn't say anymore. He wasn't just “the CEO's son” anymore. But Phainon couldn't think of any other description that would encapsulate this entire week.

Another deep breath shook his entire body, stilling his heart that had been squeezing tightly in his chest and rushing air into his throat that burned. Phainon should get back to work.

At least, that was his intention until two pairs of hands snapped against his shoulders.

"*Phainon!"* A cheery voice that was completely different from his previous thoughts sang through the air, and Phainon jumped at the two hands that landed against him. His eyes flickered toward the clock on his computer. It was already the end of the workday.

He feigned a laugh, turning off his computer. "You seem excited, Cyrene."

"Of course I am." Instead of pulling herself away, she wrapped her arms around his shoulders, leaning her head against Phainon's. "I feel like I haven't seen you in *forever*."

There wasn't much that Phainon could do with being pinned to the back of his chair, so he only relaxed into the back of his seat with Cyrene's forearms resting upon his shoulders. "You can see me anytime, Cyrene. I already said I'm not going anywhere."

The cubicles were beginning to empty, with most of the staff now heading home for the weekend. Cyrene wished them all a good night as they headed toward the elevator, until the only employees left were the higher-ups who worked in their own offices.

"What happened?" The serious tone in Cyrene's voice was a vast shift from the cheerful one she had been using just a few seconds ago. She still had her arms wrapped around Phainon; he wouldn't be able to hide even if he wanted to. And Cyrene had known him for far too long to lie about anything.

"Nothing really." Phainon let out a weak laugh. "Just… rethinking my plan to find out about that night."

"You mean the night with Mydei?"

Phainon didn't even want to hear his name anymore, and he couldn't bring himself to respond.

She pushed her cheek against the side of Phainon's head, wrapping her arms tighter. It felt good… being seen for once, and he couldn't stop his vision from blurring again, right when he had just stopped it.

“The place I want to bring you to,” Cyrene whispered. “I think you'll like it.”

“Really?” He tilted his head against Cyrene, revelling in the warmth that radiated off of her.

Cyrene hummed, pulling her arms away and spinning Phainon's chair around. He had no idea where this sudden strength of hers came from, and the world before him blurred until his blurring vision landed upon bright pink. And with a swipe of very gentle, lithe fingers, he was looking up at Cyrene. As he always did.

“I practically raised you, Phainon.” She huffed with a smile. “I know exactly what you like. Get up. Let's go.”

Phainon laughed, for real this time, as Cyrene pulled him up from his office chair and dragged him down the building. Once they had entered the parking structure, he began digging through his pocket for his car keys, only to almost drop them at another tug of his arm.

“We're going outside the city.” Cyrene didn't look back as she pulled him toward her own car. “Since I'm dragging you with me, I'll drive.”

“Outside the city?” Phainon let himself follow after Cyrene, their footsteps echoing in the dark parking structure. What could she possibly be looking for outside of the city?

As if reading his thoughts, she glanced at Phainon from over her shoulder, throwing him a playful wink. “You'll see!”

With the rush hour traffic, the drive to wherever Cyrene was trying to take him was going to take hours. Phainon stared at the screen in the car as she began driving out of the building, merging onto the street. He couldn't see where they were going, only that it was going to take four hours to get there, and whenever he tried to sneakily reach for her phone to check the address, she would always swat his hand away.

Cyrene always drove with music playing in her car, and it was the only thing that stopped Phainon from sinking too deeply into his thoughts as he watched the world rush past him from outside the window. He listened to Cyrene hum with the music while following the horizon in the distance. The sun was setting low in the sky, with orange, pink, and purple dancing across the sky, intertwining with the clouds that stretched across his vision. The streetlights were beginning to flicker on, and the lights of all the cars soon followed as the outside world was slowly enveloped in the night.

Phainon and Cyrene didn't really talk much at all during the car ride. It felt like it had been a long time since Phainon had actually had a comfortable silence. Although he wanted to sit and just appreciate the quietness, after all the events that occurred that day, he eventually closed his eyes and let the dull thrum of the car engine take him away.

“I used to have a dog.” Phainon hummed. “And… I didn't live in the city before.”

“You didn't?”

Phainon rapidly shook his head. “Not at all! We moved here when we were young.”

“'We?’ Your family?”

“Yeah! My family.”

“Why did your family move?”

“There was nothing left for us in that small town anymore.”

“Nothing left?”

“There's more to do out here than in the countryside.”

“Phainon?”

A hand abruptly shook him awake, and he rapidly blinked the sleep out of his eyes. Phainon’s body was stiff from sleeping upright in the car, and he had to pull his body from the seat to become face-to-face with Cyrene's concerned stare.

“You were… talking in your sleep,” Cyrene said. “Are you okay?”

“I was?” Phainon's eyebrows raised.

“You were talking about Snowy.” Cyrene slowly withdrew her hand from Phainon's shoulder. Snowy was his childhood dog. He hadn't thought about Snowy in a long time; was his dream about his childhood home?

“I… don't remember what I was dreaming about.” He furrowed his eyebrows in a futile attempt to recall. “I've been having strange dreams for the past week, but I can never remember them when I wake up.”

Cyrene hummed in acknowledgement, settling in the driver’s seat. She had her own eyebrows furrowed as she fell deep into her own thoughts, but she didn't say anything at all about them. “We're here. Let's go.”

She pushed her car door open, leaving before Phainon could react. He didn't question why Cyrene had fallen into her own silence and decided to follow her out the door, shutting it behind him and hearing it lock.

It was quiet outside–completely and utterly silent and completely and utterly dark. It was vastly different from the hustle and bustle of the city, and there were barely any lights around where they had parked. Only a single, worn-down streetlight illuminated each building’s entrances down the road ahead of him, but when he turned around, Cyrene was already heading into the store that she had parked in front of.

Phainon scrambled after her, still unsure where they had even arrived. There was no signage or postings to indicate where they were, and he stepped inside this unidentifiable building only to be hit with the smell of old books and antiques.

It was a quaint little store with barely any room to walk. It was stuffed to the brim with old and vintage furniture that were piled together, with pieces of paper taped to them with their price scribbled on. The walls were covered with antique frames and old paintings, and scattered throughout the small store were lines of tall shelves covered in dusty books.

They were at an antique store.

“Mister!” Cyrene yelled into the story, and Phainon had to resist the urge to slap a hand across her loud mouth. It almost felt like Cyrene broke the peace and quiet of this undisturbed store, but before Phainon could quiet her down, an older man had appeared from behind another set of bookshelves deeper into the store.

“You must be… Cyrene,” the older man eyed the two customers who had just entered the store.

She nodded her head enthusiastically. “Thank you for keeping the store open for us. We just got out of work. I brought you chocolate!”

Phainon curiously watched Cyrene carefully dodge the various wooden furniture scattered all about the floor to hand the old man a handful of chocolate that was kept in the breakroom of their workplace. The old man chuckled at the sight, pocketing the chocolate.

“I hope you find what you are looking for.” With a nod, the old man disappeared behind another set of shelves.

Cyrene turned to Phainon, waving him over, and with a light laugh, he jumped over the other pieces of furniture until he was finally right next to Cyrene.

“What are we doing here?” Phainon took in the sights around him, of the aged pictures strung up on the walls and the vintage pieces littering the whole store. It was truly an intriguing sight to behold and definitely somewhere that he could not have guessed.

“I want to find something.” With an impatient breath and hands on her hips, she pivoted around on her feet to take in the whole store. “I don't know where to start.”

“What are you looking for?” He tried to trail Cyrene's gaze to try and see what she was looking at, but she wasn't looking at one particular thing at all.

She hummed in dismay with a frown. “Can you check the bookshelves? I'll start from the other side of the store.”

Cyrene dashed off before Phainon could even open his mouth.

What was he supposed to be looking for?!

He was staring holes into Cyrene from across the shop, who only waved her hands with a cheeky grin as if trying to shoo him away. Cyrene had started on the furniture side of the store and had somehow situated herself between a bundle of upside-down chairs and a round table–some sort of dining set. But it didn't seem to be what she was looking for, as she stepped out from all the limbs of the chairs and was on her merry way.

With an exasperated sigh, Phainon turned back to the towering bookshelves that seemed to surround him on all sides. He was barely tall enough to see the topmost shelf; that was probably why Cyrene had assigned him to bookshelf duty, as she was much shorter than him without her high heels.

He languidly scanned each shelf, still unsure of what he was supposed to be looking for. Most of the lettering on the spines was faded or covered in dust, and many of the paperback copies were in tatters. There were so many books that they were practically overflowing from the shelves, with some books propped upright, and others stacked horizontally on top of the properly placed books or in the empty space in front of those books. He

pushed some of the extra piles of books aside to peek at the vertically stacked books, but there was nothing special in the back.

Phainon was strolling through each space between the bookshelves and repeating this process over and over again, as if he were actually searching for something. Truthfully, he still had no idea why they were even here in the first place. His common sense just told him to look for something pink or purple, as those were Cyrene's favorite colors, and he sifted through each of the shelves to find just that. Although he did find some pink and purple books, the contents weren't really anything that Cyrene would enjoy. She was a lover of mystery, mythology, and romance, and Phainon couldn't really find much that had the same genre and had a pink or purple cover.

He chanced a glance over at Cyrene, who was fascinated by a black box with gold foil lettering and embellishments consisting of tarot cards. Was that what she was looking for? It didn't look like she had found something that she was seeking; rather, it looked more as if she were just playing around the store like a child in a toy store. She just seemed a little too carefree to be actively trying to look for something. Then again, Cyrene was always carefree, so he really couldn't tell.

It was pitch black outside. Phainon made a mental note to offer to drive back to the city, since he had taken a nap on the way here, and it was getting late now. He still hadn't the slightest clue what he was looking for, but he continued to peruse the bookshelves as he was told to do. There was a mix of fiction and nonfiction books, but the common underlying theme of all these books was that they were all published more than decades ago.

He had already searched through more than half the bookshelves now and was almost approaching the back wall of the store. Phainon did end up finding some pink and purple books that he figured were to Cyrene's taste, but there really weren't that many. But it was when he was sorting through another stack of books and had peeled them away to take a quick glance at the books in the back that his heart instantly stopped.

It was *The Cycles of Vigethos*. Right before his very eyes.

The font on the spine was fading, but he had stared at the main character’s name for so long that he could immediately identify it. Phainon almost couldn't believe it, and with shaky hands, he placed the books he saved for Cyrene out of the way and wriggled the tiny book from the overstuffed bookshelves. Dust flew all over his vision, grime covered his hands, but he finally unearthed that thin children’s book to find that same group of chimeras he had seen on his work computer.

There was no mistaking it. He flipped open to a random page, hearing the crunch of the book's spine from being opened for the first time in probably decades. He had flipped to a random page about Fig Stew giving Vigethos a flower to wear on his head, and Vigethos was… crying? The colors were somewhat faded, but it was the real deal.

“Phainon?”

Phainon jumped upon his name being called, and Cyrene soon landed right in front of him after dodging all the furniture that had previously been separating them. She glanced down at the book with her eyes wide.

“They're so cute!” She sharply gasped, ripping the book out of Phainon’s hands to flip through all the pages. “Oh my… Which one is my favorite?” She had flipped to some sort of group picture the chimeras took, and all of the smiling chimeras were staring back at her. “You're getting this, right?”

Her bright pink eyes landed upon Phainon almost expectantly, and Phainon's wide eyes shifted between the book in her hands and his close friend.

“Do I… have to?” The book only reminded him of Mydei, someone that he really didn't want to think about right now. In fact, he was already considering just shutting down the entire operation and moving on with his life. Mydei would be more than happy about that, and Phainon was starting to think that he would feel the same.

“You must!” She shut the book with one hand, with dust flying into the air. “How else am I supposed to choose my favorite one?!”

“I mean…” Phainon squinted at the closed book with a half-hearted smile. “I can wait for you to pick one?”

“Look at how late it is. You want to stand here and wait while I pick?” With a roll of her eyes, she shoved the book against Phainon's chest and turned toward the deeper part of the store. “Mister, it's getting late, so we'll be off now!”

Two strong arms pushed Phainon toward the exit, and he stumbled upon his feet, tripping over the scattered furniture and barely catching himself in time. But he didn't have much time to gather himself, as he was being shoved again toward the door.

“Cyrene, we–” Another shove cut him off, and before he knew it, they were back outside under the night sky and the twinkling stars.

Cyrene was swiping her hands against each other as a job well done, with some remaining dust scattering into the air. “Well, time to go back! Are you staying over, Phainon?”

Blinking blankly at the other woman, Phainon was still trying to catch up with what had just happened. Did she end up finding what she was looking for? They didn't even pay for the book, let alone whatever it was Cyrene was trying to find. And the owner just let them waltz out of the store? He was sure this antique store in the middle of nowhere didn't make nearly enough money to warrant them stealing a children's book and whatever Cyrene decided to get.

“I…” Phainon was still staring at the store with furrowed eyebrows when the dim lighting of the store shut off, enveloping the store in complete darkness. “Did we… pay?”

“Of course I did.” Cyrene crossed her arms. “Do you think I'm a thief?”

“But this book–”

“I paid for it already. Come on now!” She whirled around on her feet toward the car without waiting for his response, and Phainon chased after

her.

“Give me the keys. I'll drive home.”

She seemed to consider the idea, and after a debate within her head, she eventually handed off the keys to her car.

They both jumped into the car, with Cyrene taking the book from Phainon's lap so that he could begin driving to Cyrene's apartment. He was punching Cyrene's address into his phone to begin navigating back until the crunch of that old spine interrupted the silence.

“It's really so hard to choose my favorite.” Cyrene was staring down at the pages that were basically covered in the darkness of the night.

“Can you even see?” Phainon laughed and slapped his hand on the car light, illuminating the interior of her car. She had flipped to a random page of the chimeras lounging in some sort of public bath.

Cyrene shifted in her seat, staring down at all the chimeras. Phainon couldn't stop his own eyes from drifting to the pages and watching the little chimeras frolicking in the water.

“Phainon.”

He knew Cyrene was staring at him. He knew her all too well, but he felt like everything would be exposed if he stared back at her. Phainon kept his gaze glued to the open book in her lap, but she probably knew everything already, even without him uttering a word.

She shifted in her seat once more, and the book in her lap gently shut as she turned her body toward Phainon. “You should really pay attention to what you're looking up at work.”

Phainon coughed at her giggling, and he sheepishly scratched the back of his head with an awkward smile. “You saw that?”

“I was trying to bother you in the morning, as usual.” Her giggling faded away as she recalled the memory. “You seemed to be staring so intently at

your computer, so I was curious what you were working on. Imagine my surprise when you were looking up this children's book.” She held up the book with the cover facing upwards. “I figured… this was important to you.”

“It's not really important to me anymore.” Phainon stared wistfully at the chimeras on the cover. He had no need for this book anymore. “If you only drove all this way for me, at least let me pay you back for the book.”

Cyrene laughed softly, settling the book into her lap and swiping at some of the remaining dust. “Remember when I used to pay for everything? Why don't you let me relive those moments again?”

He flinched. “I really don't want to think about those days, Cyrene.”

“They're just nostalgic memories.” Cyrene smiled gently. “I don't want to go back to those days either. We really… The [redacted] took a lot from both of us.”

Phainon stayed silent.

“But look at us!” Cyrene suddenly exclaimed, jumping up in her seat. “We both live in the city, we have full-time jobs now, and we even have our own apartments. Who would've thought that would happen to us?”

He couldn't help the soft laugh from her grand enthusiasm. Phainon had to agree they had come a long way from home.

“You should try again, Phainon.” Her hands tightly clutched the children's book. “You always have a habit of running away.”

Phainon narrowed his eyes at her words. “I don't–”

“When you're scared, when nothing is going right, when everything is falling to pieces. You run away.” Cyrene's bright eyes were staring straight into Phainon’s soul; he could feel it without even glancing her way. “It was the same back then, and it's the same right now. You *always* underestimate yourself.”

“Cyrene–”

“I'm not done!” She chastised, pressing a finger against Phainon's chest. “You *always* think everything is *so* beyond what you can do. And you think everyone is just *so* much better than you. You always think you’re doing everything wrong, but you're so much greater than that, you know?”

“But–”

“*Shh*,” she sharply cut off Phainon's retort. “I know what you're about to say, but you can do something now!”

“*Now?*” Phainon squinted at her with a scowl. “They're gone, Cyrene. It's too late.”

“Isn't the greatest revenge against Death to live to the fullest?” She winked, picking the book from her lap once more. “And I think this book will really help you with that.”

He stared dubiously at the happy chimeras. “A children’s book about chimeras?”

She laughed. “You can find out a lot about things online. That's how you found this book, right?”

Phainon slowly nodded.

“We work for quite a well-known company, don't you think?”

“What does that have to do with anything?”

Cyrene hummed, setting the book back down into her lap. “You can find a lot about prominent figures from important companies.”

His eyes wandered Cyrene's knowing face as he digested those words. Why hadn't he thought about that before?

He couldn't help the laugh that escaped him. All the tension that had been building in his body all day was slowly leaving him, and his shoulders

unknowingly relaxed. It almost felt like everything that he had felt during the day had happened a long time ago. “You really think I should keep trying? He hates me, Cyrene.”

“Did you even read the book?” Cyrene scoffed, and that only made Phainon scoff back.

“What, did *you* read the book?”

She giggled, plucking Phainon's phone that was connected to her car and started digging through to play music. “You're so slow, Phainon.”

“*Excuse me?”*

“Drive us home, Phainon! I'm *tired*.” She yawned, stretching in her seat.

There was no refuting Cyrene once she was done with a conversation, and with a chuckle, Phainon started the car and headed back to Cyrene's apartment.

Chapter End Notes

- **Phainon's "Operation Annoy Mydei" File**

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon remembered his dream this time. It was a shame, because he didn't want to remember it at all.

Those [redacted] always rustling in the wind had always haunted his dreams. The vast sea and the little run-down [redacted]. The [redacted], where he used to play with Cyrene, and the [redacted] he used to sneak off to. If he closed his eyes, he could recall every single detail of that little town, which he never wanted to think of again.

It was probably because he had spent the whole day with Cyrene, and they had touched upon a topic that he never wanted to remember. Phainon had tried so hard to erase it from his mind and move on from his old life, but it was futile. He could never forget, no matter how much he tried to block Cyrene's words. She was the only person who witnessed everything by his side, but she came out of the situation so much differently than Phainon. Why couldn't he be more like her?

Shaking his head, he pushed himself from his bed. He had stayed over at Cyrene's apartment after they had visited the antique store and had spent the following Saturday with her doing whatever she had wanted to do. She was quite pleased, saying how Phainon hadn't been giving her attention as of late. Phainon had to laugh at that; he bothered her too much with his problems back in the day. He would've thought Cyrene would be tired of him by now. But those were thoughts that he didn't want to think about, and he swung his feet off the bed to get ready for the day.

It was Sunday today. He had the entire day to himself. And he planned this entire day to do one particular thing.

Cyrene had reminded him of something. If he wanted to learn more about someone, look them up online. Knowing that Mydei was a hugely

prominent figure for being the heir to Kremnos Corporation, there had to be something up there. Even if he couldn't find much about Mydei, he could at least find something about his parents, which could help him give clues about Mydei.

He took a deep breath, settling into his desk chair and glancing at the book that aroused nothing except complicated feelings. He still wasn't sure if he should continue this operation, but Cyrene's words kept echoing in his head. Phainon really did want to be different this time, but it just wasn't that simple. He lost *everything* back then. In fact, he watched everything and everyone slip away from his fingers with his own eyes, and he could do nothing except be a witness to the tragedy that played before his very eyes. He lost everything and everyone except for Cyrene, who had stubbornly stayed by his side through it all, and he refused to recall any of those memories once he had moved to the city. He left all of those memories away in that town and all of those complicated feelings he had felt behind. Why would he ever want to remember the times when they had nothing? She couldn't unearth those memories now, when he had spent years trying to forget.

But what did Cyrene mean that this book would help him live to the fullest? Did that really mean having to continue this operation? Was she implying whatever happened that night would help Phainon finally move on? Was learning about what happened that night even that important anymore? He felt like he was losing sight of his true objective. Still, he couldn't even believe that this book was sitting right before his very eyes, right at this moment, and that it was only a four-hour drive and outside of the city to find. How in the world did Cyrene even find this place and know this book was there?

Phainon wondered if Mydei even wanted to see it; he obviously had some significant ties to this book, whether it was the book itself, the characters, or maybe even the story. And Phainon wasn't sure whether he would evoke good memories or bad memories if he just showed up with this book the next time he saw Mydei. He felt like he was at those looming doors once again, staring at the entrance into Mydei’s life, where he didn't belong.

Turning on his computer, he resolved to figure out the book later. Maybe some of the things he could find online about Mydei would help him answer his own questions, and despite the lack of explanation from Cyrene, he trusted her. She knew him well; she practically raised him when they first moved to the city, when Phainon couldn't even raise himself. When he felt like absolutely nothing, and when he felt completely empty, Cyrene was there, and he trusted her then and now. It felt weird, but he typed his coworker's own name into the search engine.

There actually wasn't much about Mydei himself. There was his age, date of birth, and that he was the heir to Kremnos Corporation. He graduated from a prestigious university with a degree in business. Phainon couldn't find his high school information. Interestingly enough, he couldn't find anything before his university days.

This also felt weird to do, as he worked at the company itself, but he decided to look more into the CEO, Mydei's father, Eurypon. It had the basic information, like his age, date of birth, and so forth. News articles would pop up regarding his father, but they mostly consisted of things related to the company itself, such as their recent developments, conferences, and stocks. But there was only one particular type of article about him that was separate from the usual drivel about the company.

Eurypon was a divorcee. Multiple news articles were dated from many years ago, when Phainon hadn't even moved to the city yet. But he couldn't find anything about his previous wife, and he couldn't find any information that Eurypon had remarried. Did this mean Eurypon had custody over Mydei? Or did he continue to visit both parents? He hummed to himself, leaning back into his chair and brainstorming now that he had come to a standstill. What else could he possibly research regarding this family?

Phainon tried a different tactic. He tried to look up Kremnos Corporation itself. Specifically, he wanted the history of the company. Maybe he could find out more about Eurypon and, subsequently, Mydei.

When Kremnos Corporation first started out, it was a technology company that branded itself on innovation. Specifically, they were focused on improving government facilities, believing that the impact would help the

regular citizens using these government-funded facilities, such as schools, hospitals, and prisons. Then, at some point down the road, they changed their alignment and began focusing on the military, citing that true innovation lay in weaponry and technological advancements in that area. That was where they were now.

He stumbled upon a timeline of the company, when the company was founded, its growing successes, and how it came to be the company it was today. It was complete with dated photographs, but one particular picture stood out to him.

Phainon was shocked to see how much younger Eurypon appeared when the company was first founded. That was beside the point; the main point was the woman who was standing right next to him, who had gorgeous, golden blonde hair gathered up in a loose bun behind her head. With sharp, intimidatingly beautiful features, there was no doubt in Phainon's mind that she was the absolute spitting image of Mydei. Wait.

He compared the dates of all the articles that had been released when Eurypon’s divorce was exposed to the timeline of the company. It occurred right around when the company’s mission began to shift to the military, and since Phainon knew he was the same age as Mydei, this divorce really did happen when they were basically children. Then, who had custody of Mydei?

His mother was never mentioned. She wasn't even mentioned at work, and Mydei never mentioned her either. Where was she?

It was really all that Phainon could find. From the caption of the photograph, he had found that her name was Gorgo, but he couldn't find anything else besides that. It meant that the divorce was kept heavily under wraps, and it also meant that Gorgo received absolutely nothing from the company and nothing from Eurypon. She had absolutely zero ties with Kremnos Corporation, and she may even have zero ties with Mydei himself. But Mydei was definitely old enough to at least remember his mother. How did he feel about all of this?

Do you want to go to the bakery today?

That was what Mydei had said after Phainon asked if he liked being the CEO's son. He definitely held some complicated feelings about it if he refused to answer, yet he had never given thought to his actual job and position in the company before.

Then maybe you should stop thinking about the money of the CEO's son.

Money does not solve all your problems.

There are things you cannot buy with money.

Phainon frowned to himself, rocking back and forth within his chair with Mydei's words repeating in his mind. Is it because his mother got nothing that Mydei felt like this? But wasn't he with his father right now and living in a penthouse? Does he despise living this high life while his mother received nothing? But wouldn't Mydei be able to just give money to his mother now that he was an adult?

He shut his eyes with a groan. He felt like he was missing something. What was he missing? He felt like the most pivotal information to solve all the mysteries surrounding Mydei's family was his mother, but he couldn't find a single thing about her. Then again, how did this have anything to do with finding out about that night he was drunk? What was he going to do with this information? And why was Mydei's family history so complicated?

At the thought of the bakery, his stomach growled. Phainon had immediately jumped into research since the moment he woke up and had forgotten to eat. Maybe he should go to the bakery since he was thinking about it already.

Grabbing his car keys, he was off to The Chimeras' Bakery. Cyrene had dropped him off at the parking structure at work yesterday so that he could grab his car, thankfully, and within a few minutes, he was back at that pastel yellow and white decor.

The bell chimed as he pushed into the shop, with a different cashier greeting him this time. He wanted to try something new, since there were so many options, but he definitely had to buy his trusty butter croissant first.

Phainon went straight for its location. It was only his third time being here, but he knew exactly where it was. That butter croissant was somehow too good to keep out of his mind. And his mouth, apparently. He instinctively reached for it, placing it into his tray, but he had noticed a brand new sign sitting next to the croissants once he had pulled his hand back.

Vigethos.

His eyes shifted back and forth at the nearby pastries. Fig Stew, the golden honeycakes, hadn't changed, and the other adjacent pastries didn't change either. Then, were these butter croissants now named Vigethos? But why? And which pastry was Vigethos before? He recalled the previous cashier explaining that their specialty items were named after the characters in the children's storybook, but the butter croissant was not a specialty item when he had previously visited the bakery. Why would they possibly name such a basic pastry?

“Did you need help with anything, sir?”

The cashier's voice shook him from his head, and he must've realized he probably looked extremely peculiar, frozen and hovering over these butter croissants.

“Are… these croissants *Vigethos?*” He pointed at the croissants sitting on the shelf, and the cashier nodded.

“Vigethos used to be a blueberry cream cheese Danish, but the croissant was recently renamed. Were you looking for the Danish?”

A blueberry cream cheese Danish made much more sense as a specialty item than a basic croissant. Also, knowing Vigethos's appearance in the story, that dessert really did deserve to be named Vigethos. This croissant had nothing to do with what Vigethos looked like.

Phainon's eyes wandered through the store. Now he really wanted to try that blueberry cream cheese Danish, but he needed some answers first since it concerned the chimeras. “Why was it renamed?”

“I'm… sorry.” The cashier shook her head. “That's only for the owner to say. He's the one who bakes these and names them.”

Phainon hummed. Interesting. The owner just decided to name a basic croissant with a fancy name?

“Has he ever renamed pastries before?”

“Not that I'm aware.” The cashier's eyes gazed upward as she pondered the question. “I have only been working here for a few months, though. If you're a regular, you may have been here since the previous owner. I believe there were different pastries with different names then.”

“The previous owner?”

The cashier nodded. “I've only heard things, but I believe the previous owner was the one who founded this bakery. If you're confused by the names, it may be the previous owner's names that you're thinking of.”

It was Phainon’s turn to nod. He wasn't sure how this information was going to help with his operation, as it was more about the previous owner and less about the chimeras, so he decided to ask a more direct question. Maybe he could squeeze something else out from a different cashier. “Do you know Mydei?”

“Mydei?”

“Yes.”

“He's a regular here,” the cashier promptly responded. “Unfortunately, I cannot disclose information about other customers besides that information. I *can* tell you that he has been visiting for a long time and knew the previous owner, but I cannot tell you anything else regarding our customers.”

“*Knew?*”

“The previous owner is no longer here.”

Phainon's gaze became downcast. “I'm sorry.”

“No need to be sorry.” The cashier smiled. “But it is appreciated, all the same. I heard the previous owner was a lovely woman, but she passed away at a young age.”

“Really?” His eyebrows raised.

The cashier nodded once more. “A car crash, so I heard. Her son now runs the bakery in her place.”

“So, the owner of this bakery was the son of the previous owner and founder?”

“That's correct.”

“That's admirable.” Phainon smiled. “Does the son like baking too, or?” He didn't want to directly ask if the son was only keeping this business alive because of his mother.

“He does,” the cashier confidently replied. “I don't think there would be so many pastries if he didn't.”

With a quick scan around the room, Phainon laughed in agreement. There were probably too *many* options here, and it was always hard for Phainon to pick what to buy.

“Can I see that blueberry Danish?”

“Oh! Yes, it's over there.”

Phainon followed the direction the cashier was referring to and was able to find the previous Vigethos with ease. He brought his items up to the register. Phainon would just have to come back and try the rest of the pastries.

“Did you read this children's storybook? About the chimeras?”

The cashier glanced quizzically at him. “I only did when I got hired, because I didn't know what these chimeras were.”

“Do you think Vigethos matches this croissant?”

The cashier smiled in amusement, bagging up the pastries and calculating the amount due. “I think… It does. The croissant… It's a basic pastry, right? But it's actually made with extreme intricacy and is extremely difficult to make correctly. I think Vigethos is the same way. Have you read the story?

“I didn't.” Phainon shook his head, staring at the croissant in its box. “When I came here before, the cashier told me about it. I just didn't think a croissant would get a special name.”

“I don't know what the owner was thinking.” The cashier laughed, pushing the pastry box over to Phainon while he pulled out his credit card. “But, I get the rationalization.

“In the story, Vigethos thinks he isn't special. Just a normal, average chimera with no special talents. If you look at all the designs for the chimeras, he has the most basic design. The other chimeras all have accessories or fun colors, but Vigethos is just gray with blue eyes. Yet, he's the hero and protagonist of the story. I think the croissant being Vigethos makes sense. Something you think is normal and average, but is actually the most complex of them all. Vigethos’s appearance may seem plain, and he thinks himself average, but he is the main character of the whole story.”

Phainon pocketed his credit card once he finished paying, with the cashier's words echoing in his head. Vigethos thinks himself average even though he was the hero of the story? “I didn't realize the lore went so deeply in this book.” He chuckled. “Isn't the book hard to find?”

The cashier returned the laugh. “It's only with Vigethos. The other chimeras have very basic personalities that are normal for a children's book. And, the PDF file for this book is actually online, if you are interested. There really isn't much in it; just chimeras going on adventures, so it's an easy and quick read. But yes, I heard the book itself is hard to find. I'm not sure; I only really looked up this book when I got hired here.”

Thanking the cashier for her time and patience, he exited the store and returned home to feast on his new pastries. He only bought two croissants and one Danish, as he wasn't sure if he would even like the Danish in the first place. But everything he had tried from this bakery so far had blown him away, so his expectations were already set pretty high. Maybe one day, he would get to personally thank whoever the owner was.

Arriving back at his humble apartment, he dropped his keys and pastries onto the counter, settling into one of his stools after grabbing the book off his desk.

The Cycles of Vigethos. There was no author listed, which Phainon found was because the author chose to stay anonymous when publishing. Did Cyrene actually read this book? The cashier said the PDF was online, so Phainon wouldn't be surprised. Then, was this book so important to Mydei that he *needed* a physical copy?

He grabbed a croissant, cracking open the children's book once more and hearing the stiff spine loosen. The pages were thick, typical of a children's book, and it began with Vigethos arriving at this city where the sun never set. It was just an average children's book that consisted of very typical, simple sentences that could be found in any book aimed at children.

Each page had a different illustration, coinciding with whatever Vigethos was doing on that page. And as the story progresses, more chimeras join the story and the adventures Vigethos goes on. Phainon tried to pay particular attention to Fig Stew once he had entered the story.

Fig Stew was from another city.

Fig Stew came to join the Deliverer's party.

Fig Stew was very lazy.

Fig Stew was sleepy.

That was pretty much his introduction. Phainon sighed tiredly, taking a bite from his croissant, ensuring that none of the crumbs landed on the book

itself. Was he actually going to find anything relevant here?

He flipped through some more pages, skimming through the pages about the other chimeras. It seemed that Vigethos had a mini story with each of the chimeras as they joined, and he eventually landed upon the story with Vigethos and Fig Stew, and he frowned.

Fig Stew absolutely hated Vigethos. That was the message that Phainon was getting. He joined the adventures and treated all the other chimeras nicely, but not Vigethos. The moment they met, Fig Stew *hmphed*–the book's words, not Phainon's. It was almost as if Fig Stew was forced to accept Vigethos as the hero. But on every adventure, whenever Vigethos was stuck, it would be Fig Stew that came to help him, and Fig Stew would be secretly watching over Vigethos. On pages with Vigethos dealing with monsters, there was always a little Fig Stew peaking behind in the background. Phainon had to chuckle at that. How cute.

He eventually found the page he had flipped to a few days ago, of Vigethos crying by himself. Vigethos had failed at something and wanted to make someone else a hero. Vigethos thought he was no good. Then, Fig Stew appeared and gave him a flower. That was when Vigethos realized Fig Stew was in love with him.

This kind of… reminded him of…

His hands started becoming clammy as he flipped to the next page, and he was all too aware of his heart beating against his chest. He was aware of every breath he took, but it felt like no air was filling his lungs. It had moved on from Vigethos and Fig Stew and was about a different adventure, but Phainon's mind could not bring itself to move forward from those pages about Fig Stew.

It reminded him of exactly how Mydei treated him.

Obviously, it was in a children's format. But the way that Fig Stew treated Vigethos poorly, but at the very end, would jump in and help, was just too reminiscent of all the times Phainon had bothered Mydei, only for him to let

him join at the very end. Was… Mydei using this book as a way to express himself?

No. No, that couldn't have been right.

Phainon slammed the book shut before he could even get to the end. His heart was wildly racing in his chest. His hands were getting sweaty, and he couldn't bring himself to swallow another bite of his croissant. It felt like his throat *burned*. He couldn't breathe. His head hurt. It ached and pounded and beat so hard it felt like someone was slamming his head into a door. And if Phainon shut his eyes, it only emphasized his palpitating heartbeat and his throbbing head.

He had to get away from this book. That wasn't it, right? *Right?* Mydei didn't… No… He *shouldn't.* Phainon was wrong. That was what it was. There was definitely another perspective. He was clearly thinking of this wrong, and there was another reason why…

Why, Phainon couldn't think of another reason.

Phainon was trying to take deep breaths, burying his face into his palms and trying to recall his most recent memories with the other man, but it was futile. He was shaking too much. His elbows kept slipping off the counter. His eyes burned. Every single interaction was exactly how Fig Stew would've reacted. It was almost as if Mydei were using this little chimera as a guideline for how to act. When Mydei eventually let Phainon into his car, when he waited for Phainon during their lunch break, when Phainon felt bad he couldn't go to the bakery with him, and Mydei had offered him a smile. All of it. *All of it.*

And the Deliverer name… Phainon wasn't sure if he could bear to read it anymore. He wasn't sure what he would do if he heard it one more time from the other man's mouth.

What happened that night? *What did Phainon do to Mydei?*

The strange dreams he couldn't remember. Talking about his childhood dog in his sleep. It was safe to assume that *Phainon had probably told Mydei*

everything, and an unbearable weight crushed his chest at the thought. His eyes widened. His heart dropped into his stomach, and his entire body stilled.

Mydei knew everything.

Too much was happening at once. So much information was flooding into his brain that he couldn't make any sense of it. Mydei knew everything. *Mydei knew everything.* This book, these chimeras, that drunken night, those memories. Fig Stew was in love? He could just guess what happened that night. The erections he kept having. The heat that seemed to consume his body. He would have to be stupid at this point not to realize what he had done.

Phainon laughed. His stiff, unmoving body shook with laughter that echoed in his apartment. He was pulling at his hair and trying to rip out all the memories of the last two weeks. Mydei was really hiding all of this from him? That fucking bastard. *That fucking bastard.*

In love? What a joke. Mydei wasn't in love.

His laughter faded away until he was left with nothing. Just an empty, unmoving silence. And this book. This stupid children's book. Phainon wasn't a hero. He was far from it. How dare Mydei call him that nickname? *How dare he?*

After everything Phainon had told him that night, Mydei wasn't in love. Not even in the slightest. How could anyone possibly fall in love with someone who let his entire [redacted]? Phainon didn't do anything but *watch*. His [redacted], his [redacted], his [redacted]. He was a spectator in his own damn life that could do nothing but watch everything fade away. He wasn't a hero. And Mydei wasn't in love with him.

He couldn't be in love with him.

What a fucking joke. What a damn good laugh. The only sound remaining in this apartment was the sound of Phainon's own breathing and the ringing

of his heart in his ears. His body felt empty. His body felt heavy. He couldn't feel his limbs anymore.

How could someone possibly fall in love with Phainon?

He couldn't get that searing image of Mydei's smile out of his head. He couldn't forget that car ride when Mydei was staring at him in the car in front of his apartment. Phainon's hands started sweating just from thinking about it. The nerves that had shaken his core, his heart that had told him to run. It was like he was back in that car all over again, with Mydei's golden eyes staring straight into his soul. He just wanted… Phainon just wanted to thank him for those honeycakes.

Fuck, *Mydei made those for him*.

The first pastry Mydei had ever bought him was this croissant. *Vigethos*. The Deliverer. The croissant being complicated to make, but was plain on the outside. Mydei knew Phainon's entire life story inside and out. Honeycakes just sprouting on his counter the next day. The love, the childhood stories, the erections. Mydei had made those golden honeycakes for him. After Phainon railed the guy while blackout drunk, and then didn't remember a single thing.

Phainon scoffed incredulously. Mydei was making a fool out of him this entire time. He was watching from afar, just like Fig Stew, laughing at Phainon. Laughing at him for not knowing the truth, laughing at Phainon for being a spectator in his own life. Mydei was far from being in love. It was better to say that Mydei had been ridiculing Phainon this entire time. Mydei has had Phainon wrapped around his little finger since the very beginning, watching Phainon make a fool of himself for this week and a half. He kept bringing Phainon to his own bakery, feeding the cashiers information just to egg Phainon on. Mydei was probably in the back the entire time, just snickering to himself.

But even beside Mydei keeping all of this a secret, and beside the fact that Mydei was ridiculing him while watching Phainon pathetically put the pieces together. At the thought that, after all of this, after visiting his bakery,

trying his food, sharing breaks with each other, and the back-and-forth bickering, Mydei still never cared for Phainon.

And that hurt so much more.

Chapter End Notes

- **~~Phainon's "Operation Annoy Mydei" File~~**

Chapter 10

“Aedes Elysiae?”

Mydei was staring at this piece of paper that was taped to his office door first thing in the morning. But this was the only thing that was written on it– no explanation, no call to action, nothing that would indicate to him what to do with it. So he ripped off the piece of paper and unlocked his office door, stepping inside into the air-conditioned room.

He couldn't recall that piece of paper being there when he left his office before the weekend started. But Mydei had just returned from the bakery, and there was still half an hour left before the workday officially started. So who would possibly come at dawn just to tape this piece of paper to his door? With some words he has never heard of before?

It bothered him. There was something wrong. The hours ticked by. People walked in and out of his office. He attended multiple meetings. But it felt like something was off. It felt like he was missing something.

He had his arms crossed at the third meeting he was attending, leaning back in the office chair and listening to the finance department drone on about their investment progress. But he couldn't care less. What was Aedes Elysiae? Mydei had just thrown that piece of paper away, brushing it off as a prank, but the fact that someone had beaten Mydei to the office just to tape that paper on his door meant that those words meant more than Mydei could've imagined. Everyone knew that Mydei was always early into the office, so the message was purposefully intended for him.

Rustling suddenly broke his thoughts, and he was snapped back into reality when people began leaving their chairs. Mydei scrambled as nonchalantly as he could to leave as well, feigning attention to the entire meeting. He had to focus if he wanted to win. He couldn't let something so minor as two strange words take all his attention away.

But that empty feeling of his was soon confirmed. He was waiting in front of his office now that the lunch hour had started, and even though the floor had basically cleared, no one had come to approach him. Mydei furrowed his eyebrows to himself. Was that why it was so quiet today?

Approaching the human resources department, he saw that all of the cubicles were cleared. Taking a glance at that specific cubicle, the computer wasn't even on.

“If you're looking for Phainon, he's not in today.”

Mydei tore his gaze away from the untouched desk to land his eyes upon Aglaea, the human resources director. “He didn't come in?”

“He called out today.” She had a fresh cup of coffee in her hand; most likely, she had caught Mydei while returning to her desk from the break room. “He said he may be out for a few days, so I would suggest checking back next week if you still need him.”

A few days?

Mydei nodded in response, thanked her, and returned to his office, shutting the door behind him.

With Phainon gone, that meant he could actually take a nap during his lunch. But he was still too unsettled to even begin falling asleep.

He only sat at his desk, staring at nothing. It was so quiet that he didn't know what to do with himself. Mydei had gotten too accustomed to Phainon's loud presence too quickly, and it was unusual and unsettling now that he was gone.

But where did Phainon go on such short notice? It was normal for people to call out for a day at the last minute, but a *few days?* Where was Phainon going? He hadn't told him anything.

Mydei shook his head. They weren't anything, and Phainon didn't have any obligation to tell him his business. But he couldn't imagine that the guy,

who had been teasing him incessantly for a week and a half, wouldn't take the opportunity to tease Mydei about his lack of presence.

“Are you going to miss me, Mydei?”

“Don't get too lonely without me!”

He would've expected those statements at the bare minimum, at least. Maybe, was there something wrong? Did something happen over the weekend?

His eyes unexpectedly drifted toward his recycling bin, where the only thing that sat in there was those mysterious words that appeared on his office door. It wasn't like it would have anything to do with Phainon, but maybe it would give him something to do to get his mind off the other man.

Fishing out the piece of paper, as there was no way he would remember how to spell such strange words, he punched the letters into his computer. There, his screen was immediately filled with lush fields, golden wheat, and a vast sea that stretched far beyond the horizon.

It was a small village at the very edge of the country, and its main source of income was their luscious wheat fields that spanned farther than the eye could see. They did sell various other crops as well, but they were most famous for their wheat. However, an epidemic had swept the village, and due to a lack of resources and the lack of proper healthcare within a reasonable distance, everyone passed away.

There were only very few articles touching the topic, and they weren't even from big journalism companies either. It seemed to be just smaller journalism sites that were already aware of this village, as this village was so small that it didn't get any news coverage. It was a village that no one knew existed, and it was quickly wiped from the maps. And it seemed that, there were no other villages even nearby Aedes Elysiae, so no one else was affected by the epidemic. It was a story barely worth covering, which was why no one did.

If this village was so isolated, where did this epidemic even come from? None of the articles mentioned where it had come from, only that it was the cause of their downfall. There weren't any photos of the villagers either. Most of the pictures were scenic photographs of the pier or the wheat fields, since that was what they were known for. The village was so out of the way that they couldn't even attract tourism for their scenic sights.

Mydei took a deep breath. Did this have anything to do with him?

There was nothing left for us in that small town anymore.

He narrowed his gaze at the picture of the wheat field across his screen, recalling Phainon's words from when he had gotten drunk during the company dinner. Was this Phainon's hometown? The one that he talked about? But didn't he say he moved with his family? The articles all said there were no survivors. Then again, Phainon was a survivor. Maybe there was a chance his family was still here?

Phainon didn't really talk about himself much when he was drunk. Well, he did, but they were mostly more random facts about himself. He talked about how he used to have a dog, how he had blonde hair in college, and a bunch of random other facts and stories about himself whenever they came to him. Mydei didn't even know the dog’s name. They were all very nonsensical trivia about himself that popped into his head at random times during the walk to his apartment. He didn't reveal specifically why he had moved to the city, and he didn't specifically reveal his own childhood.

This was all based on the conjecture that Aedes Elysiae was actually related to Phainon in the first place. There could be a chance someone was making him research this small village for an entirely different reason, but the only thing that had been unusual all day was Phainon. His only best assumption was that Aedes Elysiae was Phainon's hometown, and he had moved to the city when it was wiped out. No, more like he was *forced* to move to the city. Based on when the few articles had been released, this had happened a long time ago, when they were children.

He couldn't have imagined that someone so carefree had such a tragic background. Then again, one could never guess what someone had gone

through. It was already a miracle that Phainon was a survivor. He should be proud of himself.

Despite finding out this information, Mydei still couldn't figure out why he was gone from work, no matter how much he racked his brain. The village had been gone for a long time, and Phainon was coming into work just last week. He was missing something else, but he didn't know what it was and had a very slim chance of finding out unless Phainon actually came in for once. But for the next few days, Phainon still hadn't returned.

“Mydei? How can I help you?”

“Can I speak with Cyrene?”

“Of course!”

The human resources assistant dashed off. Since recruiters were always on the phone, talent acquisition had its own set of cubicles where they could freely speak without disrupting others. And Mydei couldn't just barge into there either, as he would just have to wait for them to get off the phone anyway.

It was a few short minutes of waiting. The human resources assistant returned and let him know that Cyrene was on a call but would head to his office shortly. With a nod, Mydei returned to his office.

He had to admit it: Mydei was worried. It was the fourth day since Phainon had been gone, and Mydei had returned to his usual, quiet life; the quiet life that he was no longer used to, after Phainon had barged in unceremoniously. And no, he wasn't keeping count at all. Absolutely not at all. But he had to admit that it was becoming difficult to focus on his work. It kept feeling like Phainon would barge through his door at any moment, walk past him in the hallways without him knowing, or jump into his car while he was trying to leave work. Mydei's eyes kept drifting beyond him, looking for that familiar silver head of hair, and he was always on edge for the very moment he would spot just a sliver of that man within his vision.

And after three full days of complete and utter silence filled with noise and distraction, he decided to ask someone else if they knew what had happened, and he could only hope that Cyrene had some sort of hint as to why he was gone. At least, he just wanted to know if Phainon was okay. He didn't need any specific details; only that Phainon would come back.

Of course, it was because Mydei liked Phainon. What other reason could he have for being so worried? Mydei was always thinking of Phainon, always looking for Phainon. Ever since that day he had first heard Phainon's voice, he had been unconsciously looking for him ever since. Far longer than Phainon had ever taken notice of Mydei. And it crushed his heart that Phainon couldn't recall a single memory from the one night that they shared.

But that was beside the point now. He had moved on from that a while ago, mostly because he had Phainon himself in his life. And yet, right when he had started getting his hopes up, right when he was beginning to revel in his presence, he just disappeared. As if he were never a part of Mydei's life at all. And it infuriated him more than when Phainon was trying to annoy him for the truth regarding that night he was drunk. He was going to give Phainon a piece of his mind when he returned.

A knock sounded at his door, and Mydei called them in.

A head of pink hair peeked inside. “You were looking for me?”

“I just…” Mydei began to speak only to shut his mouth at his own thoughts. Was it weird to call someone all the way to their office just to ask where someone else was? He had just wanted to ask the woman a quick question, but now it was suddenly becoming complicated.

“Are you looking for Phainon?” With a knowing smile, she stepped inside, leaning back and shutting the door behind her.

“Were you the one who left that piece of paper on my door a few days ago?” Mydei had suddenly recalled the mysterious paper, and the fact that she had brought up Phainon herself meant that she definitely knew something.

Cyrene hummed, pulling up the spare chair and sitting down. “I think… Phainon read that children's book.”

His heart sank at those words, and a deep breath left his body. Mydei didn't want to know. He really, truly, didn't want to confirm, but he asked anyway. “Children's book?”

“*The Cycles of Vigethos*.”

Mydei stayed silent. Of course it was that book. What other book would it possibly be? The silence between them had become so unbearable that it made Cyrene want to fill in the silence.

“I brought him to an antique store on Friday. We found a physical copy–”

"You're lying.”

“Huh?” The other woman blinked blankly at him, a confused smile upon her face. “What do you mean?”

Mydei had thought about that book for far too long. A huge chunk of his life was from that book, but he didn't have the headspace to think about it right now. Not when his heart was still worrying over Phainon. “There shouldn't be any copies of that book anywhere.”

“But–”

“My father paid the publisher to destroy all physical copies. There shouldn't be any more.”

Cyrene fidgeted in her seat, with pink eyes flickering between Mydei and her lap, where she was playing with her skirt. Mydei hadn't meant to sound so adamant, but it was the truth. There should not be any more physical copies of that children's book.

“May I ask why?”

“He just didn't like it,” Mydei simply stated. It was the truth; his father didn't like the book, and he had it disposed of. As he always did with

anything he didn't like or disagreed with.

Cyrene furrowed her eyebrows, staring into the air at nothing in particular. “I see.”

Another silence settled upon them. The silence that Mydei had been struggling to get used to this entire week. That suffocating silence that left him feeling empty, that left him yearning for something that had disappeared in a blink of an eye. He was already yearning for moments that only occurred for the span of a week and a half, yet it had felt like so much longer. He couldn't take it anymore, so Mydei opened his mouth.

“So,” Mydei deeply exhaled, resisting the urge to shut his eyes. The weight had settled upon his shoulders now. Now that Phainon had read the book, Mydei knew. Phainon knew everything. And he had left. That was it then. No more Phainon in his life. No more stupid banter, no more shimmering blue eyes, no more clinginess. “Phainon isn't here because he read that book. I guess… He doesn't–”

“No!” Two hands slammed on his desk, making him jump in his seat and his eyes widen. “Don't finish that thought!”

“You don't even–”

“He won't even let me into his apartment.” Cyrene slumped in her chair, but her arms were still outstretched to reach his desk as if reaching out to Mydei himself. “I keep calling him every day, and he keeps saying he's fine and that he'll come back soon. But it's already been a week already.”

Mydei stayed silent, letting Cyrene continue.

“I just think… He's scared.” Cyrene's eyes were downcast, staring at her hands along the edge of his desk. “I think… He doesn't want to accept the truth. Knowing him, he probably came to the truth, became scared of the truth, and then convinced himself that it wasn't true at all.”

Mydei frowned, his gaze turning toward his desk. Has Phainon always been like that? Him? That carefree corporate worker who didn't seem to care

about what anyone else thought of him?

“Did you look up Aedes Elysiae?”

Mydei grunted, crossing his arms. “So it *was* you who left that note there.”

She chuckled weakly. “Phainon and I… You may not know, but we are childhood friends–born and raised in the same small village.”

“Which was Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei could only assume.

Cyrene nodded slowly. “I won't say too much… about Phainon. It's not my place to say. But, do you know what the…” She knit her eyebrows together, carefully reciting the words, “What the Black Tide is?”

His body immediately grew right at her words, with his heartbeat freezing at the mere sound of that term. It was as if all the pieces suddenly fell into place. Mysterious epidemic that came out of nowhere? And only affected an isolated village? Mydei scoffed. “Of course I know what that is. This is a company working with the military. You're telling me that the village that scientist tested his war machine was *Aedes Elysiae?*”

Cyrene's eyes widened, and a small, pitiful smile emerged upon her lips. “When I was young, when it all happened, I didn't know what happened either. All I could find online was that it was some random, unfortunate epidemic with unlucky timing. But I was there. I know what I saw. And I know it wasn't random.”

She shifted in her seat once more as she recalled the memories. “Phainon and I had run to the forest to play, as we always did. Which is why we were out of the target area for the Black Tide. At least, I think so. I can't find much about it. But someone… Some black-cloaked man had arrived at the town, and when he left, everyone was dead.”

Mydei could only stare at Cyrene, who had her head bowed so low that he could only see the top of her head, but she was shaking in her chair. After all of these discussions about military weapons, he had become desensitized to it all, but here was a living survivor right before his eyes.

The Black Tide was a key point in his plan, so Mydei knew all too well about what the Black Tide was. It was quite a feat that Cyrene had even found information on it. It was kept heavily under wraps, but she may have stumbled upon information about it while working here and put some of the pieces together herself.

It was a toxic agent, one that was barely noticeable, that caused hallucinations, marred the human body, and then death, all in that order. It had made even a peaceful, remote village turn on itself until there was no one left. Cited as the turning point of any war in its scientific conclusion, it was extremely dangerous, extremely effective, and his father had been trying to gather the funds to own the rights to the Black Tide for the past few years. He hadn't realized that the remote village cited in the research papers was actually Aedes Elysiae this whole time, and that it was Cyrene and Phainon's hometown.

"Phainon… blames himself for that day," Cyrene breathed out. "He always… tells himself how he shouldn't have gone to the forest that day. That if he had been there from the start, he could've done something."

If he had been there since the start, Phainon would've fallen right into the Black Tide's hallucinations. He would've taken part in the massacre that the Black Tide had instigated, and he would have had blood on his own hands before dying a gruesome death. There would've been nothing he could've done if he had been there at the start, and that was the truth.

Taking a shaky breath, Cyrene suddenly straightened in her seat, resolutely staring into Mydei's eyes. "That's besides the point. It was a long time ago. And we are in a much better place now. But Phainon… Phainon thinks of himself as an anti-hero."

Anti-hero… Mydei could guess what was going through Phainon's head after reading *The Cycles of Vigethos*. But even after hearing all of this and everything that he had gone through, Mydei would still confidently call him his Deliverer. Phainon was just mistaken and trapped within that memory of Aedes Elysiae. He just needed someone to wake him up and tell him that he was here, in the city, as a new person. Someone just needed to pull him out of that village and its golden wheatfields.

“You won't… give up on him, right?”

The emotions swirling in Cyrene's eyes were complicated–hope and anticipation, sorrow and empathy. Mydei couldn't even begin to fathom the experiences that the heavy layers of their relationship had gone through and all the things that have tested them over the past years. It was clear that Cyrene cared very deeply for Phainon, and they were the only ones who could rely on each other from that forgotten village.

Mydei was left with his own complicated feelings. He didn't know how much Cyrene had told him, and he didn't know what else Phainon was hiding from him. All he knew was that Phainon was going through his own battles this entire week, and Mydei wasn't going to back down without a fight either.

“I think… things will be very different from here.” It was the only explanation that Mydei could think of. He had his eyes narrowed, deep in thought, predicting the coming events. From what he had learned of Phainon and what he could guess about the other man, Mydei knew for certain that their situations were about to be very different from last week's.

Cyrene laughed, dabbing the corners of her eyes. “I think they will be too.”

“And that's the office of the son of the CEO!” One employee in the human resources department squealed.

“Everyone has been *dying* to get on his good side.” Another employer chimed in. “He's so cold, though. He never attends any social events, and he always stays in his office.”

“But the effort will be worth it; just think about being on the good side of the future CEO.”

“That's so ridiculous.”

Mydei's hands froze in the break room that was situated between the human resources department and the executive department. He was mixing his

favorite fruit drink as he usually did every afternoon, and it wasn't unusual to hear gossip about himself; in fact, he heard it every day. Ever since he got hired here, all he had faced were false smiles and false pleasantries, trying to appease him to get on his good side. And Mydei had become tired of it. He was only here to do a job, not try to play corporate politics. But, a different opinion rang in the room, interrupting the usual gossip that Mydei always heard.

“What did you say?”

A man laughed, and Mydei furrowed his eyebrows. There was a man in the human resources department? He couldn't recall any, but maybe they were recently hired.

“I said that's ridiculous,” the man repeated. “He seems like a better guy than that.”

“A better guy than *what?”*

“To fall for such false pleasantries.” The man couldn't help but let out another chuckle at the thought. “Mydei is so much better than that.”

“Do you even know him? Weren't you just hired?”

“That's just… the impression I got. Mydei seems like a man who knows exactly what he wants.”

“Really?”

“I think he would shine the best if you treat him just like anyone else. And if you ask me, I think that's exactly what he wants. To be known for himself and his work, rather than as the CEO's son.”

The group outside seemed to have moved into a different conversation now, but Mydei was too busy trying to still his pounding heart.

And from that day forward, miraculously, everyone had started to treat him normally. And so, Mydei did too. He didn't shy away from conversing with

others and attending social events; he didn't mind speaking with his coworkers at all anymore.

Well, except for one coworker. Mydei only had *The Cycles of Vigethos* to thank.

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A yellow rose and a croissant.

Those were the two things on Phainon's desk upon returning to work. No note, no explanation, just those two things on his desk when he had arrived at work first thing in the morning.

Phainon had taken a week off. He probably had a lot of work to catch up on. He had new hires to review. Exit interviews to schedule. Onboarding documents to correct. Questions and inquiries to address. He didn't have the headspace or time for this. Not right now. Pushing the croissant and the rose aside, he turned on his work computer to begin the day.

His coworkers had come up to him and asked how he had been, since he had been gone for a week. It was a morning of casual smiles and laughter while sifting through his thousand emails that he had received during his week off. Phainon had shoved the rose and the croissant into an empty drawer at his desk.

Time to continue work.

It had taken him basically two days to finally clear his inbox. There was another yellow rose and a different pastry on his desk on his second morning. He didn't bother to check what pastry it was. This time, it was a doughnut.

Thankfully, his coworkers took care of many of the more urgent tasks while he was away, but he still had much to do. As this was a big company, many people were constantly being hired and leaving all at the same time. As that was Phainon's entire job, he had plenty of things to occupy his time with and plenty of people he needed to meet with. Phainon reviewed his work

calendar with a sigh, tossing the yellow rose and the pastry into that empty drawer.

Time to continue work.

His third day almost consisted of back-to-back meetings. He barely had time to sit at his own desk. Orientations were usually scheduled for the first day of every week, but they had pushed it to Wednesday for Phainon to catch up. He was very grateful for that, and for half of the day, he was helping the new hires understand the company.

Phainon spoke with them, taught them, and joked with them for hours in the auditorium. He helped them with any new hire documents they didn't understand, and for the second half of the day, he gave them a tour of the entire corporate office. Twelve entire floors that Phainon walked through with the new hires, and one by one, he helped them become adjusted to their new workspaces on whichever floor and department they would be working with.

He didn't have time to look at the yellow rose and the other pastry on his desk. It was the blueberry cream cheese Danish he had previously bought. He was barely even at his desk that day in the first place. Phainon tossed them into that empty drawer during his lunch break.

Time to continue work.

Murmurs and whispers echoed through the floor when he stepped off the elevator on his fourth day upon returning. Phainon had caught up with his work and had returned to his usual routine, and he was excited that tomorrow would be the final day of the work week before he was able to relax on the weekend. But he was caught off guard upon seeing everyone's attention turned to the human resources department.

Staff from the executive department were standing a considerable distance away, muttering to each other. And as he turned the corner that led to the human resources department, his steps immediately halted.

There was a giant bouquet of yellow roses sitting on his desk, neatly held together with a grand, pastel blue ribbon. And sitting next to the bouquet was a steaming plate of golden honeycakes, littered with berries and dripping in a sweet, viscous syrup.

Phainon's eyes widened, rushing to his desk and parting the sea of employees that had gathered to witness the grand spectacle. And when he had finally reached his desk, he saw a note tied with a blue ribbon from around the wrapping paper that held the flowers together.

Meet me at the bakery.

His heart ached. His face burned. His lips quivered. His hands were shaking, holding the letter up to his trembling eyes. His breathing was sporadic. He slammed the card to his desk, trying to calm his burning features. But it was pointless when his entire vision was flooded with gold, spanning across his desk to the point where he could barely see his monitors. He couldn't tear his gaze away from those five words that were wrapping around his hand from underneath his fingers.

“Phainon, do you have a secret admirer?”

“Who could be Phainon's secret lover in the building?!”

“Phainon talks to too many people as the HR specialist; it'll be impossible to figure out who it is.”

His eyes were trained on the card, burning holes through his desk. Phainon had drowned out all the noise around him. He could only hear his quickening heartbeat and feel his trembling fingers. Pain erupted in his bottom lip, where he had sunk his own teeth into it to stop his own shaking.

Meet me at the bakery.

Phainon rapidly shook his head. *He* didn't want to see him. He didn't want to see *him. He* was probably so much happier without Phainon in his life. Phainon was an incessant bother.

Meet me at the bakery.

He was doing this just to ridicule him. *He* was going to show him *his* bakery, which *he* owned himself, and have one final laugh at Phainon before leaving him. As everyone always did to Phainon.

Meet me at the bakery.

His vision was covered in gold. There were too many yellow roses. He hated it. *He despised it*. It made his head hurt. His eyes were stinging. And when he shut his eyes, all he could see was gold, spanning as far as the eye could see under clear, blue skies, ending at the vast, infinite sea under a golden, shining sun.

Meet me at the bakery.

Phainon's throat closed up. He grimaced. His shoulders tensed. His fingernails were digging into his palms. And then, two hands had landed on his shoulders, jolting him from that sunny day.

“Phainon?”

He gasped sharply, the air returning to his lungs as he whipped his head around with wide eyes. He was heaving as if he had run through all twelve floors of the building, and every breath made his throat ache from feeling dry and scratchy. His gaze flickered from Cyrene to behind her, where no one stood. The crowd had dispersed at one point, and everyone returned to their desks. How long was he standing here, in this office?

“H–Hi, Cyrene.” He forced a chuckle, smiling despite her concerned expression. “Good morning. It's Friday tomorrow. Should we do something?”

Her pink eyes briefly fluttered between his face and the note he was trying to hide underneath his hand, and she grinned. “I have plans.”

His smile twitched. “Plans?”

She nodded enthusiastically. “I'm going to the mall with Castorice. Right, Cas?” Cyrene raised her voice by the end of her statement, but her eyes never left Phainon's.

“*U–Uh, um.*.. Right!” Castorice's usually timid voice boomed from her cubicle. “We're, *um.*.. Going on a drive!”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “I thought you said you were going to the mall?”

“We're going on a drive *to* the mall!” Cyrene laughed and playfully smacked Phainon's shoulder. “Silly, how else would we get to the mall?”

“I mean, we live in the city, so you could definitely walk there.”

“Why would we walk if we own cars?” Cyrene feigned another laugh once more. “You're so funny, Phainon.” And with another playful slap, she returned to her cubicle.

Phainon was now left alone. With these fresh golden honeycakes and a bouquet of yellow roses. He couldn't bring himself to throw them away. He couldn't bring himself to throw *anything* away. Phainon still had those three pastries and three yellow roses in his drawer from the previous days. The croissant, the doughnut, the Danish. The pastries that he swore he didn't pay any attention to. The pastries that he swore he didn't give a single thought to.

What was *he* playing at here? What was *he* trying to do with Phainon? Stop making his heart race. Stop making his cheeks burn. Stop making him so excited. Phainon loved it. He hated how much he loved the attention.

Phainon couldn't continue work that day.

His eyes kept drifting to the yellow bouquet that was propped up on his desk in a spare vase found in a storage room. He couldn't stop smiling at them. He couldn't stop his fingers from reaching out to brush against the petals. Gold had never looked so beautiful before. When was the last time he loved the color gold just like this?

Phainon didn't know what to do with himself. His heart was being tugged in different directions, and his mind kept alternating between two different thoughts. The yellow was beautiful, the yellow was mocking him. The yellow was beautiful, the yellow was mocking him. How could he cave so easily to a man who had deceived him? Who had ridiculed him? Who had watched him from afar for such a long time, mocking him from the sidelines? Phainon was a lost cause. Every time he looked at those yellow roses, his frustration dissipated, and the tension fled his body.

He tore his gaze from the flowers, staring straight into the document that had been pulled up on his monitor for the past thirty-three minutes. *He* only sent these here to mock him further. *He* knew what he was doing, sending yellow roses. Yellow. Yellow. *Yellow*. Yet, Phainon couldn't find it in himself to be mad. If Phainon were in his position, he would mock himself too. Phainon's entire life was just so laughably unfortunate. He couldn't blame him for mocking him further with this color, this stupidly unfortunate color that has haunted his dreams for years.

Phainon would go to the bakery, hear *his* final laugh, and watch *him* leave him. Maybe, *he'll* even take the roses back. He was sure this bouquet cost a lot of money. Maybe *he'll* even take the pastries back. Phainon hadn't even had a bite out of them yet. No, Phainon shouldn't eat them anymore. He should stop sparing them any thoughts.

The golden honeycakes were also still sitting on his desk, right next to the filled vase. The scent of the sweet syrup continually wafted in his nose as if he had placed a scented candle on his desk. It was as if it were constantly reminding him that they were there, waiting for Phainon to cave. Waiting for Phainon to break.

The workday ended before Phainon could continue his work.

His coworkers in the nearby cubicles began departing, bidding their farewells and good nights. Phainon couldn't believe he hadn't done a single thing while at work. For the entire day, his eyes kept returning to those yellow roses sitting upon his desk, as if hypnotizing him.

Phainon's heart was racing. His limbs felt stiff as he packed his things for the day. He could feel every sensation in his body. The mouse underneath his fingertips. The cushioned office chair that he was sitting in as he shut off his computer. Everything around him, Phainon was too aware of it all. Phainon knew *he* was waiting for him. Should Phainon even go?

He was the last one left at the cubicles as he rigidly pushed his chair in. He was all too conscious of himself, as if those golden eyes were already staring at him, watching his every single move. Taking the yellow roses and the golden honeycakes into his arms, Phainon walked to his car, with every footstep reverberating in his brain.

Every rumble of the engine, the lock of his car door, the feeling of the leather steering wheel underneath his hand. Phainon felt that he wasn't in his own body, yet he could still feel every part of the world around him, watching him at every turn and waiting for Phainon to make a fool of himself. Those golden eyes were trained on him at every moment, from every little thing that surrounded Phainon. It was hard to keep his eyes trained on the road when the yellow roses were staring so intently at him. He shouldn't have brought them with him, but how else would he return them when *he* asked for them back?

The drive to that place felt far too long for Phainon's liking. He recalled the drive was only a couple of minutes, but why did the drive feel so long? Every second was counted with his palpitating heartbeat, every stoplight felt like hours. Every turn of his steering wheel felt like a full minute. He could still feel the yellow roses boring straight into him from the seat next to him. He should've thrown everything into the back. Better yet, he should've thrown it all into his trunk.

He could barely feel his own body once he had pulled into that parking lot. His pounding heart was shaking his entire body. It was hard to breathe. His throat had closed up, and every shaky breath took his entire chest. Phainon forced his limbs to push himself out of the car, and the cool evening air washed his burning body. He was so hot that he was sweating. His hands felt clammy, yet nothing would be able to calm him down as he stared at those pastel yellow and white decorations. *Of course they were yellow.*

His heart dropped to his stomach as he heard the chime of the bells right above the entrance. He was met with those pastries once again, that watched his every move and every step around the shop. His stomach hurt. He could barely see. Could barely breathe. Phainon swallowed dryly, and it felt like a rock had lodged itself in his throat. He was all too aware of how much he was shaking.

“Phainon?”

Phainon jolted as if he were shocked by electricity upon hearing his name. With his gaze whipping toward the counter, *he* was there, emerging from the curtains that led to the kitchen. Was that… his voice? Saying his name? *He said his name?*

His eyes widened upon laying eyes on his golden head of hair and the golden eyes that he had felt mocking him this entire day. This entire *week*, in fact. Phainon opened his mouth, but he immediately shut it. He didn't have anything to say to this man, but he remembered the things in his car. So he parted his lips once more.

“I brought… the things you gave me.” Phainon swallowed. His voice was hoarse, and every syllable clawed at his throat. “If you want… them.”

“They're for you.” That smooth, deep voice reverberated through the shop. He bent down to mutter something to the cashier, and with a brief nod, they departed from the store. It felt like Phainon's entire world had stopped spinning when the chime of the bells rang behind him and a rush of wind breezed past him until there was complete and utter silence.

Phainon swallowed once more, trying to soothe his aching throat. “Why did you call me here? To ridicule me one more time? To show me your precious bakery and that dumb croissant you renamed?”

His eyes slightly widened at the mention of the croissant, but he quickly returned to his usually beautiful stoic face. Why did he have to be so pretty, even when Phainon felt like he was being admonished under his stare?

“Do you know what yellow roses mean?” He had pivoted back to the things he had given Phainon.

“Didn't you get those just to laugh at me?”

“Of course not.” His voice was gentle, and it only made Phainon tremble even more in his place. “You should see their meaning later.”

“What's the point?” Phainon immediately scoffed. “So you can get me to look more at that cursed color?”

“Phainon.” That deep, sultry voice spoke his name once more. Why did it feel like Phainon's heart was pounding for a different reason? “I renamed that croissant… because it is your favorite. I don't know what other reason you had conjured up in your head, but it's because it is your favorite that I decided to name it for you.”

Phainon had to try to keep his eyes glued onto the man in front of him instead of letting them drift toward the croissants sitting next to the golden honeycakes against the wall in their usual spot. “You *had* to name them Vigethos?” He had to hold in his laughter. “That dumb hero who could barely do anything?”

“Phainon–”

“The one who thought that even he, himself, couldn't be a hero?” The scene of Vigethos pitying himself flashed through his mind. That stupid little gray chimera who couldn't do anything at all. “You're just making a fool of me, aren't you? This entire bakery set up around that book? Bringing me here in the first place? Making me read that damn book? All so that you could make a fool out of me at the very end once I had finally put the pieces together.”

“I wanted you to taste my pastries. I never thought of you once as a fool.”

“Don't lie to me,” Phainon snapped. His voice was rising, and he took another deep, shaky breath. But it did nothing to soothe his burning blood

that coursed through every limb of his body. “You couldn't just *tell* me? Anything at all?”

“I… This bakery is a secret. They tell everyone that I don't work here.”

“This bakery, that's only a couple of minutes' drive from work, is a secret?” Phainon couldn't stop the scoff once more. “Make the lie more believable.”

“My mother opened this bakery,” he began to explain. “I didn't choose its location.”

“Then what about that night? Didn't want to tell me that I fucking railed you? Making a fool out of me there too?”

“You wouldn't have believed me if I told you.” His voice had lowered at the mention of that night. “You hated me, Phainon. You wouldn't have–”

“I *do* hate you.” Phainon's voice rang clearly in the bakery. “I *despise* you. Your golden eyes, your golden hair. I hate looking at you. I hate hearing your voice. I hate speaking to you. I don't even want to think about you anymore.”

His eyes were stinging once more. His throat was throbbing, and he found himself swallowing after almost every other word. Phainon knew it himself: Every single word was false. He was going to leave this bakery, still thinking about the man standing right in front of him. Just like he always did. And he *hated* it. Just like this man he was supposed to hate. Phainon could not bring himself to hate him at all. And it only made him hate himself even more.

“I'm leaving you alone, just like you wanted. You said I was an inconvenience, so why are you trying to come into my life now? Because there's no one to make fun of anymore? Your entertainment is gone, and you're trying to get it back?”

The man behind the counter continued to stay silent. It only left Phainon with his own thoughts, and he didn't want to be there anymore.

“Maybe do me a favor and stop giving me roses. They're an eyesore.”

After waiting for a few seconds, waiting to see how the other man would react, nothing came. So when the man across from him didn't utter another word, Phainon whirled around and pushed open the doors. His entire body was enveloped in the cool air once more, but his body could barely feel it as he walked back to his car, slamming the car door next to him as he dropped into the car seat.

That was it, right? No more of that man, no more gold, no more unnecessary feelings, no more unnecessary thoughts. Phainon was back to being by himself again. As he always was.

The yellow roses and golden honeycakes still sat in the passenger seat, strapped in with the seatbelt. Phainon clenched his fists, resisting the urge to throw them out his door and get rid of this color once and for all.

Instead, he pulled out his phone, with the search engine emerging onto his screen.

Yellow roses primarily symbolize friendship, joy, and happiness, and are used to express warmth and support… Today, they are also linked to optimism, new beginnings, success, and gratitude…

Modern meanings of yellow roses:

Joy and happiness: Their bright color evokes positivity and is perfect for celebrating happy occasions.

Optimism and good wishes: They are a symbol of good luck and a cheerful outlook, perfect for new beginnings.

Gratitude and care: A bouquet can be a way to thank someone for their support and show you are thinking of them.

Historical and traditional meanings:

Apology: In some traditions, a yellow rose could also mean "I'm sorry".

On Phainon's desk the next day, the final day of the work week, there sat another yellow rose and a croissant. Similarly to the first day, but this time, a note was tied to the rose:

My father does not know the bakery exists. If he did, he would shut it down. He is trying to erase all traces of my mother.

This croissant is named after my love. Fig Stew's beloved. Fig Stew's hero. There is no other meaning for its name.

Chapter End Notes

> The Google search results for "meaning of yellow roses" has been copied and pasted into this chapter.

▶ **Mydei's "Operation Annoy Phainon" File**

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

This happened for the next few weeks.

Every day upon arriving at work, there sat a small yellow rose and a new pastry. And attached to every yellow rose would be a new note. Every little note, Phainon learned a little bit more about the other man, and every little note, the other man would slowly explain himself.

I took over the bakery when my mother passed away. My mother taught me how to bake.

My mother read me The Cycles of Vigethos *when I was young. It was my entire world.*

My father left me with my mother when they divorced. He didn't want me. He only took me back when he needed an heir.

My mother didn't get much money from the divorce, but she used it all for only two things.

To commission someone to write a story for her, and to open a bakery.

They were all facts related to the other man. Facts that Phainon was trying to put together so meticulously before. Facts that had seared themselves into Phainon's brain as he convinced himself they were for that dumb operation. It was never about the operation.

He could not bring himself to get rid of a single thing. It felt as if he were collecting little pieces of the other man, little pieces of *himself* that the other man had relied on him to keep, to treasure, to cherish, and to protect. It had gotten to a point where the empty drawer he had been shoving everything into was no longer empty. And it had gotten to a point where he would

catch himself pulling open the drawer, staring at everything that was gifted to him, only to admonish himself and slam the drawer closed.

He read every word with extreme scrutiny. He tossed and turned the note within his fingers for hours, admiring every little stroke of the pen that was used. He went back and ate all the pastries that were gifted to him from before. He began bundling up the roses together, making an entirely new bouquet of yellow roses before roughly shoving them back into the depths of his empty drawer. Then, he could not stop his heart from aching over how badly he treated the roses, and he would pull them back out just to straighten them. They never did anything to Phainon. Not at all.

It felt like Phainon was in high school, exchanging notes with someone else. Except it was all one-sided because Phainon didn't send *him* a single note in return. Yet, a new yellow rose, a new pastry, and a new note never failed to appear upon his desk the next day, despite his doing nothing at all. He had found himself, every workday, looking forward to what would be written on the next note. And the next note. And the next note. He cursed himself in his head not to cave so easily, but his heart and his head all yearned for the other man and *his* little gifts that he and his life were already so accustomed to.

The notes weren't always about him. The next week, the notes would be about Phainon. He had even found himself cracking a smile at some of the notes, only to quickly wipe his expression from his face before anyone had caught him, and before he had caught himself.

That night that you were drunk, you told me you had blonde hair in college. You were pulling at my hair that night you were drunk. I wanted to smack you so badly. Your breath smelled like alcohol.

You said you had a dog, and you moved to the city when you were young. You said there was more to do here.

Why do you have a motorcycle license? You tried to steal someone's motorcycle to drive me home.

I'm glad you enjoyed the honeycakes I made you that morning. You said you wanted to try my baking. I hope I cleaned your apartment well. I had to leave early that morning to get a change of clothes.

I'm sorry I slept in your bed with you that night. I couldn't get out of your grip. Maybe I didn't want to either.

They were all the things that happened while Phainon was drunk. The first note that second week had caught him off guard. They were no longer about the other man, but about *Phainon* instead. The second note that week had put him on edge. Then the next note… didn't concern *that* day at all.

He didn't know how to feel that week, opening every letter and seeing that he hadn't told him a single thing about his hometown. Not even a detail about his hometown. The only slight mention was his childhood dog, who he didn't even name while drunk. Phainon hadn't revealed a single thing. Not even a single thing.

He thought to himself, surely *he* was saving it all for the third week. Surely, *he* was only building up for Phainon's demise. He couldn't let his guard down because it was going to come. And *he* was going to destroy Phainon from the inside and out after lavishing him with flowers and gifts. After making him feel important. After making him feel *special*.

But the third week came, and it wasn't about that at all. No, Phainon didn't want to put into words how he felt during the third week. He would've lost himself.

My father didn't like that I was gay, and I was raised in that way. I was mad that you forgot about that night you were drunk, but I was more frustrated at myself for being so deeply infatuated with you.

I'm sorry I couldn't tell you anything from that night. A part of me was jealous you could forget. I was haunted by dreams of you, following that night. I wished I could forget too.

My infatuation quickly became so much deeper the more you forced yourself into my life. I hated every second of it. I loved every second of it.

I cannot describe how happy you made me feel when you first tasted my baking. Every morning when I made the croissant afterwards, I always thought of you. I couldn't stop myself from naming your favorite pastry from my store after that little chimera.

Fig Stew was made after me, and I couldn't stop myself from seeing Vigethos in you. Both as a hero, but also as my beloved. Even before that drunken night. After learning more about you, you are still my Deliverer.

They were so… forward. So forward that Phainon had to escape to the stairwell during the fifth note that week and slammed the door shut to wait out his burning face, his stinging eyes, and his trembling body. He had slumped onto the dirty floor, with his face burning within his shaking hands, to try and forget that note. And the note before. And the note before. But it was futile. Phainon had memorized every single word. And every single stroke of the pen, where *he* applied more pressure at the beginning of the words, and how *his* writing would curve upwards at the end of every word. He could identify *his* handwriting from a mile away from how often he had stared at those notes.

He couldn't hear a single thing in this stairwell. His heartbeat had taken over every one of his senses. His chest hurt. His head hurt. He shut his eyes to block everything out, but it only made his urge so much worse.

Phainon wanted to see [redacted] *so badly.*

The moment Phainon read the most recent note, his body immediately pushed himself from his desk. He hadn't even the slightest clue where he planned to go, yet his body all called for one single man. And instead of running to *him,* Phainon ran to the stairwell, where he was sure no one else would be.

What was *he* playing at here? ~~To ridicule him? To mock him? To watch him from the sidelines, laughing from afar?~~

[redacted] ~~was making a fool out of him this entire time.~~ *He* loved Phainon. ~~He was watching from afar, just like Fig Stew, laughing at Phainon.~~ *He* loved Phainon. ~~Laughing at him for not knowing the truth, laughing at~~

~~Phainon for being a spectator in his own life.~~ *He* loved Phainon. [redacted] ~~was far from being in love.~~ *He* loved Phainon. ~~It was better to say that~~ [redacted] ~~had been ridiculing Phainon this entire time.~~ *He* loved Phainon. [redacted] ~~has had Phainon wrapped around his little finger since the very beginning, watching Phainon make a fool of himself for this week and a half.~~ *He* loved Phainon. ~~He kept bringing Phainon to his own bakery, feeding the cashiers information just to egg Phainon on.~~ *He* loved Phainon. [redacted] ~~was probably in the back the entire time, just snickering to himself.~~

[redacted] *loved Phainon.*

Phainon couldn't deny it anymore. His previous thoughts about the other man had shifted entirely. Three weeks of little notes all about themselves, tilting his entire world. He wasn't sure if his head could process and accept everything, yet here he was, slumped in this stairwell, with only thoughts of the other man.

He had never craved the color gold so deeply before. His eyes kept searching for that golden head of hair when he was supposed to be working. He desired so deeply to stare into those golden eyes when he was supposed to be staring at his computer. He wanted *him* to personally deliver the bouquet of yellow flowers to him. He didn't want the flowers to just show up on his desk anymore. Phainon wanted to be drenched in gold.

He had returned to his desk at some point. Phainon could barely feel his own body. Shaking, with heavy breaths, and with a throbbing heart, the mouse connected to his work computer was suddenly in the palm of his hand. He couldn't even recall a single workday of that third week. It was all a blur, with thoughts of gold, yearning for gold, and searching for gold. Every slight corner he turned, he wanted to see gold. With every slight movement around him, he hoped he would see gold. What was Phainon even thinking? What would he even do when he saw what he wanted? All thoughts of his told him to run, yet all thoughts of his told him to keep searching.

“Thank you for your time. I wish you the best in your next job.”

“Of course. Thank you, Phainon! It was lovely speaking with you.”

The end of the work week at the end of the day meant exit interviews for Phainon. He was almost done with the workday. Almost done before he could finally leave. He had just finished one, but he still had another before his work for the day would be officially over. The employee who had just resigned returned their work equipment, completed their exit interview, and had just departed from the meeting room that Phainon had booked so he could hold these interviews.

This smaller meeting room had one window, from floor to ceiling, that overlooked the executive department. Immediately standing up the moment the door was closed, he shut the blinds of the window until he could no longer see the other cubicles outside. His eyes kept drifting outward during the interview, and he grimaced every time he caught himself. Phainon was too close. This meeting room was too close. He should've booked a different meeting room. Why did he pick this one in the executive department?

Phainon shook his head before the obvious reason came to his head.

He sat himself back down in the office chair, staring at his computer and saving the document that housed the employee's interview answers before pulling up the next one. Phainon had a couple of minutes before the next individual would arrive, but he didn't know what else to do.

He needed to find something to do.

Blue eyes met the window's closed blinds, and he cursed to himself, tearing his gaze away. Swiping a clammy hand down his face, Phainon quickly pulled up the available meeting rooms, wondering if he should just email the next employee to meet him somewhere else. He wasn't sure how long he would last in this room. It was too close.

Just one more exit interview, and he could leave for the week. Then, he could be far, far away. Just like he wanted.

A knock sounded at the door, and his eyes darted to the clock on his laptop. The employee was still a little early, but it was no matter. Phainon wouldn't have wanted it any other way. He could leave this meeting room early and finally have peace within his head.

Pushing himself to his feet and wiping his sweaty hands along his slacks, he approached the meeting room door as calmly as he could. And with a hand running through his hair to further calm his appearance and a leisurely smile along his trembling lips, a confident hand opened the door.

“Phainon?”

His vision was flooded with gold. The gold he had been craving to see. The gold he didn't want to see.

Phainon swore his heart, which had been twisting in his chest all day, had finally stopped. Blue eyes widened upon the sea of gold that appeared before him as his breath hitched in his throat. His hands, which he had just wiped the sweat off of, were shaking once more, and his body had grown so rigid that Phainon didn't know if he wanted to run or if he wanted to stay rooted to this spot. There was only a single thought running through his mind as he stared at the sea of gold with widened eyes.

He said my name.

“I… Hey.” Phainon's faltering smile twitched upwards. His throat was constricting in on itself, and he swallowed dryly, resisting the urge to cough. It was so hard to breathe, let alone speak. “Did you need something?”

“I had a meeting in here earlier.” His smooth, unbothered voice echoed in Phainon's head, and he hung onto every single timbre and tone in his words. Phainon still couldn't believe he could finally hear *his* voice. “The COO forgot something here earlier and sent me to look. May I check?”

Phainon forced a nod, the most rigid nod he had ever had in his life, as he dragged his feet to allow the source of all of that overwhelming gold to step inside.

He was too close. He *was too close.* The slight breeze of *him* stepping inside brushed through Phainon's bangs. The sweet smell of sugar and bread wafted into his nose. His hand had instinctively raised, chasing after that sweet scent, and Phainon immediately rushed his hand back to his side before the other person noticed, clenching his fists so tightly that his knuckles were almost the same color as his own hair.

Please leave.

Phainon stood planted in that spot right next to the door. His clammy hand was still glued to the doorknob. His eyes kept darting between the floor and the man who was lingering at the conference table. *He* was taking too long. *He* was too close.

Please leave.

Phainon was begging, screaming in his head for the other person to leave. His heart wasn't going to take it anymore. It was rattling his ribcage, pounding so hard Phainon swore it would knock him off his feet. It drowned out all his other senses, with Phainon begging to keep his gaze glued to his feet. He was all too aware of the other man in the room. He should've booked the bigger meeting room. *He* was too close.

Please leave.

“It's not here.”

His thoughts immediately halted when the silence was broken. Phainon hadn't even realized there was silence between the two of them. The noise within his own head was already so loud.

He instinctively glanced upward at his voice, cursing himself inwardly for staring at the gold once more. The man had furrowed eyebrows as he stared at the conference table, with his arms crossed across his broad chest and his beautiful lips downturned into a frown.

The man was wearing a white dress shirt, rolled up to his elbows, that clung to his chest and his waist, a black tie that hit the edge of his waistband, and

tan slacks that hugged his thighs. Phainon's eyes darkened at the sight, with nails digging into the palms of his hands. He wished his fingertips were the tie instead. He craved for his hands to wrap around that slender waist, that broad chest, and those sculpted thighs. *He* really walked around the office like that? How many people did *he* talk to today? How many people saw *him* dressed like this? Phainon's heart ached at the thought.

“It wasn't a huge deal.” The man continued murmuring to himself. Phainon's ears could barely catch his words. He didn't want to miss a single note that spilled from this man's perfect lips.

“Was it important?” The words scratched his throat as Phainon tore his eyes away from the slacks that left little to the imagination. “I can help you look for it?” He wasn't sure what nonsense he was spouting. Phainon was sure his legs would give out if he let go of this doorknob.

The gorgeous man shook his head. “It was just a printout with notes on it. I took my own notes, so I can share them with the COO.”

The man's arms dropped to his side as he approached the door once more. Phainon's breath, which was beginning to return, immediately halted once more. He didn't want to catch even a whiff of the sweet sugar and freshly baked bread that clung to his scent. The man was finally leaving. Phainon would be able to breathe soon.

His body jolted when something warm wrapped around his fist, which was still tightly clenched at his side. With his eyes still glued to the floor and his body growing rigid at the sensation, his fist was shifted into his vision, with two warm hands and delicate fingertips prying his fingers apart.

“You're going to bleed.” The deep voice rang from in front of him. Gentle hands pried his trembling fingers apart, revealing the indents in the palm of his hand. “It's already leaving a mark.”

He was too close. He was too close. He was too close. Please leave. Please leave. Please leave.

“Are you scared of me?”

Phainon's shivering body immediately stilled at the sound of his deep voice once more, earning an amused scoff in front of him.

“So quick. Will you look at me?”

Phainon rigidly and slowly shook his head back and forth.

A silence followed. It really wasn't that silent at all. His pounding heartbeat echoed in the entire meeting room. He was positive the other man could hear it too.

The doorknob slipped from Phainon's other hand. His fingernails sank into his skin but were quickly pulled away, with fingers interlocking with his. Warmth shot up his arm, enveloping him comfortingly as his hands were cradled by others. The door to the meeting room had locked closed right beside him, with the sound repeating in his brain. It sounded too loud in Phainon's head, as if emphasizing that he was now trapped in this meeting room. As if emphasizing the warmth surging through his arms from these hands holding onto his.

“Phainon.”

He couldn't stop his body from jumping at his words. At his name running along the other man's tongue. At his name spilling from his beautiful lips. Being spoken in that deep, sultry, and perfect voice.

“Did you read my notes?”

Phainon inwardly scoffed. Did he? *Did he?* Did he memorize every word? Did he memorize every stroke of the pen, every smear, every point, and every curve? Did he imagine this man saying each and every word to his face in *his* deep voice? Did he remember every slight dent in the card and every fold? *Did he?*

Instead, he stayed silent, with his gaze trained on the leather shoes standing in front of him.

“What did you think of them?”

A step echoed in the room. Phainon instinctively stepped back as the space between them closed, but the man in front of him was relentless. He tugged on his hands that were locked with his, and Phainon was almost pulled into the embrace of the other man. Warm breath tickled his lips as their noses brushed against each other, and a pounding heartbeat reverberated in his chest. His head ached. He could barely feel his body over how hard his blood was pumping and how much his chest was gasping for air. That sweet scent of sugar and bread filled his senses once again, and it only made Phainon's breath quicken and his heartbeat increase even more.

“Phainon.”

Please stop saying my name.

A cold breeze ghosted his hands when they were released from their heated prison, but before Phainon could run out the door, two strong hands stroked his jawline before settling around to cradle his cheeks. Hands clawed at the wrists belonging to his prison, but the man in front of him never relented.

“You're shaking again.”

Was he? Phainon couldn't feel his body anymore. He was no longer in control; he could barely even think. All five of his senses focused on the scent of sugar and bread, and his brain couldn't process anything else except for the two warm hands around his face.

“Please…” Phainon swallowed thickly, refusing to move his gaze away from his leather shoes. His hands were still tightly wrapped around the other man's wrists, tugging weakly at his hands. He couldn't conjure any more strength than this in his arms. “Let me go.”

The person in front of him scoffed once more. “I will. If you tell me while looking at me.”

Phainon scowled, but his eyes never left the floor as they darted back and forth in search of a different answer. Anything to get this man away from him. “I have an exit interview to do.”

“They're not here.”

“They'll be arriving soon.”

“Then, I'll keep you company until they arrive.”

Silence followed the last statement, with Phainon unable to think of another excuse, and a deep chuckle filled his ears.

“Does that mean I can stay?”

“No.”

A quiet laugh resounded in the room, and those two hands that had been holding onto his face tugged upwards. Caught off guard, Phainon's eyes widened as his head was jerked upward, and the color gold flooded his vision before he could pull himself back. He froze momentarily, sinking deeply into those golden eyes that seemed to hypnotize him in place. They seemed to stare right into his soul, as if they could see everything that Phainon was feeling and everything that he was thinking until he could no longer hide anymore.

Pulling back as far as he could, Phainon roughly shoved against the man's shoulder, pushing and pulling against him, but the man didn't budge at all despite Phainon's attempts. It only made him hold Phainon tighter, and his breath caught in his throat at the fingertips that dug into his skin, halting his rough movements. He was face-to-face with gold, and he couldn't tear his eyes away. He was frozen in place once again, mesmerized by that tantalizing color.

“Phainon.”

“Stop,” Phainon whispered. He inwardly cursed at the pleading tone in his voice, but it had escaped from his throat before he could stop himself. “Stop saying my name.”

The man smiled beautifully, tilting his head to the side. “You prefer I call you ‘Deliverer’ again?”

A laugh slipped from Phainon's lips, and he immediately shut his mouth. When did Phainon start feeling so carefree? So relaxed that he could even utter a laugh?

The man's smile grew at his reaction, and a thumb gently swiped along Phainon's bottom lip. His eyes widened, his lips tingling at the sensation, and a deep shiver rushed down his body.

“I'm sorry, Phainon,” the man muttered, caressing Phainon's lips with soft touches. Each touch sent goosebumps running along Phainon's arms. Each touch sent his heart ringing in his ears. And each touch made Phainon's vision blur until he could barely see the gold standing right in front of his eyes.

“What are you apologizing for?” Phainon’s voice cracked, and his face burned at his own faint voice. He couldn't believe he had said those words, that the breaking voice had come from him. He was fighting the tears that were gathering in the corner of his eyes, threatening to spill down his cheeks. He grasped at the wrists again that still held him in place, trying to shake him off, but the man refused to let go. “You didn't do anything. It's just me. I'm just…”

Useless and incompetent. But the words died in Phainon's throat.

“Will you meet me at the bakery today?” The man’s face inched closer, brushing the tips of their noses together once more, and Phainon cursed inwardly at how his eyes flickered between *his* golden eyes and *his* shimmering lips. “I want to tell you everything this time.”

“Every… thing?” His body violently shook at his words. He tugged desperately, clawing at the wrists holding him, but again, they never budged.

“Everything about me. Everything about my parents. Everything about… that book.” The man furrowed his eyebrows at the mention of the book that Phainon still had sitting in a drawer at home. He could never bring himself to throw it away. “Then maybe… if you'd like… I will leave you alone from then on. I only hope that you will hear me out first.”

Alone? He was going to leave me alone? He was going to leave me?

A gentle thumb swiped along his cheeks, quickly catching the tears that had finally spilled from his eyes. Phainon wanted to rip himself away from the gold that was just watching him, leering at him, and staring at him as he made a complete fool out of himself. As the salty taste lingered upon his lips as his vision continued to blur, Phainon hated that the other man could see everything he was trying so desperately to hide. He wanted to run away, wipe this man's memory of him, and pretend as if they had never known each other. This man in front of him deserved so much better than what Phainon had done to him. He deserved… so much better than him.

He faintly registered a deep voice speaking in front of him, but he could barely hear him over his throbbing head. Phainon couldn't see what expression the other man held on his face. He couldn't see him. He couldn't smell his sweet scent anymore. Only the feeling of his warmth surging from his hands washed over Phainon's face as he swiped at the tears that were still spilling down. Surely… Surely this man was still ridiculing him now that Phainon could barely register the man in front of him. Surely… *he* never meant to come back to Phainon.

He still wasn't sure what the other man had said to him. His brain could never process what was spoken to him, even after something soft had pressed against his lips, silencing the rest of Phainon's cries.

His breaths instantly stilled. His heartbeat slowed. His brain faltered. His shoulders dropped. His hands tightened around the wrists of those hands keeping him still. His lips quivered against the soft ones pressing against him. Phainon couldn't register anything except for the tender lips that were connected to his. Not even the golden head of hair that was leaning toward him.

It was a soft, gentle touch. His lips barely ghosted against his. But it felt like it held so much more. Phainon could feel hesitation, passion, longing, and sorrow, all in a simple touch. A simple press of *his* lips felt as if *he* were sharing everything that *he* was feeling and everything that *he* was thinking with Phainon. For once in Phainon's life, Phainon could finally understand what the other man was thinking. There was no doubt in his

mind that the man in front of him only held thoughts of Phainon. And, similarly, Phainon only held thoughts of *him*.

The sound of their lips echoed in the room as their lips parted. They made Phainon's face flush with embarrassment and shame. It was too short. He felt… so good. He couldn't deny his body of the pleasure that had washed his entire being or the electricity that had coursed through his veins. And after finally meeting that golden gaze, it somehow left Phainon craving more of this cursed color that used to haunt him in his sleep.

“My… dei?” The name finally left his lips. The name that he had been trying so hard to erase from his memories and to block from his mind. A shaky breath barely spoke that name that Phainon had been trying so hard to forget. But he had to make sure. He had to be sure this man was the one his entire body and brain had been searching for all these weeks.

A gentle, gorgeous smile upon lovely lips flooded Phainon's vision. “I'm here, Phainon.” A low whisper and hot breath brushed against Phainon's lips, and it took everything in Phainon's body not to shove himself back into the warm embrace that had just taken all of his senses away before. He wanted to forget who he was. He wanted to forget where he was. All he wanted was to think of this man and to feel this man against him. All he wanted was to see his golden eyes and his golden hair.

Phainon smiled. Phainon laughed. His eyes crinkled up, with drying tears shimmering under the office lights as shaky, breathy laughs left his lungs. It felt like Phainon had been awoken from a bad dream. A terrible, haunting nightmare full of gold. Yet instead of being pulled from that nightmare, it had, instead, turned into a dream. Nothing changed. Nothing changed at all. Phainon was still surrounded by gold. His hometown was still gone. His family, his friends, and his teacher were still gone. But why did Phainon feel so safe, staring into these golden eyes? Why did it feel like this color, which had been haunting him for decades, was starting to feel comforting?

Phainon couldn't wait for the day to be over. He wanted to go to the bakery. With Mydei.

Chapter End Notes

"But I would rather you let me stay. I want to stay with you, Phainon, if you'll let me."

▶ **Mydei's "Operation Annoy Phainon" File**

Chapter 13

It was awkward sitting in Mydei's luxurious leather car with him, and it was awkward not knowing what to say. Phainon's body was instinctively cowering against the passenger side door, as far away from the driver as possible, but he couldn't help it. This man had basically watched him make a fool of himself, cry all over himself while at work, and he still wanted to take him to his precious bakery that his mother had opened before she passed away. It almost felt like Phainon didn't belong there, that he shouldn't have climbed into this extremely expensive car with him, but he couldn't stop himself from chasing after Mydei and the gold that followed with him. Phainon also found it difficult to ever reject this man again.

The car ride was completely silent, save for the dull rumbling of the powerful engine. Phainon was trying to rack his brain to think of something to break this awkward silence, but every time he simply parted his lips, he would be reminded of the salty taste that lingered on his tongue back in the meeting room, when he had shed tears all over himself and made Mydei clean him up. And every time, Phainon had to bite back whatever he wanted to say. He wanted Mydei to forget that he was even in his car.

Surely, Mydei could explain himself on a different day? When he had forgotten how pathetic Phainon was? Phainon was sure he didn't look good at all while sobbing his eyes out at work, and he didn't want Mydei to remember that moment at all. It was also extremely awkward trying to do his last exit interview of the day, and he hoped that the employee didn't remember either. He couldn't forget that employee's face upon walking into Phainon and Mydei in the meeting room.

The gear shift jolted Phainon out of his thoughts, and he whipped his head around to see that they had already arrived at the small parking lot next to the bakery. Mydei was already leaving his car, with Phainon scrambling after him. It felt like a long time since he heard that chime of the bell above him as the bakery door was pushed open.

“Welc–Mydei!” It was the first cashier that Phainon had become familiar with, which made sense considering her schedule. She stared at Phainon with a smile and a slight nod, which Phainon quickly returned.

Mydei only nodded in her direction and grabbed Phainon's hand while he was busy glancing around the bakery, tugging him into the back where the kitchen was located. Stumbling in his steps, Phainon tore his gaze from the croissant and golden honeycakes to face Mydei’s back and their clasped hands as he was pulled into the back, with the curtains parting for their entrance.

He didn't get to admire their intertwined hands for long, and Phainon couldn't help feeling slightly disappointed when Mydei's fingers left his. Holding back a sigh, he turned his gaze to the new scenery around him, one that had been here the entire time, yet Phainon had never laid eyes on it before.

It was a quaint little kitchen, but it had everything a bakery would need. Plenty of counter space, an island in the center of the kitchen that took up most of the walking space, and plenty of storage, pantries, a refrigerator, and multiple ovens. The wooden counters were quite worn down from how much they had been used, but it was still quite a tidy workspace. Phainon had to resist the urge to smile, imagining Mydei kneading dough on this very island every morning.

“I only work in the mornings.” Mydei had pulled out two barstools for them to sit on, and Phainon quickly thanked him before settling down. “There is another baker who works during the day, but I already let them know I would be closing for today. When I can't come in the mornings, they cover for me.”

“Has there ever been a morning you couldn't come in?” Phainon's voice was still faint and timid, and as much as he didn’t like hearing how weak his voice sounded, it was just something he had to accept. It would take him a long time before he was back to acting like his normal self around this man, who had seen every side there was to see of Phainon–even the sides that Phainon wanted to keep hidden forever.

Mydei's face flushed red, and he cleared his throat, averting his gaze down to the white oak island. “The… night you were drunk, I suppose.”

Phainon coughed, with his own face turning red. He didn't really give much thought to it, but Mydei was definitely slumbering away at Phainon's apartment when he was supposed to be working at the bakery. “I'm… I'm sorry.”

“No need.” A quiet laugh came from the golden-haired man. “I had… a wonderful sleep that night.”

One of Mydei's notes flashed through Phainon's mind, the one where he had apologized for sleeping the night over in Phainon's bed. It was something Mydei didn't need to apologize for at all. That was one of Phainon's initial thoughts when he first picked up that note from his desk.

“Isn't it tiring?” Phainon was still taking in the sights of the small kitchen, at the counters that had been wiped clean of flour and at the cooking utensils that were still sitting in the drying rack. “Working two jobs, waking up early in the morning to prepare everything for the store, only to go directly to your next job. How long… have you lived like this?”

Mydei was silent. He was also taking in the sights of the humble kitchen. It was a sight that was all too familiar to the other man. A sight that he had lived with for years.

“My mother loved baking.” Mydei's fingertips gently traced the wooden grain of the island, as if almost cherishing the little shop. “My father made more money as the CEO of Kremnos Corporation. When they divorced over a difference in the direction of the company, my mother said she didn't need money as long as she was able to keep me.”

Over a difference in the direction of the company… Phainon faintly remembered their divorce had occurred around the same time the company shifted its focus to the military.

“The court made my father give my mother some money anyway, and my father agreed and left me with her. My mother originally worked with my

father in Kremnos Corporation, but after their divorce, she left and opened a bakery with some of the money she gained from the divorce."

My father left me with my mother when they divorced. He didn't want me. The note flashed through Phainon's mind. Truly, he had memorized every single note that Mydei had passed to him.

"Is it because…" Phainon remembered the other note Mydei had given him during the third week of notes, flowers, and pastries.

Mydei nodded, his eyes still following the wooden grain of the counters. "My father didn't like that I was gay. I have known since I was very young. It was one thing that they fought about too, which is why he was more than glad to have me off his hands. I had originally thought… that there was something wrong with me. My father treated me quite well until my parents realized my sexuality."

Phainon stayed silent. He had never thought about his own sexuality very much. He always held the belief to love whoever you wanted to love, that there were no boundaries to love as long as the two involved truly loved each other, and that it was completely consensual. Maybe that was his inner Cyrene talking, as she was always spouting about romance, but he had never really thought about romance as much as he did until now. Romance was something Phainon thought he never had time for, and something he thought he never deserved.

"There was a period of time that I was very… quiet after the divorce. I wouldn't say I'm very talkative now, but my mother knew there was something wrong. She thought that maybe I blamed myself for the divorce. In fact, I never really thought much of it at all. Since I didn't get along with my father anymore, it didn't come as a surprise to me when he left. But my mother was intent on raising my spirits. She taught me how to bake in this bakery, as a way to take my mind off of everything, since baking is quite a process. But it wasn't enough for her, and she tried to search for more direct media. But there wasn't much media, especially for children, that involved gay people. She didn't want my father to trace the story back to her, so she paid someone else to make a story instead."

“*The Cycles of Vigethos*,” Phainon murmured.

“*The Cycles of Vigethos*,” Mydei repeated solemnly. “It was my entire world. She didn't want me to be the main character, mostly because she thought it would be too obvious if I were. But that book… My younger self, who had trouble expressing himself after he realized he wasn't supposed to be gay, used that book as a guideline for how to act. How to interact with others, how to act in public, everything. My younger self thought that was how I was supposed to live. Fig Stew acted in that manner, had friends, had a lover, and went on adventures. I thought that was how it was supposed to be, and it… carries until now. I'm sorry.”

Phainon shook his head. There was nothing Mydei had to apologize for. He was perfect in Phainon's mind.

“Kremnos Corporation became big. *Too* big. My father didn't realize how huge his success would be by shifting the company's goals and focus to the military. And he was greedy. He didn't want it to end with him. So, he took me back.”

“I was confused about that,” Phainon muttered, his eyes trying to search for the answers along Mydei’s serious expression. “How could he just… take you back? Didn't the court give custody to your mother?”

“My mother shortly died in a car crash.” There was absolutely nothing in Mydei's tone of voice. Not an ounce of emotion. “How convenient it was for my father to regain custody of me.”

Phainon swore his heart had completely stopped at the implications. His eyes widened at Mydei, whose gaze had finally raised from the counter to stare back at Phainon. “He… That's…”

“He erased all traces of my mother." A dry chuckle left Mydei’s throat. “He wanted me to focus on the company, and he wanted to erase every little trace that his son was gay. He found that book when he was packing my things after my mother’s death. So he shut down everything about that book, paid the publisher to stop printing more copies, and paid libraries and bookstores to buy the rest of their stock so he could burn them. He doesn't

know about this bakery, but if he did, I'm sure he would take it down too. And I… keep this bakery going. Out of spite for my father, and out of memory for my mother."

"Do I like what I do," and "do I like being the CEO's son," are two very different questions.

I've never thought about whether I liked my job or not.

A conversation from what felt like a long time ago emerged in Phainon's mind. It made sense now why Mydei had said that to him, and why he had asked Phainon to come to the bakery with him when he was about to ask the second question.

"I love baking." Mydei returned to Phainon's original question. "But the reasons why I keep this bakery going are complicated. I apologize for such a long-winded answer."

Phainon shook his head once more. It was simple after hearing everything. Phainon was envious. He couldn't stop these dark emotions from swirling in his heart over hearing Mydei's story. Here he was, making a mess of himself, crying all over himself, for what happened to him in the past. Pitying himself and locking himself away for a week at just the mere thought of his hometown. Yet Mydei was still standing strong and proud, as if nothing could stop him.

"You are… so much stronger than I am." A dry laugh left Phainon's body, with a wry smile hanging from his lips. Mydei's story kept repeating in Phainon's mind. "After everything that happened to you… You're still–"

"It's not too late for me to fight back," Mydei sharply cut him off. His golden eyes stared resolutely into Phainon's, and whatever he was about to say dwindled away in his throat. "For me, my father is still here, and he still hasn't won yet. And I plan to keep it that way."

"Keep it… that way?" Those words swirled in Phainon's head. Not too late to fight back? What was Mydei thinking? Fight back against his own father?

“Do you know the COO?”

Eyebrows raised in response, Phainon frowned. “Of course I do.” It was Phainon's entire job as the HR Specialist to know who worked at the company. “I only know of him. Krateros, right?”

A nod came from the golden-haired man. “There is something that my father wants. Something that he has been gathering the funds for ever since he took me back. I plan to take it from him and destroy it before his very eyes. Krateros and I have been working together on this for years.”

“Something that the CEO wants that badly?” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows at this new information. “Something that even the COO doesn't agree with?” He had no idea the CEO's son and the COO had been conspiring together for years against the CEO. This would be huge news if anyone in the company found out.

“You're familiar with it, but at the same time, you're not.” Mydei sharply inhaled, with his gaze flickering between the bakery around them and Phainon's eyes. “There is something called the Black Tide. It is undetectable. It causes hallucinations and death. The ultimate war machine.”

“For someone so keen on the military, I'm sure owning that would make Kremnos Corporation skyrocket,” Phainon remarked.

Mydei nodded once more with another deep breath. “It… was tested on a remote village. Without their knowledge. Everyone in that village hallucinated, killed each other, and died. Until there was no one left.”

A silence passed between the two men as the information settled in the air. It felt as if Phainon’s entire world had stopped. He stared at Mydei blankly, with a frozen heart, frozen breaths, and a limp body that he had no control over. Not a single thought passed through Phainon's mind as he sat there, completely still on the stool, staring at gold.

“Phainon–”

It was as if hearing his own name released a dam. His eyes widened at nothing. Phainon sharply grimaced, lurching over and throwing his hands over his mouth. It felt like he was going to throw up. The images of all those bodies he saw that day quickly flashed through his mind. Each and every corpse that he recognized all mutilated on the floor of his own hometown. He remembered all the blood in the fields, all the limbs scattered throughout the village. *Epidemic?* Don't make Phainon laugh. How could he believe it was some “epidemic” that had “unfortunately” swept through *just* his hometown? How stupid was he?

He struggled to hold his own bile back, his throat burning in acid as he gasped for desperate breaths and his eyes watering with tears. His shoulders were tense and shaking as he retched in his own hands with not a single thing coming out of his mouth. Phainon faintly heard someone calling his name, but he could barely hear it over his sporadic heartbeat as his body hovered over the wooden island, barely holding his own self back from slamming his head into the counter to get rid of the flashing memories and the piles of bodies that continually repeated in his brain.

His hands were forcefully peeled away from his own mouth, and he was turned in his chair into the warm embrace of someone in the room. Strong arms wrapped around his trembling body, holding him so tightly that he could barely even breathe and his body could barely even tremble. The embrace was so strong that his desperate gasps finally stilled, and his body went slack in the arms of the other man.

“Did you… know?” Phainon swallowed dryly, trying to moisten his burning throat.

“I only found out recently,” Mydei muttered. His arms never left Phainon's body, and his comforting body heat slowly brought Phainon back to reality. “I never knew… The scientific papers never named the hometown.”

Another dry, humorless laugh shook Phainon's body, and the arms around him only tightened. “Great. My entire hometown was just a government experiment?”

“Phainon–”

“*Destroy* your father, Mydei.” The words seethed out of Phainon's clenched teeth. It felt like his head was going to explode at the mere thought of the CEO of the company he worked for. He couldn't believe the CEO was trying to get his hands on something so wretched. “Better yet, let me in on it too.”

Mydei chuckled, and a gentle hand ran through the back of Phainon's hair. “I am prepared to do everything it takes to take him down.”

Another silence settled between them. Phainon had shut his eyes to revel in the other man's warmth that was wrapped around him, with golden hair lightly brushing against his face. It was quiet in the bakery, and it was exactly what Phainon needed right now. Peace and quiet. While in the strong arms of his gentle, beautiful man.

“How much do you know… about me? About my hometown?” Phainon broke the silence. It seemed that Mydei knew the connection between the Black Tide and that little village he lived in. As much as he didn't want to hear what else Mydei knew, Phainon knew it would have to be something he had to hear sooner or later, and he would rather hear it while in the comforting hold of someone he really, truly cared about.

“I know that your hometown, Aedes Elysiae, was destroyed as a result of the Black Tide. I do not know anything else besides what the internet could tell me.”

Phainon waited with bated breath for a few moments until he realized that Mydei was actually done speaking. “Nothing else?”

“I know you had a dog. Because you told me when you were drunk.”

A small smile cracked upon Phainon's lips as the breath he was holding left his body. It felt as if all the pressure building up in his body suddenly dispersed into thin air, and he felt his body relaxing back into Mydei's arms and the warmth that radiated off his strong body. “His name was Snowy.”

A deep laugh rumbled against Phainon’s chest. “What a fitting name.”

“You don't even know what Snowy looked like.”

“I could only imagine.” Something soft and warm pressed tenderly to his temple, and Phainon's face instantly heated up as the grip around him loosened. Mydei pulled back, finally locking eyes with Phainon.

Phainon was still trying to wrap his head around the gentle kiss against him that was too short, and he cleared his throat in an attempt to cool his face. “I didn't realize… the COO hated the CEO too.” He lightly laughed at the thought, switching topics. One day, Phainon wanted to tell this man all about his childhood. One day, they'll exchange stories from their younger days. But right now, Phainon’s head was still swirling from all this new information from today. “How ironic.”

Mydei nodded in agreement. “It was many, many years ago that I realized a way to destroy my own father. And it was Krateros who realized what I wanted to do and decided to join me. He has been holding resentment against my father for what he did to my mother.”

“How are you taking him down? If you don't mind me asking.”

“I would tell you anything, Phainon.” Gorgeous lips turned up into a soft, beautiful smile that made Phainon's heart melt at the sight. Light fingertips grazed his silver hair, and Phainon had to stop his eyes from fluttering shut at the pleasure that rushed down his spine. “I plan to take over this company, gain the rights to the Black Tide, and order its own destruction.”

“Order its own destruction…” Phainon murmured. The bangs were gently swept from his eyes as Phainon furrowed his eyebrows at the thought. “That… may certainly work. I can't imagine your father would be happy.”

“Isn't that the point?” Mydei scoffed with a confident smile. He was still playing with Phainon's hair. “I plan to turn this company back to what it used to be when it was first founded. Away from the military and into improving the technology of government-funded facilities. And the first step of that would be to gain the rights to the Black Tide and destroy it.”

“I'm… surprised you're not just taking the company down entirely.” Phainon would've imagined that to be a more straightforward approach.

“That thought did come to me.” The hand buried within Phainon's hair stilled. “But that would mean more than a thousand employees losing their jobs, including you. I couldn't do that to my staff–staff who weren't involved at all. So, I thought of a different approach; tearing something down that my father has been working toward for decades.”

Phainon still couldn't help his envy at this confident, resolute man in front of him. Mydei still had the bakery, this children's storybook, and his own baking skills from his mother. His father was still here, and Mydei could rightfully exact his revenge against the man who had caused him such agony. Phainon was left with nothing. Not a single thing was left from his hometown other than the searing memories of bloody fields and mutilated corpses. He almost wished he knew the face of the scientist who created the Black Tide, but considering it seemed to be a heavily guarded government secret, that scientist had probably destroyed all traces of any connection of themself to their own experiment long ago.

Hands gently cradled his cheeks, pulling him from his thoughts as his gaze flickered to the golden eyes already staring at him.

“After this bakery closes for the day.” Mydei inhaled deeply. He was slightly frowning, with furrowed eyebrows, and Phainon wasn't sure if he was imagining the slightly red tint that splashed across his face. “Can I come over?”

Another silence passed between them, and Phainon swore his brain short-circuited. His eyes widened. His heart stopped. And his hands immediately started sweating at the thought of Mydei in his apartment. It wasn't exactly the first time, but it would be the first time that Phainon could remember it. And Phainon couldn't imagine how he would react to actually seeing Mydei in his apartment.

He hesitantly parted his lips, trying with much difficulty not to let his eyes stray away from the nervous golden ones that were staring almost expectantly at him, and he swallowed dryly while pushing the thought of

Mydei standing in his apartment out of his head before his heart truly stopped. “When does this bakery close?”

Golden eyes quickly flickered to the wall behind Phainon, where he assumed a clock was hung. “In a few minutes. But I need to clean up all the extra pastries that haven't sold for the day. Do you want to take any home?”

Take Mydei's pastries home? What kind of question was that?

It was the most confident Phainon had felt all day. “I will eat every single pastry that is left over in this store.”

“That's really not necessary.”

“How could I waste your baking?!”

“It doesn't go to waste.” Mydei lightly laughed at Phainon's reaction. “I donate whatever doesn't sell.”

A memory of Mydei's completely overflowing tray briefly flashed through Phainon's mind. It was the first time he had ever visited this shop. “That first time you brought me here… You didn't actually eat those pastries?”

Another laugh escaped Mydei's lips, and Phainon couldn't stop the thought from coming to his mind: Mydei was extremely breathtaking whenever he smiled. “You actually thought I ate all of those.”

“I thought you really liked pastries!”

“I do.” Mydei's hands slowly slid away from Phainon's face, and he had to resist the urge not to lunge for his warmth once more. An amused smile grew upon Mydei's lips as he pushed himself to his feet, stacking his stool in a corner of the kitchen. “And don't stare at me like that.”

“Like what?”

“You're pouting.”

“I'm not…” Phainon quickly brought a hand to cover the lower half of his already burning face, and Mydei laughed at the reaction.

“Do you want to help me pack some of the leftover pastries?”

With a grin, Phainon leaped from his stool, stacking it neatly on top of the other as he prepared to help Mydei close up the bakery for the day. Not without picking which pastries Phainon wanted to bring home first. And of course, Phainon picked the croissant first–the same butter croissant that was named *Vigethos*.

Chapter 14

“Phainon.”

Mydei's car had stopped in the dim, underground parking structure connected to Phainon's apartment building. They had just returned from multiple nearby shelters to donate the leftover pastries, and when Mydei would usually waste no time in hopping out of the car the moment they were stopped, this time, he stayed seated in his chair. The fact that his car doors were still locked, and the fact that he lingered in the driver's seat, made Phainon nervous.

Blue eyes hesitantly raised from the gear shift that was just placed into park, watching the perfect hand of the driver release his grip from it. The serious expression that crossed Mydei’s face also made Phainon nervous, and he had to stop himself from fidgeting in his seat. The way his golden eyes bore straight through Phainon's head almost made it look like he could read every little thought that Phainon held. It made him feel small, and he had to resist every urge to cower against the passenger side door again, just as he did earlier on the way to the bakery.

The man took a deep breath, turning his upper body to face Phainon's as much as he could. His golden eyes flickered all over Phainon's guarded expression, who didn't know what to expect. “Before I go into your apartment, I want to tell you something.”

Phainon swallowed thickly. His heart was twisting in his chest at the sudden shift in the air, and he buried the desire to swipe his sweaty palms along his pants as he hesitantly opened his mouth. “Tell me something?”

“That day in Aedes Elysiae is not your fault.”

It was the last thing Phainon was expecting to hear, and his body grew rigid at the mention of his hometown. His breath caught in his throat, and his heart froze as he stared at Mydei with wide eyes. Phainon tried to overcome

the shock of the conversation, forcing a dry laugh out of his lips that did nothing to convince the other man. “Where is that coming from?”

Mydei didn't seem the least amused at the wry smile adorning Phainon's lips, and his golden eyes became downcast at the sight. “I know enough about you to know that you think about your hometown every day. And I know enough about you to know why you think about it every day.”

Phainon couldn't help but swallow once more, tearing his eyes away from the gold that could read his very mind and setting his gaze upon the dashboard instead. “It was a long time ago. I… went to explore in the forest. With Cyrene. I don't know if you know, but she was my best friend there too.”

He didn't like the silence that followed his words. It made Phainon want to fill the air between them, but he also didn't want to talk about this anymore. But in front of this man and his golden eyes, he couldn't shut his own mouth even though he wanted to. So he slowly parted his lips once more, sharing the memories that he wished he could keep buried forever.

“It was rare to get visitors, since it was such a remote village in the middle of nowhere. So when I saw we actually had a visitor while Cyrene and I were about to go venture into the forest, I…” A small, empty laugh left Phainon's lungs, flashing a pitiful smile at the other man. “I was the one who led him in. With such excitement too.”

“You didn't know what he was there for.” Mydei's immediate and unwavering voice shook Phainon’s core. It bothered him how self-assured Mydei could sound. It was the exact opposite of Phainon. “You couldn't have known at all, and you didn't do anything wrong.”

“I just wish I could turn back time and warn myself.” Phainon's vision was blurring again as his eyes dropped to his lap. He hated it. “I wish…” Another small, humorless laugh filled the air. “I don't know what I would wish for. Any sort of wish I can think of is naive.”

“There is nothing naive about wanting to save the people you love.” Gentle fingertips swiped the shimmering tears that gathered in the corners of

Phainon's eyes. “There is nothing naive about having regrets, and there is nothing naive about cherishing the people you love. That's just human nature. It's normal, Phainon.”

“Then, why are you so different from me?” Phainon's words could barely leave his quivering lips. His voice was weak, just like he was. “Why are you so much more… so much stronger than me? You've accomplished so much more than I have. You–”

“What makes you think we are so different?” His warm hand had settled along Phainon's cheek, and he hated how easily the warmth seeped into his heart. “Do you think I continue to cling to this bakery that I don't need because I want to? Waking up at two in the morning every day to run a bakery despite already having a self-sufficient job? Do you think I try to forget about that children's book, yet follow every word and action of that little orange chimera, because I have no regrets?”

“Forget?” Phainon's eyes widened in confusion at the other man, and Mydei took the opportunity to cup his other hand around Phainon's cheek, rooting his gaze in place.

“Did you think I pushed you away and tried to forget about that night because I wanted to?” Mydei’s thumbs swiped along Phainon's eyes, brushing through his trembling eyelashes. His body shook underneath Mydei's firm and steadfast gaze, and it only made Mydei tighten his hold on Phainon's face. “I was raised this way–raised to hate my own self. So I followed this children's book as if it were an exact guide of how a gay man should act in his life, and all it did was push the one person I cared about away.

“So what do I do instead? Take revenge by doing the exact opposite. The past has already happened, and what matters now is what you do now. So why let the past control what you do right now, in this very moment?”

Isn't the greatest revenge against Death to live to the fullest?

Phainon cannot have revenge. That scientist who created the Black Tide has already disappeared. That would be a fact for the rest of Phainon's life. He

laughed at Cyrene's words that echoed in his mind. That children's book that they went to find, which was supposed to be completely wiped from existence, had somehow turned Phainon’s world entirely upside down. How much did she already know to say that to him all those weeks ago?

It was overwhelming to hear that someone Phainon had been constantly comparing himself to all this time was exactly the same as him. Mydei always seemed so… perfect–as if he knew exactly what to do, what to say, and how to act. He could've never guessed that Mydei pushing him away ever since he had first met the other man was a result of his upbringing, that it was how Mydei truly believed he should act around the people he cared about. All because of a children's book, which he revolved his entire world around. All because of his mother, who wished for nothing but the best for him after what his father had done to them.

The only difference between them was how Mydei was handling his own situation, how he was grasping his own life by the reins and controlling his own life. Mydei wasn't a bystander in his own life. Mydei wasn't a spectator in his own life. Something that Phainon thought he always was in his life. Phainon had always believed… he could never control his own life. That he would have to stand on the sidelines and watch forever.

Golden eyes narrowed at the sudden laugh that rattled Phainon's chest, but the rest of it died in Phainon's throat as he took a deep, long breath. Phainon… would just have to take the reins into his own hands. Just like how this man beside him was doing. “It's going to take me a long time, Mydei. A long time to exact my revenge in this way.”

Mydei scoffed, with his perfect lips turning upward into the sweetest smile Phainon had ever laid eyes on. “Whatever it takes, Phainon. Don't you want to win?”

Phainon returned the scoff. Shoulders that he didn't even know were tense finally dropped, until his body was leaning in search of Mydei's radiating warmth once more. “Of course I want to win.”

A laugh left those gorgeous lips in front of him, and Mydei’s two hands released Phainon's face, much to his dismay. “I hope to see you come out

victorious in the end. To a new dawn under a golden sun you will no longer hide from."

With those final words, the sound of the doors unlocking reverberated through the car, and before Phainon could fully process those words, Mydei was already gone. A laugh sounded in the air as Phainon grabbed his box of pastries from the floor, climbing out and slamming the car door behind him. He dug for his apartment keys as he led the other man to the elevator.

Mydei was wrong. There was already a golden sun Phainon was chasing after.

The ride up the elevator was a comfortable silence. Their entire conversation was replaying in Phainon's head. His greatest revenge was to live life to the fullest? Phainon scoffed inwardly at the thought. What a difficult battle he was giving himself. But he wasn't someone who would back down without a fight.

The elevator chime broke his thoughts, and the two men stepped out into the new apartment floor. With his apartment keys swinging in his hand, Phainon unlocked the door to reveal the apartment that Mydei had already stepped into before. There really wasn't much to see, especially since Mydei had already visited once. It was just a one-bedroom apartment, equipped with a living room, kitchen, and restroom. But holding the door for Mydei and watching him step inside filled Phainon with an indescribable excitement that shouldn't have made Phainon's heart pound at the sight, and he shut the door as nonchalantly as he could.

"I'm sure you're… accustomed to more extravagant sights." Phainon sheepishly laughed, remembering Mydei's own living situation as he watched the other man scan the humble apartment.

"I didn't live in a penthouse my whole life." Mydei had made his way into the kitchen, running his fingers along the island in the middle of the space. "You forget I wasn't the CEO's son my whole life."

It felt weird to Phainon. He couldn't stop imagining a younger Mydei, baking little pastries and living a life entirely different from his current one.

Phainon had always known Mydei as “the CEO’s son” and had even said his entire job was just that. But at one point in time, Mydei was just a little boy who had trouble expressing his true self–a boy who just loved baking and reading about chimeras going on adventures.

“What was the first pastry you ever made?” Phainon wished he had met Mydei when they were younger. Maybe, he wouldn't have been as messed up as he was now. Maybe, Phainon could've learned to be just like Mydei just a little earlier.

Mydei's hands halted on the countertop as he fell deep into thought. With furrowed eyebrows and a frown, Phainon wanted to caress each and every expression this man held on his perfect facial features.

“It must've been the golden honeycakes.”

“Do you… even bake those?” It was a question that had been killing Phainon for a while now. “Do those count as pastries? Aren't they just pancakes?”

“You can make them on a stove if you wish.” Mydei turned around to lean against the counter, and his usual stoic expression softened. “They come out softer and fluffier in the oven. It's also easier to make larger batches rather than individually on the stove. On the stove… they come out a little crispier. And thinner. I wouldn't say they're pastries, but I added them to the bakery anyway.”

Phainon hummed, imagining those delicious honeycakes lathered in that sweet syrup. He could never forget the first time he had ever tasted them at the office, back when Cyrene had convinced him to eat food with mysterious origins. They truly have come a long way since then. “Did your mother have them in the bakery?”

Mydei shook his head. “She didn't, but it was the first thing she taught me how to make. I added them when I took ownership of the bakery after my mother's passing.”

Speaking of, it seemed that the COO knew a lot about Mydei and his mother, considering the COO also wasn't in favor of what the CEO had done to them.

“Does the COO know of the bakery?”

“He does.”

Phainon scowled. Why was he feeling slightly unsettled that someone else at work knew about Mydei's bakery? It made him… annoyed.

“Does he come often? To the bakery.”

“He doesn't.”

“So he knows about the bakery but doesn't support?”

“Phainon.”

Phainon couldn't believe the sight he was seeing. Mydei was standing in front of him, still leaning his weight against the island, with a restrained smile that was hiding small fits of quiet laughter. His chest was rising up and down as his body shook with every laugh.

His heart fluttered in his chest at the sight, but he covered up his obvious adoration with a slight frown. “What?”

Mydei's lips were quivering in failed attempts to stifle his own laughter. “Why are you going after the COO so much?”

“I… Well…” Why *was* he? Phainon barely knew the COO. He only knew his name as a part of his job, and he could barely even recall the man’s appearance. “I just… feel like… he should be supporting you.”

“I make more than enough money to not need the COO's assistance.”

“Well… I just…” Phainon was furrowing his eyebrows. Was he… Phainon didn't even want to confirm it himself. There was no way he was, right?

“If any of you want pastries, I would make them for you all for free.”

Phainon didn't like the sound of that either, and it only made his frown that much deeper amidst Mydei’s growing laughter.

“Do you want me to bake only for you?”

Two strong arms wrapped around Phainon's shoulders, making his entire body grow rigid and his breaths quickly still in the embrace. He snapped out of his thoughts, locking eyes with beautiful, shimmering gold right in front of him that was squinting from quiet laughter.

Phainon coughed. His blush was too obvious in front of this other man, and he didn't like it. He averted his gaze from the golden eyes staring at him. Any longer, and Phainon was going to heat up so much he was going to explode.

He entertained the idea of being the only person who could eat Mydei's creations. He would be the only person who could taste Mydei's golden honeycakes, croissants, doughnuts, and everything else that he made. Phainon would be the only person who would witness Mydei in an apron, with his long golden hair tied back as he kneaded at dough and lovingly adorned his pastries with berries, powdered sugar, and syrups. Phainon would be the only person whom Mydei would show his craft, which he put all his effort, focus, and love into making.

With a voice barely above a whisper, Phainon's face was probably hot enough to bake the very pastries he was imagining. “I… Maybe…”

Mydei laughed. *Mydei was laughing.* The arms around Phainon's shoulders shook with every breath that fell from his soft lips that were upturned into an amused smile. A faint tint of red adorned his cheeks that almost matched the crimson tattoos underneath his right eye, and his eyes sparkled under the kitchen lighting.

Phainon was going to combust.

He swiftly ducked under the arms around him, maneuvering out of Mydei's embrace and swiping a sweaty hand down his burning face with his heart ringing in his ears. His back was turned toward the other man as he did all he could to cool his face, with little success.

Phainon was almost starting to regret letting Mydei come into his apartment. He wasn't sure how much more he could take of this man's presence. His lips were flapping open and closed, but he couldn't bring himself to say anything, nor could he even think of a topic to switch to. His brain was fried–fried like the doughnuts Mydei had given him.

Mydei wasn't… going to stay the night, was he? *Mydei* staying the night over?

Phainon unconsciously swallowed thickly at the thought, with heat circulating in his core. He was already sweating just thinking about it. Phainon definitely… had to sleep on the couch. He *must* sleep on the couch. He couldn't even believe his drunken self had slept so soundly when such a beautiful man was sleeping in his bed right beside him. And according to the note Mydei had given him, *drunk Phainon was holding onto Mydei while sleeping.*

“Are you… going home today?” Phainon could barely force the words out of his own constricting throat. He swallowed once more, trying to dislodge what felt like a rock in his throat while covering the lower half of his burning face with his trembling hand. Phainon couldn't even bring himself to face the other man.

“Do you want me to?”

Phainon hated how unbothered he sounded. Phainon hated how cool, calm, and collected the other man was. Yet here Phainon was, making a fool of himself again, as he always did. Over a simple thought of another man staying in his apartment. Phainon has had plenty of people spend the night at his place. It was normal, right? So he would be fine by allowing Mydei to stay the night, right? Fuck, why did he remind himself of that?

He did not need more images of Mydei standing in his apartment, sleeping in his sheets, and perhaps… even using Phainon's clothes to change into since Mydei hadn't brought his own. The mere thought of Mydei wearing Phainon's clothes almost made him choke from how hard his breath stopped in his throat.

What was Phainon supposed to answer to his question? Should he say “yes” with the reason being “I will explode if we spend too much time together”? Or should he say “no” because *Phainon really wanted to spend more time together.*

Were they even *really* together? As in, were they *dating* now? They hadn't discussed it at all, and no one had truly asked the other person out. Was that a requirement to start dating? But Mydei had never directly referred to Phainon as his lover before. Was it enough for two people to just have feelings for each other? *Did Mydei have feelings for him?*

Sure, Mydei had kissed him… twice. Phainon's face flared once more at the memories. Though, he was in too much of a daze to even react, so would that even count as them sharing a kiss if it was all one-sided? And sure, Mydei had referred to Phainon as his… *beloved*, and that he was… *deeply infatuated* with him. But all of these things could be chalked up to being that Mydei just *really* cherished him. As a person. And not as a lover. *What if Mydei never held romantic feelings for Phainon, and he was just mistaken this entire time? Did Mydei ever really truly say he had feelings for Phainon? That he wanted Phainon to be his lover?*

“Are you ever going to answer my question?” A scoff broke Phainon's spiraling ramblings, and those same strong arms wrapped around Phainon's waist, pulling Phainon backwards until he stumbled into the warm embrace of the man he had completely forgotten was still standing in his kitchen. His back hit the other man's chest, and Phainon swore his pants were getting tighter.

Holy fuck, they were too close.

“Um… Mydei…” Phainon swallowed again. It was so loud that he was certain Mydei could also hear the anxiety seeping from his words. “Are

we…” Shame and a deep embarrassment immediately washed Phainon's entire body at the words he could not get to leave his mouth, and he opted to just shut himself up instead. The answer was obvious, but Phainon was too afraid to put the question out into the open. His heart and his entire body trembled at even the slightest chance of Mydei rejecting him. Maybe… they could just stay like this? Coworkers who were just very… affectionate?

A brief silence settled between them, with Phainon refusing to elaborate on what he was about to say. Maybe it wasn't too late to switch topics? That was what Phainon was about to think, until a deep voice beat him to it.

"Are you asking me if we're dating after I kissed you twice, said I was deeply infatuated with you, gave you bouquets of roses, and called you my beloved?”

“Can you… read thoughts too?”

Another scoff could be heard from behind Phainon's head, and his breath hitched when the hold around his waist tightened. Something brushed against the back of Phainon's head, with something tenderly pressing against him before that familiar sound of Mydei's lips echoed in his ears. Phainon's shoulders grew heavy, with his blush creeping all the way down to his neck.

“Do you want to be my lover, Phainon?” Mydei's voice was low and deep, a tone that sent shivers down Phainon's spine. Goosebumps rose along his arms as another gulp could be heard once more.

“Do you… want to?” Even the sound of Phainon's voice was trembling as he forced the words out of his mouth.

“Do I want to be your lover, or do I want you to be my lover?”

Phainon's eyes wildly searched the floor underneath his feet. “B–Both?”

Another quiet laugh followed by another soft kiss pressed against the back of Phainon's head. Keep this up, Mydei, or Phainon was actually going to

crumple to his knees. If Mydei wasn't already holding his waist, Phainon was sure he would already be on the floor.

“I was asking *you*, Phainon. So why don't you answer me first?”

Phainon couldn't help the frown that grew on his lips, but with his back still against the other man's chest, Mydei couldn't see his frustrated expression. His glaring eyes were still trained on his kitchen floor, with a pounding heart that shook his entire body even while within the comforting hold of this man who had possessed Phainon's thoughts for an eternity. Quivering lips hesitantly parted to finally form the words that had been circulating in Phainon's head for the entire day. For the entire past few weeks, even. And maybe even before Phainon knew it himself.

“I… want to be your lover, Mydei.”

His shoulders were trembling. His hands were shaking. He was losing all feeling in his legs. He was biting his bottom lip so hard that the taste of copper lingered on his tongue. But the tight embrace around him never let him go, even after his words settled in the air.

“I want to be your lover too, Phainon.”

That deep, confident voice seemed to echo in his small apartment, repeating over and over in Phainon's brain until it was all he could hear. His entire body violently shook at his unwavering words, but it was for an entirely different reason now. He could barely contain himself from the weight that had lifted off his chest. His body felt light; it felt like the air had returned to his lungs all at once, and the blood was pumping through Phainon's veins so quickly that it heated his entire body.

“*Mydei…*” His voice was shaking, and his teeth were still gnawing at his bottom lip. It took every cell in his body to hold himself back from turning around and jumping the other man, whose arms were still wrapped around his waist. This man… *Phainon’s lover*.

“Phainon,” Mydei whispered against silver hair. He was nuzzling his nose and brushing through his silver strands, and it was driving Phainon *crazy*.

Every slight touch in his hair made his body shiver and sent tingles down his spine. The heat was overtaking his body to the point where it was hard to breathe again, circling within his stomach and pooling within his core. He could barely feel Mydei's arms around him, and the only thing his brain could process was the scent of sugar and freshly baked bread.

Hands crept down to Phainon's waistband, and Phainon swore his vision turned red and his wide eyes trembled at the sight of Mydei's fingertips teasing the belt loops of his slacks, with fingers slowly dipping in and out of each loop. Lips softly pressed against Phainon's temple, and he instinctively leaned into the enticing warmth that radiated against his back. With his breath catching in his throat and heavy gasps that slipped from his lips, he could barely hear Mydei's next words over his pounding heartbeat. It was a voice so deep, so tantalizing, so full of a dangerous, stirring emotion, that it made the blood in Phainon’s body rush down his body just from merely hearing his voice.

“Do you want to take this to the bedroom, Phainon?”

Chapter 15

Phainon was sweating. *Phainon was sweating.*

He had literally just taken a shower, and all of his efforts were going to waste with how much he was sweating. Phainon didn't know what to do with himself, sitting in his bed with only the sounds of the water running echoing in his head. His entire body was trembling, and shivers were running down his spine, with his hands digging into his sheets at each sound of the water droplets hitting his shower floor.

They were taking turns cleaning themselves up, since they just had a full day of work earlier, but since Phainon lived in a one-bedroom one-bathroom apartment, they had to take turns in the shower. And there was absolutely no way Phainon was going to share the shower with Mydei. *Absolutely not.*

He could barely even contain himself right now, sitting on his bed and knowing that Mydei was *completely naked* in *his* shower with *his* water running down his body–his completely naked and utterly undressed body. Just thinking about the fact that a completely naked and bare Mydei was just a wall apart from Phainon sent all the blood rushing to the warmth between his legs, which was already half-hard just from the mere thought of what they were about to do. Just the fact that *Mydei had left the bathroom door purposefully unlocked* sent Phainon spiraling, and no, Phainon did not check. Why would he check that? That's preposterous. He obviously left the man to use his bathroom without checking the door at all, like a good host would do.

Heat was continually pooling in the pit of his stomach, and Phainon kept shifting in place at how uncomfortable his entire body felt. But that only made Phainon all the more aware of his half-hard dick between his legs, and he flinched every time it brushed against his thighs. But he couldn't sit still at all. Not when Mydei was taking what felt like the longest shower in his life, and not while knowing they were about to do… *that* in the next couple of minutes. Phainon was sure he was going to go into cardiac arrest

the moment the water turned off, and he was sure he would pass away if he saw a naked Mydei standing in front of him. Phainon had actually dressed himself back into his work clothes after his shower, unsure if he was supposed to stay undressed or not.

The water shut off in the next room over, but it felt as if it were right next to Phainon's ears, which were ringing from how loudly Phainon's heart was pounding. It was as if something were punching him in the chest from how hard it rattled from his heart, and his stomach was clenching and his shoulders were tensing for the door to open in any second. Phainon wasn't sure if he could take it anymore. He was too nervous. He could barely feel his own body with how hard his blood was pumping. What if he messed up in front of Mydei? What if he made another fool of himself in front of the other man? Was it too late to run out of his own apartment?

Before he could spring into action and dash out of his bedroom, the door connecting his room with the restroom clicked open. Phainon's breath immediately halted, and his throat tightened so much that he could barely even swallow. And when that familiar head of golden hair emerged from behind that door, Phainon swore his heart actually stopped.

Mydei was completely and utterly naked, right before his very eyes.

“You're dressed?” With an amused smirk, Mydei sauntered over to where Phainon was seated at the edge of his bed. He couldn't even bring himself to fully get comfortable in his bed because *he was way too nervous to think of anything else except for this naked man standing in front of him.* And the closer Mydei approached him, the more Phainon could smell the scent of his own bath soap oozing off of this beautifully naked body. The heat in his stomach flared just thinking about the fact that Mydei used *his* shower soap. And now Mydei smelled just like *him*. Just like *Phainon*.

Phainon's face was burning just as much as the pit of his stomach was, and he averted his gaze from the other man so rapidly that he barely spotted his red tattoos dipping lower than Phainon could've ever imagined. He swallowed thickly–the hardest gulp he had ever experienced in his entire life. “I… wasn't sure if… I should or not…”

Every word scratched at Phainon's throat. Every syllable *ached* in his constricting throat. His throat was low and raspy as if he were recovering from a common cold. He wasn't sure if he could speak another word.

“Why should you be dressed? Unless, you want to do it while fully clothed?” A soft laugh resounded from right in front of him. *Right in front of Phainon.*

“Do… it…” Phainon's ears burned at the words they had just processed as they repeated in his head, and the blood all rushed down to his dick once more. He wasn't looking, but he knew his little friend was more than just half-hard now. Phainon could already feel how hard he was every time his legs trembled.

“Yes, Phainon.” Mydei's face lowered until it was right in front of Phainon's, and Phainon's lips quivered at the heat that was radiating off the other man. Phainon could already feel this man on him, and they weren't even touching. “We're doing *it* today. Having sex.”

Phainon's body was violently shaking now, and his rumbling fingertips were digging so hard into his sheets that he was sure they were going to rip. His vision turned red, and his eyes widened like saucers upon hearing Mydei’s extremely blatant words.

They were about to have sex together. Phainon and Mydei were going to have sex.

A loud gulp could be heard in the room, with Phainon refusing to tear his gaze from the nightstand that sat right next to the head of his bed. This was definitely not Phainon's first time. *This was definitely not his first time at all.* But why did this feel so much more intense than his first time? He could barely even recall that unimportant first time. Especially not with the warmth of this other man continually brushing against his straining body.

A warm, tender hand stroked Phainon's jawline, and Phainon visibly jumped at the sensation of goosebumps rising on his arms and the soft fingertips that grazed his skin. The hand cradled his face, brushed against his burning ears, and forced his gaze to tear away from the nightstand to

lock with golden eyes that were so dilated it looked like a breathtaking solar eclipse.

“You don't want to look at me, Phainon?” Mydei’s voice was low, husky, and so seductive that Phainon felt like he could explode in his pants just from hearing his deep voice whisper in his ears and feeling his hot breath ghosting against him.

“I…” Phainon swallowed thickly again, feeling a rock lodging itself in his throat. “I… can't…”

“Can't?” Those soft, plump lips turned up into an amused smile, with golden eyes flickering between Phainon's eyes and something much, much lower than Phainon's face. “Because you're already hard without me touching you?”

Phainon gulped once more, but it did little to soothe his aching throat or his aching cock that was pulsing in his own pants. It was desperate for friction, desperate to be touched, and desperate to release. Any slight brush of this man against his body was definitely going to make Phainon bust, and he couldn't bring himself to open his mouth to respond to the other man.

Another soft laugh reverberated through Phainon's brain, and his breath hitched when a weight settled in his lap. He was actually tugging on the sheets under his trembling hands now, and the feeling of Mydei's bare cheeks rubbing against his thighs was too prominent. The weight of Mydei’s naked body finally in his lap, rubbing itself on Phainon… He couldn't think about it anymore, or his brain would stop working.

The other man was frowning, running his hands through the back of Phainon's silver hair and slowly dragging his hips back and forth along Phainon's lap. Phainon didn't dare to look down; he didn't dare to see Mydei’s naked lap that was sitting on him, nor did he dare to see what hung between Mydei’s legs.

“You should take these off.” Warm lips and hot breath tickled Phainon's quivering lips. A sharp thrust of Mydei’s hips sent Phainon's jaw dropping in a silent scream. Hands flew to Mydei’s waist to stop him, as the heat

flaring in his core was already too much to handle, but the skin underneath his hands was so soft, so smooth, and so *tempting*. His waist curved so deliciously in the palm of Phainon's hands as his fingertips could feel the flexing back muscles of the other man, and it was driving Phainon insane at how well their bodies melded together.

“Wait… *Please*.” Phainon was already panting just from a simple thrust. With dilated eyes that already felt like his vision was blown out, his sweaty forehead and furrowed eyebrows were pressing against Mydei’s in every attempt to focus on cooling his already pulsing erection, but his tight pants being suffocated under Mydei’s ass weren't helping in the slightest. His brain was still having trouble processing that a naked Mydei was sitting so prettily right in his lap, and every thought about it made his dick twitch.

“Going to cum already?” Mydei didn't listen to Phainon's pleas at all and thrust his hips once more. Phainon's eyes widened with a gasp, gritting his teeth and feeling the front of his pants become soaked with his own leaking precum. “We barely even started, Phainon. You're not even undressed yet.”

“*Please,* Mydei.” His pleading voice was straining to be barely above a whisper, but the weight in Phainon's lap did little to soothe how violently his body was shaking. “Don't say my name.”

“You don't like it when I say your name?” A devious smile appeared on Mydei's lips as he leaned even closer. Tingles of electricity rushed down his spine with every brush of the other man's lips against Phainon's, and his dick ached within his own pants, desperate for more friction than this. “You don't like it, *hmm, Phainon?*”

An unconscious thrust that Phainon had no control over rubbed his hips against Mydei’s behind, and moans interrupted the still air in the bedroom from the pleasure that erupted within Phainon's body. Mydei's lips had dropped open, parting way for the most beautiful and tantalizing moan that Phainon had ever had the pleasure of hearing, and it only spurred Phainon more.

With hands tightly grasping that gorgeously slim waist, his anxious mind completely blanked out. Phainon chased after that blossoming pleasure as

he rutted his hips against the curve of Mydei's ass, feeling the weight of Mydei's body jolting up and down with every thrust. Another moan from Mydei ripped through the air as he arched his back and dug his fingernails into Phainon's back, clinging onto his shoulders and feeling Phainon's dick poking against him through the confines of his pants. Almost as if Phainon's dick was instinctively searching for Mydei’s warmth, desperate to bury itself into Mydei's already fluttering entrance. Every brush of Phainon's clothed dick against Mydei's hole sent both men into a desperate spiraling mess of gasps and moans, with each touch only enough to tease the other man.

Mydei was thrusting back against Phainon, digging his hips into Phainon’s lap and lavishing at the dick that was poking against him. He was sliding his twitching entrance against Phainon's bulge, desperate to suck Phainon inside despite the pants that were in the way. And Phainon couldn't take it anymore with how much the heat was coiling in his stomach, at the sensation of Mydei’s naked body rubbing against him, and at the hard erection that had slipped inside Phainon's shirt and was sliding precum all over Phainon's flexing stomach. Every ridge and vein of Mydei's hard cock rubbed against his abdomen, and Phainon's face burned knowing that Mydei was just as turned on as he was. That he was feeling just as much pleasure as Phainon was.

He was trying so hard to stave away his release, to hold himself in for as long as possible, but when two quivering hands had slid along his jawline, tilting his head upwards before a soft tongue had slipped past his lips, all restraint flew out the window.

Eyes rolled back into his head, Phainon’s thrusts became sporadic, relishing in the pleasure that was rushing through every limb in his body and the heat that was seeping its way into Phainon's brain. He couldn't stop himself anymore even if he wanted to; he was too far gone into the pleasure that was ripping through his entire being, and the sound of their lovemaking only tempted Phainon further. The creaking of his bed frame with every desperate thrust and the sounds of their lips and tongues sucking against each other sounded so much louder in his bedroom, and every sound was ingrained in Phainon’s brain.

His tongue could barely fight back against Mydei’s, who was exploring every crevice and cavern of his mouth without a care in the world. Mydei rubbed along the roof of his mouth, sliding against the back of his teeth, and caressing every warm wall inside of Phainon's mouth. Long eyelashes brushed against Phainon's cheeks, moans vibrated against his parted lips, and hot breaths tangled with Phainon's until his fingertips dug into the smooth skin underneath the palm of his hands, body vibrating as his vision completely blacked out.

Phainon moaned wantonly against those soft lips that were basically suffocating him. His hips jolted violently against the other man as he squeezed his eyes shut, and electricity shot through his body as his back arched. He spilled his release into his own pants, calling the other man’s name against his lips and feeling his own underwear filling up with his thick cum until his dick was swimming within his own cum that pooled within his pants. Whimpers and gasps escaped his aching throat with every soft thrust against him until the two men eventually slowed their movements.

A string of saliva still connected their lips even after the sound of their parting echoed in the air. Phainon was panting for breath, coming down from his sudden high, and he couldn't take the overstimulation of Mydei's weight pressing down on his recovering dick any longer. He tried to shift his weight away, but it only brushed against Phainon's cock and made him jump in place at the sharp pleasure that pierced his lower half.

“You came?” Mydei scoffed, an amused smile dancing across his lips. “You didn't even get to undress.”

Phainon couldn't bring himself to respond. His pants were soaked, his eyes were blown out, there was no air in his lungs, and his dick was still pulsing from the sensation of Mydei's ass against him. Mydei only softly laughed, pushing himself from Phainon's limp body and waking him up when the sound of his zipper shot through Phainon's brain.

His eyes immediately shot to his lap, where Mydei's fingers were lowering the confines of his pants. His fingertips hooked onto Phainon's waistband, and his vision violently shook at the sight of Mydei's golden eyes that were

so dilated that they were basically black. He was staring up at Phainon through golden bangs, kneeling all prettily in between Phainon's spread legs as he pulled his slacks down to reveal his cock that was already half-hard again at the seductive view between his legs.

Mydei bent forward, and Phainon's heart palpitated in anticipation. A moan shook his chest when a tongue swiftly scooped up the leftover cum that his dick had been sitting in. Phainon's hips thrust up at the warm breath that brushed against his length, but Mydei firmly held him down while he shut his golden eyes to lap at the cum around Phainon's dick. Phainon's opened legs were trembling around Mydei, focusing on every kiss and noise that came from Mydei’s mouth as he licked and sucked at every droplet of cum that Phainon had released. He was trying so hard not to push Mydei’s head down to take in his entire length, and he was trying so hard not to thrust himself against Mydei’s bruised lips. Instead, he directed all his energy into digging his fingernails into the sheets once more before he actually began pulling on the man's golden hair. *His lover's* golden hair.

Mydei's nose was buried into silver hair, cleaning around the base of Phainon's dick, and a hand grasped around Phainon's length to lap at the cum around his shaft and the head of his aching dick until he was fully hard once more. But his greedy lips never left Phainon's shaft, and they continued to suck around his cock. With groans and pants escaping from his throat, Phainon threw his head back, shutting his eyes and reveling in the feeling of Mydei’s lips attached to his cock, teasing the head of his dick and his slit and eliciting moan after moan from Phainon’s lungs until the precum began to flow once more.

With a soft smile, Mydei's lips separated from Phainon's dick, and it didn't escape Phainon's notice when Mydei's tongue swiped along his lips, catching Phainon's precum that lingered along his tongue. Heat coursed through Phainon's veins as darkened blue eyes watched Mydei push himself from the floor and situate himself between Phainon's legs. He tugged at Phainon's shirt, and with shaky hands, Phainon obliged to those silent, commanding, golden eyes. He unbuttoned each and every button of his dress shirt while Mydei went to work on his tie until the cool air of the bedroom encapsulated his naked body.

His brain was short-circuiting as he heard his clothes dropping onto his bedroom floor. The pants that were gathered around his ankles were also thrown onto the floor, and each sound of his clothes piling somewhere in his room made Phainon's heart jump. They echoed in Phainon's head, bouncing around in his brain, as if emphasizing that he was now completely and fully exposed–exposed right in front of those golden eyes that could now see every little part of Phainon. The haze of pleasure was gone after cumming, and his previous anxiety started seeping into his brain once again.

“Are you… Are you sure you want to do this?” Phainon's voice was dead, and barely a whisper could come out of his throat. It was dry from how much he had moaned already, and his voice was raspy from their… activities. But he couldn't help but force the question out, as this would be the last time before the two of them could stop. Maybe… Maybe there was a little part in Mydei that had doubts, and Phainon didn't want to take part in any of this if there was even an inkling of doubt or hesitation in Mydei's mind. Of course, Phainon wanted to do this, but he wanted to ask Mydei, just to be safe.

“Am *I* sure?” Mydei scoffed. Two hands suddenly pushed against Phainon's shoulders, and his back hit the bed before he could even react. His recovering breaths, which were finally starting to slow, hitched once more when Mydei settled himself into his lap again, sliding Phainon's bare dick against his behind. His shaft slotted itself right between Mydei's cheeks, grinding against his already twitching entrance, and it took every cell in Phainon's body not to start rutting himself right against his hole. “I should be asking *you* that question, Phainon. Do you know how long I've been waiting for this?”

A breathy laugh left Phainon's lungs. He couldn't imagine how long Mydei had been waiting for this. How long Mydei had been watching him from afar at work, afraid to approach Phainon and only being able to treat him with hostility because a little orange chimera said so. Phainon only wished that he could've seen through his ruse earlier, that he could've realized Mydei's love for him earlier. But he was blinded by his own self-deprecation and blinded by those golden wheatfields that had haunted his

dreams, and he couldn't begin to describe how grateful he was for Mydei's patience with him. How Mydei overcame that orange chimera and took things into his own hands to explain everything to Phainon. Phainon would never throw his notes away. Not a single note.

“I just… wanted to make sure.” Phainon let out a sheepish chuckle, smiling sweetly at the man who was covering the bedroom lighting with his body and appearing as if a halo surrounded his golden hair. “This is just your final chance. I don't want you to have any regrets, Mydei.”

“*Hmph*. If you think *I* will have regrets about this, you have not been listening to me carefully enough.” The golden-haired man bent down so closely that Phainon had pushed himself against the mattress, trying as hard as he could to sink into the bed but to no avail. The tips of their noses brushed against each other, their lips ghosted against each other, and their bodies pressed against each other. Phainon swallowed thickly as his eyes widened, feeling the weight of Mydei's body against him and the other man's hard dick rubbing against his abdomen as his lips parted to form the sweetest words Phainon would ever hear.

“I love you, Phainon. Far longer than you have ever looked at me.”

Those words shot through Phainon's chest. Those words repeated over and over in Phainon's head. The sound of Mydei’s voice, the emotions of longing and passion swirling in his golden eyes, nothing escaped Phainon's attention. His hands began trembling once more, fisting the sheets as his gaze wavered against Mydei. His eyes were burning from staring into the sun, and his blurring vision was quickly wiped away with a swipe of the other man's thumb.

“You're going to cry just from that?” Despite his words, Mydei was smiling so sweetly at him. So softly that Phainon couldn't believe that gaze would ever be directed at Phainon. His golden eyes shimmered in the light, sparkling underneath Phainon's gaze as they continued to catch the stray tears that had escaped Phainon's notice. “Aren't you going to say it back?”

Phainon laughed quietly, blinking away more tears that had gathered in the corners of his eyes. “You may have looked at me for far longer, but I know I

love you so much more.”

An accusatory eyebrow was raised in his direction. “I absolutely doubt that.”

“I think I absolutely know so.”

“I love you more than you love me, Phainon.”

“My love for you is so much greater than yours, Mydei.”

“Why are you turning this into a competition?” Mydei scoffed, a playful smile evident on his lips. “Just say ‘I love you,’ you bastard.”

Phainon couldn't help another laugh escape him, and his chest rumbled with every breath. But when his laughter finally quieted down, Phainon had never been filled with so much confidence and love in his entire life. These words that Phainon spoke were truer than anything else Phainon had ever spoken before, and it felt as if the culmination of Phainon's entire life and everything that he had ever experienced all led to these four words that finally left his lips, hanging in the air between the two men for them to hear forever.

“I love you, Mydei.”

The softest smile that Phainon had ever seen. Sweeter than the smile he was given when Phainon had complimented his pastry for the first time, and sweeter than the time Phainon had said he couldn't join him at the bakery. A smile so full of love, so full of compassion, and so full of *Phainon* lay right before Phainon's very eyes. And he couldn't get enough of Mydei's smiles, glowing in the light as the ceiling lighting softly brushed through his golden strands.

Their lips pressed into a tender kiss. A deep, passionate kiss as both men's eyes fluttered shut. A deep need and yearning swirled in Phainon's core as the kiss deepened and their lips pressed even closer together. His hands settled upon Mydei’s waist once more, ravishing in the pleasure that washed through his body with every slight movement of their lips. Mydei's lips

were soft, plump, and fit perfectly against Phainon's. It was a kiss that didn't need to be messy, a kiss that conveyed everything the two men were feeling, and when cool air finally brushed against his lips as they parted, Phainon had to stop himself from pulling the man back down to connect their lips once again.

“So, I will ask you this time.” Mydei had raised himself onto his knees, reaching behind himself, and Phainon jumped when gentle fingers wrapped around his dick. “Do you want to do this, Phainon?”

A smile crinkled Phainon's eyes. He could barely stop himself from immediately answering. “I would never regret my time with you, Mydei.”

With a soft laugh from his lover, Phainon watched Mydei fumble behind him, pushing the tip of Phainon's dick right against Mydei's entrance. The feeling of his dick pushing right against Mydei’s fluttering hole that was already sucking him inside was indescribable, and the heat immediately flared up in Phainon's stomach from feeling Mydei’s warmth sinking lower and lower onto him.

Phainon was trembling, tearing his eyes away from the delicious sight of Mydei lowering onto his dick before he would explode, but the image had already seared itself onto Phainon's brain: His eyes were glazed over, his mouth was parted open while releasing soft, restrained moans, and his cheeks were ablaze, with red spreading all the way down to his broad chest. Phainon couldn't stand the sight anymore; the warmth that was already surrounding his cock and slowly taking in his entire length was too much.

He could feel Mydei’s fluttering walls squeezing around him the more Mydei lowered, massaging around his length, and Phainon cursed under his breath at the pleasure that made his legs tremble in his sheets. Phainon had never felt so good in his entire life; he couldn't recall sex ever feeling this good. But he was already gasping for breath and trying to steady his heartbeat all at the same time, and Phainon was only just bottoming out inside of Mydei's warmth.

“Won't you look at me, Phainon?”

A deep voice reverberated in front of him now that Mydei’s behind was officially pressing against Phainon's bare thighs. Phainon still had his eyes squeezed shut with his head turned to the side, refusing to stare at the temptation that sat right in his lap. Every breath he took, he could feel his dick quivering inside of Mydei's delicious hole, and every slight shiver of his body only emphasized the warmth that was squeezing around his dick. Mydei wasn't even moving; Phainon wasn't even moving. But he already felt like he was going to cum and spill himself deep inside.

A hand grasped his chin, forcefully turning his head to the sight Phainon was refusing to stare at, and his eyes widened at the view before him. Mydei was reaching out toward him, with his hand gently cradling his chin. Two perky nipples were pointed up on his muscular chest, and Phainon dug his nails into the skin underneath the palms of his hands to stop himself from reaching out and teasing the other man. He was on his knees, with his legs spread around Phainon's waist, and Phainon swallowed at the clear view of the hard erection that was standing tall and proud right on his stomach. His dick occasionally pulsed, dripping precum from his reddened tip, and Phainon unconsciously swiped his tongue along his teeth with his eyes narrowed at the delectable sight. His hazy, lust-filled brain couldn't get it out of his head what Mydei possibly tasted like.

“I said to look at me, not my dick.” His chin was jolted upwards, and Phainon sheepishly laughed. He didn't realize how obviously he was staring.

“Sorry.” Phainon smiled apologetically, tearing his gaze away from the lewd view.

Mydei scoffed. “You don't look sorry.”

But before Phainon could answer, Mydei had already lifted himself off of Phainon's lap before dropping unannounced onto him, taking his length all in one swift motion. A deep groan left Phainon's throat as he threw his head back at the shock that ripped through his entire body, and Mydei moaned at how deeply Phainon had entered inside of him. It was a sensation that neither man could tire of, and with a click of his tongue, Phainon thrust into

Mydei's warmth to chase that sweet, sweet pleasure that was building up in his body.

Mydei's hands flew to Phainon's chest, balancing himself as Phainon began pummeling into Mydei’s quivering entrance. Golden eyes fluttered shut as Phainon's dick delved deeper and deeper inside of him, and moans and cries echoed off the bedroom walls with every sharp thrust of Phainon’s hips. Pleasure was rushing through every cell in Phainon's body, and his feet were digging into the mattress with every deep thrust, craving more and more of Mydei's warmth to overtake his entire body.

How was Mydei already so loose? Did he prepare himself earlier? Was that why his shower took so long? Just the thought of Mydei standing in his shower, his naked body dripping in water as he leaned against the wall to finger himself open, was an image that snapped something inside of Phainon. Mydei bent over, with fingers buried inside his entrance, to prepare himself just for Phainon. *Mydei preparing himself just for Phainon.*

His eyes darkened, and in one swift motion, Phainon pushed himself off the bed and pressed Mydei's back into the sheets. Mydei's eyes widened at the sudden change in position but immediately rolled back into his head when Phainon pushed himself deeper inside of Mydei, continuing his breaking pace as if they had never stopped. Hands slipped under Mydei's knees, spreading his legs apart, and Phainon basically folded Mydei over to give himself a clear view of his dick completely swallowed up by Mydei's needy hole.

Phainon's vision shook at the sight, breath hitching in his throat at how deeply his dick was shoved inside. His entrance was twitching where they were connected, and Phainon could feel just how much Mydei's inner walls were pulsing at his intrusion. He pushed his hips deeper, pressing himself against Mydei's behind, and a whimper spilled from those beautiful, quivering lips underneath him.

Mydei's legs were spread apart just for him. Mydei was lying on his back just for him. Mydei had fingered himself open just for him. Mydei was moaning just for him. *Just for Phainon.* All of it was for *Phainon*. He didn't want a single other man to witness this sight before him, of golden hair

spilling over broad shoulders, of flushed cheeks dripping in sweat, and of golden, dilated eyes filled with lust.

With a deep breath, filling his lungs with air from when his breath had stopped, Phainon resumed his rapid pace, watching his dick slip in and out of Mydei's greedy hole. A long groan pervaded Phainon's ears, and he relished every shiver in Mydei’s voice and every breathless pant that cut between every moan. He tore his gaze away from Mydei's filled entrance, watching Mydei's lips forever parted, releasing moan after whimper after groan after cry, calling for Phainon's name and calling for more of Phainon to take over every single one of his senses. And who was Phainon to refuse such a request?

He pulled himself out, grasping Mydei’s waist and flipping the man over. Phainon was already climbing on top of the other man before he could react, burying himself deep inside Mydei's hole and eliciting another sweet, beautiful moan from the man below him. Every sound and every noise shot down to Phainon's dick, and he was sure he was already leaking precum inside his perfect entrance with every deep thrust.

“Did you… *hah.*.. have a fourth week of notes planned?” Phainon whispered into Mydei’s ears, nuzzling his golden hair with his nose and only increasing his pace against Mydei’s behind. The sounds of their skinship bounced off the walls and right into Phainon's head, and he couldn't get enough of hearing their bare skin slapping against each other and only emphasizing the vulgar activities they were getting up to in his bedroom. Phainon loved it. He loved every second of it and every sound of it and every scent of it. The smell of sex radiating off their bodies, the sweat dripping off Mydei’s sculpted back. Phainon couldn't get enough of a single sensation, a single sound, and a single sight.

Mydei could barely even respond while his insides were being turned upside down. It was exactly what Mydei had been craving for *weeks*, for *months* even. It was more than Mydei could've ever asked for, and his entrance was being filled to the brim with Phainon's thick length. It was taking the breath right out of Mydei with every deep pummel of Phainon's hips, pushing Mydei deeper into the bed and only stirring his aching cock to slide against the sheets. He was leaking precum all over the bed and onto

his stomach, and the dual stimulation was becoming too much for Mydei that he almost forgot that he was being asked a question. He was too far gone, being a slave to the pleasure that was pooling in his core.

“I… I did.” Mydei's voice was hoarse from all the moans that had scratched his throat. His hands were clutching the sheets that he was dirtying, with his grip trembling above him as Phainon continued to fuck deep inside him like there was no tomorrow.

A deep, husky laugh sounded next to Mydei's ear. “What were you going to tell me that fourth week?”

The heat against his ear only sent pleasure rushing down to Mydei's dick, and he bit his lip to suppress another moan. “My… My dreams.”

“Dreams?” Phainon was intrigued now, but not intrigued enough to stop chasing the pleasure of his dick that was being massaged by Mydei’s insides. He angled his thrust upward, brushing directly against Mydei’s prostate, and the man underneath him spasmed in bed as a scream ripped through the air. With a smirk, Phainon placed his hand on top of Mydei’s trembling fist, aiming right for his sweet spot that left Mydei a writhing mess of moans and cries.

“D–Dreams… of… of…us–and–*OHH! YES!”* Mydei couldn't focus on the conversation anymore. He yelled Phainon's name, cursing over and over, and digging his forehead into the mattress in an attempt to forget about his clenching stomach and his oncoming orgasm. He was so close, and Phainon's dick kept pressing right against his fluttering prostate. Mydei had squeezed his eyes shut, with his jaw slack, as moans continued filling the air around them.

“Dreams of me?” Phainon laughed breathlessly. Just the sound of Mydei dreaming of him almost sent him over the edge, and he drove himself even harder inside of Mydei as the pleasure continued to build deep within his stomach. “What were you… *mmph*, dreaming of?”

Golden eyes were rolled into the back of his head. Saliva was dripping down his chin. His throat was dry, his body was sweating profusely, and his

stomach was flaring at the pressure that was building up in his body. Legs trembled violently against the bed, which only stirred his cock against the sheets, and another wanton moan ripped through Mydei's chest as he couldn't stop his hips from thrusting against the bed, chasing his orgasm and his release.

"Dreams of… us, and–*MMM!* Of us on… dates and… *FUCK! PHAINON!"* Mydei's voice was shaking, reaching a pitch that wasn't normal for Mydei. He was panting for breath, but every sharp thrust from Phainon took the breath right out of his chest. Despite all that, his legs were still spreading even wider apart, and his back arching his behind even more sharply, eager for Phainon to fill him deeper.

"Dates?" A deep shiver coursed down Phainon's body. While Phainon was having dreams of his drunken night with Mydei and pinning him to the bed, Mydei was having dreams of… dates? Them? Going out together? Spending time together? Dreams of just them being in one another's company?

His Mydei was so cute. His Mydei was just so adorable. *His Mydei and only his*.

"Where do you want to go, *hmm?* My love?" Phainon chuckled lowly, kissing tenderly at his ear that was completely in contrast to the harsh thrusts against his ass that ravaged Mydei's aching walls and echoed throughout the bedroom. "Where would our first date be?"

"Th–The bookstore… Like you–*AHH!*–asked!"

Phainon scoffed incredulously. Mydei remembered that? He remembered Phainon asking him to go to the bookstore? When Mydei had leisurely dropped Phainon off at his apartment and driven away, Mydei had actually remembered the entire time? Phainon grinned to himself, sinking further inside Mydei's hole and breaching a part of him that had Mydei squirming underneath him. Could his Mydei get any more perfect?

"You remembered?" His blue eyes sparkled with a dangerous emotion. *He was going to cum inside of Mydei and claim him all for himself, whether*

Mydei wanted it or not. Phainon had resolutely made up his mind to fill Mydei to the brim with his cum, and he pushed himself up to grasp at Mydei’s waist, plunging his dick as deeply as possible and watching himself slide in and out of his abused hole. His twitching entrance was red and stretched out to fit the exact size of Phainon's cock, and his eyes widened at the sight.

Phainon could not wait to fill him up with his cum. He was trembling just at the mere thought of his cum dripping out of Mydei's loose hole, and he was sure he would immediately get hard again at the actual sight. He couldn't wait to actually stuff Mydei to the brim. *Phainon could not wait.*

Eyes watched Mydei's ass bounce with every thrust. Eyes watched his stretched hole being filled over and over with every thrust. Eyes watched back muscles flex with every brush against his prostate. Phainon slid his hands against Mydei's waist, feeling the sticky skin against him and hearing Mydei's lovely moans echo in the air.

He moaned Phainon's name once more. The pit of Mydei's stomach was churning. Heat was overtaking his entire body as it violently shook under Phainon's relentless thrusts, with electricity rushing through his limbs with each press of his sweet spot. His back arched, presenting himself even more to Phainon and grinding against the bedsheets until his body could no longer take the friction in front and the deep thrusts against his prostate in the back.

The walls sucking around Phainon tightened, and Phainon's hips jolted at how his dick was being squeezed deep inside. His head flew forward, gnawing at his bottom lip as the man below him screamed Phainon's name at the top of his lungs. Through blurred vision and squinted eyes, Phainon relished in the man underneath him spasming in the bed, screaming his name, and spilling his cum right into his sheets. His body jolted with every stream that landed right on his bed, and his insides grasped Phainon so tightly as if trying to milk the cum right out of him.

Phainon couldn't take it anymore. His dick was being massaged so beautifully. His name was being moaned so lovingly. The body underneath his hands shivered with every pulse of Phainon's dick. And this stunning

man was feeling so much pleasure around Phainon's cock that it finally sent him over the edge. He groaned, shutting his eyes as the heat within his core flared up, and he released himself right inside of Mydei's heat, plugging Mydei up as deeply as he could and spilling everything inside of Phainon's balls right inside of Mydei's insatiable hole.

Mydei had slumped limply into the bed. Soft whines slipped past his parted lips with every gentle thrust of Phainon's hips as he was completely filled with cum. He emptied himself right inside of Mydei, with his body trembling against Mydei’s behind as pleasure overtook every one of Phainon's senses. His vision had turned white, and his entire body had grown rigid at the first stream of cum that left his dick. He arched his back, pressing as deeply as he could against Mydei while muttering sweet nothings, moaning Mydei's name until his dick had finally gone soft.

The two men were panting desperately for breath. Phainon finally remembered that they were in his apartment as his vision slowly recovered from his orgasm. He slipped his dick out of Mydei's entrance, and the wet noises that came from his hole below and the whimpers that came from above made Phainon's face burn in embarrassment.

“Sorry,” Phainon mumbled. His gaze was downcast now that his sanity had returned. He couldn't even believe that he had cum right inside of Mydei without even asking the guy. Phainon was so turned on that he had even forgotten a condom, yet his body couldn't help but vibrate at the current sight of his cum oozing out of Mydei's pulsing entrance, dripping down his scrotum and pooling onto Phainon's bed. He swallowed thickly. He couldn't even avert his gaze from the vulgar sight. His eyes only widened at his cum that continually spilled from Mydei's hole, and it only made his dick stir.

“*Sorry?”* A glare was shot over Mydei's shoulders, and Phainon flinched, his dick immediately wilting.

“Sorry for… for…” Phainon grimaced at the sheer embarrassment and shame that washed over his body. His voice was barely above a whisper as he forced out the words. “For… cumming… inside.”

A silence settled between the two, and it only made Phainon's body anxiously shake in preparation for what sort of backlash he was going to receive. He was too afraid to look into Mydei's golden eyes, and he tore his gaze away from Mydei’s naked body entirely. Any longer, and Phainon would get hard at the sight even while preparing himself for an outburst.

Eventually, a scoff broke their silence. “You… really thought I wouldn't get a condom for you if I didn't want you to cum inside?”

Phainon shifted awkwardly in his place, hearing shuffling in front of him as Mydei pushed himself off the soiled sheets. “I… forgot… to put one on. I'm–”

“I didn't want you to.” Warm hands forced Phainon's eyes to shift to the view in front of him, and they widened at the sight of an amused smirk dancing across Mydei's lips. “I didn't want you to wear one, Phainon.”

His words settled onto Phainon's rigid shoulders, and Phainon's entire body shivered. His quivering lips parted, but no sound left his mouth. He could only stare, in complete and utter shock, at this gorgeous man right in front of him. It wasn't just Phainon? Mydei also wanted the same thing?

Mydei laughed lightly, swiping the silver bangs that had stuck to Phainon's forehead from all the sweat from their activities with gentle fingertips. “Do you get it, Phainon? I wanted to feel you inside. Just like you did earlier.”

Phainon could not believe this man. *Phainon could not believe this man.* It felt as if he had walked right out of a dream, and his entire mind went blank. He didn't know what to do with himself, and he couldn't find it in himself to react. So Phainon only stared with wide eyes at the other man, with his jaw completely slack and his body completely slumped.

A slight tilt of golden hair as hands cupped Phainon's cheeks. The smirk never left Mydei's lips as he narrowed his eyes in Phainon's direction. “Phainon, was that it?”

“Was that… it?” Phainon breathlessly repeated his words. He could barely register what Mydei was even talking about. He was still overcoming the

shock that *Mydei* wanted *Phainon to fill him up with his cum.*

A small frown was thrown his way, and it was the cutest pout that Phainon had ever seen in his entire life. He could die happy. Right now. He could die and be absolutely fulfilled.

“You don't want to go another round?”

A loud gulp echoed in the bedroom, and Mydei laughed once more at the blue eyes that were visibly shaking in front of him. With a soft peck against Phainon's forehead, Mydei shoved Phainon down into the mattress, and with Phainon's body still in a complete state of shock, he was easily pushed against the bed as Mydei climbed right on top of him.

Who was Phainon to refuse his lover?

Chapter 16

“Mydei!”

Mydei was currently blinking the sleep out of his eyes. The executives of the department were finally starting to leave, and Mydei could finally go home and pass out. He only drank a glass of wine because the executives wanted to, but because he was never a fan of alcohol and never drank it, it was starting to hit him hard. He was starting to become sleepy now, and combined with the fact that he already woke up at two in the morning for the bakery, made him extra tired. He should tell his backup to open the bakery for him tomorrow. He wasn't expecting a last-minute company dinner.

He could barely register the female voice calling for him, and he slowly turned his head to the other side of the table, where a woman with pink hair was staring expectantly at him. He could barely remember her name while in this inebriated stupor… Cyrene, was it? A recruiter from the human resources department, Mydei faintly recalled.

“Mydei, can you help me?” She called for him another time, batting her eyelashes at him despite the floundering of her lavender-haired coworker from across the table, but he was too far away to hear what complaints she had to say.

With a raised eyebrow, Mydei pushed himself up from his chair and approached the other woman. He was about to ask what she needed from him, only to immediately shut his mouth at the slumped, silver-haired man, who had a languid grin across his face and hazy, blue eyes. It was clear that the man was drunk out of his mind, but Mydei was still trying to catch his breath over the fact that he was so close to the other man.

Phainon, the human resources specialist of the human resources department. He knew Phainon all too well; in fact, Mydei would say he knew him *very* well. He was a man who had piqued Mydei's interest ever since Phainon was first hired, and Mydei had been watching him ever since. Even if he

tried to tear his eyes away, bury himself within his work, and forget who he was, his mind would always return to Phainon. He was always too intimidated to talk to the other man, who seemed like the exact opposite of Mydei, and Mydei couldn't help but be extremely, utterly, and helplessly attracted to him.

“Did you drink today?” Cyrene's question interrupted his permanent thoughts of Phainon, and he ripped his gaze away from the object of his affection to see Cyrene's eyes wandering his face.

At the sound of a drink, Mydei instinctively glanced at his seat, where he drank a glass before staring back at Cyrene. “Only a glass. I don't usually drink.”

“Perfect!” Cyrene clapped her hands together with a pleased expression. She seemed to be satisfied with his answer. “Unfortunately, neither Castorice nor I is strong enough to carry Phainon home, and I really don’t want to just call a car and leave him be. Would you perhaps do us a favor of bringing him home? I can give you his address and call a car for you too.”

Mydei swore his heart completely stopped, and the breath caught in his throat as he stared at Cyrene with the best straight face that he could muster. Too many things were already happening within her one question. Take Phainon home? To Phainon's home address? Mydei would learn where Phainon lived? Mydei would see what kind of place Phainon lived in? He couldn't stop the anticipation from rushing his body and the excitement that filled his lungs. It was hard to breathe, and his brain was swirling with so many emotions that Mydei didn't know what to do with himself. His previous sleepy stupor had been washed away, replaced with the jitters and adrenaline from now having to take Phainon home. *To carry Phainon home*.

Mydei swallowed thickly in an attempt to mask any excitement leaking through his expression, and he feigned a deep sigh. “Give me his address. I don't mind. And no need to call a car.” He wouldn't be able to drive one anyway, since he drank. And he also didn't want to have to deal with a car. If Phainon lived close, it would be easier just to carry him back rather than wait for a driver and shove Phainon into the back of the car. And no, Mydei

definitely didn't want to carry Phainon all the way back and have him holding onto Mydei the entire journey to his place. That was definitely not his intention at all.

He handed Cyrene his phone with a map application pulled up, and she quickly typed in his address. They must be close if Cyrene had his home address committed to memory, but Mydei didn't want to think about that at the moment. He wanted to revel in the feeling of being able to spend time with Phainon for the first time in his life, even if the guy was drunk out of his mind and even if this woman knew Phainon so well she knew his address by heart.

“He doesn't live far from here.” Cyrene turned the phone screen toward Mydei, illuminating his face in the dim restaurant with the directions to his apartment. “It's just a humble apartment a few blocks down from here.”

Taking his phone from Cyrene's grasp, Mydei nodded after studying the route for a few moments. It was barely a ten-minute walk from the restaurant, and Mydei refused the part of his brain that wished the walk was longer. “Get home safe.”

“Thank you!” Cyrene rushed to stand from her chair, giving Mydei access to the blacked-out man. He bent down until he was almost eye-level with the smiling man, and he threw one of Phainon's arms around his shoulders, careful not to stare too deeply into his deep, blue eyes.

“Thank you, Mydei.” The other woman staying back with Cyrene nodded in his direction. He faintly remembered her to be in employee relations, also in the human resources department; her name was Castorice, Mydei could recall.

“Castorice?” Phainon squinted at the woman who was across from them, leaning forward as if trying to get a better look at her. “How are you carrying me from that far away?”

Cyrene started rapidly heaving, shutting her eyes in an attempt to hold in her laughter. Mydei could already tell this was going to be a long night, and

they hadn't even left the restaurant yet. “I hope… he doesn't cause you much trouble, Mydei.”

Mydei huffed exasperatedly as he led Phainon out of the dining area. But he didn't get very far before Phainon started continuing his previous words.

“Castorice… I didn't realize you were strong enough to carry me. You know how much I bench, right? Why haven't we ever gone to the gym together if you're this strong? My arms are my favorite part about me, you know. I could definitely be your spotter!”

Mydei was trying really hard not to roll his eyes, laugh, and a combination of both. He was also trying not to imagine himself at the gym with Phainon. He really, really did not need an image of Phainon exercising. “I'm not Castorice.”

“Woah! Castorice, are you sick? Your voice is so deep!”

“I'm not Castorice.”

“Your voice is so…” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. They had just made it to the exit, and the cool night air immediately washed over Mydei's burning face. Whether from the alcohol or from the gorgeous man pulling down on his shoulders, Mydei didn't know. But, Phainon's next words definitely confirmed that his burning face was not due to the alcohol at all.

“Your voice is so deep. And husky. It's really… nice.”

He almost wanted to throw Phainon to the floor and leave him right on the sidewalk. They had just taken maybe three steps out of the restaurant, and Mydei’s heart already felt like it would explode from pounding too fast. He stumbled in his steps, trying his best not to actually drop the other man, but he couldn't help it when his words kept repeating in his mind.

Rapidly shaking his head, Mydei tried his best to continue stumbling forward, following the route on his phone and shifting Phainon on his shoulders whenever the weight of him began slipping off. Phainon had no idea who he was talking to at the moment. Mydei needed to get it through

to his head that *Phainon would never say these words to him if he knew who Mydei was.*

Mydei never knew how to treat people that he cared for, and he had ended up pushing Phainon away from work because of it. Because he thought that was what he was supposed to do. But Mydei quickly realized that Phainon hated him, from the way Phainon blatantly ignored him in the office and the way he always looked like he would rather be anywhere else except for Mydei's office whenever he was passing him documents. Yet, those times were always Mydei's favorite part of the day, even if Phainon hated it there. He was sure… it was too late to mend their relationship.

“You're so pretty.”

Mydei’s steps and his thoughts immediately halted, and he had to fumble to catch Phainon almost instantly after stopping or else the guy was actually going to roll all over the floor. He had to constantly remind himself that *Phainon had no idea who was taking him home.* “Do you even know who I am?”

Phainon hummed, and much to Mydei's embarrassment and discomfort, the man began leaning toward him, frowning and squinting at Mydei’s complexion as if the answer would come to him despite his drunken stupor.

“I used to have blonde hair.” Phainon suddenly laughed loudly, and Mydei’s body grew rigid, frozen in place when two hands began running through his hair. Shivers rushed down his spine as Mydei's eyes grew wide at the other man. He was in such a shock that he couldn't even swat the hands that were tugging on his hair strands, but he also couldn't help the deep pleasure that was stirring in his gut.

“My hair was a little longer than it is now, and I dyed my entire head blonde. It was in college. I used to think I was *so* cool and edgy back in the day.”

Mydei did his best to muster a glare toward the other man, but it was blatantly ignored as Phainon continued ranting. They were barely even a couple of meters away from the restaurant door, and Mydei could turn

around and still faintly see the entrance around the corner. Yet, Mydei could barely bring himself to move.

“I don't know why I dyed my hair blonde.” Phainon hummed once more as he continued his nonsensical rant. “Maybe I thought it was cool? That only cool people have blonde hair? Is that why you have blonde hair? Because you're cool? Cool and pretty?”

A scoff came out of Mydei as he rolled his eyes. *Phainon had no idea who was taking him home.* “Is that all that comes out of your mouth? Nonsense and empty compliments?”

“But they're not empty.” Phainon shoved his face right into Mydei's, who flinched at the sudden proximity. He couldn't even back away, even if he wanted to, because the guy’s arm was literally thrown over his shoulders. “You're really… really pretty.” His voice lowered into a whisper, and it didn't escape Mydei’s wide, trembling eyes when his glazed-over gaze dropped down to Mydei's parted lips.

Phainon had no idea who was taking him home. Phainon had no idea who was taking him home.

With a sharp clear of his throat that rang in the depths of the night, Mydei tore his eyes away and began stumbling in his steps in the direction of Phainon's apartment. Phainon's body jolted with every step, and Mydei had to stop and adjust him on his shoulders every now and then, since Phainon's body refused to walk alongside Mydei and was just letting him drag his limp body all around the city. That, coupled with the fact that the adrenaline in Mydei's body was beginning to wear down, the initial tiredness that he had was starting to wash over him once more. Despite all that, the alcohol kept his heart madly pumping. Or maybe it was the scent of the other man hanging off his shoulders; Mydei would never know.

It was quiet now between the two men–the quietest since Mydei had picked Phainon up. The silver-haired man finally shut his mouth, much to Mydei's relief. He wasn’t sure how long his alcohol-riddled brain could take of Phainon's scent, Phainon's laugh, Phainon's voice, and Phainon's smile. He had never had the pleasure of being so close to the object of his affection

before, and even though he should've kept his mouth shut and reveled in the silence between them, the alcohol and his pounding heart made him open his mouth once again, eager to enjoy as much as Phainon's presence as he ever could until he could no longer speak with this man like this ever again.

“What else happened when you were young?” Mydei couldn't stop smiling, imagining Phainon with slightly longer, blonder hair. He hoped one day he would be able to see old pictures of Phainon in his college days, but Mydei knew that was just wishful thinking. His heart ached at the thought, but he tried to bury it away as much as he could.

Phainon had no idea who was taking him home.

“*Hmm*, I used to have a dog.” Mydei was surprised that Phainon actually entertained his question. Maybe because he was still drunk out of his mind, but he thought Phainon would've fallen asleep by now. “And… I didn't live in the city before.”

“You didn't?” Mydei’s eyes slightly widened once more at the news, tightening his hold around Phainon and shifting him upwards on his shoulders once again.

Phainon rapidly shook his head as he was jolted up onto Mydei’s shoulders. “Not at all! We moved here when we were young.”

“'We?’ Your family?” Mydei could only assume the people Phainon moved with were family.

“Yeah! My family.” Phainon smiled softly when he responded, seeming to reminisce about his family. At his gentle expression, Mydei thought to himself, how nice it was for one of them not to have a dysfunctional family. At least Phainon's parents didn't try to kill each other.

“Why did your family move?”

“There was nothing left for us in that small town anymore.”

Mydei furrowed his eyebrows. What a vague response. And why did Phainon sound so… wistful? “Nothing left?”

“There's more to do out here than in the countryside.”

That response did make more sense. It was a true fact that there were more things to do, more people to talk to, and more sights to see in the city rather than in the countryside. Mydei could've never imagined that Phainon was a country boy, but there was still something with his vague responses that left Mydei curious. Almost as if there were another reason Phainon left, but Mydei didn't want to push it. What mattered was that Phainon still had a loving family with him despite leaving his hometown, right? At least Phainon had something going for him.

With his brain quickly wiping an image of a farm boy Phainon, the silence settled over them once more. Mydei had to stop every few steps to shift Phainon onto his shoulders more comfortably, as he kept slipping off. And every time, Phainon would laugh as he was shaken onto Mydei's shoulders, with the night sky and the city lights twinkling in his hazy blue eyes. And every time, Mydei had to tear his gaze away and ignore his alcohol-riddled brain.

Phainon had no idea who was taking him home.

Mydei was having so much trouble trying to carry Phainon, who still refused to walk alongside him. He was heaving for breath, sweating in the cool night air, and his entire body burned from the workout of carrying a grown adult man, while tired from a single glass of alcohol and a lack of sleep. Mydei was supposed to be in bed by now, obliviously sleeping his night away to wake up for the bakery tomorrow. Yet here he was, with still about half of the trip left, on the way to his crush's apartment, with said crush dazed out of his mind and slumped all over Mydei’s shoulders.

His intoxicated brain was still trying to come up with different topics of discussion. Mydei wanted to keep talking with him, holding him, and making the trip back to his apartment longer than it should be. But Mydei didn't know a single thing about this man. He didn't know what to ask at all, and he didn't know what the other man would possibly be interested in or

entertain. It was as if this silence that was also hanging off Mydei’s shoulders only emphasized how much of a stranger Phainon was to him, and how distant their relationship really was.

“Hey!”

It was Mydei's turn to almost topple onto the floor when Phainon suddenly straightened up and stared into the street. A glare immediately grew on Mydei's expression as he barely caught himself from landing face-first onto the floor. And even then, his body, pumping with alcohol, did not mind in the slightest.

“What?” Mydei sighed tiredly. He was trying to stare into the street, following Phainon's attention, but it was just a normal city street, with the traffic lights flickering on and off, pedestrians walking about, and cars lining the roads.

“I can take you home!” Phainon ripped his arms away from Mydei’s shoulders and immediately fell onto the floor with a loud *thump*, and Mydei coughed loudly to cover the laughs of Phainon strewn about at his feet. “*Ow*,” Phainon groaned, rolling over onto his back. His silver hair was in a complete state of disarray, and he clutched his forehead with his hands. “Fuck, okay, that hurt.”

A deep, shaky sigh shook Mydei’s chest as he buried away his laughter. He bent down to reach for Phainon's wrist, and his burning face from the alcohol flared up when his fingers became interlocked with Phainon's, who had already reached up for him.

“Do you see that motorcycle?” Phainon tightly held Mydei’s hand, neither allowing him to pull him up nor move away. The man was jutting his head toward the street, and with a puzzled expression, Mydei eventually tore his gaze from their interlocked hands and the sparkling blue eyes to find a simple motorcycle parked on the side of the street.

“Yes?” Mydei could not even begin to imagine what was so important that Phainon had to go floundering onto the floor for it.

“I can take you home!” His face beamed with pride, as if Phainon could actually drive a motorcycle in this state.

Mydei stared blankly at the man still sitting on the floor, with their hands still tightly clasped together. His alcohol-powered brain could barely process what this drunk man was trying to say. “...What?”

“I'll drive that motorcycle home! And I can drop you off too!”

His brain was still not processing a single word coming out of those stupidly beautiful lips. There were so many problems with this. Phainon was drunk. Phainon cannot drive in this state. Phainon cannot drive a *motorcycle*. Phainon did not have a *motorcycle license*. And the most important fact of them all, that even Mydei barely remembered, was that *the motorcycle did not even belong to either of them.*

“No.”

“Why not?!”

“You can't drive a motorcycle.”

“I can!”

With their hands still holding each other, Phainon began wildly searching his pockets for his wallet with only a single free hand, but Mydei was mostly impressed that the wallet was even on his person still. And it was a few minutes later–yes, Mydei literally stood there for *minutes*–until Phainon finally unearthed a leather wallet from his back pocket.

Golden eyes darted between the wallet and Phainon's shining eyes, and with a deep, skeptical frown, Mydei took the wallet with his free hand. As well as he could, Mydei opened the wallet, eyes widening at his driver's license with the class M1 endorsement along with the normal class C, meaning he could legally operate a motorcycle and a car.

“...Why do you have this?”

“I told you, I can drive that motorcycle!”

Mydei still could not believe he was staring at Phainon's driver's license. Ignoring how gorgeous Phainon actually looked in this government ID photo, Mydei kept blinking at the M1 class as if it would disappear before his very eyes. Was Phainon trying to be cool and edgy in college with dyed blonde hair and a motorcycle? What was young Phainon even doing in school? His brain immediately conjured an image of university student Phainon, with blonde hair and a motorcycle, and he swore his burning face and his palpitating heart would explode with how quickly it agreed with that image.

Swallowing thickly at the enticing image, Mydei pocketed the wallet, as he wasn't sure if he could ever stick it inside Phainon's pockets while he was floundering about on the floor. Mydei planned to just leave it on a counter or something once they arrived at Phainon's apartment.

“You still can't drive that motorcycle.”

“Why not?!”

Mydei immediately froze at the sight before him. Phainon was *pouting* up at him, sticking out his bottom lip with tears gathering in the corners of his eyes from being rejected. He had the most breathtaking puppy eyes that Mydei had ever seen, and with another thick swallow, he forced his gaze back to the motorcycle Phainon tried to steal. He was sure that if Phainon ever flashed that pitiful expression to Mydei again, Mydei would relinquish all his mortal possessions to this man.

“That… motorcycle isn't yours.” Mydei had to force the words out of his tightening throat. His brain never forgot that he was still holding hands with Phainon.

“But there's no one using it.”

“You can't just take it.”

“I'll return it! I'm just borrowing it.”

“You cannot just borrow something without the owner's permission.”

“Then, I'll ask!”

“You cannot…” Mydei groaned. Why was he having such a useless conversation with a drunk man? They were barely even halfway to Phainon's apartment now, and the owner of said apartment still refused to be pulled up from the sidewalk.

Phainon's laughter rang through the air once more, making even Mydei's ears burn from the sweet, pleasant sound. “You're so funny, Mydei.”

“I didn't even say any–”

Did Phainon just say his name?

Golden eyes that were previously glued to some stranger's motorcycle immediately locked with blue eyes, who stared back at Mydei with a curious, inquisitive emotion swirling in them. Phainon adorably tilted his head to the side at the shock that was clearly written all over Mydei's face. “What?”

“You know who I am?”

“My… coworker?” Phainon raised an eyebrow, with a stupid smile still on his lips. Yep, Phainon was still drunk. But he seemed to be regaining some semblance of sanity. Were they really out here for that long?

“And you don't hate yourself right now?” Mydei would've expected Phainon to push himself off the floor and drag himself back to his apartment if he knew Mydei was the one bringing him home. In fact, Phainon didn't move at all, and their hands were still tightly bound together.

“Why would I hate myself?” Phainon laughed, but it was suddenly cut short. “I mean… Maybe I do. But why would that be happening right now?”

“Because you hate me.”

“*You* hate me,” Phainon corrected. “*I* don't hate you.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. Phainon didn't hate him? “I don't hate you.”

“You do.”

“I don't.”

“But you do!” It was Phainon’s turn to groan dramatically. He was still slightly slurring his words from his intoxicated state, but at least the words he was spouting actually made some sense now. “Don't act like you ignore me at work every day, glare at me every day, and don't even know my name. I even memorized your car and where you park just so that I can stay out of your sight.”

“I…” Mydei’s voice didn't dare speak. Was that what it looked like to Phainon? Why would Phainon think Mydei never knew his name? And, Phainon really memorized where Mydei parked just to avoid him?

A tug against his clasped hand, and Mydei barely instinctively caught himself, throwing a step forward and rooting himself in place on the sidewalk while Phainon pulled himself to his feet all on his own.

“You're not saying anything because it's true, right?” Phainon chuckled lowly. “That's okay, Mydei. Just take me home.”

“I don't hate you.”

“I don't mind that you hate me, Mydei.” The man flashed a grin, swinging his arm back over Mydei's shoulders. “I don't mind at all.”

“But I don't hate you.”

“Do you think I could get away with taking the motorcycle?”

“*Why* are we back on the motorcycle again?”

With a laugh that shook against Mydei's shoulders, Mydei stumbled as best as he could with Phainon leaning on him once more. Maybe it was because Phainon’s sanity was starting to return, but the man was actually walking alongside him this time; well, it was more akin to stumbling, but Mydei

would take anything over literally dragging the man like he was doing earlier. But with Mydei's emotions being heightened from the alcohol pumping through his veins, and his mind swirling with their past conversation that ended on a sour note, Mydei could not stop his mouth from opening once again.

“I like you, Phainon.”

“Yeah, and I can go steal that motorcycle.”

“I really…” Mydei's steps slowed until he was at a complete stop, right in the middle of the sidewalk, and because Phainon was leaning against him, his steps eventually stopped as well.

Mydei's gaze was downcast, gritting his teeth and staring down at their feet. His vision was a little fuzzy, and he wasn't sure if the alcohol was taking over his mind or if it was just simply too dark to see outside. How much had Mydei pushed Phainon away that the man couldn't even believe Mydei's own words? That the man firmly believed Mydei didn't even know his name?

There was a part of Mydei that was screaming for him to stop. There was a part of Mydei reminding him that this drunk Phainon wasn't Phainon, and he would forget everything that happened that night. There was even a part of Mydei telling him that, even if this really was Phainon standing against him, that he wouldn't care for a single word that Mydei spoke. But his heart was pounding so loudly that it was ringing in his ears and taking over his entire rattling chest, and Mydei couldn't think of anything else except for the words that disobeyed all of Mydei's thoughts and instincts and eventually slipped from his parted, hesitant lips.

“I really… like you, Phainon.”

It was silent between the two men once more, with only the whistling of the night breeze filling the air and rushing through their hair and clothes. Mydei kept his gaze glued to the floor, with his hand holding Phainon completely still. He didn't dare look at Phainon, and he didn't dare see what kind of expression he held.

He mentally shook his head, willing his feet to move once more, causing the other man leaning against him to follow. Why was he bothering to have this kind of conversation with a drunk man? It was already too late to salvage their relationship, and Phainon was just going to forget all of this tomorrow when he was sober again.

“Do you really?” A slow voice next to Mydei’s head eventually broke the silence. Mydei just wanted to move on from this conversation that was making his head hurt and his throat burn, but Mydei's stupidly intoxicated brain could not stop himself from parting his lips once more.

“I know your name, Phainon. And I… look for you, every day. I want to talk to you, everyday. But I thought you hated me.”

“I thought *you* hated *me*, so *I* didn't talk to *you*.” Phainon abruptly stopped, slipping his arm from Mydei's shoulder and tugging on Mydei’s hand to stop with him. “Why do you treat me like that then? Just talk to me if you want to.”

Stop having this conversation with Phainon. *Stop having this conversation with Phainon.*

Mydei's head was ringing. His eyes were burning. His heart was aching. And his entire body was shaking, blaring alarm bells in his ears. But nothing in his body would listen to his brain, which was still being run by a single glass of wine.

“I don't know how to act around people I like.”

Another silence settled on the two men. Mydei still had his eyes glued to their shoes, refusing to see what kind of confused, or maybe even disgusted, expression lay along Phainon's beautiful face.

For his entire life, Mydei had been alone. Ever since his mother passed, he had been alone all his life. So for someone like him, to accidentally stumble upon someone that he had never felt this way about before, shook Mydei so heavily in his core and in his heart that he didn't know what to do. That he didn't know how to deal with how he felt and how to act. So he closed

himself off and shut himself away as a horrible excuse for a defense mechanism, relying on a children's book his mother had gotten for him a long time ago to teach him how to act. Because it was the only thing left from his mother that could tell him anything. Because his mother, the only person who had ever accepted him, was no longer here to help him.

His body violently trembled in place, with a deep scowl etched upon his lips, at the horrid silence that still ran through the two men. His hand was still being held by Phainon's, so maybe, just maybe, the man wasn't disgusted by him. Or maybe, Phainon was in such shock that he couldn't get his body to react or move away.

A laugh echoed in the night sky, jolting Mydei’s trembling body. His glistening eyes shot up at the sudden sound, watching with wide, incredulous eyes as Phainon's body shook with laughter. The man still had his hand tightly interlocked with Mydei's as he was bending forward, laughing maniacally with his eyes brimming with tears. Mydei was in too much of a shock to even think about why Phainon was laughing. Maybe he thought Mydei was just so stupid that he couldn't help but laugh?

“You… like me?” Phainon's back finally straightened after a fit of laughter, swiping the glistening corners of his eyes with his free hand.

Mydei didn't know what to say. Was there a correct answer to this question? Was Phainon going to immediately report to employee relations in his own department for harassment tomorrow at work? Or, was Phainon still so drunk out of his mind that his brain couldn't process what Mydei had said?

Another tug against his hand, and Mydei stumbled forward and barely caught himself again. His head was bowed low, trying to focus on not hitting the ground, but his body froze when the voice above him spoke.

“I like you too, Mydei.”

Mydei's head was still bowed low, refusing to straighten his posture and lock eyes with Phainon once more. He wasn't sure if he could handle Phainon's gentle tone of voice, his words, his smile, or his laughter anymore. He wasn't sure if his heart could take it anymore, which was

squeezing in his chest from the lies being spouted his way. The wonderful and beautiful lies that sounded so sweet in Mydei's ears. He wished they were true, and he wanted to convince his own intoxicated brain to believe they were true.

"Let's just get you home." Mydei turned around, finally standing upright, and dragged Phainon with him. He could hear the man stumbling to catch up as he was tugged along, but Mydei didn't want to look at the other man anymore, cursing his own brain for dragging out a conversation that didn't need to happen at all.

Phainon had no idea who was taking him home. Phainon was going to forget this entire night ever happened and wake up the next morning, oblivious to this entire conversation and oblivious to the lies he had tempted Mydei with.

"I mean it, Mydei."

Mydei's steps slightly faltered at his voice, but he continued dragging Phainon along behind him. He shouldn't believe the temptations that were ringing behind his back. Not even for a second.

"You should talk to me tomorrow."

Mydei sighed at his insistence. "Just be quiet."

"Hang out with me tomorrow."

"Be quiet."

"Let's get dinner tomorrow."

Mydei finally whipped around on his feet, seething and shooting the nastiest glare Mydei had ever had upon his face. It felt like his head was going to explode from the flaring heat and the pumping blood circulating in his veins. "*Shut the fuck up, Phainon*."

"Remind me tomorrow." The hand holding his tightened so much that it almost knocked the breath out of Mydei's chest. The expression across

Phainon's face didn't reveal an ounce of falsehood, and it shook Mydei in his core that he looked completely serious, as if he truly meant every single word that was spilling out of his lovely lips. “Tell me what I told you today.”

“You won't remember.”

“Then, jog my memory for me.”

“And why should I do that for you?”

“Because you like me.” A confident smirk and a confident step toward Mydei's direction left him trembling, and he tore his gaze away from those deep blue eyes that seemed to see everything that Mydei was hiding. “And I like you too.”

“Stop lying.”

“I’m not lying.”

“What could you possibly like about me?” Mydei chuckled dryly. “Didn't you say I didn't even know your name? That all I do is glare at you and ignore you? At least act disgusted instead of lying to my face.”

“You're cute, Mydei.” A hand suddenly cradled Mydei's cheek, and he jumped at the unexpected contact. But his brain refused to let go of a single word being spoken in Phainon's voice. “You're so adorable and lovely, Mydei. Why don't you give me a chance?”

“My feelings for you run deeper than just ‘cute’.” Mydei spat, glaring at the man who had begun circling a gentle thumb against his skin.

“Then, give me a chance to make it up to you.” Phainon smiled, seemingly unaffected by Mydei's nasty attitude. “I promise, I'll make it up to you.”

“And why should I listen to you?”

“Because you like me?”

Mydei clicked his tongue, pivoting on his feet, but Phainon's hands tugged at him again until he couldn't run away again.

“I'm a man of my word, Mydei.” Phainon’s voice had lowered to a whisper, and his eyes and his voice and his entire body seemed to be pleading for Mydei’s attention. “Please, at least let me try.”

“You're just going to forget about this all tomorrow. Why should I bother entertaining you?”

“Because the me of tomorrow will start to annoy you.”

“*What?”*

Was Phainon claiming to see the future now? How in hell was Phainon planning on annoying Mydei tomorrow at work when he wasn't even going to remember this entire night?

At his extreme confusion, Phainon chuckled. “The me of tomorrow is going to figure out that you took me home, and he's going to incessantly bother you for the truth.”

“Why would you care so much about what happened today?”

“Because I like you.” Phainon leaned in close–*too* close. The proximity, his warm breath, and his tender, gentle eyes were all too much for Mydei to handle, and his body began shaking again. But he couldn't bring himself to move under the passionate gaze being directed at him. “The Phainon of tomorrow doesn't know it, but *I* know it. And he's going to bother you tomorrow because he likes you. Not because not knowing the truth is going to bother him, but because he wants to talk to you, and he has an excuse now to do so.”

Mydei scoffed, averting his eyes and trying to ignore his own blushing face. “What nonsense.”

“I… have always wanted to talk to you, Mydei. And I really wanted to be close to you. It hurt that you didn't want to talk to me, and I just chalked it

up to you hating me.” Phainon laughed weakly. “Knowing this whole time that you actually liked me… makes me really, really happy. And I'm sure it'll make the Phainon of tomorrow happy too.”

Mydei wanted to roll his eyes at those words, but he couldn't. Deep down, there was a part of him that wanted to believe Phainon. That maybe, even after everything Mydei had gone through and everything that he had done to Phainon, he could still like him too.

“Please remind me tomorrow?” His warm breath ghosted Mydei, and he gulped at their growing proximity. Phainon was dangerously close now, with the tips of their noses even brushing against each other. “At least… Don't give up on me.”

“Give up on you?” Mydei raised an eyebrow at him. What a vague sentence. It certainly caught Mydei by surprise.

But what surprised him more was the pitiful expression and the weak smile that was on Phainon's face. Mydei had to stop himself from bringing his hands up to wipe that expression away. Someone like Phainon didn't ever deserve to have that expression on his face.

“Treat me normally tomorrow.” Phainon seemed to have come to some resolve in his drunken state. “At least… Treat me as you usually do. Don't tell me anything, and don't explain anything. But don't give up on me. No matter what I do.”

Mydei was desperately trying to search Phainon's saddened gaze and his conflicted expression, but Mydei hadn't the slightest clue what drunk Phainon was even talking about. Should he even believe any words that were coming out of this guy's mouth? What if this was all just drunken drivel that Phainon was saying? What did drunk Phainon mean by those words? Did they actually mean anything?

“I have…” Phainon laughed quietly, more at himself than anything else. “So much more confidence while drunk. I feel good right now. Really good. I want to kiss you, Mydei.”

Those words shook Mydei deeply in the pit of his stomach, and his wide eyes trembled at the blue ones that were flickering between golden eyes and something much lower on his face. Mydei’s lips quivered at the obvious and unashamed eye contact, clearly aware of how blatantly Phainon was staring at him.

“What?” Mydei could barely get the words to leave his mouth, and his voice cracked at how much they were forced out of his throat.

“Kiss me, Mydei?”

“*Mmph!*”

It was the fastest Mydei had ever walked. He was practically running down the sidewalk as Phainon pulled him along, pulling him toward the apartment that drunk Phainon suddenly remembered the location of. After Phainon had popped that question, Mydei's entire body was taken over by the alcohol, the adrenaline, and his own greedy feelings for the other man, and here he was, pinned against the object of his affection, who wouldn't even remember a single word spoken between them the following day.

Mydei's back slammed against the closed front door, held back by Phainon's persistent lips and his strong hands grasping his waist. Mydei's alcohol-riddled brain could barely keep up with what was even happening, and he could barely even stop himself from doing anything the two men might regret because there was only one thought currently swirling in his mind.

Mydei felt so good.

He wrapped his arms around Phainon's shoulders as he was pushed against the door, grinding his hips along the knee that had slotted itself between his legs. His eyes were shut, his hands were running through and tugging on silver hair, and he was gasping and panting and moaning against soft lips and a tongue that had breached past his parted lips to run along his teeth, his tongue, the roof of his mouth, and every single little inch of Mydei's insides.

Mydei could barely breathe. Mydei could barely even think. His entire body was being consumed by the pleasure running through his body, the electricity that shot through his veins, and the heat flaring in his stomach from the persistent tongue that was sliding against him and the knee that he couldn't stop his hips from rutting against. Hands pulled at his waistband, with curious fingertips peaking into his shirt, and Mydei moaned at the hot hands that wrapped around his bare waist, pushing his shirt aside to grasp hungrily at his skin.

“Bed… Bedroom,” Mydei gasped between slurping tongues and clinking of teeth. Drunk Phainon was practically eating him alive, biting at his lips and sucking on his tongue. And his eyes kept rolling into the back of his head at every suck and bite that sent pleasure straight into his core and every grind against the warmth quickly coming to life between his legs. Mydei threw his head back, digging his nails into Phainon's shoulders and moaning once more when teeth messily nipped at his neck, tracing his red tattoos all the way down to the collar of his dress shirt.

Hot, impatient breaths panted against his skin, with teeth tugging on the tie around Mydei's neck until it slumped onto the floor. Greedy hands pushed the shirt up Mydei's torso, revealing more of his crimson red tattoos to the cool, night air. Mydei shivered at the temperature but was quickly encapsulated by the warmth of Phainon's skin pressing against him, running along his abdomen, and leaving marks all over his neck. A click of annoyance sounded in front of Mydei, but he could barely process it before hands began grabbing at his collar.

“*Off*.” Phainon's voice was deep, husky, and commanding, and his blue eyes were completely dilated and hazy with lust. Mydei was experiencing shivers for an entirely different reason now. Shaky hands unrooted themselves from Phainon's shoulders to begin unbuttoning his dress shirt, with hungry eyes watching every slight movement from him in the dark. Warm hands never left his waist, no matter how much of Mydei's bare torso started being revealed, and when the sound of his shirt hitting the ground broke their silence, Mydei was immediately whisked away into the apartment. He barely even had time to look around to see what sort of place

Phainon lived in before a door was roughly kicked open, and Mydei was tossed onto a mattress.

He faintly registered Phainon tearing off his own clothes, and Mydei's heart stopped at the sight of lean, sculpted muscle shimmering in the moonlight that cascaded through the window. A slender waist that led down to delicious hips that were becoming uncovered from the slacks they were hiding behind, and Mydei instinctively swallowed at the seductive sight of Phainon hurriedly throwing his own clothes onto the floor.

“Why are your clothes still on?”

Phainon had two hands planted on either side of Mydei on the bed, staring dangerously into his golden eyes as Mydei was shaken from his lust-filled stupor. Phainon was only left in his underwear now, and a deep yearning swirled in the pit of Mydei's stomach at the faint sight he could only catch because of the moonlight.

Before Mydei could make a move, his slacks were pulled off in one clean motion and quickly discarded onto the floor. Hands shoved him backward into the bed as he was also left in just his underwear, and a blush burned all the way down to his chest when Phainon slid his fingertips against his inner thighs, peeling his legs apart and climbing between them. The sight of Phainon kneeling between his legs, slotting his thighs right underneath Mydei's, made his erection twitch against his underwear and pulse against the bulge that was now roughly pushing against his.

Phainon was hard. It was the new thought repeating in Mydei's mind, echoing in his brain even when those same greedy hands wrapped around his bare waist, pushing him down to grind against the bulge that was already rubbing against him.

A wanton moan left Mydei's parted lips as the other man began rutting against him, thrusting his clothed erection onto Mydei's and pushing Mydei's body against him. His head flew forward in silent screams and desperate gasps, and his hands flew to the hands digging into his waist. Phainon was thrusting against him so roughly, almost as if they were actually fucking, and Mydei was being pushed against the bed and jolting

up and down with every thrust from how harshly Phainon was rutting his hips against him.

Mydei couldn't stop his own precum from staining the front of his underwear with every shot of pleasure and heat that rushed his body with every thrust from the other man, and his feet and clenching toes dug into the sheets to stop himself from being pushed away from the heat pressing against his dick that was quivering in delight with every grind of the other hard, leaking cock. And Mydei cursed to himself, drooling over how big Phainon felt against him, desperate to feel more of Phainon on top of him and pinning his body down. So Mydei began returning his own thrusts against Phainon's twitching bulge, feeling his clothed erection even closer against him and eliciting more moans out of his mouth.

The view above him was even a sight Mydei couldn't tear his eyes away from, even with how much his vision began to blur. Phainon's eyebrows furrowed in concentration, with his teeth gnawing at his bottom lip. His silver bangs were beginning to stick to his forehead from the sweat that glistened off his sculpted body, and his face was flushed red and spread all the way down to his chest. With warm hands still grasping Mydei's waist, delicious grunts and groans slipped past his lips that Mydei wished he could hear forever, and every so often, Phainon's eyes fluttered shut from the pleasure pulsing from his bottom half. Phainon looked *so hot* in bed, and it only sent the blood rushing to his already hard dick.

"*Ahh!* Phainon! Phai–*Wait!*" Mydei gritted his teeth in an attempt to bury his moans. His underwear was becoming soaked in precum, and his eyes brimmed with tears as the pleasure wracked Mydei's entire body. His skin was so hot, his stomach tightened, and his hips jolted in an oncoming orgasm that he was trying to stave away. He didn't want to soil his own underwear, as it was the only clothes Mydei had come in, but Phainon's pace didn't slow in the slightest.

Silver hair brushed against Mydei's chin as Phainon bent down, lapping at Mydei's collarbone and sucking along his skin. Another deep moan shook Mydei's body as his legs began to spread wider, trembling open as Phainon continued roughly grinding their erections together. They were pressing so hard together that it almost hurt, yet Mydei's quaking legs were open as

wide as he could make them, with Phainon slotted right between them, leaving marks all over Mydei's neck and moving down to his chest.

Just a single touch against his nipples, and Mydei’s entire body spasmed against the other man. His chest tickled. His chest hurt. And his chest wanted more of Phainon's tongue that was sucking around them and his teeth that were biting and teasing the pointed nubs. Phainon was alternating between each nipple, flattening his tongue along the insatiable bud and sucking as hard as he could. Moans were spilling from Mydei's lips, and he couldn't even tell from the pleasure overtaking his chest and below his waist if he had even cum or not. Golden eyes were already rolled back into his head, his back was arching off the bed, and his legs were shaking so violently it really did feel like Mydei was cumming.

With a brush against his nipples from Phainon's teeth, Mydei's body spasmed again as he screamed. His hands tightened around Phainon's wrists, where his hands were still keeping Mydei's waist captive as the hardest orgasm Mydei had ever experienced ripped through his body without a warning. His vision completely turned white, his back felt like it was going to snap, and his feet lifted into the air and clenched around nothing as he came the hardest he ever had. Mydei's body shook violently against the bed with his mouth completely ajar, and his hearing was blown out until all he could finally hear were his own embarrassing whimpers and pants from recovering from that amazing orgasm.

His body washed in utter and complete shame as his feet finally found the sheets once more. Mydei's chest was heaving for breath to fill his lungs once more, and his vision finally returned to find a dangerous emotion swirling in blue eyes.

“Did you like that, my love?”

Mydei's face immediately burned at Phainon's words, and he mustered a weak scoff while trying to swallow and soothe his drying throat. “*My love?”*

Phainon laughed, his beautiful lips turning up into a cheeky smile. “Don't you like it?”

“I don't remember ever being *your love*.”

A thrust against Mydei's recovering dick completely silenced him, and a sharp gasp rang through the air as Phainon laughed once more.

“Do you remember cumming in your underwear then? Or are you going to say you forgot that too?”

Mydei clicked his tongue, his entire vision turning red from how much his body burned. He shot a glare up at the silver-haired man who had a sly smirk still dancing across his lips. “Then take them off.”

“Gladly.”

His hands deftly peeled off his soaked underwear, tossing them somewhere onto the floor. The cold air immediately washed over Mydei's body, especially his dick that had just been suffocated in his underwear, and a shiver rushed down his spine at the change in temperature. But what stood in front of Mydei instead completely took his breath away, as his ears barely registered another dull *thump* of more clothes hitting the ground.

Phainon was completely naked right in front of him.

Completely naked. Completely bare. His dick was standing tall and proud and barely brushing against Mydei. Mydei had to bite his lip to stop the whines that threatened to escape with every slight touch of his dick against him, but he immediately threw his head back with a gasp when that same, hard length began pressing against his fluttering entrance that was already twitching for Phainon to enter inside.

Mydei didn't want Phainon to ask. He really, truly didn't want Phainon to ask, or he would probably explode in embarrassment. But Phainon could easily push himself inside right now because Mydei fingered himself to Phainon almost every single night. Especially on work days, where he actually spoke with Phainon, Mydei especially went crazy during those nights trying to satisfy himself. But much to his relief, Phainon asked a different question, although slightly related.

“How long have you been waiting for this, hm?”

The head of Phainon's dick dragged against Mydei's hole, and the ring of muscle caught onto every single vein there was on his shaft. Mydei gasped at every slight ridge that brushed against him and the twitching dick that refused to push inside, and he was trying so hard to still his quivering hips from pushing the heat inside entirely. “Phainon, *please*–”

“I know, my love. But I want to take this slow, okay?” Phainon leaned down, brushing his lips tenderly along Mydei's ears, and he swallowed thickly at the lips and the warm breath ghosting over him. Mydei couldn't even bring himself to respond. His entire body was *aching* for Phainon to fuck him deeply, and tears began gathering in his eyes just from how desperately his body desired Phainon's heat.

Phainon chuckled, lapping at the tears that spilled down Mydei's cheeks. “You're so beautiful, my love.”

Mydei gasped sharply once more when Phainon pressed himself against his entrance again. He was taking too long, teasing his dick along his aching hole and rubbing each and every vein there was on his pulsing dick. He swore his entrance was already trying to suck Phainon inside with every deep push against him, and his hole parted for Phainon's entry, wrapping deliciously around his tip, only for a shock of electricity to jolt Mydei's body and a moan to hang in the air every time Phainon flicked his tip right out of his fluttering hole.

“You…” Mydei gulped, lowering his chin after his head was thrown back from the pleasure that shocked his body. “Bastard.”

Phainon laughed. “Answer me, Mydei. How long have you been waiting for me?”

Hands dug into the sheets, where Mydei had planted them while watching Phainon strip their underwear off. How long was Mydei waiting for this? Phainon couldn't even begin to fathom the answer to that question. “Too long.”

With a smirk growing upon Phainon's lips, his warm hands returned to Mydei's waist, grasping tightly around him. “You are… going to be the death of me, Mydei.”

“I'd like to see you try and die before you get inside of me.” Mydei scoffed, ignoring his forgotten entrance that was still aching for Phainon's dick. “I told you, I've been waiting too long for this.”

Another laugh shook Phainon's chest once more. “For this? Or for me?”

Mydei's face immediately bloomed red at the question with an obvious answer, and with a frown and a glare shot in his way, he swung his arms around Phainon's neck, tugging him down and watching how Phainon threw out a hand, barely catching himself. Golden eyes stared deeply and resolutely into Phainon's wide eyes, whose breath hitched at their close proximity.

“For you, Phainon.”

His voice rang clearly in the air for both men to hear. Despite Mydei's blushing face or his uneven breaths, Mydei could feel deep in his chest just how true these words were to him. And with the way Phainon's eyes sparkled in response and the way his lips twitched upward into a soft smile, Mydei screamed when something big and hot immediately and unexpectedly pushed inside of him all at once, filling him up in one swift motion and making him feel full.

“You're so beautiful, my love.”

The words were barely registered by Mydei's brain when the thrust soon followed. A deep, guttural groan left Mydei's throat when Phainon began pummeling his dick inside, breaching a part of Mydei that no one had ever touched before. It was a breaking pace right from the start, with Phainon snapping his hips against Mydei as fast as he could.

Phainon's dick felt *so good*. Phainon's dick felt *amazing*. His hole was stretching around his girth, gobbling up his entire length with every deep thrust, and the burn was unimaginably good. It was a feeling that didn't

even compare to his own fingers, and Mydei's jaw went slack as moan after moan escaped his throat as he became a slave to the pleasure jolting his body with every drive of the man’s hips.

Mydei's own dick was already hard again, slapping against his stomach with every harsh thrust and spreading precum between the two naked, sweating bodies that were sliding against each other. His arms tightened around Phainon's neck as his legs spread wider once more, and Phainon scoffed incredulously as he leaned forward, angling his thrusts to a spot that Mydei didn't know even existed that had his back arching off the bed, his legs shaking in the air, and a scream ripping from his lips.

“Do you like it right there, my love?” Phainon's voice whispered in Mydei's ears, completely in contrast to the rough thrusts that were slapping against Mydei’s behind, echoing off the bedroom walls and making Mydei's face burn from how loud their naked bodies were and how loud Phainon's bed was creaking and rocking against the wall with every push.

“*MMM!* Just like that!” Mydei's fingernails began digging into Phainon's back, clawing at the skin as the familiar heat already began pooling in the pit of his stomach once again. He couldn't get enough of Phainon's dick stretching him open and at the pulsing shaft that was buried deep inside of him, brushing against every single one of his fluttering, insatiable walls. He couldn't get enough of the tip that was pressing so roughly against his sweet spot, and he couldn't get enough of the soft moans and pants right next to his ears, driving Mydei closer and closer to insanity.

Everything was too much for Mydei's alcohol-filled and lust-filled brain, and he could only moan at the pleasure ripping through his entire body. Mydei was so glad he didn't bring a condom with him, and he was so glad Phainon didn't put one on. Mydei had no idea this was how it would feel, and the heat that was continually pummeling into Mydei was making him lose his mind. All his mind could think of was how much he wanted Phainon deeper, how much harder he wanted Phainon to fuck him, and how much of Phainon's cum he wanted to be filled with. Nothing else mattered to Mydei right at this moment, and his insides tightened just at the mere thought of Phainon filling him up deep inside. Mydei mewled at the

sensation, feeling even more of Phainon's dick that was still driving inside of him at a breaking pace.

“*Hah.*… Are you close? Can you cum for me?”

Phainon's hot breath brushed against Mydei's ears once more, and his eyes rolled into the back of his head at the husky voice that vibrated against him. His opened legs continued shaking violently in the air, and two hands slipped right underneath his knees, pushing his legs back until they were almost pressed against the bed. Mydei moaned wantonly at the position as Phainon’s cock reached even deeper than before, as the clear sounds of his abused hole echoed through Mydei's ears.

The new position heightened every single feeling and every single sensation. It felt almost like Mydei was being bred, at the mercy of Phainon's deep thrusts. He could hear just how loud his hole was as it was being filled over and over by Phainon's dick. He could feel Phainon's balls slapping against his skin. And his twitching prostate was feeling more of Phainon's length pushing against him and releasing moan after moan from Mydei's forever parted lips. Mydei was basically being folded like a pretzel even after Phainon shifted Mydei's legs to hang over Phainon's shoulders, pinning him to the mattress and driving his hips forward.

Mydei couldn't take it anymore. He couldn't take the vulgar noises of their skinship reverberating through the room anymore. He couldn't handle how deeply he was being fucked. He couldn't handle the moans and gasps brushing against his ears and the soft groans of Mydei’s name. He couldn't handle his own leaking dick that was being suffocated between their bodies. And he couldn't handle the flaring pleasure that was tightening his stomach, spasming his body against the bed until his back sharply arched off the bed once again.

“*AHH!* PHAINON, I'M–”

It was the only sort of warning Mydei could give until his body violently shook as every limb in his body grew rigid. His vision turned white as he came, screaming Phainon's name at the top of his lungs as ropes of cum splattered between their bodies. He spilled himself all over their abdomens

and chests, moaning loudly into the air as his body jolted with every stream that shook his body as his hands tightly tugged at the sheets and his spread legs vibrated over Phainon's shoulders.

And it wasn't long before riding out his own orgasm that a deep groan pierced the air, and something warm began flooding Mydei's insides. Phainon moaned Mydei's name, burying his face into the crook of Mydei's neck as his body trembled as he came deep inside of Mydei, just like he wanted. He was filling Mydei up so good, and Mydei couldn't stop the whimpers that escaped his lips even after Phainon's length slipped out of Mydei's hole with a *pop.*

Both men were left panting for breath and covered in sweat. Mydei was also covered in cum as Phainon collapsed into the bed right beside Mydei. He wasn't exactly sure if Phainon had completely passed out, especially since he was drunk out of his mind, but Mydei could only hope that Phainon didn't mind Mydei using his bathroom to clean up.

Mydei could barely feel his own legs, and he hobbled to the only other door connected to the bedroom. Much to Mydei's relief, it really was the bathroom, and after figuring out how to use Phainon's shower, he cleaned himself of the sweat and cum that littered both outside and inside his body. He didn't want to dirty Phainon's bed anymore than they probably already did, and as the one who wasn't nearly as drunk and still had some energy, he made his way back to the bedroom to clean Phainon off as well, carrying a wet towel with him after he had dried himself off with a spare towel he had found in one of Phainon's bathroom cabinets.

Phainon groaned when Mydei flipped him over to wipe the cum he had gotten on him, and Mydei quietly let out a laugh. Phainon's eyes were shut as his breathing evened out, meaning that the man was definitely sleeping now.

It was too quiet in the apartment, with Mydei wringing the dirty towel out and throwing it into the hamper with the other towel he used after cleaning it as best as he could. He resolved to clean up their clothes tomorrow morning before returning to his place, as he soiled his underwear, and there was no chance he was going to work tomorrow with cum-filled underwear.

It was too quiet in the apartment. He did find his pants on the floor, and after digging through his pockets, he found his phone, his wallet, and Phainon's wallet with him. With another small smile to himself, he dug into Phainon's pockets, bringing out his keys so that Mydei could place them with his wallet on the counter before he forgot and actually took Phainon's wallet with him tomorrow morning. He also found Phainon's phone, which he plugged into the charger by the nearby nightstand.

It was too quiet in the apartment when he stepped out into the main area of the living space. Mydei placed the keys and wallet on the counter and picked up the tie and shirt that sat by the front door. Throwing them with the other clothes on the bedroom floor, Mydei crawled back into bed, right beside Phainon. His phone screen illuminated his face in the dark as he asked his other baker if they could open the shop for him tomorrow.

Mydei wanted… to spend his last remaining minutes of the night with Phainon.

Phainon wasn't going to remember. He wasn't going to remember a single minute of this night. His aching heart and his twisting chest refused to acknowledge that fact while he was walking around Phainon's apartment, but now that he was lying in Phainon's bed and enveloped so comfortingly in Phainon's scent, he couldn't stop the negative thoughts that crept into his mind. Mydei tossed his phone onto the nightstand right on top of Phainon's charging phone after setting an alarm, ignoring the tears that were quickly blurring his vision of the dark apartment.

Why did he even have that conversation with Phainon earlier? Why did he even sleep with the guy? Was Mydei out of his mind? Sure, Mydei could chalk it up to the both of them being intoxicated, but now Mydei was plenty sober and left with the consequences of his own inebriated actions. All he could do was lie here in complete and utter silence, reflecting on the night that he wished he could erase from his mind. If Phainon wasn't going to remember, what was the point in Mydei remembering?

Treat me as you usually do. Don't tell me anything, and don't explain anything. But don't give up on me. No matter what I do.

Mydei rapidly shook his head, turning in the bed and facing Phainon, who was still peacefully slumbering the night away. It was just drunken drivel. It didn't mean anything. It didn't mean anything at all. Phainon didn't mean a single word of this night. And Mydei needed to get that through in his head because *everything was going to return to normal tomorrow.* Even if Phainon happened to remember everything, or maybe even some things, *Phainon would regret this entire night.*

Phainon had no reason to like Mydei.

“Why are you crying?”

A gentle hand swiped along Mydei's cheek, and his body grew rigid. Blue, weary eyes were staring at him, blinking the sleep out of his eyes. Mydei let out a quiet laugh at how adorable the man in front of him looked, but Phainon furrowed his eyebrows.

“Why are you crying?” He repeated the question, and Mydei was immediately pulled into the warmth of the other man. Phainon had turned onto his side, facing Mydei, and had a strong arm wrapped around Mydei's waist, holding him close.

Mydei smiled, neglecting to answer. “Go to sleep, Phainon. You had a long night today.”

“Thank you for cleaning me up.” Phainon pecked a soft kiss on Mydei’s forehead, and Mydei mentally cursed at the tears that only continued to drip from the corners of his eyes.

“It's… no problem.” Mydei's throat burned with every syllable. It was getting hard to breathe, and he was trying to stop the tears from flowing before he soaked Phainon's sheets with his own tears. They were rushing down the side of his face, pooling endlessly in the palms of his hands despite his shaky efforts, and Mydei grew increasingly frustrated with himself that he couldn't stop crying over a *fact.*

Two hands eventually pushed Mydei's hands out of the way, and they began working on swiping Mydei's tears instead. His hands were so gentle with

him, and Mydei loved every brush of his fingertips along his skin. “Are you staying tonight?”

“Is that okay?” Mydei's voice was shaking, cracking, and weak. Mydei had never heard himself sound like this before. It didn't even sound like the voice had come out of Mydei at all.

“I want you to.” A hand riddled in Mydei's tears began cradling his cheek, and Mydei smiled into the soft touch.

“I'll make you something tomorrow, as a thank you.”

Phainon’s eyes slightly widened. “You can cook?”

“I can cook, but I was thinking of baking you something.”

“Why haven't you told me that before?”

Mydei laughed lightly. It was too quiet in the apartment. Every word being spoken echoed in his head. “We don't talk, Phainon.”

Phainon pouted adorably. “Then, we'll talk now. What kind of baking do you like best?”

He couldn't even believe they were having such a casual conversation. It felt like a dream, and he was even starting to forget the salty taste along his lips and the tears still gathering at the side of his face. “I like sweet pastries.”

“Sweet pastries?” Phainon hummed. “I wasn't expecting that from you.”

“I like everything sweet.”

“Really? I'll remember that then.”

A scoff of disbelief immediately left Mydei's lips. “I'll make you my favorite thing tomorrow.”

“What is it?”

“Golden honeycakes. It's a stack of fluffy pancakes topped with butter, syrup, and berries. Are you allergic? It uses blueberries, raspberries, and blackberries.”

Phainon shook his head. “That sounds really delicious. I just…” He sheepishly chuckled, his eyes darting along Mydei's face. “I don't know if I have all those ingredients in my fridge. I only really have stuff for salads.”

Mydei laughed. “I can buy them tomorrow. I just hope you'll… like them. It was the first thing I…”

The hands cradling his cheeks began swiping at the tears that began flowing once more. Mydei's voice was shaking again, his throat was closing in on itself, and it was getting hard to breathe as the realization dawned on him. *This entire conversation was pointless.*

“Why am I still having this conversation with you?” Mydei tried to turn away, to push himself from the bed before any more stray tears littered the sheets, but Phainon kept him rooted in place.

“I'll love them, Mydei.” Even through his blurring vision, and even through the darkness of the night, Mydei could spot his glowing, radiant, and gentle smile from a mile away. “Watch me tomorrow. I'll bring them to work and eat them. And you'll see how much I love them.”

“Are you even going to eat food that came out of nowhere?” A laugh rumbled Mydei's chest despite the tears still flowing down his face. What was Mydei thinking, making food for someone who would forget he was even there?

Phainon hummed, deep in thought. “I'll eat them. Trust me. So watch over me, okay? Because I really, really want to try your cooking. Promise me you'll make them?”

“I'll make them.” Mydei swallowed in an attempt to soothe his aching throat. He couldn't stop himself from making the promise when Phainon was so lovingly asking him. “I'll… find a plate in your cabinet to put them on.”

“That works.” Phainon laughed lightly. “Maybe I'll trust them more that way.”

Mydei was pulled into Phainon's embrace once more from the arm that had already settled around his waist. He reveled in the heat radiating off his body, and it lulled Mydei to sleep. Mydei didn't want this night to end at all, and he wanted to keep talking with Phainon and treasuring Phainon's presence forever. But despite trying to fight his body, sleep eventually overtook him.

It was the most wonderful sleep Mydei had ever had, and it was a sleep that Mydei would soon wish he could forget.

Chapter 17

“Who was your first time with, Mydei?”

The man being held in Phainon's arms scoffed, his chest rumbling against Phainon. “Why do you care?”

It was the next day following their reconciliation, and they were lying in bed together with the morning sunlight quietly streaming through Phainon's bedroom window. He had just woken up and was admiring the smooth skin and red tattoos underneath his palm, only to find out that Mydei was awake and lying in Phainon's arms in silence the entire time. So they continued the peaceful and comfortable silence, with Phainon sliding his hands along Mydei's waist and back, and Mydei quietly enjoying Phainon's company. That was, until Phainon decided to break their tranquility.

Phainon buried his pout away into the crook of Mydei's neck, and the scent of him immediately filled Phainon's senses as he pulled Mydei’s body closer. “I'm just curious.”

“You're not just being clingy?”

“I'm not clingy.”

“Right.” A deep chuckle vibrated against Phainon's chest. “It was a man.”

Phainon hummed, trying his best not to let his true emotions seep into his words. “So I wasn't the first person to be inside of you.”

Another scoff came from the other man. “Does that bother you?”

“No.”

The response came just a little too fast, and it was very clear to both men that it bothered Phainon despite his abrupt answer.

Mydei chuckled, and it only made Phainon's pout grow deeper. “Why don't you tell me your first time then? You seem to already know your way around bed, from how much my back hurts.”

“I can give you a massage, Mydei!” Phainon instantly jumped into action but was immediately swatted back down into the bed.

“Just tell me your first time. I'll feel better in a bit.”

Phainon slowly wilted back into bed, but at least he was in the warm and comforting and strong and lovely and beautiful arms of Mydei. “I don't remember my first time.”

“I'm surprised you don't. You seem like the type of person who would.”

“I…” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows in concentration and buried his face into Mydei's chest, his voice muffled from how closely he was pressing his face against the other man. “I don't remember what I did in school.”

“Was it in college?”

A slow nod came from Phainon. “I was… depressed back then. I think I acted very differently, with my blonde hair, as you know. Cyrene probably remembers better than I do.”

“Cyrene remembers better than you?”

“I didn't take care of myself well, and Cyrene was the one who did.” A weak laugh came from Phainon's lips. “She took care of me and paid for everything for me because I didn't do anything myself. I only listened to her because she's the only person I would consider my family nowadays. Back then, and even now.

“I was really serious back then, and I never went out or did anything, which was why Cyrene would always drag me out to random places with her as a way for me to go outside. And I just slept with anyone who asked me, so I don't know who my first time was with.”

The arms around Phainon tightened, and he laughed quietly at the comfortingly strong hold. “I graduated from college, following whatever Cyrene told me to do. I was really only living because I was alive, and I felt like I had to keep going and do what I was supposed to do, as someone who was still living. So Cyrene got this job and roped me in to work here too, and I had to slowly lose my blonde hair now that I worked in a corporate office. And also trim my hair because I usually didn't do anything to my hair until Cyrene cut it herself. It's why my hair was so long when it was blonde. I guess I can thank her that I met you.”

A brief silence settled between them, and Phainon was sure Mydei was processing Phainon's recount of his college life. It was a time that Phainon didn't reflect fondly on, but he would tell Mydei anything about himself.

“I'll be sure to make her something nice the next time I see her.”

“That's really not necessary, Mydei.” Phainon rapidly scrambled to cut his thoughts short. “You can just thank her.”

“You just don't want me to bake anything for anyone else, right?”

Phainon fell silent.

Another laugh rumbled Mydei's chest. “What is her favorite dessert?”

“I'm not telling you.”

“She seems like she would like sweets, right?”

Phainon fell silent once again.

“Does she like pink? Maybe I'll make her something sweet with a lot of colors and fruits.”

He physically flinched in Mydei's arms. “Can you stop analyzing my friend so well?”

Myde scoffed. “Do you want to help me make it for her?”

Pausing, Phainon couldn't help his brain from imagining the scenario. Him, in the kitchen, helping Mydei bake? Something that Mydei loved to do? Helping Mydei with something that he loved doing? And seeing Mydei in an apron? *Mydei in an apron?* "Help you?"

Phainon could faintly feel Mydei's head nodding from above him. "It'll be our way of thanking her."

He couldn't help the blush that began forming across his cheeks or his heartbeat from speeding up at the thought of baking with Mydei. From how hard his own heart rattled his chest and heated Phainon's body, he was sure Mydei could feel it too. Pressing his face right into Mydei's warm chest, Phainon's voice was muffled. "I want to help you."

"Good. We can make it tomorrow, so we can give it to her at work on Monday."

"How about making it on Monday morning?" Phainon tried his best to crane his neck upwards to see as much as he could of Mydei's gorgeous features. "Wouldn't that be better?"

Mydei raised an eyebrow. "You want to wake up at two in the morning with me to open the bakery on Monday?"

"Can I not?"

The other man only stared at him, blinking blankly at Phainon's best attempt at puppy eyes. The tight grip that was previously around Phainon even loosened as Mydei was shocked into a daze.

"You… really want to open the bakery with me?"

"Am I not allowed to?"

"It's at two in the morning, Phainon."

"I know that."

"Will you even wake up?"

“You're not staying over on Sunday night either?”

A laugh graced Mydei's beautiful face, with his warm breath faintly ghosting over Phainon as he chuckled. His golden eyes sparkled in the morning sunlight, shimmering in its rays as he parted his upturned lips to ask, “Do you want me to stay over and wake you up?”

Phainon nodded enthusiastically, and with another short laugh, lips gently pressed against Phainon's forehead before Mydei pushed himself from the bed. Phainon could barely scramble to catch up with him before his brain registered Mydei's departing words as the man shut himself into Phainon's bathroom to get ready for the day:

“My first time was with my drunk coworker who made me take him home.”

Phainon had no idea where they were going. His entire morning was completely fuzzy because all he could think about was that Mydei's first time was with *him*. It was with *Phainon* the whole time when he was drunk. *Mydei’s first time was with Phainon. Mydei’s first time was with Phainon*. And the most important part, that filled Phainon with complete ecstasy and left his heart racing in his chest, was that *no one had ever seen Mydei in bed except for him.* Except for *Phainon.*

He couldn't even remember how he managed to get ready in the morning, but he was now seated in Mydei's car on the way to who-knows-where. Well, Mydei knew, as he was the one driving. Phainon had tried to ask where they were heading, only to be immediately dismissed. What was with his loved ones taking him to random places without telling him?

“Are you… not bothered by it?” Phainon eventually broke the silence in the car. His mind was still echoing Mydei's words before he dipped into his bathroom, but it was then that he realized Mydei didn't really seem to care that he wasn't *Phainon's* first time. Did Mydei just not like Phainon as much as Phainon did? Or maybe, it truly did not bother Mydei that Phainon was with other people? But Phainon couldn't bear to think about Mydei spending time in bed with someone else.

“Bothered by what?”

It was almost as if Phainon completely forgot Mydei could not actually read his mind, and he started nervously shifting in the passenger seat over the fact that he had to explain himself now. Maybe he could just brush it off as an impulsive thought?

“Nothing.” His voice was barely above a whisper, but the driver of the car clearly heard Phainon's response.

“You're going to ask if I'm bothered by something and then say it was nothing?” Mydei raised an accusatory eyebrow, with his eyes never leaving the road. “At least give me an excuse if you don't want to talk about this anymore.”

“Are you not bothered that you're not my first time?” The words blurted out of Phainon's mouth before he could stop himself, and he inwardly cursed that he could never hide anything from this ethereal man sitting next to him.

A silence settled in the air, and it only made Phainon's anxiety worse and his hands sweat. He was shifting so much in the passenger seat that he was sure he would ruin the leather material. Why was Mydei taking so long to respond? It was definitely a bad idea for Phainon to ask him that question; why was Phainon already screwing up on what could now be considered their first full day of dating?

He tried to chance a glance toward the man beside him, who refused to open his mouth, but that didn't help his situation in the slightest and only made his heart palpitate for an entirely different reason. Because Mydei didn't bring a change of clothes when he went to Phainon's apartment, Phainon's dreams officially came true: Mydei was wearing Phainon's clothes. Phainon had almost fainted on the spot when Mydei had asked to borrow his clothes, and Phainon almost died when he had actually seen Mydei wearing his clothes.

Even though they were similar heights, Mydei was bigger and more gorgeously built than him, so Phainon's clothes were… tight on his frame. It

didn't escape Mydei's notice when Phainon's eyes had immediately gazed downward at the man when he had first put on Phainon's clothes, and he was in for a rude amount of incessant teasing from Mydei because Phainon could not tear his eyes away from Mydei's body. It made Phainon immediately run into his room and throw an oversized hoodie over the man, but even seeing Mydei in Phainon's yellow hoodie made him combust too.

“You've only slept with women.”

The deep voice that cut through the heavy silence shook Phainon out of his stupor, and it took him a few moments to process what Mydei had even said. But even though his brain finally understood what words broke the silence, Phainon still couldn't conjure an actual response.

“...Huh?”

“I'm the only man you've slept with.”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows and crossed his arms. Was that true? Even if Phainon tried to think about the other people he had slept with before, he wouldn't be able to remember.

“Why are you even thinking about that still?” A deep sigh left Mydei’s chest. “I don't mind at all, Phainon. Even so, I do know that I'm the only man you've ever slept with.”

His brain was still having trouble understanding what Mydei was saying. “How do you know that? Even I don't know that.”

“It was because of something you did when we slept together the night you were drunk.”

“Did drunk me remember who I've slept with before?”

Mydei laughed lightly. “Why would we talk about that?”

“I don't know!” Phainon threw his hands up in the air. “I just can't think what I would do or say other than just telling you directly.”

With a knowing smile, Mydei parked the car and left Phainon all by himself. Phainon didn't even realize that they had arrived, and he quickly rushed out of the car to catch up with the other man. And what stood before him was a trendy café, with quite modern decorations and a minimalistic design.

“Where… are we?” Phainon tore his gaze from the building to stare at a golden head of hair.

Crossing his arms, Mydei threw him a smirk. “Our first date.” And he left Phainon all alone outside, with a cold breeze rushing against Phainon, who had his jaw agape and a deep blush rapidly spreading across his face.

Finally coming out of his stupor and rushing inside, Mydei was already at the counter where a customer would order. Phainon was too busy scanning around, taking in the sights of the students studying at the tables and the organized displays, when an elbow poked into his side.

“What do you want?” Mydei jutted his head toward the menu that was suspended from the ceiling.

“Maybe just… a hot white mocha latte?” Phainon didn't really have much time to scan the menu, but it was the first thing he saw that intrigued him.

Mydei laughed lightly, paying for the drinks and guiding them to some cushioned chairs while they waited for their order to be prepared. “A white mocha matches you well.”

“Does it?” Phainon chuckled and instinctively ran a hand through his silver hair, swiping at the bangs that already fell in front of his vision. “I guess I’ll have to agree with you on that.”

Their order was ready in record time; it wasn't a hugely busy café, so Mydei and Phainon were able to grab their drinks with ease. Phainon assumed they would be sitting down at one of the empty tables scattered across the store, but Mydei continued walking somewhere down the back of the café. It seemed that Mydei already knew his way around here, and Phainon quickly scurried after him until they came to an open arch in the wall.

“You said you wanted to go to the bookstore, right?” With a small smile, Mydei disappeared into the open arch, but that was when Phainon immediately started sweating.

He still had The Cycles of Vigethos *just sitting in a drawer at home!* Phainon forgot to give it to his own damn boyfriend, who treasured that book his entire life! That was the whole reason why he was trying to get Mydei to go to the bookstore with him!

Instead of slapping himself in the face, Phainon followed after Mydei, making a mental note to give him that book the next time he had a chance.

The café was directly connected to the bookstore right next door. It had an entirely different vibe from the previous modern café, where the bookstore was very dim, quaint, and peaceful, but still just as organized as the previous store. With rows of bookshelves lining the store, and even smaller tables with stacks of featured books and authors, there was no shortage of literature for any customer to peruse through.

“You must come here a lot.” Phainon peeked over Mydei's shoulder, where he seemed to be flipping through a history book.

“This was the first bookstore that came to mind when you suggested going to one.” Without lifting his gaze, Mydei answered while turning to the next page that displayed a diagram of some sort. It seemed to be… a book about war? The diagram displayed one of many military formations that was used by the soldiers Mydei was reading about.

“So you *did* think about a bookstore, but you didn't bring me here and drove me home instead.” Phainon hummed sarcastically, a mischievous glint twinkling in his blue eyes. He leaned close against the side of Mydei's head, and his lips brushed through his golden hair with every syllable as he spoke lowly. “Did you have a dream about us that night at this bookstore?”

The book in Mydei's hands slammed shut as he shoved it back into the shelf and stormed off, and Phainon laughed at how brightly his ears burned underneath his hair, trailing after him.

“What did you get from the café? I thought you said you didn't like coffee.” Finally catching up with the glaring, and yet blushing, man, Phainon was trying to peer into the cup in Mydei's hand, but since it was in a paper cup for hot drinks, he couldn't see.

“Tea,” Mydei shortly replied.

“What kind of tea?”

“Do you want to try?”

The cup was lifted toward Phainon's face, with the scent of a sweet, fruity tea wafting through the air. Due to the plastic lid on top, Phainon couldn't see inside the cup. But that also meant that Phainon could only taste the drink from a single slit in the plastic lid where the tea would come through.

“That's okay.” Phainon sheepishly smiled at the raised cup despite his flushed face.

Mydei raised an eyebrow, taking a sip from his own drink, but Phainon's trembling eyes immediately glued themselves to Mydei's lips that had softly wrapped around the slit in the cup, watching how his throat bobbed with every gulp of the fruit tea.

“Are you really that embarrassed by drinking from the same spot as me after what you did to me yesterday?” Mydei's teasing voice shook Phainon out of his stupor, and the realization that Mydei knew exactly what was running through Phainon's mind made his blush creep all the way down to his neck.

“I–*Mydei!*” Phainon hissed as Mydei lightly laughed. “We are in public!”

“Did I say anything wrong?” A confident smirk graced his lips as he took another sip, locking his eyes with Phainon's wide ones. “Just try it.”

“I'm really–”

“Just drink it.”

With shaky hands and unfocused vision, Phainon managed to bring his lips to the plastic lid as he sipped on the hot tea swirling inside. Ignoring the image of Mydei’s soft lips sucking along this same spot, which he couldn't ignore at all as the picture was actually embedded in his brain, the tea slid past his quivering lips, running along his tongue, and he was pleasantly surprised at how sweet it was.

“You didn't even take the cup from my hands.” Mydei was stifling a laugh in between fits of coughs as Phainon's lips finally left the lid, and he immediately blushed at the realization as well. *Phainon was just drinking out of Mydei's hand.*

“S–Sorry,” Phainon managed to stammer out, swiping a sweaty hand down his face with Mydei still trying to calm his own laughter.

“How was it?” Despite how nervous Phainon was, Mydei still appeared extremely unfazed, and Phainon inwardly pouted about it. How could Mydei act so normal around him? When Phainon’s heart was pounding a mile a minute just from standing too close to the golden-haired man?

“Good.” The taste still lingered on his tongue as he tried to focus on that instead of his rapidly beating heart. “It was sweet. What was it?” All Phainon could tell was that it was fruity, but he didn't drink enough tea to know what it was.

“Pomegranate tea.” Mydei swirled the tea in his hand. “Mixed with hibiscus. It makes the taste sweeter. This is the only café I've found that serves sweet pomegranate tea. You got the white mocha?”

Phainon nodded quickly, handing Mydei his own drink. “I know you don't like coffee, but do you want to try it?”

With a shrug, Mydei took the cup from his hand, and Phainon quickly averted his gaze while Mydei sipped on his coffee. He wasn't sure if he could handle the sensual sight anymore, so he scanned around the little bookstore, watching nearby customers peruse the shelves and the featured books on the tables.

“It's good.” Mydei's voice eventually brought Phainon's attention back from the other people in the store. He was squinting at the taste still circulating in his mouth. “It's sweeter than I was expecting. I still don't like the taste of coffee, though, but I'll have to get used to it.”

Furrowing his eyebrows, Phainon opened his mouth to ask, “Why do you have to get used to it? Just don't drink it.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow in response with a frown, appearing equally as confused. “Because I'll be kissing you a lot, obviously.”

He sauntered away, leaving Phainon absolutely gawking in place. He was rooted to the floor, unable to move as his mouth dropped open, and his wide eyes watched Mydei disappear behind another bookshelf.

Was Mydei always this smooth?!

It was unimaginable to think that over a month ago, all he received from Mydei were glares, half-hearted grunts, and the occasional insult every now and then if he wasn't receiving the silence treatment from Mydei. Yet here he was now, with flirtatious line after line and making Phainon combust! Phainon didn't think his head, his heart, or the head below his waist could deal with any more of these lines, but with a wavering frown, he dragged his feet to catch up to Mydei, who seemed to be perusing more of the nonfiction history books in this bookstore.

The man had his head bowed low with furrowed eyebrows as he read the open book in his free hand, with his tea in the other. It was a sight to behold, seeing Mydei so seriously absorbing the information in this book, that Phainon almost wished he had gone to college with Mydei. Imagining a time where they could've had study dates together and picked each other up from class… It would've been a vast contrast from Phainon's actual college life. He could imagine Mydei being quite the serious and dedicated student, and it made his chest warm just thinking about a younger, college student Mydei.

“Do you like history?” Mydei's voice stopped Phainon's admiration of the other man.

“How could you guess?” A smile grew on Phainon's lips upon listening to Mydei as he scanned the bookshelves they were standing in front of. They were all history books, and Phainon could easily assume that Mydei enjoyed nonfiction literature.

“The plates in your cabinet were very…” Mydei hummed, squinting and recalling the time he prepared a plate of Golden Honeycakes for Phainon in the morning. “Vintage. They were all ceramic and porcelain plates. I couldn't find a normal plate to put your honeycakes on.”

A laugh shook Phainon's chest. “You know, I thought I had at least one normal plate in there. Then again, I usually don't have any guests over except for Cyrene when she barges in.”

“Do you like antiques?”

“I love them!” Shooting Mydei a grin, Phainon reached over the other man to pull out the only nearby book of antiques he could find. He flipped through the pages, briefly scanning through them all. It was a book about different antiques hailing from different time periods, with diagrams showing how to identify and assess these antiques. “There's just something about antiques that I love. I think I just love how much you could learn from antiques and the history and stories that they hold. There are… a lot of things in this world that have happened that never become known.”

A gentle hand brushed through Phainon's hair, and he glanced up from the book to find that Mydei had already stored his book away and was playing with the bangs hanging low in front of Phainon's face. With an appreciative smile, Phainon closed his own book, placing it back onto the shelf.

“I'm glad you… told me the truth about that day,” Phainon muttered. He was trying his best to hold onto his smile and never let it drop. “Thank you, Mydei.”

“You don't have to smile in front of me if you don't want to.” A serious gaze stared deeply into Phainon, with a tender swipe along his quivering, upturned lips. “You don't have to hide anything from me.”

Phainon laughed weakly, ignoring how his throat began to burn and his vision began to blur. “Really, thank you. I'd probably still never know without you and live the rest of my days without ever knowing.”

“What matters is that you're still here and living.” Mydei caught the tears gathering in the corners of his eyes, murmuring in a low, deep voice. “And that you didn't give up, even if you wanted to.”

He leaned into Mydei's hold, savoring the comforting warmth radiating off his hand as Mydei's words repeated in his head. Phainon's eyes fluttered shut as a genuine smile replaced the straining one on his lips from before. “I'm glad you're here, Mydei.”

“I'm glad you're here too.”

The rest of their day at the bookstore was peaceful. They perused the shelves, discussing the different subjects in history that they liked to read about and sharing the different books that they had already read. And when their drinks were finally finished, they departed from the bookstore with the sun hanging low in the evening sky. It was a beautiful evening and a beautiful sunset as Phainon climbed into the car belonging to an even more beautiful man right beside him.

Phainon could not wait to spend even more beautiful days with Mydei.

Chapter 18

It was pitch black outside when Phainon finally arrived at the bakery. Mydei had already departed before him; in fact, he woke Phainon from his peaceful slumber on Monday morning when he was already dressed and ready to go, saying that Phainon could catch up later while Mydei prepped the bakery for the day. It was about an hour later that Phainon finally rolled out of bed and got ready for work before driving to the bakery at three in the morning.

Phainon would consider himself a morning person, but three in the morning was just a little too early for him after he had basically stayed up quite late doing… certain activities with Mydei. The only reason they didn't go another round was because they had plans to open the bakery and bake something for Cyrene too. Mydei was also starting to neglect his bakery duties, and his backup baker had to open the store the entire weekend that he stayed over at Phainon's apartment.

With a yawn, Phainon pushed open the front door of the bakery, hearing the familiar chime of the bell above his head. The main area of the bakery was dark, as none of the lights or the heating lamps in the shelves were on, and the only light that barely lit the area seeped from under the curtains leading to the kitchen.

He slowly approached the back of the store, careful not to surprise Mydei in the case that he didn’t hear the chime of the bell from his entrance, but when he finally parted the curtain and was washed in the warm lighting of the kitchen, it was truly a beautiful sight to behold.

Mydei was serious at work, with knitted eyebrows and flour flying everywhere in the kitchen. The ovens were already on, but Phainon couldn’t tell if they were preheating or if something was already in there. The golden-haired baker was currently kneading some dough at the center island, with tray after tray after bowls of other goods and ingredients lined up on the surrounding counters.

“Since there are so many pastries in the store, I have to make multiple things at once.” It was as if Mydei had returned to being able to read Phainon’s mind again, and Phainon tore his gaze from the littered counters to stare over at Mydei, who didn’t raise his gaze from the counter even once.

Smiling softly, Phainon leaned over the opposite side of the island, admiring Mydei hard at work. He and his strong arms flexing, his concentrated expression, and his golden eyes all focused on the dough beneath his hands. But the most important part about Mydei's appearance was the light pink apron covering the front of his body, which was also covered in flour. It suited Mydei extremely well, almost a little *too* well, and Phainon wanted this image of Mydei in an apron framed all over his apartment.

“You look cute in your apron.”

Said pastry chef scoffed at the compliment. “I’m going to try and get as much done, but in the last hour before we leave, we have to make Cyrene something.”

“Do you have an idea of what to make her?” They had lightly discussed and brainstormed different pastries and desserts to make Cyrene, with Phainon offering suggestions based on her preferences. Her favorite fruit was peaches, so Mydei had thought of different pastries and desserts that were colorful and involved peaches. Phainon wasn't sure what Mydei decided to make though.

“A raspberry peach upside-down cake,” Mydei replied. “You layer the raspberries and peaches first before the cake batter, and you flip everything over at the end after baking.”

Phainon's mouth started watering at the thought. “That sounds amazing.”

Mydei nodded, seeming to set the dough he was kneading to rest in a bowl while he started cutting into blocks of butter. “I sometimes have them in the bakery, so I'll feature some today and make a batch last to bring into work for Cyrene.”

“She's going to be excited.” Phainon smiled. “She loves cake. Oh, you know what you should do?” The thought suddenly came to mind. “If it's possible to make it heart-shaped, she would like that too.”

“Heart-shaped?”

“She likes very romantic things.”

Mydei grunted. “I can do that.”

“You can do everything, Mydei.” Phainon propped an elbow onto the wooden island, leaning his chin in the palm of his hand.

Mydei only rolled his eyes as he continued to work. Even while being half-awake, Phainon could still appreciate how hard Mydei was working at creating so many pastries and desserts. He admired Mydei's work ethic, and he still couldn't believe the man was working two jobs. But was Mydei really going to live like this forever? What would happen once he became the CEO of Kremnos Corporation? Would he be a CEO waking up at two in the morning every day, including the weekends? Was there… some way Phainon could help him?

He continued watching Mydei running around the bakery. Phainon really hadn't the slightest clue what he was doing, but he tried to offer help only for Mydei to brush him off, saying he could keep watching and jump in once they made Cyrene’s cake. Though, Phainon really did want to help him somehow, so Mydei suggested that he set up the pastries and desserts on the main floor for him as they finished baking.

The clock ticked by in that quaint bakery, with Phainon running in and out of the kitchen to set up everything that was done. About an hour had passed since Phainon had arrived at the bakery, and it was approaching four in the morning now. The sun was still nowhere near rising and was just as dark outside as it was when Phainon woke up, but the shelves in the main area were starting to fill up now that it was almost halfway through Mydei’s shift until they left at seven in the morning, when they had planned to leave the bakery and arrive at the office.

Parting the curtains after setting up another batch of pastries, Phainon heaved a deep sigh and slumped his forehead onto Mydei's shoulder, wrapping his arms around the baker's waist after he had washed his hands. He couldn't even believe that Mydei was still up and running, as Phainon was already getting tired. And they still had a full workday left to go.

“Tired?” Mydei's voice vibrated against Phainon, who barely perked his head upon the man's shoulders to watch him filling eclairs with vanilla custard before dipping their topmost surface into a rich chocolate sauce.

“How do you do this for so long?” Phainon heaved a deep sigh as the stack of completed eclairs began to grow off to the side.

“I'm used to it.” Mydei leisurely added another eclair to the group. “And I like baking.”

The question began swirling in Phainon's mind again, wondering if Mydei was going to keep the bakery running forever, but he decided to stay silent as he continued to watch the eclairs being stuffed with the piping tip. It wasn't Phainon's business what Mydei does with the bakery, right? But he couldn't help but be worried for Mydei’s well-being, especially since he seemed adamant about keeping Kremnos Corporation around too.

His fingers began leisurely playing with the rough cotton texture of the apron under his hands as he fell deep into thought, watching eclairs become filled over and over and the pile off to the side continued to grow. And it was after a few minutes of this that the man in his arms cleared his throat, disrupting the silence.

“Can you not?”

With slightly widened eyes, Phainon turned his head, which was still resting on Mydei's shoulder, over to his face, where his ears and his cheeks seemed to be glowing a bright red.

“What?” Were there other things Phainon needed to set up?

“I'm asking you if you can stop.”

“Stop… what?” His hands immediately stilled, and it was then that he realized Phainon was practically running his hands all over Mydei while trying to feel up the apron. So with a loud laugh, Phainon immediately ripped his hands away and backed off. “Sorry!”

The tense shoulders of the other man only slightly relaxed as he continued with his work, but there was a deeper emotion stirring within Phainon that wanted to tease him more the longer he stared at Mydei's brightly glowing ears under golden hair. Wasn't it just so unfair that Phainon was always the flustered one between the two?

“Were you feeling good without me, Mydei?” The man immediately flinched when Phainon wrapped his arms around his waist once more and muttered into one of his burning ears.

He could hear Mydei swallow thickly, refusing to answer, and Phainon's eyes darkened at the sound as the man gritted his teeth. But it didn't escape Phainon's notice at all that the hands holding the eclairs and piping the custard inside slightly trembled as the blush across Mydei’s face deepened.

Phainon was suddenly… really horny now.

Mydei jolted, almost dropping the eclair he had just dipped into the bowl of chocolate, and Phainon had to stifle a laugh at the nasty glare he received that wasn't at all convincing from how brightly Mydei’s face burned. Phainon still couldn't believe that he used to dread and avoid these glares.

“Aren't you busy, Mydei?” Phainon innocently tilted his head to the side at the same time he slipped his finger back between lush cheeks, prodding against Mydei’s hole again, and a sharp gasp slipped out of Mydei's lips as he was trying to shakily add that completed eclair to the pile. “Shouldn't you be filling the rest of those eclairs?"

Mydei clicked his tongue, and trembling hands grabbed the next eclair waiting to be filled. “You think… You can get me to stop?”

“I'd like you to finish, Mydei. Why do you think I want you to stop?” An innocent smile graced Phainon's features as his index finger continued

rubbing against the ring of muscle that had quickly begun relishing in Phainon's presence. It fluttered underneath his fingertip, eager to suck Phainon inside, and he had to bury away his quiet laughs over how honest Mydei's body was.

“*Hmph*. Try and stop me then.” And the baker was back to work, piping custard into those eclairs and dipping them into the chocolate bowl. But at the challenge that hung in the air, Phainon had the sudden urge to win.

Hiding his devious smirk, he plunged a finger inside, and Mydei's body jumped forward against the wooden island at the intrusion as his lips dropped open into a soft moan. Mydei's eyes fluttered shut as Phainon began stirring his finger inside, feeling those familiar warm walls pulsing around his digit and gobbling up more of his finger the more he sank himself inside. An undecorated eclair and a piping bag sat within limp hands that were trembling against the countertop, and Phainon smiled in amusement at the sight.

“Those eclairs won't fill themselves,” Phainon whispered against golden hair, causing Mydei's eyes to slowly open once more. They were hazy and dilated, and the pit of Phainon's stomach churned at the tempting sight.

Blue eyes lowered to the light pink apron tied neatly behind Mydei's lower back, and even lower were Mydei's pants that Phainon had unbuttoned to slip his hand inside. He watched his hand push against the fabric of Mydei's slacks as his finger began pushing in and out of Mydei's twitching entrance that was sucking tightly around him, almost as if he didn't want Phainon to leave. And of course, Phainon was going to oblige to such a polite request.

He was still quite loose, as Phainon and Mydei had just gone at it last night, so it was quite easy for Phainon to ease another finger inside, feeling Mydei’s warmth swallow up knuckle after knuckle. Another low moan vibrated in the air, and Phainon's gaze flickered back to Mydei, who had abandoned the pastries and was savoring the feeling of Phainon's fingers pushing inside of him. Phainon wasn't exactly going fast, only stirring his fingers inside and gently pushing in and out, but Mydei already seemed completely out of his mind now.

“Do you like that, Mydei?” Phainon whispered against his ears with a deep chuckle, and Mydei immediately snapped out of his stupor from the sound of Phainon's voice.

With another unconvincing glare, Mydei picked up the next eclair. He was almost done with the entire stock, and trembling hands gripped the piping bag to shove the piping tip into the eclair, filling its interior with custard. It was a slow process; one that had significantly slowed due to the fingers that were stirring inside of Mydei's fluttering entrance.

He raised the eclair that was finally filled with custard, and Phainon abruptly thrust his fingers inside, earning a jolt and a loud moan from the other man. Mydei slammed his elbows on the counter, shaking in place over Phainon's digits that continued to slowly thrust and scissor inside of his pulsing, warm walls.

“You still have a couple left, Mydei.” A deep chuckle left Phainon’s chest as he eyed the small pile of bare eclairs before flickering his gaze back to the parted lips spilling the sweetest noises Phainon had ever had the pleasure of hearing, and every slight noise or gasp from the other man being stretched open sent heat swirling in his core.

“Phainon,” Mydei panted. His shoulders heaved with every breath, and he could barely manage to stand on his own two feet anymore. His legs were violently shaking, and Phainon stepped forward just in case the man really did fall. But now his bulge, pulsing in his work pants, was perfectly aligned with Mydei's behind.

Phainon hummed innocently in response, alternating between scissoring and swirling his fingers in small circles and brushing against Mydei's inner walls, causing the other man to jump. “Do you need me to help you?”

With another click of his tongue, Mydei shakily dipped the eclair that was getting crushed in his hands into the chocolate and practically threw it on the other side of the island with the hardening eclairs. Phainon laughed at the rough movements, leisurely watching Mydei grab an eclair and tremble every time his fingertips made contact with Mydei's walls.

“Only two left, my love.” Phainon pressed the area right next to Mydei’s sweet spot, earning him a sharp gasp as Mydei threw his head forward.

“*Fuck!* Phainon, *please!”* Mydei was panting and shaking around Phainon's fingers, which were completely swallowed up by his entrance that was trying to gobble up even more of his digits. It was so warm inside, and Phainon could not tire of the heat that tightened his stomach.

“*Please?”* Phainon repeated with a low voice. He leaned forward to ghost his lips against Mydei's burning ear, where Mydei had his head thrown forward. “Please help me make these eclairs? Or are you asking for something else?”

Mydei bit his bottom teeth, stifling a groan from the warm breath brushing against his ear and the fingers still stretching him open, and his unfocused, hazy golden eyes landed on the piping bag that had been discarded at some point during this exchange.

Phainon stared at it with a smile, watching in amusement as twitching fingers grasped around the piping bag and clumsily shoved the piping tip back into this new eclair, stuffing it to the brim. His eyes darkened at the sight of the custard slightly leaking out of the hole Mydei had already made earlier, and he curled his fingers inside of Mydei's entrance at the somewhat lewd sight.

A deep groan shook Mydei's chest, and his hole instinctively clenched around Phainon's knuckles as his back arched and his hands slammed the piping bag back onto the counter.

“One more, Mydei.” Phainon gulped at how much Mydei was trembling just from two of Phainon's fingers and how much his hole was fluttering around him. Even his pants were starting to get unbearably tight as his eyes trailed the newly finished eclair that had just been dipped in chocolate and set off to the side.

The last eclair. It seemed that Mydei was speeding through this one, roughly shoving the tip of the piping bag as deeply into the eclair as he could and pumping it as fast as his shaking hands would allow him.

Phainon laughed at how hastily and impatiently Mydei moved and how he almost dipped the entire eclair into the chocolate, but his stirring fingers inside never once stopped in massaging Mydei's fluttering walls.

“They're… done.” Mydei swallowed thickly, and Phainon watched as his throat bobbed with every word. “Put them… *mmph.*.. outside.”

“My hands are dirty, Mydei.” Phainon aimed his fingers right at Mydei’s favorite spot as his reward, and he began massaging that sweet spot as a long mewl echoed in the kitchen. “Did you want me to set up your beloved pastries with such dirty hands?”

“Wash them–*AHH!”*

Another flick of Phainon's fingers against his prostate sent Mydei flying down into the counter, and Phainon gulped at the delicious sight before him that was even more tempting than the shining chocolate eclairs off to the side.

Mydei had his forearms pressing down against the counter, with trembling fists clawing at the wooden countertop. His back was arched, with his pants loosely hanging off his hips, and Phainon wasn't sure if Mydei was aware that his body was instinctively moving itself on Phainon's fingers, thrusting his digits in and out of his hole. Phainon had already stilled his movements after teasing his prostate, but Mydei seemed to be having fun all by himself with parted, quivering lips that were releasing soft moans and gasps into the morning air.

An incredulous scoff left Phainon's lips as his eyes widened at Mydei bouncing his hips up and down all on his own, and he swore his vision turned red when Phainon yanked Mydei's pants down, exposing his naked behind and his stuffed hole and letting his slacks gather at his ankles.

“Having fun without me, Mydei?” Phainon's darkening gaze landed upon the ring of muscle in between his cheeks, swallowing up his fingers over and over again. His eyes were glued to the sight of their connection, watching his entrance fill itself up and being stuffed to the brim over and

over again as Mydei continued riding his fingers and releasing soft gasps and whimpers from his parted lips.

Mydei let out a shaky breath as he attempted to stop his hips. But even then, his hips were still softly thrusting in place, which slightly stirred Phainon's fingers still pressing right against his prostate. “Phainon.”

“Yes, Mydei?”

“I cannot think of anything else except for your dick right now.”

That was all Phainon needed. Those were the only words Phainon needed to be sent over the edge, and in one swift motion, he ripped his digits out of Mydei's hole, leaving the man moaning and spasming against the island he was slumped over. His stretched entrance clenched around nothing, searching for Phainon as Phainon began unbuckling his own pants.

“Can you be patient for me, Mydei?” Phainon had just shoved his hand into his own underwear, finally exposing the hard length that was straining in his slacks and letting the cool air brush over him. He was hard merely from watching Mydei getting himself off on his fingers.

“Put it in, you bastard,” Mydei managed through gritting teeth, arching his back even more and presenting an even more delicious view of his clenching, pink hole. “I have a bakery to prepare.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow before letting out a breathless chuckle. “That makes me want to take my time, Mydei.”

Hands grasped Mydei’s waist, feeling the rough material of the apron in the palms of his hands before lining himself up with Mydei’s entrance that was already trying to wrap around his tip. With quiet laughter, he pushed himself inside, and deep, guttural moans left both men as Phainon sank himself inside. The heat from Mydei's insides radiated throughout his entire body as it swallowed more of Phainon’s cock, and Phainon was already panting for breath once he bottomed out inside of Mydei.

His lover, against the island, had his head bowed low, with shaking arms and hands clutching against the countertop. Phainon smiled, waiting for the man to catch his breath as he adjusted to Phainon’s presence stirring inside of him. So while Mydei was doing that, Phainon went to work on the apron.

“What… are you doing?” Mydei croaked out, feeling Phainon fumbling behind him.

“Don't mind me, my love.” Phainon laughed softly. He had loosened the knot around Mydei’s waist, sliding a hand underneath the tied strands and pushing Mydei's shirt up his back. He admired the crimson red tattoos that crossed down his back and all the way down his naked body, with dilated eyes lingering on the dick that was smothered between two full cheeks. Once Mydei's back was exposed as much as Phainon could manage, he tightened the apron once more, clinching it around his bare waist.

He grasped at the warm skin before him, gliding gentle fingertips along his back and feeling every ridge and flex of his muscular back muscles with every deep breath from the other man. Goosebumps arose along his skin, and Phainon lightly laughed once more. “We should go to the gym together, Mydei.”

“Where is this coming fr–*OHH!*”

Phainon pulled out and thrust in without warning, cutting off the rest of Mydei's sentence. A loud slap reverberated in the kitchen, sounding louder than it usually did. And Phainon was completely and utterly obsessed with that sound.

Clutching tightly at the apron tied around his waist, Phainon began driving himself deeper inside of Mydei, reveling in every slapping sound of their skin echoing in the quaint little kitchen and every moan and gasp that left Mydei's parted lips. The island underneath them started shaking with every thrust; thankfully, it was locked in place, so it couldn't roll away, leaving Phainon to fuck Mydei as hard as he wanted to.

Mydei had buried his forehead into the counter. He couldn't stop the moans that kept erupting from his throat with every push against his sweet spot. Phainon was basically holding him up now, as Mydei’s legs had become weak and started trembling from the pleasure rushing down his body. His hard dick was pressing into the apron that was still wrapped around his waist, and he was sure he would leave a stain from the precum that was already dripping from his tip.

The island was rocking against the floor, with the sounds of their skinship becoming louder as they began sweating underneath the warm kitchen lighting. Phainon was relishing how hot and tight it was around his dick, with Mydei's insides deliciously massaging around him and pulsing with every thrust against his prostate. Phainon had his eyes fluttered closed, savoring every spark of electricity that pumped through his veins every time he plunged himself deep inside of Mydei's heat, but opening his eyes made him see the seductive sight that he had been missing.

Trembling legs barely held Mydei up. A head of golden hair was pressing into the wooden countertop; unfortunately, Phainon couldn't see his face, but the wanton moans that were filling his ears already told Phainon everything he needed to hear. With a back arched and presenting his vulgar entrance, Phainon watched his cock sliding in and out of that beautiful, quivering ring of muscle that had turned red from the friction, and the slapping sounds that echoed in the air with every thrust inside was a sound Phainon could never tire of. Mydei's ass jiggled with every hard snap of Phainon's hips, and the sight of the light pink apron tied neatly behind Mydei's bare, naked back was an even better sight to behold–one that made Phainon's vision tremble in excitement.

He leaned forward, flattening a palm onto Mydei's lower back, sliding underneath the knot tied around him and making the other man spasm against the counter. With a devious smirk, Phainon pressed harder, pushing down on the arched back and eliciting a loud moan from his lover.

“Do you… like it when I touch you here?” Phainon grazed his fingernails against the middle of his back, and Mydei slammed his forehead against the countertop with another loud groan. Phainon laughed at the reaction,

teasing that spot around the middle of his naked back and making the trembling body underneath him jolt even more against the wooden island.

“Not… Not there, Phainon,” Mydei managed between fits of pants and whines. He had finally raised his head from the counter, throwing his head back as he lay across the island, but it only allowed Phainon to savor even more of his moans.

“Don't you like it here?” Another glide of his hand, and Mydei moaned wantonly. His eyes were squeezed shut as he reveled in the pleasure coursing through his veins and the heat tightening in his stomach with every deep thrust of Phainon’s dick.

“I… do,” Mydei gasped sharply. “*Ahh!* Right there!” He was driving his own hips down in time with Phainon's thrusts, and Phainon had to bite back a moan at how Mydei's hole began hungrily gobbling up even more of his length.

Shaky and breathless laughter left Phainon's throat as he continued snapping his hips against Mydei’s ass and teasing his back underneath the apron's knot. He had to bury the urge to rip Mydei's clothes off altogether, and he had to stop himself from throwing themselves onto the kitchen floor so he could drive himself even deeper and faster inside of Mydei. Biting his bottom lip to stop his head from exploding and caving to his innermost desires, the best Phainon could do was to push Mydei's back, just where he liked it, and pin the man to his own counter to fuck him deeply and roughly, just like how his lover liked it.

With another rough push against Mydei's back and sending shocks of electricity through Mydei's torso, his body flew back down into the counter again, slumped and limp against the wood as Phainon continued pummeling inside of him. Phainon's tip was pulsing inside of him, hitting his sweet spot perfectly and dragging along his inner walls that reveled in Phainon's presence inside. No matter how much they had sex over the weekend, somehow, neither man was satisfied yet.

Mydei moaned Phainon's name, throwing his head back and thrusting his hips once more. At how sporadically Mydei was bouncing on Phainon's

cock and pushing back against him, he knew the man was close and was trying to chase his own release, so Phainon leaned over Mydei's slumped body, grasping tightly at his hips and driving himself at a breaking pace. He could feel his own stomach tightening in pleasure as his dick was constantly consumed and enveloped in Mydei's perfect walls, and with heat flaring in his core, he wanted so badly to stuff Mydei to the brim just like those abandoned eclairs. But they had work today.

They had work today. *They had work today.* Phainon could not cum inside of Mydei. *Phainon should not cum inside of Mydei.*

Phainon should not shove himself deep inside of Mydei's fluttering hole, plug him up with his dick, spill all of his thick cum inside of Mydei, watch Mydei's hips quiver with every pump of his cum, and watch it leak out of his clenching entrance and onto the kitchen floor.

Phainon should not do that at all.

That was ridiculous. They had work today. Mydei had to sit in an office chair all day. He had to sit on his ass that *Phainon had been thrusting and slapping against all morning.*

But Phainon could not get the image of those custard-filled eclairs out of his mind.

"PHAINON! *PHAINON!"* Mydei's desperate cries woke Phainon from his swirling desires, and his vision focused on Mydei's pleading gaze, which was thrown over his shoulder. Golden eyes were brimming with tears, and a flushed face and soft, plump lips were calling for Phainon's name as he was jolted against the island with every harsh thrust inside of him.

"*My love*," Phainon panted. He pushed himself back as his lust-filled gaze lowered onto those twinkling tears, continuing to snap his hips against Mydei's ass and his greedy, insatiable hole. "Are you going to cum? Are you going to dirty your own apron?"

"I… I can't!" Mydei's breathless voice traveled in the air as he squeezed his eyes shut and furrowed his eyebrows together. Phainon could tell the man

was trying to hold his orgasm back, but they couldn't have that.

“Can you hold it in for me, Mydei?” Phainon leaned forward once more to whisper against Mydei's ear, and his lover whimpered at the warm breath that tickled against his skin. With a tender kiss against his temple that contrasted his rough thrusts, one unexpected graze of Phainon's fingernails against the middle of Mydei's back had his lover screaming at the top of his lungs. His body spasmed against the countertop as his hole tightened around Phainon's dick, and he grimaced to the sound of Mydei moaning and crying his name as he came all over the island and his apron.

Ropes of cum splattered along Mydei's apron, with some streams even dripping onto the floor of the kitchen between his trembling legs. His hole was clenching tightly around Phainon's cock, who couldn't pull out and was at the mercy of the heat flaring in his stomach and the pleasure ripping his body apart. The muscles were massaging and pulsing against Phainon's quivering dick as the man rode out his orgasm, and Phainon's mind completely blanked out to the pleasure as he came inside of Mydei.

He threw his head forward, and his grip tightened around Mydei's waist and apron, with a deep groan scratching at his throat, as he spilled himself right inside of Mydei's twitching warmth that seemed to flutter in delight at the cum streaming inside of him. And it wasn't until Phainon's vision began to return and his heavy breaths began to even out did he see Mydei completely limp against the counter and his plugged up hole that was already leaking Phainon's cum.

Phainon didn't even know what to say. He was still trying to catch his breath, and his eyes could only focus on the cum that was dripping onto the kitchen floor. Swallowing thickly, he had to force his eyes away from the vulgar sight and onto golden eyes that were still rolled into the back of his head and parted lips that were drooling onto the counter.

“Mydei?” A breathless voice hesitantly asked. Phainon slowly loosened the grip around Mydei’s waist, which seemed to help Mydei come to.

His lover's eyes began fluttering, and that familiar gold filled Phainon's vision once more as Mydei shakily pushed himself from the counter.

Phainon flinched, as his cock, which was still inside Mydei, began to stir around with every slight movement from the other man, and he had to quickly pull himself out before he got hard again.

With a *pop* that echoed in the kitchen, Phainon's breath hitched in his throat at the thick streams of cum that began leaking out of Mydei's hole, slipping down his inner thighs, and Phainon completely froze at the sight. His blue eyes widened, trailing the cum that was oozing out of his entrance, and he gulped loudly. Phainon was completely unmoving from his spot in the kitchen.

Mydei clicked his tongue at the feeling, swiping a hand down to his leaking entrance, which immediately snapped Phainon into action.

“I'm so sorry!” Phainon began whipping his head around the kitchen, trying to find some clean towel or napkins he could use to clean Mydei up, and a shaky, breathless laugh filled the kitchen.

“That towel over there.” Mydei pointed in a direction to their right, and Phainon hurriedly scurried over to the clean towel that was hanging off a cabinet handle. Running it quickly under warm water, he insisted on wiping Mydei down of his own cum before moving onto the floor and the island.

“I'm so sorry… I got your apron dirty.” Phainon stared with shaking eyes at the apron that Mydei had already discarded before pulling down his shirt.

“Is that your cum on my apron, or is that mine?” Mydei scoffed playfully, running gentle fingers through Phainon's silver hair. “You stretched me out this time.”

“... Huh?”

“You didn't do that when we first had sex.” His voice was full of amusement as he pulled his hand away from Phainon's hair.

Phainon was frozen on the ground where he was cleaning up their cum, and Mydei had already pulled up his pants and begun washing his hands. But Mydei’s words were still settling within Phainon's head. Did he… try to

shove himself right inside of Mydei with no preparation at all when he was drunk?

“Mydei–”

“Fuck, it's four-thirty.” Mydei's eyes were glued to the clock. “And we still need to make Cyrene's cake.”

It was as if Phainon suddenly remembered that they were in a kitchen–*Mydei's bakery's kitchen*, in fact. Anyone could have just walked in and heard them getting it on in the back! They weren't even being quiet at all! There wasn't even a door separating the main area from the kitchen! And he hadn't even set the finished eclairs out in the main area either!

He immediately jumped from the ground, cleaning up the towel and his own appearance as best as he could, before dashing out of the kitchen with the tray of eclairs in hand just to double-check that the cashier, who was supposed to be working today, hadn't arrived yet. Mydei had told him that the cashier for the morning shift doesn't usually arrive until six-thirty, but he just really wanted to make sure. Thankfully, the lights were still off in the main area of the bakery, with only the heating lamps on the shelves turned on from when Phainon had begun stocking the shelves earlier.

He couldn't even believe he had just fucked Mydei in his own kitchen. And even in his own bakery! Was Phainon insane?! Did a demon of lust possess his body earlier?! Did this count as public indecency?! Phainon couldn't even stare at the eclairs normally anymore after the previous thoughts that had run through his head while fucking Mydei's insides, and he hastily set them all up in the shelves before erasing them entirely from his mind once he arrived back in the kitchen.

Mydei had already returned to work as if nothing had happened. He was already even wearing a brand new apron, with the light pink one thrown off to the side on an empty side of the counter.

“Mydei…” Phainon was awkwardly shifting in place near the entrance to the kitchen. He wanted to apologize properly, whether it was for fucking

Mydei in his own kitchen, fucking Mydei in his own bakery, cumming inside of him when they still had work today, or all of the above. “I–”

“Save it for later,” Mydei gently interrupted him. “I need you to brush egg wash onto these before I throw them into the oven.”

“But I–”

“I'm fine, Phainon.” Golden eyes finally raised from the pastries he was sprinkling powdered sugar onto. “You can never hurt me. I enjoyed it. And as for cumming inside… I'll clean it out when I get home later. I don't have time to go home right now.”

Mydei seemed to naturally return his attention back to his pastries as if what he had just said was completely normal, but now Phainon was violently trembling in place for an entirely different reason now.

Mydei was going to keep Phainon's cum inside all day?!

Chapter 19

“Oh my!”

The pink-haired woman gasped in awe, bringing her hands to her mouth as wide eyes sparkled at the cake set before her on her desk. Meanwhile, Phainon couldn't even stare at the cake anymore after what he had done to Mydei in the same kitchen this cake was made in and even prepared in just a few hours after what they had done.

Cyrene's wide, pink eyes were shimmering, twinkling in the office lighting as she stared at Mydei with her jaw still agape. “Is this for me?”

Mydei simply nodded. “I hope you enjoy it.”

The cake that they finally made, after many trials and tribulations, was a heart-shaped, peach and raspberry upside-down cake. Mydei had prepared and baked the cake in a heart-shaped pan to retain its shape, and he had gotten raspberry syrup to spread along the cake in a decorative fashion to make the cake appear more colorful. Not only did it appear more colorful, but it made the cake and all the fruits glisten underneath the white fluorescent lights hanging over them. The cake was still quite warm, as they had just finished baking the cake about half an hour ago to ensure it was at its best when they brought it to the office.

It was a lot of running around and scrambling in the kitchen, as they had lost thirty minutes for some… certain reason. Mydei actually pulled Phainon in to help him with certain tasks to prepare the pastries for the bakery, such as gathering ingredients from the refrigerator and pantries, cutting butter, cracking and separating eggs, and cleaning up after him. He also decorated quite a few pastries, such as setting the berries or syrups on top of them, which was quite fun. As for any part involving the dough itself, Phainon was happy to leave the important parts over to Mydei. But they eventually finished everything in time, and here they finally were, delivering the cake to Cyrene after such arduous trials.

“It’s even heart-shaped too! How romantic!” Cyrene had rested her elbows upon her desk and was admiring the extravagant design with smiling eyes, but only a few minutes passed of admiration did Cyrene suddenly jump out of her chair and dash off without any warning or explanation. It wasn't long, of Mydei and Phainon staring at each other in confusion, did she return a few moments later, pushing Castorice in front of her to join.

Castorice appeared extremely confused but seemed to be following Cyrene's whim, but her eyes also sparkled when they landed on the shimmering cake before them. Cyrene began to hand out paper plates and plastic utensils found in the break room on the way back to her desk.

“You made this, Mydei? It looks amazing.” She smiled and nodded her head toward Mydei, who returned the nod.

Cyrene was trying her best to cut into the extravagant cake with a plastic knife, and after much difficulty, pouting, and squinting, Cyrene finally cut the first piece.

“Mydei! This is your cake, so you have the first piece!” She beckoned Mydei to pass his plate over, who almost wanted to argue that Cyrene should have the first piece, but everyone could tell just how adamant Cyrene was. So he quickly acquiesced, giving her his plate that was soon covered by a lavish piece of the upside-down cake.

“How come you don't think I made this cake?” Phainon watched Cyrene struggling to cut another piece with the plastic knife. He realized they didn't actually tell Cyrene or Castorice who made the cake, yet everyone was automatically assuming it was Mydei.

“I don't think you have the artistic vision to make such a nice cake,” Cyrene answered without tearing her eyes away from the cake before her.

“It was my idea to make it a heart!”

“That's the bare minimum, Phainon.”

“I…” Phainon could not think of another argument.

“Phainon helped me make the cake,” Mydei jumped in with an amused smile. “It was his idea to make a peach cake.”

His eyes widened at the twisted truth, but he couldn't say anything to retort before Cyrene began to thank him graciously.

“Then! Phainon, have this next piece! As Mydei's little helper.” With a wink, she set the next piece of cake onto Phainon's paper plate before moving on to cutting a third piece.

“What is the occasion of celebration?” Castorice seemed to have fallen into a silence while admiring the beauty of the cake, but she finally lifted her gaze from Cyrene's desk to glance between Phainon and Mydei. “Or, is it just the kind of day for cake?”

Phainon and Mydei immediately locked eyes. Although they both knew why they were making the cake, they would have to explain that they were dating now, and they didn't actually explicitly discuss if they were going to tell other people that they were dating. Obviously, they have to lay low, since the CEO didn't like that Mydei was gay, but they didn't really talk about anyone else in the office, especially for Phainon's closest friends at work. They also all worked in the HR department, except for Mydei, so did this cause a problem if HR knew? The best person to know the answer to that question was Castorice herself, as the employee relations person.

A silence settled between the two men, with neither one of them knowing what to say to answer Castorice’s question, but Cyrene suddenly jumped in and cut the silence, as she usually did.

“It's my birthday soon!” Cyrene clapped her hands together. She had just finished cutting the third piece and started beckoning for Castorice to come forth.

Castorice scrambled forward, handing her the paper plate while wishing her an early happy birthday. Mydei stared at Phainon, who had an extremely puzzled expression on his face. It was nowhere near Cyrene's birthday, and Phainon knew that because Cyrene would never let him forget it.

“It's so good!” Cyrene had a hand covering her mouth while chewing on her first bite of the cake. She finally finished cutting a fourth slice and was able to try her own cake herself now.

“It's really good, Mydei, Phainon.” Castorice quickly went in for another bite after giving her compliments.

Phainon was waiting for everyone else to try it first, so when a bite of the upside-down cake entered his mouth, he couldn't agree more. The cake was moist and fluffy, with a beautifully sweet and somewhat tart flavor from the raspberries and peaches that littered the top, or technically bottom, of the cake. The cake itself was very sweet, but paired with the fruit gave it a nice balance, and Phainon couldn't help but savor every single delicious bite in his mouth.

“It's amazing, Mydei.” Phainon flashed a smile toward the main baker, and it was then that he remembered and quickly turned to Castorice and Cyrene. “Also… could I ask that you don't tell anyone Mydei made this cake?”

The two, with mouths full of cake, stared inquisitively at Phainon before slowly staring at Mydei, who nodded silently. And at his nod, they both nodded as well and continued on with their slice of the cake without any further questions.

The four of them spent the first hour of their shift just talking amongst each other about the cake. Many coworkers passed by and asked what the occasion was and where the cake came from, and the story they were all running on was that it was Cyrene's birthday, and Phainon had baked a cake for her to celebrate. It was convincing enough since the entire department knew that Phainon and Cyrene were close, but it was awkward having so many people compliment Phainon on his baking. Phainon could only sheepishly laugh and quietly thank them for their kind words.

When the hour had passed, Mydei bid his farewells and returned to his office in the executive department to continue with his work. Phainon couldn't stop himself from smiling over how happy Mydei was with everyone's compliments. Even though Mydei couldn't thank them himself, and even though everyone assumed this was Phainon's craft, Phainon could

tell from his softened eyes, relaxed posture, and ever so slightly flushed face that those words meant more to Mydei than Phainon could ever imagine. Though, a side of him thought Mydei looked a little *too* happy with their words, and he made a mental note to remind Mydei not to bake for anyone else again on his personal time.

Once Mydei had left, Phainon was going to offer to store the cake in the refrigerator in the break room for Cyrene before returning to his desk, but before he could open his mouth, Cyrene suddenly pushed herself from her desk.

“I reserved a meeting room for us!”

Phainon and Castorice blankly blinked at Cyrene, and Phainon was running a mental note of his meetings for the day in his head and why he would possibly have to meet with these two. He *did* have orientation today, as he did every Monday, but he didn't actually have to go see the new hires until another half an hour or so. He didn't have anything planned until orientation, since orientation usually took the majority of his Mondays, so he definitely just had checking emails and reviewing documents on his agenda in the morning until then.

“A meeting room?” Phainon could barely get the words out while Cyrene was casually cleaning up her desk, stacking the used plates and utensils to throw away and gathering the cake into her arms, which Phainon quickly took from her to put away himself.

“Thank you, Phainon!” Cyrene giggled. “I reserved the smaller meeting room. Let's go! And you too, Castorice!”

They could barely keep up with Cyrene's whim, and they scurried after her to the break room to put everything away before entering the meeting room that was just around the corner from the talent acquisition cubicles. This meeting room was barely used, as it was far from everyone else except for talent acquisition, and it was quite a small meeting room that could only seat about four to five people at the round table. It was mostly used by recruiters if they needed a separate space away from their own cubicle.

Cyrene shut the door as Phainon and Castorice warily entered the room. Phainon usually used this room for exit interviews, as it was very out of the way, quiet, and private, and he could also imagine that Castorice has booked this room before for employee relations-related investigations. But neither one of them could imagine why Cyrene decided to drag them here today.

“What are we doing here?” Phainon's eyes trailed Cyrene, who was practically skipping through the room, and she excitedly rolled one of the office chairs out and patted enthusiastically on its backside.

“Sit! Sit!” She waved her hands in both of their directions, and with glances exchanged in confusion, Phainon followed Castorice over to the table to sit, with Cyrene seating herself in one of the chairs across from the both of them. She cleared her throat as Phainon and Castorice stared at her with much anticipation, and her clear, pink eyes stared straight into Phainon. But she didn't say anything at all, which only made Phainon shift awkwardly in his seat.

With eyes flickering between Cyrene and Castorice, who appeared equally as confused with Cyrene's behavior, Phainon eventually asked, “Did you need something from me?”

“Do you not see anything unusual?” Cyrene had her hands clasped together on the small conference table, and it made Phainon feel like he was being interrogated. Nonetheless, he followed what Cyrene told him to do, and his gaze scanned the meeting room. But Cyrene laughed, bursting into a big grin. “No, silly. I meant between you and Mydei earlier! What was all that about? Weren't you two on nonspeaking terms just last week?”

Phainon glanced toward Castorice, who seemed to be physically leaning toward Phainon in anticipation of his answer, and when his eyes landed on her, she began nodding enthusiastically for more information.

Again, Phainon and Mydei hadn't explicitly discussed how secret they were going to keep their relationship, so he really wanted to keep this as vague as possible. “Mydei and I got… close on Friday. Toward the end of the day.”

He really didn't want to reflect on that day, when he had sobbed his eyes out in front of Mydei in the other meeting room in the executive department. That day truly felt like a long time ago.

“Close?” Cyrene raised an eyebrow. “Close enough to bake a cake together?”

At the reminder of them baking a cake together, his mind immediately flashed through everything that had occurred this morning, where they definitely did more than just *bake*. They did… a lot more than just baking this morning, that was for sure.

It was as if Mydei were trying to get revenge on Phainon for fucking him in his own kitchen, because every five minutes, Mydei was right there and right next to Phainon while he was trying to help Mydei decorate pastries or prepare ingredients. Every time they accidentally brushed hands while working in the kitchen together, Phainon would immediately flinch, catching Mydei's attention. And every time they locked eyes, Phainon's hands would always falter at the half-lidded, golden gaze that seemed to swirl with a mischievous, knowing emotion before Phainon was left with a burning red face while Mydei laughed at his shame. There were even some moments where Mydei would mutter curses to himself in the corner of the kitchen, and Phainon would approach him, thinking that he had messed up somewhere or he had forgotten an ingredient, only for those golden eyes to stare back at him and his deep voice to reverberate so quietly that only the two of them could hear:

“It’s dripping out.”

Phainon kept his mouth shut to Cyrene's question, but it didn't escape either woman's notice when he grew a deep, crimson red. Both of their eyes simultaneously grew wide, and Phainon rapidly threw a hand over his face in an attempt to cover the embarrassment that was washing over him.

“Phainon! Phainon!” Cyrene slammed her hands onto the desk and was jumping up and down now. “What happened?! Tell me!”

“Are you and Mydei close now?” Castorice appeared much calmer than the hopping Cyrene, but even Phainon could hear how her voice shook in excitement.

“Tell us everything! Tell us!” Cyrene's pink hair was bouncing up and down with every jump on top of her high heels. How in the world was she jumping with heels on?

Phainon frowned underneath his hand, his blush showing no signs of cooling down. “I need to ask him.”

“Ask who? Ask *Mydei?!*” Cyrene's hands were practically clawing at the table now. “Go! Go! Ask!”

She started waving her hands to shoo Phainon away, and Phainon laughed while digging into his pockets. “I have his number. Let me just ask him.”

“You have his number too?!” Cyrene cried while Castorice sharply gasped beside him. Was it really that crazy of news to have a coworker's number?

They had exchanged numbers during their bookstore date, so it didn't take long for Mydei to respond to Phainon's text.

If you want to tell those two, I am okay with it too.

“Well?!” Cyrene's impatient voice interrupted Phainon, who was relishing in the fact that this was Mydei's first-ever text to him in his entire life, and he pocketed his phone once he was shaken out of his stupor. Mydei texted so formally, and he had to bury his laughter at the thought of how adorable Mydei was.

He took a deep breath, flickering his gaze between the two pairs of wide eyes that were staring so intently at him. “Mydei and I are dating.”

“*DATING?!”* Cyrene screeched. “Wait, wait!” She almost looked like she was going to collapse onto the floor with how excited she was, and she bowed her head down with her eyes focusing on the tabletop while Castorice gasped loudly with a hand covering her mouth.

Phainon had a sheepish smile on his face, glancing between his two coworkers and friends. “Is that… wrong?”

Castorice rapidly shook her head back and forth. Her face was beaming bright red, and she was speaking so quickly that she strung all her words together. “There is nothing in the handbook that does not allow coworkers to date.”

“Oh, Phainon!” The breath was knocked out of his lungs when strong arms wrapped around his shoulders, and he almost toppled onto the floor from the strength that Cyrene had collided against him with. “I can't believe it! Phainon, congrats!”

“Is that really something to congratulate someone on?” Phainon laughed at her dramatic reaction.

“Was the cake actually to celebrate your and Mydei's union?” Castorice's eyes were still shaking, and Phainon's blush spread all the way down to his neck and to his ears at her words.

“Absolutely not!” Phainon cried. “That's… What a weird reason to get a cake.”

“So was it truly Cyrene's birthday?”

Cyrene laughed. “It's not my birthday, Cas. But what was the cake for?” She still had her arms wrapped around Phainon and was staring inquisitively at him.

“It's… Mydei and I wanted to thank you.”

“Thank me?”

“You know, because I only work here because of you. I wouldn't have met him otherwise. And also just because of everything you've–”

The breath was knocked out of his lungs again as a tight squeeze took hold of his entire body, and he coughed and laughed in Cyrene's tight hold as she buried her face into the crook of Phainon's neck. Phainon managed to

wriggle his arms free and return the hug, but Cyrene stayed silent this time in his arms.

“Congratulations, Phainon.” Castorice nodded at him, only making Phainon scoff.

“Seriously, guys. What's the big deal? There's no need for congratulations.” Phainon chuckled, but the arms around his neck only tightened further at his words. Her pink hair slightly brushed against Phainon's face with every breath, and it made him want to pat her on the head.

Cyrene's voice was low and muffled as she spoke into Phainon's neck. “We should… all hang out together.”

He tried to crane his neck to see her, but she was buried too deeply against Phainon. “Cyrene, are you crying?”

Her voice was shaking against Phainon's skin, and it was as if that question broke the dam that was holding Cyrene's tears back. Her sobs were silent, but they wracked her body as she trembled in Phainon's hold and the tears began to gather along Phainon's neck. Phainon smiled softly, squeezing her tightly in his arms while Castorice scooted forward in her chair to run gentle fingertips through her hair.

“S–Sorry.” Cyrene barely mustered, sniffling in between syllables. Her voice was muffled from just how tightly she was holding Phainon in her arms. “I just… You've come a long way, Phainon.”

Phainon smiled down at her trembling head of pink hair. “I know, Cyrene.”

“You can finally… love now.”

“I know, Cyrene.”

“The younger you wouldn't even believe how far you've gone.”

He softly laughed at the remark. “I know, Cyrene.”

“Do you feel better now?”

Her voice seemed to have stabilized now, with deep breaths brushing against Phainon’s skin as she caught her breath. Her body slowly came to a stop in Phainon's arms, no longer trembling as it had been before.

“I think… I feel a lot better,” Phainon murmured. “I can't have everything, but I… have someone now. Thank you, Cyrene, for everything.”

“Oh, Phainon!” Another tight squeeze around Phainon's body before she pushed herself off, quickly wiping the tears that had left trails down her face. Her makeup was starting to smear, but it seemed like that was the least of Cyrene's worries as she continued sniffling amidst the silence in the meeting room. “That's so romantic of you!”

Another laugh escaped Phainon. “Is it really?”

“It's,” Cyrene swallowed thickly, “the most romantic thing you have ever said in your entire life. You cannot even begin to imagine how many girls I had to fight after you slept with them in college.”

“*Cyrene!*”

“Phainon was like that in college?” Castorice's eyes grew wide at that new information.

“Castorice, please forget you ever heard that.”

“I will never let you forget it, Phainon!” Cyrene jammed a finger into Phainon's chest and pouted at him. Her voice was still somewhat weak from her cries. “You were so… sad in college.”

He smiled softly once more. Phainon couldn't imagine how this all sounded to Cyrene. Cyrene, who had seen Phainon crashing down when their village was burned to the ground by their own friends and family. Cyrene, who had moved to the city, dragging her only friend along with her, who didn't even want to go with her but had nowhere left to go. And Cyrene, who took care of both herself and her friend, who had changed so much since that day that he didn't even seem like the same friend anymore. Cyrene had seen so many versions of Phainon, so many different sides to Phainon that he couldn't

even begin to imagine, but he was sure this new chapter in Phainon's life was one that was even new to Cyrene as well.

“I know, Cyrene.”

“I'm really proud of you, Phainon.” She ran a hand through his silver hair, tousling it in her fingers. “You can finally view the world the way I've been viewing it!”

“The way you've been viewing it?” Phainon raised an eyebrow.

“With rose-colored, heart-shaped glasses.” She teasingly poked the tip of Phainon's nose, shooting him a wink, before standing up. “*Ahh*, time to go fix my makeup and get back to work. Phainon, tell me when Mydei is free so we can all go out sometime.”

“I'll ask him,” Phainon promised with a smile.

Castorice also stood up after Cyrene, giving Phainon another nod. “I wish you both the best, Phainon.”

“Thank you, Castorice.”

As Castorice exited the meeting room, Cyrene was about to follow. But she paused in the middle of her step and whirled around, and Phainon's eyes slightly widened as she leaned down towards Phainon's face.

“Did something happen while you were making my cake?” An accusatory eyebrow was raised in Phainon's direction, and his entire face burned at the reminder of that memory.

“What would make you say that?” It was a straining smile that Phainon did his best not to let drop, and Cyrene’s following hum was dripping in suspicion.

“Phainon, you know you can never hide anything from me, right?”

“I… know… Cyrene, ” Phainon rigidly forced out of his mouth with a dry swallow.

She placed her hands on her hips with a roll of her eyes and a regrettable sigh, shaking her head before stepping toward the exit. “Boys and their urges.”

And she left Phainon in the meeting room, who had a brightly glowing face, and his jaw dropped to the floor.

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

> Happy 100k words! I didn't plan for this fic to be so long, but thank you to everyone who loved my story enough to make it this far

Because they work in the office and in a very professional workplace, Phainon and Mydei agreed over text to act as coworkers. Since Mydei usually never conversed with others on a day-to-day basis, this also meant that Phainon also could not converse with him every day, as that would be out of the norm for the CEO's son. Which would garner the attention of the CEO, and they definitely didn't want that. Mydei also didn't want to go home with Phainon either, in case that also attracted unwanted attention, and as much as Phainon hated to hear the sound of that, it made complete sense. So Phainon and Mydei returned to their separate homes.

So here Phainon was, Tuesday morning, glancing at the clock every five seconds because he missed Mydei. Monday was fine, as he had orientation the majority of the day, so the new hires very easily captured his attention and made him forget about Mydei.

But his entire Monday night was just spent thinking about Mydei, what Mydei was doing, and if Mydei was even thinking about him. Mydei didn't really text Phainon all too much, and Phainon didn't want to text him and constantly blow up his phone. He knew Mydei slept extremely early because of the bakery, and Phainon also knew that he was stealing some of Mydei's sleep time. He was sure Mydei was starting to lose sleep, and Phainon was worried for him. So Phainon was left with his thoughts all to himself about the other man, hoping that he was getting a good night's rest and catching up on sleep Phainon may have stolen from him. But now that he was left to his own devices at his desk the following day, Phainon was left with this extreme dilemma of *craving his boyfriend even though his office was quite literally down the hall from his cubicle.*

He checked the time on his work computer, and it had only been a solid two minutes since the last time he checked the time. Every minute felt like decades, and time seemed to crawl every time he thought about Mydei. They already made plans to get dinner later today, which was why Phainon was checking the clock every five seconds to see if it was time for dinner. But alas, it had only been another two minutes since he last checked the time, and with a heavy sigh, he forced himself to begrudgingly click through some documents that needed his review and answer the questions from the new hires from yesterday.

Every slight task that he completed, he would check the time, and every slight movement from his coworkers in the nearby cubicles also made him check the time. Phainon literally saw Mydei yesterday morning, so he wasn't sure why he was going crazy without seeing the guy. It was funny to think about the Phainon of two months ago, when he could barely stand the guy's presence. Because now he was left wondering, in all of this spare time, what he even did with his life before focusing so much on Mydei.

The day ticked by, and it was finally his lunch break now. It felt like the first four hours of work were his entire eight-hour shift, and he had to drag his feet to the corporate cafeteria just because he told himself he should eat. And also, Cyrene was going to drag him with her anyway.

He stabbed half-heartedly into his salad, watching Cyrene split the upside-down raspberry peach cake at the table. There was still some left over from yesterday, and Cyrene was very adamant about sharing and eating it together with Phainon and Castorice. She did want to invite Mydei, but after he had tried to explain the situation to her, without delving too deeply into Mydei's past, she eventually agreed and promised she would save the last slice for Mydei in the break room refrigerator for him later.

“Do you miss your husband?”

“Stop calling him that.”

Cyrene had been constantly teasing and poking fun at Phainon since their lunch break had started, but he couldn't help but agree that it was glaringly obvious there was something wrong with Phainon.

“Don't you have plans with him later? I'm sure he's just as excited as you are for them.” Cyrene casually hummed and passed him a plate of the upside-down cake.

He shoved an abundant amount of greens into his mouth, chewing slowly and eyeing the cake that had seen too much of Phainon and Mydei's flirting in the kitchen yesterday. Phainon would bet even the cake missed its chef too.

“I'm happy to see that you're in love, Phainon, but please eat properly,” Cyrene playfully chastised him in a singsong voice while passing a slice of the cake to Castorice.

“I *am* eating.”

“You're barely chewing.”

Grumbling under his breath, Phainon finally straightened up in his seat and actually ate his salad properly. He needed to stay alive to see Mydei later today, after all.

“Mydei really is amazing.” Castorice had just finished taking a bite of her slice of cake. “I would have never guessed.”

Phainon could only assume she meant “would have never guessed he loved baking,” and he inwardly thanked her for staying so vague. “I wouldn't have guessed it either. He didn't seem like he would like sweets.”

“Isn't it cute, though?” Cyrene giggled to herself. “That he's so different from what his appearance tells you.”

“Don't call him cute.”

“Stop being so jealous, Phainon.”

With some more grumbles under his breath, Phainon shoved some more salad into his mouth.

“Seriously, Phainon, you have to tell us the next time he is free!” Cyrene exclaimed with her signature pleading eyes. “Stop hogging him all to yourself.”

Phainon glanced over in Castorice’s direction, where she began to vehemently nod her head in agreement.

“I'll ask him tonight.”

“Good.”

“If I remember.”

“Phainon, I'm going to text you tonight to ask him, so you better remember.”

He couldn't help the loud laugh that escaped him, no longer able to keep up with the facade. Phainon couldn't ask for anything more in his life than his loved ones all spending time together, after all. There really was nothing else Phainon could ever ask for in his life. Of course he would ask Mydei when he was free.

“I'll remember, Cyrene.” He flashed Cyrene a smile before digging into his lunch once more.

Cyrene returned the smile while finishing up the last of her cake. “I'm so excited! I can't even begin to imagine what Mydei is like outside of work.”

“Me too.” Castorice nodded. “My only impressions of Mydei are from work.”

“I want to know how Mydei acts around Phainon now!” An excited squeal came from Cyrene as she grabbed Castorice’s shoulder. “How do you think the two love birds will act together?”

“We are not going to do anything in front of you guys,” Phainon interjected by clearing his throat, interrupting the fantasies of the two women who very clearly had blushed cheeks just at the thought.

“I *need* to see this new chapter of you, Phainon.” With one swift movement, a crouton from his salad disappeared and landed straight into Cyrene's mouth along with a satisfied grin. “You should just text him now! Ask him when he's free.”

Shrugging, Phainon couldn't exactly argue with that and pulled out his phone, typing to the other man to ask when he was free to hang out with all three of them. “He takes naps during lunch, so don't expect a response right now.”

That only made Cyrene hum in amusement. “So you know Mydei's schedule too?”

“We all have the same schedule.”

“But you know he sleeps during his break?”

At the teasing voice, Phainon was having difficulty retorting back, and his face began to burn in embarrassment. “I–It's only because I was stalking him so much, trying to figure out what happened that night I was drunk. Not… Not because I know him that well or anything.”

“That's right!” Cyrene slammed the table, jolting both Phainon and Castorice. “What *did* happen that night?!”

Phainon's eyes widened like saucers. He didn't… really remember every single detail of that night. But he definitely knew the general gist of what happened, and he wasn't sure if he wanted to explain a single part of that night.

“*Err*… Well… We–um.”

Cyrene raised an eyebrow, leaning uncomfortably close from across the table. “*We?”*

“He… Um… Maybe I can tell you guys later? When we're not at work?” It was as if the more Phainon tried to force the words out, the more he became aware of all the different coworkers that surrounded them and the different

conversations happening amongst them as everyone enjoyed their own lunches in the *corporate cafeteria* at their *corporate office*, a place that was *not suitable for the activities Phainon and Mydei engaged in that night.*

Two pairs of eyes widened at how red Phainon's face had gotten and how often he was shifting in his seat, and the two women turned to each other with equally flushed faces.

“Something good must have happened that night,” Castorice muttered.

“Something *very* good must have happened that night, Cas,” Cyrene immediately agreed.

“I must take notes.”

“You must! You must!”

“*Guys*.” Phainon's voice finally interrupted their excitement, and the two women seemed to have suddenly remembered that the main subject of their conversation was still sitting with them at the table.

Cyrene only snickered in response while sneakily stealing another crouton. “Sorry, Phainon!” She didn't sound apologetic in the slightest.

The rest of Phainon's lunch break continued exactly like that, with Cyrene constantly teasing Phainon and Castorice watching from the sidelines, agreeing with Cyrene and taking notes on her phone. What Castorice was going to do with those notes, Phainon hadn't the slightest idea.

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (1:00pm): *This is the address for dinner tonight. As for meeting with Cyrene and Castorice, just let me know when.*

Once Phainon had bid his farewells to Cyrene and Castorice, he received this text upon sitting himself down at his cubicle. He still couldn't get over how properly and formally Mydei texted, and he made a mental note to tease the man about it later. But for now, he copied and pasted the address

Mydei had sent him into a search engine to see the building, and he regretted it immediately.

Phainon (1:01pm): *Mydei ꒰ᐢ ˘̀ ꒳ ˘́ ᐢ꒱ this looks expensive??? (˘̀ ᗜ ˘́)*

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (1:01pm): *Dress casual.*

Casual?! Nothing about this building screamed *casual?!*

It was a sleek, black skyscraper–yes, literally a skyscraper–with floor-to-ceiling windows that covered every inch of the walls besides the bottom floor. It even had its own connected private parking structure, and with the building being right in the middle of the city, all it told Phainon was just how expensive and luxurious this building was. He couldn't see anything else about this building other than what he could see from street view pictures, but he was sure that, no matter what Phainon wore, he would be extremely underdressed. It was like whiplash to him; he had completely forgotten already that Mydei was no short on cash.

How casual was *too* casual? Did Mydei consider their work clothes as casual? Because this type of attire for work was extremely fancy for Phainon. Should he just wear his work clothes? But what if Mydei actually really did mean “casual”? Would it be weird if Phainon showed up to this swanky establishment in jeans? Unless, Mydei was so wealthy that he had booked a private room for them, so it really did not matter what Phainon wore?! His head was already spinning, and he wasn't even working at his cubicle. Phainon decided he was going to leave this problem to later, after-work hours, Phainon.

His dilemma about what to wear stopped Phainon from checking the clock every five seconds. Every time he saw the time, he only thought about what he was supposed to wear or what could constitute a suitable “casual” outfit. He was able to actually get some work done, but the moment it hit the hour to leave work, Phainon basically sprinted out of the corporate building to drive home as fast as he could. His dinner date was soon approaching with Mydei, after all, and he needed to look his best. Well, as best as he could while adhering to Mydei's ambiguous dress code for him.

He had his hands on his hips, standing in front of and staring at his open closet. Phainon still hadn't the slightest clue of what to wear. Should he truly wear something casual, and if it was *too* casual, then Phainon could blame Mydei for the vague dress code? Or, should he just bring backup clothes? Yes, that was right! Phainon was taking his car anyway, so he could definitely leave a fancier pair of clothes in his car in case his casual clothes ended up being too casual.

Humming and reaching into his closet, Phainon finally changed into a much more comfortable outfit. It was just a simple pair of jeans and a hoodie, and he blocked the images of the building out of his mind before he ripped off all of his clothes and changed into the fancier outfit he was packing. Just thinking about walking into that sort of establishment in jeans and a hoodie made him sweat.

There was also one very important thing that he couldn't forget either. Phainon hadn't opened this drawer since about a month ago, but what sat at the very bottom of his drawer at his desk was a children's book. A children's book that he hadn't opened since the day after he bought it.

The Cycles of Vigethos. This book made Phainon go through a multitude of emotions, and it was just a simple kids' book about chimeras going on adventures together. Denial, realizations, and acceptance all flew through Phainon's head because of this simple book. To be honest, Phainon had been too afraid to pick up this book ever again, but now that he had been awakened from his long, long dream in those golden wheat fields, Phainon could confidently say that this complicated book had helped him far more than he could've ever imagined. This book was truly the catalyst that he needed in his life, and he brought the book with him before jumping into his car.

The remainder of his day before the dinner date was spent visiting his nearest retailers, buying flowers and a gift bag for when he saw Mydei. He remembered about Mydei's pomegranate hibiscus tea from the café, and he bought the pomegranate flowers that the store just happened to be selling. He needed to ask Mydei what his favorite flowers were later. Phainon also placed tissue paper and *The Cycles of Vigethos* into the gift bag to give to the man once he arrived.

When it was finally time to head to that building, Phainon's entire body was rigid as he was turning into the private parking structure. His hands were clammy as they grasped the steering wheel, and he eventually turned into a guest parking spot on the first floor. Surprisingly, he didn't have to pay at all. He arrived earlier than their planned time, but Phainon didn't really want to leave his car dressed so casually. So he actually lingered in his car for a few minutes, with tense shoulders and the flowers and gift bag in hand, until the urge to see Mydei eventually grew bigger than his embarrassment at his own clothing. With the sound of the car door shutting echoing in the vast parking structure, Phainon finally approached the elevator leading to the lobby.

Phainon certainly didn't belong here at all.

That was Phainon's first thought once he set foot into the main lobby. It was a grand lobby, with a chandelier hanging from a high ceiling, warm porcelain tile flooring, and even a desk spanning the entire back wall that housed multiple front-desk employees. There was even a guy just standing at the elevator; was his job just to press the elevator button for people? That's when you know the place was wealthy; they could afford to hire people just to press buttons on an elevator.

Despite scanning over the grand lobby a multitude of times, Mydei was nowhere to be seen, and Phainon struggled to reach for his phone to ask where he should go or if he should wait for Mydei. He needed a professional in the high-class scene to direct Phainon.

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (7:02pm): *Tell the doorman 600.*

Who was the doorman?! Was it the guy by the elevator whose job was to press elevator buttons?!

Phainon was flickering his gaze between his phone and the guy standing by the elevator, trying to make some sort of awkward contact, along with silently pleading for help, in hopes that someone would notice Phainon and direct him to the correct person. It was a couple of seconds of blatant staring into this man did that guy finally lock eyes with Phainon.

He scurried over, his footsteps echoing in the grand lobby as he wedged the flowers in the crook of his arm to bring up the numbers Mydei had sent him. “Do you know where 600 is?”

The man nodded with a polite smile and gestured toward the elevator, pushing the button, with the doors immediately parting open afterwards. With a hesitant step forward, Phainon entered the elevator, and the assumed doorman pressed the floor that Phainon was, assumedly, supposed to be going to.

The doors closed before Phainon's eyes, and the elevator began to rumble underneath his feet as the floor number began to tick up on the wall above the elevator doors. Now that he was here, he could only assume that this was Mydei’s home. The penthouse that he said he lived in. Which meant that Phainon was in for quite the elevator ride, as Mydei's home was most likely at the very top of this giant skyscraper, considering his door number was 600. At least Phainon didn't actually come dressed in his work clothes now that he knew this was Mydei's home.

Once the gentle chime following the elevator door's opening roused Phainon from his thoughts, there was only one set of doors right in front of him. And with a hesitant hand, Phainon rang the doorbell.

It was just a few minutes later until the doors parted open, and there stood that beautiful, golden-haired man whom Phainon felt like he hadn't seen in decades. His golden hair was slightly darker and damp from taking a shower, and the compression shirt and sweatpants that he was wearing made it *extremely* hard to lock eyes with his equally stunning, golden eyes.

The breath was knocked out of Phainon's lungs as he stammered, “It's nice to see you.”

“You made it.”

How much Phainon missed his ethereal and gorgeous smile and sultry, deep voice was something Phainon couldn't put into words, and Mydei stepped aside to allow Phainon room to enter.

“I brought you flowers and a gift.” Phainon slightly raised the things in his arms. “Where should I put them?”

“They're beautiful, Phainon.” A quick peck against Phainon's cheek made him instantly melt, and he barely caught Mydei's voice telling him to put it on the counter. Tearing his eyes away from his bare, muscular arms and those crimson red tattoos, Phainon stumbled inside to gently lay the flowers and gift bag on the counter.

“I didn't realize the dinner was going to be at your home.” Phainon's eyes wandered the expansive space before him. The kitchen he was standing in was extremely grand, looking almost like a professional kitchen, that sat right by the entrance and waiting room that he had just walked through. Just the fact that a home even had a waiting room before the main home was incomprehensible to Phainon.

Ahead of the kitchen, Phainon could see the grand living room, with a high ceiling and floor-to-ceiling windows that looked out into a stunning view of the city skyline. Especially at night, with the lights, it was a breathtaking scene. Phainon couldn't imagine having this sort of view every single day. He almost wondered why Mydei even stayed over at his humble apartment over the weekend instead of returning home. The rest of the penthouse, Phainon couldn't see from where he was standing near the counter of the kitchen, where he had dropped off the flowers and gift bag, but there were stairs leading up to even more of Mydei's home.

“I was confused when you said it was expensive.” Mydei scoffed. He was cleaning mushrooms in the double sink on the giant island in the middle of the kitchen. “I thought you were just making another remark about how much money I had.”

“No!” Phainon immediately retorted. “I… I really thought this was a restaurant.”

With an amused smirk, Mydei returned to draining the water in the bowl of mushrooms, and Phainon approached him to peek over his shoulder.

“I'm surprised you even wanted to stay in my apartment when you live here.” Phainon glanced around the space around him once more at the thought. “You are right though. No maids or butlers in sight.”

Mydei laughed at the reminder of Phainon's previous words, patting the mushrooms dry. “You forget I didn't always live like this. I lived with my mother in a small, one-story home at one point, but…” His voice quieted into a murmur as his hands reached a stop. Mydei’s eyes had glossed over, as if he had truly traveled back in time and relived those moments again. “I enjoyed it much more in that small home.”

The more Phainon looked around, the more he couldn’t help but agree. He was right about one thing: This penthouse was way too big for one person to live in. Phainon couldn't stop thinking about how lonely it was that Mydei was the only occupant of this giant space. What was the point in living in such a grand residence if he was the only one here?

Phainon wrapped his arms tightly around Mydei’s waist in a comforting hold, leaning his chin onto Mydei's shoulder while he went to work cutting the mushrooms in half. “Where was your old home? I can't imagine it was in the city.”

“It was right outside the city.” Mydei dropped the cut halves into the bowl. “Right on the river. It was maybe a twenty-minute drive from the bakery, and a little more with traffic. And this position reminds me too much of the bakery. Get off.”

With a loud laugh and a face burning in embarrassment, Phainon immediately backed off. It didn't escape Phainon's notice that the other man's face was also slightly tinged pink.

“What are you making for dinner?” Phainon swiftly switched conversation topics as he scanned the kitchen. His eyes found lettuce, snap peas, pumpkin, marinated meat, and even more ingredients scattered across the counters.

“Salad, pumpkin bean casserole, and lamb steak with mushrooms,” Mydei responded without taking his eyes from the mushrooms. “If you want to

help, can you peel and wash the lettuce? The casserole is already in the oven and should be done soon. I just need to make the lettuce and cook the steaks.

“I could definitely do that.” It was Phainon's specialty, after all, and after rolling up his sleeves, he washed his hands and returned Mydei’s kiss from earlier before approaching the head of lettuce. Chancing a glance over his shoulder, he smiled to himself upon seeing how much Mydei's ears burned a bright red from the quick kiss Phainon had given him.

Mydei was so cute. Those were the only words echoing in his head as he peeled the lettuce leaves and rinsed them in the sink. He couldn't stop stealing glances at his boyfriend, who had moved on from the mushrooms and had begun cooking the steaks. He was basting the steak using butter he had cut and prepared beforehand, and the smoke from the stove was rising into the air. He looked so professional in this kitchen; truly, there was nothing Mydei couldn't do.

“You can prepare the salad however you'd like.” Mydei's voice rang from above the sizzling steaks on the stove. “Just look through my refrigerator and add whatever you'd like.”

Phainon hummed and swung open the refrigerator. “Is there anything you want specifically in it?”

“I want whatever you want.”

Phainon immediately clicked his tongue and grabbed the ingredients he usually added to his salads, slamming the refrigerator door shut. His heart was pounding and rattling against his chest as he dropped everything onto the counter next to the salad bowl. “Mydei, you cannot be so unfair.”

“Unfair?”

“Stop being so adorable today.”

A cough immediately sounded from the direction of the stove, and Phainon had to bury his laughter at how red his boyfriend's face became.

“*Adorable?*”

“You're adorable every day, Mydei, but exceptionally so today.” He threw a smirk over his shoulder, where his boyfriend still stood with a deep frown, scrunched eyebrows, quivering lips, and a burning face. Mydei was basting the steak as normal, trying to pretend that Phainon hadn't said anything.

The oven rang just when Mydei had finished cooking the mushrooms in the remaining butter and juice that came from the steak, giving the mushrooms a rich, savory flavor that paired well with the steak. Phainon only knew this because he snuck a bite from behind Mydei's shoulder. But now that everything was done, Mydei directed him over to the dining table.

With the table set up with their meal, including their plates and utensils, everything was ready for dinner. The dining table was off to the right of the kitchen, where there was a full dining room ready for them. At one point during the cooking process, Mydei had even placed the pomegranate flowers Phainon had bought into a vase to set upon the dining table. It was a much smaller space than the kitchen and living room, but still an adequate enough size to house multiple people inside. And the view outside to the city, right next to the dining table, was quite a nice touch.

Salad, pumpkin bean casserole, and lamb steak smothered in mushrooms were all laid out on the dining table. It was truly an extravagant dinner, and Phainon could not wait another second to dive into Mydei's cooking.

“I bet you're just as good at cooking as you are baking.” Phainon chuckled while slicing into the tender piece of meat.

Mydei scoffed in response. “What is with you and the compliments today?”

“What's wrong with compliments?” Phainon hummed playfully. He finally took a bite of the steak, and he had to stop himself from trying to swallow the rest of the entire steak in one bite. It was absolutely delicious, tender, and juicy. The marinade brought out an enhanced flavor of the steak that danced across Phainon's tongue, and the meat basically melted in his mouth. It was perfectly salted, and the mushrooms added an even more savory flavor that truly did pair very nicely with the lamb steak now that he was

eating them together. Phainon couldn't emphasize it anymore in his head that Mydei was truly perfect at everything.

“I just feel they're very over the top today.”

“I haven't seen you in a full day. How could you blame me?”

Phainon playfully batted his eyelashes at Mydei, who only scoffed once more with a shake of his head.

“I wanted to ask,” Phainon glanced towards the flowers, which were propped up at one end of the table, “what are your favorite flowers? I only bought pomegranate flowers because I knew you liked that pomegranate tea from the café.”

A gentle hand brushed through the petals of the blood orange flowers that were just beginning to bloom. “My favorites *are* pomegranate flowers. You made the correct choice.”

A light pink tinted Phainon's cheeks as he smiled, taking another hearty bite of the steak and mushrooms. “I'm glad to hear you enjoy them. They really do suit you.”

“Pomegranate? Or these flowers?”

“Both.” Phainon laughed. “Everything suits you, Mydei.”

With a burning face, Mydei dug more into his food without another response.

It was a few minutes of comfortable silence as they enjoyed the lavish meal before them. It reminded Phainon of their days in the corporate cafeteria, where Mydei didn't seem the least pleased to be anywhere near him. Though, their silences back then were anything but comfortable to Phainon, and he was always struggling to fill in the silence with the sound of his own voice.

But now here Phainon was, cooking and eating dinner right in that man's very home. The same man that had previously treated him with so much

disdain, and the same home that Mydei had sworn he would never bring Phainon to. He silently laughed at the memory, grabbing more salad to load his plate with.

“Phainon.”

Mydei’s voice eventually ended their silence, but at the sudden serious tone in his voice, Phainon immediately paused at the sound of his name, glancing upwards from his plate. He had never seen Mydei appear so conflicted before, with his furrowed eyebrows, deep scowl, and his flickering gaze. Phainon frowned at the sight, lowering his utensils. He almost wanted to go over there and hold him comfortingly.

“Is there something wrong, Mydei?”

Mydei immediately shook his head, but his eyes were still glued to the table. “No, nothing at all. I asked you over because I wanted to tell you something. I…”

Phainon rushed from his seat when he saw Mydei physically flinch, and he kneeled at his side at the other end of the table to look up as best as he could into his trembling, golden eyes. The man was shaking, and he wanted to hold him close and tell him that everything would be okay, but he didn't even know what Mydei was feeling conflicted about in the first place. What could be so important that they had to discuss in person and in private at Mydei's own home?

He hesitantly parted his lips, furrowing his eyebrows together and trying to get Mydei to look at him. “Mydei?”

A deep, long breath left Mydei’s chest, and his body stopped vibrating in his seat. Resolute golden eyes locked onto Phainon's, and the breath caught in his throat at the suddenly sharp gaze being directed at him.

“Phainon, I'm thinking of closing the bakery.”

Chapter 21

“The…”

Phainon couldn’t get his voice to work. He was too busy staring at Mydei with wide eyes and his jaw slack.

Mydei’s gaze was downcast at the news, and another deep, shaky breath left his body. Phainon snapped back to reality at the sound and quickly grasped his hands, squeezing tightly as Mydei continued to explain: “I’ve… been thinking about this for a few weeks now. If I become the CEO, I also cannot run the bakery. I just won't have the time.”

These thoughts also ran through Phainon’s mind earlier, but he thought it was too soon to consider his new position as CEO. But instead of bringing it up, Phainon kept quiet to let Mydei finish.

“These days, I don’t even have the time now. At this time, right now, I would be sleeping to wake up early for the bakery tomorrow. But right now, all I want is to be awake with you. All I want… is to spend time with you.”

The words settled within Phainon as his gaze flickered to the quivering hands that were holding him tightly. “The bakery… Mydei, I don’t want you to close the bakery because of me. If anything, if you want to spend more time with me, I can go to the bakery with you again and again. However many times you want, I will go with you every time.”

Mydei immediately shook his head. “I don’t want to make you wake up with me every day when we also have a full workday in the office. That’s… That would be impossible to ask of you.”

“Mydei, I don’t mind–”

“*I* mind, Phainon,” Mydei sharply interjected. “*I* don’t want you having to live like this every day. I don’t even want to be living like this myself.” His weakening voice was quieting into a murmur, and Phainon hated how Mydei looked like he was holding himself back. He wanted Mydei to be

able to speak with him properly and express everything that he was feeling in his heart. He didn’t want Mydei to hide anything from him.

“Mydei…” Phainon squeezed the warm hands in his. “I’m not going anywhere, Mydei. If you want to keep it–”

The other man shook his head once more. “I shouldn’t keep it.” He swallowed thickly, most likely to soothe his aching throat. “It has been long enough. I will eventually have to close it when I become the CEO. And I… I’m not closing it just for you.”

“Is it… because you want more time to yourself? Don't you like baking, Mydei?”

“I…” The hands within his vision began to vibrate more violently, and Phainon immediately released his grip to wrap his arms around the trembling man instead. He hugged him tightly, breathing in that beautifully familiar scent of freshly baked bread and sweets as Mydei buried his face into the crook of Phainon’s neck.

“I have someone else to bake for now.” Shaking hands clutched at Phainon’s hoodie, and he pulled his lover closer against his body. Mydei's voice was soft, low, and muffled against Phainon's neck. “I don’t need to bake for my mother anymore. That was the only reason I kept the bakery going. Because it was my mother’s. Something that my mother left for me, and something that I clung to forever. But now I… have someone else who will look forward to my creations. Someone else who will be with me when I am baking.”

“I will always be here, Mydei.” Phainon squeezed him tightly. “I will always be here to taste your cooking, your pastries, your desserts. Everything that you make, I will be here to try them all.”

“I know you will be.” A breathless laugh and warm breath ghosted against Phainon’s neck. “That’s why… I think it’s time now. I have to let her go. I can't keep living this life, working a job that I don't need, and keeping the bakery alive. I love baking, but I don't need the bakery for that. It is a remnant of my past, one that I want to let go of. I will ask my backup if

they want the bakery, but if not, it will be shut down completely. As for all the current employees… I will be supporting them for a little while until they can find a new job."

"But that's…" Phainon couldn't help but frown. He knew how much Mydei treasured that bakery, and he knew how much that bakery meant for Mydei. "Surely, you could find someone else to keep the bakery open? Hire more staff? Or, why don't you become a full-time baker instead? Leave the office life behind, and work only for the bakery."

"I don't want just anyone to keep the bakery running just for the sake of keeping the bakery running," Mydei firmly explained. His body had stopped trembling in Phainon's arms, but he never made a move to leave. "At that point, I would rather shut it down if the bakery ends up changing from what it used to be. I'd rather let my mother's bakery close down as it was rather than have it transform into something completely unrecognizable.

"I don't want to keep living within the memories of my mother anymore. I want to transform Kremnos Corporation back to what it was supposed to be. It is my responsibility to turn this company around, to return to what it started as, but I can't keep the bakery alive at the same time. And I don't want to."

Phainon stayed silent. The reasoning was sound, but he couldn't help but lament the bakery's destiny. Surely, Mydei didn't need to sell the entire bakery to grow from his mother's memories? There had to be another way, right? But Mydei… seemed so adamant about this. Was Phainon just biased because Mydei still had something tangible left of his past, something that Phainon would never have?

"My father… has told me that he is thinking of retiring soon."

It felt like a bucket of ice cold water was dumped onto him, and Phainon's entire body became frozen solid. So that was why Mydei seemed so intent on selling the bakery now. That was why he was already considering his new position as CEO. Because that new position was going to be coming so much sooner than anyone would've ever expected.

Mydei took another deep breath. “I don't have the time to hire new staff anymore. It is the last thing my mother left for me, and I don’t want this bakery to be marred at the cost of staying alive if I cannot train the staff myself. Even my backup baker does not make the pastries exactly the same as I, or the same as my mother.” Mydei’s voice was soft and wistful, and Phainon tightened his hold once more around him. “But I… want to move on too. I will be fine. I will live without the bakery. It’s… about time. Time to let the bakery go, and the memories of my mother go. I shouldn't be… holding on for this long.”

It was his words that immediately reminded Phainon of something, and with a soft kiss on top of his golden hair, Phainon whispered to the other man that he would be back with something. As much as he didn’t want to part from those saddened, golden eyes and those downturned, quivering lips, Phainon knew this was something that Mydei would want to see. So he dashed off as fast as he could to the next room, bringing back the gift bag he had brought inside Mydei’s home with the pomegranate flowers.

Golden eyes glistening with tears stared confusedly at the gift bag being handed to him. “What is it?”

“Open it.” With a soft smile, Phainon gently shook the bag he was holding out in front of him. “I think you’ll like it.”

Hesitant hands took the gift bag from Phainon, and his eyes widened and his breath stopped at the sight before him once the tissue paper had been discarded on the table.

“This is…”

“You said the bakery was the only thing your mother left for you.” Phainon kneeled onto the ground once more, watching Mydei’s complicated expression with tender eyes. “But there’s also something else she left for you.”

Mydei’s hands were shaking again, grasping the book from the gift bag and carefully opening the children’s book. The spine cracked under his hands, echoing in the dining room, as he flipped through each of the pages. All the

stories of the little chimeras that Mydei had grown so closely and familiar with were spelled out in front of his very eyes.

“It’s… real.”

“It’s real, Mydei.” Phainon gently nudged him. “It’s all yours.”

The sound of a drop echoed in Phainon’s ears, and he immediately glanced from the book to see that tears had begun pooling in the corners of Mydei’s eyes and running down his face, hitting the thick book pages. He jumped into action, cradling those soft cheeks while swiping at the tears that had begun to spill.

“Sorry, I kept forgetting to give it to you earlier. It was in my room the entire time you stayed at my apartment last week.” A breathless laugh left Phainon, followed by a soft smile as he continued catching the tears running down Mydei’s face. “I hope you like my gift for you, Mydei.”

Those beautiful golden eyes, still shimmering with tears, finally tore themselves from the children’s book. He was on that page that Phainon was so familiar with: The page of Fig Stew giving Vigethos a flower when he was crying.

“I love it, Phainon.” His voice cracked, and Phainon knew his throat was burning. But he was relishing in the tender, quivering smile that danced across Mydei’s lips, and before Phainon knew it, the children’s book had been set onto the table as he was pulled into a tight embrace.

“When we get older, Mydei,” Phainon whispered into Mydei’s ear, “we can open our own bakery.”

“Our own bakery?”

Phainon hummed in agreement. “This isn’t the end of your bakery, Mydei. We can always open a new one. One that your mother would love to visit. I’m sure that she would love to see a new bakery too.”

Mydei returned the breathless laugh, his body shaking within Phainon's arms. "One that my mother would love to visit… That sounds nice."

"Doesn't it?" Phainon pressed a kiss against Mydei's ear, rubbing his hand along Mydei's backside. "We can run our own little bakery together once you pass on Kremnos Corporation to someone else, and I can be your little helper."

Another laugh left Mydei. "Surely you don't mean the help that you gave me on Monday?"

"That's…" Phainon buried his pout and his burning face away, pushing his face into Mydei. "I wasn't *really* hired on Monday. When I am an actual employee, I will be much more serious."

"Right." A weak scoff vibrated against Phainon's neck. "That means I have to teach you how to bake, if you want to get this serious about it."

"I will be your devoted student, Mydei. I promise."

Mydei finally separated himself from Phainon's embrace, and Phainon stared into those loving, golden eyes that were glistening in the light. Mydei's cheeks were slightly flushed, with puffy eyes, and lips shimmering in tears. Phainon brought his hands up once more, caressing Mydei's face.

"I won't go easy on you, Phainon."

"I wouldn't expect anything less."

A brief silence settled between them, but Phainon was too busy to notice the silence. He was too busy staring into Mydei's golden eyes, counting the eyelashes that framed his beautiful gaze, and watching his golden bangs brush gently against his face.

"I… also have something else to ask you."

Phainon raised an inquisitive eyebrow and tilted his head to the side. "Something to ask me?"

Mydei nodded. “You remember the COO, correct?”

Phainon slowly nodded.

“I plan to tell him that… we're dating.” Mydei cleared his throat over the deep blush that began to bloom across his face. “I want to know if that's okay with you.”

“Is that…” Phainon's mind, which was in a gentle and comforting mode, could not handle this sudden switch in conversation. Was it okay for the COO of the company to know that information?

“I want to tell him… as a close adult figure of mine. He may be the COO, but he was first a close family friend of my parents.”

“I see.” Phainon knew Krateros was close with his parents, due to Krateros's vendetta against the Black Tide and Mydei’s father as well, but he didn't realize their history went so far. “If you want to tell him, I don't mind at all. I mean, I technically told my family, after all.”

A quiet laugh left Mydei's lips. “I didn't realize we were already being introduced to each other's families.”

“Our families, huh?” It was ironic to hear such a statement, and Phainon couldn't help but join Mydei’s quiet laughter. “Oh, speaking of, Cyrene has been begging me to ask when you're free, but with the bakery closing down, it might not be for a while, right?”

Mydei slowly nodded. “Give her my apologies. Once I start going through the process of either transferring ownership or closing it down entirely, I will be very busy. I hope… that's okay with you.”

“Of course that's okay with me.” Phainon softly pressed his lips against Mydei's, savoring his soft lips and the salty taste that still lingered on his lips, before pulling back. He swept his hand through golden bangs once more, admiring those beautiful shimmers of gold hiding behind. “You do what you need to do, Mydei, and I'll be here every step of the way, whenever you need.”

“Thank you, Phainon.” There was a guilty emotion swirling in his golden eyes, alongside gratefulness, relief, and love. Phainon tenderly rubbed small circles into his cheeks while trailing his drying tear tracks with a tender smile.

“There's nothing you need to thank me for,” Phainon murmured. “I'm glad that I was finally able to get this book into your hands again. And I'm proud… that you're also taking a step forward.”

“I want to be with you, Phainon, wherever you are. If you are taking a step forward, I must do so as well if I want to stay by your side.”

A laugh escaped Phainon's lips, and he pulled Mydei into another tight embrace. “Mydei, even if you were behind me, which you never would be, I would turn around and pull you up right beside me.”

“I would never want you to pull me up yourself.” Mydei weakly scoffed. He buried his face back into the crook of Phainon's neck. “I would rather walk right beside you on my own, right next to you.”

“And you always will be, Mydei, no matter what.”

Phainon was planning on going home after dinner, but he decided to stay with Mydei for the rest of the night. He didn't want to leave him alone after that conversation, and he wanted to see Mydei flipping through the children's book he had gotten for him.

They finished the rest of their dinner, which was practically cooled down after their conversation, and they cleaned up the dining table of all the dishes and cooking utensils together. The entire time, Phainon always had his eyes on Mydei, making sure that the man was still okay. He could tell the previous conversation about the bakery still lingered in his mind and weighed heavily on his heart, and it hurt Phainon that he couldn’t do anything to help him. Occasionally, Phainon would come over to Mydei, pressing soft kisses against him and telling him that everything would work out, that this wasn't the end for Mydei and his bakery, and with tears glistening in the kitchen lighting, Mydei would nod silently.

Mydei was having his own growth. He was taking his own step forward in his life, away from the path that used to chain him before. He had been clinging to the memories of his mother, the bakery, and the words of that children's storybook, and he was slowly undoing everything one by one. Mydei was becoming a new person, his *own* person. If Mydei needed him, Phainon would be there, right by his side and supporting him, just as Mydei had done with his yellow roses and little notes. It was the least that Phainon could do to show his love to the other man, and it was the least he could do for the person who never gave up on Phainon, even when Phainon wanted to give up on his own self.

At least, that was what Phainon wanted to tell himself. Why was this not sitting right with him? He agreed that Mydei was moving on, and he agreed that Mydei would no longer be living in the memories of his mother. But did that all really have to lead up to selling the bakery? The bakery was under Mydei's name now. Sure, his mother had opened it, but it was Mydei's now. So why did *he* have to sell *his own* bakery? Could Phainon not see Mydei's perspective solely because Phainon wished to have something of his own from his past?

Even then, Phainon could not think of another solution. Hire more staff? Mydei didn't have the time to train them. Find a new owner? The bakery might change beyond what was recognizable. Become a full-time baker? Then what? Abandon Kremnos Corporation entirely? The more Phainon wracked his brain, the more he realized this was the only path left. Was there any other way to keep the bakery going? Phainon didn't have the money to buy it from him if the bakery really did go up for sale. Would he just… have to hope that the backup baker would take over? Was that really the only way?

Once they were done putting everything away, Mydei led him to his bedroom upstairs. It was just as luxurious as downstairs. There was a very long staircase that led up to the second floor, and there, Phainon could find another seating area just on top of the landing, with double doors leading to a huge terrace outside. Down the hallway, there were more rooms available, which was where Mydei led him, and over the railing on his left, Phainon had an expansive view of the entire downstairs space.

“Do you want a separate room?” Mydei stopped in the middle of the hallway, with Phainon quickly halting his steps right behind him. There were multiple doors ahead of them and to their right.

“A separate room?” Phainon raised an eyebrow. An amused smile crept upon his lips as he tilted his head to the side. “Afraid I'll do something?”

“Wha–” Mydei immediately clicked his tongue, tearing his eyes away from Phainon. But no matter what he did, Phainon could still make out his burning ears behind golden hair. “I just thought to offer. Sleep wherever you want, but my room is at the very end.”

“Then, I guess my room is at the very end.”

With a scoff coming from the other man, they proceeded to the door at the very end of the hallway. Mydei's room was absolutely ginormous; it was probably just as big as Phainon's entire apartment space. There was so much space that the room practically looked empty. Phainon didn't think he would be able to fill up this entire space by himself either, and it was so big that there was just another living room in here. Equipped with a king-sized bed and a desk setup, there was also a huge TV, couches, a coffee table, and rugs placed underneath the bed and the living room area. What caught Phainon's eyes were the guitars suspended on the walls in the living room area.

“You play guitar?”

“Only a little bit.” Mydei had placed the children's book on his nightstand and was already digging through a walk-in closet connected to his bedroom. “I don't have much time these days to play, but I used to when I was younger.”

“You talk like you're so old, Mydei.” Phainon chuckled, warily entering the open space before him. He didn't know where to approach first. “Maybe once the bakery closes, you can play for me sometime.”

A small smile grew upon Mydei’s lips as his hands searching through the closet slightly faltered. “I'll make sure to do that for you. It has been a long

time; I'll have to practice again.”

“I’d love to hear that too. It doesn't have to be perfect.”

“Then, I'll be sure to do that too.” Mydei approached Phainon with a change of clothes. It was a simple white T-shirt and sweatpants.

“You know, I actually brought a change of clothes with me.” Phainon laughed to himself at the thought, thanking Mydei and taking his clothes. “But it was my work clothes. I brought it in case the restaurant we were going to was too fancy for my jeans.”

A loud cough rang in the air as Mydei turned around, covering his laughter, but it only made Phainon laugh even louder.

“I thought it was obvious the building would not be a restaurant.” Mydei was still struggling to contain his laughter, and his body violently shook with every cough.

“How am I supposed to know?!” Phainon wailed, but he couldn't help the smile on his lips. It made him happy to see that Mydei was starting to feel a little better now. “I don't think I've ever stepped into such a fancy-looking place, except for maybe work itself.”

“Just go get changed.” With a clear of his throat, Mydei pushed him toward another door in the bedroom, which Phainon could only assume was the bathroom.

It was silent now once the door was closed behind him. It was a little too quiet after the previous conversations that were still swirling in his mind. A lot was going on, and a lot was happening, and Phainon vowed to try his best for Mydei. Although Phainon would've been shocked at the sight of the giant bathroom he was standing in, he was now fully aware of how heavy the clothes felt in his hand instead. There was now a new problem sprouting in Phainon's mind that was completely irrelevant to their previous conversations.

Phainon was going to wear Mydei’s clothes.

His hands started sweating as he raised the clothes up in front of him. They really were just simple clothes, but it was nothing but simple to Phainon. His brain, which was still thinking about the bakery, suddenly couldn't stop thinking about Mydei’s bare, sculpted chest, and how that same chest most definitely was pressed against this shirt, the same shirt that Phainon would also be pressing against his bare chest. He didn't even want to think about the pants, or Phainon’s heart might start beating so fast he would go into cardiac arrest.

Shaking his head rapidly back and forth, he tore his clothes off and shoved his limbs into Mydei’s clothes before he could delve more deeply into his thoughts. Mydei needed him out there, and this was no time for these sorts of imaginations.

He swung open the door, with the breeze from the door cooling down his heated face. Phainon marched into the bedroom and found that Mydei was sitting on his bed, with his back leaning against the headboard, while he flipped through *The Cycles of Vigethos*.

“Is it as you remembered?” Phainon folded his previous clothes neatly in a pile, which Mydei said he could just leave on the other nightstand.

“It is. The book is online, but it's not the same as having it in my hands like before.” There was a fond, gentle expression on his face as he flipped the pages, and Phainon wished he could ingrain this expression into his head forever. He resisted the urge to run his hand through his golden hair, to caress his face, and to plant kisses all over him. Phainon wanted so dearly to treasure his lover, and he couldn't even begin to pay Mydei back for everything that this man had ever given him.

Phainon climbed under the covers and joined Mydei in leaning against the headboard. “I'm surprised your father didn't take the online version down too.”

“I don't think he knows it exists.” Mydei laughed. “It emerged much later after his purge. I'm not sure where it came from. Maybe the author wanted it to keep on living. Or maybe another owner of this book uploaded it online.” He flipped to another page in the book. Vigethos and Fig Stew

were fighting a formidable opponent with two other chimera characters. “Truly, Phainon. Thank you.”

“Like I said earlier, you don't have to thank me for anything.” Phainon leaned over, pressing a tender kiss against his temple and playing with golden strands that were astray. He really couldn't stop himself from treasuring Mydei. “If anything, you can thank Cyrene for finding the antiques store. I don't know where she pulled that up from."

“Did you tell Cyrene about this book?”

“I was looking it up on my work computer, and Cyrene saw.”

Another quiet laugh shook Mydei's chest. “So you were looking up a children's book when you should've been working.”

“I–” Phainon couldn't think of an argument fast enough, which only contributed to Mydei laughing even more and Phainon's cheeks to flush. “I was… I was trying to think of other things to talk to you about.”

A hand ran through Phainon's hair. “You really tried hard to get my attention.”

“That's… *No*,” Phainon sharply retorted, his face only burning even more brightly at Mydei’s teasing. “I was just trying to find out what happened that night. That's it. Nothing more than that.”

Mydei chuckled. “Right. So what do you think now? After knowing what happened that night.”

“I wish I could remember what you looked like sleeping with me for the first time.” He wistfully and dramatically sighed as he slumped his head onto Mydei’s shoulder. Mydei was still turning the pages of the children's book, admiring each and every individual page underneath his fingertips. And Phainon watched him flipping through the pages, even reading pages that he could never get to before. “Hey, Mydei, do I look good in your clothes?”

“They're a little big on you. You should go to the gym more.”

“I wanted you to call me cute, Mydei.”

“You're cute, Phainon.”

Phainon couldn't help erupting into a laugh at his immediate compliment, and he swung an arm around Mydei's waist to pull him closer against him. It was clear Mydei loved his mother, from how much he treasured this children's book in his hands. Did he really… have to let go of the bakery too? As a part of moving on?

“Mydei… will you miss the bakery?”

“Of course I will,” Mydei muttered in response. His golden gaze was still trained on the pages of the book in his lap. “It has been with me almost my entire life, but as CEO, I won't have time for the bakery anymore. But now, I have someone else who wants to be with me for even longer. Someone who clings to me even more strongly than my desire to bake for my mother.”

Burying his face into Mydei's neck, Phainon scoffed and smiled against the warm skin against him. This scent of sweets and freshly baked bread was something Phainon would never tire of. “I'll be here, Mydei. Whenever you need me. Whenever you miss the bakery, just come to me instead.”

“This someone seems very possessive too.”

“I am not!”

“You seem very adamant about me baking for no one else except for yourself.”

“No one else should see you in an apron, Mydei.”

“No one else would pin me to my own counter, Phainon.”

Phainon physically flinched at the reminder, refusing to lift his gaze, and Mydei laughed at the reaction.

“You… would only let me pin you to the counter, right?”

“What kind of question is that?”

“Just answer the question.”

Mydei scoffed. “Yes. Are you happy now?”

A slow nod pressed against Mydei's shoulder as Phainon shut his eyes. With hands holding Mydei close, the warmth from his lover’s body radiating against him, the scent of a bakery wafting through his nose, and the monotonous sounds from the turning pages from *The Cycles of Vigethos* filling his ears, Phainon fell into a deep sleep, wondering if there was any other way to convince Mydei to keep the bakery, and wondering if he was in the wrong for not wanting to let go of that little bakery.

Chapter 22

Phainon was sweating. *Phainon was sweating.* And it was for a completely different reason than Chapter 15.

Mydeimos (8:32am): *Phainon.*

A message popped up on Phainon's computer screen, and he almost fell out of his office chair when he saw it was Mydei. What could he possibly need from him right now that he had to message him through the work chat? Maybe Phainon forgot something when he left Mydei's house? He didn't see Mydei when he woke up because Mydei left early to prepare for the bakery, but he left a spare key for Phainon on his counter for him to lock up when he left. Maybe he was asking for Phainon to return the key? But before he could even reply back, another message came through.

Mydeimos (8:32am): *The COO wants to meet with you.*

His heart immediately stopped.

Who wants to meet with him?! Right now?!

Phainon's palms started sweating so much that he could barely grip the computer mouse in his hand as he navigated to the chat window. It was the first work message Mydei had ever sent him; usually, when they needed work-related tasks completed, Phainon would just go directly to Mydei himself at his office, but he was way too nervous right now to relish Mydei's first-ever work message to him. Shaky hands barely managed to respond back.

Phainon (8:33am): *Right now???*

Mydeimos (8:33am): *After lunch.*

His heart sank at the message. That was even worse. That meant Phainon had to sit here for the entire rest of the day, just waiting for this meeting to take place while thinking of different ways this conversation could go.

Mydei should've told him the moment the meeting was supposed to start, so that Phainon didn't have so much time to panic by himself. Because now here Phainon was, bouncing his leg while sitting at his desk and re-reading Mydei's message multiple times instead of actually doing the work he was just doing before.

The COO wants to meet with you. The COO wants to meet with you.

Phainon was going to rip out his own hair. Was this going to be Phainon's version of meeting his boyfriend's parents? Was he about to get interrogated over why he's dating Mydei? Is he going to have to prove his love to Mydei? What if he didn't answer the COO's questions correctly?

Or worse, was Phainon going to be bribed to stop dating Mydei?!

They were rich, right?! The CEO was, Mydei was, and Phainon was sure the COO also was. Was Krateros about to bribe him to leave Mydei alone?! There was no amount of money that would make Phainon leave Mydei! Wait, would he get assassinated for saying that? Like in the movies?!

Phainon did not get a single thing done, and now it was his lunch break.

"You're going to be fine!"

Phainon was currently slumped on the cafeteria table, with Cyrene and Castorice patting him comfortingly.

"Just win him over with your charm, Phainon!" Cyrene was patting him on the head. "No one will be able to resist you!"

"I'm sure the COO can resist me plenty," Phainon mumbled against the table.

"I heard the COO is much more amicable than the CEO." Castorice was lightly patting him on the shoulder.

"Like, how much more amicable are we talking?" Phainon's voice was muffled from his face being pressed into the table. "Because the CEO is a zero for amicableness, so the COO could just be a five."

“*Much more* amicable, Phainon!”

“So like what? A thirty?”

“That's a thirty percent chance you won't get bribed or assassinated!”

“Those are not very good prospects, Cyrene.”

“Cyrene, I'm going to have to agree with Phainon on this one.”

“Oh, come on, guys!” Cyrene cried. “With Phainon's charm, that's like, times three! He has a ninety percent chance of not being assassinated!”

“I would rather my chances be one hundred percent for no assassination, thank you.”

“Phainon, you're *not* getting assassinated.” His head was swatted by a swift hand, and he flinched. “And Castorice, stop siding with him.”

A loud groan shook Phainon's chest as he begrudgingly pushed himself from the table. His salad was completely untouched and off to the side as he stared at the woman across from him with a downturned, but serious, gaze. “Cyrene, if this is the last time I will ever see you, I want you to know–”

“Stop, stop, *stop!*” A hand was immediately slapped over Phainon's mouth. “I do *not* want to hear your will right now.”

“I can help you write it, Phainon.”

“Castorice, stop siding with him!”

Phainon gently pushed Cyrene’s hand to the side, a deep sigh leaving his body along with the rest of his optimism. He couldn't help but be deathly anxious over meeting the COO. Mydei had said he was like a family friend, right? Wasn't that just another way of saying he was Mydei’s father figure, since no one truly liked his actual father? So, in less than an hour from now, Phainon was going to meet this man?

It felt like his heart was sinking into his stomach. His chest was twisting over just thinking about what could possibly go wrong, and it was so hard to breathe. Phainon was usually an optimist, but he was too afraid of messing up in front of someone Mydei really cared about. If Mydei had personally asked Phainon to tell the COO about them, Phainon couldn't even begin to imagine their close relationship. And it only made his anxiety grow higher and his stomach feel like a complete void.

“Phainon, at least eat.” Cyrene had shoved his salad bowl right in front of him again, from where it had been discarded and forgotten off to the side. “It wouldn't do you any good to meet the COO without eating lunch, right? And anyway, we already technically know the guy! He goes to the executive and human resources meeting every month, right?”

“So he's… just going to go straight to interrogating me?”

“Phainon, no!”

Another dramatic sigh left Phainon. There was less than half an hour already before their lunch ended, and the time was passing by faster than Phainon could've ever imagined. Where was this energy when Phainon was trying to go on his dinner date with Mydei yesterday?

Mydei had sent a calendar invite to him earlier, and all Phainon basically did was stare at that one-hour block on his calendar until their lunch break. Seriously, did Krateros *really* need a full hour? Surely they could wrap this up in about… twelve minutes, right? Phainon was going to suggest half an hour, but even that still sounded too long. Even five minutes sounded too long to be interrogated by the COO.

It was just a couple of minutes more of forcing the salad down his tightening throat, and Cyrene and Castorice trying to comfort him, before the inevitable time arrived. It truly felt like something was squeezing around his heart as he warily stood up from the cafeteria table. He barely even finished his salad, and Cyrene took the trash out of his hand.

“Phainon, tell us after how it goes, okay?” With her free hand, Cyrene squeezed his hand. “Good luck, Phainon.”

“You will do well, Phainon.” Castorice offered her prayers as well, smiling gently in his direction.

He managed a weak smile, bidding his farewells to the two of them before he proceeded to the meeting room Mydei had booked for them. It was the smaller meeting room in the executive department, where Phainon previously had his exit interviews before making up with Mydei. It seemed like he was going to cry again in this same meeting room, depending on how this interrogation with the COO went.

Phainon wasn't sure if they were already in the meeting room once he had arrived. The door was shut, and the window blinds were closed, so he raised his hand to knock, only to be immediately interrupted.

“Phainon.”

That deep, familiar voice stirred Phainon, and he whirled around to become face-to-face with gold.

“Mydei.”

It had been a while since Phainon had seen Mydei in the office, since he decided to stay as coworkers once they began dating, and he couldn't help but be completely awestruck at the sight. Mydei was wearing a bomber jacket this time over his usual dress shirt and tie, and it looked *really* good over his broad shoulders. With a brown belt, light colored pants, and matching brown leather shoes, Mydei was definitely a pleasing sight to see in the office. Phainon almost forgot about the nerves rushing through his body since eight in the morning.

“The COO will be coming soon. We can wait inside.”

Stiffly nodding, Phainon rigidly forced his hands onto the doorknob, opening the door and stepping aside for Mydei to enter first. With a nod towards Phainon's direction, Mydei disappeared inside, with Phainon following afterwards.

The door shut behind him, and Phainon immediately slammed his hands upon the conference table, where Mydei was just about to sit down, before he got jolted by the loud sound.

“Mydei. Am I going to die today?”

“... What?”

The expression of extreme confusion was evident across Mydei's face, but Phainon didn't move from his spot at all as he continued rambling about all of his anxious thoughts that had been bouncing inside his head all day.

“Is the COO going to assassinate me? Is he going to bribe me to stop dating you? Is he going to fire me if he doesn't like my answers? Is he going to–”

“*Phainon*.”

Phainon couldn't even believe it. He couldn't believe his own eyes at the sight before him. Mydei was *laughing* at him! The guy could barely even contain his snickering, no matter how much he tried, and here Phainon was, about to explode over meeting the COO and probably the closest adult figure in Mydei's life!

“Were you that worried about meeting him?” Mydei’s gentle voice and his reassuring smile somewhat relaxed Phainon, and he leaned toward the raised hand that Mydei had put up. “He's not going to do any of that, Phainon.”

“He's not?”

Hands tenderly cradled Phainon's cheeks. “No, Phainon. He doesn't have the jurisdiction to do any of that to any of my lovers.”

“... Lovers, plural? I thought *I* was your only lover.”

An exasperated sigh escaped Mydei’s lungs. “Sounds like you're okay now. I was just speaking generally.”

Phainon chuckled softly and continued leaning into the warm hands holding him. “I really was worried all day. I thought it was going to be like I was meeting your father.”

“I'm sure Krateros wants to meet you as my boyfriend today, but he won't be making you leave me or anything like that.”

“You promise?”

Mydei laughed lightly. “I promise, Phainon.”

“You guys done?”

Phainon swore his heart jumped with him when he jumped backwards, hitting the conference table with his knee and eliciting another muffled laugh from Mydei's direction. There, standing right behind Phainon, was the COO himself.

This wasn't their first meeting, technically. As Cyrene had said before, the COO attended the meetings with the executive department and the human resources department every month, so Phainon was at least somewhat familiar with him. Well, Phainon knew *of* him but didn't personally know him. He could recognize the COO by his dark brown hair, thick beard, and mustache that were all the same color. With graying front bangs, the most prominent part of the COO's appearance was a long scar down one side of his face.

“Sit, Krateros.” Mydei gestured to the conference table, and Phainon swiftly moved out of the way for the COO to sit himself at the table. Before Phainon could panic about where to sit, Mydei gently tugged on his hand, and with a breath of relief, Phainon sat down right beside him.

“I didn't realize this new side of you, Mydeimos. I'm impressed.” The COO huffed, crossing his arms. The action made Phainon’s eyes flicker toward the table, and his shoulders immediately started to relax at the sight before him. And the sight on the table was… absolutely nothing, which was exactly what Phainon wanted. No briefcase full of money, no assassination weapons, not even a pen and paper with interrogation questions on it.

Mydei scoffed, mirroring the COO in crossing his arms. “Impressed about what?”

With a slight chuckle, Krateros shook his head. “Nothing. This man is your boy lover?” His eyes locked with Phainon's. "I recognize you from the human resources department.”

Phainon was trying extremely hard not to sweat buckets in his work clothes, and he stiffly nodded, straining a smile as best as he could. “That's right. My name is Phainon. It's nice to meet you.”

Krateros hummed, leaning nonchalantly back into his chair. Krateros was… a lot more relaxed than Phainon was expecting. He was expecting a more tense atmosphere, the executive signature glare that he received so many times from Mydei, and a more serious tone of voice.

“Right. It's nice to meet you, Phainon. Mydeimos told me he has a lover now, and I just wanted to meet him. Since Eurypon won't be doing any of that.” It didn't escape anyone's notice when Krateros rolled his eyes upon mentioning the CEO.

“Was there anything you wanted to know?” Phainon offered. “I can answer anything you'd like.”

“No, no.” A hearty laugh shook Krateros’s chest, surprising Phainon. “I didn't come here to interrogate you. Is that what you thought?”

Phainon couldn't even bring himself to refute the claim, so he stayed silent instead.

Another laugh echoed in the conference room at Phainon's silence that indicated an obvious answer, and Krateros leaned forward to rest his elbows on the table between them. “Mydeimos is too stubborn to convince. Even if I didn't like you, Mydeimos would stay with you anyway. He's just that kind of guy. Whatever I say to you, or whatever I ask you, won't affect what Mydeimos will do next. Though, there is one thing I would like to bring up.”

Here it was. Krateros was leaning forward and staring at him with sharp eyes. It was exactly what Phainon had pictured all day before he stepped into this room, and he tensed, bracing himself for the interrogation that Krateros was going to bring. Krateros may have said he wasn't going to be questioning him, but surely some sort of warning or threat was going to come too, right? He could only hope that his answers were enough to impress the COO himself. Phainon may be experienced with interviews, but certainly not like this.

“Mydeimos informed me that you hail from the village that was used to test the Black Tide. And for that, I want to apologize.”

That was… the last thing Phainon was expecting to hear, and his breath caught in his throat at his words. A warm hand grasped his fist underneath the table, and his hand relaxed. Phainon didn't even realize he was shaking.

“I… There's nothing you need to apologize for.” With a gaze downcast toward the table, a smile of self-pity grew on Phainon's lips. “It was… a long time ago.”

“A long time ago or just yesterday, no one deserves to live through something like the Black Tide.” Krateros’s voice rang clearly amongst them. “The first time I saw the scientific research behind it, I knew… It had to be gone. No matter how heinous a crime, I cannot imagine any village, city, or country going through such a thing. Mydeimos has told you, correct? That we plan to destroy it.”

Phainon solemnly nodded.

A sigh came from the COO across from him. “Mydeimos… Is there anything you haven't told your boyfriend?”

The man next to Phainon coughed, and Phainon couldn't help but crack a smile at the teasing words.

“I tell him everything.”

“Okay, I get it. You're in love. Get out.”

Phainon immediately shot his head up from where he was staring at the table, with Mydei following the exact same movements.

“What?” Krateros returned to crossing his arms across his chest while staring at the two men staring at him with wide eyes. “I have some things to tell Phainon. So get out.”

Mydei scoffed, raising an eyebrow. “You’re going to tell him without me here?”

“What do you think ‘get out’ means?” Krateros returned the scoff. “What, you can't leave your boyfriend for ten minutes?”

“What are you telling him?” Mydei narrowed his eyes, causing Krateros to laugh once more.

“*Relax*. I won't bite. Your loving boyfriend will return safely to your arms right after this. Don't you have the transition work to be doing?”

A silence crept into the conference room, with Phainon constantly switching his gaze back and forth between the two employees of the executive department. They were having some sort of staredown, or some sort of silent communication, and Phainon could only sit there and wait on the sidelines for the result of their nonverbal argument.

A deep sigh finally left Mydei's lips, and he slowly pushed himself from the office chair after squeezing Phainon's hand one more time.

“Krateros, if you do something to him–”

“I'm not going to do anything to him.” It was the most serious Krateros had sounded this entire conversation besides when he brought up the Black Tide. “If I do, Phainon can go and tell you, right?”

At the expectant stare the COO was giving him, Phainon instinctively and automatically nodded. Truthfully, it did not matter what Krateros said; Phainon was going to nod anyway if the COO of the company he was employed at was staring at him like that.

“See? So go and return to your office. With the transition coming up soon, Eurypon will be bothering you a lot. Wouldn't want to be caught not at your desk, right?”

Hesitant golden eyes flickered between Krateros and Phainon, but Mydei couldn't argue with that logic and soon exited the conference room right after warning Eurypon one last time.

The door shut behind Mydei, with the noise booming in Phainon's ears and sounding louder than usual. It rattled his already pounding heart, and it felt like the temperature had dropped multiple degrees in the conference room. Phainon didn't want to tear his eyes away from where Mydei last stood, and his gaze was still trained on the conference room door.

“Mydeimos tells you everything, right?” Krateros's voice finally filled the brief silence between them.

Tearing his eyes away from the door to stare at the intimidating COO across from him, Phainon rigidly nodded. “I would like to assume he does.”

“Then, he told you that he's becoming the CEO soon, yes?”

Phainon nodded once more. “He said his father was thinking of retiring.”

Krateros's expression appeared somber at the news, and a deep sigh shook the man's chest as he leaned back in his chair. “That's right. As much as Eurypon would like to live as the CEO forever and ever, running this place until he dies, Mydeimos has proved to be… too good at his job.”

“Too good at his job?”

“The executives and board of directors all love him. They think Mydeimos would make a great CEO, and they have been pushing to make Mydeimos the CEO for quite some time now. He's old enough now, has worked long enough now, and knows more than enough now. There aren't enough excuses left for Eurypon to keep pushing them back.”

“So… the CEO is going to follow what the executives say?” Even the words sounded wrong coming out of Phainon's mouth.

Krateros laughed. “*Hah!* Yeah, right. He's going to keep clinging to this position forever. There's no way in Hell he's going to let it go. But Mydeimos intends on gathering the support of the higher-ups and forcing Eurypon to retire.”

“*Forcing* the CEO to retire?” Phainon's eyes were wide with shock. Was that even possible?

“It's possible.” It was like Krateros could read his thoughts. Was this just the power of the executive department? “The CEO may own the company, but the higher-ups and board of directors may boot the CEO if necessary. And if they think the CEO has been in this position for too long, think Mydeimos would be a better fit, or for any other reason, the executives can band together and get rid of the CEO. Eurypon brought Mydeimos here to keep his company forever, but now it might just backfire on him after Mydeimos basically overthrows him early.”

Holy fuck. Was this really happening in Phainon's workplace? An entire coup d’etat was occurring? And Mydei was running the whole thing?

“I'm sure Mydeimos hasn't gotten into the full details. I'm sure all he's told you is that he's becoming the CEO soon, or that Eurypon is thinking of retiring soon.” Another tired sigh filled the conference room. “Mydeimos is… very headstrong, as I said earlier. Very stubborn, very intent, and very headstrong. He knows what he wants, and he will get it. Which brings me to my next point.”

There was a next point? Phainon didn't think his mind could handle any more classified information.

“Is this… alright for me to hear?” A weak chuckle finally left Phainon's throat. “I… I mean, I work here.”

“I have deemed it to be fine. Why else are we in this cushy conference room with soundproofing?” Krateros waved his hand nonchalantly in the

air. “I brought this all up as some background because I want to discuss the bakery.”

“The bakery?” Phainon's breath stopped at its mention. It was safe to assume Mydei told the COO his plans for the bakery.

Krateros slowly nodded. “This is all due to the bakery. Did Mydeimos tell you?”

“That he's… closing it down?” Phainon muttered. He didn't want to think about the bakery's unfortunate end right now.

“He really does tell you everything.” Krateros laughed to himself. “But yes, he told me this morning he plans to sell it. Which is why I immediately asked if I could meet you.”

Phainon tried with all his might to search for the answers in Krateros's smug expression, but he couldn't find anything at all. He belonged to the human resources department, not the mind-reading executive department, apparently. But, if Krateros was bringing this up, then…

“Do you have a plan for the bakery?”

A smirk crossed Krateros's expression, and Phainon’s entire body stilled. There was no way, right? Did Krateros have his own plan for the bakery? Something that Phainon couldn't think of before? He swallowed thickly, anticipating the final answer as Krateros opened his mouth.

“Let him sell the bakery. We'll let him do what he wants, like he always does. And we won't tell him a thing.”

“Won't tell him a thing?”

“*I* will buy the bakery.”

His entire body went slack. It felt like Phainon's head was going to explode. His heart was ringing so loudly in his ears that he could barely even process what the COO had just said, and he struggled to even part his lips as he breathlessly forced the words out with his failing voice, “Buy the bakery?”

Phainon *did* consider buying the bakery right from Mydei's hands for a single second, but he immediately disregarded the thought because he didn't have the funds. But, the COO of a large corporation? He definitely had the money to buy a little bakery.

“The moment Mydeimos puts it on sale, I will buy it.” Krateros's eyes sparkled with a dangerous emotion. “Let him do what he wants, and I will bring it right back to him.”

“But, why?” Phainon couldn't help but be attached to the bakery. He's visited multiple times, spoken with the staff there, and even opened with Mydei one time. But if Mydei's previous words were correct, Krateros never visited the bakery even once. So why did he want to keep it so badly? Badly enough to buy it the moment it goes up for sale?

“With what is going on with the company right now, with the conflict that is about to ensue between Mydeimos and the board of directors against the CEO, he will have zero time for the bakery,” Krateros stated. “That is a fact. He won't succeed if he's distracted with this… little bakery.”

“Then–”

“He claims it is so he can forget about Gorgo, so he can move on from her.” Krateros was leisurely tapping a finger against the conference table. “He says he is stuck in the past and wants to move on, but I think that’s all nonsense.”

“Nonsense?”

“Mydeimos will be stuck in the past forever until Eurypon is finally taken down.”

The words weighed heavily upon Phainon's shoulders, and he couldn't bring himself to respond.

“Whether or not the bakery is closed, Mydeimos will be stuck in the past until revenge is exacted upon Eurypon. Until the Black Tide is gone, and until Mydeimos succeeds in what he plans to do, Mydeimos will continue

with or without the bakery. It's just more convenient for him and for his plans if the bakery is gone, so he has more time."

"Does it matter to you then?" Phainon couldn't help himself from asking the burning question at the forefront of his mind. "If he's going to do what you both planned to do for a long time now, then wouldn't you also want the bakery to stay closed?"

"Mydeimos does not want to be CEO."

"He… doesn't?"

It was as if Krateros had to force the words out of his own mouth. He didn't seem to be the least pleased with this information. "Mydeimos has made it very clear to me. He sees this as a responsibility. That this is what he needs to do, and what he should do. Mydeimos cares about the employees and the company itself, and he believes it is the right thing to do to guide this company back onto the correct path. But he has never once said he wanted to."

I've never thought about whether I liked my job or not. This is… just a job I have to do.

Words from a long time ago rang in Phainon's head. The answer that Mydei had given him when Phainon asked if he liked his job. Mydei… never said he wanted to be CEO. Not even once.

"I think Mydeimos would make a great CEO. Even more than that, I think Mydeimos would be an amazing CEO." Krateros regrettably sighed. "He is an exemplary example of a leader, who cares about the company, his employees, and what they do. It's a shame that… it is not what he wants to do. Mydeimos will be CEO for a long time, to do what he must do in turning this company around. But I know Mydeimos will always be thinking of that bakery in the back of his mind. Do you see this scar on me?"

Phainon was slightly taken aback by the sudden question. "The one across your eye?"

Krateros chuckled. “I was in the car with Gorgo when she died. This scar is a result of that. Mydeimos was never supposed to be here. He was supposed to be with Gorgo, along the river forever, making… whatever he makes in that bakery. During their divorce, I kept in touch with both of them. But when I saw the lengths Eurypon would go through to secure his company forever, when I have a physical reminder upon my face forever, that was when I began to switch sides.”

It was already a shock to hear that Krateros lived through such a big event, and Phainon's head was swirling from all this information. “So you're… going to let Mydei leave and run the bakery in the future?”

Another regrettable sigh filled the space between them. “It's not what I want, that's for sure. But it's what Mydeimos wants. Even if he doesn't say it out loud. I've already argued about it with him before. I wanted him to sell that bakery *years* ago, but Mydeimos was intent on keeping that bakery back then. So imagine my surprise when I heard this morning that he was selling it.

“It makes sense. Eurypon is finishing up gathering the funds for the Black Tide, and Mydeimos needs to take over Kremnos Corporation *right now.* Eurypon is thinking of retiring once he gets those rights, and Mydeimos is going to take over before that happens. He doesn't have the time or the need for the bakery right now. Which is why I'm going to buy it, and tear it down.”

“*Tear it down?!”* Phainon slammed his hands against the table before he could stop himself.

“*Relax*.” Krateros nonchalantly waved his hand once more. “I'm going to rebuild a whole new bakery. By the time Mydeimos is ready to step down from the company in the future, many years from now, once all his responsibilities and goals have been fulfilled, a new bakery will be waiting for him. He won't have to worry about the bakery while he is CEO. Because it won't exist until a new bakery is ready for him at the end of his career.”

“A new bakery…” Phainon slumped in his chair, with his shoulders immediately dropping.

“Whether I buy this bakery or not, Mydeimos will step down from CEO anyway. That's why I wanted to speak with you today. Think of a name for the new bakery. I know you know Mydeimos the best, so I trust you can come up with the perfect name. I kind of need a new name eventually if I'm building a whole new store.” Krateros crossed his arms. “Mydeimos wants his own bakery, away from his mother. So I will give him just that. He will have an entirely new bakery, under an entirely new name, opened by him entirely. It's about time anyway; that bakery is behind its time.

“By then… I'll have to figure out who will carry on this company, because I know Mydeimos is going to put all that responsibility on me later.” Krateros scoffed incredulously at the situation that hadn't even happened yet. “Maybe by then, Mydeimos might merge the company with another company that has the same goals as ours. That is probably what will end up happening.”

Another loud, exasperated, and disappointed sigh left the COO. “If I had the choice, I would keep him as CEO of this company, but I don’t see that happening. So think of a name, and don't say a word of what I told you today. I don't want Mydeimos to think about that bakery for another second more than necessary.”

Their meeting ended just like that, with the COO exiting the meeting room after his final words.

Chapter 23

The bakery was being sold.

Mydei had messaged Phainon about it a few days after they had spoken with the COO, and Phainon hadn't seen Mydei very much since then. News of his becoming the CEO hadn't come out to the company yet, which most likely meant that Mydei, Krateros, and the board of directors were either still working to overthrow his father or working through some sort of transition until it was officially announced.

The final date for the bakery was several weeks from now. Mydei was still working hard to keep the bakery open until its final days while also wrapping everything up with the bakery. He was dealing with a lot of things at the moment: selling the bakery, keeping it running until its final days, dealing with the Black Tide rights, and transitioning to become the new CEO.

Phainon understood that he wouldn't be seeing Mydei for a long while. Mydei worked early in the mornings for the bakery, and he was even starting to stay after the company had closed to complete more of his work. Phainon always kept his eyes on him from a distance and texted him every now and then to check in on him, just to make sure he was still okay. And even though Mydei’s responses were now often late and brief, he never failed to respond to every single one of Phainon's messages. They rarely even spoke to each other in the office anymore. As the weeks progressed, Phainon was starting to see more of the actual department assistant rather than Mydei, so documents that needed to be signed were passed to them instead of going through Mydei, which made Phainon figure that something was definitely happening behind the scenes.

Over text, Phainon asked if Mydei knew who was buying the bakery. He said he didn't, only that the seller said they wanted to make their own building and were looking into speaking with the city to tear the whole thing down. Phainon couldn't tell how Mydei felt about it through his formal text messages, and he had to stop the urge from spilling everything

to Mydei. He wanted to tell Mydei that the bakery wasn't truly gone, that it wasn't going to be rebuilt into an entirely different store. It was going to be Mydei's new bakery, one that Phainon still had to think of a name for. But he did his best to keep the information to himself while brainstorming different names.

Funny enough, Phainon also exchanged numbers with the COO. The COO had messaged him through the work chat right after their conversation. It was a simple message that consisted only of ten digits. Phainon added the number to his phone, but they never exchanged any messages after that work message.

So for the next few weeks, Phainon returned to how he spent his days before. They were the days from before when he went about his life without Mydei. He would work in the office and return home in a never-ending cycle. It was a little unsettling at first; his eyes were constantly drawn to the color yellow for the first couple of weeks, constantly seeking that man and perking up at even the slightest of gold. It was during those early days that he had messaged Mydei often, usually multiple times a day, without fail.

He couldn’t help feeling empty without Mydei at his side, who had solidified his presence in Phainon's life, and Phainon was always itching to tell Mydei something. But after seeing how prolonged his responses were and how brief his messages had become, Phainon began to pull back, only asking if he was still eating well and reminding him to have a good night's sleep. Mydei was a busy man; Phainon would see him later.

There were some weekends he went out with Cyrene and Castorice, either out to eat or to the mall were the most normal things they did. But Cyrene's spontaneous adventures never stopped, and she somehow roped Castorice into starting to get her own motorcycle license too. Phainon had a lot of joy trying to watch and teach Castorice how to drive a motorcycle–one that Cyrene had to rent because neither of them owned one either.

They helped to take his mind off of missing Mydei’s presence, and he apologized to them that they couldn't spend time with Mydei as they had wanted before. They quickly reassured Phainon that they could wait however long Mydei needed, and they were always welcome to spend time

with him later. It also seemed like Castorice was quite the busy woman, so there were many days when it returned to just Phainon and Cyrene, just like how his story began a long time ago.

But throughout all of these weeks of returning to his monotonous life before Mydei, Phainon couldn't stop thinking about the bakery. Most of all, he was trying to think of a good name to give to Krateros.

What possible name would be good enough for Mydei’s new bakery? He really wanted to name it something that meant a lot to Mydei, was something that came from his past, yet also meant something for Mydei’s future. He wanted the name to emphasize that Mydei had moved on and was growing as a person, but he never forgot about his roots. But that would be complicated to capture in a single bakery name. And Phainon wouldn't be able to ask anyone for name suggestions without delving into Mydei's past either, so he was just left to his own devices.

Every time he went out, he would think about Mydei and the bakery. Every store name he passed by in the city, Phainon would note each one that piqued his interest. But nothing was a truly perfect name, and Phainon always came up empty whenever he tried to think of a name. If Krateros, someone who had known Mydei for the majority of his life, was asking *Phainon* for a name for the bakery, Phainon had to make sure it was perfect.

Another deep sigh left Phainon's body. Today, he was in the biggest meeting room on the floor to conduct a stream of reference checks, and he just didn't want to be talking for hours on end at the cubicles. But the only meeting room available at this time was the big one that was used for the monthly executive and human resources meetings. So here Phainon was, in this giant space, setting up his laptop to call a bunch of references all by himself.

These past few weeks have been filled with nothing except long, exhausted sighs. Not because returning to his monotonous life was difficult or anything. Sure, he missed Mydei a lot, but Mydei always made sure to respond to his messages whenever Phainon texted him. It was because his mind was constantly overworking to come up with a name for the bakery. Should he ask Mydei for his favorite bakeries and come up with a similar

name? Would that be too obvious? Maybe he could ask Mydei for bakery suggestions now that Phainon's favorite one was closing down? Actually, did Mydei even have enough spare time in his day to visit other bakeries?

Phainon couldn't believe Mydei still made time for him despite his busy schedule, and his hands faltered while he frowned at the thought. Mydei really put his all into spending time with Phainon, sacrificing even his own sleep to continue staying awake with Phainon, and it only motivated him to think of the perfect name for the bakery. Something simple, something that would stand out as a store name, but something that meant a lot to Mydei? His head hurt the more he thought about it. Phainon didn't want to disappoint Mydei with a name he disliked.

The door clicked behind Phainon, and he jumped, whirling around and eyes widening at the sight of the three people in front of him.

“Uh… Hey.” Phainon's eyes flickered between the group of people. There was the executive assistant, the IT director, and Mydei. He was trying extremely hard not to become overwhelmed at the sight of gold flooding his vision once again after so long ago, and he swallowed thickly. Was Phainon not supposed to be here?

The two other people stared at the executive assistant, who began scrambling and checking the papers in their hands. “I'm so sorry! I think I forgot to book this meeting room.”

“It's fine!” Phainon laughed. “I can just leave.”

It wasn't like Phainon was literally finished with setting up his laptop or anything, definitely not. He scrambled to grab his laptop, his notes, and other documents as fast as he could while the other three started settling at the conference table. Whatever meeting was happening had to be big and confidential, considering that the IT director, Anaxa, was setting up himself.

“Phainon.”

His body immediately froze at that lovely, familiarly deep voice above him, and he tilted his head upwards to stare into those equally familiar and gorgeous golden eyes that he was trying so hard not to fawn over in front of the other two employees.

“Yes?” Phainon swallowed. He was currently kneeling on the floor, trying to unplug his laptop. When was the last time he spoke with Mydei in person? When was the last time they were in such close proximity? How much he missed that scent of the bakery on him, and how much he missed staring into his golden eyes, running his fingers through his golden hair, and listening to his sweet voice. But at that thought, Phainon's shoulders dropped. With the closure of the bakery, did that mean that, soon, Mydei wouldn’t smell like freshly baked bread every day anymore?

“Can I speak with you?”

“Right now?” Phainon pushed himself to his feet and stared at the other two in the meeting room, but they weren't paying the least attention to the two of them.

“Right now. In my office.”

Phainon stared again at the other two in the room, and he saw Anaxa waving his hand from the other side of the table, shooing them away.

“If you're going to talk, leave now,” Anaxa snapped. “I'm not getting blamed for you not being here when the meeting starts.”

Immediately locking eyes with gold, Phainon was whisked out of the meeting room while clumsily shifting his belongings in his arms before they tumbled out of his arms and onto the floor. He had some sort of idea of what Mydei wanted to discuss with him as the office door closed behind them.

“Is Anaxa going to care that we are speaking privately in your office?” The entire walk toward Mydei’s office, Phainon was trying not to make eye contact with any of the staff they passed by, as if it would somehow erase his presence right next to Mydei. He wasn’t sure if it would rouse the IT

director’s suspicions if the CEO’s son was speaking privately with some random human resources employee right before, what Phainon assumed to be, a very important meeting.

“Anaxa won’t care at all. If it doesn’t appeal to his interests, he won’t take another glance.”

Phainon had to stifle a laugh. That *was* what Anaxa was like, after all.

“So, is it happening?” While finally peering straight into Mydei’s golden eyes, Phainon tried not to let his breath stop at being so close to his boyfriend again after so many weeks. He was trying very, very hard not to stumble over his words or forget to breathe at the sight of the ethereal man before him. How did Phainon manage to speak to someone so stunning before?

Mydei nodded, leaning against his desk. “This meeting in an hour is with all the higher-ups to finally solidify my transition.”

“How… has it been?” Phainon never really got any details throughout all of this. He knew Mydei was going through a lot, and he knew the general gist of what was happening. But he didn’t know the when or where of anything, only that it *was* happening.

“The bakery is in its final stages now.” Mydei sounded as if he were relaying a verbal report. There wasn’t a hint of emotion in his voice, and it stung to hear him speak about the bakery, something Mydei held very dear to his heart, in such a cold manner. “It’ll be its last day in a few days.”

“That’s really soon.” It felt like the energy and adrenaline of seeing Mydei again immediately dissipated. Even though Phainon knew this wasn’t the end, Mydei didn’t know that. What was Mydei feeling through all of this? Watching his mother's bakery being sold by his own hands and willingly signing off on all the papers to do so. Phainon couldn't even imagine what Mydei was feeling, and Mydei had never confided in him about the bakery ever since he told him he was going to sell it. “How are you doing?”

Mydei didn’t answer, but Phainon now knew him well enough to distinguish his ever so slightly trembling fingertips, tense shoulders, and downturned, golden eyes. He wanted to hold Mydei close and grasp his trembling hands, but he had to shut his mouth before he spilled the plans for Mydei’s new bakery.

“Mydei–”

“My father is close to securing the Black Tide rights now.” Mydei shifted the conversation, but it only made Phainon’s heart twist with guilt. But they didn’t have much time left, so there was nothing Phainon could do except follow Mydei’s flow of the conversation. He was also sure Mydei didn’t want to think about the bakery when such an important meeting was happening so soon.

“How did pressuring the CEO to step down go?”

“My father was not pleased.” Mydei scoffed and crossed his arms, but he appeared quite proud of himself. “It was quite the ordeal to rally everyone in the board of directors against my father. But he can’t fight all of us. And… he doesn’t know what I plan to do with the Black Tide rights either.”

“You were able to win them over from him?”

“So most of my father’s assets and funds are in this company,” Mydei explained. “So that means the corporation owns the Black Tide, not Eurypon himself. Stepping down as CEO means he loses the right to manage the Black Tide. I’m either aiming to take over before he gets the chance to own the Black Tide for even a second, or taking over before he can do anything with those rights. Because once the corporation owns those rights, he will do anything to own it personally. Once this transition is solidified, I’ll have a better chance at dealing with the rights. Eventually, I will own it, and I will destroy it.”

A surge of pride swelled within Phainon’s chest. Everything seemed to be all planned out, and Mydei knew exactly what he was doing. Phainon's lover was strong. He was the strongest man Phainon would ever know, and he was confident about that fact. “You have it all worked out.”

“I hope so.” Mydei’s gaze was flickering along the office floor, most likely thinking about the next steps in his plan. “I have to become CEO without my father knowing my intentions with the Black Tide, but he is quite obsessed with it. I am prepared for a long, withdrawn debate with him in that conference room in about an hour. He will not give me that position if he knows what I plan to do.”

“Good luck, Mydei.” Phainon offered him a reassuring smile. “I really do believe you will succeed. I… won’t be able to help you in this battle, but if you need me for anything, let me know.”

Phainon was about to nod and exit Mydei’s office so that he could return to the conference room for such a significant meeting, but his deep voice cut Phainon short before he could even move.

“I do need you for something.”

He said those words without any hesitation, and it slightly surprised Phainon, considering that there was very limited power Phainon could work with as a humble human resources employee. Was this really something Phainon could help him with?

“*Err*, right now?” The most action Phainon was able to take was to raise his hand toward the doorknob, and he stayed frozen in this position. If Mydei believed in him, Phainon would do whatever it took to help his lover succeed. “Is it something I should do for you while you’re in the meeting? Or, perhaps later?”

“No, right now.”

“*Right now?*” Phainon could not hold in his surprise. “Isn’t the meeting in an hour? Should I run and grab you something?”

It was the most conflicted Mydei had ever appeared, besides telling Phainon he was selling the bakery all those weeks ago. He was fidgeting with his hands, with golden eyes shifting around the room and Phainon as he cleared his throat. “Was I…” A long silence settled between the two men, and Mydei suddenly straightened, pushing himself off the desk. “Never mind.”

“Wait.” Phainon reacted first and quickly stepped forward, blocking Mydei before he could escape through the door. “What were you going to say?”

“Nothing.”

“Mydei.” Phainon knew Mydei was going through a lot, and he tried his best to sound as gentle as possible with the other man. There were probably so many things running through Mydei's mind at the moment, and Phainon couldn't even fathom the stress that Mydei was enduring. “You know you can ask me for anything, right?”

Golden eyes continued to shift back and forth, and Phainon brought his hand up to softly cradle his cheek.

“Tell me, Mydei,” Phainon whispered, staring deeply into his wavering golden eyes. “What were you going to ask me?”

Mydei gulped, glaring in Phainon's direction through his golden bangs. But it didn't escape Phainon's notice, and he was surprised and puzzled at seeing the faint tint of pink splashed across his face.

“Was I…” Mydei’s voice was weak as he croaked out the words. “Was I the only one who missed you?”

Phainon's eyes widened. It felt like the breath was knocked out of Phainon's lungs and swept Phainon right off his own two feet at the view before him. Mydei was staring timidly at him through his golden bangs, with flushed cheeks and downturned lips, and Phainon's hands began trembling at the sight.

“Of course I did, Mydei." Phainon strung all his words together, struggling for breath. He was still trying to force air into his lungs at the gorgeous sight before him. “Did you not think I did?”

Furrowing his eyebrows, Mydei's gaze began to flicker back and forth once more, until he eventually locked eyes with Phainon and forced the words from his mouth. “I just thought I would be seeing you more often.”

Phainon blankly blinked at him with wide eyes, and his lips turned up into a confused smile. “Huh?”

Mydei clicked his tongue and crossed his arms. “I just thought you would be forcing yourself around me more often.”

“Was I… allowed to?” Phainon just didn't want to bother Mydei during such a pivotal moment. *Of course* Phainon missed Mydei. *Of course* Phainon thought about Mydei every day. Not an hour went by that Phainon wasn't thinking about Mydei; in fact, it would be easier to ask how many times Phainon *didn't* think about his lover. They had already discussed how they would be seeing each other less with how busy Mydei would be, after all, so Phainon tried to adjust without Mydei's presence and to pull back from bothering him so often.

But Mydei stayed silent, which only made Phainon’s anticipating heart begin to flutter as he leaned closer.

“Mydei, did you want me to be clingy around you?”

“I didn't say that.”

“I feel like that's what you're implying.” Phainon tilted his head to the side. His smile was only growing the longer Mydei prolonged his silence.

The other man frowned, with his blush only deepening and his glare only darkening. “Just kiss me, Phainon.”

With a loud laugh sounding in the private office and a huge grin spreading across Phainon's face, he wrapped his arms around Mydei’s waist and pulled him into the deep kiss his boyfriend had been so politely asking him for. Their lips pressed together as their eyes fluttered closed, and a surge of pleasure rushed through Phainon at the smell of freshly baked bread and the soft lips pushing against him, filling all his senses. A low moan vibrated against him, and a deep shiver ran down Phainon's spine at the sound.

Tilting his head, Phainon pushed his lips deeper, feeling their lips moving against each other as Mydei stumbled backward into his desk. But it didn't

stop Phainon in the slightest, especially when two strong arms wrapped around Phainon's shoulders and pulled him closer. Gentle fingertips brushed through Phainon's hair, and he couldn't stop the moan that slipped past his lips and the noises of their passion echoing in the small office.

The longer the kiss grew on, and the longer Phainon's body began rubbing into Mydei's, the messier the kiss became. Lips were pushing back and forth, teeth began tugging on each other's lips, and tongues began tangling with one another. Phainon settled his hands upon Mydei's hips, pulling him close and slipping his tongue in between Mydei’s panting lips, and another moan erupted from the other man as Phainon began sliding his tongue against his. Hands were now pulling on Phainon's hair, and he groaned with every single tug.

His mind was succumbing to the pleasure. He was all too aware of the saliva they were exchanging, of the hips that began moving, and the adventurous hands that were roaming his hair and the back of his shirt. He was all too aware of the moans bouncing off the walls, of their lips smacking against each other, and the breathless, desperate pants filling his ears.

Listening to the last shred of sanity in Phainon's mind, he forced himself back, pulling his head away and hearing one last sound of their lips parting, which repeated over and over in his head. Mydei was gasping for breath, with arms still wrapped around Phainon as he was basically leaning against his desk. His lips were noticeably much redder than before, and his cheeks had become a dark crimson. With hazy and dilated golden eyes, Mydei was the picture of seduction that almost had Phainon leaning in for another long taste.

“*Mydei*.” Phainon was panting *hard*. He was grasping Mydei’s waist so tightly that his leather belt and the belt loops of his work pants were beginning to dig into his palms. Every cell in his body was screaming to push Mydei down into his own desk, and there was only one single inch of his brain that was stopping him. Not even an inch–probably only a single millimeter was holding him back from jumping his lover in his own office.

It had been so long–*too* long–since he had Mydei in his hands. Too long without brushing through his soft, golden hair, staring into his golden eyes that twinkled as brightly as the stars in the sky, and being filled with the scent of bread and the bakery. It had been too long without that sweetened taste of pomegranate lingering on Phainon's tongue and the soft lips that gently caressed him. Too long without those strong, built arms that pulled Phainon closer and the desperate moans that would lovingly echo in Phainon's ears. His body craved so much more of Mydei and to have all his senses completely overtaken by Mydei. He wanted all his thoughts to consist of nothing except for Mydei and this stunningly beautiful man that was staring expectantly up at Phainon through those golden bangs, leaning against the desk as if *waiting* for Phainon.

“Phainon.” Mydei resolutely stared straight into Phainon's eyes. “I have forty minutes.”

The adrenaline started pumping through Phainon's veins. His already pounding heartbeat was quickening and knocking against his chest, and the one shred of sanity he had left was beginning to fade away as his mind turned blank at the implications of his words.

There were so many problems with this, yet not a single problem ran through Phainon's horny and lust-filled brain. He couldn't think of anything else except for those plump, red lips and those sparkling golden eyes.

“I…” Phainon's gaze found the clock in the office, but his brain could not compute a single thing that he was looking at unless it was gold.

“I have condoms with me.” The buzzword snapped Phainon's attention back onto the man in his arms. “I'll keep it down.”

Phainon swore his brain was going to explode. His body wanted so badly to pounce onto Mydei, but that one single millimeter was still barely hanging on, and his throat bobbed at Mydei’s words.

There were so many problems with this. There were so many problems with this. Yet not a single problem ran through Phainon's mind.

Hands shook Phainon from his stupor as fingertips ran through the hair on the back of his head. Goosebumps rose along Phainon's arms as he jolted, lips parting into a sharp gasp when those same fingertips roughly tugged on his hair once more.

“Are you going to take your pants off, Phainon, or should I do it myself?”

That last millimeter in Phainon's brain completely snapped.

Chapter 24

“You really, really missed me, Mydei, didn't you? Did you touch yourself here while thinking of me?”

“Shut… it–*MMPH!*”

Phainon already had two fingers stirring inside of Mydei, but it really didn't feel like he needed to. Mydei's entrance was already stretched out, much to Phainon's extreme amusement. Though they did prepare Mydei with a mysterious lube bottle that he was already carrying in his bag, Phainon's fingers easily slipped inside with absolutely no resistance the moment he pressed them against that familiar, fluttering ring of muscle. Once his head was cleared of lust, he was going to tease Mydei for touching himself during their weeks apart. Well, it wasn't as if Phainon was exactly innocent either.

“You're not being very quiet, Mydei.”

“That's why I'm telling you to–*AH–MMM!*” Mydei threw his head forward to stifle his moan, and Phainon couldn't help his chuckle over how adorably Mydei was trying to keep himself in. But his lover's trembling legs, shaking arms holding him up against the desk, and his clenching insides were already telling signs that Mydei was close, and they had barely even started.

“Is it because it's been a few weeks?” Phainon shifted closer, delving deeper inside and propping his chin upon one of the tense shoulders that were quivering from his prodding fingers. “Are you extra sensitive today because you've been waiting for me for too long?”

“Stop… whispering… in my ear.” Mydei alternated between heavy gasps and pants, his chest heaving for more air.

“Didn't you tell me to be quiet?” Phainon chuckled quietly once more, planting a quick kiss against his temple before pulling his fingers out.

Darkened eyes watched the entrance trying to squeeze Phainon back inside as he pulled against him, and he swallowed thickly at the hole searching for Phainon's presence once he had left, clenching around nothing as Mydei’s shoulders dropped.

They were limited in time, after all, and Phainon didn't have the patience to tease Mydei as he usually did. As adorable as Mydei always was while moaning around his fingers and pleading for Phainon to put it in, Phainon *needed* to be inside of Mydei right now. He had been waiting too long and could not wait another second more when Mydei’s pants were wrapped around his ankles. Phainon’s own pants were already way too tight, and his hard and neglected dick was just aching to be freed.

“The condoms are in my bag too.” Mydei weakly gestured to the black leather bag sitting on Mydei's desk.

Swift fingers searched through the pockets of the bag before eventually unearthing a couple of packaged condoms.

“When did you buy these?” Phainon ripped off one, removing it from its packaging and throwing the trash into Mydei's trash bin.

Much to Phainon's amusement, Mydei was still trying to fill his lungs with air, and he was stringing all his words together into one single breath. “I couldn't deal with your cum inside of me all day again.”

His face burned at the memory of their… time at the bakery, and he focused his brain power on pulling down his pants and putting on the condom instead. But his brain couldn't stop thinking about the implications of Mydei's sentence. “Did you… buy condoms because you want to start using them? Or… did you buy them in the case we have sex out in public again, and you didn't want to walk around with my cum inside all day?”

A very long silence stretched between the two men in the office. Phainon's gaze flickered between Mydei, who still had his back facing him with his palms flat against his desk, and his dick, where Phainon was rolling the condom down his entire length. Even after covering his entire girth with the condom and lube, Mydei still did not speak.

“Mydei?”

“I only have thirty-five minutes,” Mydei growled, quickly changing the subject.

A loud laugh shook Phainon's chest at his lover's obvious refusal to respond, and he leaned against Mydei, lining himself up with his already quivering and anticipating entrance while feeling the warmth of Mydei's skin radiate against him.

“I'm going in,” Phainon whispered into golden hair.

With no objection from the other man, Phainon eased himself inside, trying not to groan out loud at the searing pleasure and flaring heat that tightened so lovingly around his dick. Mydei's walls pulsed deliciously against him, fluttering in complete ecstasy the more Phainon eased himself inside and the more Mydei’s heat continued to gobble his entire length. Phainon bit his lip as moans threatened to slip out, but his eyes rolled into the back of his head once he had completely bottomed out and was completely consumed in the taste of Mydei.

Mydei had trembling fists grasping his desk, lips fighting to close around the moans that were slipping into the office air. The stretch of his hole around Phainon's girth absolutely burned. It had been too long, and tears were already brimming in the corners of Mydei’s eyes at the burning rod of heat that was shoved deep inside of him and filling him up all the way to his stomach. But when Phainon completely bottomed out inside of him, Mydei's lips dropped open into a silent scream.

His vision turned white, and his body trembled violently, clutching tightly around Phainon's dick as cum spilled out from his tip before he could stop himself. His dick bounced with every stream, and his cum splattered along the side of his desk as everything in his balls completely emptied along his desk, and his hips jolted within Phainon's grasp as he rode out his orgasm. His eyes fluttered open the moment his dick finally went soft, and he was gasping desperately for breath, trying to gather his own breathing to steady himself from that mind-numbing orgasm.

Mydei's face was already burning at the thought that he had already cum before they barely did anything, and he was faced with his cum that had painted the side of his desk with the color white already. Phainon chuckled softly, sliding his hands along Mydei's waist once his lover had finished cumming all over his desk.

“Already, Mydei?” Phainon teased with a low voice. “Just from me entering inside? Did you miss me that much?”

He leaned forward, with hands on Mydei’s hips, and the slight movement of his dick stirring inside already had both men flinching at the shock of pleasure that coursed through their veins. Phainon had grimaced with tense shoulders the entire time Mydei was riding out his orgasm around Phainon's cock, and it was so tight inside of Mydei that he had almost cum himself. All Phainon could think of was that there was absolutely no way they could get out of this with no one hearing them with how sensitive both of them were right now, especially since Mydei literally just came.

“Move… Phainon.” Mydei gulped so loudly that even Phainon heard it, and with an amused smirk growing upon his lips, Phainon began to pull his hips back. He wasn't sure if Mydei knew what overstimulation was, but sparkling, dilated eyes watched his entrance pulsing around Phainon's length as he pulled out, until Mydei’s hole could only flutter around Phainon's tip that was now barely inside.

“Mydei, be quiet, okay?”

He thrust his hips back against Mydei's behind, and the sound of their skin colliding echoed loudly in the office. A sharp gasp came from the other man, with elbows buckling and almost collapsing into the desk as Phainon's eyes and lips snapped shut before a moan escaped his throat. The pleasure was almost overwhelming, and his lower stomach tightened at the electricity already overtaking his body. With just a single thrust, Mydei’s overstimulated walls were absolutely throbbing around his length, and Phainon could not stand this reverberating pleasure that was constantly running through his body.

It truly had been too long. Too long without being wrapped within these warm walls that reveled in Phainon's presence. Too long without this golden hair and this luscious body that couldn't get enough of Phainon's touch. Every slight brush against the man’s body already had him shivering and groaning, and Phainon was just all the more tempted to tease his lover.

But Phainon also could not get enough of Mydei either. He already felt like he was about to cum from that single thrust and the rush of pleasure that overtook all of his limbs, and Phainon was gnawing at his bottom lip to distract himself from his tightening core and his oncoming orgasm. The heat from Mydei's furiously fluttering walls permeated into Phainon's brain, and all he could think about was how much he wanted to continue pushing Mydei to the edge and how much his dick was quivering in absolute delight over the hot, tight, and wet insides that finally wrapped around his entire length after so long without Mydei at his side. It truly felt as if Phainon belonged here, buried deep inside of Mydei’s pulsing warmth forever.

“*Phainon*.” The quiet whine that left Mydei’s lips sent deep shivers down Phainon's back, and he grasped tighter at the skin underneath his hand.

“Yes, my love?”

“Hurry, Phainon.”

It was almost as if Mydei sounded unsatisfied, and with a scoff, Phainon began snapping his hips against Mydei’s behind, who moaned aloud and rapidly shut his mouth before any more noises spilled. But now, Phainon was intent on fucking Mydei so hard he would forget the time and where they were, and he was adamant about that.

Which was already happening to Mydei, who was crying from the overstimulation that wracked his body. He couldn't believe the pleasure was already too much and was tightening so dangerously in his stomach to the point where he could barely breathe, but Phainon was thrusting inside of him and hitting his already swirling stomach at a breaking pace with his tip. Shaking legs could barely hold him up now from the electricity locking his body up, and he was at the mercy of Phainon's snapping hips and deep plunges of his cock. Every brush against his overstimulated prostate sent

Mydei into a spiral, with drool dribbling from his lips and eyes rolled back into his head. He already felt like he was going to cum again with how much pleasure was rushing his body, yet he could feel that absolutely nothing was going to come out.

Phainon was already sweating in this air-conditioned office, with sweaty palms grasping at sweaty hips that were bouncing against him with every deep thrust. Phainon was thrusting right where Mydei liked it and exactly how he liked it–roughly and deeply–and the muffled moans that were trying to escape Mydei's quivering lips only spurred him on. It only made him more intent to hear more of Mydei’s beautiful noises and tempt him into moaning aloud in his own office. It was as if Phainon were being dared into seeing just how much it would take for Mydei to lose even more of his control here.

It was then that Phainon realized that thought, and his already pleased dick that was sliding against Mydei’s walls began quivering inside at his realization. The realization that *Phainon was fucking his future CEO in his own office.*

Why did that thought turn Phainon on so much? Just the thought of that left him panting for breath. Hungry eyes roamed Mydei's back, where his dress shirt was rolled up around his slender waist before revealing his bare, naked skin right underneath. Mydei’s hips were shaking as he thrust himself against Phainon, riding his length and pushing deeper every time Phainon thrust against him, and he scoffed at the thought that Mydei was already chasing more pleasure after just cumming all by himself. His lover truly was greedy.

A hand grasped Mydei’s cheek, peeling them apart, with deep blue eyes watching the sight of their connection and watching his own dick pummeling into that stretched, red ring of muscle. Lube was beginning to pour out of Mydei's entrance, right where they were connected, and the sounds of his squelching hole shot pleasure into the pit of Phainon's tightening stomach at every single noise.

Phainon leaned forward once more, and another intense moan rang through the air as he began sucking against Mydei's skin, pushing his blonde hair

away with the tip of his nose, peeling his collar back with one hand, and leaving marks all over his red tattoos. He kissed along the back of his neck and sucked underneath his ears, and Mydei began tightening around Phainon's length with every mark that began to blossom along his skin.

“Phainon, *Phainon!*” Mydei whispered sharply. “I can't, Phainon, I–”

“Can’t keep quiet? Or can't hold it in?” Phainon pressed his lips against Mydei's ear and murmured lowly, and Mydei's body shivered from the hot breath that brushed against him. He chuckled at the obvious shiver, pushing deeper inside of Mydei and pushing him against his own desk. “First, you came all over your kitchen island. Then, you came all over your desk because you couldn't hold it in. Are you going to cum again already?”

With every thrust, Mydei’s dick, which was hard once more, brushed against his office desk, and Phainon scoffed at the vulgar sight that he was watching over Mydei’s shoulder. His hard dick was bouncing up and down, and he was already leaking precum all over his desk. Phainon imagined the sight of his entire desk being covered in cum, and he began snapping his hips even faster to make that dream a reality and add to more of the cum that was already dripping down his desk. He wanted to see Mydei unable to hold himself back. He wanted to see Mydei spilling all over himself and calling for Phainon's name. He wanted Mydei to completely forget they were at work and doing such dirty things while on company time, and he wanted to see Mydei completely let go of all his restraints.

Phainon planted one last kiss against Mydei's temple before grasping his hips once more, sliding his hands against Mydei’s waist underneath his shirt and pushing it up as far as it could go. It revealed Mydei’s chest to the open air, and the bright crimson tattoos caught Phainon's attention in the corner of his eyes.

“Do you see yourself, Mydei?” Phainon nudged Mydei with the tip of his nose. “You know your window shades are up?”

Mydei had his head bowed low, struggling to stifle his moans, but his gaze snapped up at his words as he became face-to-face with his faint reflection in the window. He tightened so hard at the sight, almost restricting

Phainon's thrusts, and a low groan slipped out of Phainon's throat at the heated walls that were gripping tightly around him.

With palms still pressed against his desk, holding himself up with shaky arms, Mydei was arching his back and presenting himself and his filled entrance so beautifully to Phainon as he stared with wide eyes at his reflection. Meanwhile, Phainon was having trouble deciding on what to admire, either the red entrance hungrily gobbling up his dick down below, or the two perky buds upon his chest that he could barely see in the window reflection.

“You're lucky we're on the top floor.” Phainon laughed. He resumed his sharp thrusts, slapping against Mydei’s behind, and his lover within his arms jolted at the pleasure that started sparking inside of him once more. Sounds of their skinship echoed loudly in the office as adventurous hands crept up Mydei's torso, pinching at his hard nipples and eliciting a loud moan that erupted from Mydei’s lips.

“Do you like being touched here, Mydei? Because you don't sound quiet at all.” A hum of amusement vibrated against Phainon's lips as he continued teasing Mydei's chest. He pinched and swirled his fingers along Mydei's hard nipples, with his thrusts only quickening against Mydei's behind. Mydei had thrown his head forward with a hand slapped over his mouth, muffling his cries at the stimulation all over his body. His body was shaking his desk with every thrust, and every jolt only spilled more precum onto his desk.

“*MMM! Phainon!*” Mydei had his eyes squeezed shut as he tried to stifle his moans as best as he could. He was trying to say something to him, but he couldn't hold it in anymore; his lips kept parting into loud cries, and the best he could do was muffle them against his trembling hand. He was a slave to Phainon's powerful thrusts that continued to drive into the deepest parts of him and brush against his twitching prostate.

His warm insides relished in Phainon's presence, fluttering in delight from being stimulated so well after such a long time of his absence. Not even Mydei’s own fingers could provide the stretch that Phainon's dick gave him, and his body trembled every time Phainon thrust inside and stretched his

hole open. The burn made Mydei’s eyes roll back once more, and he relished in the feeling of Phainon's tip hitting right in his lower stomach, completely knocking the air right out of his lungs.

His dick reached every part of Mydei's insides, and every part of his hole twitched in the absolute ecstasy that Phainon's cock provided. Nothing except for Phainon's dick could ever make Mydei feel this good, to feel like he was no longer in control of his body, and where the only thing Mydei’s brain could think of was that girthy length filling him up inside and how much deeper and harder he wanted it to take his breath away. He wanted Phainon to take all his sanity away, and he wanted nothing more than to be filled by Phainon forever. It wasn't as if his greedy, insatiable hole already memorized every ridge and vein upon Phainon's dick anyway.

“Phainon, I–*MMPH*–Wait, I–*MMMM!*” Every time Mydei opened his mouth, moans would spill instead of words, and he had to press his palm harshly against his lips to stop the sounds from leaking past his office walls.

“Do you want to tell me something, my love?” With a smirk and one last pinch upon Mydei’s nipples, Phainon shifted his hands back to his waist and pummeled harder into Mydei’s ass, which only heightened the sounds of their skinship, the sounds of the lube leaking out of Mydei's entrance, and the sounds of Mydei’s muffled moans. One of Phainon's hands deftly swiped against Mydei's weak spot upon his back, making the man jolt as if he were shocked by electricity.

“Around–I–*MMPH!*–Turn… around. I want… *MMM!* To see…you!”

Phainon's hips immediately faltered, eyes growing wide as he pulled out as swiftly as he could and whirled Mydei around, pinning him between his body and the desk. The man stumbled backward into the desk, with his blushing face lined with tear tracks now facing Phainon. And at the sight of his reddened lips, glistening, golden eyes, and golden hair sticking to his forehead from sweat, Phainon's lower stomach began to tighten in arousal. Dilated icy eyes darkened and lowered onto the leaking tip in front of him that was glistening in precum, and Phainon parted his lips to speak in a low voice.

“Get on top of your desk and spread your legs for me, Mydei.”

Golden eyes slightly widened at the demanding request, but a smirk soon grew upon the lips of the other man. It was without hesitation that Mydei stepped out of the slacks that were gathered at his ankles, and he bent over, presenting his puckered hole to Phainon. He leisurely tossed them to the side and pushed himself onto his desk, spreading his legs as far as he could go and raising his feet in the air.

“Like this, Phainon?”

A golden head of hair tilted to the side, with equally dilated, golden eyes staring straight into Phainon. At the seductive view before him, of those legs spreading wide for Phainon's entry, and the fluttering hole right between Mydei’s cheeks that was waiting to be filled, Phainon scoffed incredulously and pulled Mydei right into his arms. Legs immediately wrapped around Phainon's waist as he was lining himself back up to soothe the hole that was twitching just for him, but he paused when lips pressed against the corner of his.

“Can you keep me quiet, Phainon?” A low voice rumbled against him as strong arms wrapped around his shoulders, causing goosebumps to rise along Phainon's arms.

He couldn't stop the low laughter that escaped his throat as Phainon stared into those golden eyes that he could never tire of. He knew Mydei was asking to kiss him, and as much as Phainon desperately wanted to press his lips back against Mydei’s, Phainon wanted to absolutely revel in Mydei’s struggle to keep his voice down. “Mydei, my love, I'm the wrong person to ask.”

Phainon pushed his entire length inside all at once, earning a scream that vibrated against the crook of Phainon's neck as he began driving his hips once more at the breaking pace he had before. Mydei's insides fluttered deliciously around him, massaging his length as if physically telling him how much they missed Phainon's presence inside. How much they missed Phainon's tip that brushed against that quivering prostate, and how much they missed the dick that Mydei’s hole easily remembered. His entrance

was stretched to fit the exact size of Mydei, and Phainon couldn't ask for anything more as he continued driving his hips inside of Mydei and reveling in the surge of pleasure that began to overtake him once more.

The scent of the bakery filled his senses in this new position, and he buried his nose into soft, golden hair, groaning softly at the heat that surrounded his dick and the hands that were now clawing against Phainon's back through his shirt. His eyes fluttered shut as the only thing his body could feel was the warmth his cock was submerged in and the arousal that was swirling in his core, tightening his stomach as he chased his release. It was a shame that he couldn't cum inside of Mydei today; his brain was already thinking of making it up to Mydei another day. Phainon was sure Mydei missed his cum after all these weeks, after all.

Mydei's legs were bouncing up and down in the air with every harsh thrust, and Phainon's hands slid underneath his knees to spread his legs even wider. Their bodies were brushing against each other now, with Mydei’s dick slipping underneath Phainon's dress shirt to rub against his stomach. At this newfound pleasure of rutting against Phainon's sculpted abdomen, Mydei groaned, burying his face into Phainon's neck to stifle his sounds as his golden eyes rolled into the back of his head. He began thrusting his own hips, grinding his dick against Phainon in time with Phainon’s thrusts while chasing that sweet pleasure that consumed his every being and made his legs tremble in the air. The sweat running down Phainon's body was a terrible lube that didn't do very much for Mydei's dick, yet the pleasure of grinding against his leaking cock, along with his insides being pummeled into, was absolutely indescribable.

If someone so much as opened Mydei’s office door, all they would find is the owner of said office folded over his own desk and being fucked into oblivion. Phainon couldn't help the adrenaline that rushed through his veins at the thought. His already pounding heartbeat rattled his chest even more, and his already hazy eyes filled with lust began glinting dangerously at the thought. So what if someone saw them? At least now it would be known to everyone at their workplace that *Mydei was his and only his*. *That Phainon was the only person Mydei would willingly climb onto his desk and spread his legs for.*

The man in his arms was moaning Phainon's name so lovingly, and every syllable that spilled from his beautiful lips only sent pleasure straight into Phainon's dick. He pushed Mydei's back against the desk, pinning him to his own office desk and continuing to thrust his hips deeper. Those strong arms pulled Phainon down until he was basically leaning over Mydei, and teary eyes and quivering lips buried themselves back into the crook of Phainon's neck as moan after moan continued to erupt from his lover's throat. He wasn't even trying to hold back his noises now and was only using Phainon's neck to stifle them, and the thought of Mydei losing his control over the pleasure of Phainon's cock filling him up sent his stomach flexing in his own pleasure.

Hands desperately tugged at Phainon's silver hair, and the legs that were spread wide around Phainon began violently trembling in the air. Phainon moaned at every rough tug at his hair, and he shifted his hands from Mydei’s knees back onto his hips, bouncing his lover up and down on his cock and pushing him against his desk. Mydei continued spreading his legs as wide as he could without Phainon's assistance, allowing Phainon and his pummeling dick to do whatever he pleased to him and his aching, hungry entrance.

Phainon buried his face back into golden hair, planting kisses wherever he could reach. The sounds of his lips and the sounds of Mydei's hole echoed in the office. The sounds of their bare skin slapping against each other filled the room, and muffled moans could clearly be heard over all of their vulgar noises. Phainon could barely remember that they only had a couple of minutes because he wished he could hear these noises and relish in this pleasure coursing through his veins and gathering in his lower stomach forever.

A loud groan sounded above all the noises, vibrating against Phainon's neck. Mydei was fisting Phainon's hair and crying his name, and Phainon knew his lover was close now. But no matter how much Mydei tried to warn him, Phainon wanted to see Mydei make a mess of himself with his own cum. He wanted to see Mydei covered in cum, adorning his pretty tears and his blushing, crimson face, and Phainon bit his lip and trembled just at the mere thought of it.

“Mydei,” Phainon muttered into Mydei's ear, “are you close, my love? You're tightening so much around me right now. Are you going to cum for me again?”

“I–*MMPH!*” Mydei bit hard right into Phainon's neck, stifling another loud moan that was scratching against his throat. The shock of pain made Phainon moan instead, and he threw his head forward at the pain and pleasure that rushed through his body.

“I…” Phainon swallowed thickly, trying to moisten his scratchy throat after all of his moans, “want to see you covered in cum, Mydei. I want to see you make a mess of yourself. Can you do that for me?”

An unconvincing glare brimming with glistening tears was quickly shot in Phainon's direction, but with another rough thrust against his prostate, Mydei went flying back into Phainon's arms, burning his face into the crook of his neck once again to quiet his wanton moans.

A laugh labored by Phainon's heavy pants shook Phainon's chest. “Haven't I been so good to you? I've been so good to you, Mydei. Look at how well I'm fucking you in your own office. Don't you feel how much you're twitching around my dick? Can't you do this one thing for me, my love? I'll give you all the cum you want later, okay?”

A whimper vibrated against Phainon's neck, and the heat massaging Phainon's dick tightened at his words.

Another breathless laugh left Phainon's lips. “Did you like that, Mydei? Did you want to be filled with my cum?”

“*Please… Phainon!”*

“‘Please fill me with your cum’? What do you want from me, my love? If you cum for me right now and do as I ask, I'll do whatever you wish for.”

“Phainon, I–I’M–*MMMM!”*

Mydei instantly tightened around Phainon, and a loud moan was muffled against his neck as his spread legs vigorously shook in the air. Mydei screamed Phainon's name over and over with every jolt of his body and every stream of cum that left his pulsing cock. It spilled right against Phainon's abdomen inside his shirt, splattering all over his torso as Mydei’s back arched off his desk, spasming against the mahogany wood as he came and pulsed around the giant dick still buried deep inside of him. He was clutching so tightly around Phainon's neck, pulling on Phainon's hair, and the heat that was tightening in his core and around his dick finally made Phainon explode.

With his vision turning white and his hips burying his dick as deeply as he could, Phainon came, trembling against Mydei’s own spasming body as the heat in his stomach flared up and took over every one of his senses and every limb in his body. A loud moan escaped his throat, and he had to equally bury his face into Mydei’s hair to stifle his lover's name that was spilling from his lips at the same time he was spilling his load. Streams of cum filled the condom with every jolt of his hips until both men finally stilled in each other's arms and their vision began to return. It was eerily silent now in the office after it had just been reverberating with their stifled moans and slapping skin, and only the sounds of their own desperate gasps for breath filled the room now.

Phainon was all too aware of how much they were both sweating, and with one last gentle kiss against Mydei's forehead, he untangled their limbs and set Mydei’s legs back down against the desk. Mydei's head was drooped to one side, and his lips were parted, with his chest rising up and down for breath to enter his lungs. Golden hair clung to his forehead, cheeks, and neck, and right above his disheveled collar and loosened tie, Phainon could barely spot the love marks that he had left upon Mydei's skin.

He slowly pulled himself out, wincing at the overstimulated walls that pulsed around him with every movement, and a soft whine came from Mydei’s parted lips as he finally pulled out. The cool air swept across his dick now that it was exposed to the air-conditioning with the condom off, and he tied the condom to safely dispose.

Tearing his gaze from the beloved sight of his lover, sticky with sweat and lube and limp on his own desk without any pants on, Phainon found that clock once more that he couldn't process before.

“Mydei, my love.” Phainon gently rubbed his hands along Mydei's thighs. “You have a little less than ten minutes until the meeting. Let me clean you up while you catch your breath, okay?”

Mydei weakly nodded, which was all the confirmation Phainon needed to know he was okay, and he began making quick work of wiping up the lube that was still leaking out of Mydei’s hole as best as he could and the cum that was running down Mydei’s dick. There were wet wipes in one of the desk drawers, which was a convenient sight but a sincere relief to see, and after cleaning Mydei and himself as best as he could, Phainon worked on their clothes.

He pulled his own pants up before moving to adjust the collar of Mydei’s shirt. He retied the tie around Mydei’s neck, and he bent down for the discarded slacks to pull them up Mydei’s legs. Once he had gotten the pants to Mydei’s thighs, his lover pushed himself off his desk, dropping to his feet and stumbling against Phainon.

“Careful!” Phainon swiftly stepped forward to catch him, and Mydei laughed quietly as he landed in Phainon's arms.

“I really missed you, Phainon.”

Those were not the words that Phainon was expecting when Mydei literally almost toppled onto the floor, and his face burned in embarrassment at his lover’s straightforward words.

“How are you nervous after hearing that when you just fucked me in my own office?”

“*Mydei!*” Phainon hissed. Because Mydei was still lying in Phainon's arms, he was quite aware of how loudly and sporadically Phainon's heart was pounding against his ribcage.

“Let me stay here until I have to leave.”

And so Mydei did just that, shutting his eyes and listening to Phainon's pounding heart before he had to go in a few short minutes. In just a few short minutes would be the most pivotal meeting Mydei would ever have, and Phainon was going to grant Mydei whatever he wished for until then. He didn't even have time to panic this time over having sex again in a public place; his mind was already too busy worrying about his lover, who was about to face the CEO of their company.

Phainon settled on the floor, pulling up the rest of Mydei's pants as he seemed to be already falling asleep. His breathing had evened out, and he was curled into Phainon's arms with his face pressing into Phainon's chest. It was a peaceful silence now in the office, with Phainon alternating between admiring his lover and checking the time on the wall, counting down the minutes until the inevitable meeting.

The time passed by too quickly, much to Phainon's dismay. When the time finally came, Phainon gently woke Mydei up, giving him another quick kiss and wishing him good luck. And with a nod and an expression steeled with determination, Mydei fixed his golden hair and departed from the office. Phainon watched him go, watching that beloved golden color disappear behind the door as it closed.

Chapter 25

BCC: Message from the CEO Eurypon

It is with great pleasure that I inform you all that I am now stepping down from my position as CEO to enjoy a life of retirement. My son, Mydeimos, will be taking over as planned. It was wonderful news to hear that my son was interested in this company, and it is a great honor to pass this company onward to my beloved son. As he has already been working closely with the executive department for many, many years, I have nothing except faith that Mydeimos will bring this company the glory it deserves. He is knowledgeable, kind, and bright, and this company will see many equally bright days alongside Mydeimos.

It was a joy seeing how much this company has grown, from the first day the company's doors opened to now having more than a thousand employees. It fills me with great pride to know this company has such hard and diligent workers, and this company would not be here, in this position, without each and every one of you working in this very corporate building. Everyone has worked hard for this company, and your efforts do not go unseen. I thank you all from the bottom of my heart and hope that you all will be welcoming of my son. Mydeimos will be doing his utmost to support you all in all of your efforts, and he will be working hard to ensure that no one in this company is left behind.

As your new CEO, he is determined to guide this company on its righteous path. With the transition now in the works, Mydeimos will be taking over in a month. Please express your sincerest gratitude and congratulations to my son, as I am more than confident that he will be achieving grand things as Kremnos Corporation's next CEO.

Signed by Eurypon

CEO of Kremnos Corporation

It was a long email, consisting of the accomplishments Mydei will achieve, and a long rant about how much Eurypon enjoyed his job here, building this company from scratch and growing this corporation to be as big as it was now. The email was sent just two days after the big meeting, meaning that the wording of the email was pushed through the public relations department in just a short span of a day. Phainon wondered who drafted this email, as the wording clearly implied it was definitely not the CEO himself.

After talking with Mydei in his office before his big meeting, Phainon was determined to make more of an effort to see Mydei, just like he had asked him to. He didn't realize Mydei was waiting for him, even after his busy schedule, and Phainon was going to do his utmost to make up for all their lost time together. But at the end of that day, after the big meeting, Mydei had messaged him telling him to wait for an email. Phainon could only assume this was the email.

He wanted to congratulate Mydei and shower him with the love and affection his boyfriend deserved, but he still couldn't just show up at his office. They were still keeping their work life professional, so once he saw the email, he sent his congratulations over text. Something that did worry him, though, despite sending his congratulations, was that Mydei would be taking over in a month. Did that mean Eurypon had the Black Tide rights for a month still? Or were the rights not secured by the corporation yet?

Nonetheless, Phainon made a mental note to buy Mydei flowers and a gift to celebrate his success. This meant that the transition was proceeding after many weeks of working to have Eurypon step down and relinquish his title, and Phainon could not be prouder of Mydei. He would give a proper congratulations to Mydei once he was able to meet with him in person, outside of the office. Maybe he should go out to buy a gift and bother Mydei at his home on Friday night, so he could stay with his lover for the weekend.

“*Phainon!*”

Two hands clasped his shoulders as a singsong voice rang through the air. Pink hair brushed against his face as Cyrene leaned down, scanning the

email that was still pulled up on his screen.

“I was just reading this too,” Cyrene murmured softly. “So this is what Mydei has been up to all this time.”

Phainon nodded, his eyes never straying from the computer screen. “He's been hard at work. I'm sure once this transition is finalized, he'll have more time to hang with us.”

Cyrene laughed lightly. “There's no rush! It's not like we're going anywhere.” With a pat on Phainon’s shoulder, she pushed herself up and straightened her back. “Cas and I are going out into the city after work today. We were wondering if you wanted to come.”

“Today?” It was a random weekday, one that Phainon didn't think was suitable for just exploring the city's nightlife. It wasn't as if Phainon really minded anyway; he was just curious where Cyrene’s whim was taking them today.

“We're just going to shop around and then go out to eat,” Cyrene explained. “I've been *craving* that place that's around the block. The diner, I think? So I thought, why not look around the city at the nearby shops before stopping by to eat? There are so many stores to look at around here!”

“Sure, I'll join.” Phainon was already planning his own excursion. “I was going to go look for a gift anyway.”

“*Ooh!*” The grip around Phainon's shoulders tightened. “Is it who I think it's for? To celebrate a certain something?”

At her teasing tone, Phainon couldn't help but laugh, slightly flushing at her suggestive words. “Did you want to help me look?”

“Yes!” Cyrene sharply gasped. “Oh my gosh! Yes, I want to help you look! What kind of question is that?! Wait! I'm telling Cas. Okay, see you after work, bye!”

And she dashed off without another second wasted. Phainon could only quietly chuckle to himself while resuming his work. Not without lingering upon the email on his screen for one final time.

It was a peaceful day that day. There was much talk surrounding the email that was sent to everyone, with discussions about the future of the company and its policies once Mydei took over. Many people were in favor of Mydei already, and since they were already familiar with who Mydei was as a person, there wasn't much dissent surrounding his promotion to CEO. Everyone knew Mydei was the CEO's son, and they also knew he was brought here with an unofficial title so that he could learn about the company anyway. It was just a matter of time before Mydei eventually took over the reins.

Phainon relished the praise that was heard all around the office for his lover. He truly could not be prouder of Mydei now that his hard work was finally paying off. The office was happy for Mydei, excited for Mydei, and grateful for Mydei. It was hard to cover his smile at hearing so much praise surrounding Mydei, and he hoped Mydei wasn't busy enough so he could hear it too. He wished he could bottle up all of these praises and gift them to Mydei and see how much his face would light up, just like when they had complimented his upside-down cake. Phainon was also sure Mydei would like nothing more than to hear what all the employees thought of him as their new CEO, especially after everything that he had gone through and everything that it had taken to get here.

His lunch break was fast approaching, and he spent it with Cyrene and Castorice, as he usually did. Phainon tried to poke his head into Mydei’s office during their lunch; he knew Mydei usually slept during this time, but Phainon thought he could hang around with him even while he was catching up on sleep. But miraculously, Mydei was not there. Maybe he was still in a meeting?

“What are you looking for as a gift, Phainon?” Cyrene’s bright pink eyes were sparkling in the cafeteria lighting. He was sure Cyrene was more than elated to talk about more love and romance with her closest friend.

“I'm… not sure.” Phainon frowned, tilting his head to the side. “I haven't given it much thought. I definitely want to buy him flowers, though.”

At his words, Phainon sheepishly smiled and ran a nervous hand through his hair, while both women sitting in front of him blushed and cooed.

“We're going to find the perfect gift!” Cyrene vowed, with Castorice nodding vigorously beside her.

“Is it…” Castorice’s voice was timid as she hesitantly blinked at Cyrene and Phainon. “Is it too early to give a ring?”

“A *ring?*”

“A *ring!*”

Two very different reactions sounded between the group, with Phainon's face flaring a bright red, and Cyrene's equally turning red but for an entirely different reason.

“That's a perfect idea!”

“That's *not* a perfect idea.”

“*Aww*, Phainon!” Cyrene shot the blushing Phainon a look. “Why not?!”

“That's…” Phainon was scrambling to cool down his heated face, and he was covering the lower half of his face with a hand. “That's just… He's going to think I'm crazy.”

“No, he won't.” Surprisingly, it was Castorice firmly reassuring Phainon this time. “I know he would love it.”

“Really?” Phainon couldn't really wrap his head around it. He had been dating Mydei for just a couple of months now, so he didn't exactly think it was appropriate to buy a ring so early. They hadn't even been dating for half a year, after all, and their relationship pretty much just started. Not that Phainon was exactly opposed to it, but he didn't want Mydei to think he was insane. The thought of seeing Mydei wear a ring that Phainon had bought

for him sent a dangerous shiver down his spine. But, they had only been dating for a few months. Surely, Mydei would think Phainon was extra possessive, right? He *did* tell Phainon he liked him being clingy, but surely a ring was out of the question.

“It's not, like, a *promise* ring or anything,” Cyrene jumped in. “It's just a nice accessory to gift him! Not that I'm… *opposed* to promise rings or anything.”

“He's going to think I'm even crazier if I buy promise rings right now.”

“So just a normal ring then!” Cyrene exclaimed. “What's the harm in buying him a ring? It's like… buying a woman a pretty necklace, or buying him a watch! It's just a nice, fancy accessory to get him.”

“A fancy accessory that is associated with marriage?”

“You got this, Phainon!”

Phainon sighed heavily, burying his still reddened face into the palms of his hands. His voice was muffled as he spoke, with his voice vibrating against his hands. “Maybe I'll just look around at the stores we go to and find something he would like.”

“Like a ring!”

“I'm not getting him a ring, Cyrene.”

“I really think he would love it, Phainon,” Castorice gently reiterated.

It was a little unsettling how sure Castorice seemed to be about Mydei's opinion on a ring, and he peeked through his fingers to narrow an eye at his lavender-haired coworker. “Did he buy me a ring and tell you or something?”

“No!” Castorice blurted, her face equally turning a bright shade of red. She was waving her hands in the air, with both Phainon and Cyrene staring suspiciously at her. “I don't really talk to him! Really! I just really thought he would like anything Phainon gives him!”

“Isn't it a *little* suspicious that you brought up me giving him a ring, though?”

“It was only a suggestion!” Castorice squeaked. She was so red that Phainon swore he could see steam coming out of her ears, even while still peeking through his fingers.

Phainon laughed and finally relinquished Castorice from his interrogation. He set his hands back onto the table, swirling the salad he had set in front of him with his fork. “I'll just look around and see what speaks to me, and if a ring happens to speak to me, so be it.”

“YES!” Both Cyrene and Castorice cheered into the air while exchanging a high-five, and Phainon had to return to hiding his obvious blush behind his hands.

“Cas.” Cyrene turned to her friend beside her with a dangerous glint in her eyes, grasping the woman's shoulders as if Cyrene's life depended on it. “We need to find a ring that Phainon likes.”

Castorice nodded firmly, an equally dangerous glint also twinkling in her eyes. “We need to find a ring that Phainon likes.”

“Guys!” Phainon threw his hands down and stared exasperatedly at the two women, who weren't even paying the slightest attention to him. “You do *not* need to find a ring for me.”

“Oh, don't worry about us!” Cyrene nonchalantly waved her hand toward him, as if shooing him away. “You can look around at the shops, and we'll also… be looking around the shops.”

“We will just be perusing the stores with you, Phainon.”

Phainon did not appreciate the affirmative tones coming from the two women, and he did not appreciate the anticipatory and eager emotions swirling in their eyes either. But with a deep sigh, Phainon returned to finishing the rest of his salad while the two women began brainstorming for kinds of rings that Mydei would like.

Once their lunch break had come to an end, murmurs filled Phainon’s ears the moment the elevator doors opened for the three of them on their floor. The staff who had returned to their offices early were whispering amongst each other and staring in their direction with a knowing smile. He was confused at first, glancing between Cyrene and Castorice, who seemed equally as confused, but as they stepped out onto the floor, he was hit with a wave of nostalgia. That something like this had happened before. And with Phainon’s heart beginning to race at the familiar memory and being on the receiving end of these stares once again, his steps unconsciously quickened until his suspicions were confirmed once they turned the corner.

There was a giant, grand bouquet sitting on top of Phainon's desk again. The only difference was that this time, Phainon stood frozen to his spot, unable to approach the flowers due to the searing embarrassment that was settling in his veins and the crimson red blush crossing his entire face.

“Phainon! Your secret admirer striker again!”

“There are different flowers this time!”

“Phainon, who is crushing on you so hard in the office?!”

Cyrene was barely holding back her own snickering, and Castorice was also frozen to her spot, unable to digest the sheer amount of flowers towering over Phainon's workspace. Phainon rapidly forced his feet down the hall to try and draw attention from the flowers as much as possible, while Cyrene was happily laughing away at the comedic scene and shooing the bystanders to return to their desks.

The flowers that sat upon Phainon's desk were no longer yellow roses. Well, there were some yellow roses included within this bouquet, but the main flower this time was blue. They were small, light blue flowers, with a bright yellow center, and tied around them, as usual, was a card:

Meet me at the place where our story began.

Friday night. 7 PM.

You said you would do whatever I wished for.

Phainon breathlessly laughed, covering the lower half of his blushing face with his free hand. Was this where Mydei disappeared off to during lunch? To pick up this grandiose display of flowers? Whatever he wished for? Was he referring to Phainon's words two days ago when he was doing… *that* to him? The thought of remembering their time together in Mydei's office only made his entire body burn in even more embarrassment.

“Oh, Phainon! That's so romantic!”

He jolted and almost dropped the card as he whirled around to lock eyes with Cyrene, who was just peeking over his shoulder to read the card in his hand.

“*Cyrene!”*

“I didn't know he was so romantic!” Cyrene was too busy gushing to listen to what Phainon had to say. “Oh, I'm *so* excited to hang out with him soon! Tell me how Friday goes!”

And she rushed off to her desk before Phainon could unleash his embarrassed and exasperated wrath onto her.

Castorice laughed lightly as Cyrene disappeared down the hall, smiling softly at the flowers that were displayed for all on the floor to see. “Forget-me-nots. I'm sure he is referring to how you forgot what happened that night.”

“Is that what these flowers are?” Phainon stared at them once more, admiring their bright yellow centers that matched the adorning yellow roses, and contrasting blue petals that added a beautiful variance to the bouquet. “Do you know a lot about flowers?”

Castorice hummed with a nod. It was probably the biggest smile Phainon had ever seen on her face. “I love flowers. Forget-me-nots hold a meaning of love and remembrance. You must truly mean a lot to him, Phainon.”

With a blush only continuing to grow across his cheek from her words, Phainon could only awkwardly laugh, scratching the back of his head while never tearing his gaze from the flowers. “Then, I guess I have to prepare for a dinner date on Friday.”

“Phainon, we really must get you the perfect ring to present to him on Friday.”

“I'm not–!”

Castorice darted off toward her cubicle before Phainon could unleash his embarrassed and exasperated wrath onto her.

With a deep sigh exiting Phainon’s body, he sat himself down at his cubicle, admiring the flowers and his lover's handwriting. He traced the pen strokes, felt the textured cardstock between his fingers, and brushed through the abundance of flowers before him one last time with a soft smile before returning to his work.

“Why don't we go to an antique store?!”

Phainon, Castorice, and Cyrene were standing outside the diner that Cyrene really wanted to eat at. It was a popular local restaurant, Marmoreal Diner, and it was always one of their favorites to visit after work. Lately, they hadn't gone, so Cyrene had been itching to visit again. They had just made their reservation for later in the night for dinner, so they were now trying to decide where to shop around first.

“Why do I feel like I'm always going to antique stores with you?” Phainon smiled sheepishly at the thought of the last time they went to one.

“I just thought you would love to look at antiques and vintage stuff since you seem to like it.” Cyrene was already scrolling through nearby vintage sellers on her phone.

“I'm just tagging along with you guys. You can go wherever you want.” Phainon glanced at Castorice for some support, only to find that she was

also looking up vintage sellers.

“Yeah, we just happen to really want to look at antiques today.”

“Cyrene.” Phainon laughed loudly. “I'm not getting Mydei a ring.”

“Why not?!” Both women cried, staring up at Phainon with almost glistening eyes.

As much as Phainon *really did want to see Mydei wearing a ring that he had gotten for him*, he just thought it was too… forward. Wouldn't Mydei think he was absolutely crazy? He was going to think Phainon was crazy possessive! And, would he even be able to wear it to work? Wouldn't people question him if he showed up one day with a brand new ring? They weren't supposed to be attracting attention at work anyway, so there was no point buying him something he wouldn't be able to wear for the majority of his days.

He really, really wanted to gift Mydei a ring, and the more he entertained the idea, the more it sent his heart racing at the thought. He could just imagine Mydei's shining eyes and gentle smile while he admired a ring on his finger that Phainon had bought for him. He imagined Mydei playing with the ring while thinking fondly of Phainon, and he so desperately craved to see Mydei's face once Phainon pulled out a ring for him. Mydei would be absolutely glowing while accepting the ring, with that adorably pink blush that he always had whenever Phainon complimented his pastries and desserts. How much Phainon desperately wanted to see such a sight was indescribable.

But he had to keep telling himself that it was way too soon. As tempting as the sight would be, Phainon would have to swallow his own desires down and bury them away. Mydei was so much more grounded and self-assured than Phainon, and Phainon really wanted to be the same toward Mydei. And getting a ring right now, when they had barely been dating for that long, wouldn't exactly scream a “grounded, self-assured boyfriend.” It wasn't as if Phainon couldn't buy him a ring at all; he'll definitely get one for his lover eventually.

“I think we're getting ahead of ourselves here.” Phainon ran a hand through his hair with another chuckle. “I'll just tag along with you guys wherever you want to go, and I'll eventually find something to gift to Mydei.”

“But wouldn't gifting him a ring to celebrate becoming CEO be so cute?” Cyrene wailed.

“Cyrene.”

At the small, pitiful smile that Phainon gave her, they finally acquiesced and dropped the idea, much to their dismay. So they eventually decided to aimlessly walk around the street in whichever direction they pleased, waiting out their time until their reservation.

Most of the stores on this street were quite fancy; it was safe to say anything in the city was expensive, but even more so on this street since they were close to the financial district where their office building was located. These shops on this street consisted mostly of name-brand stores, so they decided to peruse those. There were clothing stores and makeup stores that they spent the most time in, but there were also cafés and dessert stores lining this street.

He spent most of his time brainstorming what to buy for Mydei when they were in the makeup stores. Phainon didn’t really wear makeup, but he did like skincare. But since he was here for Mydei and not for himself, he decided to only scan around the store while thinking of his boyfriend. It didn't really help that looking at anything red reminded him of Mydei and his golden hair dyed crimson at their ends and his crimson tattoos, and Cyrene even suggested buying him red makeup to match. Phainon immediately fell silent while actually considering the idea, resulting in an endless amount of teasing from Cyrene. It wasn't Phainon's fault that Mydei would look good in literally everything and anything.

When they stopped into their first name-brand clothing store, Cyrene and Castorice were adamant about buying Phainon a new outfit. He tried to shoot them down, explaining that the store was way too expensive, and he would much prefer something else. However, his two friends wouldn't budge.

“Phainon, you are *not* showing up to your date on Friday wearing your normal clothes.” Cyrene was furiously sifting through racks of coats and holding each one up to Phainon’s torso before roughly shoving them back and sifting through some more.

“Why not?” Phainon was mostly in awe at how fast she was moving to realize her blatant insult.

Cyrene didn't answer, seeming to be focused on finding the perfect outerwear, so Castorice hesitantly opened her mouth, jumping into the conversation. “Phainon… do you not own a mirror?”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “I do?”

“It doesn't look like you do.”

He blinked blankly at her with a puzzled smile slowly forming upon his lips. “What is that supposed to mean?”

“Cas!” Cyrene seemed to be consumed in piles of coats, but she didn't appear to need help in the slightest. “Help me find a black turtleneck, please?”

Castorice dashed off to the shirt section before she could answer Phainon's question.

Since Castorice was gone now, Phainon could only stop Cyrene. He tried to pull her out of the racks of clothing she had shoved her head into, but she swatted his hand away.

“Cyrene, I have plenty of clothes to wear on Friday. I can just wear one of–”

A perfectly manicured finger shoved straight into his face, and he fell silent.

“You are *not* showing up wearing your own clothes on Friday.”

“What's wrong with my clothes?”

“Phainon.” An exasperated sigh came from the rack of clothes she was currently shoved into, and a pink head of hair eventually emerged from the coats. While flattening her own tangled hair, she spoke, “Ever since we were young, you have always had such terrible fashion.”

“But–”

“No!” That perfectly manicured finger was shoved against his lips, silencing him once more. “I'm not done, Phainon. No one has ever said anything because of your pretty, pretty privilege.”

“I–”

Cyrene clicked her tongue, as if scolding Phainon. “You can make anything look good with your pretty face, but that does not mean what you wear is good.”

Phainon had never seen Cyrene so passionately reprimanding him about something before, and never in thirty-three million years was he going to guess that it was about his clothes.

“Are my clothes… really that bad?” He glanced down at his work clothes, and it was just a white collared dress shirt, a black tie, black slacks, and black leather shoes.

“Your work clothes are just standard work clothes, Phainon. But when it comes to your everyday clothes…” Cyrene frowned while shooting him a pitiful look. “They're… how should I put this nicely? You don't really know what textures go well together, and you don't really know what clothes look good together either.”

“Textures? I thought we were talking about clothes? To wear?”

“Clothes are made of textures, Phainon!” Cyrene cried while almost throwing the coats in her hand out of sheer exasperation. “The material they're made of matters!”

“Isn't it as long as it's comfortable, it's fine?”

“But some textures don't look good with each other! Of course, it matters if the material feels good on you, but it also matters what they look like together! And don't even get me started on the colors of your clothes.”

“What's wrong with the colors of my clothes?”

Cyrene had already buried herself back into the rack, determined to find a new outfit for Phainon.

Despite Phainon’s very valid arguments, Cyrene and Castorice had made him try on his new outfit, and with a nod of approval, they bought everything before Phainon could stop them or, at least, buy the pieces himself.

“This is to celebrate you having a super hot, rich boyfriend, Phainon!” Cyrene swiped her credit card with a grin, with Castorice nodding in agreement right beside her.

Phainon could only stare with worried eyes toward the credit card terminal, where a number that appeared way too long to be a price tag appeared before swiftly disappearing to display a thank you message. “At least let me pay you back.”

“Nonsense!” Cyrene nonchalantly waved her hand in the air. “When we all go out together with Mydei, you can buy your own outfit then.”

“An outfit that we approve of,” Castorice interjected.

“An outfit that we approve of,” Cyrene repeated.

“There's nothing wrong with my clothes!” Phainon cried, but the two women had already departed the store with bags of Phainon's new outfit in hand.

The next couple of stores that they visited were more name-brand clothing stores, and Cyrene and Castorice spent the majority of their time shopping for themselves now. Phainon casually and mindlessly sifted through the racks while still trying to think of what to buy for Mydei. But as store after

store whisked before his very eyes, Phainon still did not know what to get for his lover.

Was there even anything that Mydei needed? He couldn't imagine that Mydei was missing anything in his life, and if he was, he had more than enough money to go out and buy his own. Phainon also already found him *The Cycles of Vigethos*, so now there really was nothing that he could think of to gift Mydei. Phainon thought about buying him chocolates, but he thought that was too low an effort. Was Phainon just being picky at this point? But he really, truly wanted to get something that would mean a lot to Mydei. He had worked so hard to get to where he was now; surely Phainon could spend extra care getting him a gift that meant a lot to him.

They had ventured quite far from Marmoreal Diner now, the place where they had started, and Cyrene and Castorice were carrying an impressive number of bags. Even with Phainon helping them carry as much as he could, he still didn't have enough space to help them carry the rest. Since their reservation was nearing soon, and they had to make the trek back with all their purchases, Castorice suggested consolidating all their bags together into the bigger bags, which they had to stop off to the side of the sidewalk to do so. It was when Phainon was trying to fit everything together that a sharp, dramatic gasp rang through the air.

“Phainon! Phainon, Phainon, Phainon!”

Phainon was kneeling on the ground, trying to consolidate all their purchases together, when nimble hands started smacking and shaking his shoulders. With a laugh while fighting through the persistent hands, Phainon glanced up to his best friend, only to see that she was gaping at something a little more down the street, but from where he was kneeling on the floor, he couldn't really tell what she was staring at, no matter how much he squinted and waved his head around.

“Cyrene?”

“We should go in there!” Eager hands hurriedly pulled him from the ground, tugging at his clothes and hair until he was standing upon his two feet with as many purchases as he could hold in his hands.

“It's… actually an antique store.” Phainon laughed in disbelief at the sight. “I didn't think we'd find one on this street.”

“Rich people love antiques, Phainon!” With a wink from his friend, Cyrene promptly disappeared toward the store. Castorice and Phainon quickly finished up, shoving as many bags together as they could before catching up to her.

The store was definitely much more expensive than the other antique store that Phainon and Cyrene had visited outside the city, and it was definitely much smaller as well, considering stores couldn't be hugely expansive while crowded side by side in the city. Although stuffed to the brim, it was a lot more organized and a lot more well-kept. Phainon could only assume that many wealthy people visited here from the steep prices that he saw lining the shelves and floor.

There was a jewelry section all the way in the back, right in front of the cash register, and it was where Castorice and Phainon finally caught up with Cyrene.

“Phainon, look!” Cyrene's sparkling eyes were glued to the jewelry case set before her. There were various antique and vintage jewelry items, ranging from necklaces, bracelets, earrings, rings, and even watches. Phainon couldn't help but also admit that they were absolutely beautiful pieces that were polished and thoroughly taken care of by the store, though he may be biased as an antique lover himself.

“Many of these pieces were sold to us.” The store associate behind the counter approached their group. “A lot of them are either from departed family members and friends, or simply someone trying to get rid of their collection to give to a better home.”

“So you can sell your jewelry here?” Cyrene finally glanced up from the shining glass case.

“We don't buy everything, but if you have something you want to sell, we will take a look.”

Cyrene hummed, planting her gaze back to the jewelry pieces before her and pointing out the ones she was really interested in. The store associate offered to bring some of these pieces out for her to try on, which Cyrene adamantly denied with a shake of her head.

“I'm actually here for a friend of mine!” A tight grasp suddenly tugged on Phainon’s wrist, and he stumbled toward her and almost dropped their bags.

“I'm… actually not here for anything.” Phainon awkwardly chuckled. “Sorry about her.”

“No, he *is* here for something.” Cyrene shot him a look before turning back to the store associate. “We were interested in looking for something to celebrate? His partner recently got promoted at work, and he wants to buy a gift to celebrate.”

Just hearing someone else verbally acknowledge their relationship sent Phainon's ears burning and his palms sweating, but the store associate didn't seem to realize, only raising her eyebrows in surprise.

“Why, that's certainly a cause for celebration.” The store associate smiled, and, much to Phainon's fear and anxiety, she began sliding open the glass case on her side. “Were you looking for any jewelry pieces in particular? Necklaces, bracelets, or rings?”

This was moving way too fast for Phainon to stop them, and he opened his mouth in a panic. “No, actually I–”

“Could we look at some rings first?” Cyrene abruptly interrupted Phainon. “His partner is very strong, intelligent, confident, and mature.”

“She sounds like a wonderful woman.” With her customer service smile never fading, the store associate hummed while delving into their collection. Much to Phainon's horror, there were even more pieces behind her, which she began sifting through until eventually bringing back *a velvet cushion* displaying a wide array of jewelry. Phainon wasn't even sure if he could afford just that pillow.

“I tried to collect pieces for a woman who exudes maturity, confidence, and strength.” She set the cushion before them on the glass case that separated them while Cyrene and Castorice leaned in to get a better look. “Many of these use gold, but I am unsure if your partner prefers gold or silver, so I also included a couple of sterling silver pieces from our collection for your viewing.”

“They… like gold.” Phainon was feeling somewhat defeated now. It wasn't as if he could exactly tell the store associate to put everything away now, right? Was it too late to tell her that his partner was actually a man? Would it be weird to buy women's jewelry for Mydei? He could just say he didn't like any of the pieces, but he might as well look through them since the store associate had gone through so much trouble gathering everything.

“If you're unsatisfied with any of these, I can also look for more in the back.” The store associate nodded and stepped back, allowing the group more space to admire the pieces.

“Phainon, look at how gorgeous these are!” Cyrene whispered once Phainon finally bent his head down to scan everything laid out before them. True to the store associate’s word, most of the pieces were gold. They were cleaned and polished, with only the wear of belonging to a previous owner.

“Also expensive,” Castorice muttered.

“Guys, I'm not actually getting Mydei a ring.” At the look sent his way by two pairs of eyes, Phainon somewhat deflated under their gazes. “... Right?”

“Well, just look and see if you like any!” Cyrene sharply muttered, pulling Phainon closer to have a better look at all the items on the velvet cushion. A sigh escaped him before he finally acquiesced. It wasn't as if he was *actually* going to buy anything, so he might as well look around to appease the two women next to him.

He peered much more closely at each of the pieces, and he couldn't deny that each and every one of them was simply beautiful, unique, and had its own story to tell. It was exactly why Phainon loved antiques; they all possessed their own special memories. Memories that people would never

see again. These jewelry pieces had experienced so much with their previous owners, and here they were again, ready to embark on another adventure. And another adventure. And another adventure. In a completely endless cycle of adventures. Only these jewelry pieces themselves knew how many stories they had been a witness to.

It may have been fortunate for Phainon, but there was nothing really that spoke to him. Maybe he thought the pieces were too feminine and dainty for Mydei, but he couldn't imagine himself giving any one of these pieces to Mydei. So with a shake of his head, the store associate took the velvet pillow away and began storing everything back into their respective spots.

“You didn't like any of them?” Cyrene shyly tugged on his sleeve, which was a stark contrast to how she had been treating him all day.

“I just couldn't imagine gifting any of them,” Phainon responded quietly. He couldn't help but feel disappointed. Maybe he was secretly hoping to find a ring to give to Mydei, but it didn't change the fact that he didn't like any of them. “I don't think they're the right style.”

“If they're not the right style, may I suggest something else?” The store associate's voice rang in the air, and as she drew their attention once more, she called into the back room. “Chartonus! Can you give me the red box we keep back there?”

Rustling ensued in the back, and the three of them shared quizzical glances as the store associate continued to smile at them. “Chartonus is in charge of restoration. He is in charge of maintaining our jewelry, and any that come in broken or missing gems, he repairs them as well.”

It was only a few moments later that a burly man eventually emerged from the back, setting a crimson red jewelry box onto the glass case in front of them. Though Phainon didn't get much of a chance to have a look at the man, because with a brief nod, Chartonus disappeared into the back while the store associate opened the box with delicate fingers.

At just the first look at what was inside, it felt like the breath in Phainon's lungs was knocked out of him as he stared at what lay before him with wide

eyes. With signs of scratches on its surface, reflecting under the store lighting, it was still kept in top condition. It was a gold signet ring, with some sort of crest engraved at the top. With its circular bezel, it leaned more toward the feminine side of jewelry, but without gemstones, it seemed to lean more gender-neutral, if anything. It was a simple, yet elegant and classy ring, and something about its simplicity, yet sturdy and thick shank, seemed to exude strength and maturity from its simple and timeless design.

“This is quite the precious ring, and we never show it to anyone.” It seemed the store associate was also admiring the ring. “But I think it will be the best choice for your partner, from what I've heard. The other pieces we have are much more feminine, but this piece tends to be a little more neutral. Yet, not too masculine either. I think it would be perfect for your partner.”

As much as Phainon wanted to agree, he also knew that such a ring would also come with a hefty price. This ring was definitely something he could imagine Mydei wearing. Someone who was self-assured in themselves and never backed down in the face of danger; that was who this ring belonged to. It was almost as if Phainon could feel the power of the previous owner in this ring.

“How… much is it?” Phainon hesitantly tore his gaze from the ring to land upon the all too pleased store associate. His hands were already shaking to anticipate hearing such a horrid number, and he almost wished he hadn't stepped into this store only to find out he could not afford what he would consider a perfect gift for Mydei. It was as if the sane part in Phainon's mind that had been pulling him back from buying a ring so early in their relationship had completely disappeared. The ring was so perfect that it negated all of Phainon's rational thoughts.

A calculator was whipped out from behind the counter, and the store associate began tapping too many times on it for Phainon to know that it was definitely a price that he could not afford. Even after a few moments of typing away, he almost wanted to interrupt her since it was clear he could not afford such a special ring. His suspicions were only confirmed once the calculator was turned toward them, displaying a number that Phainon couldn't even fathom.

“Phainon,” Cyrene gently tugged on his sleeve, “if you really want it, we can split it?”

Castorice also gently tugged on his other sleeve. “I do not mind chipping in either.”

“No, guys, it's fine.” Phainon immediately dismissed their suggestion. “I'd… rather be able to afford my own gift for Mydei.”

Glancing toward the store associate with a small smile, he thanked her, swallowing down his disappointment and exiting the store.

Chapter 26

Phainon could not forget about that ring.

When he returned home after the diner, he saw the moon through his window and was reminded of that circular bezel. That night, before he felt his consciousness slipping away, he was reflecting upon the day’s events, and that signet ring flashed in his mind. The next morning, on the drive to work, he saw the golden sun peeking above the horizon, and he thought about the gold color of that signet ring. At work, clicking away on his computer, he would glance down at his hand and think about that signet ring.

Every little thing reminded him of that signet ring. Frankly, Phainon could not take it anymore. He knew how much it was, yet he could not stop himself from thinking about that ring. He was all too aware that the store associate, whom he was now realizing was probably the owner, most likely set the price at an unreasonably high number because she didn't want to part with it. Phainon couldn't blame her; he wanted that ring too. But there was no possible way for Phainon to afford that ring, and his heart ached knowing that he had found such a perfect gift only to have to voluntarily force his own two legs to walk away from it. He wished he had never walked into that store; now, anything Phainon was going to buy as a present would pale in comparison to that ring.

There was something about that ring that just screamed for Mydei's name. Something that seemed to just exude his very being, and Phainon *needed* that ring on Mydei's finger. There was no one else who could possibly wear that ring except for Mydei; Phainon was absolutely adamant about that fact. Every time he hyped himself up to close his eyes at the store and swipe his credit card to finally purchase the ring, his entire body would deflate at the cemented memory of all those numbers on that calculator. There was no possible way he could afford that ring.

Surely, it wouldn't hurt to look again, right? Surely, the same store would have other similar-looking pieces? Maybe Phainon could find something

else that was at least somewhat similar to the ring, right? He wasn't going to stop by *for* the ring; he was going to stop by for other things! And, it wouldn't hurt to take a look at the ring *while* he was there. Again, he wasn't going *for* the ring, but he might as well look at it if he was going to visit the store anyway.

“Why are you acting so suspiciously?”

A deep voice cut his thoughts, and Phainon laughed, patting a head of golden hair that was slumped on the desk. “I don't know what you're talking about.”

He was finally reunited with Mydei after their fiasco in this very office they were sitting in, and it was their lunch break now. Mydei was trying to blink the sleep out of his eyes to stay up with Phainon, which Phainon found absolutely adorable, but he was softly running his fingers through his golden hair and trying to coax the man to fall asleep.

“You keep looking at me. I don't know what you want,” Mydei muttered slowly.

“I always look at you, Mydei.” Phainon chuckled. “Why wouldn't I admire my beautiful boyfriend?”

Phainon could not believe that Mydei noticed he was staring at him differently. In fact, Phainon was trying to gauge Mydei’s ring size the entire time he was sitting in here, and he couldn't do it in a very discreet way and was left squinting and glaring at Mydei's hands. He was trying to be very subtle about it; clearly, he was not being subtle at all. He couldn't get that ring out of his mind, no matter how much he tried, and even with Mydei sitting right before his very eyes, all it did was emphasize how perfect Mydei would look wearing that ring.

“You…” With a burning face, Mydei flipped his head to face the wall, earning a laugh from Phainon.

“Just go to sleep, Mydei.” Phainon bent down to whisper into his lover's ear, and the shiver that rushed down his body didn't escape Phainon's notice.

He smiled at the sight, continuing to run his hair through golden strands. “You're still working at the bakery during all of this. Don't let me bother you and just sleep.”

“It's… been too long.” Mydei's faint voice murmured. Phainon could tell Mydei was just stubbornly fighting sleep now, and he felt a little guilty that he decided to come visit Mydei while he was supposed to be sleeping. Was this what Mydei was going through the entire time he was making time for Phainon despite his busy schedule? Was he always teetering on the edge of consciousness, fighting to stay awake just to see Phainon? It only made Phainon more motivated to get that ring for Mydei.

“I know, my love.” Phainon pressed a soft kiss against his golden head of hair. “Please, just go to sleep for me? You sound so tired. We can talk all we want on Friday, right?”

“Then, tell me why you're acting so suspicious, and I will go to sleep.”

“I don't know what you're talking about. I'm acting perfectly normal.”

Mydei turned his head back around just to shoot a glare in Phainon's direction just to turn back, causing Phainon to laugh once more.

“I really loved the flowers you gave me yesterday, Mydei.” Another gentle kiss pressed against golden strands. “I put them on my counter at home. They look really beautiful.”

“I'm glad you liked them,” Mydei murmured. His voice was becoming quieter with every word spoken. “They reminded me of you.”

“Because I'm forgetful and lovable?”

Mydei weakly scoffed. “Because, despite you forgetting that night, I still like you for some reason. I see you looked up the meaning of the flowers without me telling you this time.”

“Castorice told me.”

“Castorice?”

Phainon nodded only to realize that Mydei was not facing him anymore. “She told me they meant love and remembrance. It really does remind me of us.”

“That reminds me. I need to thank her.”

“Thank her?” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. His mind immediately flashed to yesterday, when Castorice was extremely and suspiciously adamant that she and Mydei did not converse with each other, but he wasn't able to receive a confirmation or any sort of clarity because Mydei did not respond.

Humming curiously, Phainon gently tugged on Mydei’s arm before pulling him backwards. He shifted their seats as best as he could, allowing Mydei’s head to drop onto Phainon's shoulder, and a small sigh left Mydei's lips as he curled into Phainon’s side as best as he could in their office chairs. Phainon was trying extremely hard not to gush over how cute Mydei was right now, and instead repeated his question once more.

“Did you ask Castorice for something?”

At the lack of an answer, Phainon glanced down to his shoulder only to see that Mydei had finally succumbed to sleep and let unconsciousness take over his body, and he couldn't get over the fact that he had immediately fallen asleep the moment he rested his head on Phainon. He smiled to himself and hoped his excitement wasn't noticeable to the other man because his heart was beating loudly at the thought that Mydei felt so safe with him and so comfortable with him, and he hoped his own palpitating heart wouldn't wake his lover up when he had finally fallen asleep.

With a blush tinting his cheeks, Phainon spent the rest of his lunch eating the rest of his salad, playing with golden hair, admiring delicate and sharp features, and trying to figure out how to take measurements for a finger.

It wasn't as if Phainon was actually going to buy Mydei a ring, right? He couldn't afford it. He couldn't afford it *at all*. Even if he miraculously received some sort of discount on the ring, he still wouldn't be able to afford

the ring. So, there was no point in continuing to think about that ring or even entertaining the idea of that ring.

There was no point in looking up how to take a ring measurement, and there was no point in actually following the instructions, he told himself while cutting up a blank sticky note found on Mydei’s desk and carefully wrapping a thin strip around his finger, trying not to move Mydei too much that he would wake him. There was no point in doing this, he repeated in his mind while marking where the sticky note overlapped on Mydei's finger. There was no point in doing this, he emphasized while pulling up his phone to measure the distance between one end of the sticky note and that line he marked.

So why was Phainon here after work, standing in front of that cursed antique store again? He had somehow convinced himself all day with that dumb excuse that if this store held such a ring, surely they also held other products that exuded Mydei's energy. So here he was once more, about to walk away from that ring yet again, which he could not afford.

The store was just as empty as it was yesterday; it was probably why the store owner was entertaining them for so long, despite none of them appearing as if they could afford a single thing in that store. However, this time, that store owner was nowhere to be found behind the counter.

Phainon was left wandering around that glass case full of jewelry pieces that didn't manage to grab his attention. It was a few minutes of pacing back and forth and swaying his head this way and that until he finally sighed. He whirled around on his feet, already planning to visit another day despite having absolutely no intentions of buying a single item in this shop, when the door leading deeper into the store clicked behind him.

“Something you need?”

Changing a glance over his shoulder was that burly man he had seen yesterday. According to the assumed shop owner, he was Chartonus, the one in charge of restoration and maintenance of their pieces.

“You're… Chartonus, right?” Phainon tried as nonchalantly as he could to return to the counter with his heart rattling his ribcage, where Chartonus only grunted with a nod. “My name is Phainon. I'm not sure if you remember me, but I visited yesterday with two of my friends. I was… wondering if I could see that ring again. The one from yesterday?”

“River ring.” Chartonus nodded and disappeared into the back before Phainon could respond.

River ring? What did that even mean? Phainon didn't have much time to ponder it before Chartonus emerged once again with a familiar crimson box in his hand.

Phainon's eyes widened as it was placed onto the counter, further confirming that this was indeed the same crimson box from yesterday. He wasn't sure how exactly this ring was associated with the river, but at least Chartonus actually remembered him. So with shaky hands, Phainon plucked up the box, opening it with timid hands and revealing that same golden, signet ring that took his breath away.

The more he stared at the ring, the more his eyes turned downcast. The more he admired it shining in the light, the more he could see just how much value this ring held. It was truly a beauty, and Phainon was more disappointed that he could not return home with it. His heart felt emptier the longer he stared at it and the more the truth settled within his head that this ring was just absolutely perfect. It was the pinnacle of perfection for Mydei, and it tore Phainon to pieces that he had to leave it here. He even considered taking the ring from the box just to twirl the ring within his hands, just to imagine what it would be like holding this relic within his hands, but he decided against it. It would make Phainon feel worse leaving this crimson box behind after holding the ring himself.

Closing the box, he slid it across the counter toward Chartonus's direction, who had just been standing there watching Phainon wistfully admire the ring. His heart sank the longer he lingered in that store in the presence of that signet ring, and he had to remind himself that it was time for him to go. He had no other business to attend to here, and Phainon had that last look that he wanted. It was time to accept that he could not bring it with him. At

least he could admire it this time without the unsettling customer service smile of the shop owner. He much rather enjoyed Chartonus's quiet presence more.

“Thank you, Chartonus,” Phainon managed despite his tightening throat. “I hope you have a great evening.”

He had to force his gaze away from that crimson red box, pulling his body away from the counter and away from this store. It felt like resisting a magnetic pull that drew him so much to this ring, and his limbs felt heavy as he headed toward the exit. Who was Phainon kidding? He didn't come here to find a similar gift for Mydei at all; he merely just wanted an excuse to look at that ring one last time. That was it. He just wanted to relish in that signet ring’s presence for one last time before finding an actual gift for Mydei that he could afford. Phainon could only hope that the next owner of that ring, who was able to afford it, would treat it with the care it deserved.

“The ring… You want?”

A deep voice stopped Phainon in his tracks. He was already halfway down the store when he glanced over his shoulder once again. Chartonus was staring at him just as he had before, so Phainon doubted those words even came from him. That was, until he repeated his sentence, bringing Phainon back to his senses.

“I… do.” Phainon slowly turned around to face him, flashing a sheepish smile. Being in the city meant meeting a diverse melting pot of people, and he could tell from the way he spoke that Chartonus most likely hailed from a different nation. Phainon wondered what kind of stories even he had to tell, and what kind of experiences led him to move to the city for work. “But I–*uh*–don't have enough for it. Maybe don't tell the owner I was here again, okay?”

Chartonus seemed to stare at him silently, making Phainon awkwardly shift in place. It was almost as if the man were assessing him, but all Phainon could do was continue staring back at him while rooted to his spot in the shop.

With a rough grunt, Chartonus nodded. “Help. The ring, I give.”

Phainon blinked blankly. A few moments of silence passed between them, with Phainon staring straight at Chartonus, who seemed to be doing just the same toward him.

“... Huh?”

It was the only noise that could come out of Phainon's throat. He couldn't even comprehend what Chartonus was saying. Was he even allowed to give the ring? Just like that? Without the shop owner's consent? What would a burly man like Chartonus possibly need Phainon's help with? If anything, Phainon wanted to know more about what kind of exercise routines Chartonus had to get arms like his.

“The ring, I give,” Chartonus simply repeated.

Phainon could still barely bring himself to say any sensible response back, only flapping his lips open and scrambling back toward the country. “You… You can just *give* me the ring? If I help you?”

Chartonus nodded.

“Without asking the shop owner?”

Chartonus nodded.

“Doesn't she… like this ring?”

Chartonus nodded.

“Then… you can just give the ring away? The one she wants so much money for? Just for my help?”

Chartonus nodded.

Phainon was trying to search his face with exasperated and incredulous eyes, trying to find some sort of lie hidden by his words, or perhaps the help he needed was outrageously difficult. But there was nothing but honesty

behind Chartonus’s serious appearance, and Phainon couldn't find any other justification to say no.

“What… am I helping you with?” Phainon was still extremely hesitant. Even while trusting the big man in front of him, who seemed to tower over Phainon from their short interaction, it didn't seem as if Chartonus would lie, but the deal just seemed too good to be true.

“Antiques, you like?”

Phainon nodded.

“Appraisal, you know?”

Phainon nodded much more slowly this time. From all the history books he had read about relics and antiques, he had picked up some knowledge about it, but he never had the chance to put it into practice. Antique appraisal wasn't very common in the modern world in the heart of the city, after all.

“I know… a little bit.” Phainon wasn't sure if this was going to ruin his chances of securing the ring, but he didn't want to lie to Chartonus, who seemed to be offering him a chance. “But I have never been able to put it into practice.

Chartonus shook his head. “Tomorrow. This address, go here. My friend, help with the appraisal.”

The man pulled out a notepad and a pen from his back pocket and clumsily scribbled an address onto the first page, ripping it off and handing it to Phainon. Taking the piece of paper from his hands, Phainon studied the address. It really wasn't that far from here–only a few streets down. There also wasn't much concern for getting kidnapped, hopefully, considering that the store was on one of the main streets in the city.

Glancing up from the paper, Phainon narrowed his eyes at the other man. “And… you're sure you'll give me this ring if I help your friend here?” He waved the paper in the air.

Chartonus simply nodded. “This ring, I found. Owner, is me.”

“Owner… of the ring? Or this shop?”

With another nod, Chartonus disappeared into the back, leaving Phainon absolutely dumbstruck all by himself in the antique store.

Phainon had received a text message from Mydei the next day. During this one-month transition, it seemed that Eurypon was hatching a plan to try and find as much dirt on his son as possible to win over the board of directors and reinstate himself as CEO before it was too late. He was told not to come by Mydei's office or even his house until the month was over, which was some unfortunate news considering how much Phainon missed his lover. Phainon asked about their dinner planned for Friday; he was completely fine with cancelling if that was better, but Mydei insisted on keeping dinner, saying that he would look into upgrading their reservation to a private room.

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (8:33am): *I want to see you.*

Scoffing incredulously to himself, with his face blushing from those five simple words, Phainon pocketed his phone after reading that message again from this morning. It made him elated knowing that Mydei felt the same as him, and he could not count how many times he had read his message over and over again throughout the day.

But Phainon had other things on his mind now. Since he couldn't see Mydei, he had more time to himself. So here he was again, after work, back in the city instead of relaxing in his own apartment.

He raised the piece of paper in his hand, matching the address with the building standing in front of him, before stepping inside. It was another antique store–this one much smaller than the previous one. It was also much more bare than the other store, with only vintage and antique framed paintings hanging from the walls, and a glass case holding jewelry toward the back of the store. The rest of the store was empty, save for some low, cushioned seating placed in the center of the store as if it were a shoe store.

“Phainon?”

Phainon whipped his head up from where he was taking in his surroundings to find someone now behind the counter. He scrambled up to the front with a nod. “I was told to come here by Chartonus. Are you the friend I'm helping?”

With a big grin, the man nodded. “Call me Theorodos. I need help.”

“Help?”

The grin immediately dropped from his face as Theodoros sighed heavily. “This store is mainly empty, as it's mostly used to appraise antiques and jewelry. Many of the pieces that are appraised here are brought to my other store, where Chartonus usually works to repair everything.”

“So… *you're* the owner?” Phainon was absolutely flabbergasted, and he was trying really hard not to let his surprise seep through to his words. He had already cycled through two other potential owners, and now Phainon was hearing of a *third* owner? Was this guy going to give him another address where Phainon would find a *fourth* owner? Was the price Phainon needed to pay for the signet ring a scavenger hunt around the city?

“It's a partnership,” Theodoros explained. “I'm in charge of appraisals. Chartonus is in charge of restoration.”

“So… is that other lady in charge of running the stores?”

“What lady?” Theorodos squinted, making Phainon immediately shake his head.

“Never mind. So, if I help you, Chartonus will let me keep that signet ring?”

“*Ahh*.” It seemed as if Theodoros had come to some sort of epiphany. “I was wondering how he was paying you. Chartonus comes from a land that doesn't use a currency system. I was wondering what he would possibly be giving you to come here. You said you're experienced in appraisals?”

“I… read a lot about them.” Phainon awkwardly scratched the back of his head. “But I haven't been able to apply it in practice or anything.”

“No need. Just a general knowledge is all I need.” Another heavy sigh left Theodoros’s body; he seemed to be under a lot of stress. “Too many people have been submitting antiques to appraise, and there are just too many fakes being submitted. I wanted someone who could help me sort through the antiques and even help me appraise some of them. I can walk you through it too. It's been hard trying to find someone who could help, especially in the wealthy district here.”

Phainon’s eyes widened at the actual normal request. He wasn't sure what to expect in exchange for such an expensive antique, and he had been preparing himself for the worst all day yesterday. For someone as skilled as Chartonus, he could not even fathom what the man would need Phainon’s help with, and it took everything inside of Phainon not to start jumping up and down to immediately agree with Theodoros's request.

As exciting as this sounded, it seemed like it was going to be a long endeavor. He would love to continue antique appraisals just for fun, in his free time, but he really needed that ring soon. The dinner was on Friday, and he didn't have many days left. So Phainon had to quickly jump in. “How long is this going to take? I kind of need this ring by the end of this week.”

“Just a few days. It can be even faster depending on how fast you work.” Theodoros shrugged.

That sounded like a fair deal. In fact, Phainon was going to enjoy his time here a little *too* much. His heart was pounding just thinking about it, and he had to bite himself back from cheering and throwing his hands into the air to celebrate. Who knew there was a place like this just a few minutes from his own workplace? He was going to be able to handle antiques? And even appraise them? And receive an antique to bring home at the end of all this?

With a nod and an eager smile, Phainon began rolling up his sleeves. “Tell me what you need, Theorodos.”

Chapter 27

Phainon was quite the busy man.

For the next few days, until Friday, Phainon barely talked to anyone else. During lunch, he would rush to the appraisal store and help Theodoros, and he would rush back to the office at the end of his lunch break to continue his work, only to rush back again after the work day was concluded to help sort through even more antiques.

Necklaces, bracelets, rings, furniture, paintings–everything of all kinds was brought into this shop. The first time Theodoros had taken him into the back room, Phainon’s jaw nearly dropped to the floor at how many things were littered in the back. The entire room was basically covered, and he had to wonder how Theodoros even managed to get by every day when there were so many appraisals waiting for his expert hand. He also was not even sure if Phainon and Theodoros alone could get through everything, which was why Phainon had started rushing to the store during every single opportunity to get through as much as possible.

It was easy enough picking up Theodoros’s instructions, considering that Phainon had already read about the basics so thoroughly in his spare time. Although it was a bit difficult to become accustomed to actually using all the tools and which situations to use which tools, rather than just reading about them, it didn't take very long for Phainon to become more of an expert due to the sheer amount of antiques that needed appraising in this back room. But after all of their hard work, the room was finally sorted between fake and authentic antiques, with Theodoros noting down each and every one to report to his clients later.

“If you ever want to come by again, just let me know.” Theodoros flashed him a grin. “You've been an amazing help, Phainon, and I can tell just how much you like antiques. I can see why Chartonus was fine with giving you the signet ring.”

“Is the signet ring important?”

It was Friday evening, right after Phainon's normal workday, when he stopped by the antique shop to finish the rest of the appraisals, and Theodoros was just finishing up writing down all of the antiques that they had sorted through in a giant clientele notebook.

“Chartonus found it by the river,” Theodoros explained while continuing to jot down his notes. “The one right outside the city. There's a small, humble neighborhood that lives on that street, but one house was completely cleared a long time ago. The owner wanted everything gone, so Chartonus and a few of his other workers went and cleared the entire thing to be thrown away, sold, or donated. It didn't seem like the owner cared at all about what happened with everything in that house. But Chartonus found the signet ring there, and he knew it was valuable and handed it to me.

“I could tell without any special tools just how much it was worth. It was made a long time ago and passed down through generations of families. I couldn't understand why the owner wanted everything gone, but there was no reaching out to the owner anymore. He paid them on the first day and disappeared after telling them to clear everything, so that's what they did.”

“That's… quite interesting.” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows with this story digesting in his mind. He couldn't have imagined the ring went through such an ordeal so recently. “And the owner just disappeared?”

Theodoros shrugged as he finally closed his notebook. “The owner called Chartonus, brought him to the address, and paid him a hefty sum on the spot to get rid of everything. And that was that. He never saw that guy again. All I did was verify he was really the owner of that house because suddenly trashing everything was just unusual. Moving everything is normal, but trashing every single item in that house was not. But after I confirmed it, Chartonus and his team took everything down and only saved that gold signet ring.”

Phainon fell silent. It was quite the story, and one that didn't sound very believable. It was one of those stories that sounded completely made up, and it also felt like there were holes missing in this story. But it wasn't as if Chartonus or Theodoros could confirm; they confirmed all the information they needed and completed the job they were paid to do. Phainon was only

left silently wondering where that owner had disappeared off to. Maybe they were moving out of the country and thought it easier not to take so many of his belongings with him, but Phainon still couldn't fathom why he wouldn't take the signet ring with him.

“You should go get the ring from Chartonus. Didn't you say you needed it today?” Theodoros’s voice had reminded him, and Phainon immediately jumped from his chair at the thought.

“You're right; I should go.” With a laugh and a wave, Phainon bid his farewells to the antique shop owner, who said that Phainon was welcome to drop by at any time to continue helping if he would like to, promising to compensate him anytime he did so. Phainon grinned, promising to take him up on the offer before rushing down the street toward the other antique shop where Chartonus worked.

He hurriedly fished out his phone; it was half past five, and he still had to get ready for the date before arriving at the restaurant at seven. He could… just throw on his clothes and go, right? Surely getting ready won't take very long, considering that Cyrene and Castorice had so graciously prepared a whole new outfit for him anyway.

Pushing open the doors to the antique store, there was a different store associate behind the counter now. He was in quite a hurry, so he scurried over to the counter while trying to run a hand through his hair to somewhat untangle it from practically sprinting down the street.

“Is Chartonus here?”

“Your name?”

“Phainon.”

The store associate nodded silently and disappeared into the back. It was just a few moments later that the same man emerged from the back, but this time, he brought that crimson red box with him without asking.

Phainon had actually previously asked Chartonus to make the ring bigger when he first started helping out Theodoros. Since this was supposed to be for a woman, he couldn't imagine that Mydei's fingers would actually be able to fit it, and Phainon said he could at least pay for the ring adjustment. But Chartonus shot him down, saying he already had the materials and that it would be an easy adjustment to make. Now that Phainon had discreetly found Mydei's ring size, he was able to request the exact size he needed so that Mydei could actually wear it.

Chartonus opened the box, revealing that exact ring Phainon had ingrained into his head all week. With the shank adjusted bigger to accommodate the size Phainon had asked for, he noticed that it was also even more polished than he remembered.

"You… polished it?" Phainon chuckled lightly, holding the crimson box up into the light and admiring all the details and slight scratches that were able to shine even more thoroughly.

The man staring at him from the other side of the counter nodded. "Gift, want to make special."

Phainon's hands faltered, lowering the box slightly to stare up at Chartonus. "You knew I wanted to buy this for someone else?"

"The look in your eyes. The ring, not for you. And the size, not for you. The ring, for someone you love," Chartonus simply explained. "The look in your eyes, the ring belongs to you."

It felt like Phainon's very soul trembled at his words, and he stared back down at the glistening ring and the box that weighed heavily in his hands. What did Phainon look like to other people whenever he thought about Mydei? Talked about Mydei? Listened to Mydei? Was he really that obvious that even someone he barely met could tell?

Why did these words not settle within Phainon's heart? Why did it feel like his eyes were burning, and his throat was throbbing as these words repeated in Phainon's mind? Why… did he not like the sound of Chartonus's words?

“Thank you. Truly, I cannot thank you enough, Chartonus.” Phainon’s voice was barely above a whisper. He was still admiring the ring, and he was still too afraid to take the ring out of its casing. Chartonus’s words kept echoing in his mind, and with a slight nod, he bid Chartonus a farewell, promising to visit him again. Chartonus did not respond, only nodding as usual while Phainon departed the store and rushed to buy flowers before subsequently rushing back home.

He was ready to dart into his room, throw on his clothes, and dash out. It was approaching six now, and he had spent too much time conversing with Theodoros and Chartonus. By the time Phainon arrived home, he would probably only have about half an hour to get ready before he had to speed-walk to the restaurant. Fortunately, he was not drunk this time, and the walk would actually be a little under ten minutes.

That was the plan, at least, until he unlocked his door and started getting absolutely berated in his own apartment.

“Phainon! Where have you been?!”

Cyrene had Phainon's apartment key for any emergencies, and vice versa, Phainon had Cyrene’s apartment key. But there wasn't exactly an emergency, so he couldn't imagine why Cyrene and Castorice were standing in his living room right now.

“... Huh?”

“You–” Cyrene cut herself off. She ripped the bouquet of flowers from his hand, setting them gently on the counter before shoving Phainon into his bedroom. He stumbled, barely catching himself before another forceful shove landed on his back again and again until he was in his room. “You only have half an hour! Sit down!”

Two rough hands pushed Phainon into his bed, and he caught Castorice scurrying inside and plugging some sort of hair tool into the nearest outlet.

“What… is going on?” Phainon was too dumbstruck to process what was happening in his own home, and he watched Cyrene practically ripping the

hinges off his closet door to bury herself inside and unearth the items they had bought for him a few days ago.

Cyrene huffed, finally gathering the last of the accessories she needed. “I've been calling you to ask if we could come over and help you get ready! You didn't see any of our messages at all?”

Blinking momentarily, he quickly dug into his pockets to pull out his phone. True to her word, there were multiple missed calls and texts from Cyrene, Castorice, and even… Mydei.

His heart sank, and he rapidly unlocked his phone to open his messaging application as fast as he could. Blue eyes rapidly scanned the screen, with Castorice gently gathering his hair, spraying his hair with heat protectant and brushing his bangs out of his face to begin styling it for him.

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (11:55am): *Phainon, for dinner tonight, tell them you're here to see Polemos when you arrive.*

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (3:36pm): *Phainon?*

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (5:05pm) missed call ×1

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (5:49pm) missed call ×1

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (5:50pm): *Why the hell are you not answering. I need a yes or no.*

My love (˘ ³˘)♥ (5:55pm): *If you're not going anymore, just say so instead of not answering.*

It felt as if his heart had completely frozen over as he stared at his phone screen with trembling eyes. He could barely even read Mydei's messages anymore with how much his hands were shaking. Mydei was pissed. *Mydei was pissed*. Phainon could barely bring his trembling hands to click on the contact number to call him directly.

Truthfully, Phainon hadn't been checking his phone very often these past few days. All of his free time was spent at the antique store, and all of his

time at work was spent either thinking about work or thinking about that signet ring. He had completely neglected Cyrene, Castorice, and most of all, Mydei himself, the person he was doing all of this for. Phainon truly could not believe himself, and he could only hope that this call would be picked up as he sat there on the edge of the bed, bouncing his legs and waiting for this incessant ringing to finally stop.

The ringing on the other end clicked, and Phainon had to resist the urge to jump from his seat before Castorice messed up his hair and possibly even burned herself.

“Mydei?!”

“*Why the fuck did you not answer?*”

Mydei didn't sound pissed. He was downright, absolutely, and horrendously *furious*, and Phainon was trying hard not to begin shaking in his seat.

“Mydei, I'm really–”

“Are you still going or what? I almost cancelled the reservation.”

“I'm still going!” Phainon practically shouted into the receiver. “Mydei, I'm really, really, *really* sorry. Please let me apologize and properly explain everything to you in person.”

There was silence on the other end, and Phainon was worried that Mydei had just straight hung up on him. He was almost about to take his phone from his ear to check when that beautiful, deep voice stopped him.

“*Hmph*. It better be a good reason for ignoring me almost all week.”

The call ended before Phainon could get another word in, and a deep sigh left Phainon's chest as he slumped over, watching his phone screen display Mydei's contact and the duration of the call before showing his messaging application once more. It was so quiet in his room, with Phainon wallowing in his own misery, that he had completely forgotten there were two other people standing with him at an arm's length away.

“Did something happen, Phainon?”

Cyrene's soft voice made Phainon jump, and he whipped around and began apologizing profusely to Castorice, who barely managed not to burn either of them.

He turned back around, locking eyes with pink. She had Phainon's coat raised in the air with one hand, and a steamer in her other hand.

“I… was busy… is all.”

“*Busy?*” Cyrene narrowed her eyes, watching Phainon carefully pull something from his blazer pocket.

“Is that–?!” Cyrene couldn't even finish her own words, and Castorice sharply gasped at the sight of that crimson red box in Phainon's hand.

“I made a deal… with Chartonus.” Phainon weakly laughed, snapping open that jewelry box and displaying that same signet ring they had all seen earlier this week. “The guy who brought out the ring for us to see from the back. I went back the next day. I couldn't… I couldn't stop thinking about this ring.”

“So you went back the next day and asked for it again?” Cyrene asked.

“I only went back just to look one last time.” Another deep sigh left his body. “I thought… I don't know. Maybe I would stop thinking about it if I saw it one last time, but Chartonus said he was willing to give it to me if I helped his friend.”

“And you just *accepted?*” Cyrene frowned. “Phainon, this sounds shady.”

“*I know! I know*.” Phainon shot an expression of exasperation and a pleading gaze toward his friend. “But I… couldn't stop thinking about it. He gave me an address, so I went–”

“You just went to a strange address all by yourself?!” Cyrene looked like she wanted to throw the steamer at Phainon. She probably would have if it didn't ruin Castorice’s hard work.

“It was on a main street, so I… I just thought the chances of anything bad happening were low,” Phainon hurriedly spoke all in a single breath. “It was another antique store, and Chartonus wanted me to help his friend with appraisals because he was being hired for too many.”

“So for all these last couple of days when Castorice and I couldn't find you…”

“I was at the antique shop.” Phainon's shoulders slumped. “And I… didn't really talk to Mydei either, so he thought I wasn't going tonight.”

It was Cyrene's turn to sigh exasperatedly. “Phainon, you better get on your knees when you apologize to him today.”

“I know. I will.” Phainon smiled weakly.

“And next time you do something shady, please tell someone.”

Phainon deflated, wringing his hands together in his lap while his gaze fell toward them. “I know. I'm sorry. And, I'm sorry for ignoring the both of you.”

“I understand, Phainon.” Castorice’s gentle voice sounded next to him. “You were working hard for Mydei. I don't mind that you didn't talk to us, only that I wished you had asked someone to go with you when you went to that address.”

“I should have, Castorice. I'm really sorry.”

He turned toward Cyrene, who had her hands on her hips and was staring with sharp eyes at him. In turn, he pouted as much as he could with downturned eyes and slumped shoulders, pulling off his best pleading gaze and glistening eyes as he could. “I'm really sorry, Cyrene. I'll make it up to you?”

A few moments passed before a much louder, more dramatic sigh left Cyrene's lips as she turned back to Phainon's clothes. “I'm only letting you off the hook this time because what you did was actually really romantic of

you. *But!* You *better* stay true to your word and owe us something next time.”

Phainon laughed. His chest felt lighter now as he watched Cyrene steam the rest of his clothes. “I will, Cyrene.”

The next twenty minutes flashed by. Castorice finished his hair and secured it with hair spray, and Cyrene was throwing every piece of clothing that she finished steaming one by one, snapping at Phainon to hurry it up and dress himself in each piece as they finished. Phainon didn't even have time to really think about the fact that he was basically stripping in front of his two friends, who were also women, by the way, because he was also too busy rushing to arrive at the restaurant on time.

“Phainon, you're supposed to wear it like *this!*”

With an impatient huff, Cyrene roughly tugged at the white button-up underneath his coat, which they, for some reason, left unbuttoned. Phainon could understand that it was cold outside, but did that warrant wearing *three* layers? He was wearing a dark blue coat and a white button-up thrown over a black turtleneck. He didn't know what purpose this white button-up served, but Cyrene was very adamant that it peeked out from underneath his coat. Obviously, whatever he wore underneath his coat would get covered, so he wasn't sure why Cyrene was trying so hard to make his clothes lie perfectly so that all the layers showed.

The only clothing item that they did not buy for him was his shoes, opting to use his usual black leather shoes that Phainon wore to work. Besides that, everything on his body was brand new, with the long, dark blue coat hanging off his shoulders, the white button-up shirt over a black turtleneck, and white slacks. Castorice was currently standing on her toes and trying to clasp a necklace around him, and Cyrene was securing a broach on his coat’s lapel and a thigh strap around one of his legs. He didn't exactly know what purpose that served either. It wasn't as if Phainon were carrying a weapon with him, nor was he wearing socks that high to need the belt on his leg. Since neither of them passed a mirror to him, he genuinely had no idea what his hair looked like.

“Done!” Cyrene clapped her hands together as the two stepped back to take in all their hard work, scanning Phainon up and down with keen eyes to ensure they didn't miss a single detail on his body. Phainon could only stand there and sheepishly smile, hoping that he would pass their inspection.

“Thank you,” Phainon offered while flickering his gaze between the two women. The two of them only nodded in unison before Cyrene resumed shoving him through his own apartment again.

“Okay, okay, go! We'll clean up here, okay? Have fun!” Cyrene was yelling at him in both a singsong voice but also an urgent voice, and it wasn't very long until Phainon was back outside his apartment with the bouquet of flowers in hand.

It felt as if so much had happened in half an hour, but he didn't have time to question it. Because the restaurant was a little less than a ten-minute walk, he left his car at home and dashed down the sidewalk, with his phone and the ring box in his coat pockets. He could only hope, while dodging the pedestrians around him, that he did not ruin Cyrene and Castorice's hard work on his appearance as he arrived breathless at the restaurant.

“Hello.” Phainon was trying to make himself sound like he did not just sprint down the street for almost ten minutes. “I'm here for Polemos?”

The attendant at the front desk nodded, gesturing for him to follow into the back. The restaurant was exactly how Phainon remembered it before his drunken stupor, but he had never seen this part of the restaurant as he was led to the area with their private rooms. In fact, he didn't even know there were private rooms at this establishment, but if the executive department had chosen to dine here before, then that must mean they had already probably visited much earlier and even hosted private clientele here.

He was too busy trying to catch his breath and fix the bangs in front of his face, but when the attendant knocked on the door and bid Phainon a farewell, all the nerves began to settle into his body all at once. Watching the attendant leave and hearing their footsteps echo against the polished wooden floor only emphasized that Phainon was now by himself, standing

in front of the only door that separated him from his fuming boyfriend, whom he had to beg for forgiveness from.

Phainon was fighting his own heart. He was excited to see Mydei again. He was excited to see Mydei's reaction to the ring, but it was also so hard to breathe. He would have to face Mydei's wrath inside, and what if Mydei didn't even like the ring? What if Mydei found his reasoning a poor excuse for forgetting to contact him? Then that earlier anxiety suddenly dawned on him. What if it was *still too early to gift his boyfriend a ring?* Would he just drive Mydei mad if he stepped inside? Phainon could just give Mydei the flowers and save the ring for later, right?

The ring weighed heavily in his pocket. It was so heavy it was taking everything in Phainon to continue standing in his spot in front of the door rather than crumple to his feet. Should Phainon even give that ring at all? But how was he supposed to explain himself to Mydei and beg for forgiveness without any mention of the ring? The whole reason he accidentally cut off all contact with everyone was *because* of that ring.

Oh shoot, the attendant knocked on the door, and Phainon was still standing out here and sinking deeper into despair.

Before he could overthink it, he grasped the doorknob and turned it, stepping into the room before his eyes could even register that golden head of hair and fall into another deep state of panic.

“Why were you just standing out there?” Mydei scoffed. "Too afraid to come in and face me?"

Phainon hesitantly gazed up at him, where he had his arms crossed over his chest and his back leaned against the cushioned chair. “I... I'm really sorry, Mydei.” Phainon slowly approached him, handing him the bouquet of pomegranate flowers he bought in a rush before returning home. “I bought these for you.”

Mydei warily took the flowers from his hand while Phainon began settling into his seat. He practically tore off his coat and hung it in the open closet that was in this room. He could not wrap his head around the fact that there

was even a closet in a restaurant, but his mind was too occupied with other things to even worry about that minuscule fact.

“Tell me.” Mydei set off the flowers to the side and stared at Phainon with glaring eyes once he sat down. Phainon immediately froze at the glare; he hadn't been on the receiving end of Mydei's nasty glares in a long time, and he almost forgot how much they made his heart clench and his stomach sink. “Why did you ignore me almost all week? I tell you not to visit me anymore, so you just blatantly stop talking to me?”

“That's not–” Phainon cleared his throat. He didn't want to start a fight right now. Mydei's feelings were valid; that was exactly what it looked like Phainon did to him. He was trying not to let his eyes stray away from Mydei's piercing ones that seemed to glow in the warm restaurant lighting, and Phainon swallowed thickly with his eyes trembling upon gold. “I was…”

His throat couldn't force out the words. Phainon was in a dilemma. He wanted to explain himself. He wanted Mydei to understand what Phainon was doing. He wanted Mydei to know that Phainon had done this while thinking of Mydei the entire time.

But that meant bringing up the ring.

Mydei's glare only grew at Phainon's silence, and he began shaking in his seat, desperate to try and force the words from his throat despite his brain screaming at him not to say a word. He was fighting his own self to try and explain himself to Mydei, who he could tell was betrayed and hurt by what Phainon had done to him. Mydei was so convinced that Phainon wasn't going to show up, that Phainon was just going to ghost him without saying a word, and that hurt Phainon more than anything he was feeling about himself.

“I was trying to buy you a gift.” Phainon's shoulders deflated. “It took up all of my free time, and I didn't really check my phone at all. It was completely my fault. I'm really sorry.”

A deep sigh left Mydei's chest. A few moments of silence passed between them, where Mydei seemed to be processing his explanation and deciding whether he should even let Phainon off the hook in the first place. Eventually, after what felt like an eternity, the golden eyes somewhat softened. “Well, it wasn't as if you totally ignored me. You *did* message me back on the other days, only at a much later time than your usual. It just happened to be today you didn't respond to me.”

Phainon flinched. It was true that Mydei had texted him throughout the week, and Phainon only really checked his phone and responded when he was about to go to bed. He was so exhausted from running back and forth between work and the antique store that he would respond to Mydei and then immediately pass out in bed for the next day. Phainon was sure that the behavior was unusual, considering that Phainon almost always messaged him first every other hour within a day.

“I'm sorry, Mydei.”

“Look at me.”

Phainon didn't realize that his gaze had dropped to his lap, and he slowly raised his eyes until they fell upon the sight of gold spanning before him once more.

“I'm really sorry, Mydei,” Phainon repeated. “I should've at least told you I was busy.”

Another sigh left Mydei’s lips, and he pushed himself forward, leaning over the table with lowered golden eyes that sent Phainon's heart racing. “If you want me to accept your apology, then hand over the gift. Unless, after all your efforts, you still could not get it.”

Phainon’s pounding heart, which was reveling in Mydei’s beautiful features that were illuminated in the dim, warm lighting, immediately froze. His hands immediately started sweating, and he swore the ring box was tearing a hole in his coat despite him not even wearing it anymore. “No, I… I have it.”

“Then let me see it.”

“See… it?”

“Isn't the gift for me?”

Phainon's entire body grew rigid, and he began trembling in his seat once more as his eyes wandered everywhere on the table except for Mydei himself. “I… Right. The… The gift is for you. That's right.” Phainon laughed weakly. “I'll… um… Mydei, are you sure you want to see it?”

He hesitantly stared at his lover in front of him, who narrowed his eyes. “Why wouldn't I want to see it?”

“Well, because it's kind of…” Phainon fidgeted in his seat but couldn't figure out how to explain that it was a ring without actually saying it was a ring.

“*Kind of?*”

“Kind of… um…” Phainon's eyes resumed wandering anywhere except for the blaring gold that was glowering impatiently at him. “I just… I don't know if you'll like it.”

Mydei shut his eyes and huffed, “Then let me see it, so I can tell you if I'll like it or not.”

“But… It's very…” Phainon grimaced at his own thoughts, but he shot his head up at a sudden realization, eyes widening at a new plan. “Maybe I'll buy you a different gift–”

“*Phainon*.”

Phainon slumped back into his chair with a deep exhale. “Fine. Just… if you don't like it, you can do whatever you want with it and just don't tell me, okay? I'll still buy you a new gift after this.”

“I can't imagine how this gift could possibly be bad enough to warrant that sort of explanation,” Mydei was muttering to himself as Phainon slowly

stood from his chair. His footsteps echoed in his head along with his ringing heart as he approached the closet, and shaking hands started fishing for the ring box in his coat. When his hand eventually closed over the ring box, he froze once more, which didn't go unnoticed by the other man.

“*Phainon*.”

“Okay, okay, just,” Phainon ripped the box from his coat, hurrying back into his seat and holding it out in front of him without looking at the other man, “just don't say anything. I don't want to hear what you're thinking.”

Gentle fingertips pried Phainon's open, taking the box from Phainon's hand and leaving his sweaty palms brushing against the cool restaurant air.

“Did you buy me jewelry?"

“Mydei, I really like you, but I do not want to hear your voice right now.”

A quiet laugh came from the other man, which Phainon couldn't even believe he was hearing. Here Phainon was, sweating through his two layers while trembling in his seat and trying not to combust over giving Mydei a ring, and here Mydei was finding amusement in his wallowing misery.

Phainon was trying to distract himself with everything possible, which was hard when they were in a private room all by themselves. He was wringing his fingers together in his lap, tracing the stitching on his thigh strap and watching the metal logo on the belt shine in the light. It was when he was following the wood grain of their table that he finally heard the ring box pop open from across the table.

True to Phainon's wish, which he realized now that it was happening, that he did not like this reaction at all, Mydei was completely silent.

Chapter 28

Mydei, I really like you, but I do not want to hear your voice right now.

There were two extreme dilemmas occurring in Phainon's head right now. One, that sentence he just said did not sit right with him. The longer he thought about it, the more it made Phainon feel… antsy. Like he couldn't sit still. It felt like his body was just itching to fight, as if Phainon entered fight-or-flight mode every time he thought about that sentence. It was the same when he was speaking with Chartonus earlier. The words just weren't settling with him, and the longer he thought about it, the more it made his head and his heart hurt.

And the second dilemma was that Phainon had plenty of time to think about these words because *Mydei had fallen into complete and utter silence.*

Phainon still refused to glance at his beloved and had his head bowed low, staring into his lap and filling in their silence with his own deteriorating thoughts and his pounding heartbeat. He started bouncing his leg the longer the silence grew and the longer he tossed his own words within his own head, and he almost jumped when the other man finally spoke after what felt like thirty-three million years.

“Where did you get this?”

His leg immediately stopped bouncing, and he cautiously peered at his boyfriend and was already wincing before any lashing had started. But Mydei's golden eyes were glued to the ring staring back at him with a completely unreadable expression across his face.

“An… antique store,” Phainon hesitantly murmured. Did Mydei not like that Phainon had basically given him a used and pre-owned ring? Phainon thought it suited him well, considering that they had already discussed their love for history, and Phainon really liked antiques and wanted to give Mydei a piece of that love. But, maybe it was too much, especially for a ring?

“Which antique store?”

“It's… a few minutes from work. If you don't like it, I can–”

“I didn't say I didn't like it.” Sharp golden eyes immediately bore straight into him, and Phainon wilted in his seat.

Before either of them could say anything, a knock sounded at the door, and Phainon jumped. He was saved!

A waitress came in, carrying an assortment of dishes in her hands and setting them on the table.

“Did you gentlemen need a couple more minutes to decide what you would like to order?”

Mydei nodded before Phainon could even open his mouth, and with a pleased smile, the waitress was already on her way, shutting the door behind her.

“I already ordered some appetizers while waiting for you to arrive,” Mydei explained each of the dishes the waitress had brought in, but Phainon didn't have time to listen to a word he said because he was busy scrambling for the menu. He was so worried about giving Mydei the ring that he had completely forgotten to think about what to order! And he was sitting in a whole restaurant!

“Did you order for yourself yet?” Phainon was trying not to laugh in a panic as he finally grabbed the menu and began haphazardly flipping through it.

“Not yet. I was waiting for you. So take your time.”

From Mydei's gentle voice, Phainon could tell that Mydei was not angry with him for the ring, at least. He somewhat relaxed at the thought but immediately grew tense once again the longer he flipped through the laminated pages. He had completely forgotten how expensive this place was! And if they were in a private room, did that mean this was even more expensive?!

“Um, Mydei–”

“I'm paying, so pick whatever you want.”

“But–”

"I'm the one who insisted on seeing you today despite my father, so I'll pay.”

Phainon shut his mouth and decided to order something that wasn't too expensive. Despite already choosing his meal, he still didn't really want to lower the menu in his hands because that meant having to face Mydei now that he had seen the ring. He just wanted to hide his embarrassment and shame behind this menu forever, but Mydei wasn't having any of that.

“Phainon.”

He tried not to jump at the sound of Mydei's voice. It took a long time for Phainon to open his mouth, and it felt like his jaws were creaking on their hinges as he slowly parted his lips. He wanted the silence to last forever, and he wanted to continue hiding from Mydei's presence behind this menu. He even entertained the idea of just not answering the other man to further prolong this silence, but he decided against it to not earn more of Mydei's ire. “Yes?”

“Do you know what you want?”

“... Yes.”

“Then put the menu down.”

Hesitant hands eventually lowered the menu, slowly revealing the golden gaze that was already trained upon him. Phainon tried not to jump backwards at the sight; the adrenaline was already pumping so loudly in his head just from preparing himself for his verbal outburst. Instead, he tried to focus on the appetizers laid out in front of them, but his eyes couldn't even focus on anything except for the leering gold in his peripheral vision.

“Phainon, I'm not angry at you.” Mydei's sharp glare, which seemed to look right through him, completely contradicted his words. “How did you get this ring?”

“How?” Phainon wasn't about to lower his guard just yet. His heart was still crashing against his chest and waiting for Mydei to begin demeaning him for buying him a ring. “I… helped the owner of the shop, and he gave me the ring in return.”

“The ring was just there?”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “Huh?”

“I'm asking you if this ring was just in that antique store.” Mydei's glare only grew more impatient, making Phainon flinch and rush to respond before Mydei's patience wore thin and he actually took Phainon’s head off.

“It was.” Was there something wrong with the ring that Mydei noticed? It didn't sound like Mydei was angry with a ring, but it sounded as if there was something wrong with *this* ring. “It was in the back.”

“In the back,” Mydei repeated quietly, more to himself than to Phainon. “Do you know where it came from?”

“It was from a house the owner of the shop was hired to clean,” Phainon recalled the story that Theorodos had recounted. “From… Mydei, is there something wrong with the–”

“Just tell me,” Mydei snapped.

Phainon buried away his curiosities and did as he was told. “The owner of the shop was hired to get rid of everything in this house by the… river.”

His voice faltered as he repeated the story, with the realization dawning over him as his last words faded into the air. Surely, this was just a coincidence, right? Mydei had said he used to live by the river, but did Mydei really… *recognize* this ring? He had to know about this ring if he

was reacting like this and interrogating Phainon on its origins. Now the next question was if this recognition was a good thing or a bad thing.

“A house by the river,” Mydei murmured, glancing down at the ring in his hands. “I thought…”

Mydei's eyes lowered as he stared at the ring silently, and Phainon continued to stare at him, watching how the ring shone in the light. Phainon couldn't describe the silence that had settled upon their shoulders; it wasn't comfortable by any means, with Phainon still waiting for Mydei's next words, but it wasn't an uncomfortable silence either. It was almost as if Phainon were giving Mydei a moment by himself, yet Phainon couldn't bring himself to leave the room, feeling as if Mydei would stop him if he tried to do so.

He had many questions to ask Mydei that he couldn't gain the answers to by reading his face. Mydei's expression was wistful, holding longing and an accepting sadness. Was the ring important to him? Where did he recognize it from? Who was the previous owner of the ring? He was afraid the ring might have been his father's, but considering it was a woman's ring, perhaps it was…

“Phainon.”

Phainon couldn't help but jolt at the sudden break in their silence, and he locked eyes with the golden ones that were already staring at him.

Mydei took a deep breath, with his gaze fluttering back to the ring before landing upon Phainon once more. “I… want to thank you.”

“Thank me?”

“For giving me this ring. Thank you.”

Mydei's smile was glowing. His entire face was absolutely radiant, blooming just like the pomegranate flowers that lay on the table by his side. His golden hair perfectly framed his smiling lips and his crinkled golden eyes as if capturing this moment forever, but Phainon didn't see any of that.

Eyes widening at the sight, he pushed himself from his chair, rushing around the table and pulling Mydei into his arms before any of those gathering tears spilled down his face.

“Hey, why are you crying?” Phainon whispered into golden hair. “If you don't like it, I can buy you something else.”

“I didn't say that at all.” Mydei breathlessly laughed. He lay limply in Phainon's arms, with the ring box still in one hand. “Didn't I just thank you?”

Phainon's arms only grew tighter around Mydei as the scent of freshly-baked bread washed over him and empowered any of the appetizers still sitting on the table. “I didn't want you to thank me with tears in your eyes.”

“They're happy tears, Phainon.” Mydei nuzzled his face into the crook of Phainon's neck, and Phainon's breath caught in his throat at the act, face flushing from how adorably Mydei was cuddling against him. He wished he wasn't wearing a black turtleneck so he could feel Mydei's warm breath and his parted lips pressing against his hot skin.

Phainon's shoulders somewhat relaxed. He buried his fingers into golden hair, tenderly cradling the back of his head against him. “I'm glad you like the gift, Mydei, but your tears really scared me. I thought you hated the ring that much and were smiling through the tears.”

A weak scoff sounded against his neck. “Were you really that afraid of giving me a ring? What are you going to do when you actually have to get down on one knee?”

“Well, I…” Phainon's voice died in his throat, with his face blooming a bright red instead at the thought and the implications in Mydei's words. He swore he was the same shade as the ends of Mydei's hair, and he was thankful Mydei couldn't see just how bright he had become. “That's… Well, that's… I–I was just afraid you would think the ring was too much…”

Mydei unburied his face from Phainon, wrapping his arms around Phainon's shoulders instead and pulling him close until the tips of their noses were

brushing against each other. Phainon had to bury a gasp and how radiant Mydei was, with shimmering eyes glistening with tears and a light blush splattered across his cheeks. “I love it, Phainon.”

Phainon's eyes widened once more. It felt like a ton of bricks had dropped onto his body as Mydei's words repeated in his mind. The words that Phainon hated from Chartonus, and the words that Phainon hated from himself. It all made sense now, and his heart was pounding so loudly in his ears from the truth that had dawned on him that he was unsure if Mydei was saying anything else. His entire body was swirling in a crushing anxiety that seemed to overtake his lungs, and he choked on his words, smiling through a grimace.

“I'm glad, Mydei.”

Phainon was in love with Mydei. And he wished Mydei had said he loved him instead of the ring.

A quick peck against his lips momentarily shook him from his thoughts, but Phainon couldn't react before Mydei was already pulling away to stare at the ring once again. The love that was so evident in his golden eyes, and the soft smile that danced across his lips as he stared down at that golden ring. Phainon almost wanted to curse himself for getting him the gift. Did Mydei look at Phainon the same way? Even an ounce in the same way?

He was just as beautiful as Phainon had imagined he would appear while accepting the ring, if not even more beautiful than his imagination, but it was eating Phainon's entire insides that he craved for even more from Mydei's attention on *him* rather than the ring. Phainon wanted to hear those three words from him, spoken in his lovely, deep voice. He craved so desperately to hear that Mydei was also in love with him, that he too felt like he could not live without Phainon, but he knew Mydei was smarter than him. More grounded than him. More self-assured than him. Mydei was someone who would not fall in love after a mere couple of months of dating, and it ate away at Phainon's heart the longer he thought about his own deep emotions for his boyfriend.

Sure, Phainon has called Mydei “my love” and “my lover,” but it was as if the clouds had parted and finally revealed the truth to Phainon of his deep desires and emotions for the other man. He couldn't imagine that Mydei was actually *in love* with Phainon, and Mydei had never actually called him by those names either. How many times had Phainon professed his love to Mydei only to never receive the same in return?

“This ring was my mother's ring.” Mydei's voice rang above Phainon's own rattling heartbeat. “After she passed away, my father was given ownership of her home, and he got rid of everything. Including this ring.” A shaky breath left Mydei’s lungs as those sparkling golden eyes locked onto Phainon’s once more. “I didn't think I would ever see it again. I thought it was just thrown away, but who knew it was at an antique shop the whole time. Thank you, Phainon, for bringing this back to me.”

Phainon swallowed dryly. “Of course, Mydei.” He hoped this smile looked natural. He hoped he at least sounded natural enough. “I didn't realize it was your mother's. I… just thought it would look good on you.”

“A woman's ring?” Mydei laughed quietly.

“It just… looked like it belonged on you.” With a straining smile, he pulled his arms from Mydei, settling back into his seat again across the table. “I'm just… a little relieved you didn't think I was too forward with the ring or anything. It wasn't my intention to get you a ring, but it just happened to be the one thing I found that I thought suited you best. I did get it resized for you. I… wouldn't have done that if I knew it was your mother's. I'm sorry.”

“Don't be.” Mydei shook his head. “That means I can wear it now.” He suddenly flipped the box to show it to Phainon, and Phainon actually had to stop himself from wincing at the mere sight of it. “Can you put it on for me, Phainon?”

It felt like Phainon's entire world was crashing down, but Phainon replicated the perfect boyfriend that Mydei wanted right now. Mydei had so many other things to think about; he was sure he did not have time for Phainon's overwhelming feelings either. So with a deep exhale and a small

smile, Phainon took the ring box from his hands, setting it on the table once the cool metal of the ring was pressed between his fingertips.

He silently held out his hand, and Mydei placed his dominant hand in front of him. His hand was warm against Phainon's as he slid the ring over his right ring finger, and Phainon couldn't help his own disappointment at seeing how perfectly the ring fit around him and how perfectly the ring matched Mydei himself. He almost wished there was something wrong with it; Phainon couldn't explain it himself. Was he jealous that Mydei said he loved the ring and not him? Was he mad that the ring so perfectly matched Mydei when Phainon didn't? Why was he having so much trouble accepting this ring around Mydei's finger when Phainon had labored away all his free time the last few days *because* the ring was so good for him?

“It looks really good on you,” Phainon whispered. He watched the signet ring shine under the restaurant lighting, giving it a warm and vibrant sparkle upon Mydei's finger.

Golden eyes smiled lovingly at the ring upon his finger. A soft smile adorned his face as he gently played with it, watching how it caught the light above them. It truly was exactly what Phainon had imagined, but now he didn't want to be associated with that ring anymore in Mydei's thoughts. All Phainon would be reminded of was how much more Mydei loved the ring than him. Mydei had never said that he loved Phainon, yet he could say it so easily for this ring.

“Thank you, Phainon,” Mydei murmured, finally tearing his eyes away from the ring to smile at Phainon. “I know I've already said it so many times, but you cannot believe how much it means to be reunited with my mother's ring once again. It had been passed down in her family for many generations, and I thought my mother would be the last in the family to wear it. I owe you so much, Phainon. I cannot imagine how I could pay you back for this.”

Phainon slowly shook his head. “You don't owe me anything. It's a present for… finally achieving everything you wanted to do. You've come a long way. You deserve everything in the world.”

“Everything?” Mydei quietly chuckled. “That's a bit much.”

I would give you everything. But Phainon swallowed down his words.

A knock sounded at the door, with the waitress entering their private room once more. Mydei conversed with her, explaining something about the appetizers, but their voices were completely drowned out in Phainon's head. All Phainon could think of was that signet ring. The ring that seemed to glare so obviously in Phainon's direction, shining brightly under the lighting which Phainon could not do. They burned his eyes, screeching in his head, and he gritted his teeth to stop the feeling of metal scratching against his brain–

“*Phainon!*”

His blue eyes suddenly widened, glancing between Mydei's concerned golden eyes that Phainon couldn't stand the color of anymore and the waitress who was expectantly staring at him. He scrambled for the menu he had set off to the side, pointing his finger at the menu item he wanted to order, and with a quick apology and a sheepish smile, the waitress returned the smile before exiting the room.

“Phainon, what is wrong with you?” Those golden eyes continued staring at him. Phainon couldn't stand it right now, and he tore his gaze away to stare at the menu that he had forgotten to give to the waitress before she left.

Phainon shook his head despite how hard it was to breathe. “Nothing at all. I was…” He swallowed thickly, “admiring your ring.”

“You're not even looking at it.”

“Well, I *was* until–”

“*Phainon*.” Mydei’s sharp voice made Phainon flinch in his chair. “*Look at me*.”

It was a few moments of battling his own head, of wanting to see Mydei and not wanting to see him all at the same time, but Phainon eventually

locked eyes with Mydei's golden ones and the golden ring that still seemed to glare brightly in his direction.

“What are you thinking of right now?” Mydei was frowning, trying to search whatever expression Phainon held upon his face. “I'm not letting you leave today until you tell me what happened. Didn't I tell you I love the ring?”

The grimace that flashed across Phainon's face at that one singular word didn't escape Mydei's notice, and he leaned forward, almost pushing his chest against the edge of the table.

“Phainon, I thought you wanted me to like the ring.”

“I do,” Phainon slowly muttered.

“Then why did you react like that when I said I loved it?”

“I… didn't do anything.”

“Then what are you thinking right now?” Mydei tilted his head to the side. “Tell me what you are thinking.”

If Mydei could read Phainon's thoughts, he was sure Mydei would leave him. Phainon was crazy about Mydei. Phainon was absolutely possessive over Mydei. Phainon wanted Mydei only for himself. He could barely even stand an *inanimate object* that matched Mydei better than him. Phainon owed Mydei *everything* about him. Those golden fields that Phainon wanted so desperately to forget about; they were always there every time he stared at Mydei's golden hair and golden eyes. Yet, Mydei had made him learn to love it. Phainon loved his golden hair, his golden eyes, and those golden fields that Phainon thought he hated. Was it so bad to be angry over the fact that the gold Phainon desperately chased after didn't love him back? That Mydei wasn't acting crazy for Phainon too? Phainon felt like a completely different person around Mydei, yet Mydei always seemed so in control, even around Phainon.

“I'm thinking of you,” Phainon simply replied.

“Me?”

Phainon nodded silently.

“Then why do you look so angry with me?”

Was that what Phainon looked like? “I'm not angry.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “You haven't spoken a sentence more than five words since I asked you what was wrong.”

“It'll pass.”

“So you are angry.”

“I'm not angry.”

Mydei scoffed. “So what will pass then, if not anger?”

Phainon immediately thought of his deep love for Mydei, but he stayed silent.

Hands brushed into silver hair, and Phainon jolted in his chair. Mydei was standing up, leaning over the table to bury his fingertips into the hair Castorice had spent half an hour styling. “Do you not trust me?”

It felt as if Phainon's entire heart had cracked, and he spoke before he could stop himself. “Of course I trust you.”

“Then why can't you tell me why you look so angry with me?”

“I'm not angry with you.”

“Then what is it, if not anger?” Mydei repeated. “If you're not angry with me, you can at least tell me why you look like that.”

Gentle fingertips brushed Phainon's quivering lips, which he did not even know were trembling in the first place. His gaze was downcast, and Phainon could no longer stare into the golden sun that was shining brightly

above him. How was Mydei so much more perfect than him? So much more mature and responsible than Phainon? Has Phainon even accomplished one single thing in his life, compared to Mydei?

“I really…” Phainon wanted to tell Mydei what was wrong. He really did. But every time he spoke, the words failed to come out of his trembling lips. He balled his hands into fists, pushing them against his lap to try and squeeze the words out of him despite his brain screaming at him to keep quiet forever.

Phainon was scared.

Those gentle hands swiped at the corners of his eyes. Heat trailed down his face but was quickly caught by Mydei's swift fingertips. Phainon's parted lips were wet, with the taste of salt lingering along his tongue. He couldn't bear to look at the sun that was drying his tears away. He didn't deserve this shining sun, who deserved so much more than some idiot who had already fallen in love within just a few months. He deserved more than some idiot who had already bought a ring for him within just a few months.

“This day is supposed to be about you, Mydei.” Phainon laughed weakly. He glanced up, but his entire vision was blurred. Phainon was a little thankful he could not make out the gold at all. “We're here to celebrate you, Mydei. We can talk about this another time.”

“I may have cried tears of happiness, but I know your tears are anything but that. I cannot celebrate myself when my lover is crying in front of me.” Mydei's deep voice rang clearly in the room.

“*My lover?”* Phainon's voice cracked as a dry laugh left his lips. “You've never called me that. Are you pitying me right now? You know why I'm crying, don't you?”

“I wouldn't be asking you if I knew,” Mydei immediately retorted. “Have I never called you that?”

Phainon adamantly shook his head.

“I…” Mydei's hands, which were wiping Phainon's tears away, stilled. “I'm sorry; I should've told you so much earlier. I didn’t realize that… I've only been saying it in my head this whole time. I call you that all the time in my head. In my thoughts of you. In my dreams of you. In my memories of you. Every time I think of you, you are my lover. My Deliverer, Phainon. What else would that mean to me other than *I love you, Phainon*.”

The words echoed in Phainon's head. Phainon couldn't feel a single part of his body, and nothing was in his head except for Mydei's sweet, gentle voice and the warmth of his hands that had left his face.

I love you, Phainon.

My Deliverer, Phainon.

I love you, Phainon.

My Deliverer, Phainon.

“You… love me?”

Those big, warm hands returned to his face once more, cradling his cheeks and catching those hot tears that ran down his face. His blurring vision was wiped away with gentle thumbs, and his entire sight was flooded with gold once more. As it always was.

“I love you, Phainon,” Mydei repeated earnestly. His golden eyes were staring straight into Phainon without a single bit of hesitation swirling within them. He tilted his head to the side with furrowed eyebrows. “Did you not think I did?”

“I… thought you didn't,” Phainon mumbled with a frown. “You're just so much more… mature than I am. That I was the only one who fell in love in just a couple of months. That I'm the only one who loses myself around you.” He laughed weakly, his vision blurring once again. “I didn't do anything for you. I didn't help you with anything. Of course I would fall in love with you so fast.”

Another scoff left Mydei's mouth. “You forget that I liked you way longer than you even knew me, Phainon. It was a couple of months for you, but it was *years* for me. Why wouldn't I be in love with you? Why do you think you didn't help me with anything? Why are you assuming things without asking me?”

“What could I have possibly helped you with?” Phainon's entire past was rewritten into a different golden light because of Mydei. His nightmares no longer haunted his sleep anymore. He could not possibly fathom that he did anything similar for Mydei.

“A long time ago, no one ever authentically spoke to me.” Mydei was working on cleaning Phainon's tears once more, as he always did. “Everyone spoke to me as ‘the CEO's son.’ I was nothing without my father. I didn't mean anything at the company without that damn title. All people cared about was that I had the same cursed blood running through my veins. The only person who treated me differently was you. The only person who saw past my blood and my connections and who treated me without an ulterior motive or without walking on eggshells was you.

“My Deliverer, who was the first person unrelated to the bakery to compliment my pastries. My Deliverer, who stayed by my side and supported me despite not even being able to see me. What kind of lover would stick around if they couldn't even see me? I was busy, and you understood. I'm shutting down the bakery, and you never once left me. Ever since my mother, I have been alone. No one had ever treated me apart from my father except for you. I love you, Phainon. You are dear to my heart, and I am sure it is more than you love me.”

Phainon couldn't help but return Mydei's scoff. “I doubt that.”

“Yeah? You haven't once said it to me. Haven't I said it three times already?”

“Wha–” Phainon immediately cleared his throat, straightening up in his seat, with Mydei snickering at his sudden change in attitude. “I love you, Mydei.”

Mydei hummed in amusement, raising an eyebrow. “I think I've said it more times still.”

“I love you, Mydei. I love you, Mydei. I love–”

Lips pressed against Phainon's parted ones and immediately silenced him. His blue eyes fluttered shut, relishing in the soft lips that were moving so deeply against him, and he couldn't help the low moan that rumbled his chest at the pleasure sparking from their connected lips. It felt as if Mydei were earnestly communicating everything in his heart, all of his feelings, and all of his thoughts of Phainon, and Phainon's heart fell the fullest it ever had as he returned the kiss, eager to tell Mydei just how much he meant to him too and how much Phainon loved him. How much Phainon thought of him and how much Phainon literally breathed for him. Everything was all laid out for Mydei to see, and with arms swinging around Phainon's shoulders and pulling him close, he could not believe that Mydei was accepting of every part of him and all of his overwhelming feelings.

Their lips parted, echoing in the air, with both of their faces flushed a bright red, but all Phainon could think of was how gorgeous this man in front of him was and how perfect he was. Mydei was perfect, and he was even more perfect for Phainon.

“Do you feel better now?” Mydei pecked the corner of Phainon's lips, making him turn an even deeper shade of red. “Were you pouting because you thought I didn't love you?”

“I wasn't pouting.” Phainon pouted.

Mydei laughed, pressing another kiss against Phainon. He tried to pull back and return to his seat, but Phainon immediately pulled him back into another embrace, shutting his eyes and kissing him deeply once more before he could stop himself. Phainon didn't want Mydei to leave. Not now, not later, and not anytime soon. He wanted the scent of the bakery to wash over him. He wanted the color gold to flood his vision. And he wanted nothing more than for Mydei to continue holding onto him and whispering nothing but his love for him.

His lover smiled into the kiss, returning the same passion and pressing his lips against his. Mydei wrapped his arms around him, and Phainon struggled with trying not to actually pull Mydei into his lap. Phainon was sure he would commit heinous acts in this restaurant if Mydei straddled him now.

They parted once more, much to Phainon's dismay, but it was worth it to see those golden eyes absolutely blown out, hazy, and dilated as he stared into Phainon's. He was sure his blue eyes looked exactly the same.

“I wish I could come over,” Phainon muttered solemnly. Each syllable brushed against Mydei's lips and sent tingles down Phainon's spine. It left him craving more. It left him wanting to feel more of Mydei upon his body and to fill his senses and his mind with nothing but Mydei. He would bring Mydei back to his apartment, if he could, or invite himself over to Mydei's house just to taste more of that lingering pomegranate that danced across his tongue.

“Later,” Mydei reassured quietly, pecking the corner of Phainon's lips. “In a month, when my father is gone from the company, you can come over as many times as you wish.”

“You're going to get sick of me, Mydei.” Phainon chuckled softly. “I'd be inviting myself over every single day.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “Do you think I don't want that?”

Phainon's eyes slightly widened, with a light laugh shaking his chest. “*Do* you want me to come over every day? I'm going to take these words completely seriously, Mydei. This is your last warning.”

“What am I making, a pact?” Mydei scoffed playfully. “Come over whenever you want after my father is gone. The key was placed in your hands the moment our promise was made. The moment I decided I would bake for you forever. How else will I bake for you without a kitchen? Speaking of, there was something else I wanted to give you today.”

The man returned to his seat and bent down to the other side of his chair, digging for something, but Phainon could not possibly predict what his lover was going to pull out.

“I thought we were celebrating you today, not me.” Phainon curiously watched Mydei pull out something rectangular, but he could not tell what it was since it was covered in gift wrapping paper.

“Who said we were celebrating anything?” Mydei handed him the gift, and he even pulled out a bouquet of forget-me-nots and held it over the table. “I was going to give these to you earlier, but you pissed me off for not answering me today.”

Phainon choked, quickly grabbing the items held out for him before he reminded Mydei of his previous anger. “Sorry.” He sheepishly smiled.

Mydei rolled his eyes. “I accept, but only because you returned my mother's ring. So just open your gift.”

Phainon did exactly as he was told, quickly tearing into the gift wrapping paper and having a book revealed before him. With no author's name listed on the cover, it was quite an embellished cover, with light blue foil wrapping around the main center in a circle and showcasing the cycles of the moon. With an ornate golden border and stars shining in the dark blue background, Phainon traced the title with his fingers.

“*As I've Written*,” Phainon muttered. “Where did you get such a beautiful book?”

“Open it.” Mydei had leaned forward, with an elbow resting upon the table and his chin within the palm of his hand to watch Phainon’s reaction.

Phainon slowly opened the book. It was a brand new book and one that had never been opened before, from how stiff the pages felt between his fingers. But upon opening it, his eyes widened at the sight of a familiar-looking gray chimera and a familiar-looking orange chimera.

“Vigethos… and Fig Stew?” Phainon slowly flipped through the pages with his heart pounding so rapidly that it was even shaking his hands. Quivering hands flipped through page after page as wide eyes took in each of the drawings of the two chimeras, and it wasn't until he had almost flipped through the entire first half did his eyes shoot back toward smiling golden ones. “Is there… a sequel?”

Mydei laughed quietly, shaking his head. “*As I've Written* is about Vigethos, who is struggling to defeat the final boss but is only able to do so after jumping into his past experiences and adventures and recording all of his past memories to rewrite the future with the help of his chimera friends. I wanted… to give you a book that meant a lot to you as well, since you were able to give one to me.”

Jump into the past and rewrite the future.

Phainon smiled, laughing softly at the meaning of the book and the cute little chimeras scribbling into a miniature copy of the book in Phainon's hands. “I… can't believe you got a version for me. Where did you get it from?”

“I enlisted help to write the book for me.”

“Help?”

“Weren't you asking if I asked Castorice for something?”

Phainon's mind immediately blanked. He couldn't even think of anything else, even if he tried, and his mouth could only mumble a single name. “... Castorice?”

Mydei nodded. “I knew she liked writing, so I asked her to help me write a book for you, a book about accepting one's past and looking toward the future. Castorice said she would start taking notes about you to write this story for me, and she even read *The Cycles of Vigethos* to write a sequel.”

It felt like Phainon's eyes were going to pop out of his skull. *That was what Castorice was using her notes for?!*

Wait. Phainon's entire mind was swirling. So Castorice and Mydei really *did* talk to each other? Castorice just flat-out lied to him? Did she suggest buying a ring because *she knew Mydei was going to give Phainon this book today?*

A loud laugh left Phainon's lips at the realization, shaking the book in his hands. He could not even believe Mydei and Castorice were hiding this from him this entire time. He also could not even believe how much they were scheming behind his back either.

“Mydei,” Phainon's laughter finally faded as he gently shut the book closed, “I *really* wish I could stay over your place tonight.”

Mydei's eyes widened instead, with a deep red spreading all the way down to his neck as he hissed, “*What are you talking about?!”*

Laughter erupted from Phainon once more as an unconvincing glare was shot his way. He cradled the book in his hands, feeling the cover along his fingertips. Phainon could not take his eyes off this book or off the gold foil wrapping around the cover and the silver foil of the moon shining under the light. “Thank you, Mydei. I… I must thank Castorice as well. I cannot believe you guys were doing this behind my back this entire time. How did you guys even make such an official-looking book? I thought you bought it.”

“In the time we spent apart, I picked up bookbinding. The cover, I had to learn engraving and foiling. It proved to be worth it with the reaction I received today. I was adamant about meeting today, specifically, because the book was finally done.” The smile across Mydei’s lips almost made Phainon jump the man from across the table, but he buried it away with a deep, shaky breath that rattled his chest along with his palpitating heartbeat.

“It's beautiful, Mydei.” Phainon could not bring himself to put the book down. “I… I still can't believe it. Where did you even find the time?” He stared deeply and resolutely into Mydei's eyes, grasping the book tightly within his hands. “This is going to become a family heirloom.”

“Stop exaggerating.”

“I am not exaggerating at all.”

Mydei laughed once more, filling Phainon's ears with the most beautiful music he had ever been blessed to hear. “Even though it cannot beat my mother's long-lost ring, I am glad you enjoy your gift too.”

“This is the best gift I have ever received in my entire life, Mydei, and I will treasure it until the day I die.”

“Again, stop exaggerating.”

“I am not exaggerating at all.”

Another laugh left Mydei's chest as he pushed one of the appetizers over to Phainon. “Eat. We have been delaying this for too long.”

With a grin, Phainon happily dove into the food. It was at the same time he was tasting a bite of everything that their waitress returned with their dishes, and with both of the men thanking her, she nodded with a smile and swiftly departed.

“I wanted to ask you something today, Phainon.” Mydei had just begun cutting into a steak on his plate while Phainon was already burying himself in the appetizers, but he glanced up at him with a quizzical expression. Mydei smiled in amusement at Phainon's stuffed mouth, and he grabbed his napkin to swipe it along the corners of Phainon's mouth. “The bakery's last day is this Sunday. I wanted to ask if… if you wanted to open it with me that day.” Mydei's voice had dropped to a murmur as he continued to speak, withdrawing his hand and setting the napkin back down against the table. “I understand it is quite early, and I know you were tired last time. But–”

“I'll go.” Phainon had swallowed all of the food in his mouth already to clearly respond to Mydei's request. “Of course I'll go with you. You don't even have to ask.”

Mydei's shoulders dropped in relief as a small smile grew on his face. “Thank you, Phainon.”

“That isn't something you need to thank me for.” Phainon filled more of his plate with the salad Mydei had ordered previously. “I would go wherever you ask me to go.” He paused, suddenly remembering they weren't supposed to be seeing each other. “Is your father going to know?”

“He still doesn't know the bakery exists, and even if he learned now, it's closing down anyway. So it's not like he can do anything to the bakery,” Mydei explained. “He will probably think you are just another one of the bakery staff.”

“Does he… know we're here right now?” Phainon resisted the urge to glance around. The private room did not have any windows.

“I'm having Krateros distract him tonight.” Mydei chuckled to himself at the thought. “I definitely owe him one.”

The thought of the bakery closing and then, subsequently, Krateros, made Phainon's eyes widen like saucers. The utensils in his hands almost clattered to the floor at the sudden thought that dawned on him.

Phainon hasn't been thinking of a name for the new bakery!

He was so worried over finding a gift for Mydei and worrying over whether he would even *like* said gift that he hadn't been thinking of the new bakery at all! And Phainon *still* didn't know what to name it after all this time!

“Phainon?”

Phainon immediately snapped out of his whirlwind of thoughts and started shoving his mouth full of salad at lightning speed before he could let the secret slip.

“Yes?” Phainon's sentence was muffled behind greens, and he did his best to pull his most innocent eyes that blinked prettily in Mydei's direction.

“Nothing.” Mydei started cutting into his steak once more. “You just seemed out of it for a second.”

After mentally cheering in his head, Phainon and Mydei enjoyed the rest of their dinner together and the rest of their time for the night together. It took a long time for them to part even after they had finished all the food, and with an abundance of kisses, Phainon finally had to bid his farewells to Mydei until Sunday.

“I’ll go first.” Mydei pressed one last kiss against Phainon before, regrettably, untangling his arms from Phainon. They were standing in front of the exit of the private room after eating and were swapping kisses with each other instead of leaving. “If my father sent anyone to tail me, they would follow me first. Wait about ten or so minutes before you can go home. I'm sorry I cannot take you home myself.”

“Take me home?” Phainon pecked the corner of Mydei's mouth, whispering against his cheek and tightening his hold around Mydei's waist. “If anything, I would be going home *with* you.”

Mydei coughed, with an adorable blush blooming across his face as he shoved against Phainon's shoulders. “I'll see you Sunday.”

“I'll see you Sunday.” Phainon flashed him a smile before finally pulling his arms away, and he watched Mydei grasp the doorknob with the signet ring shining in the light from his ring finger.

But before he stepped through the exit, Mydei threw a glance over his shoulder to stare straight at Phainon. “Phainon.”

“Yes?” Phainon raised an eyebrow, his gaze flickering around the room and Mydei to see if he had somehow forgotten something.

Mydei smirked. “I love you, Phainon.”

He disappeared before Phainon could say it back, leaving him in a completely baffled and blushing daze. It was a few minutes of utter silence,

with his mind finally beginning to recover from Mydei's sneak attack, that he whipped out his phone to furiously type along the screen.

Phainon (8:12pm): *I love you too, Mydei.*

Chapter 29

Krateros (7:33pm): *???*

Phainon (7:34pm): *Is that not a good name?*

Krateros (8:12pm): *If you think that's best, then suit yourself. I'll put it down.*

It was bright and early Sunday morning as Phainon sat in his car with last night's messages reflecting in his eyes. He had just arrived at the bakery, but he couldn't stop thinking about the name Phainon had wracked his brain over for many painstaking weeks. Especially from Krateros's reaction, it just made Phainon overthink the name.

Was it bad? Did it sound weird? Phainon didn't know the first thing about naming a store; surely Krateros could cut him some slack. Phainon almost replied back to Krateros to tell him to give him a bit more time for the name, but he threw his phone onto his nightstand and went to sleep instead. If Phainon was going to keep taking back the name and changing it, this new bakery was going to go nowhere.

Yet here Phainon was again, overthinking the bakery name, so he shoved his phone back into his pocket and pushed the car door open before he could toss the name around in his head anymore. Today, it was the last day of Mydei's mother's bakery. Tomorrow, it would be the beginning of Mydei's own bakery. A bakery all to himself. A bakery that Mydei's mother could visit.

The front door was already unlocked as Phainon slipped into the quaint little shop. As usual, the lights were all dark outside in the main area, with only a sliver of light peeking through from the kitchen in the back through those heavy curtains. Pushing them to the side, Phainon was not greeted with the same sight he had seen before upon visiting the bakery this early.

There were no ingredients littered around. No cooking utensils, bowls, or trays, nothing was out. The entire kitchen was cleared, as if no one was ever cooking in here at all, and even the ovens weren't switched on. Only Mydei stood there, behind the kitchen island, with his head bowed low and the light pink apron tied around his torso. Phainon wasn't sure if it was because he arrived at two in the morning rather than three as he did before, but it was still unusual to see the ever-bustling Mydei completely still.

“Mydei?”

The other man behind the island flinched, shooting his glowing golden gaze at Phainon, and his shoulders instantly relaxed. “It's you.”

Phainon smiled with a light chuckle, approaching his lover around the counter. “It's just me. I'm here, Mydei.”

A brief silence settled between them, with Mydei's gaze lowering to the wooden counter once more. Phainon had reached his side, brushing gentle fingertips through his golden bangs and playing with the neat braid that cascaded down one side of his face. His lowered eyes traced his lover's long eyelashes, the bridge of his nose, and the philtrum leading toward his downturned lips, and Phainon had to resist the urge to swipe his thumb along his lips as if trying to wipe away his frown.

“It's your last day,” Phainon murmured. He was thumbing the golden cuff that hung along the end of his braid. “You should be looking around rather than at the counter. Take in the sights of your childhood kitchen, so look up at me, okay?”

A familiar scoff echoed in the kitchen, and Phainon slightly relaxed at the sound. With his lover now staring straight into Phainon, a hint of amusement swirled within those golden pools. “Says the one who refused to look at me just the other day.”

“I don't know what you're talking about.” A teasing smile danced across Phainon’s lips. “Today is about you, Mydeimos.”

It was as if hearing his full name awoke something within Mydei. After a brief *hmph* from the other man, he sprang into action. Ingredients began flying onto the counter. Cooking pans and bowls were unearthed from the abundance of cabinets lining the walls, and it was just a few moments later that the counters were all filled to the brim with everything that Mydei needed for the day. Phainon smiled at how quickly everything was prepared, and he couldn't stop the swell of pride growing within his chest at watching his lover navigate the kitchen with ease.

“Did you need my help with anything?” Phainon offered, tilting his head to the side and watching the other man preheating all the ovens.

“What do you want me to make, Phainon?”

He paused with slightly widened eyes. His blue eyes never left the radiantly glowing man as Mydei settled in front of the island once more. “Me?”

Mydei was rolling up his sleeves and unfurling a bag of flour. “Who else is named ‘Phainon’ in this kitchen?”

“Well, I'm just… You're asking *me* what to make for the day?”

“It's the last day. I want you to pick.” His voice was gentle as he stared into the bag of flour, but soon, those glowing golden eyes landed upon Phainon once more. An unreadable emotion spiraled within them, and Phainon had to resist the urge to pull his lover into his arms.

“I… will be honest that I don't know much about running a bakery. Does it matter what is served for the day?”

“Not at all. If you cannot think of everything for the bakery, I can take any requests you may have.”

“Then…” There were really only a handful of options Phainon definitely wanted to include for this bakery's final day, and with a light chuckle from the other man, he went straight to work on the requested pastries.

Although he was unsure which pastry Mydei was starting with first, it was still a joy watching Mydei fly into his work. He was swiftly moving through the kitchen and gathering milk, flour, eggs, yeast, salt, and sugar into a metal bowl that he had taken from a standing mixer. Mydei was pouring ingredients into the bowl without measuring at all–a true testament to how many times he worked in this very same kitchen and working with these very same pastries. He grabbed a stick of butter to set upon the counter, grabbing a knife and raising it into the air, but it was here that Mydei faltered. The knife stood still in his hands, with its blade pressed against the stick of butter, but it never sliced down.

Phainon waited for a couple of moments to see if something had happened, if Mydei was thinking, or if he decided he no longer needed butter anymore, but there was still no movement from the other man even after a solid minute had passed with him frozen in this position. With eyes constantly flickering between golden hair and the stick of butter, he hesitantly opened his mouth to call for him, but a deep voice interrupted him instead.

“Can you help me cut this?”

Slightly surprised at the request, but with no time to think about it, Phainon rushed over to his side, where he stood with all the ingredients surrounding him. It wasn't until he was standing by his lover once more did he see that the knife in his hand was trembling. Eyes lowering upon the quivering hand without a word, Phainon wrapped his hand around Mydei's, slowly pressing down and sinking the blade into the butter before hearing a dull *thump* of it hitting the counter.

“This isn't the last time, my love.” Phainon pressed a kiss upon Mydei's bowed head. “Didn't you promise to bake for me at home? I still have the key you gave me to your place.”

A deep breath shook Mydei's body. His hand never left the handle of the knife, where Phainon's hand was still wrapped around him. “I would rather bake in your kitchen than in mine.”

“Then, I'll give you my key,” Phainon whispered. “A promise is made between two people, after all. The key was placed in my hands, and it will

also be placed in yours.”

Glistening golden eyes finally met Phainon, and his heart was completely shattered at the sight. The corners of his eyes shimmered with tears. They were the eyes of someone carrying a destiny upon their shoulders that was impossible to stray from. Those healing and comforting golden pools that Phainon loved to submerge himself deep within had finally cracked, with streams flooding over their edges. Phainon raised his free hand to catch as much of that overflowing water as he could.

How Phainon wished he could bear the weight of Mydei's world upon his own shoulders instead. How he wished he could free Mydei from the burdens of his own blood family. It was a life that was set in stone, completely unmoving by the changes of fate, and Mydei would barrel through every obstacle that lay before him, whether he wanted to or not. As much as Phainon wanted to take Mydei's wishes as his own, he knew his lover would not stand for it, so Phainon would try his utmost to support Mydei as long as his key was in his hands.

“Why don't we just move in together?” Mydei muttered while blinking the tears from his eyes, and Phainon immediately grew rigid, with his free hand freezing upon Mydei's cheek from where he was wiping his tears away. Phainon was sure he had gotten so lost within Mydei's glistening golden eyes that he had hallucinated a dream while awake.

“... What did you say?”

“Didn't you say you were going to invite yourself over every day? Why not just move in and make things easier?”

“I…” Phainon was about to jump his own lover in his own kitchen again, but reality quickly shackled itself to him. He resumed swiping the tears that had trailed down Mydei’s face and trying to stare anywhere except the golden pools that were shining against him. “I can't afford however much it costs to live in your penthouse.”

“Did you think I would charge you?”

“I can't possibly move in with you without contributing anything.”

“Then, I'll move in with you.”

Phainon's heart was beating a mile a minute just at the mere thought of it, and he was positive his lover could hear it too. His brain was trying to overcome his own growing feelings, but it was hard to think over his own pounding chest that seemed to drown out the rest of the logic in Phainon's brain. Was it too early to move in together? But if Mydei was suggesting it, surely he wanted this too? Then, what would happen to his old house? There was no way he wanted to give up such a luxurious penthouse, right?

“Don't you want to keep living in that penthouse?”

“Why would I want to live in something my father gave me?” Mydei scowled just thinking about it. “I only stayed, as it was easier to monitor my father in a place where he was also monitoring me, but now that I no longer need to do so, I was already thinking of leaving. But if you don't want to live together, perhaps I can look elsewhere for–”

Strong arms swung around Mydei before he could even finish his statement, and Phainon buried his grinning face into the crook of Mydei's neck. That wonderfully familiar scent of freshly-baked bread filled Phainon's senses, and it made him all the more excited to know he could smell this every single day within his own home soon. Just the thought of it sent adrenaline rushing through his body in mere excitement and anticipation as he spoke with as much of a level voice as he could: “Don't finish that thought, Mydei. I will look for a new place for us to live in this month.”

A deep laugh vibrated against Phainon's chest, and it was just a few moments later that a hand began rustling through his silver strands. “I don't want a place so big anymore. I'll leave it to you.”

They stayed there just like that, tangled within each other's arms, and hearts beating so erratically that they knocked against each other's chests. Phainon could not also believe that Mydei was feeling just as excited as he was at the thought of moving in together, and he almost talked himself into believing the heartbeat pounding against his chest was just his own. But

with the way Mydei stood still, tightly embraced by Phainon's arms, he knew at this moment that Mydei was feeling the exact same as he was, and Phainon's heart felt so full that he didn't know what to do with himself and his elated feelings that felt like he was floating. He nuzzled his face against Mydei's skin, planting loving kisses along his neck, and his voice was muffled against soft skin as he parted his lips.

“Mydei.”

“What?”

“When we have a new kitchen in our new home, you should make croissants for me.”

Mydei scoffed. “You want croissants? Nothing else?”

Phainon laughed lightly, with the lights of the bakery shimmering within his crinkling eyes. “I can ask for more?”

“You can ask me of anything. Anything that you want and anything that you wish for.”

Phainon hummed, his voice vibrating against Mydei's skin as he smiled nostalgically at another thought. “There's a dessert my mother used to make me when I was young. Honey suncakes. But, I don't know how to make them.”

“I'll figure out how to make them for you,” Mydei answered without hesitation, and it made Phainon's eyes sparkle with the slightest hint of moisture as he squeezed Mydei even further within his arms. He couldn't wait to try those desserts again. Phainon hadn't had them since his hometown was burned away, and he knew the man held within his arms wouldn't give up until the recipe was just perfect. Phainon desired so strongly to share a taste of his little village with his lover.

“Can I ask for something else?”

Mydei's deep voice rumbled against his chest. “Anything at all.”

“Then, is the pastry chef on the menu too?”

A harsh shove made Phainon stumble backwards, and he laughed loudly at the flaring blush across his lover's cheeks before they were quickly hidden behind golden bangs. Mydei shoved the piece of butter that they had sliced together into the mixing bowl, and Phainon could no longer hear anything else above the whirring sounds of the standing mixer.

The fresh dough that was just made was stored in the refrigerator, where Mydei began working on more of Phainon's requests. Phainon would help Mydei fetch ingredients and prepare the proper amounts for him, and the actual creation of the food was left in Mydei's hands.

The entire time, Phainon's eyes never strayed from Mydei. He watched his lover swiftly moving through the kitchen as he attended to multiple different recipes all at once. His eyebrows were always knit together in concentration, with a slight frown etched upon his lips, but it was almost unsettling how Mydei seemed *too* okay. As if nothing about this bakery ever affected him at all. As if this were just any other day working in the bakery.

Whenever Phainon had the time, he would linger by Mydei’s side, resisting the urge to tangle his fingertips within golden hair. He would've already if his hands weren't covered in flour and butter, but Phainon couldn't stop the worry from leaking into his expression every time he stared at the other man. After a few hours had flown by of Phainon fidgeting back and forth, monitoring Mydei's unwavering expression and wondering if he should even say anything when it seemed like his lover was concentrating on the pastries, Phainon slowly and finally opened his mouth.

“Mydei, how are you feeling?”

The hands that were melting chocolate paused. Despite his halted movements, Mydei's gaze never left the bowl of chocolate that sat on top of a heated pot of water.

“Fine.” The brusque answer cut through the still air, and both men knew the truth behind his simple word.

“Mydei–”

“This was my choice and my choice alone.” The hand gripping the spatula began to stir the chocolate in the bowl once more. “I cannot falter now.”

“But you can at least let yourself feel over those choices, right?” Phainon was hesitantly approaching him as if approaching a slumbering lion. As if moving too noticeably would earn Mydei’s ire. “Just because you made the choice yourself does not mean you need to act so emotionlessly.”

Phainon was trying to peer into Mydei's golden eyes, but his head was bowed too low, with his long bangs covering his face, so that Phainon could not see what he wished for. He tried to raise a hand to swipe his heavy curtains away but was quickly swatted away.

“Your hands are covered in flour.”

“Then, if I wash my hands, will you look at me?”

A silence settled between them, and Phainon smiled softly at the other man. He was still tilting his head to the side, trying to catch any slight movement of those golden pools he loved so much. He wanted to go wash his hands to tenderly cradle Mydei's lowered face, but he was also struggling to leave his lover's side. Phainon didn't want to leave–not for a single moment.

“Mydei,” Phainon murmured, facing a golden curtain that cascaded over golden pools, "I love you so much.”

“... Where is this coming from?”

“Can't I say it whenever I want?” Phainon pressed his lips upon his temple, leaning over and switching the stove off. He peeled the spatula from Mydei's hands, which were frozen within the bowl of melting chocolate, ensuring that none of the chocolate dripped from the spatula and onto the stove. “The chocolate seems done.”

“*Hmph*, you don't have to tell me.”

“Then, will you look at me now?” Phainon smiled against the golden curtains. “There's no need to look at the stove anymore, right? Unless you think the chocolate is sweeter than I am.”

An unamused scoff left Mydei's lips, and a sharp glare that didn't affect Phainon at all pierced through him. With his smile only softening at the gold that filled his line of sight, Phainon swung an arm around Mydei's shoulders, pulling him close and causing him to stumble against him.

“I love you, Mydei,” Phainon whispered against his parted lips. He stared deeply into his golden eyes, where the glare that had previously consumed them slowly gave way to glistening gold once more.

“You don't have to say it so much; I get it.” Despite his nonchalant, unwavering tone, his expression said otherwise, and it only spurred Phainon more as he leaned forward to press a kiss against his lips.

“I love you a thousand times more.” He pushed his lips against Mydei's once more, trailing kisses wherever he could reach and pushing golden bangs away with the tip of his nose. He planted kisses along his chin, the corner of his mouth, his nose, and his cheeks. “Won't you say it back to me?”

A small smile grew upon Mydei's lips, but it seemed to make his entire face light up like the sun rising over the horizon. He stared at Phainon with an expression of relief, as if being reunited with something he had lost long ago, and Phainon loved it. He was *in* love with it. He wanted Mydei to look at him with this expression of passion and wonder and relief and love forever and ever, for the rest of their lives. Phainon would do anything to ensure this expression would stay on Mydei's face forever.

“I love you, Phainon.” A low laugh left those beautifully upturned lips. “I thought *my* bakery was closing. So why are *you* the one crying now?”

“I don't know what you're talking about.” Phainon swiped at the moisture gathering at the corners of his eyes, and with another chuckle, Mydei brushed Phainon's hands aside to swipe at his eyes instead.

“Can you put this in the refrigerator for me?” Mydei withdrew his hands and had turned back to the cooling chocolate still sitting on the stove, and Phainon quickly grabbed some kitchen gloves to store it away.

Mydei moved through the kitchen much more slowly than usual after their conversation. Phainon didn't mind at all, and he jumped in to help whenever he could. Phainon thought it best for Mydei to savor the last of this bakery, and it killed him inside that he could not reveal the truth to Mydei–that this would not be the last time he stood in this spot baking for others. It was hard to see how much Mydei was shedding tears today, when he was usually so good at masking his emotions, and Phainon almost whipped out his phone just to call Krateros and ask if he could reveal the truth.

Was Mydei just good at controlling his emotions, or was he confiding more in Phainon now? Phainon would like to hope Mydei was trusting him more, especially since Mydei was relying on him to help prepare the bakery on its final day. Mydei wouldn't ask Phainon to join him on the bakery's final day if he didn't trust him, after all.

The sun was beginning to rise outside, shining rays of sunlight through the windows of the bakery and illuminating the world around them. It was a soft, comforting, and warm glow in the bakery. Mydei worked as diligently as he could, finishing the final touches on the pastries and desserts. It was silent between them, with only the sounds of the oven sounding off every now and then, and the sounds of kitchen utensils being dragged across the counter with every pastry being adorned in its final decorations. Every sound was heightened amongst the silence that surrounded them, and that included the drops that began running down his lover's face.

Phainon's eyes widened at the sight of the tears that began sparkling in the sunlight, and with the preparation for all the pastries finally completed, he rushed to wash his hands before cementing himself by Mydei's side to catch all of his spilling tears. Mydei continued to say nothing, only working through his blurring vision to finish the last of the pastries. His hands never faltered again, yet the tears only fell faster as time progressed.

Every tear seemed to emit its own sound that echoed in the bakery kitchen. Every tear resounded loudly in Phainon's crippling heart. The guilt gnawed

at him from the inside with every rivulet that ran down Mydei’s cheek and every drop that Phainon caught within his hands. The silence was too loud, reverberating each and every tear being shed, and they only continued to grow as time passed by and as the sun rose higher in the sky. The clock was approaching seven in the morning, and the cashier was already setting up in the main area of the bakery, but all Phainon could think of was how Mydei was trusting in him now and how Phainon was purposefully hiding the truth from him.

Every passing minute and every running teardrop made Phainon inch closer to insanity. Phainon was swallowing down his own tears and his own guilt just watching Mydei silently prepare the bakery for the past few hours and silently shedding tears all by himself. The sunlight would glow against Mydei’s golden bangs and reflect upon the tears that fell into the palms of Phainon's hands, and every splash against his skin only made Phainon fall deeper into his own despair. And as Mydei finished the last pastry, he could not pull his hands away, with golden eyes glued to the fresh tray of butter croissants that lay across the counter.

Phainon's heart was completely shattered into pieces as he stared wordlessly at Mydei, who was gazing longingly at the counter filled with the croissants Phainon had requested. It felt like his entire chest was being squeezed, and his limbs could barely move to pull the silent Mydei into a tight embrace. Phainon peeled those trembling hands away from the tray and buried his glowing golden head of hair into the crook of his neck, and it further made Phainon's own body tremble at feeling the crook of his neck become filled with tears.

Phainon wanted to tell him.

“Mydei, this won't be the last time,” Phainon whispered into the shimmering hair illuminated by the morning sun. It was seven in the morning now, and it was the end of Mydei's shift. Mydei's final day in the bakery was over.

They may end up staying the rest of the day just to relish in its final moments, which Phainon did not mind at all. In fact, he would love to stay here, spending the rest of his Sunday with Mydei in this place which held a

very special place in his lover's heart. But Mydei was motionless in his arms, neither moving to hold onto him or responding back. He simply lay within Phainon's arms, with tears continuing to spill from his golden eyes.

“Mydei, won't you look at me?” Phainon's own vision was blurring as he ran tender fingers through the radiant golden hair that flooded his vision. It was a beautiful day outside, with the outside city basking in the Sunday morning sunlight, yet Phainon could not feel the warmth in his chest at all.

Phainon gritted his teeth, tightening the hold around the limp body that continued its silence. It only made Phainon want to fill in that silence with something, *anything*, but all he could think about was how hard it was to breathe and how much the new name continued swirling in his mind. How much Phainon wanted to reassure Mydei and grant him every wish he could ever want. Holding Mydei within his arms in complete silence was killing Phainon and stabbing through him with every breath, over and over again. Silence had never been so overbearing and overpowering of his entire body before, and Phainon craved so desperately to be rid of this uneasy silence that was shaking his very brain.

“You're getting a new bakery.”

Phainon had blurted the words before he could stop himself. Before he could stop the first tear that traced down his face and dripped from his chin. If Phainon felt like this merely from the bakery closing, he could not even begin to imagine how Mydei felt in Phainon's arms, and even after finally revealing the truth, Mydei still stayed silent.

“... Mydei?”

“I do not find comfort in lies.”

Mydei's empty voice vibrated against Phainon's neck, and it only made Phainon's entire world crash to the floor. He couldn't take back his own words, but Mydei's still voice only made Phainon want to convince Mydei even further.

“It's not a lie.”

“I already met the new buyer of this property. Unless you happened to find another empty store looking for a bakery in the city.”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. He met the new buyer? Mydei would've definitely figured out it was Krateros; did that mean he sent a proxy to show his face to Mydei?

“That was…” Phainon's voice died in his throat as Mydei gently pushed himself away. His golden gaze had returned to normal. No emotion seemed to reflect within them despite how much the remnants of his tears shimmered in the morning sun, and Phainon winced at the sight of Mydei’s moistened and downturned lips that were all evidence of Mydei's true inner feelings.

“We should go,” Mydei muttered, glancing at the last batch of pastries that needed to be placed onto the main floor. “I'm not needed in this building any longer.”

“Surely you could still stay for the day?” Phainon scrambled to tug on Mydei's sleeve before he could step away. “What's the harm in staying?”

“The fact that it'll be suspicious for the tail pinned on me to see you linger here for much longer than a normal shift.”

Phainon flinched at the reminder. It was probably already suspicious to see only their cars in the parking lot the entire morning; if anything, the tail probably already figured out the car belonged to Phainon and was waiting to see if he had any connection to the golden-haired heir that overstepped a simple coworker and boss relationship. But he tugged on Mydei's sleeve once more, making the other man lock eyes with him.

“If we stayed,” Phainon pulled Mydei closer to him, taking the tray of croissants from his hands, “would that ruin your plans of being CEO?”

Mydei’s eyes flickered over Phainon's expression, seeming to contemplate the idea himself, and with a deep exhale, Mydei's tense shoulders relaxed. “They would find you suspicious.”

“I don't mind.”

“They'll know you work at Kremnos Corporation.”

“I don't mind.”

“I don't want you to get wrapped up in this mess.”

“I already have.” Phainon stepped forward, setting the tray onto the counter and staring deeply into the color gold. “When my hometown was destroyed, I was already involved. And I don't mind being involved further, if that means you get to have a single day of solace. Please, let us stay for the rest of the day. It's your last day.”

Mydei shut his eyes, clenching his jaw. Phainon couldn't tell if he was holding himself back or burying an outburst, but it wasn't long until that golden gaze was focused on him once again with an incriminating glare framed by tears.

“What did you mean by ‘I am getting a new bakery’?”

Phainon's eyes widened. That was not what he expected to be asked. “It… means exactly what it means.”

“Tell me in layman's terms what exactly that means." Mydei's voice was strong and commanding, and his unwavering tone immediately made Phainon spill the truth.

“The COO bought this building when you put it for sale.”

Mydei’s glare slowly morphed into a stare of absolute confusion. The gears were turning in Mydei's head. Phainon could physically see them turn. That golden gaze was still trained on Phainon as if trying to detect a lie in his words, with his eyes shifting back and forth along Phainon's unchanging expression. It was a few minutes of emptiness that Mydei finally opened his mouth with an expression of utter bafflement.

“Krateros?”

Phainon could not tell from Mydei's voice if he was furious or not with the COO's actions, and Phainon could only bring himself to weakly nod.

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “When?”

Phainon's lips moved before he could even think. “He told me that day at work when he wanted to meet with me and kicked you out.”

Mydei immediately clicked his tongue and tore his eyes away from Phainon as if actually cursing out Krateros standing beside them. “So that was his true motive.” Glaring golden eyes landed upon Phainon once more, making his entire body grow rigid. “I should've known he would have no interest in meeting you.”

“I'm sorry I didn't tell you.” Phainon was anxiously wringing his hands together in front of him under the piercing stare from his lover. “He… told me to keep it a secret. He didn't want you to get distracted during this important time, but I know I should've just told you right away. I'm really sorry.”

“Don't be.” Mydei shook his head and reached over to grasp Phainon's trembling hands. “If he really wanted to keep it a secret from me, he wouldn't have told you in the first place.”

“Really?” There was a slight hopeful emotion swirling in Phainon's shimmering eyes, making Mydei laugh quietly.

“Didn't we establish in that conversation that we tell each other everything?” Mydei murmured with a smile, brushing a finger through Phainon's silver bangs.

“So he *knew* I would tell you?” Phainon's shoulders dropped.

“I'm sure he wanted it to be kept a secret but wouldn't be surprised if I found out.” A hand cradled Phainon's cheek, with a thumb rubbing small circles into his skin. “Thank you, Phainon.”

As much as Phainon loved being praised by his lover, the truth fully weighed upon his heavy heart as he responded to Mydei's heartfelt words: “I didn't do anything.” Phainon smiled sadly. “I couldn't save the bakery. I couldn't do anything for it. All I could do was rely on the COO to save it himself.”

“All I needed was for you to be here,” Mydei whispered, tilting his head to the side and staring into the lowered eyes hiding behind silver bangs. “You knew this wasn't the bakery's last day, yet you still came. You woke up to come here at two in the morning, helping me throughout the entire day. You never failed to ask me about the bakery whenever we met, and you wanted to come here. For me. For the bakery. Whether or not this bakery was going to close, you still came despite that. And I cannot thank you enough for being here with me. Krateros can throw all the money that he wants at this building, but you're the one who's standing here with me, Phainon. And that's what matters to me.”

Phainon was tugged forward with the feeling of his lover's soft lips pressing gently against him following soon after, and his blurring eyes overflowing with tears fluttered closed at the warm, pleasurable sensation that embraced his entire body. It was a salty kiss riddled with remnants of farewells, and a kiss that spoke of promises for a new future.

“I love you, Phainon.” Gentle words brushed against Phainon's parted lips. Air rushed into his lungs as he opened his eyes, meeting the glorious golden rays staring back at him.

“I love you too, Mydei.” Phainon pecked another kiss against his alluring lips, bringing a smile to both of their faces.

“I can't believe…” Mydei's voice trailed off as he stared at the stove adjacent to them. “I was told this building was going to be demolished. Or was that a lie too?”

Phainon chuckled, following Mydei's eyes to stare at the stove. “He wants to rebuild a new bakery. For you. A bakery all to yourself that started with you, so that, many years from now, when you are ready to leave the company, a new bakery will be waiting for you.”

Wide eyes fell upon Phainon, with Mydei slowly opening his mouth to utter the words, “He actually remembered.”

“Did you not think he would?” Phainon lightly laughed.

Mydei scoffed. “I told him, a long time ago, that the company would end with me. We argued for a long time about it, but I didn't think he would end up acquiescing.”

“You thought he would say ‘no’ to you?” Phainon tilted his head to the side with an amused smile.

“I thought he would refuse my words, pretending as if the conversations had never happened.” A wry smile grew upon Mydei's lips. “That is… typically Krateros’s way of conversing.”

“You guys seem close.”

“How did you get that from what I just said?”

Another laugh left Phainon's lips as he stepped away, quickly returning with two stools in his hands and setting them near the island.

“So, are we going to stay here all day or what?”

A glowing, ethereal smile adorned Mydei's lips. His eyes were like the rising sun that was hiding behind the morning horizon, with his eyes crinkling upwards into the shape of sparkling crescent moons. They settled at the island together, picking at the fresh croissants still sitting in front of them and reminiscing about the bakery's final moments together.

Stories of Mydei's first moments in this bakery with his mother, stories of Mydei's first day working as the new owner–so many memories were recounted between the two of them. Intimate recollections stirred into the air, filling the kitchen with stories that left their traces upon the wooden counters and tile floors. It was almost as if Phainon could physically see a younger Mydei navigating through his new bakery, and he smiled to himself while listening to the humble beginnings of Mydeimos the baker.

The taste of those butter croissants that filled Phainon's senses that day would be a taste he would never forget.

Phainon (7:33am): *I'm really sorry…*

Krateros (8:00am): *I'm surprised you kept it a secret for this long.*

Chapter 30

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Meeting
✓ Accept. ? Tentative. × Decline. ⏱ Propose New Time

Executive Assistant on behalf of the CEO
Required: Phainon Khaslana

⏱ Monday, xx.xx.xxxx 11:00 AM-12:00 PM

⚲ First floor, Security Room 1

It was the first thing that set Phainon's heart racing at eight in the morning on Monday. He was reviewing his emails, as he usually did upon returning from the weekend, but there was a mysterious meeting that was scheduled right in the middle of when he usually conducted new hire orientation. He tried to email the executive assistant to explain he could not meet during this time, and perhaps even delay this ominous meeting, but the executive assistant simply said they already had another employee planned to step in during the time of the meeting.

The meeting didn't even have a name. It was quite literally named “Meeting,” and it only made Phainon's anxiety even worse. Was he meeting with the executive assistant, or was he actually meeting with the current CEO, Eurypon? Did they actually figure out that Phainon had close ties to Mydei? How much information did the tail have on both of them? Phainon didn't want to be the reason for Mydei's plans spanning for literal years to fail, and he would do his utmost to overcome this challenge, whatever it may be.

He spent his entire morning on autopilot, working to prepare onboarding documents for orientation while preparing his own answers. He was sure the meeting would be an interrogation–one that would center on Mydei and

their relationship entirely. The CEO probably didn't even know Phainon existed until just yesterday, when his car and Mydei's stayed at a bakery parking lot the entire day since two in the morning. He wasn't sure how much the tail was able to see of them together, but he hoped it wasn't enough so that Phainon could talk his way out of it.

Even though he was greeting new hires, presenting to them, and helping them complete orientation, his mind never strayed from Mydei. Not even once. Even when he learned all the new hires' names, joked with them, and answered their questions, Phainon never forgot about the meeting he would have in just a few short hours. In just a few short hours, Phainon would figure out exactly what the CEO had been hiding up his sleeves.

"Any questions?" Phainon smiled at the audience, tilting his head to the side and scanning the new hires sitting before him. He was just going over a general overview of the employee benefits for working at this company, and there were almost always questions during this segment.

One employee raised their hand, but before Phainon could open his mouth, the audience door swung open. Every single pair of eyes in that room fled toward the door, where there stood a woman with a bright pink head of hair and a bright smile across her neat appearance.

"Cyrene?" Phainon was trying hard not to make his jaw drop to the floor. "Did you need something right now?"

Cyrene's eyes turned wide, frowning in confusion as she approached the front of the room with Phainon. "I thought they told you I was taking over orientation right now?"

Phainon's gaze snapped to the clock in the room, where the time told eleven in the morning exactly. It was as if Phainon immediately entered fight-or-flight mode, with his heart ringing loudly in his ears, adrenaline pulsing through his veins, and palms sweating at the realization of the time. Time passed by faster than he could've ever imagined. Swallowing back his nerves as best as he could, he turned back to Cyrene, filling his lungs with deep breaths and trying to calm his growing and erratic heartbeat.

“I see.” Phainon turned a dry smile over to his coworker. “Thank you, Cyrene.”

Cyrene didn't respond immediately, and she watched Phainon pack his things as quickly as he could, along with the rest of the new hires who silently watched Phainon prepare to leave in the middle of orientation. It was completely silent in the auditorium, and every rustle of Phainon's belongings sounded louder in the room, echoing off the walls and being caught by every single pair of eyes that watched him and every single action he did. It felt as if Phainon were about to be executed and had an entire audience waiting to see his head roll to the floor, and Cyrene could already tell that the nerves were beginning to take hold of Phainon's limbs as he rigidly and stiffly took his things with him.

“Phainon,” Cyrene hesitantly spoke up, “what is this for?”

“What do you mean?” Phainon flashed a reassuring, shaky smile toward his friend, but she didn't seem the least comforted by his false confidence.

Cyrene furrowed her eyebrows, with her frown only deepening. “Is something happening? They didn't tell me why I'm stepping in. Only that you were going to be busy.”

“I'll be fine, Cyrene,” Phainon immediately answered. He could explain later, not when so many pairs of eyes were watching them. And it wasn’t just in this room, but in this entire office building as a whole.

All of his things were packed, and it was time to go. Time to go see what exactly the CEO had planned for him, and he could barely breathe through his constricting throat just thinking about it.

“I'll see you at lunch, right?” The other woman stuck out her bottom lip in a pout, causing Phainon to laugh, patting the top of her hair.

“I'll see you later.”

With a nod from Cyrene, Phainon apologized to the new hires, waving and rushing out of the audience room to give the floor to his reliable and

dependable friend. The auditorium door shut loudly behind him, reverberating against his body swirling in anxiety as he made his way to the security room. He was expecting the worst, and he wanted to prepare himself for the absolute worst. He prepared himself to face the CEO, and he prepared himself for the bombardment of intrusive questions his way.

There was also a chance Phainon could get fired right here and now, yet somehow, Phainon wasn't worried about that. His overworking brain could only concern itself with Mydei, whether Mydei's position was secure, and if anything happened to him while coming into work today. He sincerely hoped Mydei was having a normal day, that it was only Phainon going to his security room. He didn't want Mydei to worry at all.

The security room was separated from the main lobby by glass walls, but the shades had been pulled down to conceal everything inside. It didn't alleviate any of his jitters at all, and he could barely hear anything over his pumping adrenaline and his palpitating heart. But with one last gulp and one last deep breath, Phainon pulled open the security room door, bracing himself for whatever scene could possibly be inside and whoever was possibly waiting for him.

However, what was inside was definitely not what Phainon had prepared himself for. He even double-checked the room number just to ensure he hadn't waltzed into the wrong room with complete confidence, but it was the exact room that the meeting invite had described.

Phainon was completely still, with his eyes completely wide and his gaze completely frozen at the person who awaited him inside. It wasn't the executive assistant, the CEO, or anyone from the executive department, for that matter, and it made Phainon completely rethink all of his thoughts, preparations, and plans since this morning. How was Phainon going to overcome this now?

“This is the right place. Why are you looking around like that?” The only other person in the room laughed. She was relaxed in her seat, leaning back with her feet propped upon the desk.

“I just…” Phainon's eyes were darting through the office as if he missed anyone else. “I just thought I would be meeting with the executive assistant.”

The other woman shrugged nonchalantly. “They sent the invite; didn't mean they would be here.”

“That's kind of what it implies, Cipher.” Phainon settled into the chair across from the security guard with a sheepish smile. “To what do I owe the pleasure of seeing you today?”

Phainon didn't really interact with Cipher very much. In fact, Phainon never really interacted with any of the security guards very much. The two he knew the best were Hysilens and Cipher, but they all worked on the first floor, whereas Phainon worked on the very top floor, so they almost never crossed paths unless he passed by them while entering and exiting the building. But from the few interactions he *has* had with Cipher, the best way Phainon could explain her was that she was quite… the character.

She was nonchalant and relaxed about her job, yet she could be quite serious about her job when needed. She never rushed anywhere and always took her time, yet she could be the fastest person if needed. Cipher never really cared for much except for an easy job and a high salary, which was exactly why it made sense to work a cushy security guard job at a well-known corporation. She would do as little work as she could to maximize her pay. Besides her at her job, Cipher was amusing to talk to, as someone who never took corporate politics too seriously, and Phainon even found himself running with her quips and whims as well.

It was as if Cipher had completely forgotten Phainon was here for a purpose and not just visiting, and she immediately straightened up in her chair. Though, her feet never left the desk. “That's right! You–” She pointed a finger straight at Phainon, staring incriminatingly at him, but it was hard for Phainon to take her seriously when he was well aware of Cipher's nonchalant attitude.

“... Me?” Phainon smiled, pointing at himself as well.

“You know what you did.” It was like a soap opera in this security room with how dramatically Cipher was acting. She pulled back her finger, crossing her arms and leaning back once more. “You know, I haven't told the big boss at all yet.”

“The big boss?”

“Did you not think the CEO was going to put a tail on Mydei?”

A couple of beats went by before the information truly sank in Phainon’s head. He just couldn't imagine Cipher ever being involved in this matter, and with how relaxed Cipher was acting, he had almost forgotten the high stakes involved in this meeting. Phainon's eyes shot wide, and he had to stop himself from jumping up from his chair. “That was *you?”*

Cipher hummed proudly as a devious smirk grew on her face. “I have to say that I am *quite* good at my job. More than good, really. I'm amazing. Neither of you noticed me while you guys were out on your little dates, after all.” She scoffed, shaking her head dramatically. “He really thought he could get away with *Polemos*, huh?”

His heart sank into his stomach as he stared at the security guard. Cipher was the one who saw them at the restaurant? *And* the bakery? Phainon was completely frozen, struggling to either ask if she knew the truth or completely deny her words, but Cipher began waving her hand, as if shooing him away.

“Don't say anything; you're shocked by my expertise, I know!” Cipher was nodding and monologuing all to herself. “I didn't realize I was so good at this either. Maybe I should quit being a security guard and go work for the mafia or something. I'd make an amazing thief!”

“Cipher–”

“Whatever you say now can be used against you!” Cipher slammed her hands against the desk, causing Phainon to jump. She had both feet planted on the floor now, towering over Phainon. “Wow, I've always wanted to say that.”

“Is that even the right line to say right now?”

“Silence!” Cipher slammed her hands upon the desk once more, and Phainon immediately fell silent. An amused smile danced across Phainon's lips as he watched Cipher lean back, crossing her arms once more and staring down at Phainon.

“Trying to get rich without me, huh?” Cipher sneered. “Trying to marry your way into the CEO's family now?”

Phainon sighed, raising his hands in defeat. “You caught me, Cipher.”

“*Aha!* I knew it!” She jumped up, pointing another incriminating finger in Phainon's direction. “I knew you weren't gay!”

“No, I am.”

“Wait, really?”

“I'm in love with Mydei.”

Cipher immediately pulled a face, kicking her chair back and sitting back down. “I didn't need a declaration of love, dude.”

“You literally asked.”

“Silence!” Cipher demanded again, dropping her feet onto the desk once more. “So, you admit your debauchery, huh? Didn't take long for you to confess.”

Phainon sighed with a small smile. Despite admitting the truth, he quickly realized something with the way Cipher was putting up such a dramatic display, and he jumped into action while he had the chance. It wasn't too late. “Is there something you want from me? Considering that you didn't tell the CEO yet. Are you going to ask me for more money?”

Cipher laughed, but it was immediately cut short. “No. Not at all. I don't even think you have enough money to pay more than what the CEO paid me to find dirt on his son. But, there is… something I want.”

Her demeanor changed like a flick of a light switch. She pulled her feet back, setting them upon the floor as she scooted closer to the desk that separated the two of them. Clear blue eyes landed upon Phainon as she stared at him with the most serious gaze Phainon had ever seen this security guard wear. “I'm going to make you an offer you can't refuse.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow. “I'm guessing you've always wanted to say that too?”

“Damn, I'm good,” Cipher muttered to herself. “Anyway, yes, there is something I want to ask you about. It's… I think you are the best person for it.”

The dramatics had all dropped in the security room, and Phainon straightened his back at the sight of a deflated Cipher sitting in front of him. She was always beaming with confidence whenever he saw him, so he was sure, whatever it was, that it was sincerely important to her.

“You're going to exchange my cooperation for hiding the truth from the CEO?” Phainon narrowed his eyes.

Cipher nodded. “It doesn't have to succeed. I just want… a chance.”

It was so quiet in the room that Phainon could hear his shaky breath and his pounding heart once more. He could only hope that whatever favor Cipher wanted of him was easy enough to fulfill, and he hesitantly opened his mouth to ask for the fated favor. “A chance?”

“I want to speak with Aglaea.”

A moment of silence passed between them. Phainon could not tell if Cipher was kidding or not, but with the way she continued, completely unmoving, and staring up at Phainon with pleading eyes, it was evident that she was more than serious. And it confused Phainon.

“You… just want to talk with her?” Phainon’s expression of confusion was clear across his face. “You can… just go to her office.”

The other woman sighed loudly and exasperatedly. “You think I would be asking you if I tried? She's the HR director. She's in a meeting every single minute of the day.”

“So you want me to schedule a meeting between you and my boss.”

“Exactly!” Cipher seemed to perk up once more. “Listen, it's a long story. But I only came here to work at this place just to see Aglaea again. I took up the job with the least requirements to get in here, but… I didn't realize it would be so hard to meet with her.” She smiled weakly while recounting her beginning working days. Her shoulders dropped as she quietly spoke, “I just want to apologize.”

Phainon frowned. “Apologize?”

“None of your business, golden boy!” Cipher was always the range of emotions, and she jumped back up once more. “If you can do that for me, I'll tell the CEO that I couldn't find any dirt on his son. Deal?”

As easy as this job sounded, and as easy as it was to jump at this opportunity, it was difficult to accept a deal that Phainon had almost no details of. Why did she want to meet with Aglaea so desperately that she would even turn down the CEO's money for it? Was Phainon going to start something that he didn't even know *what* exactly he was starting? But the offer was too good to refuse. As his boss, Phainon could ask to see Aglaea at any time of the day. It was almost too easy a deal, and it made Phainon suspicious. Cipher could also tell Phainon's lack of an answer leaked his suspicion as well, and she heavily sighed once more.

“Look, I knew Aglaea a long time ago. She raised me when I was just a nobody on the streets. Due to… certain circumstances, I ran away, never to be seen by her again.” Cipher shifted awkwardly in her seat. “I just want to see her again and apologize. Is that so bad? You just happen to be the best person to ask for this favor, and when I saw you with the CEO's son, I thought of this instead.”

“You would turn down whatever money the CEO is offering you just to see Aglaea?” Phainon wasn't convinced. “I thought money was your thing.”

“Yeah, well.” Cipher smiled wryly. “We all have one person we think about, right? Aren't we both here for them?”

She was right, and she knew that Phainon was aware of it too. “You're really going to let me go? Just like that?”

“Did you want me to ask for something else?” Cipher hummed amusedly, as if tossing the idea in her head. She rocked back and forth in her chair, throwing her hands behind her head. “Just think of this as coming from the goodness of my big ol' heart. The whole thing from the CEO sounded petty, anyway. I wouldn't have taken up such a shady deal if not for the money. Well, I'm just glad I was able to get something out of this, if not the CEO's money.”

Phainon couldn't think of another reason to refuse. The deal was too good, and it was tilted exactly in Phainon's favor. “Fine. I'll talk with her today."

Cipher grinned and immediately began shooing Phainon away, wasting absolutely no time at all. “Great! Then, I'll await your lovely news. In the meantime, I'm going to burn all these amazing pictures of you and the CEO's son sucking face.”

“*What?*” Phainon was just about to step out the door but immediately rushed back to Cipher's desk. “What pictures?!”

“You thought I was going to bring incriminating evidence to the CEO without photographic evidence?” Cipher laughed. “Unlike you two, who couldn't go two days without clinging to each other's sides, I'm actually good at my job.”

“Give them to me.”

“No way!” Cipher scooted her chair away from the desk Phainon was leaning over. “I'm going to burn them, so don't worry!”

“Let me watch you.”

“Okay, okay! Get me that meeting, and you can watch me burn them, you weirdo.”

Phainon pivoted on his feet and dashed out of the security room without another glance back. It was approaching their lunch break now, which was the perfect time to catch Aglaea. It was the one time she was never riddled with meetings, considering that everyone else was also off on their lunch break. Well, she actually did sometimes have meetings during her lunch, so Phainon only hoped, as he rushed to her office door, that she would be available today. He had to catch Aglaea right when their lunch break started, before she left her office to grab lunch; otherwise, he could not talk to her in person again and would have to message her and nervously await her response, and Phainon did not want to keep Cipher waiting another minute longer.

There was no chance Phainon would let those pictures slip from Cipher's grasp. As much as he trusted Cipher to keep her word, he did not trust the CEO at all.

“Aglaea?!” Phainon was out of breath as he grasped the frame of the open doorway. It was the fastest trip Phainon had ever taken from the bottom floor all the way to the top floor, and he was sure the sweat running down his body was evidence of that.

Aglaea casually glanced up from her desk as if this were any other day. “Do you need something, Phainon?” Her usual pleasant smile was on her face despite being interrupted right at the beginning of her lunch break. “How were the new hires today?”

“Can I ask you for a favor?” Phainon did not acknowledge her question at all; it wasn't as if he could, anyway, since he was ripped from new hire orientation right in the middle of it. Taking a deep breath, he leisurely stepped into her office, pretending as if he did not just sprint the entire way from the security room on the first floor. “I want to schedule a meeting sometime this week with you. Do you have time?”

With curious eyes, Aglaea set down her keys, her smile never fading. Phainon literally caught Aglaea right when she was about to leave. “Of

course I have time for you. When do you want to meet?”

“Anytime this week. The sooner, the better.” Phainon didn't want to give the CEO another chance at possibly seeing those pictures.

His boss hummed, tossing her schedule in her head. “Is something on your mind, Phainon? You seem to be thinking of something. If it's truly urgent, we can speak right now.”

Cipher probably dashed out of her office the moment her lunch break started, so Phainon dismissed the idea. “Someone wants to meet you.”

“Meet me?” She raised an eyebrow. “That they asked you to schedule it for them?”

He shifted awkwardly on his feet. Phainon didn't know their relationship, and if Cipher's words were true, then Aglaea may even despise Cipher for disappearing on her. But Phainon had to take the chance if it meant helping Mydei. “Do you know someone named Cipher?”

She furrowed her eyebrows. “Cipher?”

She sounded confused, and Phainon frowned. “Um… Gray hair, blue eyes. A lithe frame. Kind of mischievous. Actually, no, *very* mischievous. She said you… raised her when she was young?”

Golden eyes slightly widened at the description, and Aglaea's lips slightly parted to mutter, “Cifera.”

“Cifera?”

“Yes, I do know of her.” As quickly as always, Aglaea regained her composure, with her polite smile soon returning. “I have been keeping watch of her, after all. Though, I did not know she went by ‘Cipher’ instead.”

There was a lot to unpack here. Cipher's name was Cifera, and she was raised by Aglaea but disappeared on her. But Aglaea knew the entire time but had been keeping watch of her from afar?

“So you *knew* she worked here?”

“I have always known she worked here, but I always let her be.” Memories were flickering inside Aglaea's mind; even Phainon could tell.

“You never reached out to her?”

Aglaea lightly chuckled. “I thought it best for her to make the first step. You don't want your mother to be overbearing on you the first moment you see each other again, right?”

Phainon would like nothing more than that, but he smiled instead. “Right, I see. Are you… willing to meet her?”

A melancholy smile adorned Aglaea's usual unwavering lips. An unreadable emotion sparkled in her golden eyes, and Phainon almost opened his mouth to retract the proposal. But he had to stand his ground at even the slightest chance of retrieving the evidence from Cipher.

“Aglaea,” Phainon’s eyes flickered across the floor as he fell deep into thought, “if you don't want to meet with her, perhaps–”

“That's alright, Phainon.” A gentle hand landed on his shoulder, bringing his gaze back to the soft golden eyes that were directed at him. “As your boss, I would like to alleviate your concerns. And if that means meeting with Cifera, then I will.”

Was Phainon throwing his own boss into a fire? Maybe there was another way they could communicate? “Aglaea, maybe we could communicate in a different way? If you don't want to meet with her, we could–”

“I would love to meet with Cifera,” Aglaea gently interrupted his thoughts. “In fact, I would like nothing more.”

“May I… ask why?” Phainon couldn't help but inquire. He wanted to make sure he wasn't throwing his boss under the bus to get what he wanted. As much as he wanted to win against the CEO, he didn't want to destroy the people he cared about to achieve his end goals.

Aglaea simply smiled. “I'm sure she has explained everything to you already. A long time ago, before this job, I ran a tailor shop, where a little girl with no possessions at all would drop by, trying to barter for one of my products with stolen goods. I took care of her, a little girl living on the streets all by herself, and I gifted her the boots instead. One day, I never saw her again.”

It almost sounded like Cipher received what she wanted and immediately left, but Phainon knew otherwise than to believe that. It seemed as if Aglaea believed otherwise as well, and her unshakable confidence in Cipher despite being forsaken spoke volumes of their close relationship. He was sure they both cared for each other deeply and yearned deeply to be reunited once more, but all Phainon could do for the two of them now was to wish the best for their reunion.

“I see. Then, I will tell Cipher the news.” Phainon smiled gratefully at his boss. He had always admired Aglaea, someone who was strong, knowledgeable, and intelligent, and she was someone whom Phainon had immensely learned from. He could not be more appreciative to learn under her guidance. “Thank you, Aglaea.”

“Thank you, Phainon. I will reach out to her with details for the meeting.”

With a nod, Phainon turned to depart from the office, with a smooth voice calling after him as he stepped away.

“I hope what is bothering you will be resolved in due time, Phainon.”

His steps slightly faltered at his boss's words, but he continued on toward the elevator, quickly dropping by the break room to grab his salad. While passing by the executive department on the way to the elevator, Phainon confirmed that Mydei’s office door was closed, as it usually was. It was the only sense of relief that Phainon had all day–that Mydei was, at least, experiencing his normal, routine work schedule. Although now that the bakery was officially closed, Mydei's sleep schedule would slowly recover, meaning he wouldn't have to shut himself in his office to catch up on sleep any longer.

It was hard for Phainon to pull himself away from the executive department and force his feet to continue toward the elevator. He wanted so desperately to slip into that quaint little office and run his fingers through Mydei’s soft, golden hair. He wanted to stare into those loving, golden eyes and watch Mydei slowly drift into a peaceful sleep. Phainon couldn't be impatient now, and it disappointed him that he could not see Mydei as often as he wanted to. Even though Mydei was most likely sleeping now, he whipped out his phone to wish Mydei a good night during his break.

There was nothing Phainon could do now except wait for their lunch break to be over for Cipher to return. The only problem was that he couldn't relax during his lunch break at all. Not when all he could think about was what Cipher could have possibly taken a picture of while Phainon and Mydei were together. How many pictures did she have of them making out and then crying together? He could not even begin to imagine the absolutely incriminating evidence Cipher was carrying on her person, and it would hurt Mydei's position if those pictures got out. He was too worried over the photographs being leaked to be embarrassed over the fact that Cipher most likely witnessed everything.

Cyrene and Castorice were both shocked to see him when he had sat down at their table in the office cafeteria, and they were trying to badger him for information as to why he was pulled out of orientation in the first place, when half of his job consisted of orientation and onboarding. But Phainon was too busy drowning in his own anxiety, bouncing his leg and gnawing at his bottom lip in anticipation for their lunch break to be over. He had never desired so strongly for their break to be over and done with, and Phainon was glancing at the clock every twelve seconds to check the time.

Even if Phainon ended up caving to his two friends and confessed the truth, he didn't feel safe doing it in the corporate office, where it felt as if all eyes were boring deep into him all at once, as if everyone in this building could see exactly what he was thinking. It only made Phainon fidget even more in his seat, barely picking at his salad, as his mind could not think of anything else except for Mydei and those pictures. He waved dismissively at his two friends, flashing them a struggling smile and promising to explain more later.

The only joy that Phainon felt during this day filled with anxiety and apprehension was thinking about a day when Mydei and Phainon could go out for lunch together. They had never ventured outside of the office before for lunch, and it was something for Phainon to look forward to, something that would motivate Phainon to secure whatever photographs Cipher may be in possession of.

He sank into his own wishful imaginations of meeting Mydei at his office at the beginning of their lunch break and trying all the nearby restaurants in the city during their lunch. He imagined returning to the office, walking Mydei back to his office and sneaking kisses before anyone could notice before returning to his desk. He even imagined meeting with Mydei even after work to go grocery shopping together or maybe even to the gym.

Soon, these imaginations would be a reality, and soon, Phainon would be as free as he had always wanted to be. As free as he felt lying in those golden wheat fields of his hometown, immersed in the color gold that filled his entire world and embraced him in a comforting, warm hold underneath a beaming sun. Phainon had pushed the color gold away, as far as he could, equating him with the very blood that stained his hometown. And yet, Phainon could not wait to feel those wishful dreams shrouded within golden strands and within sparkling, golden eyes. The color gold was the only thing that had ever truly listened to him.

He dashed down to the security room the moment the clock struck one in the afternoon, never bothering to return to his cubicle for even a second. Phainon had to silently thank Eurypon just this once, for choosing Cipher as the tail rather than anyone else, or Phainon may not ever have had the chance to salvage this situation. He hurriedly waved goodbye to his two friends, whom he could barely pay any attention to during his lunch, only to travel in the complete opposite direction of their desks. He would explain to them later. He had more important things to attend to.

It was quite typical for Cipher to arrive whenever she pleased, and Phainon prepared himself to wait for a couple of anxious minutes for her to arrive. However, upon exiting the cafeteria and heading toward the security rooms, he was shocked to see that Cipher's office door was already unlocked. In

fact, his steps slowed down until he was at a full stop, gaping at the unlocked door with complete surprise.

“You don't have to look *that* surprised that I'm here. I can be fast when I want to be.”

“Why are you back on time?”

“Because!” Cipher dragged the utterly shocked Phainon into the security room. “This seems important to you, and it's important to me too. So I'm here, at your command.”

She shut the door, throwing a Manila folder and a flash drive onto the desk, but Phainon didn't move at all, only standing there and gazing at the beige folder.

“What? It's not like you guys were going at it in the bakery or something.” Cipher dropped into her seat, which made Phainon follow suit as well, pulling out his chair to make himself warily comfortable in the security room. “I had no idea the CEO's son was so strapped for cash that he had to run a side business. Though, it doesn't seem like that at all, right?”

There was a knowing, mischievous glint sparkling in her eyes. Now that Phainon knew who raised her, it was almost identical to the knowing stare Aglaea always gave him, only Cipher was much cheekier about it. He didn't know how much Cipher had dug up about Mydei and his past, but he chose not to acknowledge her last statement.

Phainon slowly picked up the flash drive and folder from the desk, eyeing them and Cipher carefully. “Did Aglaea message you?”

She leaned back in her office chair. “Why do you think I'm giving you the evidence? I'll be meeting with Aglaea this week.”

A few seconds of silence littered the security room. Phainon knew Cipher wanted to discuss something else, and he waited until she acted first. It didn't take long until she slumped in her chair, dropping her chin into the palm of her hand. “I should think of what to bring her, but I'm not sure what

someone like me can buy for the HR director of this humongous corporation.”

He had to stop himself from smiling at her words. It was almost as if Phainon were speaking with his own self, who used to be suffocating under an empty myriad of ideas of what to gift to Mydei, someone who seemed to be able to own whatever he wanted. He chuckled quietly to himself at the irony, hoping Cipher didn't hear him and watching her dejectedly trace her fingers along the desk. Phainon knew Cipher was waiting for him to suggest something, especially since he worked directly under Aglaea for so many years.

“Even if I suggested something, I think you know her better than I do.”

“I haven't talked to her in *years*, buddy.”

“And I still think you know her better than I do.” Phainon laughed, mirroring Cipher's previously nonchalant attitude and leaning back in his chair. “What were you thinking of gifting her?”

“Textiles,” Cipher mumbled toward the desk. “Bath oils. Sewing materials. Is that enough for leaving her?”

Phainon smiled softly. “I think Aglaea would be happy just to be reunited with you again, no matter what you bring. It sounds like she misses you.”

The lithe finger running along the desk's surface froze, and Cipher's expression flickered between a warm comfort and gnawing guilt. It didn't last long, however, when Cipher instantly recovered from whatever memories or thoughts she had sunken into.

“Right, well.” She cleared her throat, throwing her phone at Phainon, who barely caught it. “My phone is unlocked. You can check that I don't have the pictures anymore. You can check my computer too. You held up your end of the deal. And I'll tell the CEO that his son is the very picture of perfection.”

He only briefly swiped through her phone and computer. Phainon trusted Cipher. She may act on her own and have outlandish ideas, but he knew she was good. Directing his attention to Cipher's files, most of her pictures consisted of very shiny objects or travel destinations that, Phainon assumed, she had visited. Although, he tried to hide his smile at seeing that Cipher had saved a screenshot of Aglaea's work message to her, and even after a little digging, he found a young Cipher with Aglaea. They had to be standing in the tailor shop that Aglaea used to own, based on the background of the picture.

“I'm completely wiped.” Cipher shrugged. “There's nothing left for me. No more money.”

“You don't sound sad at all.” Phainon chuckled, handing her phone back to her with amusement swirling in his eyes.

“I can assure you that I am lamenting my loss right now, so just take the pictures and go.”

With a nod, Phainon quickly pushed himself from the chair. He sincerely smiled in her direction, gathering the evidence within his hands. “Thank you, Cipher. Really, I don't know what I could've done if it wasn't you.”

“We both got something out of it.” Cipher smiled triumphantly to herself. “Praise me when he becomes CEO. And maybe even frame those. I take good pictures, you know.”

Phainon laughed, clutching the pictures tighter within his arms. “I'll let you know where I end up putting them.”

It didn't take long for Phainon to reach his car in the adjacent parking structure. As much as he wanted to take just the slightest peek at the pictures, he didn't want to risk anything at all while still being so close to the office. So he shoved them away, hiding them as deeply within his trunk as he could before returning to his usual routine at work.

Phainon would await the day when those pictures could finally see the light of day.

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is the epilogue. Thank you, if you made it this far ❤ You cannot believe how happy it makes me to see you make it to the final chapter, so thank you for enjoying and following along with this office AU

Chapter 31: Epilogue

Chapter Notes

I added new tags because of this chapter, just as a warning ! They get... a little freaky...

Sorry I haven't updated in a bit. This chapter is a long one! I promise I was working quite consistently on it <3 I actually went to an amusement park over the weekend and was somehow seated in the purple and yellow cart 4 times... So Phainon would never let me forget this story, even if I wanted to.

I will probably take quite a bit of a break before working on my next story. It was amazing meeting so many new friends and Phaidei supporters, and I thank you again for reaching this far into my humble story. Thank you again for reading, and maybe I will see you in the next one!

“It has been more than a month since Kremnos Corporation has seen a shift in leadership. The company was passed down to the founder's son, current CEO Mydeimos, who was previously working with the executive department for a few years to learn the ropes of their management. The company had a transition period of a month before the son officially took over, and now it has already been another month since Mydeimos stepped up to the top.

“Which didn't seem to work out in the founder's favor, so to speak. What we've heard here in Amphoreus News is that the founder is fighting back against his own efforts and his own son.

“Surprising, isn't it? To gain more information on this matter, we're turning to Reporter Ica, who is already at the scene in downtown Okhema. Reporter Ica, what do you have to say about this news?”

“Hello, everyone. My name is Reporter Ica. It is a bright and sunny day, and we are standing right outside the main building of Kremnos

Corporation to learn more about this fiasco between the founder, the previous CEO Eurypon, and his own company.

“Staff working in this building have been very discreet in the information being shared, but other sources of news have indicated the previous CEO is trying to take back his own company and end his retirement, despite the lack of response from the Board of Directors. As for the reason for this reversal, this is something that will be uncovered very soon.

“Kremnos Corporation is hosting a live panel next week to address the growing demand for answers from news and media outlets regarding this huge corporation and seemingly controversial shift in leadership. Some are claiming the new CEO has achieved something the previous CEO has been looking for through the eyes of the company. Others report the new CEO plans to alter the company's vision, directly rebelling against the founder's ideals. More news will be reported at–”

“Please… *hah.*… turn that off.”

A laugh echoed loudly in the air as Phainon scrambled for the remote on the coffee table, and the television was immediately shut off. The entire living room was enveloped in silence as deep blue eyes turned toward gold.

“You didn't like hearing the news, Mydei?”

“I don't want to hear about work when you’re balls deep inside of me.” A glare was shot in Phainon's way, earning him another laugh.

With every breath that left his lungs, the man underneath him jolted, grimacing with every slight movement. It didn't escape Phainon's notice, who grinned cheekily, leaning down to peck a teasing kiss upon beautifully pouted lips.

“Don't you like it when I'm deep inside?” Phainon whispered, glancing toward glowing golden eyes that were narrowed in his direction.

“*Hmph*. Just move, unless you never want me to bake you Honey Suncakes again.”

“Mydei, no!” Phainon's eyes shot wide. “Not when we just moved in together!”

“Then hurry up and fuck me, *Deliverer*. We don't have time.”

Phainon chuckled, pushing himself up to pull himself out, only to immediately ram himself inside and make the man below him spasm against the couch. Warm heat permeated his entire body, tightening dangerously in his stomach as he swallowed back his own moan. “Hearing you rush me makes me want to take my time, my love.”

Mydei opened his mouth to retort, but a moan left his parted lips instead when Phainon began snapping his hips against his behind at a rapid pace. Golden eyes fluttered shut as sweet moans and gasps filled the living room, with his body bouncing up and down against the cushions with every deep thrust that hit his stomach swirling in pleasure. Phainon's own name bounced off the walls, leaving him hungry to hear more of his name fill his ears in the sound of his lover’s deep, sultry, and husky voice.

It had been a long time since they had slept together, and every drive of Phainon's length as he buried himself inside of Mydei's pulsing warmth knocked the air out of both of their lungs. Phainon was already running out of breath, panting like a madman with blurring vision that had turned red from arousal. He could barely make out the tantalizing view before him, of Mydei with his trembling legs spread wide, with one foot propped up on the back of the couch and the other draped over the edge to brush against the rug their couch was set upon. He could barely make out the twitching dick that was leaking precum all over Mydei’s stomach, bouncing and slapping against him with every thrust of Phainon's hips that echoed along their empty walls.

Hands clawed at Phainon's abdomen and his hips, tempting Phainon to a further breaking pace. He planted his hands upon Mydei's waist, grasping his lover tightly to bury his insatiable dick as deeply inside as he could. Fingernails clawed into soft, tan skin and red tattoos, and a mewl left Mydei's throat at the pain and pleasure that surged through his body, back arching at the delicious sensations that traveled his veins.

Curses spilled from Mydei's lips at how Phainon's tip perfectly brushed against his sweet spot, and every sound sent shivers rushing down Phainon's spine and his sweating back that was already sticking to his shirt. His blue eyes were drawn to the bruised, blushed lips that were forever parted, moaning into the air of their new home, and his ears were drawn to every slap of their sweating skin, every wet noise that came from Mydei's stuffed hole, and every pant and cry that left Mydei's lungs.

It was hard for Phainon to enjoy the view through his own blurring vision when his eyes struggled to stay open through the pleasure heating his entire body. He wanted to throw his head back, intertwine his moans with his lover's, and revel in the electricity that rushed through his body and made his entire body grow rigid with every slap of their skin, but he could not tear his gaze away from the temptation that lay underneath him as if being served on a silver platter to a starving prisoner. How could he possibly deny any request made by this ethereal man, who had his legs spread wide just for him? Just for Phainon to ravish him entirely, both inside and outside of his perfect body?

Perfect tattoos that crossed down his body, outlining every single perfect curve and crevice that captured Phainon's gaze everywhere along his skin. Perfect, golden hair that glowed under the sun, framing his sharp features and delicately strong expressions. Perfect golden eyes that pierced Phainon's soul so deeply that it left Phainon gasping for the air and life that only this man underneath him could provide.

Fingers began desperately tugging against the hem of Phainon's shirt, and Phainon laughed breathlessly, leaning forward once more to suck against the lips that were begging to kiss him. Tongues intertwined, moans and gasps were exchanged against taunting lips, and saliva escaped down their chins as they lost themselves to the pleasure of their sliding tongues and thrusting hips. Strong arms wrapped around Phainon's neck, tugging him closer and burying himself further inside two separate heats that sank deeply into Phainon's already short-circuiting brain, and all five of his senses were consumed by one singular, golden-haired man. He could no longer perceive anything else except for the fingers that were tugging at his

silver hair and the fluttering heat that gobbled up his entire length that was begging for more heat.

Every thrust into his lover’s hole wasn't enough and left Phainon chasing more. Every moan that vibrated against Phainon's lips only left him greedy for more. And every sharp tug against his hair made Phainon gasp, electricity pooling in his tightening abdomen and making his hips snap faster. He begged for more, begging for Mydei to pull at his hair the same way he always pulled at his heartstrings, and he buried his dick over and over inside of Mydei’s hole that was perfectly stretched out to encompass Phainon's exact shape and size.

His dick was quivering delightfully inside of Mydei's delicious heat and leaking precum with every harsh tug of his silver strands, and a scoff and a smirk brushed Phainon’s lips at every one of his desperate, pathetic begs and whines. Phainon moaned wantonly when a fist balled up in his hair, tugging at his hair so roughly it made his toes clench and his eyes roll back and brim with tears.

“*Please,* Mydei, *please!*” Phainon whined, chasing the sweet friction that deliciously massaged his hungry, leaking cock. “More, Mydei–*ahh! Harder!*”

It was tight, hot, and wet inside, and every thrust into Mydei’s hole encompassed his dick so perfectly, cradling him with so much warmth, that it just felt like Phainon belonged there, inside of Mydei, forever. He wanted to feel Mydei around him forever, sucking and tasting Phainon's length forever, and have his lover’s body heat mixing with Phainon's forever.

“You're so needy today, Deliverer.”

Another tug, and another wanton moan left Phainon's lips. His hips staggered at the pleasure that took hold of his body and left him panting, but the twitching heat that was consuming his entire cock didn't let him stop for a second. Phainon drove his hips as fast as he could, chasing the heat and pleasure that he pushed into over and over like a madman.

He could feel his own dick pulsing inside of Mydei’s tantalizing warmth, and his lust-filled brain could not wait to thrust into streams of his own cum that filled Mydei’s hole to the absolute brim. He could not wait to see his own cum leaking out of Mydei’s hole, sliding against his inner walls, and filling the deepest parts of him that even Phainon's own tip could not reach. He wanted to cement Mydei as his own and leave his own scent upon Mydei’s body. He wanted to tattoo his own self across those crimson tattoos. He wanted to mark him up and let everyone know Mydei belonged to him, and that Phainon also belonged to Mydei. His brain was telling him that there was no other way except to stuff him entirely with his cum and plug him up with his own dick. It was the only way. *The only way.*

A rough tug pulled Phainon out of his possessive thoughts, earning a sharp gasp that faded into Mydei's name. Their kiss couldn't even be considered a kiss anymore with the way they were eating each other's scents, biting and licking and sucking along their lips and tongues and practically rubbing their lips together in a poor excuse of a desperate kiss. Their noses and teeth clashed against each other, with loud groans and warm breath intertwining between the space that didn't exist between them.

Mydei’s legs were quivering violently, shaking against the couch and Phainon's snapping hips. Hands rushed through his silver hair and his yellow shirt, digging underneath to claw at his sweating skin. Phainon revelled in the pain that mixed with the pleasure radiating from his dick, and he could not stop the pleas and begs for Mydei to go harder, to tug harder, to dig his fingernails deeper into Phainon's skin to leave his marks and traces all over his body.

Heat was pooling dangerously in his stomach, and Phainon could barely breathe over it. His abdomen was tightening, staving away his oncoming orgasm, but the sight of his own cum dripping out of Mydei's hole made his entire body spasm, with shivers rushing down his spine and goosebumps rising along his arms just at the mere thought of filling Mydei to the brim. His vision was about to turn white as his lips dropped into a silent scream, and his stomach tightened so much that he could barely register his own words spilling out of his mouth and the words that were reverberating against his own lips.

“Phainon, *Phainon!* I'm–*AHH*–cumming, I'm–”

“Mydei, Mydei, *Mydei*, *please*, I'm about to–”

A ringtone completely made both men immediately freeze.

Blue met gold, with wide eyes being the only thing Phainon could perceive. The ringtone repeated again, cutting through the air and shaking Phainon from his stupor, and he slowly pushed himself up, with fingers untangling themselves from his hair and his shirt. It was when sanity started returning to Phainon that he realized just how much he had sweated through his shirt, just how much air had left his lungs, and just how dry his throat was.

Phainon's eyes flickered to the vibrating phone on the coffee table, where he could barely read the contact name that he could only assume was quite impatient with him.

“Shit, what time is it?” Phainon began wildly searching for a clock along the walls, only to realize that they had not bought one for the living room yet.

“Is it Cyrene?” Mydei’s scratchy, deep voice almost made Phainon explode right inside of him, and Phainon had to actually still his breath lest he actually cum right then and there.

They were supposed to set up their television in the living room while the Honey Suncakes were baking in the oven. Yet upon peering into the kitchen, the oven had already sounded off, and the television was long since turned off after confirming that it could power on. The Honey Suncakes were timed to be completed right when they had to leave before they met up with Cyrene and Castorice, and they had somehow become *extremely* sidetracked while completely forgetting about the pastries.

“It… is.” Phainon felt his entire body wilting at the name that seemed to glare at him from his phone screen. “I'll text her later.”

“Just answer.”

His heart immediately dropped, and Phainon’s mouth gaped open. Wide eyes flickered between golden eyes and the ring of muscle that was still twitching around Phainon's burning cock, as if trying to visually display to the other man why that was an outrageous idea. “Um… right *now?*”

“Is she not going to call again if you don't pick up?” Mydei gave a very good point, and it was right on cue as well. Right when his phone fell silent, it erupted once more, replaying Phainon's ringtone that repeated Mydei's gentle strums on his guitar that Phainon recorded of the other man while they were packing up his belongings in the penthouse together.

Phainon still could not believe what he was hearing. He thought *he* was the perverted one out of the two of them. Then again, Mydei had brought Phainon to his own office for sex during work hours. Was Phainon actually being outfreaked right now? Even while uttering the outrageous question, Phainon could still not believe the words that were coming out of his own mouth: “You want me to pick up the phone *right now?*”

A smirk grew upon Mydei’s lips as he cocked his head to the side, as if challenging Phainon. He shifted himself against the couch, as if settling in to become comfortable. “Only if you want to.”

An incredulous scoff left Phainon's lips as he swiped his phone from the coffee table. The device shook in his hands, with his thumb hovering over the answer button. “You'd better keep quiet then.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow oozing in confidence. “I think *you* will have a harder time than I will, *Deliverer*.”

“*Hah!* We'll see about that, *my love*.” Phainon confidently pressed his finger down, pressing his phone against his burning ear. “Cyrene?”

“Hello?” Cyrene’s voice rang through the other end. “Cas and I just got here! Though, we can't find you guys. Is this the right place?”

Phainon smiled sheepishly. “No, I think it's the right–*ngh!*”

His smile immediately dropped, and almost along with his phone, when the walls embracing his dick suddenly tightened around him. One hand tightened around his phone while the other around his lover's waist, and a glare snapped up toward golden eyes that were smiling tauntingly at him. Phainon could not tell if it was anxiety or anticipation that rushed through his veins at the knowing smirk being thrown at him, as he could tell exactly what sort of devious plans were swirling in his lover’s mind.

“Phainon?”

“We… haven't left yet.” He swallowed thickly, his eyes gluing themselves to the sight of his dick buried deep inside of Mydei. His entrance was twitching where they were connected, and Phainon could feel his own tip being massaged by Mydei's hole as he began moving his hips, pushing Phainon’s dick to slide against his inner walls. Phainon held in a gasp as his lips dropped open, watching how his dick was revealed to the open air, only to sink deep inside of Mydei's pulsing entrance.

“You guys haven't left?!” Cyrene cried over the phone, but Phainon could barely hear it now. He could barely hear anything that did not involve Mydei slowly beginning to move his hips up and down, dragging Phainon’s length inside and emitting sparks of pleasure to rush down his spine.

“S–Sorry.” Phainon could barely bring himself to stammer a reply. “We're leaving soon. We were–” Phainon coughed to stifle a moan that threatened to leave his lips at the sight that was flooding his vision. Mydei was fully riding Phainon's dick, using his cock to reach his own orgasm, with his lips dropped open to emit soft moans and gasps with every slight brush against his prostate. His eyes had fluttered closed, hands clawing above his head at the couch underneath him, as he was completely consumed in the pleasure of using Phainon's dick as his own toy. Phainon’s hips were twitching at the sight, trying to stop himself from pummeling his hips right now into the tightening warmth that was surrounding his cock and lovingly sliding against him. “–running into a little… trouble with our TV.”

Cyrene hummed. “Did you guys need any help?”

“No!” A cold sweat ran down Phainon's back at the thought, but then he remembered that Cyrene did not have the key to his home this time, since he had just moved. Now, he was more worried about the fact that he definitely answered too fast. “We just fixed it! So we're about to get ready to head over now!”

A stifled laugh came from below, and Phainon glanced down to see Mydei's head turned away, attempting to hold down his laughter that was shaking his chest. Mydei had brought a hand to his blushing face to try and quiet his own chuckles, but his amused smile was clear as day to the panicking Phainon.

“Okay, just… let us know when you guys are on the way, okay?”

“Righ–*MMPH!*” Phainon clenched his jaw as his head flew forward, burying the moan that had almost slipped out when Mydei slammed his hips against Phainon, completely consuming Phainon's entire length inside. Phainon felt like he was going to cum just like this, with his leaking tip crying for more friction and breaching the deepest parts of Mydei, and he quickly fumbled to reveal his phone screen to his eyes. His words were all stringed together as he was entirely out of breath and trying to brush past the muffled moan that he was sure went through to the other end. “Okay, Cyrene, I'll let you know.”

He hastily slammed his thumb against his phone to end the call, and Phainon practically threw it across the living room, scattering his phone along the rug that they had just laid down underneath their couch.

“*Mydei*.” Phainon gazed helplessly at the other man, who was still stifling his laughs behind a triumphant smirk and sparkling, golden eyes.

“You seemed plenty confident you weren't going to make a noise, Phainon.” Mydei chuckled. “Looks like I won this time.”

“*Hah!* Then what's this?” Pulling himself out, he rapidly shoved himself inside, rubbing right against Mydei’s prostate and earning a loud slap and a loud gasp from the man below him. But before a golden glare and a sharp retort could be thrown in Phainon's way, he repeated the action, burying his

dick as deep inside as he could and ramming his length over and over inside Mydei's tantalizing heat once more.

Mydei threw his head back, unable to stop the wanton moans that slipped past his parted lips as he began bouncing up and down against the couch. His body began shaking, eager to reach the orgasm that had been interrupted earlier. The pleasure was hitting him much harder than before from being cut short before, and he could not stop his body from growing rigid with every deep thrust of Phainon's burning, twitching tip.

Phainon was panting again, eyes growing hazy from the lust that began consuming his body once more and the hole that was gobbling his cock so deliciously. His mind had completely forgotten the conversation he just had with his friend as his core was tightening in pleasure and arousal, chasing the sweet friction that ignited his dick and the sweet moans of his lover calling his name. He chased the sweet sounds of their sweating skin that collided with every thrust and the sweet tears that ran down his lover's cheeks. His hands grasped tightly at Mydei's waist that curved perfectly in the palm of his hands, and with a rough tug against the hem of his shirt, Phainon leaned down with an eager grin to comply with his lover's silent request, capturing Mydei's lips in another messy kiss that had them exchanging pants for breath and desperate, needy moans that begged for more pleasure.

He sucked on Mydei’s bottom lip and ran his tongue along Mydei's, making his lover spasm underneath his touch. Phainon shifted his hands underneath Mydei's legs, lifting his lower body and pulling him upward for an even easier angle to ravish Mydei's taste entirely. His brain and his dick could not handle the fire that was erupting in his core, and Phainon's entire brain completely blanked out. He could process nothing except for Mydei, Mydei, and *Mydei*. The scent of Mydei, the taste of Mydei–everything about Mydei was permeating through his very being the longer and faster that he pumped inside of his lover's warmth.

Mydei moaned at the new angle, and every breath was ripped from his lungs with how deeply Phainon was piercing him now. He clawed at Phainon's back, tugging at the hideously yellow shirt that adorned his torso, as he felt that familiar spark surging within his stomach again. His toes

were clenching at nothing, with his legs trembling in the air and shaking within Phainon's grasp, and his mouth being sucked and licked and bitten by Phainon dropped down into a wanton moan, screaming Phainon's name as his entire body jolted in place as he could no longer hold back anymore. His core tightened, his entrance tightened, and his eyes rolled into the back of his head as his back arched, and he came, spilling his load all over both himself and Phainon. His cum splattered along Phainon's shirt and across Mydei’s naked torso, painting both of them in streams of white.

It didn't take long, of Mydei riding out his orgasm, tightening and massaging around Phainon's pulsing dick, that his entire vision turned white. He slammed his hips inside of Mydei, eyes fluttering shut while spilling streams of cum inside of Mydei. His hips stuttered and twitched against Mydei’s behind, emptying everything that Phainon had been holding back for the past month and groaning at how eagerly Mydei was eating up every last drop. He had been waiting too long for this–too long of patiently waiting to pump Mydei with his release, and Phainon was reveling in how much he was filling Mydei’s hole and how much his walls seemed to flutter in delight with every stream that left Phainon's tip. After a gasp for breath as his hips finally stilled, Phainon's vision returned to the glorious gold that was spilled all over his couch.

Mydei was breathing heavily, chest rising and falling for air, but all Phainon's hazy brain could make out were his two perky nipples that had been ravaged much earlier. Teeth marks and love bites were blossoming all over Mydei's skin, from his neck and down to his chest, and Phainon's wandering eyes eventually found themselves at the sight of their connection, where his own cum was threatening to spill from his entrance. But before he could pull himself out and admire his load leaking out of Mydei's loose hole, a deep, raspy voice cut him short.

“Do *not* pull out.”

Blue eyes immediately snapped upward, where Mydei was glaring in warning at Phainon. His lover's lips were completely red and bruised, matching the crimson blush that was spread across his cheeks, and Phainon had to resist the urge to lean down, capture those plump lips once more, and continue snapping his hips against Mydei just as he had been a few minutes

ago. If they didn't have plans that they were already late to, Phainon would've done just that.

“Mydei,” Phainon's eyes were struggling to stay focused upon Mydei’s face, as his eyes kept flickering between golden eyes and the burning red entrance that was still tightly wrapped around his dick, “are you into cock-warming?”

“What kind of–” Mydei's face grew an even deeper shade of red, and his hands, still grasping Phainon's shirt, balled into even tighter fists. “I don't want *your cum* staining *our new couch*.”

Phainon's eyes widened at the realization, and his mouth dropped open to release a measly, “Oh.”

It was as if Phainon completely forgot. Actually, he did completely forget. He completely forgot that he had instigated sex in their own living room, while Mydei was trying to set up their television. Phainon was bored, watching Mydei play with the remote, and his tired eyes that had been looking at cardboard boxes all day were trying to find any sort of amusement that wasn't his phone. They eventually landed upon these two perky nipples that Phainon could faintly spot through his tank top. One touch and one moan led to another, and now both men were completely late to their plans, sweaty, blushing, breathless, and absolutely covered in cum.

“How do we… um… get ready?” Phainon was watching his own cum that was barely slipping out of Mydei's entrance, and he was sure an entire stream would flow out the moment he pulled out his dick.

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “You didn't think of that while you came inside of me?”

“Why would I think about anything else except for cumming?!” Phainon wailed. “Did you want me to pull out before I came?”

Mydei’s jaw tightened as he averted his gaze. “... No.”

“Exactly!” Phainon wildly waved his hands, earning a wince and a groan from the two men who were still connected. “Fuck, okay, what about…” Phainon's eyes wildly searched his lover, who still had his legs spread wide on the couch, and Phainon was trying to look anywhere except for his dick sitting in between those tempting opened legs. “Why don't you sit on my lap, and I'll try to slide us down the couch to the floor?”

Mydei smirked in amusement. “You want me to ride you?”

“Not–Not necessarily!” Phainon hastily swiped a hand through his silver hair. “You didn't have to word it like that.”

“So you don't want me to ride you.”

Phainon pouted as his eyes shifted back and forth at the thought. He swore even his dick was twitching back to life at the mental image, and Phainon's shoulders tensed. “... Maybe next time?”

A laugh left Mydei's lips, and hands began pulling Phainon's shirt over his head. “Pull out, and I'll use this shirt to catch any cum that spills out.”

“Not my shirt!”

“This shirt is hideous.”

“It's just yellow?!”

“It doesn't look good on you at all.”

Phainon didn't have much of a fighting chance, considering that every slight movement only stirred his cock inside of Mydei’s stuffed hole, and every brush inside of his wet and tight hole was making Phainon whimper at the overstimulation. The shirt was pulled right over his head, and Mydei positioned it underneath him, acting as a towel while Phainon slowly pulled himself out. After a tandem of groans filled the living room, a *pop* sounded loudly between the two of them before Phainon's cum began spilling right outside of Mydei’s clenching entrance.

“Stop staring and go get ready.”

Mydei's voice completely snapped Phainon out of his stupor, where his gaze was unashamedly glued to Mydei's quivering hole that was leaking Phainon's cum onto his beloved shirt. A hand blocked Phainon's view, lowering between spread legs, but it only aroused Phainon even further to see his cum continuing to stain his shirt that even Mydei's hand could not hide. His eyes were trembling at the vulgar sight, and his dick was half-mast just watching how Mydei was trying so hard to hide what both of them knew was there.

“Go… get ready.” Mydei’s face had become flushed once more at Phainon's obvious attention.

“Mydei…” Phainon could feel the blood rushing down to his lower half once more. He could feel that familiar pleasure swirling in his stomach, his breaths were quickening just trying to hold himself back, and he gazed helplessly at the glaring man who was just as embarrassed as he was. “I don't think I can get ready right now.”

“You're lucky I'm only letting this slide because you two are so madly in love with each other.”

“Sorry, Cyrene.”

Phainon and Mydei had just experienced a twelve-minute scolding session the moment they locked eyes with pink in the café. They had agreed to meet in the place where Phainon and Mydei had their first date, and they were quite late to the planned meeting time due to… reasons that everyone at this table was embarrassingly aware of.

“And I'm… really sorry too, Castorice.” Phainon flashed a sheepish smile at the other woman, who was waiting for their arrival, and she began rapidly shaking her head and waving her hands.

“There is no need for you to apologize!” She cleared her throat and settled her hands into her lap. The growing blush across her face did not escape anyone's notice at the table. “I have gotten plenty of material to work with.”

Phainon shot wide eyes at his childhood friend. “Cyrene, was I on speaker?”

“You weren't on speaker, but my volume was all the way up,” She sharply retorted, earning another awkward laugh from Phainon. “I turned it down as fast as I could, okay?”

His shoulders wilted under Cyrene's piercing stare. “I'm really sorry about that, Cyrene.”

She propped an elbow on the table, leaning her chin to rest in the palm of her hand. “I already told you that you get a pass this time. It wasn't as if *you* called *me* or anything.” A loud sigh left her chest as she shook her head. “I know you two usually aren't late unless there’s a specific reason, so it was my fault for continuing to call even when you didn't answer the first time.”

“I apologize, Cyrene.” Mydei offered his own apology this time, earning a sparkling smile from Phainon's friend.

“Oh, Mydei!” Cyrene clasped her hands together, grinning brightly at the other man. “There's no need for you to apologize! And no need for you to be so formal either! I know it was Phainon's fault.”

“It was not my fault!”

“Oh, hush, Phainon.”

“He was the one who told me to answer!”

“Mydei, is Phainon treating you well?” Cyrene leaned over in Mydei's direction, batting her long eyelashes. “Is he spouting lies about you?”

Mydei laughed, with amusement twinkling in his golden eyes. “I think he is spouting lies about me.”

“*Mydei!*” Phainon pulled on his lover's sleeve with a pout. “Are you on their side or my side?”

“I brought pastries for you two.” Mydei completely ignored the pleading gaze Phainon was throwing his way as he set a glass container filled with pastries upon the table they shared. “Feel free to have as many as you want; we have more at home.”

“Oh, wow, Mydei.” Castorice blatantly stared at the shining pastries with wide eyes swirling in hunger. “They look amazing.”

Cyrene inspected the closest one to her, hesitantly plucking it from the container and turning it in her hands. “Are these… These are… Honey Suncakes?”

“The one Mom used to make.” With a nostalgic smile, it was entertaining to see Cyrene's face light up instantly at Phainon's confirmation. “I… obviously don't know how to bake, but I remember exactly what it tastes like. It took us all night to figure out how to replicate them. Mydei is truly a genius.”

“Your mother is a genius for creating such a delicious recipe,” Mydei chimed in.

“I can't believe I get to eat these again!” Cyrene dove right in, chomping a majority of the pastry so quickly that Phainon wasn't even sure if she had the chance to actually taste it, but her entire body seemed to melt at the flavor that lingered on her tongue. She closed her eyes, sighing contentedly, as if she was sitting outside of Phainon's house once more, as a little girl, watching the golden wheat fields swaying under the gentle, glowing sunlight.

“They're delicious, Mydei.” Castorice nodded with a small smile. She was already picking at another pastry from the container.

“They're… truly perfect,” Cyrene whispered. Only a small piece of the pastry was left in her hands, and she lowered it to admire the inside of the suncake. “It tastes just like the ones Phainon’s mom used to make. A long, long time ago. I… didn't think I would ever eat these again.”

Mydei smiled gently. “I'm glad it suits your tastes.”

“Oh, Mydei!” Cyrene jumped up from her seat, running around the table and throwing her arms around the golden-haired man, whose eyes widened at the sudden physical affection. “You didn't have to bring these!”

“I wanted to apologize that I couldn't meet up with you all earlier.” Mydei’s body was slowly relaxing and becoming accustomed to Cyrene's tight embrace, where she had her arms wrapped around his shoulders.

“There's nothing you need to apologize for!” Cyrene retorted. “If anything, it's Phainon's fault.”

Phainon gawked. “*My* fault?”

“It's your fault for always hogging your boyfriend!” Much to Phainon's incredulity, Cyrene shot him a look with a piercing pink stare over Mydei's shoulders. “I understand that you love him, Phainon, but you should give your friends a chance to get to know your boyfriend too!”

Phainon's mouth was still dropped open, barely hanging by its hinges as Cyrene continued praising Mydei to the high heavens and leaving her own childhood best friend in the dust. “Are you… trying to get on the CEO's good side right now?”

“This has nothing to do with Mydei being our CEO.” Cyrene giggled. “Mydei is one of the girls now.”

Both Phainon and Mydei were thrown into an unexpected coughing fit, and Cyrene laughed while releasing the golden-haired man from her tight embrace and patting him on the back. “Are you guys going to order something first before we go around? Or should we head out now?”

“Let's,” Phainon cleared his throat, recovering from the outrageous claim Cyrene had spouted, “go order something?”

Mydei nodded, similarly clearing his throat as well, and Phainon pulled his lover away from the table as they approached the cashier.

“I'm just glad they're not mad.” Phainon sighed heavily, scanning through the menu that was suspended from the ceiling.

“They are kind people,” Mydei simply remarked as he crossed his arms. “You have good friends, Phainon.”

Phainon smiled to himself at the compliments, almost as if Mydei were complimenting him instead, and he teasingly jabbed an elbow into his lover's side. “They're *your* friends now too, you know.”

Golden eyes were scanning the menu with Phainon, even though he already knew his usual order. “I just officially met them today.”

“You met them before,” Phainon retorted. “Cyrene's cake, remember?”

“It was for only a brief moment.”

“That brief moment meant so much to them.” Phainon lightly laughed, recalling all the times that the two women had been excessively bugging him to bring Mydei out with them. “Ever since then, they have been pestering me nonstop to get you to join us.”

Mydei chuckled quietly. His eyes shimmered in a gentle, tender joy while playing out Phainon's words in his mind. His eyes were a soft beauty, sparkling fervently under the afternoon sun, that Phainon wanted to pull his lover into his arms to ensure that no one else could capture this awestrucking radiance that was standing right here in this humble city café.

“I'm glad to finally have the pleasure of granting them their wish.”

With his words lingering in the air, Mydei stepped up to the counter and ordered for himself, and he beckoned Phainon over, who quickly came over and automatically recited his order. He decided to order the same drink he had last time, the hot white mocha, but before he could react, Mydei had already swiped his credit card.

“It's the least I could do for humiliating you earlier,” Mydei explained before Phainon could fight the cashier for a refund so he could pay instead.

“I'm sorry.”

A smile adorned Phainon's lips, but his expression of perplexity was evident across his face. “What are you apologizing for? You think I wouldn't enjoy anything I do with you?”

Mydei scoffed, his own smile of amusement creeping onto his face. “Is that your way of saying I'm allowed to do whatever I want?”

“You've *always* had that privilege, Mydeimos.” Phainon lowered his eyes, gently swiping a hand through long, golden bangs as his voice lowered to a whisper. “Don't we share the same key now?”

That gorgeous smile that always took Phainon's heart captive, taking his breath away and leaving him in a complete stupor. That glowing, ethereal shimmer that radiated underneath a golden frame and a golden sun that would never stop shining–Phainon would never tire of the smile that always graced Mydei’s lips, that always made his eyes crinkle up into crescent moons that sparkled in the vast, open sky. His heart was pounding so loudly at the sight that he didn't even realize that the golden sun had disappeared from his view, where Mydei was reaching over the counter to thank the barista, who had just finished making their drinks.

Phainon scurried over to take his drink from Mydei’s hands, and they both returned to the table where Cyrene and Castorice had completely wiped out the rest of the Honey Suncakes and were deeply immersed in a conversation that didn't make much sense to Phainon.

“He would be a rockstar for sure!” Cyrene was nodding eagerly, peering over Castorice’s shoulder, where they were both staring at the tablet that she had, presumably, pulled from her purse. “And… what if he was a *huge* fan of the rockstar? It would be like a fated meeting between a fan and his idol!”

“I was thinking more of an accidental, fated meeting,” Castorice responded. Her tablet pen was in her hand as she scribbled along the screen. “About two men who don't know either of their identities, who fought over a drink

at a club, but quickly became attracted to one another, the longer the argument went on."

Cyrene sharply gasped. "I love that idea! An enemies-to-lovers trope! That seems much more in line with them."

It was Castorice's turn to eagerly nod as she glided the pen along her tablet screen. "I would think he would mess this up somehow, but I wasn't sure how."

"Like he loses his number or something?" Cyrene snickered. "Doesn't that sound like him?"

Castorice chuckled quietly, writing down notes on her tablet. "I will include that idea. Thank you, Cyrene."

"Oh, you *must* let me read it when you start, Cas! I can't wait for it to be done!"

"Are you guys done?" Phainon's gaze flickered between the two women who were basically vibrating in their seats from the absolute excitement that was swirling in their twinkling, eager eyes. He hadn't the slightest clue what they were talking about; were they drafting up a story?

The two women froze, slowly meeting Phainon's inquisitive gaze, and Cyrene shot up from her chair while Castorice hastily shoved her tablet back into her bag.

"Wow, Phainon!" Cyrene feigned the most awkward laugh Phainon had ever heard come out of her mouth. "How long have you been standing there?"

"Since…" Phainon furrowed his eyebrows to recall the confusing conversation with no context. "Someone being a rockstar?"

"*Ahah… Ahaha!*" Two rough hands pulled Phainon into his chair, where he quickly grasped the coffee cup in his hand before it threatened to spill all over the outfit Mydei had meticulously chosen for him. "You're so creative,

Phainon!” Cyrene continued, laughing loudly and robotically until the tablet that Castorice was using had completely disappeared into her purse.

Phainon only narrowed his eyes but sipped his coffee, where Mydei did the same with his tea once he settled into the seat beside him. Cyrene had busied herself by closing Mydei’s glass container that only held mere crumbs as the only evidence that the Honey Suncakes even existed before rigidly settling back into her seat.

“Are you two allowed to go out together now?” Cyrene pushed the glass container over to Mydei, who nodded to thank her.

“Now that my position is secure, there is no need to hide anymore,” Mydei explained.

“Even though you're dating Phainon?”

“My partner is not a valid reason to undo the company transition, and it would be illegal for the Board of Directors to do so.” God, Phainon could not help but fawn over how hot Mydei was whenever he was in boss mode. “My father may have found out about my relations with Phainon, but he cannot do anything now that he is no longer in this position of power. It would be easier to cancel the transition while he was CEO, but he can no longer do so in retirement.”

“Oh, so he knows?” Castorice's eyes widened.

“It would be hard for him not to notice my mother's ring on my finger.” Mydei softly laughed. There, shining in the café lighting, was the gold signet ring that all of them were quite familiar with. “Now that I am CEO, there is no need for me to hide this ring any longer, and there is no need for me to avoid Phainon out in public any longer.”

Much to Phainon’s embarrassment, Cyrene cooed dramatically. “You guys are *so* romantic! A forbidden office romance that grew into overcoming past hardships together, and now your relationship can be seen under the light after much triumph!” She waved her hand over, beckoning Mydei’s hand to be placed upon the table as both Cyrene and Castorice studied the

ring that was glimmering on his dominant ring finger. “I have to give my applause to Phainon; this ring really is beautiful on you, Mydei.”

“It suits you very well, Mydei,” Castorice agreed with a nod.

“You make it sound like I was going to give Mydei a bad gift,” Phainon teased, but his eyes were also drawn to the gold that adorned his ring finger. It was a striking gold color that attracted any and all attention in his way, exuding both power and elegance that only emphasized the owner’s own stature.

“I was really afraid you were going to buy him clothes,” Cyrene remarked. “Cas and I were going to stop by your place today, but since Mydei was picking your outfit, we trusted him!”

“You trust *his* taste in fashion more than mine?”

At the silence that responded to Phainon, he knew not to argue any longer.

“Do you still speak with your father, Mydei?” Castorice peered at the golden-haired man, who frowned at the idea.

“Not particularly,” Mydei answered. “More like… He does not wish to see me after what I have done to him.”

The moment Mydei became CEO, the Black Tide was completely eradicated. True to his words, Mydei ordered its own destruction, as the new owner of the Black Tide, and Eurypon was absolutely furious about it. His father had been trying to convince the board of directors to remove Mydei from his position as CEO, even going as far as trying to do it himself, but there was nothing that could be done now that Mydei was the new CEO. There was truly no valid reason to remove Mydei from the company, as Mydei had fairly won the majority vote with the executives to eradicate the Black Tide.

“Anyway!” Cyrene clapped her hands together, with a wide grin growing on her face. Mydei told Phainon that he had discussed the Black Tide with Cyrene before, so Phainon could only assume that Cyrene also knew the

truth of what happened to it. “How is moving in together? You guys have an apartment, right?”

Mydei nodded. “Just a small apartment. And in the future, we plan to move into a small home for the two of us.”

“I'm glad I'm here instead for a little break.” Phainon chuckled, resting his chin in the palm of his hand. “I was getting tired of all those boxes.”

Cyrene laughed, nodding in agreement. “If you guys need any help, let me know!”

Castorice also nodded. “Me as well. I would love to gather more material.”

“Oh, you're *so* right!” Cyrene whipped her head toward Castorice with wide eyes. “We can see more of Phainon's romantic side!”

“I'm not going to do anything in front of you guys.”

At the silence that responded to Phainon, he knew not to argue any longer. The message that hung in the air was clear to all four of them at the table: Phainon had already done something.

Cyrene giggled, playing with her half-empty coffee cup. “It's so exciting to hear you two moving in together. I feel like you both have come such a long way.”

“Indeed, we have,” Mydei responded firmly. “A lot has happened these past few months.”

“It must be nice to finally relax, right?” Cyrene tilted her head to the side with a smile. “You guys can finally breathe the open air together! We should go out! Enjoy the city life while it's the weekend!”

Cyrene was already pushing herself up from her chair before any of the other three could respond. Everything had returned to normal, with all of them following Cyrene's wishes and whims, and they practically chased after Cyrene, who was already leaving the café without them to explore the

city. Perhaps even, Mydei would be next in obtaining his motorcycle license.

The day was spent perusing the shops in the area. They all visited the adjacent bookstore that Mydei frequented, sifting through the numerous shelves that were available to them. Cyrene made a joke to Phainon about their time in the antique store outside the city that she had dragged Phainon to, and Phainon could not believe how many months ago that had occurred. He laughed at the thought. It was surreal to think about how different he was back then, at that antique store in the middle of nowhere, to now.

Castorice also asked him about his gift, *As I've Written*. Truthfully, because of the chaos of trying to find a new apartment and move while also steering clear of Eurypon's eyes for a month, he hadn't exactly had the time or the headspace to read her book. He only had a chance to flip through it briefly, admiring the little pictures of the two chimeras. Phainon apologized to Castorice but still thanked her for the gift, who was completely understanding of his situation and said there was no need to apologize, only that she was glad to hear that Phainon appreciated her book. If he managed to find it in the many boxes he had packed his belongings in, he really wanted to read it soon–hopefully, with Mydei right by his side.

He wanted to hear Mydei's thoughts on a book he commissioned from her. He wanted to hear the things he wanted to include in the story, things he had thought about while presenting Castorice with the request. He wanted Mydei to read the book alongside him, experiencing the same adventures and memories that Vigethos was experiencing. He wanted to show Mydei everything that he could and take him along the same journey that Vigethos had taken. It was wishful thinking for Phainon to want to take his lover back to visit his hometown, his childhood home, and those same fields that he had always labored in as a child, so the best he could do now was to bring Mydei along as much as he could in their present and their future.

The first step of that was, of course, to introduce Mydei to his dear friends, whom Phainon has already shared so much of his life with. Cyrene, the first friend that Phainon had ever made in his life, and Castorice, the first friend Phainon had ever made in the city. Phainon had shared so many memories with these two women, and he couldn't wait to share so much more of his

life with Mydei, to fill in the empty pages of the rest of his life, recording his present and his future with Mydei right beside him. It would be a book that Phainon would want to read over and over again, just like how Vigethos experienced adventures over and over again with Fig Stew and his other companions at his side.

They ended their day in another clothing store. It was probably the fifth closing store that they had looked through, and the sun was starting to set in the sky now, hanging low over the horizon, which was painting a show of gold to cross through the previously blue sky. It was an inspiring sight to behold, and Phainon could not help but become enraptured by the searing gold that spread across his vision and the rings of light captivating his eyes that surrounded the setting sun. The color gold was reflected in his own eyes as he watched the grand display before him, but he was interrupted from his admiration when someone tugged on his arm.

Pulling his gaze away from the gold that was still staring at him, he met eyes with a mischievous Cyrene, who was holding something behind her back. Phainon raised his eyebrows curiously, with a somewhat awkward smile slowly forming on his face. It was clear that Cyrene had something planned for Phainon, and he could not tell if it was a good plan or a bad one. “Yes?”

“We all picked something out for you!” Cyrene jumped up and down in place.

Phainok blinked blankly at his friend, his puzzled smile never fading. “... What?”

“Just get over here, Phainon.” A deep voice directed his attention elsewhere, where Phainon found the most beautiful sun to ever glow, standing a little ways away.

“Where am I going?” Phainon's wide eyes flickered between Cyrene and Mydei, where Cyrene only continued to smile ominously while pushing Phainon in the direction of the other man.

“We *can't* let you go home without more clothes!” Another shove from Cyrene made Phainon stumble, and Mydei perfectly caught him despite Phainon’s floundering hands.

“I already have clothes?” Phainon grasped Mydei’s hands tightly to straighten his back. “I didn't pack them for nothing.”

“I threw them away.”

Phainon stared at his lover, whom he was just praising to the highest of heavens and preaching about how he would trust him for the rest of his life, for one, two, three, four seconds. He stared at him blankly, with his jaw and shoulders completely slack, and his hands hanging loosely in Mydei's firm grip.

“What?”

“I threw them away.”

“You threw my clothes away?!” Despite how flabbergasted Phainon was, Mydei was smiling. *Smiling!* The audacity of this man to throw away his clothes and to continue standing here in Phainon's presence!

“I didn't technically throw them away. I donated them.”

“That's the same thing!”

Mydei chuckled. He was *chuckling!* And Phainon could not even believe that he was standing here, admiring how gorgeous and radiant Mydei was when smiling!

“I want to buy you new clothes, Phainon,” Mydei intertwined his fingers in Phainon's hand, pulling him toward what Phainon could only assume was the changing rooms. “I'm glad to have gotten an excuse to rid my eyes of your awful yellow shirt today. I couldn't do it before because you're always wearing it.”

“It's a comfortable shirt,” Phainon grumbled.

“Do you even remember a single piece of clothing in your closet?” Mydei tilted his head to the side once they had finally arrived at the changing rooms, where Castorice was already waiting for them. “Other than your work clothes, or the outfit that Cyrene and Castorice gave you?”

“My…” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “My yellow shirt?”

Mydei scoffed, crossing his arms. “Anything else?”

Phainon sharply gasped at the realization, whipping his head around and tightly grasping Mydei's shoulders in a panic. “Did you throw away my matching pajama set?!”

Mydei was being shaken back and forth, his golden hair swaying all over his face the longer he did not respond and the more frantically Phainon began shaking him due to his lack of response. “I… think so.”

“You think so?!”

“What color were they?”

“Green! They were green! With little animals on it!”

“Why do you pick the worst colors to wear?”

“What's wrong with green?!”

“If they were green with animals on it, I definitely threw it away.”

Phainon immediately slumped, hanging his head in defeat. The only thing that kept him standing was the fact that his hands were still tightly grasping Mydei’s shoulders. Otherwise, he would have already dropped to his knees in anguish.

A few long seconds passed before a deep sigh left Mydei, but Phainon was too busy staring at the floor and wallowing in his own mourning to see his expression.

“Did you really like those?”

Phainon remembered that pajama set as clear as day. It even came with a peach-colored cardigan, one that Phainon loved the feeling of with his green pajamas. It was a soft, billowy cardigan that paired well with his cotton pajamas, and the little animals scattered over the fabric were just an extra touch that made him smile. He always saved that set for special occasions due to how soft the material was, and he didn't want to use it too much and ruin it over time with wear. He wasn't sure if he had ever worn it in front of Mydei before–that's how preciously and carefully Phainon treated that pajama set.

“It's fine.” Phainon slowly raised his gaze from the floor, but he could not help the sorrowful sigh that escaped his chest. Phainon wasn't angry with Mydei by any means; only that he wished he had a chance to wear those pajamas one last time. “I'm sure I can find more. There are… plenty of clothes out there, after all.”

He finally released his tight grip from Mydei's shoulders, and he was about to drag himself to the fitting room, where he was originally supposed to go, when Mydei cleared his throat, stopping him in his tracks.

Mydei had his arms crossed, frowning at Phainon with a set of piercing eyes. What intrigued Phainon the most, though, was the faint blush that Phainon was sure only he could notice. “I'll… let you pick a matching pajama set with me.”

It felt like the entire world just dropped onto Phainon's shoulders with how heavy his body suddenly felt. His feet were planted to the floor as he stared with wide eyes at his lover, feeling as if his lungs were going to collapse with how much the breath caught in his throat and how fast his heart was pounding at the thought. He was sure he imagined that; no, Phainon *definitely* imagined that. It was almost impossible to think that Mydei of all people was the first one of the two to suggest matching clothes. And the fact that Mydei was letting *Phainon* pick? Phainon had to be dreaming.

“... What?”

“I'm letting you pick,” Mydei snapped. “So *pick* before I change my mind.”

Phainon disappeared into the store before the three of them could shove Phainon into the new clothes they picked out for him.

“You're so sweet, Mydei.” Cyrene giggled once Phainon had completely disappeared from their field of view. “I would never let Phainon pick matching clothes to wear with me.”

Mydei sighed exasperatedly. “I'm starting to regret my words already.”

Cyrene laughed. “I'm really glad you got rid of that yellow shirt though. It has been driving me insane since he bought it all those years ago.”

“The clothes Phainon brings back can't be too terrible, right?” Two dubious stares landed upon Castorice, who quickly wilted at their knowing gazes. “Let's… just hope Phainon brings back something adequately nice. It's not as if this name-brand store would carry Phainon's sense of fashion, right?”

As if Castorice spoke too soon, Phainon soon reappeared bearing two bright, highlighter yellow, silk pajama sets adorned with cartoon pictures of dark purple grapes in his hands that neither of the three knew where he could have possibly pulled from. Instead of making any sort of remark on the clothes, the three of them decided to shove Phainon into the fitting room to try on the new clothes they prepared for him, while Mydei, regrettably, purchased the matching set of pajamas that Phainon picked out. It was when Castorice had joined Mydei at the checkout counter, and Phainon was trying on probably his third outfit of the day, that Cyrene approached him with a huge grin, pushing another set of clothes into his arms.

“You should really thank me, you know.” She winked. “You wouldn't be dating Mydei right now if it weren't for that bottle of wine, right?”

Phainon laughed. “Are you *really* going to be crediting this all to yourself right now?”

She laughed with Phainon. “I'm just saying! I only planned that whole last-minute company dinner because I wanted to see why Mydei was always paying attention to you. My efforts really paid off.”

Phainon almost dropped all the clothes onto the floor the moment he digested Cyrene's words. The only thing that kept them in his hands was their price tags. “Wait, *you* were the one who planned that? *You* were the reason we mysteriously went out to eat that day?”

“Weren't you just *so* curious as to why Mydei hated you?” Cyrene giggled, turning Phainon around and pushing him into the changing room. “I wanted to see why Mydei paid so much of his attention to you, and I wanted to find some sort of way to pair you two together. Speaking of, what happened that night?”

Cyrene could instantly feel how rigid Phainon became under her stubborn hands, and she narrowed her eyes upon Phainon, who was beginning to sweat under the changing room lighting.

“*Phainon, what happened that night?*”

Phainon knew he wasn't getting out of this one. With the way Cyrene was speaking to him so strictly, he could not fabricate any sort of excuse to wriggle free from her grasp, where her hands were already tightening upon his shoulders and refusing to let him retreat into the changing room.

He sighed deeply, with his shoulders dropping along with his sense of shame. “We… slept together.”

“You *what?!*” Cyrene's eyes widened, pulling a hand over her mouth and quickly apologizing to the other shoppers nearby for her sudden exclamation. “Phainon, I did *not* raise you to be like that!”

“I didn't–What do you mean *raised?!*” Phainon whirled around on his feet, running an impatient hand through his hair and bunching up the clothes in his other hand. “I obviously didn't *mean* to, but I… think I've always liked Mydei before. And the alcohol just… capitalized on that.”

Cyrene's eyes were bulging now, and her hand was still slapped over her mouth as she spoke. “You had a crush on Mydei and didn't tell me?!”

“*That's* your concern right now?!” Phainon cried. “It's not like I *knew* I liked him back then because I thought the guy fucking hated me!”

“Did it bother you that he hated you so much before *because* you liked him?” Cyrene’s hand finally lowered from her mouth, and she spoke in a whisper but with such fervent passion that it didn't sound as if she were whispering at all.

“I really think so.” Phainon smiled sheepishly. “I just don't think I was able to realize it before. Whether because my mind didn't want to or… everything Mydei did just bothered me so much more that I didn't get to think about it, I don't know.”

Cyrene hummed, a smile forming upon her lips. “I still think you owe me one for this.”

Phainon's own lips curved upward into a smile. “I owe you a lot, Cyrene. Thank you.”

He could not even begin to explain how much Cyrene had done for him, and he couldn't imagine how else Cyrene had helped him, even without him knowing. She was always like that all throughout their lives, because to her, it was the most romantic way to live.

It seemed she wasn't expecting such a sincere response, as she slightly faltered at such heartfelt words. Instead of responding, she returned his tender smile, wrapping her arms around him in a tight embrace, before shoving him back into the fitting room to continue trying on their abundance of clothes.

The sun had disappeared under the horizon when they finally exited the clothing store. With arms full of shopping bags filled with Phainon's new closet, Phainon and Mydei bid Cyrene and Castorice goodbye to return home and continue unpacking. Due to their little break during fixing the television that caused them to be late, they didn't have nearly as many boxes unpacked as they had planned, and now Phainon had even more clothes to store in his closet after their little excursion with Cyrene and Castorice.

While Phainon was throwing his clothes and their new matching set of pajamas into their closet, Mydei went to work washing the dishes that he didn't have time for from when he baked the Honey Suncakes earlier. It was when he was drying all the dishes with a towel to store in their cupboards that Phainon finally reemerged from their bedroom. Their *shared* bedroom in their *shared* apartment, might Phainon add. It was still surreal to Phainon that they were living together, under the same roof, and that Phainon would be able to see Mydei whenever he wanted, for whatever he wanted, and for however long he wanted.

“They really loved the Honey Suncakes.” Phainon had settled against the counter, leaning against it and watching Mydei stow the rest of the dishes away.

“I'm glad it was to their taste. It relieves me to hear Cyrene also enjoyed the taste of the Honey Suncakes. I don't think I could exactly replicate your mother's baking, but I'm glad to hear it was close.”

“They were practically identical, Mydei!” Phainon grinned. “It was as if I were back at home again, taking a break from working in the fields and eating my mother's pastries.”

Mydei smiled softly, setting the towel down to hang dry now that the last of the dishes were put away. “Whenever you want a taste of home again, just let me know. I'll make them for you whenever you want.”

They were truly simple words. Just a simple offer on Mydei’s part, as someone who loved baking and loved his partner. But to Phainon, those words meant so much more. It meant he could return home whenever he wanted, to a place that no longer existed. It meant Phainon could experience memories that were long forgotten to the world from a place that left not a single trace. Cyrene and Phainon were the last living evidence that this small village ever stood, and now, there was one more thing that would continue from his hometown. One more memory that would continue living for the rest of their lives.

“Aren't I home right now?” Phainon smiled sweetly. He chuckled lightly, innocently tilting his head to the side while staring at this beautiful array of

gold that spanned his vision, farther than his eyes could ever capture. He really was at home, admiring the endless sea of gold, where Phainon felt he could retreat to, hide within, and live as his true, authentic self. There was nowhere else Phainon would go except for here, where gold would always surround him, embrace him, and comfort him. Whether it was those golden wheat fields that Phainon always worked in or his lover, who was standing right before him, Phainon would not call them anything else except for what they were. “Where else would I be standing, if not our home?”

A tender thumb swiped along the corners of Phainon's eyes, where his vision was beginning to blur, revealing the shimmering smile upon his lover's glowing expression. “That's right. This is our home now, and I can make you those Honey Suncakes whenever you want. It is our promise, after all.”

Phainon leaned into Mydei's hold, where his hand was now cradling his cheek and catching any stray tears that had slipped from his eyes. “I actually was given the responsibility of naming your bakery. Did you want to hear it?”

Mydei scoffed, but his smile as he admired Phainon within his hand never faded. “*You* named my new bakery? Let's hear it then.”

“I wanted to name it something that meant a lot to you.” Phainon's eyes lowered to the counter, as if searching for the name that he had painstakingly come up with after weeks of debate within his head. “I wasn't sure if you wanted the chimeras again, since that was the last bakery's name, so I tried to think of something else. I'm not an… expert at naming stores, so don't hate me too much.” He smiled sheepishly at Mydei, who softly laughed.

“It's not too late to rename the bakery if you don't like it,” Mydei reassured. He was rubbing small circles into Phainon's skin now, and Phainon had to stop his eyes from fluttering closed at the pleasant sensation that tingled down his spine.

“It's not?”

“Since the bakery is undergoing construction, we won't need a new name until it's complete. What name did you think of?”

Phainon couldn't stop the embarrassment from washing over him as he hesitantly opened his mouth. “The Granatum Bakery.”

Mydei scoffed, his lips turning upwards into an amused smirk. “*Granatum?* For pomegranates?”

“I know you like history, and I also know you like pomegranates too.” Phainon laughed awkwardly. “I thought, maybe the Latin word would make sense for you. But if you don't like it, we can obviously let Krateros know to change it.”

Mydei's eyes twinkled in amusement, and he dug into his back pocket for his phone. “I think I have a better name.”

Regrettably, Mydei withdrew his hand from Phainon's face, but it was just a few moments of watching Mydei type before his phone was pocketed once more. Before Phainon could even open his mouth and ask what he did, Phainon's own phone vibrated in his pocket. He eyed Mydei suspiciously from across the table before digging for his own phone, pulling up a message that wasn't actually from Mydei.

Krateros (7:49pm): *Do not let Mydei name the damn bakery The Great Bakery of Kremnos: Granatum II.*

Phainon burst out laughing, slamming his phone onto the counter and wheezing in between fits of erratic breaths. He couldn't even register what Krateros had asked of him, only the absolutely outrageous name that filled his phone screen. He could faintly feel the phone being peeled from his hand through his laughter, and it was just a few seconds later that he barely registered Mydei's voice.

“I don't understand why he had to go and tell you and not me,” Mydei muttered while Phainon was gasping desperately for air to fill his lungs once more while wiping the tears from his eyes.

“*What* did you want to name the bakery?” Phainon could barely speak. His voice was hoarse from how much he had just howled in laughter, and his legs were trembling from barely keeping his body from toppling to the floor.

“Is that not a fitting name?” Mydei tilted his head to the side. “A grand name for a grand bakery. Should it be named The *Grand* Bakery of Kremnos: Granatum II instead?”

“Mydei.” Phainon coughed, trying to hide his teasing smile. “Is that not a long name for a bakery?”

“A long title that befits its high status,” Mydei explained as if this were an actually normal name for a bakery. “I don't see a more fitting name than a long title.”

Was it awful to think that Phainon found Mydei's naming sense absolutely adorable? Was it wrong for Phainon to respond to Krateros’s message in support of the outrageous name? Just seeing how adorably and stubbornly Mydei was sticking to this name made Phainon want to keep it. If they kept this up for a little while longer, Phainon may actually cave to such a name.

“Why not a name that's easier to say?” Phainon offered. “I feel like the other name is a mouthful.”

Mydei frowned, crossing his arms. “Another name? I suppose I can think of an easier name for the average person to say.”

Blue eyes watched Mydei fall deep into thought, frowning with golden eyes flickering along the countertop as different names tossed and turned in his head. It didn't take long for Mydei to bring out his phone once again, messaging whom Phainon could only assume was Krateros. This time, Phainon's phone did not buzz immediately after Mydei pocketed his phone.

“The Golden Granatum,” Mydei confidently spoke, answering Phainon's curiosity before he could ask himself.

“The Golden Granatum?” It was Phainon's turn to frown. “Why *Golden?*”

Golden eyes stared deeply into Phainon, full of conviction and assurance swirling within. The name was final, in Mydei’s eyes, no matter what anyone else said. “For you. For us. The name encompasses our promise.”

“Us…” Phainon buried the lower half of his burning face into his hand. His heart was pounding against his chest, rattling his ribcage just from repeating his lover's words in his mind. The way Mydei so casually declared his love in simple conversation was one thing that Phainon's heart could never grow accustomed to. “Mydei, this is *your* bakery. I don't need to be in it.”

“I want you to be.” Hands peeled Phainon's hand away, interlocking fingers together and causing Phainon's cheeks to flare even brighter. “It also includes me, does it not? I thought you hated looking at my golden hair and my golden eyes.”

Phainon flinched as he shot up from his place against the counter, whipping his head toward Mydei, who was only staring at him in amusement. “That's–No! I was just… I was just angry at myself. I love looking at you, Mydei. I love your golden hair and your golden eyes. I love–”

His lips were captured within Mydei's, completely halting Phainon's ramblings. His entire body melted into his lover's touch, with eyes fluttering closed as a soft moan left his throat. The kiss wasn't nearly long enough before Mydei parted, and Phainon's fingers twitched against the counter as he stopped himself from pulling himself back into that comforting, sunlit warmth.

“I know, my love,” Mydei muttered. He didn't pull back very far, and the tips of their noses still faintly brushed against each other as Phainon stared deeply into hypnotizing golden eyes. “My bakery would feel incomplete without you. My love, who has been by my side, upholding our promise. I want you, Phainon, to be in the name with me.”

Phainon didn't know whether he wanted to laugh or cry. His heart swelled with love. His eyes brimmed with tears. And his lips turned upward as a breathless laugh left his lips. His vision was being blurred by gold as tears littered his cheeks, but they never had the chance to fall to the floor before

Mydei caught them in his hands, cradling his cheeks and catching wherever Phainon would fall.

“I love you, Mydei.” Phainon's voice was shaking as his words left trembling lips. A quick peck landed upon them, and another, and another, until he was sinking once more into his lover's warmth. His hands balled into fists on the counter as his face was pulled into Mydei. Phainon could barely even breathe between his rushing tears and his captured lips, but he wouldn't have it any other way. He wanted to suffocate within Mydei's tight embrace, feel his body upon his forever, and become wrapped within the comforting hold of these golden wheat fields that Phainon loved so desperately.

Their lips parted with a sound that rang clearly in Phainon's ears. His vision was clear again, but the breath was still caught in his throat at the radiance of the golden sun staring so deeply into him that it almost made his body tremble under its rays. Mydei's gaze was unwaveringly still, even while swiping at the last stray tears upon Phainon's face.

“I love you, Phainon.”

Phainon's body was definitely trembling now. His fingernails were digging into his skin, and his limbs felt heavy as he hurriedly pulled Mydei to their bedroom. The bedroom that they shared together. *Together*.

It was Mydei's turn to laugh as Phainon impatiently pushed him into their bed that they had just put together earlier that day, and he watched Phainon tear off his clothes that Mydei had meticulously chosen for their day out with Cyrene and Castorice before throwing them onto the floor.

“Impatient, are we?” Mydei smirked. Phainon slid his hands along Mydei's torso, pushing Mydei's arms above his head and pulling his shirt from his body before it quickly joined the already discarded clothing on the ground.

“Just finishing what I started earlier today,” Phainon murmured and bent down, sliding his hand underneath Mydei's jaw to tilt his face upwards. Brushing his fingers through golden hair and against Mydei's ear, Phainon

pressed his lips against Mydei, eliciting a moan that he wasn't sure came from himself or his lover that vibrated along their connected lips.

It was as if the tension immediately left Phainon's body as he melted against Mydei's touch with his eyes fluttering closed. Their lips danced upon one another, sounds reverberating through the night air, with hands digging themselves deeply into silver hair. Phainon shifted in between Mydei’s legs, settling Mydei's thighs on top of his own as he fumbled with Mydei's zipper. An amused scoff brushed his lips as hands left his hair, pushing Phainon's hand out of the way to deal with the matter himself. It was just a few moments later before the rest of Mydei's clothing landed upon the floor at the same time Phainon's impatience wore thin.

He pushed himself forward, rutting his hips against Mydei and earning himself a sharp gasp that brushed against Phainon's lips as their hard erections collided. Mydei threw his head back, digging his fingernails into Phainon's skin and causing him to groan. He moaned Mydei's name, feeling his voice vibrating along his lover and attaching his lips to Mydei's neck to suck hard. He was eager to leave his mark all over his lover, and he kissed and nipped along his crimson tattoos, trailing down to his collarbones and burying his nose into Mydei's sweet scent while planting his hands upon Mydei's smooth waist.

Phainon was sucking on Mydei's skin, with love marks evidence of their connection blossoming all over his body. He was thrusting his hips against Mydei and dragging their already hard lengths together, making his lover tremble and moan within his grasp. It spurred Phainon further, with heat pooling in his core with every gasp of Phainon's name that echoed in their bedroom. His toes curled with every scratch that Mydei left upon his back, and Phainon was greedy for more of Mydei's marks upon his body. He yearned for Mydei's touch, and he drove his hips forward, using his hands on Mydei's waist to drag their bodies together in search of that delicious friction that rushed pleasure through their bodies.

The more Phainon thrust his hips, the more Mydei was left moaning into the air. Mydei's hips began moving with Phainon as he spread his legs wider, rubbing their dicks together and giving Phainon more space to do whatever he wished to the man lying in their bed. Phainon pulled his

hungry lips from Mydei's smooth skin, driving his hips downward as fast as he could and watching Mydei mewl underneath him at how much their hard cocks were sliding together. He was clawing along Phainon's skin, making Phainon gnaw at his bottom lip and spectate the delicious scene playing right before his half-lidded eyes. They were already making a mess, with their tips leaking precum all over Mydei's flexing torso that was already staving away an oncoming orgasm. And when the slapping of their skin grew in tandem with Mydei's moans, words cut Phainon from his lust-filled stupor.

“*Please*, my love, inside.”

Phainon's hips faltered. His ears would never get tired of hearing Mydei repeat the name that Phainon had also given to him. He wanted to hear his lover calling him that, with the same desperate, pleading tone that Phainon always held for Mydei, over and over for all night long.

With smiling eyes reflecting shimmering gold, Phainon lined himself up with the entrance that was already searching for his presence, clenching around nothing and fluttering in delight once Phainon pressed his leaking tip against him. He was already loose from their earlier activities, and Phainon inwardly scoffed at how eager Mydei's hole was to be filled with Phainon’s girth despite how much they already went at it today in the living room.

“Did you want me that bad, my love?” Phainon laughed lowly. His eyes were glued to Mydei's entrance, which was sucking along Phainon's dripping precum, gobbling as many drops as it could catch. Phainon chuckled at the sight, dragging his tip along the ring of muscle and pushing it just lightly enough to tease the edge without actually pushing inside, and Mydei's pink hole would tremble at the pleasure and the pressure of Phainon's dick, trying to suck him inside entirely.

“Just put it inside,” Mydei snapped weakly.

“You're always rushing me, Mydei.” Phainon pouted. “Can't I take my time just once?”

“I want you inside, my love.” Mydei's deep, sultry voice pierced Phainon's soul, making Phainon's entire body falter. His grip on his own dick went slack as shivers rushed down his body at Mydei's words. Phainon was a slave to this pleasure and a slave to his lover, and nothing would stop him from hanging onto every word and syllable that left his lover's beautiful, gorgeous lips.

He eased himself inside, just like Mydei wanted, watching his hole stretch open to encompass Phainon’s thick girth as he slowly sank deeper. His quivering walls graciously welcomed Phainon, massaging around his length the moment he pushed inside, and pleasure flared up in Phainon's stomach, building within his body and making his limbs grow rigid from the electricity rushing through him the more he pushed himself inside. He watched his length disappear as it was embraced by fluttering, twitching heat, and his teeth sank deeper into his bottom lip as his eyes struggled to stay open to watch his cock become gobbled up by Mydei’s entrance until he was fully submerged inside and his hips had become flush with Mydei's behind.

Phainon was out of breath just from the vulgar scene, and he already knew he was leaking precum right inside of Mydei's warmth without even moving. His hips were already twitching against Mydei, desperate for the sweet friction that would take hold of his body, but he was keeping still and waiting for Mydei's signal to continue. He swallowed thickly, trying to stave off his orgasm before he even moved and trying to think of anything except for the tight heat that was deliciously holding onto Phainon’s pulsing dick.

The tight, hot walls that were equally pulsing around Phainon. The tight, hot walls that were stretched out to fit the exact shape and size of Phainon's cock. The tight, hot walls that Phainon had spilled into just earlier in the day, which they could not fully clean out because they were rushing to meet with their friends at the café. The tight, hot walls that Phainon was sure were still holding onto remnants of Phainon's cum and allowing Phainon to slip inside so easily.

He couldn't forget how much these tight and hot walls had fluttered and quivered in absolute pleasure when Phainon spilled his load right inside,

plugging him up and filling his walls to the brim. He couldn't forget the delectable scene of Mydei trying to hide his leaking hole with a single hand, and he couldn’t forget the rush of pleasure that ran down Phainon’s spine when he shoved his dick right back inside his leaking warmth, fucking Mydei senseless until he came inside again and stuffing his lover with so much cum that it spilled outside despite still being connected.

Phainon clenched his abdomen tightly, almost keeling over and exploding inside of Mydei just thinking about it.

“*Phainon*.”

Phainon’s deteriorating brain barely caught onto Mydei’s pleading, whispering voice, and he glanced up and clenched his abdomen once more at the sight that was lying right before him, right on top of his sheets, all for him to enjoy and ravish until he was full. He could feel his precum leaking from his tip just admiring the golden rays that spanned down Mydei's shoulders, delicately framing his fierce, yet soft features that were flushed a bright red that matched his tattoos and the love marks Phainon had riddled his skin with. His golden eyes were brimming with tears that had gathered in the corners of his eyes, and his breaths were ragged, with his lips parted, trying to pant for breath despite the burning rod that was reaching his stomach.

“*Move*, my love.”

It felt like Phainon’s sanity had snapped. His entire mind went blank. He could not perceive anything around him or think of anything else except for his lover being displayed just for him on a silver platter, and he rammed his hips in without warning, driving himself inside at a breaking pace that made Mydei’s golden eyes shoot wide. Hands immediately tightened on Phainon's shoulders, digging his fingernails into his skin and clawing at his back the faster Phainon thrust his hips into the heat that was surging throughout his entire body from his quivering dick. He could not stand the friction that was brushing against him, and he was hungry for more of the pleasure to build in his stomach and completely take over his mind.

The pleasure was hitting Phainon in waves, more so than it had ever before. Goosebumps were rising along his arms, and he lifted Mydei by the tight hold around his waist as best as he could to fuck his lover right against the spot that left Mydei screaming and writhing within his hands. Sweat was dripping down their bodies, making their slapping skin louder amongst the night air in their bedroom, louder than even the moans and gasps that were leaving both of their chests.

Mydei was being bounced up and down against the bed that was creaking on its legs and knocking against the wall the bed was pushed up against in tandem with Phainon's rough thrusts. Golden hair was tangling with the sheets, with toes clenching into the blankets that were becoming stained from their activities. It was between thrusts that Phainon desperately fumbled for a pillow, shoving it underneath Mydei's lower back and pushing him against it, and Mydei moaned loudly at the new position as Phainon's tip rutted right into his lower stomach, almost bulging right against his skin. Blurring golden vision glanced down just to check, only to find his own leaking, pulsing dick slapping against his stomach riddled in precum and sweat.

Phainon was fucking Mydei so roughly that it was shifting the pillow higher up his back. Mydei jolted at the pleasure that began sparking from the middle of his back, and his back arched at the electricity that was sprouting from the friction behind him and below him as he continued to claw at Phainon's back.

Phainon was sure his back would be all red and scratched from how tightly Mydei was clinging and crying onto him, and it made Phainon shiver in pleasure, burying his face into the crook of Mydei’s neck and lifting his lover's legs even higher into the air. He slotted his hands underneath his knees, folding Mydei over and hearing the squelching of Mydei’s hole echo in his ears. His dick twitched with every sound Mydei's filled hole was making and every moan that reverberated against Phainon's chest, and he was desperate to feel more of Mydei’s leaking erection slapping against his abdomen and his fingernails clawing all over his skin.

His lover's trembling legs were raised high, with toes clenching around nothing and shaking within Phainon's hands. Mydei’s hole was tightening,

fluttering, and twitching around Phainon's thrusting length, and he knew from how loudly Mydei was now screaming Phainon's name and how desperately he was tugging on his silver hair that his lover was close. Eyes fluttered closed with every tug on the back of his head, and he moaned Mydei's name into his crimson tattoos. Phainon yearned to hear more of his own name fill their new apartment in Mydei’s pleading voice, and he yearned to fuck Mydei through his orgasm and have his body writhing and spasming in absolute overstimulation even after Mydei spilled all of his thick load onto both of them.

He wanted Mydei to cry just as much as Phainon had. He wanted the tears to rush down the tattoo underneath his right eye, pooling onto their bed as streams of cum painted both of them in white. He wanted to see those bruised, red lips whining Phainon's name as that muscular, tanned body jolted within Phainon's arms, and he folded Mydei further, almost pressing his knees right against their mattress. The mattress that they now shared, and the mattress that they were now leaving evidence and traces of their lovemaking all over to deal with later.

“*PHAINON!*” Mydei's whining voice interrupted Phainon's possessive thoughts, and his entire body and mind melted at the sound of his name filling their new bedroom. Mydei was calling for him, over and over and over again, just like Phainon wanted. He wanted Mydei to think of nothing except for him and his dick that was filling his body and driving into him over and over and over again, and when nails began scratching at the golden sun tattoo across Phainon's neck, Mydei screamed Phainon’s name, back arching as a thick load of cum splattered along their abdomens.

Whimpers and moans left Mydei’s lips as he rode out his orgasm, with his body spasming against the bed and legs violently shaking in Phainon's hands. Phainon was whispering sweet nothings into his lover's ear, brushing his hot breath and brief kisses against him while softly thrusting into the tight heat that had clamped down all around Phainon's dick, refusing to let him leave while he came and made a mess all over both of them. His walls were equally spasming inside, massaging against Phainon and making Phainon moan in between his sweet ramblings, and when Mydei’s entire body went slack, Phainon pressed another kiss against his temple.

“You came so much for me, my love,” Phainon whispered. “Was earlier today not enough?”

Mydei's head was still spinning. He was barely recovering from his orgasm when he felt Phainon's hard erection continue to stir inside of him, and he flinched at the hard tip that was still brushing right against his already spasming prostate.

“*Phainon*,” Mydei croaked. His voice was completely gone from all the screaming he had just done, and he swallowed dryly in any sort of attempt to soothe his aching throat. But nothing was going to get through the man above him, who was slowly increasing the pace of his pummeling hips and taking Mydei’s breath away with each deep thrust that was pushing against his overstimulated walls. The pleasure was starting to become too much with the way it locked Mydei's limbs together, making his body grow rigid to the point where he could not breathe. He was gasping for breath with every slight drive of Phainon's hips and the dick that was still digging into him, and his insides could not stand the repeated pleasure that was erupting in his body and flaring up his entire core.

Phainon hummed innocently, planting another kiss along Mydei’s temple. “Did you need me, my love?”

“Give me a minute, *please*.” Mydei gasped sharply, golden eyes rolling into the back of his head. The tea from earlier that he drank back at the café was starting to hit him hard, and he wasn't sure if he could handle Phainon's greedy, insatiable dick that was beginning to pull out almost completely before snapping all the way inside. Each and every thrust, Phainon pulled out more of his dick before slamming inside, and whimpers would erupt from Mydei’s lips despite the deep, burning embarrassment that was rushing through his heart at the new feeling that was beginning to stir in his stomach. It was unlike anything Mydei had ever experienced before, and it left his entire body shaking every time Phainon so much as breathed. “Phainon, wait, I think–*NGH!*–something is… coming!”

“Are you going to cum again, Mydei?” Phainon whispered. He couldn't help the mischievous smirk from growing on his lips as he pulled his cock out until only his tip remained inside before shoving himself right into the

delicious warmth that was fluttering so violently around him. Every thrust felt as if Mydei were cumming with how much his walls were violently pulsing and clamping down on Phainon's length, and he could not believe that he hadn't done this earlier. Phainon was absolutely reveling in the pleasure his dick was sunken into with every drive of his hips, and he was absolutely reveling in how tight and warm it was around his cock that was quivering in sheer delight with every deep thrust. Phainon could feel that he was close with how much his dick was twitching inside of Mydei, but he wanted to ride this out for as long as he could to savor how much Mydei's fluttering hole was clenching around him.

“No, I–” A rough hand shoved against Phainon's shoulder, almost making his hips stutter to a stop. *Almost*. “Phainon, I need to go.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow at the audacity. “Go? Go where?” Phainon slammed his hips inside, earning a loud slap that reverberated against his thighs and a loud, wanton moan that echoed against the bedroom walls. Mydei's entrance clung so tightly to Phainon's dick that it actually took the breath from his lungs, and he could barely move his hips now from how tightly Mydei was holding onto his length. But before Phainon could continue retorting, Mydei's lips dropped down into a silent scream as his entire body was wracked into a violent tremor.

Back arching off the sheets and head thrown so far back his forehead was digging into the mattress, a clear liquid began spraying into the air. They began in small rivulets that shyly escaped Mydei's tip in small streams, landing upon Mydei's clenching abdomen. It was an orgasm unlike Mydei had ever felt, and the sensation of releasing even just those small streams felt euphoric and, even, relieving to Mydei. But as Phainon fell into a stupor on what he saw, stilling his hips that were flush against Mydei's behind, the longer Phainon's dick continued pressing and twitching against Mydei's overstimulated sweet spot at the lewd scene, and it wasn't long before those small streams grew into larger sprays that splattered along the both of them and splashed onto the sheets as Mydei's rigid body continued jolting sporadically with every abundant stream.

It was too thin to be called cum, yet it was a little too colorless and odorless to be called anything else. Mydei’s dick was standing tall and proud now,

twitching unashamedly in the air as it continued to pump this clear liquid from its slit, and it wasn't until a few seconds later that Mydei’s entire body slumped into the bed, chest heaving for breath and golden bangs haphazardly thrown over his blown out, dilated golden eyes as he lied in sheets drenched in this clear, almost odorless, liquid.

Phainon blinked blankly at the blushing man underneath him, who was still trying to catch his breath. He stared at the trembling hands that were balled into fists and were still pushing against Phainon's shoulders while trying to process what he had just witnessed, but a weak, low voice drew his attention instead.

“That's not…” A pleading golden gaze, swirling in confusion and horror, shot toward Phainon as hands began pushing against his shoulders. Mydei's teeth gritted together as his face bloomed just as brightly as his tattoos, and his voice lowered into a murmur so quiet that Phainon could barely catch his words, but Mydei never finished his sentence.

Phainon flew into action, leaning forward and pressing his lips upon the corners of Mydei's eyes that were glistening in hot tears and the cheeks that were flushed bright red. Phainon's dick was suffocating inside of Mydei's clenching warmth, and he was trying to ignore how much his stomach swirled in pleasure with every slight shift of their bodies as he attempted to comfort his lover, who was shaking in his arms.

“I know, my love,” Phainon whispered against Mydei's skin, planting kisses down his face and brushing his lips along any part of Mydei that he could reach. “You just felt so good that it happened. I know you think it's something else, but I promise you it's not.”

Mydei frowned. “It's not?”

“It's not.” Phainon pecked Mydei's quivering lips, smiling against them and nuzzling him further. “It happens when you feel really good. Nothing bad happened. I liked it, Mydei. Did you?”

Golden eyes searched warily upon Phainon's face once Phainon pulled back, searching as if he could detect any lies dripping from Phainon's

words. But from the wide, innocent blue eyes and his head slightly tilted to the side, Mydei sighed deeply, acquiescing to the only explanation that he had for now.

Mydei stared at the mess that he made between them, dripping from both of their torsos and staining the sheets that he was lying on, muttering lowly and almost hesitantly, “It felt good.”

Deep blue eyes brightened as he leaned forward, causing the golden-haired man to flinch at the pleasure still stirring in his gut. Phainon quickly apologized, turning to what he actually wanted to discuss: “You liked it?”

Cheeks began to blossom a deeper shade of red as Mydei averted his gaze. “*You* actually liked that?”

“You were so hot, Mydei,” Phainon immediately responded, causing Mydei to roughly shove his shoulders and for Phainon to laugh loudly. “I'm serious, Mydei. Can't you feel that I'm still hard?”

As if trying to prove his point, Phainon thrusted his hips, eliciting moans from both men as a sharp golden gaze shot back to Phainon.

“You *still* haven't cum?”

Phainon's shoulders wilted, but nothing would ever cause his dick to do the same this far into sex. “I thought you were going to ride me this time, Mydei.” Phainon pouted. He leaned forward once more, brushing the tip of his nose against Mydei as he murmured, “I was holding myself in so you could ride me, but if you don't have enough energy now, I could–”

Rough hands shoved Phainon backwards. The force was so strong that he felt his back hit the mattress this time, and a golden sun began towering over him as legs swung around Phainon, feet planting themselves next to Phainon's hips as blue eyes grew wide.

Mydei was grimacing, struggling to balance himself on his feet even while slipping the hard erection back inside of him. Phainon could barely even breathe at the sight of Mydei’s spread legs that hid absolutely nothing of the

golden hair between his legs or the soft dick that was hanging over him. He was unashamedly staring, with lips dropped open, at the vulgar sight of Mydei literally squatting over Phainon's quivering hips that were holding back from thrusting upwards into the deep warmth that was clenched tightly around his dick as Mydei found his footing.

“You're staring, *Deliverer*.”

Blue eyes were flickering between Mydei towering over him and the sight of their connection below. Hands were digging into the bed, balling the sheets in his hand as wide eyes watched Mydei lift himself up only drop right onto Phainon's hips. The pressure took Phainon's breath away as he gasped for breath, chest staggering, and fingers clawing at the bed sheets as Mydei repeated the motion.

“You better not move, *my love*.” With a smirk from the golden-haired man, he repeated the action, gasping at how deeply Phainon was spearing into him in this position. His golden eyes fluttered shut, reveling in the friction as he began chasing the pleasure that was starting to rush through his body and his soft dick once more, slowly stirring to life until it bounced along with Mydei's vulgar movements.

The view was way too hot. It was absolutely too much for Phainon's spiraling brain as his eyes stared at Mydei's ass slapping against his thighs with every bounce and his cock slapping against his sculpted abdomen. Phainon was digging his heels into the mattress, attempting as if his life depended on it to keep his hips still, but the sparks of pleasure that rushed through his cock left him as a shaking and gasping mess. His legs were trembling violently against the bed as he became a slave to the pleasure and warmth that sweetly embraced his pulsing, hungry dick, but Phainon could do nothing except continue to lie there limply, digging his clenching toes, shaking legs, and trembling fists into the bed while trying to keep his hands off this meal being taunted before his dilated eyes.

Biting his bottom lip and peeking in between silver bangs, moans continued slipping from his throat as he watched Mydei bounce on his cock and chase a third orgasm, trying to milk everything that Phainon was holding back. But it was so hard with how sexy the view was before him, of Mydei's legs

spread wide as he rode Phainon's dick and submerged his entire girth as deeply inside as he could, moaning and crying Phainon's name at the top of his lungs every time his tip accidentally brushed his sweet spot. Mydei's body jolted with every slight brush against his prostate, and his back arched with red nipples pointing straight up into the air as he tried to hit that spot again and again.

Sweat was dripping down their bodies again as hands landed upon Phainon's chest. Mydei dug his knees into the bed as he assumed a different stance. Rutting his hard erection against Phainon's swirling stomach, Mydei began chasing his own friction. He was grinding his dick against Phainon's sculpted abdomen and pushing Phainon's quivering length inside, and Phainon clicked his tongue at how hot Mydei was and how sexy it was that Mydei was just treating him as his own dildo to get off on.

Mydei was savoring the pleasure, with golden bangs sticking to his face and lips parted open to release moan after moan, but Phainon could not take it anymore that he was not pushing as deeply inside of Mydei as he would've liked. He could feel his cock quivering in pleasure, but hungry for more friction, and Phainon shifted slightly in the bed, eager to chase just that.

“My love, please forgive me.” With those last words leaving Phainon's lips, he grabbed handfuls of Mydei's ass, shoving him down at the same time Phainon thrust his hips upwards, driving his dick so deeply inside that the breath caught in Mydei’s throat. His lover fell forward, burying his golden eyes that were now rolled into the back of his head into the crook of Phainon's neck as Phainon thrust his hips again, pulling Mydei’s hips down in tandem with his upward thrusts.

Bending his knees, Phainon planted the soles of his feet on the mattress. He found the perfect position to fuck Mydei even while on the bottom, and his lover began jolting in his arms with every push of their hips together and every drive of Phainon's dick deep inside. Phainon was all too aware of the spot that Mydei loved the most, and he aimed straight for it, snapping his hips as fast as he could and pressing his tip right against Mydei's abused prostate. Moans vibrated against Phainon's sun tattoo as their roles were reversed once again, with Mydei being a slave to the pleasure that was driving deeply into his twitching hole over and over again.

His entrance was gobbling Phainon up so sweetly, even in this new position, hungry for more of Phainon’s length to fuck him deeply and roughly right against his sweet spot. Mydei wrapped his arms around Phainon, with his quaking legs tightening around Phainon's hips. His own hips were rutting up and down, chasing the friction against his dick that was now leaking more precum all over Phainon's flexing abdomen and meeting every single one of Phainon's deep thrusts. Mydei gasped and moaned at every drive of Phainon's hips, and his vulgar noises joined the sounds of their slapping skin and their creaking bed once more.

The lewd sounds were permeating straight into Phainon's head. Phainon felt he could hear Mydei's hole even when he was nowhere near it, and his core was flaring in so much heat that he could barely feel his pounding heartbeat that was rattling his chest. His stomach was flexing, trying to hold his orgasm away, but Mydei's inner walls were massaging so beautifully around him, as if asking to be filled. And who was Phainon to deny such a polite request?

“Mydei, *Mydei*, *AHH! MYDEI!*” Phainon was desperately crying his lover's name, with his hips staggering as he neared his release. His dick felt like it was going to melt in Mydei's tightening heat, and when lips pressed deeply against Phainon's rambling words, Phainon's entire vision turned white. He moaned wantonly, with Mydei's name vibrating against their lips, as he finally came, back arching off the bed and plugging his dick deeply inside Mydei's hole, spilling everything he had been holding back. His mind completely blanked as his hips jolted, spasming against Mydei’s ass as he filled Mydei to the brim with his cum, and it felt like Phainon achieved a second orgasm when those soft lips pressed even harder against him, stealing his breath away as the walls fluttering around Phainon tightened and pulsed even further.

Streams of cum were shooting into Mydei, and Mydei couldn't help but cum a third time that night at the feeling of Phainon's cum filling him up. Moans reverberated upon their lips as Mydei's body shook violently in Phainon's arms, with sweet nothings filling the air as both men rode out their orgasms together, cumming and spilling everything inside of them. Cum smeared between their sliding abdomens, and cum leaked out of

Mydei's plugged entrance to run down Phainon's scrotum, pooling onto the sheets between his legs. It was all too quiet when their lips finally parted with a sound that snapped Phainon from his haze, and as his vision slowly returned, all he could see was gold spanning across his line of sight.

“Mydei?” Phainon leaned his head forward, brushing the tip of his nose against his lover, who still seemed to be in a daze.

Golden eyes slowly blinked at Phainon. It looked like Mydei was fighting the sleep that was threatening to take hold of his body, and with a soft laugh, Phainon gently flipped them over, laying Mydei down in the cleanest spot he could find on their ruined bedsheets before taking his lover up into his arms. Phainon kicked open the door to the bathroom, gently setting Mydei into the bathtub that was beginning to fill with warm water. Phainon was quite adamant about finding an apartment equipped with a bathtub so he could take baths with Mydei, but he could never imagine they would already be using it within the first days of moving in.

Phainon spent the next hour cleaning them up, wiping Mydei down, who had passed out at some point during the bath, clearing their floor of loose articles of clothing, and throwing their bedsheets into their washing machine, which Phainon was also adamant to have in their new apartment together.

It was when Phainon was settled into bed much later into the night, encompassed by freshly washed sheets, that Mydei finally stirred awake. A deep groan resounded next to him, and Phainon chuckled lightly, brushing his fingers gently through golden hair.

“Sorry, is the light too bright? I can turn it off for you.”

A slight shake of a golden head of hair made Phainon's smile grow, and he withdrew his hands from his lover's hair so he could push himself up.

“When did I pass out?” Mydei’s voice was hoarse, and Phainon rapidly turned to their nightstand, handing him a glass of water that he had prepared in case Mydei happened to wake up during the night.

Phainon wasn't sure if he wanted to tell him or not. He wasn't sure if Mydei would adamantly deny that he passed out right after having an orgasm, and he sheepishly smiled, taking Mydei’s glass after he completely emptied it. “Right… after we came?”

Mydei narrowed his golden eyes upon Phainon as if assessing if he was speaking the truth or not, and Phainon could only continue smiling at his lover, who lazily rested his head upon Phainon's shoulder.

“What are you looking at?”

Phainon smiled, glancing down at the picture frame in his hands. He dug them out while Mydei was sleeping, as they had been left in his car so many moons ago. He wanted to bring them out as a house-warming gift for Mydei, even though they now shared the same home, but Phainon wasn't sure how photographs would fare sitting in a car. Thankfully, they still shone just as brightly as when Phainon first received them, and now that they were beginning to settle into their first home together, he thought it to be the perfect time to present Mydei with his gift.

“I brought you a gift,” Phainon murmured, shifting the picture frame in his hands. “I didn't frame everything, only just one picture I thought you would like best. But we can look through the other ones together and buy more frames to decorate the apartment. Only if you want to.”

“Pictures?” Mydei glanced down to Phainon's lap, where there sat a single picture frame and an abundance of other pictures spilling out of a Manila folder.

“It's a… long story.” Phainon awkwardly chuckled, passing the frame to him. “I didn't want to worry you, so I didn't tell you earlier.”

Golden eyes scanned the first picture that sat in his hands. It was the scenery taken in the glow of the soft, morning sun, with rays of sunlight streaming through a window and cascading along the surface of what seemed to be a kitchen island. The camera was positioned to be taken right outside, through the window, peeking through the curtains as if interrupting a personal moment. Two men were standing near the island, with one's head

bowed so low that the audience could not see his face, but another man stood beside him, with a gentle smile directed at the first man. There, filling the counter in front of them, was a metal tray filled with fresh, butter croissants.

Mydei's eyes widened, bringing the frame even closer to his face. He scanned the photograph up and down, seeming to take in every single detail that was inlaid in this frame, and even when the picture was finally pulled away from his eyes, Mydei was silently digesting the entirety of the photograph.

“That… The bakery,” Mydei muttered. “When I finished the croissants on the bakery's last day.” Mydei's hands dropped into his lap, where the picture frame followed suit, and golden eyes quivered in front of Phainon as they locked eyes with blue. His eyes swirled with complicated emotions that Phainon could not begin to describe. He was sure Mydei was feeling conflicted and yet, nostalgic, at seeing his old bakery again. “Where did you get this?”

“I… said it was a long story.” Phainon sheepishly laughed once more, but it only made Mydei narrow his eyes, causing Phainon to immediately cave. “We… um… The tail… actually… gave these to me.”

“*The tail*.” Mydei did not seem pleased in the slightest, which only made Phainon begin to squirm in his seat.

“The… yeah.” Phainon's shoulders slumped in defeat. “I got a meeting invite on the Monday after the bakery closed, and they gave these to me there.”

Mydei's eyes widened, with a fierce glow emanating from his golden gaze. “You didn't tell me.”

“I didn't want to worry you.” Phainon quickly scrambled to respond before earning more of Mydei's ire. “You had so many other things to worry about, and I wanted to help you, at least a little bit.”

The golden gaze only grew fiercer at Phainon's explanation. “You can help me while telling me.”

“It seemed like a situation I could handle, so I… didn't.” Phainon turned his body toward his lover, who was staring with furrowed eyebrows at the picture in his lap. “I should've told you earlier, I know. I really… really wanted to help you, Mydei. Just once.”

Mydei seemed to be arguing with himself, whether to continue reprimanding Phainon or to acquiesce, but soon, his tense shoulders relaxed ever so slightly. “I have already told you. You have helped me plenty of times, Phainon. More times than I can count. More times than there are stars in the sky. You do not need to continue throwing yourself into danger for situations we can handle together.”

Phainon's lips curved upward. Even during this situation, it still made Phainon's heart full knowing how worried Mydei was for him. Even though Phainon was sitting right beside him, completely fine, it made Phainon’s heart swell just knowing that someone loved him so dearly enough to even worry about past Phainon, who had already endured all the troubles and strife that they were discussing. Phainon could not ask for anything more in his life, for someone to be with him and to think about him, even when the past had already happened.

“Don't you trust me?” Phainon tilted his head innocently to the side.

Mydei scowled, and Phainon almost yelped in surprise when two strong arms swung around his neck, pulling him toward the other man. Phainon had to shoot out his arms to catch himself before he toppled over Mydei, who was glaring adorably at him with shimmering eyes.

“*Hmph*. Don't do that again.”

With a warning glare being shot in his way, Phainon hurriedly nodded. Satisfied with his simple answer, a quick peck landed upon Phainon's lips, sending him into a stupor and not realizing when those strong arms had pulled away from him until his lover spoke once more.

“I get that you don't want to rely on me all the time, Phainon.” Mydei leaned back into the headboard, staring unwaveringly into Phainon's blue eyes. “But I want you to. And in turn, I would like to rely on you as well. You don't have to do everything yourself. Isn't that why our promise was made?”

The promise. Mydei was right; that *was* why their promise was made. A promise built upon the struggles that they both toiled through. A promise built upon the mutual agreement to rely on the other, to depend on the other, and to fight alongside each other. It was a promise built from the backstories of their lives that they both lived through and saw through the eyes of the other person. It was a promise that Phainon could have with no other person except for Mydei, and a promise that Mydei could have with no other person except for Phainon. A promise of unwavering trust, and why Phainon was given Mydei's key in the first place.

Phainon breathlessly laughed, curling into Mydei’s side and wrapping his arms around his lover's waist. “I promise, Mydei.”

“Good.” Mydei's satisfied voice rumbled against Phainon. “So tell me now. What happened?”

Smiling at the memory, he nuzzled closer against Mydei’s side. “The tail was Cipher. Isn't that funny?”

Mydei scoffed, plucking the frame from his lap to stare at the picture of them in the bakery. “You're telling me that lazy security guard took this picture?”

“She's quite serious about her job when it comes to money.” Phainon chuckled, tilting his chin upwards to admire the photograph alongside Mydei. It was truly a lovely picture–one that almost looked staged. The sunlight seemed to shine just perfectly among the two men at the kitchen island, and the gentle, morning glow served to illuminate their private moment of the bakery's final day. Phainon couldn't even be mad that Cipher was there since she had taken such a picture of the bakery. A picture of a memory that no longer existed in this world.

“So what did you give her in exchange for these pictures?” Mydei briefly bent forward, snatching the Manila folder from Phainon's lap before settling once more against Phainon's side.

“She wanted to speak with Aglaea.”

“The HR director?”

Phainon nodded. “She said she only started working there to see Aglaea, but because Aglaea is always stuck in meetings, she never could. She asked me to have Aglaea make time for her.”

“More important than my father's money, I assume.” Mydei hummed in amusement while flipping through the other pictures. Most of them were taken while the sun was up, probably due to better lighting and better quality. The photographs consisted of them treasuring the last hours of the bakery: talking amongst each other, laughing amongst each other, and comforting each other. They were quiet, tranquil pictures of them baking extra batches of pastries together throughout the final day, pointing out specific memories that occurred in the bakery, and quick exchanges of kisses, intertwined fingers, and gentle brushes against each other, as if neither man could not stand to be without the other for a single second.

“They seem to go way back,” Phainon explained. “I don't know the full details, but Aglaea raised Cipher when she was young.”

“I see. That would explain her desire to see Aglaea over whatever outrageous amounts of money my father may have paid her.”

Phainon laughed at Mydei's comment. “How much do you think your father paid her?”

Mydei raised an accusatory eyebrow at him. “Why? So you can turn these pictures in to him and get a cut?”

“Wha–No!” Phainon shot up from his spot, where Mydei was already smirking in amusement at him. “I was just curious! I'd never do that to you, Mydei!”

Chuckling, Mydei eased back into Phainon's embrace, where Phainon slowly began to do the same, relaxing against Mydei's body as he flipped through the photographs.

“I will have to thank Cipher for these pictures, then. Let's buy more frames when we have time. I want to bring one to my new office at work.”

Phainon grinned. “Then, I want one as my phone background. Pick one for me, Mydei?”

Mydei waved the picture frame in his hand. “I'd say this framed picture, but I want to put this somewhere in the apartment. I'll pick a different one, so you pick one for my office.”

“Your new office?” Phainon hummed while reaching for the pile of photographs. “Let me see… We should pick one of us kissing, just so that we can display it in the office your father used to work in.”

Mydei laughed loudly, leaning into Phainon as they searched for the most risqué photograph of them together while reminiscing the last pictures and the last physical memories of Gorgo's bakery for the rest of their peaceful night.

The rest of their weekend consisted of more unpacking. On Sunday, the day after they picked out photographs to hang around their apartment and in Mydei's new office, they dug through as many boxes as they could, intent on unpacking everything before the weekend was over. Since they were a bit behind schedule from the previous day, they barely conversed with one another on Sunday, only speaking with each other to figure out where to store their belongings or where to place furniture.

Although Phainon wouldn't have minded having quick bites to eat throughout the day to focus on packing, Mydei was intent on indulging in full meals, emphasizing the importance of properly nourishing the body with vital nutrients. These were the only times the apartment was filled with much conversation, bantering, and laughter, giving Phainon just a sneak peek at what his new apartment would soon be immersed in once the two of them officially settled in.

He was excited; more than that, he was elated to begin sharing his life with his lover, and those few sneak peeks over mealtimes left him craving for more of Mydei's love and attention. So he was unpacking at a ferocious pace, intent on relaxing tonight in bed with everything accordingly sorted in their apartment. He had tried to convince Mydei to stay in bed on Sunday to recover from… how many rounds they had done the day before, but Mydei was almost appalled that Phainon even suggested such an idea, so a part of Phainon was also rushing to unpack as much as he could before Mydei could get to those boxes. There was even a part of Phainon that wanted to compete with Mydei and unpack more boxes than Mydei did, and he was sure Mydei was inwardly thinking the exact same.

It was much later in the evening, after they had finished dinner, that Phainon was approaching the last boxes of their belongings. It was almost certain that they could finish everything by the time the day ended, so Phainon began slowing down, leisurely looking through and fiddling with all of the things that he had packed as if he were a little child cleaning his bedroom and finding various knick-knacks that he had forgotten about. One of those things in this box was the book Castorice had asked him about yesterday, which Phainon had not had the chance to peruse due to his busy schedule, and his eyes lit up at the sudden epiphany that he had.

“Hey, Mydei?”

Mydei's voice came from the closet, where he was organizing their clothes. “What do you want now?”

It seemed Mydei could sense Phainon's eagerness just in his voice, and with a grin that Phainon could barely hide, he rushed over to his lover, swinging his arms around his waist and burying his face in the crook of Mydei's neck. “Do you want to read this with me tonight?”

He could feel Mydei shifting in his arms, glancing down at the book that was in Phainon’s hands.

“*As I've Written?* You want to read it with me?” Hands peeled the book from Phainon's grasp, and his ears picked up the cracking of the book's spine as Mydei carefully flipped through its contents.

An all-too-eager smile brushed against Mydei’s skin at the idea that Phainon was absolutely intent on making a reality. “In our new matching pajamas.”

A silence immediately followed his words, and Phainon peeked up from Mydei's neck to see his eyes narrowed and a deep scowl etched upon his face. He had completely frozen at a specific page in the book, where Vigethos seemed to be convincing Fig Stew to follow a risky battle plan.

“You weren't going to buy those without ever wearing them, right?” Phainon tightened his hold around Mydei, gently swaying them in place while batting his eyes up at his lover. “You wouldn't do that to me, right, Mydei?”

Phainon clearly caught Mydei’s throat bobbing as he refused to make eye contact with Phainon's innocently sparkling eyes. It seemed that Mydei wasn't taking the bait, so Phainon had to turn it up another notch.

He pushed himself deeper into Mydei's scent, nuzzling his face into the crook of Mydei's neck and playing with the drawstrings of Mydei's sweatpants. Phainon’s voice was muffled as it vibrated along his lover's skin, ghosting warm breath along his neck, and it didn't escape Phainon's notice that Mydei shivered with every breath that brushed against him. “Didn't I do so well today, Mydei? Didn't I unpack everything in time for the weekend to end? Can't I get a reward for finding such a nice apartment and unpacking our stuff in time?”

Flashing his innocent, teary eyes at Mydei once more, a deep sigh finally left Mydei's chest when he accidentally locked eyes with Phainon.

“Fine. Only because you did so well with this apartment.”

With Mydei’s decisive words, Phainon rushed out of the walk-in closet they were standing in, pumping his fists into the air in the living room and diving into the last few boxes left to have more time reading together in their new pajama set. He didn't want to celebrate too loudly in front of Mydei, or else he might take back his words.

It didn't take long for Phainon to basically throw the rest of their belongings in their respective spots. This would probably be the first and only time Phainon would ever be enthusiastic about putting clothes on Mydei, as he was always excited about the exact opposite, but when the deed was finally done, when they were both dressed in the adorable matching pajama set that Phainon had picked out for them, a deep blush burned Mydei's cheeks as Phainon dragged him to their bed.

“You look cute, Mydei.” Phainon was trying to stop himself from kissing his lover all over, or else it would soon lead to Phainon stripping him of his clothes once again. Instead, he anchored himself to Mydei's side, cuddling against him and planting his arms around Mydei’s waist to lean against him while Mydei held the book in his hand. This was definitely worth ridding all his clothes for.

“I look like a walking traffic light,” Mydei grumbled.

“Then, you're the cutest traffic light I have ever seen.” Phainon palmed the silk pajamas that adorned his lover, nuzzling his cheek into the fabric. Because the store that they perused was much nicer than the stores Phainon usually visited, the material was vastly better than the first pajamas that he had. The fact that he was matching with Mydei now already beat out his first set of pajamas. “Aren't they so soft? Aren't these pajamas a good idea?”

With a slight *hmph* from the only man and a blush creeping down to his neck, Mydei peeled open the book once more. It was just a basic children's book, similar to *The Cycle of Vigethos*. The sentence structure even copied the original book; Phainon had to give his props to Castorice for writing such a similar book. It almost felt like the original author took part in its development, with the way the world was built and the plot pushed forward.

The book mostly focused on Vigethos and Fig Stew, which made sense since Mydei specifically requested this book to be made for Phainon. There were times the two chimeras were living out a very domestic life, baking together and taking baths together in pools filled with gold. There were also

times they were fighting monsters together, defending their city, and exploring abandoned ruins.

But there were little things in the story that made it personalized, little Easter eggs that wouldn't be noticeable to anyone else except for the two of them, and Phainon knew Mydei must have specifically requested Castorice to include these little moments for the two chimeras. The two pastries Fig Stew loved to bake the most were Golden Honeycakes and butter croissants. The flowers that were always decorating the background were yellow roses, forget-me-nots, and pomegranate flowers. Whenever Vigethos was always struggling by himself and hiding from himself, Fig Stew would always find the little gray chimera amongst stalks of golden wheat. And the sun in the sky always stood high and proud, shining gloriously down on the two of them.

Phainon couldn't help smiling to himself at each little Easter egg that he caught, chuckling and pointing out each one to Mydei. Mydei had never read the book himself either, so everything was both new to the two men as they leisurely flipped through all the pages together, even toward the last few pages that were completely blank. The little chimeras had just taken down the final boss after jumping through past memories to rewrite the future, and Phainon wasn't sure what to expect on the subsequent pages. But he surely wasn't expecting the pages to be completely empty.

“It's… empty?” Phainon was staring at the pages as if words would suddenly form on their surface.

Mydei chuckled at Phainon's blatant confusion as he rapidly flipped through the rest of the book, where there only stood equally empty pages. “I asked Castorice to leave some empty pages for you.”

“For me?”

“I want you to write your own ending, Phainon.” Mydei gently shut the book with a dull *thump*, and the beautifully ornate cover decorated in metallic foils shimmered under their bedroom lighting like a river sparkling under a pale dawn sky. “I thought it would be best for you to pen your very own story, all the way to the final punctuation mark. You can use this area

as you see fit. Write everything you see, or write everything you imagine. I want you to write whatever you wish onto these pages. Then, in the future, you will always have something physical to look back upon, a record of your strife, struggles, and the more joyous memories that I wish only surround your life now.”

Phainon was in awe as he hesitantly took the book from Mydei's hands. He flipped through the rest of the pages and, true to Mydei’s words, every single page was left blank. Just for Phainon to cover with his own story, his own thoughts, and his own memories. A physical reminder of all the things Phainon has gone through, and a physical wish for Phainon's future. He was left with nothing from his hometown when he moved to the city, only Cyrene and their faint memories covered in blood under a bright, golden sun.

But now, why did it feel like he owned so many things from so long ago? Why did it feel like he had never lost them at all, that they had been here with him this entire time? The Honey Suncakes that he could taste again in his home, the golden sun that continued to shine brightly over him as he went to work, the laughter and stories shared over a dinner table with someone that he loved. Did those memories and stories find him, or did Phainon find them again?

There was actually something Phainon wanted to put on the first page, and he pushed himself up to reach for the Manila folder that they had placed on their nightstand the night before. It was the perfect way to begin these blank pages. He was starting with someone who had helped him pick up what he had lost during the move to the city, and there was no other person whom he wanted to put right on the first page to continue the rest of his story, all the way to that final punctuation mark.

“There *is* something I want to start this with.” Phainon began sifting through the bakery pictures that Cipher had taken, earning him an amused scoff from the other man.

“The very first thing you want to put in this book are those pictures?” Mydei’s voice was dripping in doubt, but Phainon was quite adamant about it.

“Of course.” Picking a fitting picture from the pile, he placed it right in between the first two blank pages, wedging it inside so it wouldn't slip out. It was a picture of Phainon and Mydei sitting at the counter, picking at the butter croissants in front of them. Phainon clearly remembered this moment, when Mydei began recounting his first days working in that same bakery. “I can't think of anything else more perfect than us and the bakery.”

“*Hmph*. You would start your story with a story of mine?”

With a gentle smile, Phainon leaned toward Mydei, brushing the tips of their noses together and tangling their breaths into one. His eyes fluttered closed as he pressed a kiss against his lover's lips, which Mydei returned just as eagerly as Phainon. Phainon wanted to show Mydei how much he meant to him, how much Phainon wanted to begin these blank pages with him, and how much Phainon wanted to bring Mydei with him and show him the rest of his story. It was a way for Phainon to bring Mydei along through his own memories when he could no longer bring him back to his hometown, and Phainon could not ask for anything more as he parted his lips from Mydei's, staring deeply into passionate, golden eyes. “Of course, my love. Isn't that what our promise is for?”

He reached for Mydei’s hand, radiating in warmth, to intertwine their fingers together, just like how their stories had become. They were stories that could no longer be apart, and stories that had tangled together to become one. Mydei's story was his own, which Phainon would stand to live with him for the rest of his life, and Phainon's story was his own, which Mydei would stand to live with him for the rest of his life.

Two very different lives, united by a romantic coincidence, and two very different lives that have been locked away, only to be unlocked by the other at the tone of a promise. A shared key, intertwining two stories into one that would continue for the rest of their peaceful, tranquil days, as long as the golden sun continued to glow ablaze high above in the vast, pale dawn.

As many days continued on, as the golden sun continued to shine above them, many memories and stories were recorded onto those blank pages. Phainon filled them with memories of Mydei’s accomplishments as CEO, turning the company around to their starting days. Phainon filled them with

memories of their new apartment, which started overflowing with their own unique stories. Phainon filled them with memories of every date that they went on together, every time they could stand in the shining sunlight with intertwined fingers and gentle smiles. And Phainon filled them with memories of the new bakery, Mydei’s bakery, that came to life over many, many bright and golden days.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!